



The Grand History of Eberron



Edited by
Christopher J. Monte

Based on the bestselling campaign world of Eberron created by Keith Baker and
Wizards of the Coast

The longer you look back, the farther you can see forward.

—Sir Winston Churchill

The world is a fine place and worth the fighting for...

—Ernest Hemingway,
For Whom the Bell Tolls

*There is a tide in the affairs of men,
Which, taken at the flood, leads on to fortune;
Omitted, all the voyage of their life
Is bound in shallows and in miseries.
On such a full sea are we now afloat,
And we must take the current when serves,
Or lose our ventures.*

—William Shakespeare,
Julius Caesar, Act IV, scene iii

Acknowledgements and Works Cited

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Introduction

The world of Eberron is one of swashbuckling action and dark heroic fantasy, a world where magic is harnessed in the form of fantastic technology and conspiracies and intrigue abound. The result of a ground-breaking campaign setting search undertaken by Wizards of the Coast for the Third Edition of the *Dungeon and Dragons* game in 2002, the Eberron setting, created by Keith Baker, was eventually chosen out of more than 11,000 one-page proposals from around the world.

The features that first set Eberron apart for Wizards of the Coast and for thousands of other fans, *Dungeon Masters* and players alike was that it combined traditional medieval fantasy with pulp action and dark, intrigue-laden adventure. The world of Eberron possesses an incredibly rich fictional history stretching back for millennia that has been built on the deeds of countless heroes, potent magic and the suffering of a long, devastating, continent-spanning war. And, unlike in more traditional fantasy settings, in the wake of this Last War the world has emerged into an age when life cannot be painted in the monochromatic shades of black and white but only in a thousand shades of gray.

Magic is also presented differently in the world of Eberron than in previous settings. It pervades and influences the everyday life of the people of the world and provides comforts and conveniences unknown either in our own world or any other world of medieval fantasy. In essence, in Eberron magic *is* a form of technology that has been harnessed for the betterment of that world's people much as science has been harnessed by the citizens of Earth. Massive cities with sky-scraping castles and towers can be found throughout Eberron's continent of Khorvaire, while a thriving aristocracy (some would say monopoly) of mercantile families controls most of that continent's economy through their possession of the rare and powerful dragonmarks.

The pseudo-medieval world of Eberron is a place of magic and monsters from the furthest corners of the human imagination, a place where arcane energies have infused the landscape and greatly influenced the subsequent development of both culture and industry. Thanks to a developing mastery of arcane magic, the great cities of the continent of Khorvaire contain skyscraping towers, elemental-powered carriages, galleons and airships. Arcane magic is involved in every industry across the face of Eberron and represents the cornerstone of the innovation that propels the society of men forward, just as science does in our own world.

The advances of and conveniences provided by the mastery of magic augment the traditional trappings of a world that would otherwise be considered equivalent to the late medieval or early Renaissance period in Earth's own history. Magic and the technological adaptation of the arcane arts allowed the society of Khorvaire to enjoy certain conveniences that mimic the technological marvels that first appeared on Earth in the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. A device resembling a telegraph powered by magic rather than electricity provides long-range communication between two locations. An arcane analog of a railroad connects defined routes among the civilized areas of Khorvaire. Magic is used to accomplish tasks otherwise impossible for the pre-industrial technology of the day—if one can find the right arcanist and there is enough gold available to pay for the privilege. Even in Eberron money talks.

As any campaign opens in Eberron, the continent of Khorvaire is emerging from a long and devastating war similar in scope and damage to the world-spanning wars of the Earth's eighteenth century. The five major kingdoms of the continent of Khorvaire were once part of a greater kingdom of legend, the mighty state of Galifar. When King Jarot, the last Galifaran monarch died, his five heirs, each in command of one of the Five Nations that comprised the kingdom, refused to bow to ancient tradition in regards to the succession. Instead of allowing the eldest scion to take the crown, the siblings rallied their vassals and individually sought to gain control of the kingdom for themselves. Over time, this decades-long destructive conflict became known as the Last War, for everyone involved came to imagine that the taste for bloodshed and violence would be wiped from the face of Khorvaire when it ended, never to return.

The Last War continued for more than a century, with each of the Five Nations alternately fighting against or alongside one or more of the others as alliances shifted with the wind. In time, new, independent kingdoms were formed as deals were cut and opportunities for rebellion presented themselves. After 102 years of war, the leaders of the twelve recognized nations of Khorvaire that had emerged from the wreckage of Galifar met at the city of Thronehold, the ancient capital city of that kingdom, to draft a peace agreement. With the signing of the Treaty of Thronehold, the Last War at last came to an end.

Today, two years later, the nations of Khorvaire seek to rebuild what has been destroyed and find a long-absent prosperity as the new and uncertain peace spreads across the continent. While officially at peace, the nations continue to vie for economic and political supremacy across the face of Eberron. Minor skirmishes break out every so often, especially in the more remote regions of the continent and on the more hotly contested international frontiers. Espionage and sabotage are the preferred methods of true diplomacy between the Five Nations and the other Galifaran successor

states. The nations engage in trade and diplomatic talks publicly while working their intrigues and double-crosses in the shadows.

From its inception, the world of Eberron has been defined by ten characteristics which set it apart from any of the more traditional fantasy settings.

First, if it exists in the Dungeons and Dragons game, then it has a place in Eberron.

Though originally a dictum laid out for the Third Edition of the game, this holds just as true for the Fourth Edition. In fact, this characteristic is even more true in the new rules of the game, since individual campaign settings are tied more strongly to the core rules than ever before. A monster or spell or magic item from the core game may require some modification in its lore to match Eberron's tone and overarching story, but otherwise everything that appears in any of the Fourth Edition core rule books or sourcebooks has a place somewhere in Eberron. It's a big world; there's a place for everything.

Second, Eberron possesses a very distinctive tone and attitude. Eberron combines traditional medieval high fantasy with dark heroic fantasy and pulp noir. Alignments are only relative gauges of a character or creature's worldview and not absolute barometers of affiliation or intent. Put simply, sometimes good people do bad things and even confirmed villains might have a soft spot for puppies. It is possible to encounter an evil metallic dragon or even a good vampire. Traditionally good-aligned creatures might wind up opposed to your heroes, while well-known adherents of darkness might provide timely assistance. In Eberron, nothing is simple and nothing is as it seems.

Third, Eberron is a world defined by arcane magic and technology based on magic.

Eberron is a world whose cultures developed not through the advancement of science but through the mastery of arcane magic. This reality allows the existence of certain conveniences which would be impossible in a truly medieval or Renaissance-era civilization. The magical binding and harnessing of elemental creatures makes airships, elemental galleons and lightning rail transport possible. An artisan class of minor mages called magewrights uses spells to provide energy, illumination and other necessities in most of Khorvaire's civilized towns and large cities. Advances in the creation of magic items led to everything from self-propelled farming implements to the birth of the sentient, free-willed constructs called the warforged.

Fourth, Eberron is a world of swashbuckling adventure. From the steaming jungles of Aerenal to the colossal ruins of the giant civilizations of Xen'drik, from the high towers of Sharn to the perfectly ordered bastion cities of the Inspired in Sarlona, Eberron is a world that presents constant opportunities for action and adventure. These adventures can and should draw heroes from

one exotic location to another across multiple nations, continents and even the entire world for the most epic of journeys. Even other planes should eventually come into play.

Fifth, the Last War has ended—for now. The Last War, which plunged the continent of Khorvaire into a century-long conflict of enormous destruction, ended with the signing of the Treaty of Thronehold and the establishment of twelve recognized nations that succeeded to the territory of what had once been the united Kingdom of Galifar. At least publicly. This peace has held for almost two years as the campaign begins. However, the conflicts, the anger and the grief engendered by the long war remain and the new nations seek every advantage as they prepare for the inevitable new war that will eventually break out on the continent.

Sixth, the center of civilization on Khorvaire lies in the Five Nations. The human-dominated kingdoms of the continent of Khorvaire trace their lineage to the Kingdom of Galifar, which was made up of five distinct provinces, or nations. These were Aundair, Breland, Cyre, Karrnath and Thrane. Four of these states survive in the present day as independent kingdoms; Cyre was utterly destroyed several years before the start of the campaign and was the event that essentially ended the Last War. The devastated territory that was once Cyre is now known as the Mournland. A common epithet among the peoples of Khorvaire is, “By the Five Nations!” or some version thereof. The Five Nations refers to the Kingdom of Galifar and harkens back to that empire’s legendary time of peace and prosperity when the civilization of Khorvaire advanced in leaps and bounds.

Seventh, Eberron is a world of constant intrigue. The war is over, and the nations of Khorvaire now try to build a new age of peace and prosperity. Ancient threats from long before the outbreak of the Last War linger, however, and the world desperately needs new heroes to take up its cause. The nations of Khorvaire compete on many levels—economic, political, diplomatic, territorial and magical—each looking to maintain or improve its current standing in the game of kings by any means short of open war. Espionage services find enormous amounts of employment across the continent. The dragonmarked houses, churches both pure and corrupt, crimelords, monster-run gangs, psionic spies, arcane universities, royal orders of knights and wizards, secret societies, sinister masterminds, dragons in disguise and a multitude of other organizations and factions jockey for position in the afterglow of the Last War. Eberron simply teems with conflict and intrigue.

Eighth, the economy of Khorvaire is dominated by the monopoly enjoyed by the dragonmarked houses. The great dragonmarked families are the barons of industry throughout the kingdoms of Khorvaire and beyond. Their influence transcends all the political boundaries of the continent and they remained mostly neutral during the Last War. While not technically citizens of any nation, the matriarchs and patriarchs of each house live in splendor within their enclaves and

emporiums located throughout Khorvaire. These dynastic houses of economic power derive their position from the power of their dragonmarks—unique, hereditary arcane sigils that manifest on the bodies of certain individuals within a series of related families, granting them limited but very useful arcane magical abilities associated with the trade guilds their house controls.

Ninth, magic on Khorvaire is enhanced by the existence of dragonshards. Ancient legends and the most common creation myths describe Eberron as a world divided into three parts: the golden ring that circles the planet above, the subterranean realm below the world's crust and the surface of the world between. Each of these divisions of the world was tied to a great Progenitor dragon of legend—Siberys, Khyber and Eberron, respectively. Each section of the world produces crystals imbued with unusual arcane powers—dragonshards. With dragonshards, dragonmarks can be made more powerful, elementals can be controlled and bound to service and magic items of all sorts can be crafted and shaped. These shards, however, are rare and difficult to come by, making them expensive and often the goals of great quests and adventures.

Finally, Eberron, and indeed perhaps all of the cosmos itself, is governed by the Draconic Prophecy. The dragons who called the continent of Argonessen home study the world around them for signs and portents. The dragons, long-lived and patient in all things compared to the “lesser races,” seek meaning in the patterns of nature they see all around them. These patterns are interpreted as part of the Prophecy, a record of things to come that has been unfolding since the days of the Creation. Many dragons spend a great deal of effort charting the movement of Eberron's multiple moons and the stars, studying the patterns of the Dragon Above, interpreting omens and watching for signs and portents. The draconic Prophecy is as complex and as mysterious as the dragons themselves. A few among the humanoid races learn and study snippets of the huge and constantly accumulating text, but only the dragons have the time and perspective to see the Prophecy for what it truly is. There are few traditional texts containing parts of the Prophecy. Instead, the dragons believe that the world itself is a living text that carries and reveals the passages of the Prophecy to those who can see it, in the form of what are called Prophecy marks—and the dragonmarks themselves. Passages appear throughout the world, above, below and between. Signs are revealed in the changing shape of the Ring of Siberys. Prophecy marks appear on the sides of mountains or the walls of caves, though some of these can only be read when the moons and stars are in certain alignments, or through the application and proximity of certain dragonshards. Recently, at least from a dragon's point of view, a new canvas for dragonmarks appeared in the world: the “lesser races,” especially humans and their close demihuman kin, began to manifest dragonmarks about three thousand years ago.

The appearance of dragonmarks among the humanoid races led to much debate among the dragons. For whatever reason, the Prophecy apparently has decided to reveal a portion of itself through humans and their related races. What is the nature of the Prophecy that so consumes the dragons of Eberron? Much is ambiguous or open to many different interpretations, even among the dragons. The Prophecy hints at events of doom that will overtake the world as often as its passages can be used to push the world towards a more exalted future. Most scholars believe that the ultimate purpose of the Prophecy is transformation, rather than destruction or perfection. Beyond that, the Prophecy remains an alien, mysterious and ultimately fundamental force in the lives of every living thing on Eberron and the rest of its cosmos.

Eberron can be a difficult setting for new players and Dungeon Masters to adjust to, largely because of the defining characteristics laid out above. However, one analogy from our own world's history was very useful in getting a better grip on Eberron's themes for the present writer and might be equally helpful for others. In many ways, the civilization of Eberron, and more specifically the Five Nations of Khorvaire, is very similar to that of Europe in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. Like that time period in Earth's history, the people of the Five Nations have developed incipient nationalism, a relatively organized military structure, continent-spanning networks of commerce, news and trade, basic systems of industrialized transport, communications and manufacture and a formalized system of diplomacy, espionage and alliance.

The kingdom of Breland has even advanced to the point that a constitutional monarchy with parliamentary representation similar to that of eighteenth century Great Britain is on the verge of coming into being. Literacy and education levels are far higher even for common peasants than they would be in the comparable medieval period on Earth. Like eighteenth and early nineteenth century Europe, a powerful, feudal, landed aristocracy stills controls most of the real political power in Khorvaire even as a rising economic nobility based in the dragonmarked houses' monopoly over most economic activity in Khorvaire challenges the entrenched aristocracy. Of course, in Eberron, arcane magic, not science, drives the advance of civilization forward and the lack of firearms, though somewhat replaced by arcane weapons like certain types of wands, leaves much of the "pseudo-medieval" infrastructure both intact and feasible. And, just as in eighteenth century Europe, for the first time explorers, scholars and antiquarians from Khorvaire are venturing out to discover the remains of lost civilizations all across the world. On Earth, this time period saw the beginning of over a century of what would later be considered "the Golden Age of Archeology"—and provide the fodder for the adventures of one Dr. Henry "Indiana" Jones, Jr.! All of this can help a Dungeon Master and players get a better feel for the setting by tying it into a real time period in our own

history that was defined by both medieval remnants and the characteristics of a more dynamic, modern society.

Finally, we turn to what this book specifically offers the reader. *The Grand History of Eberron* is meant to be the starting point for understanding, in depth, all the lore of the Eberron campaign setting in the Fourth Edition of the Dungeons and Dragons game. It is not meant to reprise game mechanics like feats, paragon paths, epic destinies, new skills, spells, magic items or any other game elements not specifically related to the lore, mythology and stories of the world of Eberron. *The Grand History of Eberron* is also the only source currently available where the entire complex and rich history of this world is laid out in chronological fashion to be absorbed as one complete narrative. With the Fourth Edition of the game focused on releasing a much more limited amount of source material for each Dungeons and Dragons campaign setting than was common in previous editions, much of the Eberron lore published in the Third Edition of the game is likely to be lost as those books go out of print in the coming years. The new Fourth Edition Eberron books are simply too limited in page count to replace all that was previously published. As a result, *The Grand History of Eberron* will be an invaluable resource for both Dungeon Masters and players new to the setting and for old Eberron hands who may never have seen all of the lore gathered together in one place.

With that said, it is time to begin the exploration of this wonderful world's history, legends and lore. May your blade slay many foes, may you see the sun rise from the highest towers of Sharn and may the Prophecy guide you at last to the place where no shadows fall.

Christopher J. Monte

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The History of the World

The past shapes the present, setting the stage for the future that is to be born. On Eberron, a rich and often violent history has helped craft the current age. The peoples of the continent of Khorvaire mark the passage of time according to the standards developed by the dragonmarked houses (partially based on ancient draconic measurements) and sanctioned by the rulers of the unified Kingdom of Galifar almost a thousand years ago.

Days on Eberron are twenty-four hours long, divided into day and night. Just as on our Earth, seven days make up a week, four weeks a month, and twelve months a year. The months correspond to the twelve moons that orbit Eberron, and each moon carries the name of the month in which its orbit brings it closest to the planet. The moons and months are tied to the dragonmarks by tradition and legend, as indicated on the table below. A thirteenth mark, the Mark of Death, and a thirteenth moon, Crya, once existed. The Mark of Death was a dark mark devoted to necromantic abilities concerned with death and the undead. Most consider the thirteenth mark to be nothing more than legend, but there are those who know better.

The stars are arranged into constellations that represent the eleven gods worshipped by the dragons as part of the religious faith they name Thir. This understanding was passed on in ancient times to humanity before that race spread from its original homelands on the continent of Sarlona to Khorvaire. But after humanity's exodus from the continent of its birth, these ancient teachings were adopted as part of human and Khorvairen culture. However, other cultures, such as that of the goblins of Khorvaire, may have very different names for the constellations and very different myths surrounding them.

While a particular culture may count the years dating from some significant event in its past, the common calendar of Khorvaire is called the Galifar Calendar. This reckoning of years was developed during the reign of King Galifar III "the Dark," the third ruler to sit upon the throne of a united Galifar. The Galifar Calendar counts from the founding of that kingdom to the present day. The dragonmarked houses adopted and use this calendar, as do the governments and peoples of

Khorvaire’s nations. The present year is 998 YK (the 998th Year since the Kingdom of Galifar was founded).¹

What follows are the chronicles of ages past. Events from the more distant past are shown as a number of years before the establishment of the Kingdom of Galifar (–10,000,000 YK, for example). Below the basic timeline of events for each age at certain points is a more detailed summary of those happenings for the truly dedicated scholars of the past.

¹ The days of the week on Khorvaire are named as follows: the First Day is **Sul**, the Second Day is **Mol**, the Third Day is **Zol**, the Fourth Day is **Wir**, the Fifth Day is **Zor**, the Sixth Day is **Far** and the Seventh Day is **Sar**.

Months of the Year

Month	Season	Associated Dragonmark
Zarantyr	Mid-winter	Mark of Storm
Olarune	Late winter	Mark of Sentinel
Therendor	Early spring	Mark of Healing
Eyre	Mid-spring	Mark of Making
Dravago	Late spring	Mark of Handling
Nymm	Early summer	Mark of Hospitality
Lharvion	Mid-summer	Mark of Detection
Barrakas	Late summer	Mark of Finding
Rhaan	Early autumn	Mark of Scribing
Sypheros	Mid-autumn	Mark of Shadow
Aryth	Late autumn	Mark of Passage
Vult	Early winter	Mark of Warding

The Constellations (Gods of the Dragons)

Constellation	Draconic Association
Aasterinian	Invention and trade
Astilabor	Wealth
Bahamut	Protection and good fortune
Chronepsis	Fate and prophecy
Falazure	Death and decay
Garyx	Chaos and destruction
Hlal	Humor
Io	Magic and knowledge
Lendys	Justice and law
Tamara	Life
Tiamat	Greed and power

The Age of Dragons

In the mythic past, the cosmos was an undifferentiated realm of matter and energy similar in some ways to the present day Elemental Chaos. The Progenitor wyrms, the first and greatest of dragonkind and the most powerful divine beings of the multiverse, ruled over all of this unformed creation. The three most powerful Progenitors—Siberys, Eberron and Khyber—discovered (or created) the draconic Prophecy that shapes the destiny of all Creation. A world-shattering struggle followed between the three Progenitors, splitting the newborn world into three parts and scattering the Prophecy across the width and breadth of existence. In the end, Siberys became the glowing, yellow ring of solidified arcane energy that surrounds the world, Khyber was bound in its darkest depths, and Eberron healed the surface world between by becoming one with it. Siberys called forth from his own divine essence the first generation of true dragons, the angels and the couatls, Eberron birthed all of the other known living things, and Khyber spat out the demons and the daelkyr. The race of devils was born during the great conflict between the Progenitors, when some of the angels of Siberys betrayed their father and swore their allegiance to dark Khyber instead.

The Progenitor Wyrms

The wisest dragons of the present age contend that the world of Eberron was born in battle. According to myth, the unformed emptiness before Creation was the domain of three mighty divine spirits who took the shape of great dragon siblings. Golden Siberys was the source of all arcane and divine magic. Gentle Eberron was the primal fountain of the natural energies of life itself. Cruel Khyber was the master of secret knowledge and of the foul, destructive powers that always lurk in the darkness. Together, the Progenitors held dominion over the fate of all, and they pondered the proper shape of the cosmos.

In the beginning, the Progenitors worked together harmoniously. They began their great work by first separating the fundamental planes of the Astral Sea and the Elemental Chaos from each other and then by crafting the thirteen astral dominions and elemental realms within each of these planes that made up the larger multiverse. But as the Progenitors molded reality, ethical rifts began to form between them. Dark Khyber grew greedy and selfish, and noble Siberys responded by becoming more forceful; each sought greater influence in the work of Creation. The planes of Daanvi, Fernia,

and Irian today bear the prevailing mark of Siberys. Kythri, Mabar, and Xoriat show the dominant touch of Khyber. Eberron sought to mediate between her siblings, which left a more balanced stamp on the remaining planes of existence, but she could not bridge the basic philosophical and moral divide between her counterparts. The result of Eberron's mediation was the birth of the mirror worlds of Thelanis, the Feywild and Dolurrh, the Shadowfell. Eberron joined with Siberys to craft Thelanis, a world where Siberys' arcane energies could flow through every rock and forested glade. Khyber's malignant power corrupted her joint creation with Eberron of Dolurrh, a gloomy world where the necromantic energies of shadow ran riot, later calling out with a siren call to the spirits of the dead.

When it came time to create the final, central, world around which all the others would circle in the Astral Sea and the Elemental Chaos, the ideological tensions between bright Siberys and foul Khyber could not be contained. The three Progenitors had fashioned a round sphere of rock from the chaotic matter of the Elemental Chaos that they sat spinning in the void, circling a sun created by forging a link with the fiery Plane of Fernia. In turn, this world was orbited by thirteen moons, one each to serve as a physical gateway between the planet and the other thirteen planes of the cosmos.² But no life stirred on the barren sphere and Siberys and Khyber began to argue furiously once more over the destiny of their final creation.

At last, the brewing storm between the two Progenitors could not be contained and the dark one unexpectedly tore into her brilliant sibling, mortally wounding the golden dragon and scattering his scales across the new world's sky. Although not powerful enough to defeat her foul sister, Eberron knew that Khyber could not be allowed to benefit from her nefarious deeds. The gentle Progenitor refused to fight Khyber with claw and tooth as her brother had done. Instead, Eberron embraced her, trapping Khyber within her smothering coils as she merged their dual essence with the spinning sphere the Progenitors had created at the heart of the cosmos. Eberron called on her innate connection to the primal power of all life and creation, giving birth to the new world's fertile soil, trees, animals and oceans. In this way, Eberron transformed herself into a living prison that Khyber could never escape.

Thus Eberron became the world on which all life grew and changed. To this day, she nurtures and sustains all living things. Siberys' divine remains became the pale yellow ring of golden

² The twelve Moons of Eberron include: **Zarantyr the Storm Moon**, **Olarune the Sentinel**, **Therendor the Healer's Moon**, **Eyre the Anvil**, **Dravago the Herder's Moon**, **Nymm the Crown**, **Lharvion the Eye**, **Barrakas the Lantern**, **Rhaan the Book**, **Sypheros the Shadow**, **Aryth the Gateway**, and **Vult the Warding Moon**. A thirteenth moon, **Crya the Dreamer**, once existed that was associated with Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams, and lay beyond the orbit of Vult, but it was destroyed some 40,000 years before the present day during the Quori-Giant War (see below). All these moons circle Eberron at distances ranging from 14,300 to 252,000 miles; they are the only other celestial bodies in Eberron's sky besides the sun and the stars and astronomers do not believe that any other planetary bodies circle Eberron's sun.

dragonshards that circles the world at the equator; his scattered scales became the stars. Khyber remains trapped within the heart of the planet—the Dragon Below, the Mother of Monsters, the source of all darkness, fear and pain—forever struggling to once more break free and bring an end to all Creation so that she may begin the process anew—and alone.

Soon after she merged with the world, Eberron also began to manifest marks of the draconic Prophecy on her body, which meant the appearance of dragon-shaped runic marks on the bedrock of the planet itself. Each mark provided a clue to the interpretation of the broader Prophecy and the destiny of the world and its inhabitants—for those who knew how to interpret them.

In the wake of the battle of the Progenitors, life slowly emerged on the new world over many millions of years. Siberys had fallen in battle to his dark-hearted sibling, but power remained within his spattered divine blood. Filled with the purest essence of arcane magic, that blood fell on Eberron, merging the primal forces of life and arcane magic to eventually produce new creatures with the strength of both Progenitors: dragons. According to draconic myths, where the blood of Siberys struck the clouds, silver dragons were born. It fell on the cold peaks and white dragons rose from the ice. It struck the swamps, and black dragons emerged from the dark depths. In a similar way, according to this myth, were all the families and subraces of the dragons first born on the continent of Argonessen. The dragons were mighty, numerous and proud, possessing the innate arcane power of Siberys and the vibrant, primal force of Eberron. The dragons venerated the Progenitor wyrms as the architects of Creation, but they also took up the religious faith known in Draconic as Thir, which in addition to the Progenitors, worshipped a pantheon of eleven draconic deities who were held to be lesser divine spirits who had aided the three Progenitor wyrms in their shaping of the cosmos. It was after these deities that the first dragons named the constellations that circled the world.

Thus Eberron, figuratively and literally, is a world divided into three parts. Mythology suggests that the three parts correspond to the three great Progenitor wyrms of legendary times—Siberys, the Dragon Above; Khyber, the Dragon Below; and Eberron, the Dragon Between. This figurative interpretation makes its way into the religion, philosophy, and folklore of every intelligent race of the world. Every culture of Eberron has a version of the legend of the Progenitor dragons explained above. Whether this mythology is literally true or is a symbolic explanation for physical and magical processes that took place over vast stretches of time is for the scholars to debate.

In literal terms, the Dragon Above corresponds to the ring of golden dragonshards that encircles the world of Eberron high above its equator. The Ring of Siberys can be seen in the southern sky, appearing as a luminescent band of golden specks that begins at the time of the winter

equinox as a narrow and intense band and becomes wider and more diffuse as the year progresses. It can be seen best at night but is visible during the day as well.

Khyber, the Dragon Below, comprises the Underdark of the world, the labyrinthine caverns that snake beneath the world's crust and fill the depths of the planet. Khyber consists of twisting tunnels that open on cavernous vaults of varying shapes and sizes. This subterranean expanse mirrors the world above, a dark reflection of underground rivers, still lakes, and fiery streams of molten lava.

Between the Dragon Above and the Dragon Below, the surface of Eberron stretches from horizon to horizon, a patchwork of fields and forests, oceans and mountains, deserts, swamps, jungles, tundra, and more. Beneath a yellow sun, Eberron's varied environments give way one to another across each continent. Mountains rise, valleys fall, and water surrounds the land.

Few of the intelligent beings of the current age existed at the dawn of time. The titans of Xen'drik were in their infancy, possessed of great potential power but lacking the knowledge required to use it. The lesser races of humanoids had not yet been born; the dark creatures like the fiends native to Eberron had not yet been vomited forth from Khyber's depths. So it was that wild flights of dragons soared above the world, reveling in their might.

The dragons' only true match at the dawn of Creation among the other races were the couatls, the feathered serpents who first emerged on the continent of Sarlona. For all their power, dragons are still mortal creatures. They reproduce, they grow old, and in time they die. The couatls stood outside the cycle of life; legends say that the couatls were formed from the pure blood of Siberys before it struck Eberron, and that, as a result, they were truly immortal, celestial beings, the counterparts of Khyber's fiends and equal to the angels. They were reborn only after death, so that their numbers always remained constant. Though powerful, the couatls kept to their home in Sarlona, leaving the dragons to explore the world.

The Age of Demons

–10,000,000 YK

A World of Fiends: Ten million years ago, Khyber’s fiendish offspring—the rakshashas, night hags, demons, devils and their *Na-Vakhti* or “Overlords”—the rajahs of the rakshasas—burst forth from the deep darkness of the Dragon Below and overran the surface world, creating a hellish environment where rakshasas and night hags ruled supreme.³ The seas of Eberron were little better, having become the domain of the alien aboleths. The aboleths were also children of Khyber, having arrived on Eberron from Xoriat, the Far Realm. Just as the fiends built hellish kingdoms of nightmare over most of Eberron’s surface, the aboleths established their own bizaree and incomprehensible dwellings in every major ocean and sea of the young world.

–1,500,000 YK

The Great Dragon-Fiend War Begins: After millions of years of oppression at the hands of the fiends, the dragons of Argonessen, through the combined efforts of the blue dragon Ourelonastrix and the couatl Hezcalipa, rediscovered the draconic Prophecy and rose from their primitive state to oppose the fiendish Overlords, allying with the other draconic species descended from Siberys, including the couatls. The common humanoid races of titans, humans, dwarves, halflings, orcs and goblins, all still in primitive states on their respective home continents, hid from the god-like combatants and found a way to survive the great conflict.

–100,000 YK

The Sacrifice of the Couatls: After over a million years of war between dragonkind and the fiends, the couatls sacrificed most of their race’s number in an unimaginably powerful ritual that banished the mightiest of the demon Overlords and the majority of the fiends back to Khyber, where they were trapped for eternity by the combined divine force of the couatl race, which became known much later to the people of Khorvaire as the Silver Flame. Many night hags, foreseeing the coming

³ The Overlords were also known as “Primordials” since they were the oldest and most powerful of the children of Khyber. *Na-Vakhti* was an expression in the Abyssal and Primordial tongues that means “Overlord.” Abyssal was a corruption of Primordial, the language spoken by most of the Overlords. Today, these entities are more commonly called the rakshasa rajahs, since they are the entities that the rakshasas of Eberron serve, but these beings are in no way rakshasas themselves. The term “fiendish Overlord” is far more accurate and will be used here.

doom of the fiendish races, fled instead to Thelanis where they soon became a major scourge of the fey peoples. Those aboleths who could not escape back to Xoriat fled into the deepest depths of the underground seas of Khyber, there to wait the day the Silver Flame guttered out and they could seek their own revenge with the fiends against the great wyrms. The dragons retreated to Argonessen to further contemplate the Prophecy, ignoring the “lesser races.”

The Blood of Khyber

For untold millennia, the dragons were the sole lords of Eberron during the Age of Dragons. Then a new threat emerged some ten million years before the founding of the Kingdom of Galifar. Khyber was bound in the depths of Eberron, but this did not eliminate the dark Progenitor’s power. In time, a host of horrors spawned in the depths. Rakshasas, night hags, and other demonic terrors emerged to lay claim to the world above. The greatest were the *Na-Vakhti*, the Overlords of Khyber, who were fiends of such power that they possessed strength easily equivalent to that of minor gods. At this time, the dragons of Argonessen were organized into simple clans called flights, which fought with one another as often as not. Scattered and wild, they were no match for the sudden onslaught of the Overlords of Khyber and their legions of flying, crawling and shrieking fiends.

The Draconic Prophecy

After the mighty fiends consolidated their hold on the surface world, they ruled over a nightmare kingdom for millions of years. The once-proud dragons were forced into slavery and servitude. The fiendish dominion might have continued until the end of time, if not for the couatl Hezcalipa and a blue dragon named Ourelonastrix.

Working together over the course of centuries, these two visionaries studied the sky and stars, and compared their findings with mysterious patterns that appeared on the surface of the world. They became convinced that such study could reveal a map of the future, an outline of the myriad paths history might follow. Ourelonastrix believed it to be the wisdom of the Progenitors, a blueprint for the shape of reality. He called it the draconic Prophecy, authored by Eberron and Siberys themselves in the form of the raw Prophecy marks that appeared in the bedrock of the world.

The Great War Between Dragons and Fiends

The draconic Prophecy gave Ourelonastrix insights into the weaknesses of the fiendish Overlords. Even more, it gave the dragon and his kin a sense of hope, the belief that dragons were part of something greater and grander than their own petty interests and problems. Following the path

of the Prophecy, Ourelonastrix and Hezcalipa rallied their peoples against the children of Khyber, setting in motion a war that would continue for thousands of years. Despite their raw power—or perhaps, because of it—the Overlords and their followers were scattered and overconfident. This allowed the combined might of the dragon–couatl alliance to defeat them one by one.

Despite this advantage, the war against the fiends seemed hopeless. The Overlords were truly immortal. The defeat of an Overlord was only temporary at best since their forms were reborn in less than a day after their destruction in the depths of Khyber and no simple spell could bind them. The fiends also had access to powerful weapons that could be used to devastating effect against the dragons. The most powerful of the Overlords, Tiamat, the Daughter of Khyber, created the *Orbs of Dragonkind*, artifacts that allowed the user to channel Tiamat’s infernal power to bind dragons to his will. Whatever the truth of this legend, these artifacts are both despised and desperately prized by the dragons of Argonnessen, who are determined to keep them out of the hands of mortal and fiend alike. It is believed that seven of the *Orbs* are currently held in the hoards of the mightiest elder wyrms of Argonnessen; the remaining are currently unaccounted for. Several other *Orbs* are known to have been created by other races, perhaps with fiendish aid. The giants of Xen’drik, for example, are known to have fashioned two *Orbs of Dragonkind* before their own conflict with the dragons (see below).

Then the couatl Hezcalipa’s studies uncovered a path to victory. Indeed, the outcome appeared foreordained in the Prophecy. Still, the cost was terrible. Led by Hezcalipa, the couatls sacrificed almost their entire race, using a powerful magical ritual to forge their immortal essence into a pure divine force for righteous good later called the Silver Flame. Once unleashed, this divine force could hold the Overlords and their dire followers within arcane prisons in the depths of the Dragon Below. Some fiends escaped this imprisonment and fled to the Demon Wastes on the northwestern corner of the continent of Khorvaire. There they formed an organization known as the Lords of Dust dedicated to restoring the rule of the fiends over the world, but the war was won.

Although the dragons fought fiercely, some scholars believe that they abandoned the couatls at the end, refusing to share the cost of the final sacrifice of binding the fiends in the darkness of Khyber. It is possible that this abandonment was a matter of fear, although that seems unlikely in a race as powerful as that of the dragons. It might be that, being mortal, the dragons simply did not have the same spiritual energy required to bind the fiends as did the couatls. The feathered serpents had been born from the more pure essence of Siberys and thus were immortal celestial creatures just as the children of Khyber were fiends born from the dark essence of the Dragon Below. Perhaps the dragons’ survival was a calculated decision. Whatever the truth, the self-sacrifice of the couatls

removed both celestials and fiends from the day-to-day life of Eberron, leaving the dragons as masters of the Prophecy and the most powerful beings in the world.

Draconic Expansion and Withdrawal

The Great War against the fiends united the dragons as never before. It forced them to set aside their petty rivalries and to master the arcane powers that had long lain dormant within them. The surviving dragons were more powerful than ever before, but their population had been devastated by the long battle. Following the defeat of the Overlords, most of the surviving dragons retreated to the sanctuary of Argonnessen. The elder wyrms gathered in the first great Draconic Conclave of Argonnessen and laid the foundation of draconic culture that remains in place to this day. The survivors spent tens of thousands of years nursing their wounds, rebuilding their flights, identifying and studying the signs of the Prophecy and honing the magical gifts they had developed during the war. In time, some began to look beyond Argonnessen, and to explore the lands they rediscovered.

Sixty thousand years ago, the dragons began spreading across Eberron again. They found dozens of growing humanoid civilizations—kingdoms of giants and their titan forebears in Xen'drik, primitive clans of dwarves on the arctic continent of the Frostfell north of Khorvaire, nomadic groups of shifters and humans in Sarlona, and the nascent goblin and orc races in Khorvaire. Some merely wished to study the lesser creatures. A few came as mentors, foremost among them the descendants of Ourelonastrix. These dragons shared the secrets of arcane magic with the giants, curious to see what innovations these promising creatures might develop. But the bulk of the dragons chose the path of conquest. Flights of dragons carved out new dominions across the world.

For most of the dragons, it began as a game—one with a high cost in life among nondragons. In time, however, the struggle turned dragon against dragon. Friendly rivalries became bitter. The blood of dragons flowed. And as the troubles spread, the Daughter of Khyber stirred in the Pit of Five Sorrows. Hundreds of dragons fell under her sway, and the spawn of Tiamat rose from tainted broods. Given time to spread, this infernal corruption could have destroyed Argonnessen.

Fortunately for the dragons, the watchful Eyes of Chronopsis, the draconic guardians of the law, were able to identify the tainted dragons, and the militant Light of Siberys, the dragons' military force, brought an end to the corruption. The Conclave gathered at a massive natural aerie in the heart of Argonnessen. There the students of the draconic Prophecy presented their findings. To this day, the records of this gathering remain privileged information even within Argonnessen, shared only with the most respected and powerful elder wyrms. Most dragons believe that the seers linked Tiamat's rising power to the spread of draconic activity across the globe—opining that the influence

of the dragon lords in turn empowered the Daughter of Khyber and weakened her prison. One fact is known: Following the council, the Conclave called on the scattered dragons to return to Argonnessen. The age of draconic expansion across Eberron was at an end. Outside of Argonnessen, the world would now be inherited by the “lesser races.”

The Age of Giants

–80,000 YK

The Birth of the Giant Nations: The massive elemental humanoids known as the giants rose from the ruins of the Dragon–Fiend Wars to establish a vast and powerful civilization on their home continent of Xen’drik. The giants were towering humanoids who were strongly tied to the elemental nature of Eberron, a world forged in part by the Progenitor wyrms from the raw material of the Elemental Chaos. The giants were in some ways the sentient expressions of this part of the world’s nature. At least three major giant civilizations are known to have come into being during this time through the efforts of the greatest of giantkind who were called the titans: the peaceful, intellectually-inclined Empire of Cul’sir, the Group of Eleven and the militaristic, flame-worshipping Sul’at League. The giants of these civilizations enslaved the elves, recently arrived immigrants to Eberron from the mirror world of Thelanis, also known as the Feywild. The elves were a relatively peaceful, nomadic folk who enjoyed living in the woodlands and jungles of Xen’drik before the first of their tribes began to be enslaved by the giants. This enslavement had the inadvertent effect of pulling the first of the common humanoid races out of their primitive state.

–60,000 YK

The Golden Age of Xen’drik: The dragons of Argonessen’s stormy romance with the continent of Xen’drik began tens of thousands of years ago and, as tumultuous affairs often do, it ended in tragedy. Sixty millennia ago, the dragons gazed across the Thunder Sea at the glorious empires the giants had raised up on Xen’drik and decided to share the power and majesty of arcane magic with them. Upon the steps of a towering white ziggurat at an oasis deep in the Menechtarun Desert of western Xen’drik, the dragons, led by Ourelonastrix, made contact with the giant kingdoms and began to teach the titan overlords and their fellow giants how to use arcane magic. The giants started to worship Ourelonastrix as the god Ouralon, the lord of knowledge and law, a faith that replaced the giants’ devotion to earlier, more morally ambivalent gods such as Rom-Praxis. The oasis where the great blue dragon and the giants first collaborated was turned by the titans into a magical paradise in honor of their draconic patrons. Living marble statues frolicked among pools of crystalline water whose inherent magic promised life everlasting and the cure to all afflictions of the

mind, body and soul. Vast orchards of date trees sprouted from the sand of the oasis, their fruit granting joyous visions of the future to all who partook of them.

A golden age unrivaled in any other era of Eberron's history soon followed. Giant and dragon stood side by side, crafting newborn utopias among the giant nations where none suffered from hunger or crime. Together, the giants and dragons cheated death, touched the stars and kept the Lords of Dust securely imprisoned underground in Khyber. Under the dragons' patronage, the giants crafted sky-scraping monuments and wonders of surpassing beauty that would eventually draw the notice of the inhabitants of Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams. The dragons reveled in the giants' successes and then returned to Argonessen, drunk with pride and secure in the belief that the decision to teach the giants the full mysteries of arcane magic was a correct one, for the giants were as trustworthy with the power as the elder great wyrms. Time would prove the dragons disastrously wrong.

The giants quickly mastered the arcane arts taught by the dragons and used this knowledge to create magical wonders and artifacts unequaled even in the present day. The giants used their new power to found multiple new giant settlements across the length and breadth of Xen'drik. Among the many accomplishments of the fire-worshipping Sul'at League giants, perhaps the most powerful practitioners of conjuration, transmutation and elemental binding magics ever known on Eberron, was the magical infusion of a portion of the essence of Khyber into a community of their elven slaves, creating the separate black-skinned race of elves known as the dark elves or the drow. The drow were set apart from their elven cousins from the beginning, for the giants often used the drow to hunt down escaped elven slaves or to combat the roaming tribes of freed elven slaves who often launched nuisance guerilla attacks on isolated giants in the deep jungle when they got the chance. In return for this service many drow received special privileges from their giant masters, although others came to hate their enslavement as much as any elf.

The giants of this period ranged far afield across the length and breadth of Eberron, even sending exploratory parties to Sarlona. In that distant land the giants used their magical might to create a race of half-giants by fusing their own blood with that of the psionically-potent humans of that continent. The half-giants took the elves' place as the giants' slaves and servants at their Sarlonan outposts. Other legends of the half-giants say that these giant outposts in Sarlona were only established after the fall of the giants' civilizations on Xen'drik when they tried to escape the devastation the dragons rained down on that continent and that they were the descendants of these giant explorers.

During the twenty millennia of the giants' golden age, the elves watched and learned much of arcane magic from their place at the giants' heels. One group of elves known as the Qabalin broke

away from their giant masters and founded their own civilization. The Qabalin were a reclusive sect of elves whose arcane might even the giants feared, and these elves lived alongside their drow cousins, who they employed as servants and arcane assistants. Stories tell of how the titans first learned their magic from the dragon god Ouralon, bringer of light and law, even as the Qabalin drew on the power of Ouralon's terrible divine Shadow. Whatever the truth behind the legends, these elves were the mightiest conjurers and necromancers Eberron had ever seen, pioneering many of the necromantic techniques used in the present day—along with most of the fundamental principles of the necromantic religion that would one day become known as the Blood of Vol. According to legend, the Qabalin created the first vampires, some of whom might still lie entombed in their ancient ruins.

The Qabalin lived in a single massive city-state called Qalatesh, a fortress in the legendary mountainous region of Xen'drik known as the Ring of Storms. Left unchecked, the Qabalin might have one day dominated the land, but fate—or divine providence—intervened. Over forty thousand years ago, a massive Siberys dragonshard called the Heart of Siberys plummeted from the sky, smashing into Qalatesh. The impact and the resulting devastation (both magical and natural) destroyed the necromantic elves' civilization. Remarkably, though, the damage did not extend beyond the mountain ring. The giants called this outcome a miracle, citing the harsh justice of Ouralon and the event as a divine warning to those who would traffic with the Shadow.

–40,000 YK

The Quori-Giant War Begins: The utopia the giants had taken twenty thousand years to build came crashing down almost overnight when the quori, the alien inhabitants of the Plane of Dreams, invaded Xen'drik through a planar gate that connected Eberron to Dal Quor forty millennia ago. Dal Quor's vile caress brought with it an unspeakable alien doom for the giant empires. Nightmares erupted from the earth and the sky as the giants faced the psionic power of the quori, a power that all their magical studies had not prepared them to combat. Since the quori found it difficult to operate in the physical world, which operated under such very different natural laws than the Plane of Dreams, the quori created arcane creation forges and actually funneled the primal life force of Eberron herself to craft the first warforged, living, sentient arcane constructs who swelled the quori's foul legions. The warforged did not need to eat or sleep, and they proved to be powerful additions to the quori army, especially when paired with *docents*, spherical, sentient arcane repositories of quori knowledge and memory that could interface with individual warforged to enhance their capabilities. These *docents* were originally designed to serve as magical safehavens for

quori spirits in the event that the Plane of Dreams underwent its cyclical transformation, destroying the entire current race of quori. However, the project met with only limited success and so the *docents* were later converted into warforged combat aids.

After centuries of battle against the quori and their living constructs alongside their rivals and sometime allies the Cul'sir, the Sul'at's titan overlords were forced to resort to a desperate gambit to prevent all of Xen'drik from falling before the power of Dal Quor. The Sul'at corrupted the dragons' gift of arcane magic with foul blood rites and brutal sacrifices of their elven slaves and other giants. They returned to the oasis in the Menechtarun Desert where Ouralon had first instructed the titans in the ways of arcane power and constructed a perverse sacrificial altar atop the white ziggurat where the dragons had first made themselves known to the giants of Xen'drik. This altar, the Altar of Blood, soon ran crimson with gallons of blood from the Sul'at's sacrifices. The oasis paradise where the giants had celebrated their friendship with the dragons was transformed into the horrific Oasis of Blood as the Sul'at embraced the dark power granted by blood magic. The majestic marble statues now wept crimson tears and the once-clear pools of healing waters clouded with dark red blood. The white ziggurat still stood, a sand-scoured testament to the broken bond between giant and dragon, but the dark power of blood magic that tainted its altar drew undead denizens and evil spirits like moths to a flame. The giants had tapped these dread powers far beyond their ability to control to forge and empower an incredibly powerful eldritch machine called the Moon Breaker. The Moon Breaker's baleful power did succeed at driving the quori off of Eberron but nearly took all of Xen'drik with them. The eldritch machine's activation destroyed Crya, the thirteenth moon of Eberron, and in the process severed the planar gate between the world and Dal Quor just as the Sul'at titans' arcane loremasters had foreseen. As the moon disintegrated, the result was a planetary cataclysm that shook Xen'drik to its core and plunged large chunks of that continent beneath the sea. Mountains collapsed and gaping wounds the size of entire cities were rent open in the earth. The sun's light was blotted out for a decade as portions of the shattered moon rained down from the sky for years, spreading the unspeakable devastation across the world. The physical connection between Eberron and Dal Quor was severed, perhaps forever.

At the same time that they unleashed the Moon Breaker, the Sul'at used the shadowy powers of blood magic to empower two other potent artifacts—two *Orbs of Dragonkind*, one of gold and one of crimson, created through the forced sacrifice of thousands of elven slaves and hidden in the dark shrine of the ancient giant god Rom-Praxis that had been constructed beneath the Oasis of Blood. The Sul'at titans were all too aware that their pursuit of the forbidden rites of sacrificial blood magic

might draw down the wrath of the dragons upon their heads, so they created the *Orbs* to serve as the last line of defense.

The dragons of Argonessen watched all of this tragedy unfold, weeping to see their most precious gift so polluted with evil. They observed from afar as the aftermath of the giants' involvement in blood sacrilege gave rise to various magical plagues and arcane curses that swept the jungle continent.

–38,000 YK

The Elven Uprising and the Fall of the Giants: The surviving giant civilizations of the Sul'at League and the Cul'sir Empire never quite recovered from the events of the quori invasion. Horrible arcane curses and plagues swept through the land as a result of the Moon Breaker cataclysm and the blood magic that had been practiced to initiate it, and the elves and drow used the opportunity provided by these catastrophes to rebel against their giant masters some thirty-nine thousand years ago.

At that time, the elves hardly resembled the proud, powerful race they have become, but they carried the spark of magic within them, even if they were more gifted with divine magic rather than the arcane, like their haughty eladrin cousins back in Thelanis. As the decades passed, the elf slaves concealed the fact that they had been learning to practice magic from their giant masters, nurturing these skills to a greater degree with each passing generation. Contemporary Aereni know little of this time. The extant histories only reliably begin tracking the elves' history—magical or otherwise—with their escape from Xen'drik. But the legend of the elves' grand, race-defining escape is still told to all Aereni, forming the foundation of their acceptance of death and reverence for their ancestors in the form of the undying.

As all good legends do, the Aereni story begins with a hero, an elf slave named Aeren Kriaddal. Aeren served a powerful giant shaman for the greater part of her life. Eventually earning the powerful creature's trust, Aeren was allowed to observe and even aid in the giant's most potent rituals, all of which involved blood sacrifice. Through this participation, she learned to cast simple spells.

One day, Aeren was ordered by her master to retrieve the day's sacrifices for the ritual. Kept in a small pen near the giant's house, these sacrifices typically consisted of livestock or captured wild animals. This day, however, Aeren opened the door to the large pen and found that it contained only a single small figure: an unconscious female elf. In a numb haze, Aeren took the elf slowly back to her master's abode. Her conditioning was too thorough for her to do anything else, and on some level,

she doubted her master meant to slaughter her fellow elf simply for the purpose of enhancing his magic.

Aeren's assumption was wrong.

The giant shaman plunged a knife—a weapon the size of a large greatsword in an elf's hands—into the elf, spilling her blood to power a potent magical ritual. Horror struck Aeren just as cruelly. The magic released by the sacrificial ritual was more potent than any Aeren had seen her master perform before. Despite her shock at the death of the sacrifice, the portion of her mind fascinated with magic took note of the power released by the sacrifice of a sentient being like an elf (as opposed to that of a mere beast). But the betrayal of her trust in the giant shaman seeded a new thought into Aeren's mind: revolt against those who would treat elven lives no better than those of cattle.

Aeren began to carefully and slowly build a secret contingent of like-minded slaves, including a few who were eager pupils of the magic Aeren could teach. From these unpromising beginnings, the revolution nurtured the seeds of magical lore, and slowly expanded it with each passing year. Eventually, the elves began divine and arcane magical experiments of their own. The elven slaves at first recorded their trials and successes on pilfered scraps of parchment and leather, but the thefts were too risky—the giants might find them out. Instead, they found that their own blood was an ideal ink, and the bones of their own dead served as a perfect record for their findings. The giants suspected nothing.

Aeren never forgot the power unleashed by the sacrifice of one of her own race, and she conducted her own secret experiments apart from those of her conspirators, always seeking to unleash the power of blood just as the giants did. She had no desire to sacrifice her own people for any reason, but she felt that she was close to recognizing some key element.

Aeren's giant master felt the same way. Many more elves passed across the giant shaman's sacrificial altar, but to no greater effect. Those who were sacrificed wailed in their chains if conscious, asking for release, or fought wildly to avoid the drugs that would render them mutely accepting of the giant shaman's sacrificial knife.

With a flash of intuition, Aeren finally recognized the missing element one day after a particularly vicious sacrifice. Each victim was unwilling. Even when unconscious or drugged, the slaves' souls cried out for life, not death. Aeren's insight fired her with steely determination. In the wake of her hard-won knowledge, it was finally time to initiate the elves' escape from Xen'drik.

Aeren shared her theories on the power of blood sacrifice with the trusted core of her secret resistance movement. With this precious knowledge, they hatched a daring plan for the elves to

escape the captivity of the giants. But secrecy, even among the elf slaves, was vital, lest betrayal ruin all their years of hidden labor. Of all the thousands of elves held in captivity, Aeren selected only one hundred others to share the magical knowledge necessary to free the elves, as well as the exact time of the escape.

When the appointed day of freedom came, Aeren walked into her master's chambers. All across Xen'drik, her cohort of conspirators did the same. They all spoke the final words of a terrible ritual, prepared in advance over many months. The ritual was powered by the sacrifice of all the collected elf heroes. In that instant, all these participating elves, scattered across the continent in key locations, gave up their lives. Mighty detonations of arcane power were born flaming into the world. Giant citadels fell, towns were expunged of their giant populations—and elves everywhere saw the signal for revolt. Led by agents of Aeren and her inner circle, the elf slaves slipped away in the tumult.

During the Flight of the Slaves, as the elves call their exodus, a powerful, mysterious elf cleared the way for the fleeing elves of Xen'drik, diverting giant patrols, guiding lost groups of elves, and even obliterating obstacles (giant or otherwise) in displays of blazing power. Upon arriving at the northeastern coast of Xen'drik, the freed slaves discovered a journal, prepared by Aeren and placed within a platinum urn. Carried to the shore by an unwitting messenger, the journal documented the ritual that resulted in the great sacrifice of the elf heroes, as well as Aeren's notes on the rite the elves eventually came to call the Ritual of Undying. Aeren, unlike the other elven heroes of the revolt, did not perish. The influx of positive, radiant energy from the astral dominion of Irian during the final ritual sustained her existence even as it ended her biological life. Aeren Kriaddal was transformed into the first of the undying, though to protect this secret the elves claimed that Aeren had died in the revolt, a claim that most scholars today still repeat. The freed slaves escaped in rafts and boats they crafted by the thousands across the Thunder Sea to the small, tropical island continent that lay south of Khorvaire. They carried with them all the possessions they could manage, including in some cases livestock and even horses. The elves named their new land Aerenal, or "Aeren's Rest" in the Elven tongue.

But the giants were not willing to let the entire underpinnings of their civilization—elven slave labor—simply walk away. The giants, threatened again with destruction so soon after having forced the quori to return to the Plane of Dreams, were wholly unprepared to fight another war. Faced with losing the tattered remnants of their empires to the elves' rebellion and flight, the giants decided to unleash the power of the same grotesque blood rites they had used to stop the quori on their rebellious slaves.

Before the giants could unleash such earth-shaking destruction a second time, and before they could reach the Oasis of Blood to claim the *Orbs of Dragonkind* that might have been used to spare them from draconic retribution, the dragons of Argonessen decided that their former protégés would not be allowed to repeat their cataclysmic mistake. In a display of draconic power that has not been seen since, the Light of Siberys and the Eyes of Chronopsis drafted thousands of other dragons into a military force beyond human comprehension. This draconic armada descended upon Xen'drik. The flights of dragons blotted out the sun and for the first time since their epic war with the fiends, the full might of Argonessen was brought to bear. In less than a week, the dragons cast down the last of the giants and expunged the titans' empires with their elemental fury and epic magic. When their wrath was spent, the dragons had wreaked almost as much havoc on a continental scale as they had acted to prevent. As a race, they lamented their choice to share their arcane power with the giants. To the present day, that dreadful error is a stain on the memory of all dragonkind and it is one the masters of Argonessen intend never to repeat.

The giant civilizations literally disappeared under this fearsome draconic assault, wiped from the face of Eberron. The drow, many of whom had remained loyal to their giant masters and actually fought against the elven rebels, chose to either view their elven cousins as weak for leaving Xen'drik rather than taking the fight to the giants (the Vulkoori) or as traitors to the giants' cause (the Sulatar). Some wanted nothing to do with either side and just wanted to find safety from the dragons attack (the Umbragen). Most of the drow went into hiding in the Xen'drik countryside or rode out the destruction underground, while the elves had fled to the island-continent of Aerenal that they named after the leader of their mass exodus, the she-elf Aeren. Most of the dark elves eventually divided between the primitive jungle-dwelling drow tribesmen called Vulkoori who worshipped the scorpion-god Vulkoor (an aspect of the Mockery), the sophisticated civilization of powerful underground-dwelling dark elves known as the Umbragen, and the Sulatar, a nation of fire-worshipping drow who maintained the aggressive military and religious traditions of the Sul'at League, their former masters.

Following the dragons' attack, the giants' titan overlords disappeared from Xen'drik without any explanation for where they had gone, leaving the lesser giants deeply disturbed at their forebears' absence and simultaneously somewhat relieved that the leaders who had led them to destruction were gone. The more primitive descendants of this period's giants in later years went so far as to leave sacrificial offerings to the absent titans to keep them appeased—and to keep them from returning. The dragons laid several mighty enchantments upon Xen'drik that were intended to prevent the reemergence of a giant civilization whose arcane knowledge and lack of restraint could threaten all life (especially draconic lives) on Eberron. Additionally, the abhorrent blood magic

unleashed by the giants to create and power the Moon Breaker not only left their continent in ruins, but also tainted that land with many dangerous arcane curses.

The Travelers' Curse warped distance and terrain, making a journey from one point to another in Xen'drik extremely unpredictable. As a result, the same trip could take only days on one occasion and months the next. In addition, the terrain of Xen'drik magically alters its climate and condition at random. A patch of ground hosting a steamy, overgrown jungle one night becomes a misty coniferous forest with the morning sun. Glaciers melt into lakes in hours and deserts sprout temperate flora overnight.

The *Du'rashka Tul* or "madness of crowds" in the Giant tongue was a powerful arcane curse leveled on Xen'drik by the dragons themselves—a complex epic ward intended to prevent the giants from ever rising to power again. According to legend, the curse affects any group of intelligent beings able to establish a sizable civilization on the forsaken continent, so that they are suddenly gripped by homicidal rage and spread out to kill everything in their path (including each other). The giants, drow and other local peoples of Xen'drik became terrified of this curse in later years and avoided organizing into cities or large social groups, ensuring that Xen'drik's natives remained as relatively primitive hunter-gatherer tribal societies over the millennia.

Under these difficult conditions, the Sul'at, Cul'sir and the other civilized giants slowly devolved over the millennia into the far more primitive true giant subraces of the present time—storm, cloud, fire, frost, stone, jungle and hill giants. In many cases, the giants' elemental nature became more pronounced as they devolved. Some giants fled the devastation to Dolurrah, the Shadowfell, where they were altered by exposure to that mirror world's shadowy necromantic energies and became the dangerous death giants of that foul plane. The various giantkin races—trolls, ogres, verbeeg, firbolgs, and the like—are all related to these races, though they spread across the other continents from Xen'drik.

The Quori-Giant War and the Draconic Devastation of Xen'drik

Explorers in Xen'drik, Q'barra, or Adar in the present might stumble across a weathered draconic statue or faded image scratched into a cavern wall, but the dragons left few traces of their ancient dominion over the world at the end of the Age of Demons...with one exception. The giants of Xen'drik were the most advanced humanoids of the age after the Dragon-Fiend Wars, and they had learned much in their interactions with the dragons.

Those giants who worked with Ourelonastrix and his students used draconic magic to carve out empires and dominate their continent. The arcane arts spread, and soon the giants began to

explore new approaches to this form of magic. As powerful as they were, the dragons were mired in tradition, and certain paths of magical inquiry they simply refused to tread. The giants of certain long-dead empires, such as the Cul'sir Empire, the Sul'at League and the Group of Eleven, had no such qualms—their exploration of blood magic and other dark arts like necromancy, shadow and pact magic diverged wildly from the codified teachings of Ourelonastrix and the other draconic Sovereigns who had first tutored the giants. Nonetheless, the dragons remained uninvolved. The elder wyrms of many flights studied the draconic Prophecy, but agreed that it was best not to manipulate its outcome. They simply traced its myriad paths and watched as fate chose its course.

Then the quori came to Xen'drik from the Plane of Dreams. The motivation for this extraplanar incursion remains a mystery, but the giants' records portray the quori simply as ruthless invaders seeking to capture the power and wealth of the giants' great civilizations. Other evidence suggests that the quori merely sought refuge from a disaster on their own plane, or even retaliation against acts of interplanar aggression instigated by the titan lords of Xen'drik. Some scholars have recently suggested that the quori of this age, who belonged to a different race than the quori who serve the Dreaming Dark of Dal Quor today, were aware that the *Quor Tarai*, the guiding spirit and collective consciousness of the Plane of Dreams, at this time known as the Dreaming Heart, was soon to change, wiping out their entire species. Much like the quori and Inspired of today, the quori of this period may have initiated the invasion and attempted conquest of the world in the hope of preventing the dreams of the thinking beings of Eberron from causing the change in the *Quor Tarai* and the destruction of their species.

Whatever the root of the Quori-Giant War, it was a struggle that lasted for long centuries. Powerful magical and psionic forces were unleashed by both sides, and, in time, nearly all the arcane knowledge the giants possessed was turned to the war effort. In Argonnessen, students of the draconic Prophecy warned that this struggle could shake the planes of existence themselves, but the Conclave insisted that the dragons remain aloof. The outcome is known to any student of history; the militaristic giants of the Sul'at League unleashed the doomsday weapon that was the Moon Breaker on the quori. This eldritch machine, created using the foul sacrificial rites of blood magic that were anathema to the dragons, destroyed Eberron's thirteenth moon Crya and tore the entire plane of Dal Quor from its orbit around Eberron, bringing a sudden and terrible end to the conflict. The *Quor Tarai* soon turned, the Dreaming Heart became the Dreaming Dark and the race of quori who had fought the war were wiped from existence and replaced by the current foul natives of the Plane of Dreams.

The giants' risky gambit devastated their continent and shook the very foundations of Eberron. Their former slaves, the elves and the drow, rose up against their weakened masters. Desperate, the giants began recklessly harnessing their ultimate magical power once more, preparing to unleash the same sacrificial magical forces that had vanquished the quori on the elven rebels. Perhaps they thought victory was possible, but many historians believe it was pure nihilism—if the titans could not rule the world, they would just as soon destroy it.

The dragons saw the giants' threat to the world traced out in the Prophecy. Shocked and alarmed at the effect the loss of the thirteenth moon had already had on Eberron and the rest of the cosmos, this time the dragons chose to act. A scaled army poured forth from Argonnessen, with flights of all colors led by the militant wyrms of the Light of Siberys.

The conflict was brutal, and its outcome never in doubt. The dragons had no interest in holding territory. They made no effort to avoid civilian casualties; they brought fire, fang, and epic magic to bear in the most destructive ways imaginable. In the end, nothing was left of the proud giant nations of Xen'drik. Giant, elf, and all the other cultures of that continent were laid low by the dragons, and powerful eldritch curses enacted on Xen'drik by the great wyrms of the Draconic Conclave of Argonnessen ensured that the giants would never again create a civilization advanced enough to threaten the world.

Their mission accomplished, the dragons returned to Argonnessen to brood. All agreed that the people of Xen'drik would never have posed such a threat if the dragons had not shared the secrets of arcane magic with them. The Conclave called the event *kurash Ourelonastrix* in Draconic—Aureon's Folly—and forbade any flight from sharing the secrets of Argonnessen with "lesser beings."

The Age of Monsters

–37,000 YK

The Goblin Civilizations Come into Being: After the dragons' attack on Xen'drik, the surviving giants of that continent reverted to living the lives of primitive, nomadic tribesmen in the ruins of their shattered civilization as the dragons returned to their secluded continent of Argonessen and the elves settled Aerenal.

Meanwhile, on Khorvaire, the first of the goblin kingdoms rose to power in the region that would one day become the nations of Breland and Darguun. Khorvaire's native humanoids included the three related goblin races, the lizardfolk tribes of the Talenta Plains, the gnomes of Zilargo (who may have been fey transplants from the mirror world of Thelanis like the original elves), the nomadic halflings, also from the Talenta Plains, and the even more physically imposing orcs, whose savage but noble tribes of hunter-gatherers roamed the forests and swamps that dominated the western half of that continent. The goblin races included goblins, hobgoblins and bugbears. In most of the goblin kingdoms, these three related races were dominated by a hobgoblin aristocracy that governed according to the dictum that the strong ruled over the weak, and since the hobgoblins were far larger than their goblin counterparts and far more intelligent than most of the bugbears, they were usually the rulers.

–29,000 YK

The Rise of the Orc Nations: As the goblin civilizations advanced, they were followed by the rise of the first true orc nations in western Khorvaire, in the areas known in later times as the Shadow Marches and the Eldeen Reaches. These orcish states soon competed with the goblin kingdoms for resources and territory.

–24,000 YK

The Formation of the Undying Court and the Start of the Elf-Dragon Wars: The Undying Court first appeared in Aerenal some twenty-five thousand years ago. Over the millennia following their exodus from slavery in Xen'drik, the elves of Aerenal came to revere their ancient dead as incarnate deities, seeking advice from undying councilors and petitioning for their favor. For the elves, following the example of the heroes who had won their freedom from the giants of

Xen'drik, death was not something to be feared; instead, it was embraced and ultimately welcomed. Each Aereni family expressed this attitude in a different way. Some wore intricate death masks. Others tattooed their faces with skulls or similar patterns. Members of the family line of Jhaelian went so far as to mimic the appearance of the undying while they were still alive, using magical and alchemical substances to induce rigor and apparent decomposition of the flesh.

Unlike undead creatures whose animating energies were drawn from Dolurh, the deathless elves who came to comprise the Undying Court were animated by radiant energy drawn from the plane of Irian using special necromantic rituals first discovered by Aeren herself. The undying were powerful beings of a generally benevolent cast.

As for the undying themselves, they were concentrated in the great cities of the jungled Aereni interior. An elven family estate might have an honor guard of undying soldiers and an undying councilor advising the living elders of the line, but the majority of the undying gathered in Aerenal's City of the Dead, Shae Mordai. Regardless of their family origin, all Aereni respected the undying as heroes of their race and always treated them with respect and deference. Many humans who hear tales of the elves' culture assume that Aerenal is a land of vampires and zombies, when in fact nothing could be farther from the truth. An undying soldier or councilor is an undead creature, but it is charged with radiant energy and sustained by the devotion of its descendants. Vampires, liches, and their ilk are abhorrent creatures that destroy life to preserve their own existence, and they are seen as a perversion of the undying by the elves. The creation of mindless undead, such as common zombies and skeletons, was seen by the Aereni as an unforgivable insult to the body and soul of the deceased.

Two forces actually governed the island-continent of Aerenal. The Sibling Kings held all temporal power. By ancient tradition, the elven nation had to be ruled by a bonded brother and sister. When either sibling died, the Undying Court selected a new pair to rule. The Sibling Kings were seen as the living embodiment of Aerenal, and the conduit for the divine power of the Undying Court.

The northern steppes of Aerenal were inhabited by a different cultural grouping of Aereni elves called the Tairnadal. The Tairnadal preferred the steppes because there they could better care for the warhorses their ancestors had brought from Xen'drik. The Tairnadal had a more active and aggressive culture than the Aereni elves of the jungle. They sought to honor their ancestors by emulating their heroic deeds in the present. In the last few millennia, many younger elves of southern bloodlines left their homes to join the Tairnadal, and what was once a minor sect slowly became a significant force on the elves' island-continent.

There were three major groups among the Tairnadal. The Valaes Tairn was the largest; these elves believed that glory in battle was the highest goal, regardless of the nature of the foe. The two smaller groups were the Silaes Tairn, who were determined to return to Xen'drik and reclaim the ancient homeland of the elves, and the Draleus Tairn, who wished to destroy the dragons of Argonnessen after the Elf-Dragon Wars began.

Relations between the Tairnadal and the elves of the Undying Court are cordial. They honor the same ancestors and respect the shared blood that flows through their veins, though the Tairnadal were served by a different clerical order known as the Keepers of the Past who venerated the spirits of ancestors already passed rather than the undying. The southern Aereni feel that the Tairnadal waste their blood by refusing to become undying after death; the northern elves believe the elves of the jungle spend too much time dreaming of the past instead of acting in the present.

Following the rise of the Undying Court on Aerenal, there was the first recorded skirmish between the elves and the dragons of Argonnessen, which set a pattern of long periods of peace punctuated by short, devastating battles every few hundred years between the Aereni and small flights of the dragons. The source of this conflict was the emergence of the Undying Court as the primary religious and political authority of the elven nation, for the dragons detested necromantic magic of any kind and came to believe that the undying actually represented a threat to the fulfillment of the Prophecy—or at least to outcomes that favored the dragons' preferences.

Some scholars claim Aeren Kriaddal's journal, left for the leaders of the elven uprising, contains more than the secrets to the Ritual of Undying. These whispers imply that the elf was inspired with the gift of prophecy just before the first ritual and sacrifice that initiated the rebellion against the giants, and laid out a plan for the elves to follow once they were free. Supposedly the undying now work to fulfill this prophecy in their own patient way, and this pursuit is what drives a faction of dragons on Argonnessen mad with rage. This prophecy, these same scholars believe, is what has led to the dragon assaults on Aerenal over the course of so many years. These dragons seem to believe that the prophecy of the Aereni conflicts in some way with the pursuit of their own draconic Prophecy.

–15,000 YK

The Rise of the Dhakaani Empire: The culturally advanced goblin clans of the Dhakaani united the other goblin nations of Khorvaire sixteen thousand years ago to create the Empire of Dhakaan, the greatest civilization the goblin peoples of Eberron had ever known. The foundation of the empire was the Dhakaani's great martial skill, which allowed them to forge a goblin state that

stretched across most of central and eastern Khorvaire and was ruled by a powerful dynasty of hobgoblin emperors and empresses. The empire had come into existence when the most skilled of the goblins' *duur'kala* or "dirge singers," a hobgoblin bard named Jhazaal Dhakaan, convinced the six greatest hobgoblin warlords of the time to unite their clans and choose her as their first empress. Out of respect and admiration for Jhazaal's vision of a glorious future for the goblin people and leadership in creating the new goblin state, these warlords, immortalized in Dhakaani legends as the "Six Kings," agreed to name the empire after her. It is said that Jhazaal could win the heart of a listener with but a word, or bring down an army with a scream. Whatever personal powers she possessed, she crafted many powerful magical artifacts that were used for centuries by the warriors and *duur'kala* of Dhakaan. The Dhakaani were able to come to terms with the gnomes of Zilargo through an accord in which the gnomes promised obedience and tribute to the Dhakaani monarch in return for continued autonomy in their own homeland. The goblins had less cordial relations with the lizardfolk clans of the Talenta Plains, who resisted the imposition of Dhakaani rule over those lands. The lizardfolk were subsequently forced to flee by the Dhakaani's greater numbers and superior steel weapons into the jungles of Q'barra where the goblins did not bother to follow. Their clans still reside there to this day.

One of the major differences between the Dhakaani and the other goblins of Khorvaire that allowed them to achieve such success was the degree of interracial cooperation within a clan. Among the other goblin peoples of this time, the strong ruled the weak. Leadership was founded on fear, and the weaker races hated the stronger tyrants.

Among the Dhakaani goblins, this situation was not the case. Each species had a role to serve in society, and each embraced this role. The hobgoblins ruled not through force of arms but because the goblins and bugbears respected their ability to maintain structure and discipline. The strength of the bugbears was turned against the enemies of the clan while the goblins served as the heart and soul of the society's economy.

Hobgoblins had always formed the foundation of Dhakaani society, from its beginnings to the present day. They were the most disciplined of the goblins, both in battle and at court. The hobgoblins ruled the Dhakaani state as the nobility and in the person of the emperor, and their power was rarely contested; their leadership skills had been proven over the centuries so that the bugbears and goblins accepted their respective and subordinate political roles in Dhakaani society.

A Dhakaani army was both tightly structured and surprisingly flexible. Their military was based around small units of goblin infantry that could quickly adapt tactics and formations to evolving combat conditions. Hobgoblins were trained to work together, using techniques like

flanking and pincer movements to maximize their effectiveness against powerful opponents. Dhakaani hobgoblins rarely adhered to any sort of code of honor in battle (unless they belonged to a special Dhakaani warrior sect known as the samurai⁴), nor did they seek glory like the bugbear berserkers. A common hobgoblin soldier took pride in his skills but in battle his only goal was to achieve an objective as quickly and efficiently as possible, whether it was killing the enemy, seizing a gate, or scouting a location. While there were a few exceptions in goblin folklore, military service was traditionally seen as a role solely for male hobgoblins.

Females, however, had many important roles in Dhakaani society. The most common form of arcane magic among the Dhakaani was that of the bard, and this innate talent typically manifested mostly among the females of the clans. In the Goblin tongue, Dhakaani bards were known as *duur'kala*, “dirge singers;” they were treasured both for their abilities to inspire troops and to perform healing magic. The *duur'kala* were the spiritual leaders of the Dhakaani. They used tales of past glory and ancestral deeds to bind goblin communities together and inspire them to a greater future. Alchemy, healing, and diplomacy were also seen as female arts; the male hobgoblins fought battles, and the females healed their wounds, both physical and political.

From an early age, bugbears were raised to think of themselves as the heroes and martyrs of Dhakaani civilization. They were taught to believe that their strength was the single greatest weapon of the Empire. Most were eager to prove their mettle and worth in battle. In combat, bugbear barbarians served as skirmishers and shock troops, smashing into the ranks of their enemies and using their immense strength to scatter and break formations while the strictly disciplined hobgoblin ranks moved up behind them.

With their prolific rate of reproduction, goblins formed the largest segment of any Dhakaani community. Dhakaani goblins received far more respect than their counterparts in other goblin cultures; most filled the roles of peasants and tradesmen, performing noncombat tasks that supported the hobgoblin and bugbear soldiers on the Empire’s front lines.

⁴ The samurai were devotees of a martial tradition called the Code of Honorable Devotion and swore their allegiance to various Dhakanni noble houses, who in turn ordered them into the emperor or empress’ service during the broader wars of the Empire. When the dwarves arrived in Khorvaire from the Frostfell and eventually exiled some of their number to the Mror Holds, several of these dwarves learned of the hobgoblins’ tradition and adopted it as their own, conveniently forgetting its origin among the Dhakaani. In the final decades of the Last War, a movement grew up—particularly among certain mercenary companies—to abandon national loyalty and any pretense of allegiance to a united Galifar. Advocates of the movement devoted themselves instead to individual members of Galifar’s ancient noble families, whom they consider to be the only legitimate heirs to the empire. This movement adopted the precepts of the Code of Honorable Devotion, and mistakenly believed that its roots lay in the political philosophy of the dwarves of the Mror Holds. Followers of the Code, called samurai like their ancient hobgoblin predecessors, are most common among the displaced remnants of Cyre, and they can also be found among the military orders of Aundair, Breland, Thrane, and Karrnath, as well as among the people of Q’barra. Dwarves from the Mror Holds also still devote themselves to the samurai tradition.

Thousands of years before humans came to the continent of Khorvaire, one of the greatest cities established by the Dhakaani Empire was the hobgoblin metropolis of Ja'Shaarat (Goblin for "Bright Blade"), which was nestled by the Dagger River in the southern region of what is now the Kingdom of Breland. The early Dhakaani architects carved their city into the stone instead of raising towers above the ground. As a result, the halls of Ja'shaarat extended beneath the surface of the world. The goblin miners pushed into Khyber and discovered that a vast lake of molten magma that burned with a supernatural heat blazed beneath the metropolis. The blades and armor of the greatest Dhakaani warriors were forged there and tempered in *khaar draguus*, the "blood of the dragon" as the magma lake became known. Later, the Dhakaani architects raised monolithic buildings that covered each of the plateaus over the Dagger River where a manifest zone to Syrania existed. These constructions would later serve as the foundation for Sharn, the City of Towers, the largest metropolis of Khorvaire in the present age.

When the alignment of the planes brought the daelkyr and their army of horrific aberrations to Eberron centuries later (see below), the Dhakaani Empire fell before them and Ja'Shaarat, like the other goblin cities, was utterly devastated in the fighting. The goblin empire never recovered from the conflict and its greatest city was never restored. The goblin tribes that hid in the city's ruins following the Daelkyr War renamed their desolate home Duur'sharaat, "Blade of Sorrows."

At the same time that the Empire of Dhakaan was beginning its rise to power, the Gatekeeper sect of druids first appeared among the orcs of western Khorvaire. Vvaraak, a rogue female black dragon of Argonessen, was a Child of Eberron, a dragon dedicated to the service of the Progenitor of all life. Vvaraak had foreseen in the draconic Prophecy that another great disaster like the Quori-Giant War would threaten the very existence of Eberron at some time in the future. When the Conclave of Argonessen showed no interest in acting to prevent this potential catastrophe, Vvaraak abandoned the continent of her birth and traveled to the Shadow Marches in western Khorvaire, the home of the orcish peoples. She taught the orcs the basics of druidic magic and how to channel the primal power of Eberron herself, an alternative to the arcane and divine powers already known to most of the peoples of the world. Vvaraak became the founder of the first true sect of druids in the world.

In time, druidic lore became the spiritual heart of orcish culture. The orcish druids who formed the Gatekeepers eventually passed on this knowledge millennia later to other peoples like the shifters and humans who called the Eldeen Reaches home. This spread of Vvaraak's teachings led to the gradual development of other druidic traditions in the Reaches, such as those of the Wardens of the Wood, the Ashbound, the Greensingers and the Children of Winter. But Vvaraak warned the

Gatekeepers that the druidic knowledge she had taught them was intended for a specific purpose—one day, the Prophecy foretold, the Gatekeepers would save the world.

–11,000 YK

The Exile of the Mror Dwarves: Twelve millennia ago, a large number of dwarven clans migrated from their ancestral home on the arctic continent of the Frostfell to the Ironroot Mountains of northeastern Khorvaire to escape the oppression of the frost giants—ancient colonists from Xen’drik—who governed much of that frigid land. Though the true origins of the dwarven kingdoms of Khorvaire are now lost to the mists of prehistory, it is known that soon after their arrival in Khorvaire a unified dwarven nation was established by the clans from the Frostfell that spread deep beneath the Ironroots. Within this kingdom, recalled in dwarven legend as the Kingdom of Stone, it came to pass that twelve dwarven warriors were exiled to the surface for the commission of crimes that produced barbarism and unrest. These exiles were forced to leave their underground homes with their followers by Lord Kordran Mror, the ruler of the Kingdom of Stone. The gateways to the Kingdom of Stone below were closed off using powerful runic magic and the dwarven exiles were told by Lord Mror that they would remain apart from their brethren in the deeps until they had discovered the honor that their barbaric ways had prevented them from earning. Alongside the exiles a clan of wardens was sent to the lands above to watch over these gates and reopen them when the time came—a clan called Kundarak.

For thousands of years to come, these exile dwarven clans fought among themselves for control of the lands that they ironically named the Mror Holds, both for dominance and for the right to return to the Kingdom of Stone. The Mror dwarves also repeatedly fought the original inhabitants of the Ironroot Mountains, the orcish clans known as the Jhorash’tar, for control over the region’s rich mineral resources of iron, copper, gems and other precious metals. Even the appearance of the Mark of Warding among the Kundarak clan did nothing to stem the inter-dwarven conflict; indeed, it fast became a source of bitterness and distrust among the other clans, who developed no such dragonmarks. When Prince Karrn ir’Wynarn annexed the lands around the Ironroot Mountains for his father King Galifar I several years before the founding of the united Kingdom of Galifar on Khorvaire, the fractious Mror clans were easily subdued by the human armies.

As it happened, the dwarves’ subjugation by Galifar proved to be the instrument of their salvation. Forced to set aside their violent feuds by their human overlords, the dwarven exiles created a common culture and found the honor they had long sought. In the end, though, this understanding came too late. When the heirs of Kundarak at last opened the sealed runic gates for the rest of the

Holds, the Kingdom of Stone was gone, its people destroyed by the invasion of the daelkyr while the twelve Mror clans had made war on each other.

–9,000 YK

The Elven Settlement of the Valaes Tairn Colony: The warlike Valaes Tairn sect of Aereni elves established a colony on southern Khorvaire in what is now the present-day Kingdom of Valenar some nine millennia before the founding of Galifar. Peaceful coexistence between the elves and the Dhakaani goblins did not last for long and the elves eventually launched a great war with the Dhakaani Empire that ended inconclusively for both sides. The Valaes Tairn elves abandoned their colony to the goblins when another clash with the dragons threatened Aerenal and their scimitars were needed to defend the elven homeland. The number of Valaes Tairn who were needed in Aerenal would have left the colony all but undefended before the advance of the Dhakaani, so the elves simply abandoned it rather than make a hopeless, though glorious, last stand. But the Valaes Tairn promised one day to honor the spirits of their ancestors by returning to Khorvaire.

–8,000 YK

The Daelkyr War Begins: The Daelkyr War decimated the western reaches of Khorvaire when nine thousand years ago the Far Realm of Xoriat, the Plane of Madness, became coterminous with Eberron and the daelkyr lords and their terrible armies of aberrations—mind flayers, beholders, neogi, foulspawn, dolgrims and dolgaunts—invaded the world. Determined to refashion Eberron into another nightmare version of their native Xoriat, the daelkyr and their aberrations passed through a planar portal to arrive in western Khorvaire. Their army was met by the legions of the Dhakaani Empire and the conflict between the two forces raged for millennia. In the course of the war, the Dhakaani Empire was brought nearly to ruin as the powerful fleshshapers and their hideous minions proved more than a match for the Dhakaani's finest bugbear warriors and hobgoblin samurai.

The daelkyr would have succeeded in their insane plan to begin reshaping the natural order of Eberron into an extension of the Plane of Madness if not for the intervention of the orcish druids of the Gatekeeper sect. The druids, led by the female orc Great Druid Rasha'Tornn, lured the main thrust of the daelkyr invasion into the Shadow Marches of western Khorvaire and unleashed the full, primal fury of Eberron upon the foul lords of Xoriat and their aberrations. The six daelkyr lords known to have survived the onslaught were then locked by a ritual led by the mightiest of the Gatekeepers' Great Druids deep below ground in Khyber with their surviving aberrations. The power of the Gatekeepers' druidic wards kept the daelkyr from setting foot on the surface of Eberron again, though

their foul servants could still come up from the depths at will to spread fear and death. The daelkyr were not immobilized in Khyber like the fiendish Overlords but could move around at will through the Dragon Below. The Gatekeepers' wards also shifted Xoriat in its orbit around the world so that the Far Realm would not again become coterminous with Eberron or be able to touch the world until these arcane seals were destroyed.

In time, the daelkyr's contained but subterranean influence led to the development of the Cults of the Dragon Below, foul religious organizations dedicating to worshipping Khyber and her servants, the daelkyr and the fiendish Lords of Dust, in the hopes of bringing on the end of the world and releasing Khyber from her planetary prison. In contrast, the orcs of the Gatekeeper sect remained ever vigilant for signs that their primal wards on Khyber were weakening or that another planar incursion from Xoriat was imminent. In the orcish druids' view, the daelkyr and all aberrations presented the greatest threat to the natural order of Eberron that they were sworn to uphold since they were inherently not part of the workings of the natural world, much like the undead, and sought to destroy the delicate balance between the three draconic Progenitors that sustained all life.

The daelkyr were the lords of the Far Realm of Xoriat, the Plane of Madness. A daelkyr resembled a perfectly formed athletic human male, possessing unearthly beauty and pupiless white eyes. Despite this outward appearance, daelkyr were actually sexless and did not reproduce, since they were formed from the chaotic fabric of the plane of Xoriat itself.

A daelkyr's horrible touch caused disease and biological corruption, and its very presence could trigger madness and confusion. At least six daelkyr (possibly more) inhabit Eberron in the present day. The surviving commanders of the daelkyr army that invaded Khorvaire millennia ago, they were sealed deep in Khyber and cut off from their home plane. For thousands of years, the daelkyr have bided their time in the depths of Khyber, waiting for Xoriat to be able to touch Eberron once more.

The daelkyr are immortal and endlessly patient, and their manner of thinking is almost impossible for mortals (or even other planar denizens) to understand. For the daelkyr, destroying worlds appears to be a form of art, and until Xoriat and Eberron are again linked, the daelkyr are indulging their other sordid escapades. Some are poets, musicians, or sculptors, although their works are invariably bizarre and alien to human senses. Their preferred canvas is flesh, for they are the makers of monsters. Dolgrims, dolgaunts, foulspawn, beholders, mind flayers, neogi, tsochar and other hideous aberrations are the legacy of the daelkyr—living weapons created expressly to destroy life. The subterranean citadel of a daelkyr lord usually supports a garrison of dolgrims, dolgaunt and foulspawn lieutenants, and illithid commanders. Each daelkyr also has its personal biological

creations, reflecting its own aesthetic tastes. One might have a preference for oozes. Another breeds psionic vermin, while a third crafts hideous and deadly carnivorous plants. Their experiments—creating new races by twisting existing creatures into new forms—take time. A daelkyr can magically shapechange a creature into something else easily enough; however, creating a new species of aberration such as the dolgrim and dolgaunts (created from Dhakaani hobgoblins captured during the Daelkyr War), foulspawn (created from almost any “normal” race infected by the taint of Xoriat) or neogi (fleshcrafted from the dwarves of the Ironroot Mountains) takes years to accomplish.

The ancient seals placed by the Gatekeepers trap the daelkyr beneath Eberron and keep Xoriat from becoming coterminous with the world again, but the daelkyr have not made a concerted effort to destroy these seals. Their motives are inscrutable—above all things, the daelkyr are the lords of the Plane of Madness. Insanity and corruption are the currency they deal in.

–4,000 YK

The Fall of Dhakaan: Terribly weakened by the Daelkyr War, the Dhakaani Empire was shattered by infighting and constant civil strife in the wake of the conflict, eventually leading to the collapse of the great goblin civilization into scattered goblin tribes. A small grouping of five goblin clans descended from the Dhakaani known as the Heirs of Dhakaan managed to maintain the culture and history of their lost empire in the region of Khorvaire that became the present-day goblin nation of Darguun. These Dhakaani heirs never gave up hope that one day they would be able to recover the glories of their ancient past even as their races fall back into barbarism.

Like the Dhakaani, the orc nations of the Shadow Marches were also devastated by the Daelkyr War and degenerated into scattered clans that call the Marches home. About half of the orcs pursue a simple, agrarian lifestyle and continue to observe the druidic traditions of the Gatekeepers as taught by the black dragon Vvaraak. Unfortunately, the psychological scars of the Daelkyr War were most deep among the orcs of the Marches and at least half of the clans in the region eventually gave up the benevolent spiritual traditions of the Gatekeepers for the worship of Khyber. Despite the all-inclusive name for these beliefs as the Cults of the Dragon Below, these cults had nothing in common beyond devotion to the darkly insane forces of the daelkyr and fiends imprisoned within Khyber by the Gatekeepers and the couatl. They did not communicate with one another and did not usually share the same aims or religious interpretations.

The Elf–Dragon Wars

Although the destruction visited upon Xen'drik by the dragons was monumental, some of the continent's denizens did survive. While the dragons brooded, elven refugees established the nation of Aerenal on that tropical island-continent after fleeing Xen'drik. Thousands of years of research into necromancy and the magical teachings of Argonnessen produced the Undying Court, an alliance of undying elves with a collective magical and divine might that rivaled the fiendish Overlords of the first age of the world. Since that time—nearly twenty-five thousand years before the founding of Galifar—dragons and elves have been at war. The tides of strife ebb and flow, and centuries might pass between battles . . . but sooner or later the dragons return to fight once more. The basis of this age-old conflict, and its conduct, is another of the mysteries of Argonnessen.

Many find it impossible to imagine that the Aereni could stand against the force that utterly destroyed the giant civilizations of Xen'drik. In truth, the elves have never faced the full power of Argonnessen. The strike on Xen'drik was carried out by the full, unified force of dragonkind; the Elf–Dragon Wars have involved only a few flights from the Light of Siberys, the draconic army of Argonnessen. The fact that the Undying Court has been able to hold off the dragons remains an impressive feat, but the undying have never faced the true power that ravaged a continent.

Those who study this puzzling behavior ask: Why not? What motivates this seemingly endless struggle? If the dragons truly wished to eliminate the elves, why do they not commit their full forces to the task? If they do not care enough to do so, why do they continue to fight in the first place?

One theory is that the dragons despise the extensive practice of necromancy, even when it draws on the radiant energy of Irian, but do not view it with the same abhorrence or alarm as the giants' planar studies and blood magic. Thus, they cannot agree *en masse* that Aerenal should be laid low.

Another possibility is that the struggle is a form of exercise for the dragons, a proving ground for the younger warriors of the Light of Siberys. Conversely, it might be that the wars are fought to test the elves and harden them for some future conflict foreseen in the Prophecy, just as a soldier will sharpen his blade in preparation for battles to come. The dragons might be unwilling to share the secrets of their arcane power with lesser races, but they can still push the lower creatures to reach their full potential. The long struggle with the dragons has certainly forced the clerics and wizards of the Aereni and the warriors of the Tairnadal to master the arts of battle and magic.

The elder wyrms of Argonnessen offer no explanations for their actions, nor do they negotiate. Only two instances of elves and dragons working side by side are known, and both involve the noble line of the House of Vol. Following the appearance of the Mark of Death (see below), a

number of green dragons began working with the Aereni family line of Vol in whom the dragonmark appeared. This alliance produced the half-dragon female Erandis d'Vol. Allies of Vol in the present time claim that her birth was intended to forge a bond between the two races and bring an end to the constant wars.

Others believe that the emerald-skinned dragons sought to gain control of the Mark of Death through their half-dragon offspring. In the end, the birth of Erandis d'Vol did unite Aerenal and Argonnessen . . . in a quest to eradicate the line of Vol. But this alliance was short-lived and involved minimal communication between the allies. Once the House of Vol fell into shadow, the dragons returned to Argonnessen, and in a few centuries the cycle of war began anew.

Vvaraak's Betrayal

Throughout time, rogue dragons have pursued their own agendas and dreams. Still, in the aftermath of Aureon's Folly and the destruction of Xen'drik, few dared to share the secrets of Argonnessen with lesser creatures. One such rebel was the Emerald Claw, the father of Erandis d'Vol, and it destroyed him. A more well-regarded rogue was Vvaraak, the black dragon who trained the first Gatekeepers, and brought the secrets of druidic magic to Khorvaire.

A true Child of Eberron, Vvaraak foresaw a disaster that would wound the world itself. The Conclave of Argonnessen had no interest in this struggle; just as the dragons had stood aside while the giants of Xen'drik battled the natives of Dal Quor, the elders of the Conclave told Vvaraak that they would act when a clear threat to Argonnessen existed, and not before.

Frustrated, Vvaraak abandoned her elders and her flight, traveled across the world, and began training humanoids and other creatures in the use of druidic magic and primal power. Although she is best known for teaching the orcs of the west coast of Khorvaire, Vvaraak had other students. Some Seren druids (the spiritual leaders of the human barbarians of the Seren Islands, the archipelago off the northern coast of Argonnessen that acts as a protective shield against those who seek to reach the dragons' homeland) attribute their skill to the teachings of the Ebon Mother, and lizardfolk boast adherence to the Gatekeeper druidic sect in both the nation of Q'barra on Khorvaire and Xen'drik. Vvaraak stayed in the Shadow Marches of Khorvaire for less than a century, and her final fate is unknown. Perhaps she lived out her final days in humanoid form, moving among her students and hiding from the angry Eyes of Chronopsis. Perhaps she descended into Khyber to teach the denizens of the deep. Some say that she returned to Argonnessen, that her act of rebellion was actually a carefully calculated move on behalf of the draconic Conclave. If so, it could be that the dragons

subtly planned and implemented both the destruction of the Dhakaani Empire and the defeat of the daelkyr.

Of course, it is possible that the invasion of the daelkyr from Xoriat was not the great threat to the natural order Vvaraak foresaw in the future. If this is the case, what monumental danger still lies ahead for the world?

Ghaash’kala: The Ghost Guardians’ Eternal War

In the wake of the Daelkyr War, one faction of orcs took the Gatekeepers’ philosophy of guardianship to an extreme, believing that they were meant to protect Khorvaire and the rest of Eberron from the fiends and other dark races of the Dragon Below that roamed the portion of northwestern Khorvaire known as the Demon Wastes.

North of the Eldeen Reaches, life gradually seeps out of the earth. The lush forests and great trees slowly fade into a broad tableland of dried soil and cracked volcanic rock. Further north, the elevation rises into the bleak chain of mountains known as the Shadowcrag, then drops dramatically. The land beyond, a highland plateau, is broken into badlands, a network of canyons and mesas that forms a natural labyrinth leading out to a plain of blackened sand and volcanic glass. This is the Demon Wastes—the last remnants of the rakshasa and fiendish civilization that ruled Khorvaire millions of years before the rise of goblins or humans during the Age of Demons. Amid the ruins of infernal cities, fiendish creatures searched for fresh blood while ancient forces watch from the shadows. In this realm of death and desolation, long-forgotten treasures and primeval secrets hid in the blasted wastes and the rakshasas and fiends known as the Lords of Dust plotted endlessly to corrupt the hearts of men.

Those orcs who believed that their duty was to enter the Demon Wastes to prevent its malevolent inhabitants from infecting the rest of Khorvaire were known as the Ghaash’kala, the “ghost guardians” in the Orc tongue. The Ghaash’kala barbarians believed they had been awarded a sacred duty to prevent evil in all its myriad forms from leaving the Demon Wastes. Primarily composed of orcs mingled with a handful of humans and half-orcs, the Ghaash’kala clan members were fierce but not bloodthirsty by nature. They acted to keep travelers from entering the Wastes, preferring to convince with words before drawing weapons. On the other hand, they considered anything that emerged from the Wastes—whether wild beasts, other barbarians, or travelers returning from an expedition—to be hopelessly tainted by exposure to the Wastes’ demonic residents, and they moved against such creatures without mercy.

The Ghaash'kala worshipped a force they called *Kalok Shash*, Orcish for “the binding flame.” The clerics and shamans of the clans say that the flame consists of the souls of noble warriors, and that this force holds the powers of darkness at bay. *Kalok Shash* is in actuality the same divine force revered by the Church of the Silver Flame that is composed of the collective souls of the celestial couatls, although it could be difficult to convince a templar of the Flame that a branded orc barbarian is a champion of his faith. When Ghaash'kala barbarians rage, they seek to submerge their identity into the flame, drawing on the strengths of the great warriors of the past and losing all fear of death. Noble warriors are often called to serve as paladins—although the Ghaash'kala paladin presents a very different image than the silver-armored knight of the Church.

All in all, the Ghaash'kala clans see it as their sacred duty to guard the Labyrinth passages of the Wastes from escaping fiends, rampaging horrors of the Dragon Below, and other evils that might seek to slip past the Shadowcrag and invade the Eldeen Reaches and beyond. Through the light of the *Kalok Shash*, new members are constantly called to join the clans and keep the ghost guardians strong lest the dark powers overwhelm them.

The Ghaash'kala clan members were relatively technologically sophisticated as barbarians went and their warriors made use of studded leather armor, steel-bladed weapons and bows. Clan warriors carried the brand of the binding flame on their skin as they believed that these brands helped to protect them from demonic possession. Four Ghaash'kala clans were spread throughout the region of the Demon Wastes known as the Labyrinth, where they share a common priesthood and have strong interclan ties with one another to help them carry out their sacred mission.

The Labyrinth is a convoluted series of canyons and depressions carved into the flat highland plain of the Demon Wastes as though by gargantuan claws. No part of Khyber, the Dragon Below, rests so close to the surface of Eberron as in the Labyrinth. In ages past, the orcs that eventually became the Ghaash'kala entered the Labyrinth for the express purpose of keeping the horrors of the Wastes trapped and cut off from the rest of the world. One of the oldest of these clans, the Maruk, has a long and bloody history of fulfilling this mission.

The Maruk clan of Ghaash'kala guards the central passages through the Labyrinth, the routes most often used by the Lords of Dust and their agents to reach the outside world. The sly and clever rakshasas often manage to slip past the vigilant eyes of the Maruk guards, but the sacred warriors of the binding flame are not without their resources. They can see through disguises used by the fiends, and when a fiend's disguise is seen through, deadly battles can erupt in the depths of the canyons. The Maruk clan suffers terrible casualties as a result of these constant battles; the only reason the clan has survived to the present day is because of the steady infusion of new blood from elsewhere in

Khorvaire. Orc barbarians from the Shadow Marches, human rangers from the Eldeen Reaches, and even human youths from the Carrion Tribes (see below) often hear the call of *Kalok Shash*, a divine beacon that draws them to the Maruk and other clans of the Ghaash'kala. However, the Maruk clan counts more humans and half-orcs among its members than any other Ghaash'kala clan and possesses slightly better equipment because of this greater outside immigration. The Maruk clan also has a higher percentage of paladins than the other three clans of ghost guardians. Members of the Maruk Ghaash'kala are somber and serious, prepared to die at any time in battle with the fiends of the Demon Wastes and other horrors spit up from the depths of Khyber.

The Current Age

–3,100 YK

The Great Druid Oalian Awakens: The two-hundred-and-ten-foot-tall greatpine Oalian, the future Great Druid of the Eldeen Reaches, is *awakened* to sentience through the primal efforts of the orcish Gatekeepers. Oalian will eventually become the leader of the Warden of the Woods druidic sect in the Reaches but will remain a font of primal wisdom for all of the druidic sects of Eberron.

–2,200 YK

The First Dragonmarks Appear: The first dragonmarks appeared among the intelligent races of Khorvaire over three thousand years ago. For centuries, the dragons and other explorers of Eberron had known that Prophecy marks were formed by such seemingly random forces as coral growth, lava flows and earthquakes. These were always the symbols of the draconic Prophecy studied by the dragons of Argonessen. Yet beginning three thousand years ago, such symbols, called dragonmarks, began to appear on the bodies of various related lineages of elves, dwarves, gnomes, halflings, humans and half-orcs. Like the earlier Prophecy marks, the dragonmarks represented primal forces that were tied to both the thirteen moons of Eberron and the planes of existence. As such, a dragonmarked heir was actually a pawn of the Prophecy: a tool that could be used to shape the future. The dragons could no longer ignore the “lesser races”—that they were intended to play a greater role in the Prophecy had now been made manifest by the will of the Progenitors.

Among the first dragonmarks to appear was the Mark of Hospitality among the nomadic halflings of the Talenta Plains, which eventually lead to the formation of House Ghallanda twelve hundred years later during the time of Karrn the Conqueror (see below). For those accustomed to the hard life of the plains, the powers of the mark were a real boon. The halflings knew nothing of the draconic Prophecy and concluded instead that the dragonmarks were a divine blessing and that those so blessed were obliged to use this gift to help others in need. The majority of marked halflings chose to follow this call and came together to form a new tribe. A number of ancient Talenta legends involved blink dogs who came to the aid of stranded travelers and the tribe drew on this tradition when they adopted the name of Ghallanda, a word in the Halfling tongue that roughly translated into Common as “helpful hound who appears where needed the most.” For centuries after the development of the mark, halflings of the Ghallanda tribe roamed the Talenta Plains, offering

magically conjured food and shelter to the needy. They sponsored glorious feasts for the heroes of the plains, standing apart from feuds and tribal conflicts. The helpful hounds were welcome in every camp and assisted Talentans of all the tribes.

At the same time as the Mark of Hospitality was emerging in the Talenta Plains, the Mark of Shadow and the Mark of Death appeared among the elves of Aerenal. It was at this time that the dragonmarked families of elves began to use the d' prefix before their surnames (as in d'Phiarlan) to indicate their marked status. This convention would later be adopted by all of the dragonmarked houses of Khorvaire after the War of the Mark.

The dragons watched in awe and horror as the Prophecy began to unfold among the “lesser races.” To deal with the emergence of the dragonmarks, younger dragons petitioned the Conclave of Argonessen for the right to create an organization that would study and secretly interact with the peoples of Khorvaire to learn more about their role in the Prophecy. The Conclave gave its conditional approval for the creation of this organization of relatively young dragons—known as the Chamber—and for the creation of a territory where its members could operate that was formed from the Vast of Argonessen. This area was renamed the Tapestry. The Chamber became a highly influential—and almost completely secret—power group in the political affairs of Khorvaire over the next three millennia, seeking to manipulate the common races of Khorvaire to bring about certain outcomes of the Prophecy. But even the members of the Chamber sometimes pursued wildly different agendas.

The dragonmarked families would eventually form themselves into noble houses that were the most important elements in the magical economy of the continent of Khorvaire. Communications, transport, crafting, animal husbandry, security—the cornerstones of Eberron’s pseudo-medieval economy were all effectively owned by the dragonmarked houses. The wealth and influence of the present-day dragonmarked houses extend far beyond the power of the dragonmarks, however. Though the unique magical abilities of the Mark of Making might have given House Cannith smiths an edge over their mundane competitors in centuries past, the spell-like abilities of the dragonmarked were hardly novel in a society where divine clerics, artificers, magewrights and other spellcasters were far from rare. However, it was the carefully crafted histories and reputations of the dragonmarked houses in future centuries that was responsible for their commercial dominance in present-day Khorvaire. The skillful manipulation of magic and artifice allowed the houses to use their marked heirs as the keys by which even greater magic was controlled. House Sivis’ *speakingstones*, the lightning rail of House Orien, the airships of House Lyrandar and the creation forges of House Cannith all kept the dragonmarked houses at the center of Khorvaire’s economic, military and social

development. As a result, the dragonmarked would come to enjoy a status in Khorvaire that “mundane” wizards and artificers could never match.

-2100 YK to -200 YK

The Founding of Io’vakas and Io’lokar in Argonessen: Throughout their long history, the dragons of Argonessen built no cities for their own kind. However, over thirty centuries ago, a great nondragon city called Io’vakas, the Gate of Knowledge, was founded by the Warders—a group of a dozen dragons dedicated to improving the lot of Argonessen’s humanoid “lesser races,” many of whom had been transplanted from their ancestral homes across Eberron by the dragons to act as their servants. With dragon magic and the labor of nondragon subjects collected from across Eberron, the Warders built a walled enclave deep in the south of the region of Argonessen known as the Vast. Under the tutelage of their draconic lieges, the citizens of Io’vakas—the “Gate of Knowledge” in Draconic—became enlightened dragon worshipers with an advanced understanding of nature, science, and magic. Today, Io’vakas is a mass of shattered stone jutting up from ground made barren by dragon fire. But each morning as the sun rises above those ruins, it reflects off distant towers against the slopes of a bare peak to the west. This place is still very much alive; it is Io’lokar, the City of Knowledge—risen from the ashes of Io’vakas a thousand years ago.

The creation of Io’vakas thirty centuries ago was preceded by centuries of debate and anger among the dragons of Argonessen. With the Chamber still in its infancy, most dragons opposed the Warders’ plans for empowering the lesser races. The idea of sharing even a small amount of draconic knowledge was anathema to many dragons, the fate of Xen’drik still sharp in their memories. In the end, though, the Warders prevailed. Io’vakas was built in the Vast with the tacit blessing of the Conclave and the Eyes of Chronopsis, and for almost two thousand years, the city thrived. Then the yuan-ti came from Sarlona, fleeing the strength of Riedra and the Inspired, and the doomsayers proved correct. When the serpent folk arrived in exile, the best among them were invited to Io’vakas. There, they joined the other nondragons of the city in a bountiful life that included worship of the fifteen ascended spirits of the Sovereigns⁵—a gift of faith to the nondragons from their dragon masters. However, at least one sect of the Io’vakas yuan-ti sought more power than the Sovereigns could grant. In secret, this group claimed the direct worship of the Dragon Gods of Thir—and the deepest mysteries of draconic magic—for themselves. When this blasphemy was eventually discovered in -200 YK, the dragons who opposed the Io’vakas experiment demanded a swift and

⁵ The draconic Sovereigns are identical, save in name, to the fifteen divine entities who comprise the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six pantheons worshipped by most other cultures of Eberron, but particularly among the humans of Khorvaire.

final response. Refusing to distinguish between those who transgressed and the bulk of the loyal yuan-ti, or even the Io'vakas citizenry as a whole, draconic might was unleashed with the tacit consent of the Conclave of Argonessen. Under a storm of lightning, frost, and fire, Io'vakas was leveled to the ground. A dozen or so yuan-ti escaped to the catacombs beneath the city; the rest of that serpentine race, including all the priests, were destroyed. From ruined Io'vakas, a pathetic few nondragon survivors fled to the plains beneath a sky darkened by gathering rogue dragons, anxious to add these so-called scions of knowledge to their own herds of humanoid servants.

Then Arnaarlasha, a noble gold dragon great wyrm of the Warders, descended to the wasted plain. She and a dozen elder dragons loyal to her formed a protective cordon around a thousand desperate survivors of the city. On foot, they shepherded their charges across hostile territory to the slopes of Mount Erishnak, a granite peak in the center of Arnaarlasha's own adjacent territory. To the assembled rogue wyrms and dominion lords of the Vast who had pounded Io'vakas and her inhabitants to rubble, Arnaarlasha declared the surviving nondragons free subjects of her dominion in the Vast. Over the year that followed, high on the mountainside, Io'lokar, the City of Knowledge, was raised. Arnaarlasha never spoke of what drove her actions that day on the plains, nor did she ever do so. Four hundred years ago in 600 YK, the great wyrm's death marked the city's darkest hour, and a turning point.

Within a day, Io'lokar was besieged by a coordinated attack of rogue dragons intent on claiming Arnaarlasha's territory and razing the city. Beneath arcane defenses honed over six centuries, the city's mages stood fast. Alongside the Warders and the Arnaaracaex, the stone giants who served as the city's first line of defense, flights of wyvern riders called the Spear launched themselves from the city's surrounding Moontowers, harrying rogue dragons in the air as they rained arcane fury against their reinforcements on the ground, while the city's militia, the Shield, held Io'lokar's walls. After four days, the rogue dragons retreated. Io'lokar stood fast, and its victory in the Battle of Arnaarlasha's Fall is celebrated to this day.

Throughout the great battle, the draconic law enforcers known as the Eyes of Chronepsis and the draconic army called the Light of Siberys were conspicuous by their absence, a display of indifference they maintain to this day. As long as the Io'lokari are careful to stay within the boundaries of behavior proscribed for them when Io'vakas was new, the Conclave of Argonessen now seems content to leave the city be. However, both the Io'lokari and the Warders accept that the city exists at the Conclave's whim. If any nondragons seek the forbidden lore of dragonkind once again, or should any yuan-ti presence be again tolerated, no force of will or lesser magic will be enough to save them.

In the twelve hundred years since its founding, the City of Knowledge has grown from a mountainside fort (part of what is now the Freeward of the city) to its present form. Within its walls, scholars, crafters, and artisans from a dozen humanoid races live side by side in common cause and culture. Though the Warders long ago stepped back to let the Io'lokari run their own affairs, the city remains dedicated to allowing nondragon culture to flourish on its own terms. Even after three thousand years, however, many of the city's sages believe that the Warders had a deeper purpose in their creation of a nondragon city within the dragon continent. In the same way that the dragons are said to shun the continent of Sarlona because they have seen that land's destruction in the unfurling of the draconic Prophecy, some suggest that the Prophecy predicts the eventual destruction of all nondragon life on Eberron. Whether this destruction will come at the hands of the quori, some unknown magical or natural disaster, or through the actions of the lesser races themselves remains unknown.

Either way, Io'lokar (and Io'vakas before it) might have been created as a safe haven for humanity and the other mortal races—a place in which the scions of Sarlona, Xen'drik, and Khorvaire might live on. Today, the city is home to some of the finest crafters, artisans, and spellcasters in the world. However, commerce does not drive the art, craft, and magic of Io'lokar as it does in Khorvaire. Though the city has no effective monetary limit, coin has no value there. Gems have use as currency only if they appeal to an individual Io'lokari's eye for aesthetic reasons. All Io'lokari work toward the continued survival of the city and the betterment of their own lives.

Like their draconic patrons, the Io'lokari are an insular society—many live their whole lives without ever setting foot outside the city's walls. Those who travel typically do so for scholarly pursuits, journeying across Argonnessen and beyond. Io'lokar is hardly a prison, however, and powerful citizens often leave the city to take up positions as advisers or scholars with benevolent dragon lords or agents of the Chamber. Although the powerful people of Io'lokar would no doubt have little trouble each establishing themselves as lords in Khorvaire or Xen'drik, those lands have little to offer. A powerful Khorvarien might dream of wealth or power. A powerful Sarlonan might dream of ending the injustice of the Inspired's rule. Io'lokari dream of peace, friendship, and the pursuit of ever greater knowledge. Their city is already the best place to achieve that.

Io'lokar's population of 46,000 people has been effectively stable for nearly four hundred years, even with a steady number of immigrants. The city has high standards, and those unable to meet them usually have little interest in embracing its philosophies in the first place. Powerful individuals sometimes flee here from the holds of other dragon dominion lords in the Vast, typically infuriating their former masters. Often, refugees from the Vast come to Io'lokar in greater numbers

than the city can handle. Once such folk are returned to health, it is thought that the Io'lokari quietly teleport them to the holds of more benevolent dragon lords, but this has never been confirmed.

Of all those who seek the City of Knowledge, only yuan-ti and half-dragons are denied entry. Although the Io'lokari know that examples of nobility exist even among the serpent folk and the dragon scions, the dragons' dedication to destroying these creatures makes their presence in the city too great a risk. It is rumored that persecuted half-dragons often pass through Io'lokar on their way to better lives in exile in Khorvaire or Xen'drik, but the Io'lokari shun the half-dragon cultists and crazed dragon hunters common in Argonnessen.

No matter what their moral bent, the Io'lokari take a decidedly neutral approach to the affairs of Eberron. Like the Warders who first brought their ancestors here, the folk of Io'lokar are emphatically devoted to the Prophecy. However, unlike the dragons of the Chamber, the Io'lokari are content to watch history unfold on its own terms. A group of heroes seeking aid in Io'lokar to prevent some Khorvaire-wide catastrophe and another group hunting the epic magic with which to cause that catastrophe would likely both be met with indifference.

This is not to say that Io'lokar is inhabited solely by distant aesthetes or self-obsessed scholars. The folk of the city are a rich and varied lot, and Chamber sympathizers, sages skimming secrets from their colleges, and adventurers who have developed a taste for profit can all be found here. The appearance of a band of Khorvarien adventurers causing trouble might be all it takes to bring such people out of the shadows.

–2,000 YK

Lhazaar Begins the Human Migration to Khorvaire: The great Sarlonan maritime explorer (and some say pirate) Lhazaar lead a migration of several thousand humans in a ragtag flotilla of ships across the Sea of Rage from Sarlona to the eastern shores of Khorvaire almost three thousand years ago, marking the start of a mass migration of Sarlonan humans to the new continent over the next few centuries. Lhazaar's expedition reached the easternmost territories of Khorvaire that would later be named for her, the Lhazaar Principalities. Lhazaar and most of the other settlers who sailed with her were natives of the western Sarlonan nation of Rhiavhaar. Current archeological findings indicate that Lhazaar's expedition left from what is now a ruined, pre-Sundering Rhiavhaaran port city called White Water Harbor. The sailors of Rhiavhaar often took to slaving and piracy, and Rhiavhaarian ships—as well as Lhazaar herself—were feared on both sides of the Sea of Rage. Lhazaar's flotilla was secretly accompanied by the black dragon Vyssilthar in her half-elven form,

who left her mate behind in Sarlona because she had foreseen the momentous role Lhazaar's expedition would play in the draconic Prophecy and the future of the world.

The Lhazaar Principalities region draws its name from this Sarlonan explorer and pirate whose flotilla directly colonized the islands of Greentarn, Orgalos, and Cape Far. Despite her fame, Lhazaar was neither the first nor last pioneer to settle along the eastern coast of Khorvaire. Over two dozen large islands are in the Principalities, and a remarkable range of people have found their way to the eastern shore. Gnome explorers from their homeland of Zilargo claimed the isle of Lorghalen long before Lhazaar made her crossing with the Sarlonan humans. Elf refugees from the Aereni civil war and the destruction of House Vol found solace in the icy solitude of Farlnen. Dwarves and orcs from the Ironroot Mountains migrated to the eastern shore, laying the foundations of Tantamar and Cliffscrape. And dozens of human expeditions followed in the wake of Lhazaar, with most being led by Sarlonan explorers, refugees and fugitives from nations on that continent since destroyed and assimilated by the Riedran Empire and its Inspired lords. The islanders came together over the centuries, forming cosmopolitan communities and common traditions, ultimately building the common culture of the Lhazaar Principalities.

Despite the blend of races and cultures that have come together to form the Principalities, Lhazaar's influence can still be felt. It was Lhazaar who organized the first raider fleets, leading expeditions against Zil merchants and the ships of the dying Dhakaani Empire. Lhazaar granted her best captains the rank of *praelas*—a Sarlonan rank in Old Common translated as “prince” in the present-day Common tongue—and proclaimed herself to be the prince among princes. She established the few laws that are now universal throughout the realm that bears her name, notably the fact that the title of prince is not hereditary. By the edicts, a Lhazaar noble holds his post through the power of his fleet and ability to command. Should he slip on either count, a more capable leader can lay claim to his title and his lands. Over the centuries, a number of non-human principalities have adapted this custom to their own traditions; the gnomes of Lorghalen allow would-be princes to challenge a ruler to games of wit and tests of strategy, while the Farlnen elves expect a prince to possess arcane skill in addition to naval skill and maritime power.

Though many Khorvarien humans are unaware that Lhazaar's expedition was the beginning of human settlement and society on Khorvaire, all know her name. Recently, a controversial theory has been gaining favor in academic circles, seeking to explain why the tale of Lhazaar's expedition has always been an obscure part of Khorvarien history. Ellias Onsten, a little-known Korranberg Library researcher whose reputation faded even further after his death in 980 YK, was responsible for a revisionist look at Lhazaar's expedition. Even prior to the end of the Last War, Onsten had studied

the fragmentary histories of the sorcerer-kings of ancient Sarlona who had preceded the establishment of Riedra. To him, it had always seemed odd that the first waves of humans to reach Khorvaire had brought precious little in the way of magical knowledge with them. Onsten observed that migrant populations typically hold on to their former cultures and traditions at any cost—building a new culture on a rigid foundation of the customs and traditions of their ancestors. However, almost from the first, the early humans of Khorvaire seemed intent on turning their back on the traditions and history of their former homeland. This led Onsten to conjecture that the first humans to settle Khorvaire might well have been a population that Sarlona did not want.

Today, those Khorvariens who know Lhazaar's story think of themselves as the descendants of brave explorers and seekers after glory. Onsten's less attractive notion is that it is the descendants of Sarlonan untouchables, criminals, deserters, and slaves who instead peopled Khorvaire. The notion of a slave culture was of particular interest to the scholar (and of particular abhorrence to his critics), suggesting as it did a reason why the early Khorvariens were so quick to enslave the goblins of the fallen Dhakaan Empire. In Onsten's view, the strong controlling the weak was the only world these human immigrants knew. Onsten's hypothesis has recently gained ground among Khorvarien scholars. To them, a culture built entirely by people who have a vested interest in forgetting who they had once been might look very much like that of the Five Nations of Khorvaire today.

At the same time that Captain Lhazaar and the first humans arrived on Khorvaire's shores, the Mark of Healing first appeared among the halfling tribes of the Talenta Plains who would form House Jorasco. Like its sibling House Ghallanda, House Jorasco was born on the Talenta Plains of eastern Khorvaire. House Jorasco was originally the Jorasco tribe, a collection of related halfling family lines. Eschewing the battle-hardened traditions of the Talenta nomads, Jorasco halflings earned their keep through skills at healing: from mid-wifery, to patching up wounded warriors, to helping ease the dying along their way to the Shadowfell. Their skill would be paid for by the recovering individual's family or tribe, an exchange of gifts and services that was the expected convention of Talenta culture.

The Sarlonan humans who came with Lhazaar slowly began to spread across the continent of Khorvaire, interacting at first with the few remnants of Dhakaan civilization that remained and sometimes overwhelming them, forcing the goblins to become slaves and servants in their new settlements. Central Khorvaire had once been the heart of the Dhakaan Empire for the same reason that it now appealed to the human immigrants—it possessed the most mild climate and the most fertile lands on the continent. These same qualities now drew thousands of human settlers over the next several centuries to the region, who founded dozens of new villages and towns. These human

settlers spoke a common language, shared common customs and social mores and also shared a common religion brought from Sarlona—a faith in the Sovereign Host.

-1,975 YK

The Founding of the City of Sharn: While a wave of human settlers from Sarlona eventually followed Lhazaar’s expedition to Khorvaire’s eastern shores, these brave people did not stop there. They soon pushed inland and explored their new continent’s northern and southern coasts seeking fertile land to settle and new kingdoms to establish. As a result, Malleon the Reaver, another Rhiavhaaran pirate from Sarlona, discovered the inlet of the Dagger River in southwestern Khorvaire twenty-five years after Lhazaar’s historic arrival. Malleon enslaved the goblins he discovered there hiding in the Dhakaani ruins of Duur’shaarat and built a fortress within those ruins on the bluff above the river.

Malleon, a superstitious man, hoped to make peace with whatever spirits remained in the ruins of the once-great Dhakaani city. He sealed off the deeper levels of the goblin-made mountain-monoliths that had been the home of the majority of the hobgoblins and he named the new human city Shaarat, deriving the name from the the stories of Ja’shaarat told by his goblin slaves.

Over the next six hundred years, Shaarat grew into a powerful and wealthy city. Around -1,400 YK, Breggor, the first king of the nation of Wroat that would eventually become the Kingdom of Breland, demanded that Shaarat bow to his authority. Malleon’s descendants, who were the lords of the city, refused. A long siege followed, ending when King Breggor ordered his wizards to rain down magical destruction on Shaarat, destroying the city once more.

Breggor wanted the city on the Dagger River for his own and he did not allow the place to remain ruined for long. Within a decade of the siege of Shaarat, Breggor renamed the city Sharn. For the next eight hundred years, until the outbreak of the War of the Mark in -1,500 YK, Sharn’s towers began to rise along the bluffs of the river and the city flourished along with the rest of the Five Nations.

-1,800 YK

House Sivilis is Born: The Mark of Scribing appeared among the gnomes of Zilargo in southern Khorvaire almost twenty-eight hundred years ago. The society of Zilargo, the nation of gnomes established on Khorvaire millennia before humans arrived, had long revolved around noble houses: alliances of families wielding great social and political power. Sivilis was an established gnome house even before the Mark of Scribing began to appear among its members. Though the

dragonmark originally manifested in only a few of the bloodlines within the house, it later spread to all of the families who composed House Sivilis. The gnomes of Zilargo, like the elves of Aerenal, were immigrants from Thelanis, a race touched by fey magic and driven by curiosity. The bards and sages of Sivilis worked quickly to unlock their mark's full potential. Recognizing the risk of being ostracized for the power they held, the Sivilis dragonmarked also sought to make themselves useful to Zil society, even as they distanced themselves from the politics of those they served. In this, they laid the foundation for what would become the standard for the dragonmarked houses across Khorvaire: mercantile forces whose political neutrality increased their commercial power.

Within a few centuries of the Mark of Scribing's appearance, House Sivilis spread to other lands, where its heirs' skills as translators and linguists proved invaluable to the young human nations of Khorvaire. Many Sivilis gnomes claimed that their house was responsible for the refinement and spread of the Common tongue and alphabet from the Old Common of the earliest human migrants from Sarlona. As House Sivilis spread beyond Zilargo, it made contact with the leaders of the newly created dragonmarked houses, helping to establish the common traditions shared by all of the houses to this day. As time passed, Sivilis would play a critical role in discovering new dragonmarked bloodlines and helping the younger houses establish a foothold in the world. Of all the houses, Sivilis has historically had the most interest in the draconic Prophecy and the role of the dragonmarked houses within it. Ever since Alder d'Cannith's assertion after the War of the Mark that twelve contemporary dragonmarks would one day be found in Eberron (see below), the sages of Sivilis searched for the missing marks. Despite its influence, House Sivilis never sought to dominate the other houses, instead working to be a friend and ally to all of them. Of course, the gnomes were a subtle people who knew more about political scheming than the human race could ever dream and many dragonmarked heirs wondered if the vaunted neutrality of House Sivilis was not a mask shrouding a far-reaching hidden agenda to become the puppet-masters of all Khorvaire.

-1,600 YK

The Emergence of House Deneith and the Destruction of House Vol: The Mark of Sentinel first appeared among the humans of the region of Khorvaire that became the nation of Karrnath twenty-six hundred years ago. These people eventually coalesced into House Deneith several centuries before the War of the Mark, one of the largest and most influential of the dragonmarked houses because of their maintenance of their own standing force of dragonmarked mercenary troops. House Deneith was based in the city of Karrlakton in Karrnath and its roots were set deep in Karrnathi soil. The features and militaristic temperament of the Karrns could be found at

all levels of House Deneith throughout its history and the heirs of Deneith were very proud of their Karnathi heritage. House Deneith controlled the Blademarks Guild, the primary source of mercenaries on Khorvaire as well as the elite Defenders Guild whose members served as bodyguards for prominent people. Because of its control over a standing and powerful military force, House Deneith became one of the most powerful of the dragonmarked houses alongside House Cannith and House Sivis.

Matters were proceeding less well for the elven dragonmarked houses of Aerenal. The Mark of Death had first appeared among the elven families of the line of Vol, a group of elves involved in secret necromantic studies, which took to calling itself House Vol after the appearance of the mark. The Mark of Death provided its heirs with control over necromantic magic, from the lesser ability to keep dead bodies from decomposing all the way up to the ability to control and create undead. Since undead creatures were viewed as utter abominations by the Aereni elves because of their faith in the Undying Court, the elves of House Vol were viewed with suspicion at best and downright hostility by the other Aereni.

Over the centuries, the Sibling Kings of Aerenal had established their own security forces and relied on the Cairdal Blades, a small, elite force of lightly-armed warriors and assassins and the Deathguard, an equally formidable order of knights and priests of the Undying Court, to keep the peace. The rivalry between the Priests of Transition who served the Undying Court and the followers of Vol had been building for thousands of years, and the appearance of the Mark of Death had only made matters worse. House Vol used its abilities to serve as Aerenal's undertakers and did not display the other uses imparted by the Mark of Death, though the house was riddled with elven necromancers who explored the full use of the inherent necromantic abilities of their mark in private.

Eventually, the leaders of House Vol secretly made contact with a flight of green dragons from Argonessen led by the great wyrm named the Emerald Claw. The dragons traveled to Aerenal and took up residence with the Vol nobles, magically disguising themselves in the humanoid form of elves. Historians still debate whether the dragons forged this alliance with the Vol elves as part of a broader peace initiative to end the Elf-Dragon Wars or because the dragons actually believed that they might be able to incorporate the powers of the dragonmarks into the dragon race through the birth of half-dragon children and so gain ascendancy over their brethren in Argonessen. Whatever their original intentions, in time the alliance between the green dragons and House Vol became so strong that the Emerald Claw actually fell deeply in love with and married the house's elven matriarch, a powerful necromancer named Minara d'Vol, and produced an elven half-dragon child with her named Erandis d'Vol (named after Minara's grandmother), whose draconic blood gave her

dragonmark enhanced abilities. Erandis was raised in secret while both House Vol and the Emerald Claw (his Draconic name is now known only to his daughter) tried to secure a peaceful end to the conflict between the elves and the dragons of Argonessen.

But the birth of Erandis d'Vol, intended to forge a physical link between dragon and elf, was a secret that caused nothing but horror in both races. The secret of Erandis' existence was made known to the Undying Court and the Conclave of Argonessen after being ferreted out from a traitorous member of House Vol by agents of the Cairdal Blades. The extent and purpose of this alliance between elf and dragon was never revealed to the public, but the Undying Court launched a full-scale assault on the line of Vol. The Sibling Kings declared that the blood of Vol was to be completely destroyed, since even a drop could destroy all living things as the carrier of the Mark of Death. It was the first war between elves—and the first time that dragons and elves sided against a common foe, as the draconic forces of Argonessen joined the Undying Court to destroy House Vol and its allies.

The leaders of both races made rare common cause and formed a temporary alliance to wipe House Vol from the face of Eberron, as they believed the mixing of their species to create elven half-dragons was an abomination. Despite unleashing every necromantic secret they had discovered upon the joint attack force of one thousand Valaes Tairn warriors, Aereni mages and dragons that carried out the massive assault on House Vol's home region, the elven rebels had no chance of survival. The end for the heirs of the Mark of Death came when the Emerald Claw was defeated in battle with several of the dragons' Eyes of Chronopsis who had been specially sent from Argonessen to lead the draconic assault force. This force was composed of militant dragons from Argonessen's army, the Light of Siberys. The Eyes had been ordered by their superiors to kill or capture the Emerald Claw for his heresy, though some legends maintain that the great emerald-colored wyrm survived but withdrew from the world in shame over what his hubris had wrought. Realizing that House Vol was doomed, Minara d'Vol used the powers of her greater Mark of Death to transform the young half-dragon Erandis into an undead lich and managed to teleport her safely away from Aerenal, even as Erandis watched her mother die in a fiery blast from the mouth of the red dragon Avothirax. The great red wyrm was leading the draconic component of the joint assault force. Every single heir of the Mark of Death was killed in battle with the combined elven-dragon force or became undead like Erandis d'Vol, and the magic of dragonmarks no longer functioned for undead creatures. All of the surviving unmarked heirs of Vol and its elven allies were allowed to live but exiled from Aerenal to Khorvaire forever by the Sibling Kings. The thirteenth dragonmark, the Mark of Death, was effectively erased from the face of Eberron.

With House Vol and its potential threat to the purity of both elven and draconic bloodlines extinguished, the dragons returned to Argonessen. Within only a few centuries, the brief alliance between Aerenal and Argonessen was forgotten and the Elf-Dragon Wars resumed with their regular and destructive consistency, shattering the dream of the line of Vol and the Emerald Claw.

But Erandis d'Vol had escaped and in time made her way to the Lhazaar Principalities, the island kingdoms ruled by pirate kings that made up the extreme eastern edge of Khorvaire. Erandis, who now called herself simply Vol, the Lich Queen of the Dead, constructed her Illmarrow Castle among the ice-topped peaks of the Fingerbone Mountains of Farlnen, the largest island in the Lhazaar chain. At Illmarrow, Vol nursed her grievances against both the Aereni and the Argonessen dragons who had killed her parents and wiped her house from the face of the world, forcing her to take on her foul undead state. Vol, who was an immensely powerful wizard because of her special heritage, became determined to gain some measure of secular power that then could be used to unearth the necessary magical might required to destroy both the elves and the dragons of Eberron just as they had destroyed her family. Over the centuries, Vol gathered followers—both living and undead alike—to her side and began to explore the ancient necromantic arts and the religious faith of the lost Qabalin elves of Xen'drik. Vol used her knowledge of the Qabalin to establish a new religion known as the Blood of Vol, which was largely based on the ancient Qabalin's own spiritual beliefs concerning necromancy and the undead. Cultists loyal to Vol spread word of her religion throughout the Lhazaar islands, and a handful of people among the Principalities and across Khorvaire consider it their primary religion, though the faith eventually gained its most loyal following among the people of Karnath (see below). Most followers of the faith knew nothing of Vol the lich or her history and plans for conquest and genocide. Instead, they worshipped the idea that blood was life and that undeath provided a better life beyond death than eternity in Dolurrh, as well as a path to divinity. Vol uses her highly placed loyalists to gather information and issue suggestions to the Lhazaar sea princes and their advisers. In many cases, the Lich Queen became the power behind the throne—both in the Principalities and in unexpected places on the mainland of Khorvaire.

The destruction of House Vol did not bode well for the other group of elven dragonmarked heirs who possessed the Mark of Shadow, House Phiarlan. The House of Shadow could trace its roots back to the Elven Uprising, the ancient war between the giants of Xen'drik and the ancestors of the Aereni elves described above. Many assume that this was a conflict between two monolithic entities, but neither elves nor giants were unified forces. Many different giant nations existed on Xen'drik, and there were dozens of tribes of elves, ranging from former slaves to guerillas who had fought the titan overlords for millennia. Over the course of the uprising, some elves served as liaisons between

the many different tribes. These travelers saw their role in war as being more spiritual than physical: their task was to uphold morale and maintain the alliances between the scattered elven soldiers. They called themselves *phiarlans*, or “spirit keepers” in Elven. These phiarlans learned the traditions and customs of all the elven sects, and a phiarlan bard could inspire warriors from any tribe. The phiarlans were not generals or military strategists, but their motivational work and the intelligence they carried from place to place was an invaluable part of the military effort.

In the end, pride, dragonfire and twisted magic brought doom to Xen’drik. In the last days of the war against the giants, the visionary leader Aeren gathered elves from across the continent and arranged an exodus to search for a sanctuary across the water of the Thunder Sea. Many of the phiarlans joined her cause, and their diplomatic skills and knowledge of the scattered tribes played a crucial role in the exodus. The journey was a long one, but the songs of the past and tales of glory helped soothe the fears of the travelers. Eventually the elves found a new home on the island-continent of Aerenal, and they slowly claimed the land as their own.

But in the time before the Undying Court, Aerenal was a very different realm from the ordered nation seen today. Most of the elves remained isolated in tribal communities, which ultimately evolved into the modern elven bloodlines. The phiarlans continued to serve as liaisons, working to strengthen the bonds between the bloodlines. Phiarlans would travel from court to court, performing the traditional arts of fallen Xen’drik and sharing news from other parts of the land. They also made an effort to look below the surface—to seek out rivalries and schemes that might threaten the peace and balance between the family lines. Typically a mediator would seek to settle disputes openly, but sometimes a phiarlan would quietly pass information to the parties that needed to know. This aspect of the phiarlan was well known, but accepted and even respected; a phiarlan might spy on your family’s court, but he would only use that information for the good of the growing nation. If you had nothing to hide, you had nothing to fear; conversely, anyone who refused hospitality to a phiarlan clearly had something to hide. The reputation of the phiarlans was their shield, and their remarkable skill with song, dance, and other arts was the coin with which they paid their hosts.

Death has always been an obsession of the Aereni. Millions of elves died in the fall of Xen’drik, and the elves swore that they would never lose their heroes again. But different lines followed different paths toward this goal. The Priests of Transition studied ways to preserve the spirit beyond the death of the body. The family line of Vol dabbled in blood magic and dark, necromantic arts. And the Tairnadal sought to become vessels for their fallen ancestors through perfection of the martial arts.

In time, the Priests of Transition won the support of the majority of the Aereni. The path of the undying relied on the veneration of life, while many saw the work of Vol as preying on the living to prolong the life of a few. Over the course of thousands of years, the Undying Court took form, and this served as an anchor that brought the family lines together. The first Aereni conflict against the dragons cemented this unity. Following this first battle, the councilors of the Undying Court selected the first of the Sibling Kings, and the present-day political and religious structure of Aerenal was formed.

With the Undying Court in place, laws were established to govern the land, and what had previously been a friendly alliance of elven family lines now became a true nation-state. In this era, the phiarlans moved from being pure mediators and newsbearers to actual spies. Tensions rose as the nation coalesced, and not everyone supported the rule of the Sibling Kings; in particular, the line of Vol rejected the teachings of the Priests of Transition. The phiarlans continued to carry the ancient forms of art and entertainment from court to court. But now family lords and the Sibling Kings paid them to monitor enemies, searching for signs of dissidence, rebellion, or feuds. While they began to take gold for these services, the phiarlans still saw themselves as peacekeepers: They brought light to the shadows so justice could find its way. And then the dragonmarks appeared.

The phiarlans had always been drawn from three different family lines: Tialaen, Shol, and Elorrenthi. The Mark of Shadow first appeared on a member of the Elorrenthi, but these lines had long mixed their blood and members of Shol and Tialaen soon manifested the mark as well. Some say that the ascendant councilors of the Undying Court are among the only humanoids with the age or intellect required to study the draconic Prophecy. But living sages had made some study of the Prophecy in the wake of the Elf-Dragon Wars, and while the elves did not know the significance of the marks, they recognized them as playing a role in the schemes of the dragons. The elves were the first to coin the phrase dragonmark, though few remember this. Fear followed the appearance of the marks. What was their purpose? What was the source of their power, and why had certain families been chosen? Given the long conflict between Aerenal and Argonnessen, anything tied to the draconic Prophecy was viewed with suspicion. This prejudice strengthened the bond between the three phiarlan lines, but it also pushed them away from the rest of the Aereni. The Sibling Kings came to rely on the Cairdal Blades and the Deathguard where they might have once used the phiarlans. The rivalry between the Priests of the Transition and the followers of Vol had been building for thousands of years, and the appearance of the Mark of Death three thousand years ago simply made matters worse. The situation finally came to a head when the Cairdal Blades uncovered the alliance between House Vol and the cabal of green dragons led by the Emerald Claw. This

conflict between House Vol and the Undying Court shook Aerenal to its core, but in the end the line of Vol was exterminated. Some whispered that a single heir of the Mark of Death, the half-dragon Erandis d'Vol, escaped the destruction—but Lord Haensu of the Cairdal Blades falsely claimed to have faced Erandis in battle and vanquished her. Still, the line of Vol had many followers who had no actual blood ties to the family, and these elves were given the choice of abandoning their vile necromantic traditions or leaving Aerenal for exile in Khorvaire.

Many left, though not just the former followers of Vol numbered among them. Numerous Aereni believed that the shedding of elven blood by other elves had forever tainted the land, and those who bore the Mark of Shadow feared that they would be the next to suffer the fate of Vol as all dragonmarked heirs became suspect. A handful remained, believing that it was their duty to the kingdom; these elves found themselves largely absorbed into other family lines, and this mingling of blood causes the Mark of Shadows to occasionally appear in Aerenal. But most of the elves of the Tialaen, Shol, and Elorrenthi families fled to Khorvaire so that they could start anew. To mark their departure from elven society, they formally joined their lines into a new alliance: House Phiarlan. These exiles began to call themselves Khorvarien elves to distinguish themselves culturally from the Aereni even as they merged seamlessly into the multiracial society forming among the human-dominated Five Nations.

The Khorvarien elves had been uprooted from their home and their culture, and they intended to gain a secure position in this new land as quickly as possible. That meant amassing power. The people of Khorvaire had never seen anything to compare to the artistic skills and talents of the elves, and this sparked a renaissance in culture across the continent. Elven entertainers were welcomed into every village and city, and in the process they gained knowledge and contacts. The elves of what was now called House Phiarlan had spent over ten thousand years serving as the eyes of the Undying Court, and they put these skills to good use. The Phiarlan were soon fully accepted by the other dragonmarked houses as an important member of the Twelve after the War of the Mark. And once they had sunk their roots deep into the land, the barons of the house contacted the other lords of the land, offering their services in exchange for gold or favors in the days to come.

–1,500 YK

The Extension of Human Settlement on Khorvaire: The distinct human settlements that became the heart of the Five Nations appeared in central Khorvaire around twenty-five hundred years ago as the waves of Sarlonan humans who had first arrived with Lhaazar continued to slowly spread westwards, struggling with the native goblin tribes for the best portions of the land in search of new

opportunities. These settlements included Thaliost (Aundair), Wroat (Breland), Metrol (Cyre), Korth (Karrnath), and Daskara (Thrane). These small city-states would form the core of the territories that would slowly evolve over the next few centuries into the human feudal kingdoms known as the Five Nations of Khorvaire. For five hundred years, these five human settlements grew and fought with the neighboring goblins—the remnants of the once-powerful Dhakaani Empire.

Despite the regional and political differences that ultimately made each of these states distinct, the people of these settlements all shared a common ancestry as the descendants of the human Sarlonan settlers who had come to Khorvaire with Lhazaar. This common ancestry meant that they also shared a language (the Common tongue), a religion (the Sovereign Host), a political system (feudal monarchy) and an economic structure (dominated by the growing monopolies of the dragonmarked houses over most commerce and trade). All of this commonality meant that the future Five Nations of Khorvaire were also ripe for unification under a single throne if a leader could arise capable of wielding together a strong enough military force to complete the conquest. It is at this time that it became another common custom among the human lands of Khorvaire for members of the hereditary nobility to adopt the *ir'* prefix (as in *ir'Wynarn*) in front of their surnames to mark their status as landed aristocrats. This practice later extended to the Mror Holds and Zilargo, where some dwarf and gnome families were granted noble titles by the rulers of the Kingdom of Galifar.

At the same time as the foundations of the Five Nations were laid, the Mark of Making appeared among the humans of the region of Khorvaire that eventually became the nation of Cyre. These related families made their living as roving artisans and tinkers. Over time, these families organized themselves into the more formal structure of House Cannith before the War of the Mark, which rose to eventually dominate commerce and industry in Khorvaire from its ancestral forgehold of Whitehearth in the city of Eston in Cyre. Cannith would become the single most powerful of the dragonmarked houses because it became responsible for the manufacture of most of the weapons and other tools used by the peoples of present-day Khorvaire. For every advance made in magic over the next three thousand years, the odds were good that Cannith's creation forges had a hand in it—from *everbright lanterns* to the lightning rail, from the warforged to the secret experiments now lost deep within the wastes of the Mournland that was once Cyre.

It was also at this time that the Mark of Warding first appeared among the Clan Kundarak dwarves of the Mror Holds, who became the dragonmarked house of the same name sixteen hundred years later.

–1,000 YK

Karrn's War of Conquest: Karrn the Conquerer, a human warlord with enormous military skill and strong connections to the burgeoning mercenary business of House Deneith, seized control of the territory surrounding the city of Korth in northeastern Khorvaire along the shores of the great five-spoked sound that divided the central portion of the continent some two millennia ago. The new ruler modestly renamed this first human kingdom Karnath and took the title of warlord rather than king. Karrn had not been born into the nobility of Korth and had learned his skills with a blade and his strategic sense on the battlefield while serving as a mercenary for the early Blademark Guild. The Blademarks were employed by most of the human states against each other and against the goblin tribes. Karrn eventually formed his own mercenary company and went on to use this force of arms to seize control of Korth and its allied lands while wielding his keen-edged greataxe. After assuming the throne, Karrn defeated the remaining Dhakaani goblin settlements south of Kaarnath, and then turned his attention to his human neighbors.

Karrn the Conqueror was a cruel and covetous man who believed that he was destined to rule over all of Khorvaire. He had built the most powerful human army up to this time, and after defeating the goblins he began a campaign to conquer the other four major human settlements. Karrn swept south, ostensibly to drive the remaining goblins into the wild regions, but actually invaded the region that would one day become the nation of Cyre. Caught by surprise, the humans of the area fell to the warlord of Karnath. With two of the human nations now claimed as part of his growing empire, Karrn's forces massed on the border of what would one day be called Thrane and demanded that nation's immediate surrender. Before Karrn could claim another victory, the remaining three human nations joined forces to stop the Conqueror's spread. What emerged from the carnage were five distinct but still nascent human nation-states mostly named after their capital cities (except for Karrn's new kingdom)—Karnath, Thaliost, Wroat, Metrol and Daskara—that spent the next thousand years alternately working together, competing for space and resources, and ultimately setting the stage for the great human civilization of Galifar to come.

Despite his strategic brilliance, Karrn had lacked the financial and material resources at this early point in the Five Nations' history to build an army large enough to complete the conquest of the continent and his empire proved unsustainable after his death, with Daskara winning back its independence from Karnath within months of the warlord's end. Karrn was assassinated by a trusted friend who was covetous of his rule over Karnath before he could launch yet another attempt at conquest. But his exploits—immortalized forever in his famous book, the *Analects of War*—would be

remembered by a later generation of nobles in the Five Nations (particularly in Karnath), who also dreamed of uniting all of human-settled Khorvaire beneath one crown.

Of course, while humans were the most numerous race on the continent and in many of the key positions of power, the other common intelligent races also participated in the rise of the Five Nations, especially as they became organized into the various dragonmarked houses. Thanks to the growing economic strength of these houses, all the common races eventually found a place in the developing human nations. Dwarves, elves, gnomes, halflings, half-elves, and half-orcs started out as representatives and employees of their respective dragonmarked houses, but eventually members of each race settled down and made homes in the Five Nations. These neighborhoods began as house enclaves, becoming less attached to the dragonmarked houses as the common races' populations in the human nations grew. If Karn the Conqueror taught the people of the Five Nations anything, he taught them to establish national identities that transcended race. For a thousand years, the Five Nations expanded and developed unique political personalities and distinctive cultures and economies. Karnath possessed a militaristic culture that honored preparation for battle over all other activities, Thaliost specialized in the research of arcane magic and magical items, Daskara's people were as equally committed to the divine and the search for spiritual truth, Wroat was dedicated to trade and commerce and Metrol held itself up as the height of the human arts and culture on Khorvaire.

-1,000 YK

The Discovery of Houses Ghallanda, Jorasco and Lyrandar: Karnathi soldiers first explored the Talenta Plains at this time when Karn the Conqueror sent his troops in all directions to carry out his plan for the conquest of the Five Nations. The Talenta halflings, who had never before contacted humans, were at first puzzled by the appearance of these large and unwieldy creatures, but the dragonmarked Ghallanda tribe had vowed to help all in need. Karnathi soldiers returned to their capital of Korth with tales of little people using magical marks to conjure food and castles from the air. These tales intrigued the other dragonmarked families of this time and so House Cannith and House Sivis organized a joint expedition to the Talenta Plains that led them to discover both the Ghallanda and Jorasco tribes of dragonmarked heirs.

Despite their altruistic traditions, the elders of the Ghallanda were no fools. Even those who desired to leave the Plains and explore foreign lands did not intend to do so as servants to the humans. They agreed to work with the other dragonmarked houses, provided those houses would help them find a foothold in their lands. After much negotiating, House Ghallanda was born. It took

some time for Ghallanda to spread its roots. Many humans considered the halflings to be cousins to the goblins, who were a largely oppressed and enslaved race at the time. The Ghallanda halflings had often served as tribal mediators in their homeland and they used their skill and charm at every level of society as they carved out a niche in the young Five Nations. During the War of the Mark, the Ghallanda halflings proved their worth by supplying and supporting the other dragonmarked houses' military forces in the field. This effort gained them the support of the other houses—particularly the crucial votes of House Deneith and House Cannith—and eventually secured their place among the Twelve. Over the next thousand years, House Ghallanda spread across Khorvaire and became one of the most trusted of the dragonmarked houses—at least as long as the ale kept flowing.

When the Jorasco tribe became a dragonmarked house, its traditional role of exchanging its healing services for in-kind contributions from its fellow halfling tribes changed. In founding the house and establishing its headquarters in Karnath, Jorasco soon found itself in debt to House Cannith and House Sivis—a debt that called for Jorasco's services to be repaid in hard coinage, not in-kind. In time, the healers of Jorasco were operating on a set schedule of fees and asking for payment in advance. This initial fee schedule was designed to support the healers of Jorasco in return for the time they spent caring for others. As the house became more successful, however, payment became less about survival and more about profit. The Korth Edicts imposed after the foundation of the Kingdom of Galifar (see below) codified this situation in a way and forced the Jorasco to focus their fortunes in gold alone. Since that time, Jorasco's mission of healing has always been balanced by the house's passion for profit, a reality that often angers those most in need of Jorasco's extraordinary healing gifts. Unlike their Ghallanda counterparts, House Jorasco would shift its focus from the tribal ways of life prevalent on the Talenta Plains to the cosmopolitan traditions of central Khorvaire. In the present age, Jorasco halflings have little or no connection to the culture of their nomadic ancestors and are firmly entrenched in the lifestyle of the human-dominated Five Nations.

At the same time that Karrn was initiating his war of conquest, the Mark of Storm appeared among the half-elves (Khoravar) of the human kingdom that became Thrane. Though the origins of what became House Lyrandar remain largely shrouded in myth, a few solid facts are known. Six hundred years before the appearance of the Mark of Storm, a significant number of Aereni elves had migrated to Khorvaire in the wake of the civil war in Aerenal that destroyed the dragonmarked House of Vol. Where elven and human settlements came into close proximity in central Khorvaire, intermarriage between the two races became common. However, when the earliest generations of half-elves were born, a good number of the Khorvarien elf settlers rejected them, leaving a population of half-breed children spread across the human lands. Over the following six hundred years, this

population of half-elves only grew as they began to marry each other and the new race proved it could breed true.

According to the house's own doctrine, the founders of Lyrandar were chosen by the gods of the Sovereign Host themselves. The half-elves Lyrán and Selavash were the first to manifest the Mark of Storm, both claiming to have received their marks accompanied by visions of the Sovereign lords Arawai and Kol Korran. The Sovereigns hailed the duo as the true children of Khorvaire, since the half-elven race was one truly unique to that continent. The half-elves were a race made strong through their hybrid blood and would wield great power over both nature and commerce.

In the decades that followed, Lyrán and Selavash traveled across Khorvaire, preaching their vision to others of their kind. Tales of miracles performed by the pair were common, but all that can be said for sure is that both possessed an almost supernatural ability to inspire others of their race. The charismatic duo encouraged half-elves to form their own separate communities and to recognize themselves as a unique race—the Khoravar, or “Children of Khorvaire” in Elven. Their followers began to call Selavash and Lyrán the Firstborn, naming themselves the “children of Lyrán,” or the Lyrandar. As proscribed marriage within the Khoravar community began to make the Lyrandar a line of related families, the Mark of Storm spread through those families with great speed. Those blessed by this magic soon formed themselves into House Lyrandar, operating a small fleet of swift ships, bound-elemental galleons and providing fair weather to farmers in need. Within centuries, the Lyrandar controlled almost all of the sea trade conducted by the Khorvarien nations and was also indispensable for the farmers of the Five Nations. Long after Selavash and Lyrán had passed away, legends of the Firstborn continued to spread, including one of the most influential among other Khoravar that the Firstborn did not actually die but instead became immortal krakens and that this is a state that any Lyrandar heir can achieve. According to this tale, the kraken lords remain in the depths of the sea, guiding Lyrandar heirs by way of dreams and visions as they help their descendants achieve true dominance over the waves. To this day, a good number of Lyrandar believe the spirits of their founders still guide the house and a kraken surrounded by four lightning bolts is the great seal of House Lyrandar.

It is often assumed in the present that each dragonmarked house had a single founder or founders like Lyrandar: that some ancient Master Cannith was the first person to develop the Mark of Making, with House Cannith born from his children and their descendants. The truth is not so simple. Each dragonmark first appeared within multiple families, although the marks were bound to specific races and regions of Khorvaire and Aerenal. The Mark of Sentinel appeared among the humans who had settled along Khorvaire's northern coast, while the Mark of Making was found among the human

settlers in the Metrol region that would eventually become Cyre. It took generations for these first dragonmarked to realize the significance and power of their marks. During this time, aberrant dragonmarks were as common as those that would come to be seen as true marks, in part because there was as yet no taboo against mingling the bloodlines of two different dragonmarked families.

Each dragonmarked family would pass on stories of the exploits of its ancestors from this long ago time, although these were often contradictory. The Lyrriman family of gnomes of House Sivis claim that their forebears were the first to identify and unify the dragonmarked families, while members of the Vown family of House Cannith make similar claims. Seven dragonmarks were known by the time Karrn the Conqueror sought to bring all of Khorvaire under his rule, though the families that held them were often not yet fully unified into one house. The Sivis League, the Tinkers Guild of Cannith and the Phiarlans of Aerenal had all laid the groundwork for the birth of their future houses, but the Mark of Sentinel families of the north at this time were still divided. Some Sentinel heirs fought alongside Karrn the Conqueror during his time as a mercenary and warlord, while others were among his strongest foes.

Though Karrn ultimately failed in his attempt to conquer all of civilized Khorvaire, his wars helped to raise awareness of the dragonmarked as his soldiers traveled to distant lands. Over the next few centuries, the families began to communicate with one another, with the leaders of Houses Sivis and Cannith taking the greatest initiative. However, it would take a second war, the War of the Mark, to truly bring the dragonmarked families together and forge the foundation of the present-day system of twelve dragonmarked houses that control all of the non-agricultural trade and commerce of Khorvaire.

–900 YK

The Birth of House Orien: The Mark of Passage appeared among the humans of the nation that became Aundair nineteen centuries ago. The affected families built social links with each other over the centuries and eventually came together to create House Orien. House Orien began as a collection of merchants and teamsters, forming caravans that moved around pre-Galifar Aundair and beyond. When they manifested the Mark of Passage, they enhanced their skills with supernatural magical abilities that swiftly allowed them to dominate the roads of central Khorvaire. The dragonmarks were a celebrated phenomenon by this point and the extended Orien family established itself as a dragonmarked house like Cannith or Deneith in short order. In the days before the founding of the Kingdom of Galifar, few except the couriers and caravans of House Orien could cross the boundaries of nations and the holds of minor warlords in safety. With the help of the Mark of Passage

and a knack for diplomacy, it became possible for Orien messengers to send information and packages from one end of Khorvaire to the other, with an excellent probability that the goods would arrive intact and on time. Orien caravans also carried human cargo and as workers and explorers moved across the continent, the house became one of the primary forces driving the commonality of culture that marks the Five Nations of Khorvaire so strikingly today.

-802 YK

The Arrival of Taratai and the Kalashtar on Eberron: In -802 YK, the quori who became the humanoid race known as the kalashtar first reached Sarlona, fleeing the plane of Dal Quor and the persecution of their fellow quori who were allied to the ruling collective consciousness of the Plane of Dreams, the foul *il-Lashtavar*, which meant “the Dreaming Dark” in the Quori tongue.

The plane of Dal Quor has a deep and fundamental link to Eberron, and the spirits of mortals travel to the Plane of Dreams when they sleep. Dal Quor is a mutable realm, and the fringes of the plane are shaped by the minds of the mortal dreamers. The center of the realm is shaped by an intelligent force more powerful than any mortal mind. This force, a form of collective consciousness, is vast and alien, and even its children—the quori—cannot communicate with it directly. The heart of Dal Quor is shaped in the image of this unseen dreamer, and its essence permeates all things. The quori call this force the *Quor Tarai*, “the Dream of the Age” in the Quori tongue. There are multiple quori castes, but all quori are aspects of the *Quor Tarai*. The quori are immortal as they are born from the fabric of their home plane itself. Quori are immortals alien to Eberron. Though immortal beings, the quori still feed—they consume the psychic energy of dreaming mortals. They do not reproduce, but they can be killed; the total population always remains the same, however. When a quori spirit is destroyed, a new spirit eventually appears fully formed in the heart of the realm. This spirit is generally of the same caste as the spirit that was slain, but it does not possess the memories or personality of its predecessor. So it would be impossible for a native of Eberron to kill all of the tsucora caste of quori; there will always be more. But a hero could at least eradicate a particularly hateful quori personality.

While the *Quor Tarai* is a force with the power to match that of any god, it is not immortal. Quori sages have reached the conclusion that the current age is the third incarnation of the *Quor Tarai*—and that, eventually, the current *Quor Tarai* will pass away. When this occurs, the Plane of Dreams will implode, only to explode outward with the birth of the next *Quor Tarai*. This cataclysmic event will destroy all of the quori. The sages speculate that the spiritual energy that is the essence of the quori will remain and that a new host of spirits will be formed from this force, but no

one can say what those spirits will be like, and in any case the personalities of the living quori will be destroyed.

If the *Quor Tarai* is the collective dream that shapes Dal Quor, then that dream is currently a nightmare. The center of Dal Quor is a realm of horrors, and the quori are terrifying monstrosities. At the very heart of Dal Quor is a pit of shadows, filled with impossible and terrifying visions. The sages say that this is the core of the current *Quor Tarai*. They call it *il-Lashtavar* in the Quori tongue, “the darkness that dreams,” or more commonly, “the Dreaming Dark.” When quori are slain, the newborn quori emerge from this opening in the heart of the plane. While quori cannot communicate directly with the darkness, many feel an intuitive bond to it and feel its desires. Chief among the quori is the spirit of the leading kalaraq caste known as the Devourer of Dreams, the only quori to have ventured into the maw of the Dark and returned. Most quori revere the Dreaming Dark as the force that has given them life, and they revere the Devourer of Dreams as the voice of the Dark.

While most of the quori were creatures of their age, a few felt that their very spirits were at odds with the Dark, that they did not belong to this age. One of these, a kalaraq quori named Taratai, proved the theory of the cataclysmic ages of Dal Quor. She determined not only that the *Quor Tarai* would eventually be reborn, but that it would be reborn in a vastly different form; that this was an age of darkness, and the next age would be a time of light and joy.

Taratai and her followers among the other quori castes immediately began to study the history of the plane to try to find a way to accelerate the change. This was their doom. The other quori had no desire for change and feared the thought of their world being transformed. The Devourer of Dreams declared that they would find a way to stop the turning of the age. The first step was to eliminate Taratai and her followers, with the hope that their essence would be reborn with more compliant personalities. This led to the events of the exodus and the birth of the race of kalashtar on Eberron. This conflict is the key to understanding both the quori and the kalashtar. The kalashtar want to reshape Dal Quor, and they believe that with their continued devotions to the religion they named the Path of Light they are doing so. The current residents of Dal Quor—the agents of the Dreaming Dark—are determined to maintain the current age and to break the cycle. It could be hundreds of thousands of years before the change is destined to occur, but the issue remains the same: the desire to find a path to an age of light set against the determination to maintain an age of darkness.

The kalashtar race has existed for only eighteen hundred years. It began in Dal Quor, where Taratai and her quori followers of light were being hunted down and exterminated by the agents of the Dreaming Dark. But there is more to Dal Quor than the realm of the Dreaming Dark. Every sentient creature on Eberron touches Dal Quor when it dreams, and every soul, every race, shapes its

own piece of the fringes of Dal Quor. Fleeing from the Dreaming Dark, Taratai led her followers on an exodus through mortal dreams. While the quori could not travel physically between the planes as a result of the Quori-Giant War and the destruction of the world's thirteenth moon, Taratai believed that she had found a way to cross through the subconscious and into mortal bodies on Eberron—provided that the proper portals could be found and that the hosts could be convinced to accept the travelers.

For a year Taratai and her quori traveled from dream to dream, passing through the dreams of dragons and beasts, never finding a place to rest. The Dreaming Dark's agents were still baying at their heels, and between the Dark and the dangers of the dreams themselves, Taratai's followers were slowly being destroyed. Finally, Taratai found the passage she needed in -802 YK—a subconscious conduit into the mind of a monk named Hazgaal from the mountainous nation of Adar on the southeastern tip of the continent of Sarlona. She knew that she could not maintain the connection for long, but she pleaded her case to Hazgaal, who was the master of the monastery—and to her surprise, he agreed to accept her band of fugitive spirits. Adar was the land of refuge, he said, and no creature would be turned away.

Sixty-seven Adaran men and women—including the Master Hazgaal himself—volunteered to share their bodies with the renegade quori spirits. In order to establish a permanent bond and truly escape from Dal Quor, it was necessary for the quori to merge fully—spiritually and mentally—with their human hosts, creating a synthesis of both personalities. These were the first of what Taratai called the *kalashtar*, a word in the Quori language that roughly translates as “wandering dreams.” It took time for the *kalashtar* to adapt to their new existence, but they were finally free from the Dreaming Dark.

In Hazgaal's body as the *kalashtar* Haztaratai (though many stories still call her Taratai), Taratai continued her studies of the nature of Dal Quor and the Dream of the Age, and she developed the traditions that are the core of the *kalashtar*, and now Adaran, faith called the Path of Light—a series of practices and devotions that she believed would accelerate the turn of the age in Dal Quor.

There was only one uncertainty for the first generation of *kalashtar*: What would happen when one of the *kalashtar* died? Before they found the answer to this question, another mystery was revealed: that of birth. When the first *kalashtar* child was born, they found that the quori spirit that was tied to the parent now also had a bond to the child. The spirit, Harath, found that it took more of an effort to communicate with either of his human hosts, but that he was nonetheless aware of the experiences of each.

Over the next few centuries, the process continued. As more and more kalashtar were born, the quori spirits were spread thinly among them, and it became almost impossible for the spirit to communicate directly with the kalashtar. The memories and basic personality were still there, however; even if they could not communicate, the spirits were still alive and conscious, experiencing the world through the eyes of hundreds of descendants. Each generation of kalashtar was more physically distinctive than the last, and each lived longer than the one before; it was clear that the spiritual symbiosis between human and quori was having a minor physical effect on the quori's human hosts as well. As they slowly adapted to better suit their spiritual companions, the kalashtar began to develop potent psionic abilities. The kalashtar did not have access to the full psionic power of their ancestors, but they still had astonishing abilities. They could fly, send messages from one mind to another, and transform their bodies into living weapons. It was a time of wonders.

It would not last. Three hundred years had passed in the world of Eberron, but three thousand years had passed for the agents of the Dreaming Dark in Dal Quor where time flowed more quickly. The quori had spent these millennia studying Taratai's flight, and they had found a way to improve upon it. Traveling the fringes of the Plane of Dreams where it interacted with Eberron, an interdimensional nexus called the Dreamspace, the quori could whisper into the dreaming minds of the people of Sarlona, implanting ideas and suggestions into their heads.

After a century of this manipulation, the quori managed to throw the nations of Sarlona into the chaos known as the Sundering (see below) around -500 YK. In the process, the quori arranged for certain people to meet, for bloodlines to be formed, and ultimately to create human hosts known as the Chosen that the quori loyal to the Dreaming Dark could psionically possess and control—without any degree of cooperation from the subject. Another two centuries passed, and a wave of charismatic young lords appeared among the war-torn realms of Sarlona in -302 YK. This new generation of rulers claimed to be divinely inspired, and they had the supernatural psionic powers to prove it. After a few more centuries, this alliance had “restored peace” to the shattered land—failing to mention that they had been responsible for the horrific wars of the Sundering, two centuries before. They established the nation of Riedra, home to hundreds of thousands of humans who were fanatically devoted to their new overlords, known as the Inspired.

The young kalashtar paid little attention to the events in Riedra, concentrating on their Path of Light—until the first army of the Inspired laid siege to Kasshta Keep. The kalashtar had been lucky to find Adar; the natural defenses of the mountainous land were almost impregnable. The Inspired had the resources of an entire continent at their disposal, however, and were growing more powerful every day. More than a thousand years later, this stalemate still continues.

But it was a stalemate forged through sacrifice. An aged Haztaratai had been the first of the kalashtar to cross Adar. Followed by her entire lineage, she did so as an indication that her people should spread out over Adar, stopping at the monasteries of Mountainsoul and Korrandar, marking both as holy to many Adarans. In 151 Age of Taratai (-651 YK),⁶ Haztaratai passed from this world peacefully at Kasshta Keep. But the spirit of Taratai continued on, bound to Haztaratai's lineage, and did so for over 550 years. Taratai's scions were the most numerous among those kalashtar who had visions or dreams of the Shroud in the last stages of the Inspired's takeover of most of Sarlona in the winter of 701 AT (-101 YK). The Shroud was a magical shield that would prevent the Inspired from magically teleporting into or scrying into Adar.⁷ Construction of the *shroud resonators* needed to create and maintain the Shroud started immediately, taking many months of work deep in Adar. When the Inspired finally laid siege to Kasshta Keep on the Adaran-Riedran border in mid-autumn of 702 AT (-100 YK), even the storms that naturally form when war comes to Adar could not stem the tide. The eldest of the Taratai lineage put out a call to his brethren, many of whom came to the front as quickly as they could. Together, the members of the Taratai line created a psionic *metaconcert* unlike the world has ever seen.

Accompanied by a small army of brave Adaran monks and mystics, the Taratai kalashtar met the Riedrans near the Kasshta River and on the headlands of Syrkarn. Even those who survived the clash remember only silvery light. In the end, the Riedran army was broken, and Lord Ulakhun, one of the greatest kalaraq Inspired generals in history, was slain in body and his quori soul bound and imprisoned by the Keepers of the Word, the greatest masters of Adaran magic and mysticism. A magical gem still rests in Kasshta Keep, among many others, containing that quori fiend's spirit. The war continued into winter, with the Taratai line of kalashtar fighting in the forefront against the Inspired—they felt personally responsible for the arrival of the Inspired on Eberron. By midwinter, the Inspired still pushed into Adar, razing to the ground the original Malshashar Monastery on the border of Riedra. The Inspired were less committed to taking Kasshta Keep only because of their

⁶ The Adarans mark the years from the arrival of Taratai and the other rebel quori in Adar and name this calendar the Age of Taratai, abbreviated as AT. The current year of 998 YK is equivalent to 1800 AT.

⁷ The first line of defense for the humans and other exiles of Adar, the Shroud is an energy field generated by a set of massive crystals, one in each of the eight monastery-fortresses hidden throughout the mountains. As long as all eight of the magical artifacts called *shroud resonators* are active, the Shroud provides two effects for Adar—a *dimensional lock* that prevents all forms of extradimensional movement into, within, or out of Adar, and a *nondetection* effect that hampers all scrying attempts within Adar. The lock does not prevent summoning spells, nor does it hamper spells that send creatures back to their home planes. The *resonators* require constant psionic power fed to them by various kalashtar and human psions. Should a crystal fail to receive any psychic power for 1 hour, it shuts down and the Shroud is weakened. Each of the eight main monastery-fortresses in Adar has a chamber in which a *shroud resonator* is set. All monasteries have a rotating group of psions that maintains and powers the resonator. Most resonators are placed in areas that are difficult to get to even if the surrounding citadel is breached. All *shroud resonator* chambers are built for defense.

losses to the Adarans' soul-binding magic, but their war machine ground on from the north. In the late winter of 703 AT (-99 YK), *shroud resonators* were placed in the remaining fortresses in Adar, and one was placed in a cavern provided by new psionic allies the kalashtar had convinced to aid Adar—the insectoid race of dromites of the underground realm of Zi'til'natek. In the last month of winter of that same year, the few remaining kalashtar members of Taratai's line came to each of Adar's monastery-citadels. All the kalashtar disappeared in silver light as the *shroud resonators* began to function. The line of Taratai was no more, but their sacrifice meant that Adar's borders became nearly impossible to cross by the troops of Riedra from that day forward.

The kalashtar were born in the mountains of Adar. Descended from the quori, a race of immortal and alien spirits, kalashtar have endless patience and a firm conviction that their traditions will some day usher in a golden age for all living beings of Eberron. They do not want to change in any way; they know what needs to be done to fight the Dreaming Dark, and they will continue until they succeed or have been destroyed. This attitude is reflected in the rigid monastic lifestyle of the Adarans, which has remained unchanged and uncontested for more than a thousand years. Almost all of the kalashtar live in one of the eight temple-fortresses that dot the mountain sides. What time is not spent in meditation or prayer is devoted to defense of the realm, holding the natural battlements of Adar against the endless onslaught of the Inspired of Riedra. The Adaran kalashtar have no time for cultural change and no reason to believe that change is necessary.

Things are different on the continent of Khorvaire. The kalashtar of Khorvaire come from a variety of backgrounds. Some migrated to Khorvaire before the Inspired arrived on Sarlona, blending quietly into the humans of the Five Nations before the Kingdom of Galifar united them. Others have been sent by kalashtar elders over the course of the last few centuries. Some came to study Khorvaire, while others were sent away to ensure that kalashtar society could not be eliminated in a single blow by the Inspired. The kalashtar of Khorvaire have more interaction with other cultures and do not have to deal with the constant distraction of war.

As a result, the kalashtar of Khorvaire are generally more optimistic and innovative than their Adaran counterparts, and they enjoy experimenting with new things. The kalashtar population of Khorvaire is split between a number of racial enclaves in the major cities of the continent. This pattern has largely been driven by the war with the Dreaming Dark. The Inspired might be able to arrange for the destruction of a small rural community, but they would never get away with smuggling an army into Sharn. By placing themselves in the capitals of Khorvaire, the kalashtar are also able to monitor the activities of the Inspired ambassadors: They already have strong roots in the cities the Inspired are now working to infiltrate. They cluster together not because they are

uncomfortable around members of other races, but because they need the sense of safety in numbers, and it is easier to spot the actions of the Dreaming Dark in a closed system. Within a kalashtar community, the most influential form of social group is the lineage—the quori spirit that a kalashtar is bound to. This is not the same as a family group. Kalashtar inherit the spiritual bond from their parents, but the bond is always based on gender; a son always takes the father’s bond, while a daughter inherits from the mother. Thus, each lineage is composed of a single gender. All members of a particular lineage think of the others as brothers or sisters, even if they are actually distant cousins at best. Most kalashtar live with other members of their line.

There is no tradition of marriage among the kalashtar. Members of different lines socialize together and procreate (with the children being adopted and raised communally by the others of their lineage), but it is difficult for a kalashtar to imagine living with a member of another line for the rest of his life. In Khorvaire many old traditions are being questioned, however. The kalashtar respect age and wisdom, and most kalashtar communities are governed by a council with a representative from each lineage that has a presence in the community. Conflicts between lines are uncommon; the greater threat of the Dreaming Dark has always held the kalashtar together through periods of possible unrest. The method used to select a representative varies by lineage; in general, the leader is simply the person who has the overall confidence of his line, and it will change if that confidence is ever lost. The different communities are linked by lines of psionic communication; most communities have one psion who can open a telepathic link with other kalashtar communities, which is used to check in with the guiding councils of the other cities in Khorvaire and the elders of Adar.

As a whole, mental discipline is part of kalashtar life, and this is reflected by their well-ordered society. Kalashtar generally act in the interests of what they consider to be the greater good, and mercy, kindness, and hospitality are important virtues within their society. Well-mannered visitors are always welcome, though a shadow watcher keeps a sharp eye on outsiders until he is certain they are not agents of the Dreaming Dark. Most other people find kalashtar communities to be austere; the disciplined kalashtar have few vices, and most donate any extra income to the community in the interests of defense, so they have few luxuries. But they are capable of enjoying life without much in the way of material goods, taking pleasure from the company of their kin. Some humans find this admirable, while others simply find it to be disturbing—because humans cannot understand the mental bond between kalashtar of the same line, the level of cooperation and lack of conflict between them often seems unnatural.

The kalashtar continue their devotion to the Path of Light, but many believe that the Inspired have come up with a counter to Taratai’s plans to overthrow the Dark. The Inspired have created a

stagnant society in Riedra, and they are spreading their enormous *hanbalani* monoliths across the land in the hope of eventually realigning Eberron and the plane of Dal Quor so that the quori may once again physically enter the world. Many kalashtar believe that the Inspired plan to spread these monoliths across the entire world—and that if enough of them are built, it will finally secure the safety of the Dreaming Dark as all mortals dream exactly what the quori want them to.

The kalashtar do not intend to let that happen.

–800 YK

The Formation of House Vadalis: The Mark of Handling first appeared among humans in the Eldeen Reaches who eventually formed House Vadalis some eighteen hundred years ago. House Vadalis was the dragonmarked house that created and ran the Handlers Guild, which was devoted to breeding, selling, caring for and training normal and magebred animals throughout Khorvaire. Originating in the Eldeen Reaches, Vadalis was the only human dragonmarked house to keep its center of operations outside the Five Nations. Its members were content to serve the small cities, towns and rural areas largely ignored by the other, more cosmopolitan, houses.

While the dragonmarked houses consist of extended families—separate bloodlines that all trace back to a common ancestry, the sheer size of most houses means that few house members can claim any sort of relationship outside their immediate family unit within the house. House Vadalis is the exception to this rule. While the other houses have done their best to increase their size and influence on Khorvaire, Vadalis has taken almost the opposite stance. Every Vadalis heir over the age of 10 can recite his family lineage on both of his parents' sides for several generations. This is not a matter of rote memorization for the purpose of pride, but information that sees daily use. Through this knowledge, any heirs of House Vadalis can determine the exact blood relationship to one another within an hour's time. This in turn creates a strong bond between them. It is one thing to work alongside someone who shares your name, but another to aid your grandmother's sister's great-grandson—at least to a Vadalis heir. House Vadalis is a family first and a business second. Commerical deals that might threaten the larger family unit are ignored, while plans with less profit that accommodate the house's structure are taken up instead. The other houses are routinely astounded by the Vadalis ways, often ridiculing the house's limited wealth and influence, but Vadalis simply takes a different view of the world. In their minds, no one of their blood is a stranger and no amount of money can take the place of kin.

–500 YK

The Founding of House Medani: Fifteen hundred years ago, the Mark of Detection first appeared among the half-elves (Khoravar) of the land that became Breland and they proceeded to organize themselves into House Medani. Of the twelve dragonmarked houses, House Medani had the lowest profile—and that is how the house’s heirs preferred it. The half-elves of Medani were the masters of the Warning Guild, through which they offered their services as bodyguards, inquisitives and sentries to clients across Khorvaire. Medani was the youngest of the dragonmarked houses to originate within the Five Nations, with the Mark of Detection appearing only shortly before the War of the Mark began. The Medani families banded together in pre-Galifar Breland prior to the outbreak of that conflict, but had few aspirations beyond being left alone. Only in the aftermath of the War of the Mark did Medani’s elders bow to the pressure of the other houses and take their place among the Twelve. Despite often strained relations with the other dragonmarked houses, Medani’s collective voice carries weight. The house’s warnings are ignored at the listener’s peril, but Medani’s iconoclastic nature makes it sometimes difficult to work with.

Though any number of organizations might claim a lock on the truth, House Medani can back that claim. Those who possess Medani’s dragonmark can sense arcane and divine power, the taint of poison, unseen intruders or magical observation from a world away. All Medani heirs train in the use of logic, perception and techniques for assembling fragments of evidence into a recognizable whole. As allies, they are formidable; as enemies, even more so. The Medani alliance existed before Galifar came into being; a collection of families based in the former Medani provinces of what would one day become Breland. Already accustomed into blending into human or elven society, the half-elves of the Medani concealed their dragonmarks when they first appeared. A close-knit society, they were content to use the Mark of Detection quietly, building a reputation as bodyguards and scouts while attempting to avoid the growing conflicts of the other dragonmarked. House Cannith discovered Medani partway through the War of the Mark. At first, it was thought that the Mark of Detection might simply be a widely prevalent aberrant dragonmark, but that conjecture was soon discarded. Cannith finally tracked down the elders of the Medani families and convinced them (some say threatened) to take their place alongside the other dragonmarked houses. Even in the present time, distaste for authority runs strong in House Medani, giving rise to an aloofness that many dragonmarked heirs ascribe to the house. Medani is forthright in its views on interhouse politics and is an active participant in the Twelve, but representatives of the other houses sometimes claim that House Medani works against their interests as often as it supports them.

-500 YK

The War of the Mark: Aberrant dragonmarks appeared to have come into existence at the same time as the true dragonmarks some two thousand years before the present time. The first records of the aberrant marks referred only to individuals as opposed to their appearance among families. Historians now believe that aberrant dragonmarks appeared sporadically and were only rarely passed on to their bearers' children. Fragmentary histories of this period paint a grim picture of the "children of Khyber," attributing all manner of depravity to the bearers of aberrant marks. Of course, these tales also attribute astonishing powers to the early aberrants, such as the story of one who burned down an entire thorp with a wave of his hand because he "desired warmth." Whether these stories have any grain of truth or not, tales of aberrant activity grew more frequent over the centuries. Approximately fifteen hundred years ago, the appearance of aberrants reached an apex—and the bearers of the true marks decided that it was time to act.

The War of the Mark transformed the dragonmarked houses into their present-day forms and solidified their places within Khorvarien society as the most important players in the Five Nations' economies. It also solidified the early influences of House Cannith and House Deneith among the other dragonmarked houses, since both were able to bring significant military force to bear in the struggle. Dragonmarked house lore presents the war as a bold struggle to eliminate the deadly threat posed by those bearing aberrant dragonmarks. A close study of historical documents from this period suggests that aberrant dragonmarks began to appear in far greater numbers in the century just prior to the outbreak of the war and that many of these marks carried great destructive power. However, revisionist scholars now claim that the so-called war was largely fought to secure the power and prominence of the true dragonmarked bloodlines and to eliminate a possible source of economic competition for their services. The truth is probably somewhere in between, as it often proves to be in such cases.

Whatever the true reason for the outbreak of the conflict, its first few years were very one-sided. Spread across the Five Nations, the aberrants were hunted down and exterminated one-by-one by their better-organized and well-disciplined foes in the dragonmarked houses. The war might have ended then if not for the aberrant-marked nobleman Lord Halas Tarkanan. Tarkanan organized the surviving aberrants into an army in the third year of the dragonmarked houses' inquisition against his people. Under Lord Tarkanan's leadership, the aberrants proved a surprisingly resilient enemy against the far more numerous and better-equipped troops (most of them House Deneith mercenaries) of the dragonmarked houses.

Halas Tarkanan, a powerful aberrant heir known as “The Earthshaker,” possessed an aberrant mark which gave him great control over natural forces, but his strategic brilliance often played a greater role in winning victories in battle. His consort, an enigmatic woman known only as the Lady of the Plague, was considered an even greater threat. Though she is commonly depicted as a monster in folktales, many scholars have observed that she seems only to have used her aberrant mark’s powers over disease when forced to and might even have despised her gift—facts carefully omitted from the official histories of the War of the Mark prepared by the gnome scribes of House Sivis.

Tarkanan, a brilliant tactician, used his military skills and the sheer magical power provided by the aberrant marks to turn the tide of battle against the dragonmarked armies. Tarkanan and his queen, the Lady of the Plague, seized control of Sharn, the great mercantile city growing above the bluffs of the Dagger River, and turned it into the primary bastion of the aberrant army. In the end, though Lord Tarkanan’s efforts extended the conflict for a further four years against the might of the dragonmarked houses, he simply lacked the necessary numbers to secure a victory. Tarkanan and his aberrant forces were slowly beaten back to the walls of Sharn by the armies of the dragonmarked. Tarkanan himself was trapped in the final siege of the city of Sharn alongside his consort, where the last of his troops had taken refuge from the massing forces of pre-Galifar Breland, House Deneith and House Cannith. When it became clear during the dragonmarked houses’ siege of the city that he and his followers were doomed, Lord Tarkanan, the Lady of the Plague and his other lieutenants unleashed the full horrific magic of their aberrant dragonmarks—arcane power sufficient to destroy the entire city. Earthquakes shattered its towers, rivers of lava flowed up from the fiery lake deep beneath the city, hordes of vermin rose from the depths and terrible plagues ravaged those who ventured too close to the ruins. Many think even in the present day that the Lady of the Plague’s death-curse still lingers in the depths of Sharn, the source of creatures such as the feral spirit, the roach thrall and the rancid beetle swarm (see the *Sharn: City of Towers* supplement). Those members of the besieging armies who escaped the flames of Sharn’s fall were devoured by swarms of vermin or stricken down by deadly plagues. The War of the Mark was over—but Sharn had suffered greatly and was abandoned once more.

Despite the horrific conclusion of the War of the Mark, the dragonmarked houses had eliminated the only true potential rivals to their economic hold over Khorvair and they began to assume the forms they hold at the present time. At the end of the conflict, Lord Hadran d’Cannith suggested that the dragonmarked houses formally cement their alliance by creating an arcane citadel—a center for research and the study of both arcane magic and the potential powers of the dragonmarked heirs. Though there were only ten dragonmarked houses in existence at this time, the

architect and artificer Alder d'Cannith convinced the committee to follow through on Hadran Cannith's idea to name the new institute the Twelve, based on his belief that there were twelve true dragonmarks in addition to the lost Mark of Death. Alder was a brilliant man whose works had played a critical role in the War of the Mark and the members of the committee humored him—though few expected the remaining two marks to eventually appear (the remaining two marks, Warding and Finding, were not “discovered” until after the formation of the Kingdom of Galifar). The new institute was constructed as a ziggurat that mystically floated above the city of Korth in Karrnath.

In the beginning of its existence, the Twelve played a critical role in shaping the dragonmarked houses' development, but as the houses grew in power and spread across the continent, its influence diminished. Nonetheless, the Twelve remains one of the premier centers for arcane magical research in Khorvaire. By combining the skills and mystical talents of the different dragonmarks, the wizards and artificers of the Twelve have created remarkable items. It took the combined skills of House Orien, House Cannith and House Kundarak to create the magical safe-deposit vaults that allow House Kundarak's customers to deposit goods at one bank and withdraw them across the continent. Airships, the lightning rail, even the warforged—these marvels could not have come into being without the spirit of cooperation and discovery found among the Twelve.

-500 YK

The Sundering and Conquest of Sarlona Begins: Over fifteen hundred years ago, the quori began the conquest of the twelve human kingdoms of Sarlona by using their psionic powers to make contact with the rulers of the Sarlonan nations. The quori slowly influenced them while their minds were present in the Dreamspace every night into beginning a series of devastating wars that made the continent ripe for eventual consolidation into the Empire of Riedra under the control of the Inspired, who were actually quori-possessed humans. This process was known as the Sundering of Sarlona.

By the time Sarlona's history was finally codified by the human inhabitants who had long called the continent their original homeland after the Rhiavhaaran pirate Lhazaar had led her expedition to Khorvaire, the continent's dozens of human city-states had become a land of twelve kingdoms, remaining so through long years of interstate conflict. The provinces of Riedra today bear the names of eight of those original kingdoms—Dor Maleer, Rhiavhaar, Khalesh, Nulakesh, Borunan, Ohr Kaluun, Pyrine, and Corvagura. Where the steppes of Syrkarn spread at present, the four kingdoms that once stood there exist now only as names—Mae Khree, Sunyagir, Khunan, and Lamecha. In northern and eastern Sarlona, the largest powers were the Empire of Nulakesh and the

Kingdom of Corvagura, each the conqueror of a dozen smaller Sarlonan states and city-states whose names are lost to history. For much of the Twelve Kingdoms' early history, Nulakesh was the dominant military force in central Sarlona, building its power through a reliance on a fanatical and disciplined military caste. Though the sorcerer-kings of Corvagura were renowned, it was secretive Ohr Kaluun and majestic Khunan where Sarlona's arcane might truly rose and ultimately fell. Rhiavhaar on the west coast cemented its rule using a different kind of power, controlling the Sea of Rage largely by means of piracy and slaving.

Having stitched itself together from smaller territories, the inland state of Khalesh continued to practice conquest of a different sort. As a nation dedicated to the worship of the spirits of the couatl, another race once native to Sarlona, Khalesh had a long history of crusades and attempts at conversion (some benevolent, others less so) among its neighbor states. Likewise, Pyrine sought to spread its faith—a pantheon of nine deities known as the Sovereign Host—throughout Sarlona.

In the steppes and savannah of what is now the land of Syrkarn, the kingdoms of Mae Khree, Sunyagir, and Lamecha effectively orbited the more powerful state of Khunan, carving out specific niches for themselves (agriculture for Lamecha, the breeding and training of Sarlona's finest horses for Mae Khree, and the mining of iron, mithril, gems and other precious minerals for Sunyagir). At the same time, each nation made a point of maintaining armies and magical might just powerful enough to keep Khunan and the larger northern kingdoms from getting any expansionistic ideas.

The most unusual kingdom of Sarlona's lost past remains the oddest of the modern Empire of Riedra. Borunan was and remains the homeland of "civilized" ogres and the powerful oni (mistakenly sometimes called ogre magi) lords who once ruled over this nation of giantkin. Beyond the twelve kingdoms of old Sarlona lay the frigid Tashana wastes and the mountainous land of Adar. As the wars of the Sarlonan city-states had evolved into the wars of Sarlonan kingdoms, these areas remained largely unaffected. As for the mountainous realm of Adar, it had long been known as a place of refuge, a sanctuary for individuals or entire villages of refugees fleeing from the wars of the other Sarlonan kingdoms. Eighteen hundred years ago, on a date immortalized as 1 Age of Taratai (see above), Adar received its strangest visitors—quori spirits fleeing from the Plane of Dreams, seeking human hosts. A group of Adaran monks agreed to provide shelter for these spirits, and the kalashtar race was born from this mystical union.

The arrival of the kalashtar was the beginning of the end for the Twelve Kingdoms of Sarlona. War raged in Dal Quor, and the enemies of the kalashtar were determined to bring the struggle to Eberron. The quori that served *il-Lashtavar* ("the Dreaming Dark") were not prepared to sacrifice their power and individuality as the kalashtar spirits had, and this prevented them from directly taking

human hosts. But they could still manipulate mortals through dreams. They could give a paranoid king nightmares of a treasonous conspiracy against him, leading him to persecute his own people. They could send a charismatic general visions of justice, urging him to rise up against a tyrannical monarch. They could send two people dreams of love, ultimately forming a relationship and a child more biologically suited to quori telepathic manipulation. Starting 1,500 years ago, the quori did all this and more. Exploiting human fears, prejudices, and greed, the quori threw the kingdoms of Sarlona into chaos. For two hundred years, beginning around -500 YK, Sarlona was shaken by war. As one nation became stable, another would attack it, driven by racial prejudice or religious zealotry, or a new rebel group would arise within its borders. Terrible arcane magic was unleashed. No human nation had the power to rival the arcane might of the lost giant civilizations of Xen'drik, but the wizards of Khunan and the sorcerers of Corvagura were mighty in their own right, and the dark lords of Ohr Kaluun were masters of both divine and arcane magic. This period of Sarlonan history was known as the Sundering, and kingdoms were shattered in its wake.

The quori used their psionic power and control over the Dreamspace to set the Sundering in motion, and so they used their power to end it. After two hundred years of careful psionic manipulation, they managed to breed human bloodlines across Sarlona whose members were especially genetically and mentally vulnerable to the quori's telepathic manipulation and psychic possession—the predecessors of the Riedran caste known today as the Chosen. The quori began a campaign of dreams across the continent, promising salvation to those who would follow their newly forged religion known as the “Path of Inspiration.”

Soon, the first Inspired appeared, as the quori were able to possess the minds of the Chosen. These psychically-possessed humans had great charisma and impressive psionic powers, and to the people of the war-torn lands of Sarlona they were literally the answer to their prayers. The Inspired brought an end to many of the feuds and wars, frequently by uniting former enemies against carefully selected scapegoats. The yuan-ti of Syrkarn, the shulassakar of Khalesh, the oni of Borunan, and the priests and mages of Ohr Kaluun were all targeted in this way. Many were destroyed or enslaved; others fled to Adar, Xen'drik, or Khorvaire. Throughout these struggles, the Inspired extolled the virtues of unity. Within two centuries, the old traditions and cultures of the twelve kingdoms of Sarlona had been swept away. Where once twelve proud states had stood, now only one remained: the Empire of Riedra.

-500 YK

The Sarlonan Migration to Western Khorvaire: At the same time as the kingdoms of Sarlona were falling under the sway of the Inspired, the second wave of Sarlonan human migrants to reach Khorvaire sailed east across the Barren Sea under well-known circumstances, in contrast to Lhazaar's expedition fifteen hundred years before. These Sarlonans were refugees fleeing the Sundering of the Sarlonan nations and the rise of the Inspired's new empire in Riedra. The Riedrans had pushed east into the forests of the Empire of Nulakesh, then beyond, leading many eastern Sarlonans from the Twelve Kingdoms to flee the Inspired's vision of a new utopia. These Sarlonan men and women landed on Khorvaire's western shores, spreading into the Shadow Marches where they remain today and where they eventually interbred with the native orc clans to create the first half-orcs.

Unfortunately, a few expeditions of these Sarlonan refugees lost their way and were shipwrecked on the northwestern shores of Khorvaire in the region known as the Demon Wastes. In time, these poor people would become twisted by the fiendish taint of the Wastes and become the second of the two groups of barbarians who called the Demon Wastes home: the Carrion Tribes. While the noble clans of orcs known as the Ghaash'kala wandered the canyons of the area of the Wastes called the Labyrinth, the Carrion Tribes preferred to make their homes as nomadic hunter-gatherers on the rocky plains west of the Labyrinth's deep badlands.

The members of the Carrion Tribes were the more numerous of the two barbarian hordes of the Wastes and consisted of vicious human savages who worshipped the malevolent fiendish spirits that haunted the region. Over the centuries a handful of different tribes emerged, each following a different fiendish Overlord who lay imprisoned in the depths of Khyber beneath the Wastes. No matter which demon lord they pledged allegiance to, the Carrions were bloodthirsty nomads known to slaughter any strangers they came across—including the members of other Carrion Tribes. While they worshipped the ancient fiends, the Carrion Tribes also feared the ancient rakshasa ruins scattered across the plains of the Demon Wastes and so avoided such locations. Occasionally a tribe attempted to break through to the Eldeen Reaches, which resulted in a brutal conflict with the Ghaash'kala clans in the Labyrinth. The Carrion Tribes were extremely technologically and culturally primitive and generally used hide armor and weapons made of stone or wood, though a few possessed poorly-maintained equipment scavenged from their victims. The Carrions practiced ritual scarring and mutilation; each tribe used distinctive techniques designed to give its warriors the features of fiends. The Carrion Tribes worshipped the fiendish powers that dwelled within the Wastes—the imprisoned rakshasa Overlords, the night hags, and the lesser fiends and dark spirits that dwelled in the shadows.

Barbarians were seen as sacred warriors who underwent a form of sacred demonic possession when they raged in battle. Each tribe has slightly different beliefs, depending upon the nature of the fiend they revered. But all the tribes sought to water the Wastes with the blood of their enemies—something that the rakshasas of Ashtakala found most entertaining.

Two of the most infamous of the later Carrion Tribes were the Moon Reavers and the Plaguebearers. While most of the Carrion Tribes worshipped the rakshasa Overlords and their lesser rakshasa and demonic servants, the Moon Reavers revered the night hags of the Wastes—the foul female fey who spread fear by the dark of the moon across the world. This tribe was made up mostly of barbarians, but because it specialized in terror tactics and guerrilla warfare, a number of rogues were also among the membership. Whenever possible, the Moon Reavers prefer to stalk isolated prey using methods designed to frighten them severely prior to making a kill. They draw this fear out for as long as possible, reveling in the terror of their victims. Clan members make masks and other decorations using the bones and skin of their victims. They file their teeth and let their nails grow long in emulation of the dark fey they so admire.

The Plaguebearers revered an imprisoned fiendish force of filth and pestilence. Its members sought to turn the power of their lord against their enemies. Plaguebearers smeared their weapons with dung to infect their foes with vile fevers brought on by the filth. The members of the tribe were typically covered with weeping open sores and angry welts from various infections, but they were remarkably resistant to the effects of diseases and poisons and never were seriously impaired by their myriad afflictions.

-302 YK

The Unification of Riedra Under the Inspired: The truth behind the founding of Riedra was far from the benevolent fairy tale of a new renaissance of peace and stability brought forth from a period of terrible conflict that the Inspired presented to their followers. Following the severing of all planar connections between Dal Quor and Eberron at the end of the Quori-Giant War, the race of quori who had launched that first invasion of the world were wiped out by the turn of Dal Quor's collective guiding spirit, the *Quor Tarai*. The *Quor Tarai* was transformed into *il-Lashtavar*, the Dreaming Dark, a malignant collective consciousness that spawned a new race of malevolent quori who were as determined as their predecessors to prevent their race from becoming extinct when the *Quor Tarai* turned once more. To this end, they decided that if they could control the dreams of every inhabitant of Eberron, they could prevent *il-Lashtavar* from ever turning. The quori's leaders, the members of their kalaraq caste, decided that they would take control of Eberron one continent at a

time, beginning with the human homeland of Sarlona. Sarlona was chosen because the dimensional fabric of the world was unusually weak across its surface and made communication between Eberron and Dal Quor through the Dreamspace easier there.

Since they could no longer physically enter the world, over the centuries the quori used their psionic gifts to breed a race of humans known as the Chosen who possessed the perfect set of genetic and psychic characteristics to serve as human hosts whose minds could be possessed by individual quori, in effect allowing the inhabitants of the Plane of Dreams to operate physically on Eberron once more. When the Chosen were possessed, they became known as the Inspired, and they began to unite all the kingdoms of Sarlona, ravaged and exhausted by the quori-instigated Sundering, into the utopian empire of Riedra. The Riedrans of every race were taught to believe in the Path of Inspiration, an artificial religion that presented the Inspired as divinely-appointed guardians and rulers over a racially caste-based society in which one's future place in society after reincarnation was determined by absolute acceptance of one's place in the present. Riedra became a land of perfect order and harmony rigorously enforced every night by psionic broadcasts from massive, psychically-active silver monoliths known as the *hanbalani* which were erected across the breadth of Sarlona and were actually intended to both realign Dal Quor with the world so that the quori could physically enter it and to maintain the absolute symmetry of the mortal races' dreams so that the Dreaming Dark could never be overthrown like its predecessors among the *Quor Tarai*.

Following the establishment of the Inspired's rule, the Riedrans acted collectively rather than as individuals. Their new society knew no poverty, crime, greed or any of the other imperfections found in the other human cultures across Eberron, and the borders of the empire were closed so that foreigners from Khorvaire or anywhere else from outside Riedra could not interact with the nation's people save at two Riedran port cities on the east and west coasts of Sarlona, Dar Ulatesh and Dar Jin, respectively. Unfortunately, the Riedrans also enjoyed no freedom. They were nothing more than the human pawns of their Inspired lords, who actively sought to keep the Riedran population perfectly controlled and mentally anesthetized to decrease the chances of the Dreaming Dark's rule of Dal Quor being overturned.

Over the course of the next thousand years, the Inspired tightened their grip on the people of Riedra, slowly expunging the remaining traces of the old Sarlonan cultures. The Inspired moved slowly, making changes with each generation until no one alive remembered a time when life was any different. Through psychology, indoctrination, and the control of dreams, the quori shaped a nation of slaves whose people were grateful for their chains, believing that the Inspired were their

only shield against the horrors of the past and the outside world. During this time, several major events helped shape modern Sarlona.

The first of these was the Syrkarn Migration: In one of the opening strokes of the Sundering, the kingdom of Khunan attempted to annex its neighbor Lamecha, ostensibly for its southern ports that stayed largely free of Rhiavhaarian piracy. Mae Khree, Sunyagir, and Lamecha allied against Khunan. As a result, a devastating period of arcane conflict known as the Magewars ensued. When it was done, the great kingdom of Khunan lay broken. In the aftermath, its survivors fled for the three victorious states or the nations beyond. Over the course of decades, tribes of ogres, half-giants, and worse crossed the Andnemun Desert, eager to occupy the ruins of this once-great land. In their midst, however, new creatures arose that had never before been seen on Sarlonan soil—the yuan-ti. More cunning than the ogres and half-giants, they quickly established dominance over the remnants of Khunan.

Fragments of lost lore collected by Adar’s Keepers of the Word suggest that the sages of Old Sarlona believed the yuan-ti to be magical mutants, descendants of the Khunani transformed into serpentlike aberrations that quickly rechristened their new kingdom “Syrkarn.” This was partially true, as the yuan-ti were actually humans who had once been the ancient servants of the couatls of Sarlona but had been corrupted, unlike their shulassakar counterparts. When the Inspired arrived on Sarlona, the whispered alliances they forged among the warring human states were quickly turned against the yuan-ti. Syrkarn was invaded, and the yuan-ti were hunted to the point of extinction. However, even in the aftermath of victory, the human populations of Lamecha, Sunyagir, and Mae Khree were suddenly ordered out of their ancestral lands for resettlement elsewhere.

In the Riedran year 90 Unity (-212 YK)⁸, thousands of people were moved from Syrkarn and resettled in Khalesh, Dor Maleer, and Corvagura. To this day, no official rationale for the exodus has been given by the Inspired. However, those who have attempted to piece together and connect the oral histories of the yuan-ti with the vague lore of the Age of Demons have suggested that in the course of eliminating the threat of the intelligent and powerfully psychic yuan-ti of Syrkarn, the Inspired discovered a dark power behind the serpentfolk’s creation. A fiendish Overlord was trapped

⁸ After they completed their conquest of much of Sarlona and established the new nation of Riedra, the Inspired created a new timekeeping system that set the year of their completed conquest, -302 YK on the Galifar Calendar, as year 1 Unity. However, the Riedran calendar is lunar, much like that of Galifar, and uses the same system of days and months. This is because both the humans of Sarlona and the human refugees from Sarlona who settled Khorvaire shared the same culture. For their part, the quori and the Inspired have a very different conception of time. When in Dal Quor, the *Quor Tarai* sends out powerful psionic emanations at regular intervals, which all of the quori can feel intensely. Each period of “wakefulness” lasts three Eberron days; in the differently flowing time of Dal Quor, this translated to roughly one month. This is followed by a long “sleep” cycle lasting for two Eberron weeks, or about four months in Dal Quor. During a “waking” cycle, quori experience tumultuous visions of *il-Lashtavar*, becoming highly agitated and hypersensitive to sensual and psychic stimuli. Whether its possessing quori is “asleep” or “awake” according to the rhythms of Dal Quor, however, the Inspired’s human vessel follows a normal 24-hour sleep cycle.

beneath the yuan-ti ruins of Syrkarn. Abel Varmanc, patron and leader of the Library of Korranberg expedition that bore his name, has gained recent notice for his attempts to collect the fragmentary lore of Old Sarlona from Riedran merchants engaged in trade with Khorvaire.

In academic papers and private debate, Varmanc has suggested that some lingering power from the Age of Demons was not only involved in the creation of the yuan-ti through the corruption of the couatl's human servants, but also in the destruction of Khunan that preceded that genesis. In his view, oral traditions describing the legendary devastation of Khunan bear an eerie similarity to the events in Thrane of 299 YK, when the rising of a terrible force bound since the Age of Demons gave birth to the Church of the Silver Flame through the sacrifice of a couatl and the paladin Tira Miron (see below). Whether the destruction of Khunan was the result of a bound fiend Overlord's stirrings or of potent magic wielded by the Khunani in their attempts to confine it once more, "Syrkarn" is the name the legends give to that dark presence.

The next major event in Riedran history was the Madness of Yaruun: By 177 Unity (-125 YK), Riedra was firmly established, but memories of the old kingdoms remained, giving rise to lingering cultural tensions. Then a series of devastating psychic attacks took place along the Riedran borders of Adar. The worst of these occurred in the city of Yaruun, where every inhabitant was left insane. The Inspired revealed that these attacks were the work of an unexpected enemy: the kalashtar, mortals who had given their bodies over to *altavars* (evil spirits). Now the Riedrans had a focus for their anger, and thus was set in motion the long struggle between Riedra and Adar that continues to this day. After a few costly battles (particularly at the Battle of Kasshta Keep in -100 YK, see above), the Inspired chose to place Adar under continuous siege instead of trying to invade and conquer it.

The Madness of Yaruun was the defining moment of the relationship between Riedra and the kalashtar, and it indelibly etched the image of the monstrous kalashtar into the Riedran psyche. Of course, the reason behind the attacks remains a mystery. The kalashtar have no records of them. It is very likely that the Madness was staged by the Dreaming Dark to turn the people of Riedra against the kalashtar. After a thousand years, the truth might never be known.

After Riedra was firmly established as a nation, the Inspired entered into a trading relationship with the Akiak dwarves of northern Sarlona. When the Akiak clans split from their Dorann dwarven forebears hundreds of years before, they initially settled in the passes and valleys of the Paqaa Mountains. Leaving behind the destructive clan violence of their forebears, they made great leaps in metallurgy and alchemy. The psychically-gifted duergar in particular developed advanced techniques for working with the abundant metals and deep crystal found in the mountains of their adopted home. Previous to the rise of the Inspired, the Akiak were in great demand as technicians in all of the Old

Sarlunan kingdoms, and some clans migrated even farther south, approaching Adar's borders. During this period, the Akiak began building *dalnans*, small structures of crystal and steel designed to harness the psychic energy of an Akiak community. Many of these early monoliths can still be found throughout northern Sarlona.

When the Inspired came to power, they hired many of the Akiak—who functioned nearly like a crafters' guild in this period—and the clan's coffers swelled with Riedran gold. The Akiak and the Inspired worked together to build the first of the massive *hanbalani* (monoliths), with the dwarves supplying the basic alchemical and metallurgical building blocks. The monoliths were an integral part of the quori's plan for Riedra and the whole of Eberron. Although the basic framework was derived from the Akiak design, the Inspired also brought quori insights on the nature of psionics to the work, ensuring that the monoliths could be used in ways the Akiak never considered. Once the Inspired had appropriated the knowledge they needed to build *hanbalani* on their own, they turned on the Akiak in a massive coordinated betrayal. In 536 Unity (1 Lharvion, 234 YK), Riedran forces launched a surprise attack on the Akiak in what the dwarves remembered as the Night of Razor Dreams. Planned assassinations, both physical and psychic, wiped out nearly all the Akiak leaders, engineers, and skilled technicians in the *hanbalani* construction facilities. Meanwhile, the shifter barbarians of the Harmonious Shield's Taaskan Legion—already garrisoned near many of the clan homes as “protection”—swarmed the Akiak's villages and towns in the Paqaa Mountains, killing or enslaving all who remained. Only a fraction of the once-great Akiak nation survived this horrifying betrayal, fleeing to the northern foothills of the Paqaa Mountains and the free lands of the southern Tundra. The Night of Razor Dreams burns in the heart of every Akiak, a terrible price paid for an unwise and greedy collaboration with the Inspired lords of Riedra. Over the next several centuries, the Akiak dwarves rebuilt their culture around a central precept—vengeance against Riedra for the terrible crimes the Inspired had committed against them.

In 876 Unity (574 YK), the Inspired became interested in acquiring dragonshards, crysteel-grade crystal, and other resources that were plentiful on the shattered continent of Xen'drik. A century later, in 674 YK, the Inspired established the fortress-city of Dar Qat on the western coast of that land, sparking regular contact between the people of Khorvaire and the Riedrans. The Inspired had long spurned the overtures of the Kingdom of Galifar for trade and commerce, but now the two nations' ships met on the open seas. Initially, the Riedrans were prey for the pirates of Khorvaire and Xen'drik who plied the Sea of Thunder. But as Galifar established its own presence on Xen'drik, the city of Stormreach became a neutral ground for the two empires, and open trade began.

The people of Khorvaire know very little about Sarlona. For the last thousand years, the Inspired have kept the continent behind a veil of secrecy, turning ships away and even psychically shielding it from scrying eyes. Today, that situation has begun to change.

Following the outbreak of the Last War, the Inspired sent emissaries directly to the royal courts of Khorvaire. They offered many forms of aid, from food to medicine; one of the more tragic results of this trade has been the spread of the addictive Sarlonan narcotic called dreamlily through the criminal underworld of Khorvaire. Meanwhile, smugglers made contact with Riedra's own black marketeers, the Dream Merchants, and founded secret havens on the islands of Ohr Kaluun and the coast of the Tashana Tundra. Riedran textiles, Tashanan art, and many other Sarlonan exports are slowly finding their way into the great cities of Khorvaire, and charming Inspired ambassadors are fast becoming fixtures among the upper classes of the Five Nations. In 998 YK, the Inspired took the unprecedented step of unveiling a foreign quarter in their great eastern port of Dar Jin, allowing Khorvarien ambassadors from the Five Nations, the dragonmarked houses and others who had legitimate business with Riedra to come to this bastion city.

The hallmark of all Riedrans is devotion, unswerving dedication to their state, companions, and work. Each Riedran's path has been laid out by those wiser than he is, and it is a road that leads to eternal salvation. His challenge is to resist the temptations the cunning *altavars* place in his way—temptations such as the words of foreigners, who could attempt to turn him against the glorious Inspired.

At its heart, Riedra is a massive cult. Its people have been brainwashed from birth; the *hanbalani* monoliths shape the dreams and beliefs of Riedran children before they can even speak. Anyone who would challenge the Inspired swiftly vanishes to the Thousand Eyes, so most people never hear opposing views. Even if they did, they would fear such words as deadly blasphemy. The people of Riedra truly love the Inspired, and they love their lives. Most Riedrans do not want to be rescued from the Inspired; they consider the “freedom” so treasured by foreigners to be a weakness that threatens the evolution of the soul. A Riedran farmer has a roof over his head, food on the table, and clothes on his back. He might not be able to live wherever he wants, choose his food, or even pick the color of his clothes, but in his eyes, he has a good life, secure and stable. He does not need luxuries in this world. Such things are certainly tempting, but it is by resisting that temptation that he ensures his advancement in the next life.

Riedrans place high value on honesty and community; the Path of Inspiration teaches, “A liar sells his soul with every word.” A follower of the Path strives to be honest and to be a good neighbor,

contributing to both his village and his nation. A Riedran always helps out a fellow citizen unless that person advocates a course of action that goes against the Path of Inspiration.

Work means everything to Riedrans. Each vocation and task is a lesson to be mastered for forward movement on the Path. Riedrans work long hours without complaint, and they often regret having to leave work to participate in community activities. This devotion often means that Riedrans are surprisingly skilled at their professions, but they lack versatility and creativity.

Time away from work is usually spent with other members of the community. Riedrans dine together in central halls, participate in group athletic exercises, and gather in the evenings for storytelling and religious instruction. They are allowed a brief amount of unstructured time each day, ostensibly for meditation on the day's events; however, many prefer to remain among friends even during this private time. Privacy is not something that Riedrans treasure—solitude can be a painful and disturbing experience for a Riedran.

Young Riedrans are raised communally. They are often transported to new villages as soon as they are old enough to travel, to prevent birth parents from forming an unhealthy bond with the child. Youths live in segregated dormitories, tended by dedicated caregivers. As they grow, children serve as apprentices to other members of the community, allowing the caregivers and a priest of the Path of Inspiration to determine their aptitudes. A youth is usually set on his path in his thirteenth year and moves into an adult dormitory at this time. At eighteen, a Riedran is “paired” with another. This is the Riedran equivalent of marriage, and the pair occupies the same dormitory. Those in control of this process, the pathfinders, prefer for people to be pleased with their bonding, and thus they accept mutual requests. Still, pairing is done for the sake of producing children, and if two people are genetically incompatible, their pairing is not allowed. Riedrans are expected to be monogamous, and sex outside of a pairing relationship is punished.

Riedrans seek to control strong emotions and focus their energy in positive ways. Religious ceremonies provide an outlet for emotion under the guidance of the local priest. In these rituals, people are instructed to unleash a particular emotion in response to a recent event. For example, if another villager has succumbed to “spiritual corruption” and been taken by the Thousand Eyes, the people gather to feel pity, sorrow, and hope for their lost companion. If news comes of kalashtar treachery, people gather to unleash anger and hate. Between these periods of release, people are expected to keep their emotions under control or to speak with a priest if they cannot. Of course, what none know is that this psychic projection of collective emotions actually feeds the quori, whose “food” is the emotions produced by intelligent minds.

Xenophobia is common in Riedra. Violent and chaotic, foreigners practice dark magic, eat the flesh of beasts, and destroy their nations in the name of “freedom.” Foreigners should be pitied. Lacking the direction of the Inspired, they have no protection against the *altavars*. It is only natural that they fall prey to lust, greed, and other lower emotions. Nonetheless, they are like wild animals and cannot be trusted. A Riedran must always be wary when dealing with foreigners, never allowing them to sway him from his path.

Riedra’s provinces are divided into territories known as spheres. A sphere is a circular region centered on a fortress-city called a bastion, which is ruled by a particular Inspired lord. The territory takes its name from its Inspired master—the city of Durat Tal is in the Sphere of Surasek, in the province of Corvagura, for instance. All Inspired hold the title of Lord or Lady; the ultimate leader of a bastion carries the title of Eidolon.

The typical bastion is a metropolis, and many of them rival the city of Sharn, Khorvaire’s biggest urban area, in population. They are centers of industrial production, supporting the bulk of a sphere’s troops. Surrounding a bastion is a network of villages, spread out in as orderly a manner as possible, taking environmental factors and resources into account. A sphere contains dozens of villages. Most villages focus on agriculture and simple industry. Although some variance in styles and customs exists from province to province, villages within a sphere are virtually identical. No thorps, hamlets, or towns can be found—when a population rises to a sufficient level, the Inspired draw off the excess to create a new village. Riedran villages are functional and ascetic in design. The community is centered around a building that serves as a dining hall and a public assembly, where people gather to listen to the sermons of the local priest or to hear stories of the glorious deeds of the Inspired.

Villagers live in communal dormitories, with separate houses for children. While Riedra has no lightning rail, villages and spheres are linked by a comprehensive network of maintained roads. The Inspired also have a secret system of *psionic teleportation circles* at their disposal, passing through the central hub of Durat Tal. The number of gates is limited. The Inspired can teleport cargo directly from Dar Jin to Durat Tal, but getting those goods to, say, the village of Keloar requires a caravan.

All important decisions concerning the fate of Riedra are made in Dal Quor. The bastion lords do not gather in Riedra to debate policy, because such councils are held in Dal Quor. To a foreigner, it seems that the bastion lords and generals of the Harmonious Shield operate unilaterally; however, they all act in perfect accord with the plans formulated in the Plane of Dreams. While the destiny of Riedra is set in dreams, a complex bureaucracy manages its daily affairs. The Inspired hold the top

tier. A powerful Inspired noble rules each bastion city, and Inspired serve as generals, ambassadors, inquisitors, and high ministers. Although mighty Inspired are rare, lesser Inspired serve throughout society, in positions where trust or psychic power are required. Beholden to the Inspired, the human Chosen dedicate themselves to being worthy of inhabitation by an *il-altas*. They manage the bulk of the administration of Riedra, also serving as officers in its military. Chosen overseers govern most villages. The most important positions are granted to Chosen who served as Inspired before their quori spirits moved on to other hosts; after decades of possession, the minds of these individuals have been molded by the quori, and they are fully trusted by the overlords. Whether Inspired, Chosen, or commoner, Riedrans serve in one of four groups: the Unity, the Thousand Eyes, the Harmonious Shield, or the Dreaming Dark.

The Unity forms the foundation of Riedra, and the majority of the population serves one of its branches, which deal with agriculture, industry, construction, medical care, crisis management, education and foreign trade—indeed, all the common productive activities of any society. There is no money in Riedran society—everyone works for the common good, receiving food, shelter and clothing as well as any other necessary items of daily life from the communal stores of his home city or village. While each branch of the Unity has its own ministers, the seven arms work together in the service of the nation and answer to the local bastion lords. This arrangement separates the Unity from the Thousand Eyes and Harmonious Shield, which follow different chains of command. All branch high ministers are psions.

The Harmonious Shield is the army that stands between Riedra and the countless dangers of the outside world. Whether they are fighting the treacherous kalashtar on the Adaran front, combating dromite forays, hunting Akiak dwarves in Dor Maleer, or battling skulks in the ruins of Ohr Kaluun, the soldiers of the Harmonious Shield serve the Inspired on the field of battle. The Harmonious Shield maintains garrisons in the bastion cities, and it has independent fortresses spread along the borders and in areas deemed to be especially dangerous. The largest fortresses are called *kintams*. They are connected by permanent *psionic teleportation circles*, which allow swift transportation of troops and supplies. Kintams can be the size of cities, and new recruits are usually dispatched to a kintam to learn their trade. Years of psychic indoctrination teach soldiers that honorable death in battle is the surest path to advancement in the next life. Discipline within the ranks is strict, and looting and rapine are serious offenses. A soldier needs nothing that is not given to him by the Inspired. The same training burns mercy and empathy from the minds of Riedran soldiers, so a servant of the Shield feels nothing for the people he kills. This conditioning does not always take hold, however, and a few recruits find themselves horrified by the brutal actions they must perform.

Such a warrior must either suppress these emotions or find a way to escape before his “weakness” is discovered. Riedran warriors believe they are fighting for a holy cause against monsters and those corrupted by evil spirits. Fiercely devoted to their nation, they are no more evil than the typical Brelish conscript or knight of Thrane.⁹

To a Riedran, no one in his right mind turns against the Inspired. Those who do are clearly victims of influence by the terrible *altavars*. Someone has to help these victims if possible, or do whatever is necessary to ensure that they do not threaten other innocent souls by spreading their spiritual contagion. Those tasks fall to the Riedran secret police—the Thousand Eyes. The Thousand Eyes administers justice across Riedra and maintains the reclamation centers. Public agents of the Thousand Eyes—easily identified by their green uniforms and golden badges of office—can be found throughout any bastion, and people take comfort in knowing that these guardians are watching. Far more dangerous, however, are the secret members of the Eyes. Nearly anyone in Riedra could be an agent. Furthermore, even when no one is around, psychic scrying allows the agents of the Eyes to watch the wrongdoing of criminals. Agents of the Thousand Eyes are typically human, Chosen, or changelings. The bulk are simply observers, skilled in noticing the details of their environment and anyone in it. More capable agents tend to be rogues, specializing in observation and stealth. Chosen and especially honored changelings are trained in the psychic arts. When force is required, the Thousand Eyes calls on bastion guards or the Harmonious Shield’s Sleeping Sword, but it also maintains a covert corps of psychically-empowered assassins.

The bastion city of Dul Zeer is the Thousand Eyes’ greatest stronghold. Here, a network of psychic scrying crystals allows agents to scry across the continent, and *psionic teleportation circles* let them dispatch forces to any bastion or kintam. Thousand Eyes agents present in a Riedran village can be alerted through dreams. In an emergency, Inspired psions can teleport Riedran forces to the site of a disturbance. The current Riedran high minister of the Thousand Eyes is the kalaraq-caste Inspired Lady Sharadhuna.

Officially, the mysterious organization called the Dreaming Dark holds no power in Riedra. Most Riedrans have never heard of it, and they would reject any attempt to link it to the Inspired as kalashtar propaganda. Even if presented with clear evidence of an Inspired working for the Dreaming Dark, a Riedran would likely dismiss it as a tragic case in which one of the noble Chosen fell prey to

⁹ The Harmonious Shield is divided up into a variety of specialist groups that include Riedran Stone Soldiers (heavy infantry), Air Soldiers (ranged light infantry), Fire Soldiers (mobile infantry), Water Soldiers (special forces), the Edgewalkers (special forces who fight extraplanar creatures that emerge from Sarlona’s multiple planar manifest zones), the Harmonious Sail (the Riedran Navy), the Horned Guard (corps of oni), the Tashann or Savage Legion (shifter and Borunan ogre shock troopers) and the Sleeping Sword (psychic troops made up of Inspired and Chosen).

possession by an *altavar*, not an indication of duplicity on the part of his saintly Inspired. Nonetheless, the Dreaming Dark wields great influence in Riedra. All quori bow to the ultimate authority of the Dreaming Dark, and all Inspired provide the agents of the Dark with whatever they require. Many quori that serve the Dreaming Dark have Chosen vessels spread throughout the Unity, the Thousand Eyes, and the Harmonious Shield. This influence allows agents of the Dreaming Dark to take direct action within Riedra whenever it suits their needs.

The Dreaming Dark has little need to act within Riedra, however, since that empire is already completely under the control of the Inspired and any dissent can be put down by the conventional Riedran military and the Thousand Eyes. The Dark's true agenda is to destroy the kalashtar and to spread the influence of the Inspired across Eberron. Agents of the Dark can be found in Sarlona, Khorvaire, and Xen'drik. These agents are mostly unpossessed Chosen, although the quori have used a psychic domination power called *mind seed* to subvert members of other races. Most Chosen who serve the Dark are groomed for this service from birth, ensuring that they possess the skills and devotion required. These Chosen families call themselves the shadow lines. They are aware of the power they serve, and they believe that through their service they are destined to become quori themselves after death (another lie as quori can only be born from the substance of their home plane and their number is always static).

–41 YK

Galifar ir'Wynarn is Born in Karrnath and the Border Wars Begin: Prince Galifar ir'Wynarn, a descendant of Karrn the Conqueror and the future King Galifar I of the nation that also bore his name, is born in the city of Korth in -41 YK, the son of the ruling Warlord of Karrnath. Galifar grew up eagerly devouring the stories surrounding his famous ancestor and harbored a dream to do what Karrn could not—unite all of the human nations of central Khorvaire under one crown.

A series of border skirmishes broke out in -41 YK that lasted until -31 YK and eventually drew in the fighting forces of all five of the human nations of central Khorvaire. The conflict became a low-grade struggle known as the Border Wars. The conflict had begun as each nation's frontier nobles battled over the right to expand into the best agricultural lands and gain control of the continent's water sources as Khorvaire's growing economic prosperity led to an increase in population density. And, as always, the feudal nobility of the Five Nations sought more lands to increase their own political power.

-20 YK

Galifar ir'Wynarn Ascends the Throne of Karrnath: Galifar ir'Wynarn became the Warlord of Karrnath after the death of his father shortly before his twenty-first birthday in -20 YK. Following Galifar's ascent to the throne, he began a massive military build-up in Karrnath aimed at reestablishing Karrn the Conqueror's empire—and extending beyond it. Galifar's expansion of the Karrnathi military goes over well with the Karrn aristocracy, who expect to greatly enrich themselves in lands and wealth seized from the rest of the Five Nations.

But if the Karrnathi nobles expected their new warlord to pile up the treasures of Khorvaire at their feet, they were sadly mistaken. Galifar had grown up during the Border Wars, a decade-long conflict that saw the Five Nations battle over land rights and water sources. He saw the cruelty and shortsightedness of the Karrnathi warlords, including his father, and he decided that those currently in charge were wasting the potential of the Five Nations.

Galifar envisioned a united kingdom covering all of central Khorvaire made up of five equal parts, where petty disagreements were put aside and the people worked to improve life and advance the human condition. Young Galifar had studied the exploits of his famous ancestor and decided that in many ways Karrn the Conqueror had had the right idea. Only by combining their resources and efforts could the human nations of Khorvaire achieve the next level of civilization. Where Karrn failed, in Galifar's opinion, was in his cruelty, his blood lust, and his desire for aggrandizement above all other concerns. Galifar swore to avoid these failings and find a higher purpose to lead the way towards the unification of the Five Nations.

During the first decade of his rule over Karrnath, Galifar began preparations to see his dream become a reality. While Galifar hoped to convince the Five Nations to accept his plan, he knew that his best chance of uniting the kingdom was to have a powerful army to assure compliance. He expanded the standing army of Karrnath and the feudal levy of soldiers he laid on the Karrnathi nobility and set the best minds in the nation to helping him plan the kingdom he envisioned building. Then, in the eighth year of his reign (-12 YK), he began negotiations with the leaders of the other nations. It did not take the other rulers long to reject Galifar and his plans for a unified kingdom.

Undeterred, Galifar continued to explore diplomatic approaches to Khorvarien unity for the next two years (-12 YK to -10 YK). Each demonstration of shortsightedness and refusal on the parts of the other leaders of the Five Nations simply made Galifar more determined to bring his vision to reality.

-10 YK

Galifar Begins to Unite the Five Nations: The Warlord Galifar ir'Wynarn of Karrnath began his campaign to unite the Five Nations beneath one ruler in -10 YK. On the tenth anniversary of his rise to power in Karrnath, Galifar began a military campaign to build the empire he had long dreamed about. For the next fourteen years (-10 YK to 4 YK), this campaign would rage across central Khorvaire. During this period, Galifar demonstrated his military genius time and time again, and his five children grew to become his chief lieutenants as each reached the appropriate age. While Galifar and his Karrnathi forces did not win every battle in the war to establish the united kingdom, they did win the most important ones. Over the course of the war, the warlord-who-would-be-king made two influential diplomatic ploys that helped ensure his eventual victory. The first was to take the dragonmarked houses out of the conflict and gain their support by offering them special status in the new kingdom (see below). The second was to take his dream directly to the people of the Five Nations, allowing him to slowly win the hearts and minds of those he hoped to lead, even against their own nobles. Many people in the Five Nations had grown tired of the constant squabbling between their states, especially when they shared so much in common. Galifar's promise of stability and a kingdom that was greater than the sum of its parts began to resonate with many Khorvarien humans from outside of Karrnath who began to volunteer to join Galifar's armies and aid his cause (it also helped that Galifar seemed to be winning).

-3 YK

The Korth Edicts: In the seventh year of his war to unite Khorvaire, Galifar made a deal with the dragonmarked houses of the Five Nations, offering them neutral status and natural economic monopolies in the new united kingdom he was building in exchange for their financial and political support in his campaign to unite the Five Nations under one crown.

As Galifar's armies grew and conquered more of the Five Nations, it became apparent to the patriarchs of the dragonmarked houses that Galifar ir'Wynarn might succeed where Karrn the Conqueror had failed. When the house leaders met Galifar at his request in the Karrnathi capital city of Korth at the height of his drive to unite the Five Nations, the would-be king swore to protect the houses' integrity from all royal interference and agreed to a number of provisions that would ensure their continued economic strength by establishing official economic monopolies for each house over the area of commerce they already specialized in. In return, the houses agreed to legal restrictions on their political and military power so that they would not compete with the power of Galifar's new

state—or with the prerogatives of the Five Nations’ feudal nobility, whose support for the new kingdom was crucial.

For the next thousand years, the Korth Edicts prevented any individual member of a dragonmarked house from holding a grant of land and placed limits on the size of the house enclaves and the armed forces that could be garrisoned there. Special exceptions were carved out for House Deneith, which retained the right under the Edicts to assemble military forces specifically for mercenary service in the Blademarks and Defenders Guilds. The Edicts further specified that no member of the nobility of the new kingdom could be bound to a member of a dragonmarked house in marriage without one of the two explicitly surrendering their heritage and all their rights to a noble title or a place in the dragonmarked house. Since the dragonmarked houses could not own land, the Edicts laid out a system of rents to be paid to the Galifaran Crown (and its later successors) in exchange for the territory the houses required in the Five Nations to meet their needs. The Korth Edicts established the present-day structure of the dragonmarked houses and laid the foundation for their domination of the new Kingdom of Galifar’s trade, commerce and craftsmanship. Only agriculture, the primary basis of the Five Nations’ economies (and foundation of the nobility’s wealth), was off-limits to the dragonmarked houses, though House Lyrandar’s Raincallers’ Guild still managed to make enormous sums off of aiding Khorvaire’s farmers.

–2 YK

The Mark of Finding Appears in the Shadow Marches: The Mark of Finding appeared among the humans and half-orcs of the Shadow Marches a thousand years ago. For millennia, the Shadow Marches were the domain of the orcs of Khorvaire. It was a land scarred by the ancient conflict with the daelkyr, where the descendants of the first druidic Gatekeepers and those corrupted by the touch of Xoriat continued to battle in the darkness. Five hundred years before the Mark of Finding appeared, in -500 YK, humans had come to the Shadow Marches, refugees from the distant continent of Sarlona who were fleeing the growing power of the Inspired of Riedra in the wake of the Sundering. Though many of the orcish tribes of the Marches met the first waves of human settlers with hostility, a handful of the tribes welcomed these strangers. Over time, this union of cultures produced both the human and orcish Marcher clans of the modern age and the *jhorgun’taal*: the “children of two bloods” in Orcish, the half-orcs.

When the Mark of Finding appeared among the clans of the Shadow Marches, it was carried by humans and half-orcs alike. Some considered this to be a divine gift to the humans and half-breeds to make up for their greater physical frailty compared to the Marcher orcs—a magic mark in lieu of

the great strength and dark-piercing eyes that Eberron had granted the orcs. The mark appeared among three clans of humans and their half-orc kin—the Aashta, Velderan and Torrñ—and over the next five centuries, the hunters of these clans would become legends within the Shadow Marches.

1 YK (998 years before the present)

The Unification of the Kingdom of Galifar: Galifar, now proclaimed to be King Galifar I, and his five scions—Prince Cyre, Prince Karn, Prince Thrane, Princess Aundair, and Prince Brey—officially took control of the unified Five Nations in the name of their father in the first year of the Galifar Calendar. Fourteen years after the war of unification began (the war did not officially conclude until 4 YK because some pockets of resistance took longer to overcome), the Five Nations laid down their arms and surrendered to Galifar ir'Wynarn. True to his word, Galifar did not come as a conqueror from Karrnath—he proclaimed himself the king of a new kingdom composed of five equal parts. (Originally, it was simply “the Kingdom” or “Galifar’s Kingdom.” The new state did not officially adopt the name the “Kingdom of Galifar” until the second decade of the new king’s rule.) To ensure loyalty and to push his postwar economic development programs, Galifar I appointed each of his five children to manage the affairs of the Five Nations. As governor-princes, they would administer their portions of the realm in his name, as well as serve on a ruling council that would advise and support the new king. It helped that, in the end, the common folk respected and grew to love Galifar I and his scions, seeing them as just, fair, and ultimately visionary rulers. Galifar I established that the oldest living scion would ascend to the throne upon the current monarch’s death or abdication, which ever came first. Thus, the traditions and patterns surrounding the succession of power were set in place, helping to keep the kingdom stable until King Jarot’s scions unexpectedly broke the pattern in 894 YK, setting off the cataclysm that was the Last War.

For all of Galifar I’s visionary idealism, the Kingdom of Galifar remained a feudal monarchy, as were most of the nations that re-formed after the Last War shattered that legendary kingdom. In addition to the feudal nobility and the rural peasant farmers, a middle class of laborers and craftsmen developed in the larger towns and cities. The mercantile barons that controlled the dragonmarked houses aligned themselves with no constituent nation of Galifar, which allowed them to operate independently and in all the kingdom’s regions equally, though most could not help but associate more strongly with one nation where they had first come into existence—for instance, House Deneith was strongly associated with Karrnath, Lyrandar with Aundair, Cannith with Cyre, Sivis with Zilargo, Medani with Breland, Tharaskh with the Shadow Marches, etc.

The dragonmarked houses constituted an economic aristocracy of commerce and industry in Galifar and across Khorvaire. The blood members of each family had wealth and social status that put them firmly in the middle to upper classes of Khorvarien society. The house nobles and their immediate relatives shared the highest status in the land, equivalent to the royal houses and the highest-ranking clergy. Dragonmarked house scions further removed from the main bloodline shared and took advantage of this status as the house nobles allowed, but on their own they ranked in the middle class.

Farmers dominated the countryside of most of the Five Nations of Galifar, raising crops and providing food for all the people of central Khorvaire. In some nations like Karrnath, the farmers were serfs indentured to the lords that controlled their lands. In others like Breland, the farmers were free peasants who owned or leased their land from the local nobility and paid taxes for protection and other services they required of the ruling class. Farmers toiled through the daylight hours and rested when darkness covered the land. They usually lived within a mile or so of a trading village, which was guarded in turn by a local lord and his keep or castle. When legal disputes arose, it was the manor lord (or his appointed officer or bailiff) who settled disagreements and issued binding rulings. Some farmers used minor arcane magic to help them with their chores. This magic might be provided by their lord or purchased from a dragonmarked house. The average farmer did not wander far from his or her home, but every family has a member that went off to fight as a mercenary or seek employment in a city or town, and everyone knew someone whose brother or sister decided to become an adventurer and leave home in search of fame or fortune.

Some Galifaran townsfolk and city-dwellers engaged in a craft or trade of some kind, though for every professional there were three or more common laborers working in the city. Merchants and shop owners, smiths, leatherworkers, and artisans of all descriptions lived and worked in the cities of Galifar. Many used some minor magic to ply their craft; magewrights cast *magecraft* to produce minor magic items; others less gifted in the arcane arts hired magewrights to assist them when the funds were available. People lived in close proximity in the cities, shopping in the markets, working, relaxing as the rare opportunity presented itself. City-dwellers had a bit more access to the conveniences of arcane magic than their rural counterparts did. The dragonmarked houses maintained pavilions and emporiums in many good-sized towns and cities, where their services could be purchased on a regular basis and also controlled most of the non-agricultural economic activities that occurred in a town or city through their royal monopoly over the guilds. Magewrights were more abundant in the towns and cities, and even the least well-to-do city had *everbright lanterns* to light at least the major thoroughfares and exchanges. In a city, law and order prevailed—or at least it tried to.

A city watch usually patrolled the streets of most urban areas, while a local Galifaran Army garrison protected the trade roads and caravan routes passing nearby from bandits, goblins and other “monster” attacks. Royal courts and justices of the peace held sway over matters of law, deciding disputes and determining guilt or innocence through something akin to due process through the Code of Galifar, the uniform code of laws and punishments for infractions and crimes created by King Galifar I soon after the establishment of his kingdom and upheld by each of his successors as fairly and as impartially as possible, though the Code did discriminate between people based on their legal status as a commoner, noble or member of the clergy. The Code’s most blatant transgressions were policed by the Sentinel Marshals, an elite law enforcement order administered by House Deneith and established at the request of Galifar I. Only the most trusted dragonmarked heirs of that house were honored with a position in the Sentinel Marshals, either after serving in both the house’s Blademarks and Defenders Guilds or by special dispensation of the house. The Sentinel Marshals were elite agents sworn to the service of the Galifaran Crown and the Code of Galifar who were authorized by the ruling monarch to enforce the law across Khorvaire according to the needs of the regional authorities. The Sentinel Marshals had the right to ignore all borders and all other forms of authority save for that of the Crown in the pursuit of fugitives. They were never authorized to break the law themselves, but were held accountable only to the Galifaran throne. Wherever brigands evaded local law enforcement, smugglers moved contraband across borders or criminal guilds attempted to expand their reach, the Sentinel Marshals could be called in by local authorities to deal out the Galifaran Crown’s justice.

The Sentinel Marshals imprisoned the worst and most dangerous criminal offenders in the prison of Dreadhold. Dreadhold was a prison island which floated off the northern tip of Cape Far in the Lhazaar Principalities. Established first by Karrn the Conqueror as a place for exiling deposed rulers or courtiers fallen from favor following the creation of his empire, it was converted by the early kings of Galifar into a nigh-inescapable prison set in the middle of a planar manifest zone linked to the wild lands of Lammania. The prisoners were usually powerful individuals who had to be magically restrained—in some cases even turned to stone—to prevent them from breaking out. The prison was managed, after the second century YK, by the dwarves of House Kundarak, who bore the Mark of Warding. It is also said that the dwarves used the prisoners to mine Khyber dragonshards from deep chasms beneath the island. Following the break-up of Galifar during the Last War, the new rulers of the Five Nations agreed in the Treaty of Thronehold to continue to send their worst prisoners to Dreadhold for the dwarves to guard, as long as they continued to pay Kundarak, and to continue to

use the Sentinel Marshals to track down and apprehend the worst criminals who fled across national boundaries.

From the rural communities that dotted the Galifaran countryside to the villages, towns, and cities that rose across the Five Nations wherever need and circumstance came together, the people of Khorvaire fell into three economic categories: poor, middle class, and wealthy. There were ranges and degrees of wealth in each category. Six out of ten people in the Five Nations were common peasant farmers, unskilled laborers, and tradesfolk who were in the poor economic class, having no more than 40 or 50 silver pieces on hand at any given time, and most having considerably less.

Three out of ten people were in the middle class, including skilled laborers, prosperous traders and shop owners, skilled artisans, most nobility, low-level adventurers, and some members of the dragonmarked families who normally had a few hundred gold pieces or more on hand.

One out of ten people fell into the wealthy category, those with access to a few thousand gold pieces at any given time. This class included merchant lords, barons of commerce, the patriarchs and matriarchs of the dragonmarked families, the most popular and successful urban artisans, mid- to high-level adventurers, and the ruling feudal nobility and royalty.

Throughout the Five Nations (or at least what was left of them after the Last War ended), formal schooling in basic literacy and arithmetic was considered a right and a necessary part of every child's training, a tradition begun under Galifar I. Even rural manors maintained elementary schools for the sons and daughters of the peasants and laborers at the expense of the local lords. Private tutors provided an education for the children of the royals, landed aristocrats and the economic nobility of the dragonmarked houses. In towns and cities, schools catered to all who wished to attend. In no case was education mandatory; however, most people understood the advantages offered to them by the remnants of the Galifaran education system.

Higher education and study was available at a number of colleges and universities, as well as among the religious institutions—particularly the Church of the Silver Flame, for the Purified considered it a religious duty for every individual to be able to read the Church's scriptures. For those who did not want to become scholars, apprenticeships and on-the-job vocational training replaced higher education. The exception to this system involved magewrights and wizards, who often attended one of the magical academies—the floating citadels of Arcanix in Aundair or the Twelve in Korth—for at least some of their training.

Without the inroads of the “technology” of arcane magic that saturates Eberron, the shape of society in Khorvaire and elsewhere would be far simpler. But though Khorvaire's civilization has much in common with our own world's late medieval period, make no mistake—the Five Nations of

Khorvaire are not representative of a typical medieval or preindustrial society. Whether king or commoner, the people of Khorvaire almost universally rely on arcane magic to protect their health and conduct their day-to-day lives (sometimes without even being aware of it). Even so, Eberron is by no means a modern society, and though arcane magic grants many of the same benefits as the early industrialization of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries did on our own world, it generally does so in very different ways. Of course, Khorvaire's "pseudo-medieval" culture already shares many of the cultural and economic elements of a later Renaissance or even eighteenth century human society as it developed on Earth. This is an important point, because it underscores the fact that the benefits granted by the wide-scale manipulation of magic are not provided by arcane factories of mass production. Instead, Eberron's magical wonders remain the purview of individual practitioners, artisans, and expert crafters. While skycoaches may fly among the soaring towers of Sharn, it is important to remember that each skycoach is the product of individual effort by skilled designers, craftsmen, and spellcasters. Though House Cannith's blacksmiths might chant spells to improve the way they work, their individual forges continue to spit out items just one at a time. While airship travel allows fast, safe, and expensive transport across large distances, each airship is a one-of-a-kind product produced for House Lyrandar by Zilargo workshops that are themselves unique foundries of often-competitive talent. While the streets of many Khorvarien cities are illuminated with *everbright lanterns*, their magic is individually cast and maintained by ranks of professional spell chandlers. No central reservoir of arcane magical energy powers these and other wonders through some magical analogue of an Industrial Age "power grid." Professional spellcasters called magewrights differ from adventuring spellcasters in that they earn a daily living by casting spells for payment. A true wizard is a master of this art, able to grasp the metamagical principles behind any spell he can find or create. But this level of arcane talent is a rare gift. Still, most common folk can learn to cast one or two minor spells, if they work hard enough.

While they lack the diversity or raw power of the wizard, warlock or sorcerer, these lesser spellcasters bring simple magic to the marketplace and into the world. These are the magewrights. Just like the term artisan, "magewright" is a generic term encompassing dozens of professions. "Magewright" describes a character's magical skill but it tells you nothing about the actual trade he practices. A commoner seeking to learn magic would not go to "magewright school." Instead, he would become an apprentice wordsmith or seek out a traveling tinker who might share the secrets of his trade. Without the daily spell maintenance of magewrights and others, Eberron would seem a very different place. While the possession of dragonmarks nearly guarantees a professional spellcaster economic viability in one of the houses that dominate the trade and industry of Khorvaire, unmarked

spellcasters can still earn a living by working for the various guilds (though dragonmarked houses own the controlling interests in these enterprises). The vast majority of magewrights only have a single level in the class. These are primarily commoners or tradesmen who trained as a magewright in order to learn a single useful spell. The most common choice is *magecraft*, a ritual that guides an artisan's hands and infuses his work with a touch of magic. An innkeeper might take a single level of magewright to gain access to spells that allow him to magically clean his establishment or create an invisible magical server, while a translator could take one level in the class to learn how to magically speak, write and read other languages. These dabblers are not defined by their arcane knowledge; instead, they know a single trick that enhances their mundane skills. Because of professional spellcasters, most people in Khorvaire enjoy a standard of living above that which they could otherwise normally attain in a pre-industrial society. Most people have enough liquid money to purchase transport on a short-range skycoach, and all citizens benefit from the *everbright lanterns* set along the major thoroughfares of large Khorvarien cities. Of course, plenty of magical services which only the wealthy and motivated can afford also exist.

As the heroes of the world, adventurers often break most of the rules concerning life in Khorvaire—and when a rule does not exist to cover what they do, they invent one. Adventurers move easily among all walks of life. They can champion the common folk, protect the middle class, or engage in missions for the wealthy. Adventurers form into groups, knowing that whatever one can do, four or five can do better. No single adventurer possesses all of the skills and abilities necessary to succeed; the team provides the capabilities and companionship required to get the job done.

Groups come together through chance meetings, fortuitous circumstances, open calls, and guild connections. They stay together if they work well as a team and learn to trust each other. While many adventuring parties operate as freelancers who take up each quest as it comes their way, some acquire patrons who pay their expenses and provide the missions that drive them. Now, any adventuring party can hire itself out for a mission or two. A patron, however, often defines the party's motivation and reason for sticking together. A patron can be a wealthy noble or merchant lord, an organization, dragonmarked house, or a government. Patrons command allegiance based on gold, an exchange of services, or a common goal. A dragonmarked house, a church, a university, the Brelish Crown, and the *Korranberg Chronicle* are all examples of adventuring party patrons. Whatever the case, the common folk love to read about or hear stories and ballads concerning champions of good and agents of evil. The *Korranberg Chronicle*, in particular, presents stories that follow adventurers from the towers of Sharn to the mysterious jungles of Xen'drik and back again on a regular basis.

Many towns and cities of Khorvaire had long traditions of town criers, newsbearers who presented important or interesting information in town squares, nobles' courts, or other public gathering places. It was not long before the magical arts allowed for a more permanent method of presentation, and the broadsheet chronicles were born in the early centuries of the long peace brought by the establishment of the Kingdom of Galifar. The simplest chronicles first appeared as scrolls nailed to public message boards containing the pertinent news of the week. More ambitious chronicles, including the *Breland Ledger*, the *Sharn Inquisitive*, and the *Aundairian Scroll*, are presented as folded broadsheets nested together to form simple, unbound books. Each edition is collected and stored, eventually being bound as a chronicle of news and information.

By far, the most well-known and widely-read chronicle across Khorvaire is the *Korranberg Chronicle*. Thanks to its relentless and mostly unbiased coverage of the Last War, and through a distribution deal with House Orien, the *Korranberg Chronicle* enjoyed a loyal and avid readership throughout central Khorvaire. A typical edition of the *Korranberg Chronicle* featured news from around the Five Nations, Zilargo, and the Mror Holds, as well as stories of adventurers and exciting expeditions, business solicitations, royal proclamations, and almanac information. While the main offices were located in the gnomes' city of Korranberg in Zilargo, the *Chronicle* employed chroniclers of every race far and wide, and maintained field offices in every one of the major nations that once comprised Galifar. House Orien distributed each edition (the *Chronicle* appeared three days a week; Mol, Wir, and Far) along its regular mail caravan and lightning rail runs across Khorvaire, allowing the *Chronicle* to reach a huge audience. Indeed, almost everyone in the Five Nations today knows the *Chronicle* slogan: "If it happens in the Five Nations, you'll read about it in the *Korranberg Chronicle*."

Due to the widespread influence of the dragonmarked houses across Khorvaire, Common, a spoken and written tongue descended from the Sarlonan language and alphabet called Old Common and used by the first humans to reach Khorvaire with Lhazhaar, developed into the universal language of the Five Nations and then of the Kingdom of Galifar. Commerce and diplomacy used Common to communicate on a level playing field. It is prevalent and as universal as any language could be across the continent. Common was the primary language of the Five Nations. It was a necessary second language in the Mror Holds and Zilargo and was used extensively even among the halflings of the Talenta Plains. Other prominent languages in use on the continent included Draconic, Dwarven, Abyssal, Elven, Goblin, and Orcish.

The capital of the Kingdom of Galifar, Thronehold, was established by King Galifar I soon after he completed his unification of the new state. Thronehold rested in the middle of Scions Sound at the very heart of central Khorvaire. Though Galifar I had united the Five Nations and forged a new kingdom, he realized early on that the new monarchy could not rule from one of the existing realms. To do so would be to put one of the Five Nations above the other, and that would lead to political breaks and fractures that would eventually destroy the kingdom. From the moment young Galifar stood on the banks of Scions Sound and looked upon the mysterious island that rested just out of reach of the Five Nations, he knew that the island would play an important role in the realization of his dream of unification. On this island he would build his capital—the fortress of Thronehold. Prior to the birth of Galifar, the island was considered to be haunted, a place of the old ways of Khorvaire before humanity arrived on its shores. That reputation, and its central location between the borders of the Five Nations, made it the perfect place for Galifar I's purposes. The great castle of Thronehold became a shining symbol of the new kingdom, and the island around it developed into a wondrous showcase for the realm. It remained so until the Last War, when it became a reminder of all the glory that was lost.

After King Jarot's death and the rejection of the line of the ir'Wynarn succession that led to the Last War, the island and castle of Thronehold were largely abandoned. A special detachment of House Deneith guards, the Throne Wardens, remained in place to protect and maintain the castle, but all government functions ceased with the collapse of the united kingdom. The town of Throneport, a support community in the shadow of the castle, mutated as the Last War progressed. It became a place for dissidents, spies, criminals, and mercenaries, and the once opulent and safe port turned into a rough-and-tumble town without law or allegiance to any single nation. This neutrality has served Throneport well; by 975 YK it had grown into a small city in which all of the nations and dragonmarked houses had at least a small presence, turning it into a hotbed of international intrigue. The Treaty of Thronehold further solidified this position, establishing the city of Throneport as a multinational province under the control of small peacekeeping forces from Aundair, Breland, Karnath, and Thrane, with House Deneith's Throne Wardens in place to make sure the terms of the treaty were honored. Today, the small city is neutral ground, but the castle of Thronehold and its grounds remain off-limits and under the watchful protection of the Throne Wardens.

Ultimately, Galifar ir'Wynarn succeeded in establishing the united kingdom of Khorvarien peoples—humans, elves, eladrin, dwarves, gnomes, halflings, shifters, half-orcs, kalashtar and changelings—that he had long dreamed about during his childhood. Unlike his ancestor Karrn the Conqueror, Galifar built the kingdom that bore his name not through conquest but ultimately by

persuading the peoples of the Five Nations that their societies could be greater than the simple sum of their parts.

15 YK

The Establishment of the Arcane Congress and Arcanix: King Galifar I established the Arcane Congress in the village of Arcanix in Aundair. While Galifar I believed he had cemented the loyalty of the dragonmarked houses to his new kingdom through their acceptance of the Korth Edicts, he was aware that the greatest institution of magical learning and arcane research on Khorvaire, the Twelve, was entirely within the hands of the houses. The houses controlled the direction of the magical research conducted at the Twelve and also were entitled to first use of all the possible inventions created by the wizards, sorcerers and magewrights who called the Twelve home. Galifar I wanted to balance the power of the Twelve by creating his own state-backed arcane research institution. To this end, the king established the Arcane Congress in Aundair and specifically tasked it with the pursuit of research in arcane magic and the teaching of magic to new generations of mages, sorcerers, artificers and magewrights who would produce magical innovations that would improve the lives of all the people of Galifar. The Arcane Congress consisted of a council of wizards, artificers and sorcerers who explored the limits of the arcane arts of magic.

The village of Arcanix, located along the southeastern banks of Lake Galifar, is now known for the floating towers of wizardry that surround it. These towers serve as places of arcane learning, where the tower mentors help train the next generation of magewrights, artificers, sorcerers and wizards. The village also housed the Arcane Congress itself. The members of the Congress oversaw the towers of wizardry, advised Galifar's—and later Aundair's monarch—on all things magical, and conferred with colleagues in the other nations—despite a rivalry with the wizards of the Twelve. Apprentices came from all over Khorvaire to Arcanix to train as magewrights, artificers, wizards and sorcerers at the more advanced arcanists' sides, and much of the village's economy revolved around providing for the students. Fewest were the students selected for wizard training, because the mentors held every candidate to the highest possible standards. While traders and the occasional visitor passed through Arcanix, most of the Aundairian common folk steered clear of the magically volatile village and the area around it.

28 YK

The Galifar-Lhazaar War Begins: The Galifar-Lhazaar War, a decade-long conflict between the Kingdom of Galifar and the pirates and buccaneers of the Lhazaar Principalities, began

in 28 YK. The Lhazaar Principalities developed during the same period when the Five Nations were formed, more than a thousand years before the birth of the Kingdom of Galifar. By the time King Galifar I united the Five Nations, the Principalities were already well-established, as was their inhabitants' well-deserved reputation as raiders and pirates. When Galifar I proclaimed that his kingdom "stretched across the width and breadth of Khorvaire," the Lhazaar pirates' princes ignored him. Their domains in the east were far from the great cities of the Five Nations in central Khorvaire, separated by a formidable mountain range and the endless seas over which the princes ruled supreme.

By 28 YK, Galifar I had consolidated his hold over the Five Nations and turned his attention to the threat to his new state's integrity that lay in the east. The Lhazaar princes and sea barons were wreaking havoc among Khorvaire's coastal communities, interfering with shipping and refusing to bend to the will of the Galifaran Crown. Thus began the Galifar–Lhazaar War, a series of naval engagements that lasted nearly a decade. The sea barons knew the currents better and started out with better vessels, but Galifar I dedicated his efforts to building a powerful navy. Aided by magic and the help of some of the dragonmarked houses, particularly the sea-going half-elves of House Lyrandar, the Royal Galifaran Navy was able to garner enough victories on the Sea of Rage to force the Lhazaar princes to meet to discuss terms. In the end, the Principalities agreed to officially become a part of Galifar I's united kingdom but to remain largely autonomous in their local affairs. The Lhazaar sea princes would be left more or less independent within their own domains, yet they each agreed to pay tribute to King Galifar I and recognize him and his heirs in the House of Wynam as the legitimate rulers of the mainland kingdom, as well as to refrain from attacking Galifaran shipping (an agreement often honored in the breach).

32 YK

The Five Nations are Renamed and the City of Sharn is Rebuilt: The Five Nations of Galifar eventually adopted the names of King Galifar I's royal children and their first governor-princes as their own, becoming Aundair (formerly Thaliost), Cyre (formerly Metrol), Karrnath, Thrane (formerly Daskara), and Breland (formerly Wroat). This change was meant to mirror the united kingdom's own adoption of the name of its first monarch and founder.

For over five hundred years after the destruction of the city of Sharn during the War of the Mark, the superstitious folk of pre-Galifar Breland had shunned the ruined towers of the metropolis that had once stretched above the bluffs of the Dagger River, muttering about the curses of the aberrant dragonmarked lords. Despite the superstitions, the location continued to have the same considerable strategic and economic value it had possessed under the Dhakaani and the previous

human regime. When King Galifar I took control of the Five Nations and established his unified kingdom, he sent a force of Galifaran troops to rebuild the ruined city. Continuing his excellent relations with the dragonmarked houses, Galifar I granted House Cannith a critical role in the reconstruction of the city that was still called Sharn, the City of Towers. House Cannith used its resources to help raise Sharn's towers once more and to this day remains one of the most influential forces in what has become the largest and most cosmopolitan city on Khorvaire. Galifar brought in skilled dwarven engineers from the recently subdued Mror Holds and a few members of the Brelish nobility invested a great deal of their gold in the City of Towers' resurrection. The chief among these aristocrats was the Brelish ir'Tain family. Even in the present time, the ir'Tains are known as the slumlords of Sharn and over the centuries since the city's restoration the family has made a fortune from its many tenement properties. Today the ir'Tains are one of the most powerful noble families in Breland because of their control over much of Sharn's land; Lord Hass ir'Tain is an influential member of the Brelish Parliament and his mother Lady Celyria ir'Tain is the unquestioned leader of Sharn's high society. In addition to the ir'Tains, other powerful noble families and merchant groups flocked to the new Galifaran commercial center and Sharn grew and prospered over the next millennium.

When the work on the reconstruction of Sharn began, only a few towers remained standing above the ancient Dhakaani foundations and pre-Galifar human ruins. It was believed that the aberrant curse of the Lady of the Plague still lingered in the darkness and the remnants of the older cities that had stood above the Dagger River were quickly sealed away by the Galifaran workers. In time they were forgotten, lost in the shadows of the new towers that soon stretched towards the sky. Occasionally, treasure-hunters and adventurers ventured down into the haunted levels that lay between the Lower City and the industrial workshops known as the Cogs, but the vast majority of the City of Towers' citizens knew little or nothing of the ruins that lay in the depths of their home.

Before long, Sharn had become the largest metropolis in Khorvaire, a center for trade, diplomacy and political intrigue, a city with an important role to play in the future of the continent.

40 YK

Galifar I Abdicates His Throne in Favor of His Son: At the age of eighty-five winters, King Galifar I abdicated his throne and passed the rulership of the united kingdom he had founded to his oldest remaining son, Prince Cyre ir'Wynarn, the governor-prince of Cyre. This event marked the establishment of an important tradition for the feudal nobility that came to rule Galifar—the eldest of the ruling monarch's children, regardless of gender, always succeeded to the throne.

53 YK

The Death of Galifar I: King Galifar I, Galifar ir'Wynarn, at last passed away to the Shadowfell thirteen years after handing over the throne of the great kingdom he founded to his son, King Cyre. Galifar, who had died at the age of ninety-eight winters, was buried with great ceremony beneath the great keep he had constructed at Thronehold and his funeral was attended by all the great and the good of Khorvaire, as well as tens of thousands of common Galifarans who wished to pay their respects to the visionary leader whose rule had greatly improved their lives.

106 YK

House Kundarak is Formally Recognized as One of the Twelve: The dwarven Clan Kundarak of the Mror Holds formally became the dragonmarked House Kundarak in charge of much of Khorvaire's banking and financial transactions with the aid of the gnomes of House Sivis of Zilargo in 106 YK. Kundarak was recognized by the already established dragonmarked houses as the newest member of the Twelve (though only ten houses existed at this point in time).

299 YK

The Birth of the Church of the Silver Flame: The Church of the Silver Flame was born in the nation of Thrane in 299 YK. In that year, a terrible eruption split the ground of that kingdom in what is now the city of Flamekeep and a great pillar of crimson fire emerged from the resulting chasm. No one understood the significance of the blazing column of flame, but most who dared approach it felt unrelenting malevolence in its fierce, radiating heat. A cataclysm of untold proportions had befallen Khorvaire: one of the rakasha rajahs, a fiendish Overlord, had managed to break the magical bonds long ago placed upon it by the sacrifice of the couatl race and free itself from its arcane imprisonment deep in Khyber.

Tira Miron, a paladin dedicated to the Sovereign Dol Arrah, received a powerful vision about this strange fire while exploring the western reaches of the realm. In her vision, a great rainbow-winged serpent, a couatl, warned her that a terrible evil was emerging in the east, riding crimson fire from the depths of Khyber itself. Tira rallied the local Galifaran military forces of Thrane and defeated the dark creatures that had come to venerate the crimson fire and help free the malevolent entity trapped within its flames. With her great magical sword *Kloinjier*, its pommel capped with a Khyber dragonshard, Tira turned to face the emerging fiendish Overlord just as the great serpent with the rainbow-feathered wings of her vision appeared and dove headfirst into its infernal fire. Tira

watched as the winged serpent and the demon struggled in the flames. The battle within the fire seemed to last for an eternity, and as she watched the fiend began to overcome the rainbow serpent.

Horried, Tira saw the demon strike a crippling blow. The couatl, calling on its last reserves of celestial power, encircled the Overlord and buried its fangs into the fiend's fiery throat. At the same moment, the couatl sent a mental plea to Tira, and the paladin did not hesitate. She leaped into the fire, plunging *Kloinj* through the writhing serpent and deep into the demon Overlord's blazing flesh. Then, the legend says, a powerful explosion rocked the entire continent of Khorvaire. The hot crimson fire became a cool silver flame, the physical expression of the restoration of the couatl race's wards over the Overlord. Tira remained within, her soul now part of the divine fire that had replaced the malevolent conflagration.

Tira Miron became the Voice of the Silver Flame, and a new religion was born. Flamekeep, a simple stone castle, was erected around the ever-burning pillar of silver fire. Deep within the chasm, at the point where the divine fire still erupts from the earth, it is said that mighty *Kloinj*'s blade is buried almost to the hilt, binding demonic Overlord, feathered serpent, and human paladin together forever.

In time, the castle grew to become a cathedral, and a city grew up around around it, also taking the name of Flamekeep. By 400 YK, the Church of the Silver Flame that had grown up around this event had become the dominant religion of Thrane. The Sovereign Host, accepting of most faiths, saw the Silver Flame as just another expression of the divine pantheon on Eberron. The Silver Flame, on the other hand, tolerated the Host but had little love for faiths that did not accept the cleansing light of the Flame.

Over the centuries, the kings and queens of Galifar, and their sons and daughters who governed the realm of Thrane as its governor-princes, had a mixed relationship with the faith of the Silver Flame. As Thrane's people began to turn to this faith in droves, the House of Wynam was forced to accept the Church of the Silver Flame as a force within the kingdom.

Early on, they tried to restrict it to Thrane, but the faithful were zealous, and missionaries soon appeared to bring word of the Silver Flame to the rest of Khorvaire. More than one Wynam scion over the centuries, while governing in Thrane, adopted the faith. One particularly dark episode occurred in 558 YK, when Queen Joliana reached the Galifaran throne after serving as Thrane's governor-princess. She was a devoted follower of the Silver Flame, and decided that under her rule all of Galifar would accept the Silver Flame as the one true faith. A few bloody clashes almost led to civil war before Joliana died suddenly and mysteriously before the second year of her reign had ended in 560 YK. The work of House Phiarlan's assassins in Joliana's death has long been suspected.

The Church of the Silver Flame, unlike Eberron's majority faith of the Sovereign Host, developed a rigid ecclesiastical hierarchy within only a few decades of its formation. This hierarchy was composed of four formal orders, which were supplemented by various smaller brotherhoods and monastic orders. The largest of the Church's orders was the Order of Ministers. This order included what most people would consider standard priests. They lead services and mass at the local churches, acted as community leaders, conducted theological research and liturgical debates and eventually served in Thrane's military during the Last War. The Order of Templars included the true warriors of the Church of the Silver Flame. The Templars consisted mostly of warriors, supplemented by a substantial number of monks and a few priests. Most of the Silver Flame's human paladins served as Templars. The Order of Friars was the Church's missionary wing. Rather than being assigned a specific region or community, friars traveled from land to land, bringing the light of the Flame into dark places and converting all who seemed receptive to the Church's message. They are also wandering priests, but their duties are less well-defined. They serve where they can, lead by example, conduct services, offer sermons and aid all those who require assistance. Friars are also called "priests errant," particularly among the older Purified. The previous three orders were considered relatively equal in the eyes of the Church's hierarchy. But the Council of Cardinals stood above them all. Seminarians can enter the Ministers, Friars or Templars immediately upon graduation, but only experienced and well-respected priests were promoted to serve on the Council of Cardinals. Most Cardinals were raised up from the Order of Ministers, with a notable few coming from among the Order of Templars. Only very rare individuals rose from the Order of Friars. Most observers outside of the Church of the Silver Flame believe that the Council of Cardinals serves as the governing body of the faith. In truth, that body is more properly entitled as the Diet of Cardinals and its members are drawn from the ranks of the Council. The Council itself is simply another order, like the others, albeit a higher-ranking one. As in any specialized profession, the use of arcane nomenclature helps separate the insiders from the outsiders.

The highest position in the Church of the Silver Flame is held by the Voice of the Silver Flame, though one could argue that it is not a position at all, so much as it is a part of the Flame itself. The paladin Tira Miron joined with the Silver Flame in 299 YK, binding a couatl and the escaped demon Overlord they were attempting to destroy. Since being joined with the paladin, the Flame has openly communicated with mortals—Tira serves literally as the Flame's voice to the faithful. The Keeper of the Flame serves as the intermediary between the Voice of the Silver Flame and the Diet of Cardinals. The Keeper is not elected but is called to the position by the Voice. The current Keeper is an eleven-year-old girl named Jaela Daran. A Cardinal was a member of the Council of Cardinals, the

most senior priests of the Church. Cardinals rarely conduct ceremonies of their own and have little to do with governing the affairs of individual cities now that Thrane is a theocracy, as they are too busy running the Church itself. Only a cardinal can serve on the Diet of Cardinals—the actual ruling body of the Church that stands above the Council—but not all cardinals are members of the Diet. Because cardinals must be nominated and elected by other cardinals, the overwhelming majority of them come from the ranks of the archbishops, since the cardinals have regular interactions with few others in the Church. A priest who holds authority over the bishops of several major cities is an archbishop. Only the Order of Ministers has members of this rank and it is the highest rank clergy can obtain without joining the Council of Cardinals. A bishop holds authority over all the priests of a given city or other large community where the Church operates. The term is used primarily by the Order of Ministers. The equivalent title in the Order of Templars is “Prefect.” There is no equivalent rank among the Order of Friars. A friar who wishes to advance farther in the clerical hierarchy must change orders. Those who have successfully joined the priesthood, but have obtained no higher position, are simply called priests. The overwhelming majority of Silver Flame functionaries never rise higher than this rank. A priest in the Order of Ministers is referred to as “Father” or “Mother.” A priest in the Order of Friars is referred to as “Brother” or “Sister.” A priest of the Order of Templars is “Sir” or “Lady.” The lowest rank of true priests, Pilgrims are the novice members of the Order of Friars. They are lower in the hierarchy than starting members of the other orders, because their responsibilities are fewer and less well-defined. The final two ranks of the Church are the acolytes and seminarians who are still in training to become priests but have no formal ranks as of yet.

In some regions, but particularly in Thrane, worship of the Silver Flame is the dominant religion. Most locals are born into the faith rather than being converts to it. With that said, in every area of Khorvaire save for Thrane, the Church still gains as many new members from conversion as from procreation. It is the only major religion of Eberron that specifically preaches a need to change the world and that good will ultimately triumph over evil, and justice over injustice. Other faiths preach the need to protect Eberron (as the druidic sects do) or to ascend from mortal life to divinity (like the Blood of Vol), but few grant their worshippers the sense of purpose provided by the Silver Flame, which seeks to transform Eberron into a utopia for all virtuous people. Worship of the Silver Flame appeals to those who have suffered injustice or who seek to make the world a better place. It also resonates with people who have a strong martial ethic—many of those who fight for good in the name of the Silver Flame are in it more for the fight than the good.

The Church of the Silver Flame has always been strongest in Thrane. For many years, that nation’s rulers were followers of that faith. The Diet of Cardinals would eventually take over the

nation in 914 YK and transform it into a theocracy where the Keeper of the Flame and the cardinals wielded secular as well as spiritual power. In most of the other nations of Khorvaire, the Silver Flame is just one faith among many. Although the Church might attempt to convert members of the government and influence political decisions, it has only a limited ability to do so. Some of its more zealous factions call for an open *coup d'état*, claiming that the violence would be more than justified by the good the Flame could do with all of the Five Nations under its sway. Fortunately, the majority of the Diet of Cardinals is opposed to this action—the Church, powerful though it is, lacks the secular means to carry it out in any event. The Purified coexist with the Vasals of the Sovereign Host and the other faiths, and preach to the nobility and the dragonmarked houses as much as they are able. The Church also has made itself indispensable by lending its templars to the Galifaran Army, and in the present time, to the individual nations' armies—if those armies are fighting for a cause it can support. Only in areas of Khorvaire vehemently opposed to the Silver Flame's theology, such as Droaam, the nation of “monsters,” do the Purified not operate openly and actively. Even there, however, the Church of the Silver Flame has a few hidden enclaves of templars who seek to do what good they can. Most importantly, they watch for those rare natives of that land who seem unhappy with their current circumstances and might be suitable candidates for conversion. A faithful insider within an organization or state was often a far more potent weapon for the Church than half a dozen holy warriors.

347 YK

House Lyrandar Establishes Stormhome: The Khoravar dragonmarked House Lyrandar took possession of an island off the northern coast of Khorvaire with the permission of the Galifaran Crown and Aundair's regional authorities to create Stormhome, the City of Escapes, the seat of their house. The large island off the northern coast of Aundair was once a bleak, storm-blasted outpost at the entrance to Scions Sound. In 347 YK, House Lyrandar petitioned to turn the island into a house enclave, and the Galifaran Crown relented—with the caveat that it could maintain a protective military force there to monitor the comings and goings at sea. Three years later, the weather mages and dragonmarked heirs of Lyrandar had changed the climate of the island. While cold weather and storms continued to rage around it, Stormhome itself became a temperate paradise. Today, Stormhome remains the crowning achievement of House Lyrandar's skills and abilities. The city that bears the island's name serves as the primary headquarters for the House of Storm and the seat of its present-day matriarch. Today, the Kingdom of Aundair considers the island to be an extension of its nation, and House Lyrandar continues to permit an Aundairian military contingent to use part of the

island as a base. The Aundairian Navy patrols the northern coast, stopping at Stormhome for supplies and to escape the bitter cold wind that blows across the bay.

In addition to the presence of many of the leading members of House Lyrandar and their retainers, a number of other wealthy nobles regularly visit the city. It has become something of a vacation spot, and House Lyrandar has permitted House Ghallanda to establish elaborate resorts within the city limits to cater to its guests. During the Last War, the island was mostly left alone by attacking forces due to House Lyrandar's political neutrality and diplomatic position. It became a meeting place for spies from the Five Nations and a hotbed of clandestine activities between other organizations, a reputation that it continues to hold in the current day.

498 YK

House Tharashk is Founded in the Shadow Marches: At this time, expeditions from the Galifaran cities of central Khorvaire reached the Shadow Marches of far western Khorvaire. One such expedition was led by Zil gnomes, who had calculated that the distant land might hold rich deposits of dragonshards. In this, they were correct, but the discovery of the Mark of Finding was an even greater treasure. The Mark of Finding's human and half-orc clan leaders were cunning and capable, but the House Sivilis emissaries who had accompanied the Zil expedition were intent on working with the Marchers, not exploiting them. With the assistance of the gnomes, the three great dragonmarked clans of Aashta, Torrns and Velderan and their lesser kin joined together to form House Tharashk, an Orcish word meaning "united." The Torrns and their allied lesser clans possess the strongest druidic tradition and the greatest number of full-blooded orcs as a result. The Aashta and their lesser clans produce the sorcerers of the house and have ties to the Cults of the Dragon below. The Velderan clan was made up mostly of humans and was known for its altruistic outlook. The Torrns were usually unaligned in the struggle between light and darkness while the Aashta were too easily drawn into the shadows of Khyber. For the symbol of the house, the first ruling Tharashk Triumvirate chose the dragonne, touched with the power of dragons and a fierce hunter in the legends of both the Marcher orcs and the Sarlonan human settlers.

Tharashk was founded on the dragonshard trade, its dragonmarked heirs employing the Mark of Finding to locate shard fields while their unmarked kin mined those deposits. The three Tharashk clans' leaders were ambitious, however, and not content to remain in the shadows. Over the four hundred years after their discovery by House Sivilis, Tharashk prospectors explored the deepest corners of Eberron, drawing dragonshards and other valuable substances from Q'barra, the Demon

Wastes and Xen'drik. City-dwelling Tharashk heirs sell their services as inquisitives and bounty hunters.

512 YK

The Construction of the Starpeaks Observatory: King Daroon of Galifar ordered the construction of the famed Starpeaks Observatory early in the sixth century YK. Located high in the Starpeaks, a mountain chain in northern Aundair, the Starpeaks Observatory was constructed in this year. Daroon became fascinated with the practice of charting the moons and stars, especially with the idea that these charts could provide signs and portents for the future as a part of the draconic Prophecy. Daroon had the observatory built, but he died before construction was completed. Today the Arcane Congress uses the place to study the moons and stars and a gigantic, magical orrery representing the motion of the planes and the moons of Eberron is maintained within.

778 YK

The Medusas Come to Cazhaak Draal: Medusas from Khyber took possession of the ruins of the ancient Dhakaani city of Cazhaak Draal in what is now the independent nation of Droaam in western Khorvaire, where they restored the city to a semblance of life. The medusas were led by one of their kind named Sheshka, who became known as the Queen of Stone.

Many forms of life on Eberron have been shaped by the arcane magical forces that suffuse the world. This can be seen in the minor illusion-weaving ability of the gnomes, the teleporting blink dog, or the petrifying gaze of the medusa. The deadly power of a medusa can certainly inspire terror, and thinking of this creature as a simple monster is easy. But medusas are not savage predators, roaming the wastes in search of prey. The medusas of Cazhaak Draal are, on average, more intelligent than most humans, and they have a proud city-state in the midst of what has become the newborn Kingdom of Droaam. The power of the medusas is a potent weapon in the present-day arsenal of Droaam, the “nation of monsters.” The medusas were born in Khyber, and no one on the surface knows the extent of their subterranean civilization.

In 778 YK, a force of medusas emerged from the underworld and laid claim to the city of Cazhaak Draal, an ancient goblin metropolis of the Dhakaani Empire that had been abandoned since the Daelkyr War had ended millennia before. Over the course of the next two hundred years, the medusas renovated Cazhaak Draal, repairing the ruins and domesticating many of the dangerous creatures found in the region. For the most part, the medusas were content in their tiny kingdom: Cazhaak Draal was far larger than their small numbers required, and many powerful Dhakaani

treasures and magical wonders existed in the ancient city. Explorers who ventured into what became known as the “Stonelands” around the city rarely returned, but the medusas had little interest in the outside world.

The Gatekeeper druids claim that medusas were magical aberrations created millennia ago by the daelkyr Orlassk, but the medusa priests of Cazhaak Draal offered their devotions to the Shadow. They claimed that the Shadow shaped many of the creatures humans see as monsters, giving the harpy her deadly voice, hiding the displacer beast from its foes, and healing the wounds of the troll. These priests view the deities of the Sovereign Host as the true evil, comparing the divine exile of the Shadow to the fear with which many humans respond to medusas and other creatures labeled monsters.

Of course, some medusas do earn their evil reputation. Several revel in their powers and petrify lesser creatures for sport. But a medusa who calls this sort of attention to herself will not last long in one of the great cities of Khorvaire. Those medusas chosen to represent the “monster” nation of Droaam (see below) at the present time in the wider world are carefully vetted by Queen Sheshka and officials of House Tharashk, which established a relationship with the “monsters” of Droaam and began to offer their services as mercenaries to the people of the Five Nations. The average medusa is more intelligent and cunning than the average human, and she understands the need to control her behavior among the soft people of Khorvaire. In the Brelish city of Sharn, for example, a medusa may move unfettered in the lawless districts, but if she enters a respectable neighborhood, she must wear eyeblinders, a metal visor secured with straps around forehead and chin; otherwise she may be attacked by the agents of the law. Eyeblinders require a full minute to don or remove; in some cities, a medusa must have the blinders secured with a lock for the duration of her stay.

Despite their worship of the Shadow, medusas are no more inherently evil than humans or elves. Some are arrogant and proud, believing that their deadly gaze places them above mundane creatures. Others respond to the fear they encounter every day by despising those who fear them, a path that often leads to malicious motivations. But many enjoy the same pleasures that humans do, and seek out song, good company, and the satisfaction of hard work. The medusas of Cazhaak Draal have a strong tradition of stonework, both architecture and purely aesthetic sculpture, and these works have begun to come to the notice of the outside world. For instance, in recent years, Councilor Kilk of Sharn has sought permission to bring in medusa architects and masons to perform work in the district of Northedge, although to date the other councilors have refused to use city funds to pay for the services of “monsters.”

The gaze of a medusa can petrify even an ally, and as a result, a medusa does not meet the gaze of a person with whom she is conversing. Where she directs her eyes indicates her esteem for the person. She drops her eyes toward the ground to show respect, or looks up and over the person if she wishes to indicate disdain; when speaking to an equal, she glances to the left or right. If she wishes to show trust, she directs her gaze to the person, but closes her eyes. While this may seem inconvenient to a human, it has little impact on a medusa. If a medusa concentrates, she can receive limited visual impressions from the serpents that make up her hair; as a result, though she seems to look elsewhere, she is actually looking through the eyes of her serpents. She can even use her serpents to see when she is blindfolded or has her eyes closed. However, she can still “see” in only one direction in this way; her serpents may look all around her, but she cannot mentally process the information from all of them at once.

789 YK

House Sivis Opens Continent-Wide Arcane Communications: House Sivis message stations began operations in 789 YK. The gnomes of Zilargo who carried the Mark of Scribing offered a variety of services relating to communication, from magically notarizing documents to sending short messages rapidly over long distances by means of an arcane sending. Written or verbal messages could also be sent across longer distances through the use of what the house called message stations.

These outposts, found in larger towns and cities throughout Khorvaire, served as origination and termination points for relatively short verbal or written messages, similar to the technology of the telegraph on our own world. Like the lightning rail, this service was fast but limited to only specific locations that were home to a message station. At the message stations, the house’s dragonmarked members cast spells (or use paired magic items called *sending stones*) to send messages over a distance. The service was relatively expensive and most common people who wanted to keep in touch with friends and family elsewhere in Galifar preferred to use House Orien’s caravan-based courier and mail service. But the existence of House Sivis’ message station network was one more factor that helped to tie the diverse peoples and cultures of the Five Nations into the single state of Galifar.

797 YK

Mordain the Fleshweaver is Excoriated From House Phiarlan: The elven wizard Mordain d’Phiarlan was one of the most skilled wizards ever to have been trained by the Twelve. But Mordain

proved to be ruthless and utterly amoral, concerned only with expanding his arcane knowledge and pursuing research into the forbidden magical arts of the daelkyr, for the elven mage was consumed with the ambition to create new forms of life as the lords of Xoriat had done. Mordain went too far even for the Twelve when he began to delve deep into the lost secrets of the Closed Circle of Sharn, a dark wizards circle of the City of Towers that had been wiped out by a combined strike between the Church of the Silver Flame and Sharn's other two wizards circles, the Esoteric Order of Aureon and the Guild of Starlight and Shadows, in 641 YK. The Closed Circle's members had been researching the power of the daelkyr and the other dark secrets of the Dragon Below and Sharn's city government had approved the strike. Mordain returned to the Closed Circle's ruined sanctuaries and recovered as much of their dark lore as he could manage. When the Twelve at last discovered the extent of his research and that he had been using several unwilling members of the common races as test subjects for his hideous experiments in producing new aberrations, he was excoriated from House Phiarlan and handed over to the Sentinel Marshals for justice. According to the records of Salyon Syrralan d'Sivis, the Twelve tried to execute Mordain after he was tried and found guilty of murder but failed. Salyon's account states that Mordain was bathed in acid, burned at the stake, drowned, and even dismembered, and after each attempt, "he rose again, his vigor unchecked and flesh rebound." Mordain's victims were not the only ones who had been altered by the fleshshaping magic of the daelkyr. Mordain was finally petrified by the Twelve and sent to Dreadhold, but he escaped before reaching that island prison; Salyon speculated that "no lesser mage could set his will over the flesh of Mordain." Where Mordain escaped to remained unknown for almost a century, though in fact he fled into the wild lands of what would one day become the nation of Droaam.

802 YK

The City of Stormreach is Established in Xen'drik: The Kingdom of Galifar, in cooperation with the dragonmarked houses, funded the upgrade of the trade city of Stormreach on the northern peninsula of Xen'drik in 802 YK. The city of Stormreach had a fascinating history. Forty thousand years before the present time, Stormreach had been a city of giants and served as the capital city of the Cul'sir Empire. That city's remnants were still visible throughout modern Stormreach, including the great statute of a giant ruler known only as the Emperor that looked out over the harbor, the rings of standing stones that continuously radiated magic, the colossal, cyclopean walls that divided the city's districts and the floating edifices that defied gravity throughout the city. Over the centuries after the fall of the giant civilizations on Xen'drik, communities of sahuagin and thri-kreen had also made their homes in the city before being wiped away by an unknown force.

Stormreach is relatively small—its population could live in a single ward within Sharn—but it is a free city; for all intents and purposes, it is an independent nation with its own customs and traditions. The Code of Galifar does not apply here, and the rulers of Stormreach consider themselves the equals of any king in Khorvaire. To understand the culture of Stormreach, one must look to its history. Stormreach is haunted by its past. Born in the current age, the city is a human creation, but the region's history stretches back long before the rise of human civilization. The giants of Rushemé say that the region is cursed and point to the ruins of a half-dozen civilizations as proof. Scholars from the Library of Korranberg and Morgrave University have studied these ruins for decades and have created a simple map of the region. But many of the greatest secrets remain. Uncovering the truth is a challenge for adventurers—and a task that has already claimed the lives of hundreds.

The great Library of Korranberg in Zilargo is filled with books written about Xen'drik and Aureon himself, the Sovereign of knowledge, could not condense its full history into only a few paragraphs (like those above or below!).

The history of Stormreach begins in the Age of Demons. Much about this age eludes modern scholars. The dominion of the demon Overlords stretched across the face of Eberron. There is no question that fiendish Overlords ruled domains in Xen'drik and that the dragons and couatls opposed them and might have drawn the titans, the giants' mythic ancestors, into the struggle. Explorers have occasionally found traces of the past: the magic blade of a rakshasa warrior or a brass spire in the style of Ashtakala, the citadel of the Lords of Dust in the Demon Wastes. According to the storytellers of Rushemé, it was in this age that a curse was placed upon the land near the northern ocean. Some scholars believe that a terrible secret is hidden deep beneath Stormreach, below the most ancient ruins of the giants.

Although some believe this land to be cursed, others have always been drawn to it. The titan Cul'sir made this region the center of his empire during the Age of Giants. Many sages believe that the Emperor, the statue towering over the present city's harbor, is a representation of Cul'sir himself, set to guard the city against the demons of the past. Researchers are still struggling to reconstruct the events leading up to the devastation of the original giant cultures of Xen'drik. It is clear that elves lived among the Cul'sir giants, most likely as slaves; many tools and structures from this period are designed for use by the smaller elves. What records have been recovered emphasize that the city played a critical role during the quori invasion of Xen'drik and was a focal point for arcane research tied to the giants' war effort. The historical records are obscure about what the city's wizards were researching but hint at a tremendous power source beneath the city. Whether it was a creation of the giants or a force they were trying to tap into is unknown.

The defeat of the quori set the stage for the elven uprising against the giants. Relics found in the jungles around Stormreach suggest an elven campaign of guerilla warfare lasting for centuries. This quiet struggle was punctuated by pitched battles. According to Tairnadal tales, the great elf hero Dyrael Morain led an attack on Stormreach in an effort to “destroy the greatest evil in this dark land.” Dyrael and his forces, the largest elf army ever seen at that time, were annihilated, but the Tairnadal still honor his bravery and sacrifice. Many elves of the Valaes Tairn have come to Xen’drik and searched for Dyrael’s bones and his legendary magical blade in the fields south of Stormreach.

The Age of Giants came to an end in a wave of epic magic and dragonfire. Compared to much of Xen’drik, the ruins of Stormreach are well-preserved; the colossal watchman of the Emperor is almost untouched. Other sections of the city were partially buried but otherwise left intact. The giant inhabitants were slaughtered, but some sages believe the dragons held back in dealing with Stormreach itself—that for some reason they were afraid to unleash their full power against the city.

The devastation of Xen’drik left a continent in chaos. The archeological record suggests that a number of cultures found footholds in the region around Stormreach. But each of these settlements collapsed, and by the time humans came to the area, all that was left were ghosts and shattered stone. Scholars have confirmed that the following cultures inhabited Stormreach in the past thirty thousand years. The first group to return to Stormreach was the giants, the ancestors of the modern giants of Rushemé who live near the city. The loremasters of Rushemé say that their ancestors were gripped by the *Du’rashka Tul*, a homicidal madness that forced them to turn on one another and destroyed their nation.

Thousands of years later, the sahuagin of the Thunder Sea came to Stormreach. The sea devils constructed an amphibious community in the flooded sewers of the original giant city. Modern sahuagin will not speak of this fallen culture. Some scholars believe this silence is due to shame—that the old sahuagin were corrupted by a dark force below the city. Others assert that the sahuagin civilization was destroyed so long ago that the modern sahuagin simply know nothing about it. The sahuagin were ultimately driven from the city by a group of giants called the Fallen Stone. Evidence suggests they were either storm giants or some sort of amphibious stone giant—perhaps a missing link between the two races. The Fallen Stone was short-lived; following their victory over the sahuagin, they apparently fell prey to a plague that resisted all forms of magical treatment. Within a century, the region was abandoned again.

The next civilization that left a clear mark on the region of Stormreach was that of the thri-kreen. In the modern age, the intelligent mantis folk of Xen’drik are few in number and largely avoid

human contact. But there was a time when tens of thousands of thri-kreen inhabited the region, carving twisting tunnels into the giants' foundations and sculpting strange monuments beneath the city. The fate of the thri-kreen remains one of the region's greatest mysteries. The other cultures fell to battle or plague. As far as researchers have been able to tell, the thri-kreen culture came to an end instantaneously, as if the bulk of the thri-kreen population simply vanished. The thri-kreen refuse to discuss their history with humans, but the answer might be found in Stormreach's depths.

These four cultures left clear marks on Stormreach, while others passed through with barely a trace. The Library of Korranberg has records of a gnome effort to build an outpost in Stormreach sixteen hundred years ago (around -1600 YK). After mere months, a handful of survivors returned to Zilargo. They blamed their failure on hostile giants, but in recent years the scholar Hegan Del Dorian has advanced the theory that this was a cover story hiding what really happened; he points to the written testimony of a gnome sailor who speaks of a "darkness that gripped both body and soul."

But the history of modern Stormreach itself is much less of a mystery. In the decades before 802 YK, Riedra had already been exploiting Xen'drik's natural resources for centuries and smugglers from Breland and Zilargo had long probed the mysterious continent's northern coast. As trade began to flourish in the Thunder Sea after the human settlement of Khorvair, pirates from Breland, Cyre, Zilargo and even the Lhazaar Principalities began to prey on the Galifaran shipping in the region.

The first Khorvarien humans to make landfall in the Stormreach region were pirates. They wanted an outpost to repair and resupply their ships, and the crumbling docks of Stormreach seemed a good foundation for such a hideout. They found a city in ruins, marked by the civilizations that had come before. The pirates clashed with giants, drow, and sahuagin, but they were mysteriously spared the strange horrors that befell previous settlers. A century passed without plague or warfare, and the pirates prospered. They began searching for opportunities on the continent and discovered both valuable relics in the interior and the power of *kuryeva*, a potent form of gin fermented from the berries of the *kuryeva* bush endemic to northern Xen'drik.

Piracy and smuggling grew ever more profitable in the Thunder Sea and these outlaw captains needed a base to resupply their ships. Smugglers established hideouts along the northern coast of Xen'drik, but most were quickly destroyed by monsters or the marauding Vulkoori drow clans of the interior. The rogue captains needed a truly secure refuge. Some claim it was Delera Omaren, the pirate-queen of the Thunder Sea, who laid the first stones of modern Stormreach. Others say it was Kolis Sel Shadra, the wily gnome smuggler said to own a fleet of spectral ships. Whoever began the settlement, it soon became a joint venture, with many pirate captains contributing resources to the

new town in return for sanctuary within its harbor and access to its businesses. The walls of the ancient Cul'sir giant ruins provided simple fortifications for the settlement and for some reasons, the predators of the jungle seemed to shun the city.

The small outpost grew and prospered, as did the piracy it supported on the Thunder Sea. Delera Omaren and the dwarf pirate Korchan Amanatu left bloody wakes in its waters and the newly-emboldened pirates began preying on Zil, Aereni and even House Lyrandar's shipping. House Tharashk saw the shiploads of dragonshards the pirates were capturing from the Riedrans and wanted to establish their own prospecting operations in the shattered land. Scholars and artificers seized the relics retrieved from the interior of Xen'drik and wanted more. But between harsh weather, the sahuagin, and the constant threat of piracy, travel was simply too dangerous. And all the while, the other dragonmarked houses also became increasingly interested in both Xen'drik's natural resources and the hidden magical secrets of the lost giant civilizations that lay within its forbidding interior.

The Twelve, acting on behalf of the dragonmarked houses, finally appealed to the throne of Galifar to end the pirates' depredations and establish an official Galifaran port in Xen'drik. In 800 YK the king took action. Galifar's greatest military strength lay in its land forces, but the Royal Galifaran Navy was still a force to be reckoned with. After a few sea battles in the Thunder Sea that resulted in deep losses for both sides, a gnome smuggler appeared in Thronehold to petition the court of Galifar. Kolis Sel Shadra was known by his reputation as the smuggler who had never lost a cargo—either to the Galifaran Navy, the Galifaran customs service or other pirates. Sel Shadra came to Thronehold as the representative of the four most powerful pirate captains of the Thunder Sea: the human Delera Omaren, the dwarf Yorrick Amanatu, the human Moluo Lassite and himself. Sel Shadra offered the king of Galifar a truce—if the king would offer these captains an amnesty and recognized political authority over Stormreach, the four would use their influence to disperse the pirates. After extended negotiations, the king agreed in 802 YK to an accord called the Stormreach Compact that would end the war between the pirates and Galifar, and even promised that the Galifaran Crown would join the dragonmarked houses in funding Stormreach's expansion as Khorvaire's primary port of call in Xen'drik. But the king insisted on one condition: that he and his successors appoint a fifth lord over the city who had the Crown's trust. There was much debate, but in time, the four captains—now called the Coin Lords of Stormreach—agreed to grant the privateer Jolan Wylkes the title of Harbor Lord and for the five of them to collectively rule Stormreach together as an oligarchy called the Storm Lords. Wylkes was a sailor, as opposed to the Galifaran nobles who had first been proposed by the Crown. The king and his descendants held to their vow

and the Storm Lords lived up to their end of the bargain as well, bringing an end to the rampant piracy.

For nearly two centuries now, Stormreach has grown and prospered. Several dragonmarked houses have established sizable enclaves within the city and the *kuryeva* of Molou's Distillery is prized by conosseurs across southern Khorvaire. There have been times of trouble—the Omaren Revolt in 890 YK when one of the Coin Lords sought to take over the city and the attack by an army of enraged giants in 946 YK—but the city has always persevered. Today, with the Last War over, Stormreach has become a preeminent destination for the more intrepid merchants, explorers and adventurers of the Five Nations, swelling the city's population to over 11,600 people of every race and creed found on Eberron. Stormreach has also become a major center of intrigue between the dragonmarked houses, the Five Nations, the Inspired of Riedra and many other organizations, all of whom desire a chance to gain access to the many hidden secrets of the ancient past that lie deep within Xen'drik.¹⁰

811-845 YK

Lightning Rail Service Between the Cities of the Five Kingdoms Begins: The creation of a united Kingdom of Galifar had been very good for House Orien. Even as Orien's mundane caravans and couriers connected the Khorvaire of the common folk and even held a royal monopoly on the delivery of mail and parcels throughout Galifar, the Mark of Passage allowed the house to offer services so exclusive—and so expensive—that few but kings and queens could afford them. In a united Galifar, nobles who might once have fought each other were forced to curry diplomatic favor and entertain their peers at court in the Five Nations' capitals and at the national capital of Thronehold. However, the vastness of Khorvaire (not to mention the continent's many dangers) made mundane travel for a royal retinue impractical at best when the monarch of Galifar wanted to travel across the breadth of his continental empire. As such, the *teleport* ability of the greater Mark of Passage quickly became House Orien's most requested (and most profitable) service. Effortless and

¹⁰ What almost no one in Stormreach knows is that the city has been built over the underground prison of one of the greatest fiendish Overlords from the Age of Demons, Sakinnirrot, the Scar That Abides. It is this rakshasa rajah's presence in the area that helped to lay low every previous civilization that established itself in Stormreach and also why even the most fearsome predators and drow tribes of the area stay clear of the city. But even now, the dwarves of House Kundarak have begun to delve down deep beneath the city, erecting the edifice known as the Tower of Kol Korran above their excavations. While the dwarves had secretly unearthed a cavernous complex that contains treasures untold from the days when Stormreach was the capital of the Cul'sir giants' empire, their digging also opened wider the channel between the the sleeping rajah and the unsuspecting city above—and Sakinnirrot is growing stronger as the excavations weaken the bonds placed upon it by the Silver Flame long ago. Unless the dwarves are stopped, Stormreach—and all of Eberron—may soon face a threat unlike any the world has known in a million years.

instantaneous travel between the noble courts of Galifar's provinces helped establish the foundation of communication and trust among its diverse nobility that allowed the new kingdom to thrive.

As its caravan routes stabilized and Galifar grew in the millennium after its founding, Orien took on a lucrative royal commission that seemed like little more than a dream at the time: to connect Galifar's cities with high-speed transport that would allow people and cargo to travel across the kingdom in a matter of days. In 811 YK, with the help of House Cannith's forgeholds, the first lightning rail line was established between Fairhaven, the capital of Aundair and Flamekeep, the capital of Thrane. In 845 YK, King Jarot announced his intention to see the lightning rail connect every corner of Galifar, a task that House Orien completed in less than twenty years when lines connected all of the major settlements of the Five Nations, Zilargo, the Mror Holds, and the Talenta Plains.

House Cannith created *conductor stones*—wondrous magical items that, when arranged along a route in pairs, formed a magical conduit through which a coach could travel at great speed, hovering above the ground and the track laid down by the arcane stones. For propulsion, Cannith turned to the gnomes of Zilargo for the creation of a vehicle that was powered by a bound elemental—in this case, an air elemental to propel the coach through the conduit. When the stones mounted on a coach pass over the stones arranged on the ground, a sparking effect is produced, giving the lightning rail its name. Today, *conductor stone* paths connect the nations of Aundair, Breland, Thrane, and Zilargo in the west, and Karnath, the Talenta Plains, and the Mror Holds in the east. The lightning rail travels at a speed of 30 miles per hour.

With lines of Cannith-forged *conductor stones* spanning the Five Nations, Orien controlled three Crown-subsidized lightning rail routes, all running through the heart of the nation of Cyre's capital, Metrol. From its humble origins on the caravan trails and trade routes of Aundair, Orien had grown into the dragonmarked house that held an empire together.

Soon after the lightning rail entered active service, providing rapid transport for large numbers of people from one part of Galifar to another, it became common practice for the local Galifaran authorities in each of the Five Nations to require travelers to carry some form of legal identification—an internal passport of a kind. As a result, most people of the middle and upper classes, at least in the civilized areas of Khorvaire (Aundair, Breland, Karnath, Cyre, Thrane, Zilargo, and the Mror Holds) began to carry identification papers with them at all times. Issued by national governments (first by Galifar, now by the various nations) and notarized by House Sivis, these papers present a detailed physical description of a person (the wealthy sometimes commission small portraits of themselves), the person's name and residence, and in some cases additional

information about the person's affiliations (particularly including any connection to a dragonmarked house, the landed nobility, a government, or another large institution).

Anyone who travels across national borders in Khorvaire is usually required to carry these traveling papers identifying them, their residence, their destination, and their reason for travel. Traveling papers consist of a parchment sheet with the appropriate information and an arcane watermark, carried in a small leather folder or wallet. House Sivis, House Orien, House Deneith, and House Lyrandar all offer traveling papers, for a fee, that are recognized throughout central Khorvaire.

The development of rapid, long-distance transportation and communication also allowed House Kundarak, the dwarven dragonmarked house whose heirs bore the Mark of Warding, to operate banks throughout central Khorvaire. A person who deposited funds in a Kundarak bank could request from that bank a letter of credit, which allowed him to withdraw funds from a different Kundarak bank branch anywhere in Khorvaire.

For many middle and upper class people, this system was a convenient alternative to carrying wealth around in the form of precious gems, jewelry, or coins. Letters of credit were always notarized with arcane watermarks (usually created by gnome heirs from House Sivis), making them practically impossible to forge. House Kundarak did not charge a fee for issuing these letters of credit, since their banks were already drawing on individuals' deposits to make loans to businesses and governments across the Five Nations. This financial system contributed greatly to the rapid development of Galifar's commercial economy in the century before the outbreak of the Last War and the development of a strong middle class that was not as dependent upon the landed nobility as in previous centuries.

832 YK

The Start of the Silver Purge: The inquisition to wipe out lycanthropes, known as the Silver Purge, was launched by the Church of the Silver Flame across western Khorvaire and ended in the Eldeen Reaches where the lycanthropic infestation had grown the most dangerous; the Purge lasted fifty years and drove the natural as well as afflicted members of the shapeshifting species almost to extinction, catching up many innocent shifters in the murderous passions of the inquisitors.

On Eberron, the moral alignment of a natural lycanthrope is not linked to his animal form. A werebear can be evil and a werewolf can be good. However, afflicted lycanthropes do often come to represent the moral persuasions to be expected from their animal type. Afflicted lycanthropes carrying an evil strain of the disease are some of the most terrifying creatures on Eberron: While a natural werewolf of an evil disposition may wear a human shape, he is still a born predator who takes

joy in spilling human blood. Those afflicted by the magical disease often suffer a dramatic change in personality, regardless of the alignment of the victim before and after the curse. As a result, lycanthropes of all types have always been feared by the people of Khorvaire. Under the best circumstances, the bite of a lycanthrope means a loss of identity; in the worst, it can make a good person into a vicious killer. For an afflicted lycanthrope, this mental transformation is permanent. Even the strongest will crumble before the supernatural power of the disease—and only powerful magical rituals can restore the former personality of the victim. In contrast, a natural lycanthrope cannot be cured; the beast is a part of his body and soul, and it cannot be stripped away. The lycanthrope born into evil may find the strength to become good, but he will always feel the predator in the back of his mind, urging him to prey on the weak and innocent.

The origin of lycanthropy remains a mystery that defies even divination; such rituals produce cryptic and often contradictory statements about moons made flesh and the darkness within. The sages of the Arcane Congress at Arcanix in Aundair and the Library of Korranberg in Zilargo have produced many theories, tracing the disease to the daelkyr, the Gloaming, manifest zones bound to Lamannia, or ancient druids. A more exotic theory comes from the Eldeen Reaches. A number of shifter tribes in the Reaches believe that the moons of Eberron are powerful spirits that watch the world below. These shifters maintain that the shifter race is not descended from natural lycanthropes who bred with humans as most mainstream scholars believe: Rather, the first lycanthropes were actually formed from shifters, who preceded the emergence of lycanthropes by millennia. There is some evidence to support this view, as the shifters of the Eldeen Reaches seem to be immigrants to Khorvaire from Sarlona, much like the humans of the Five Nations. In this case, the shifters appear to have originated in the Tashana Tundra region of northern Sarlona, which has long been home to a large population of Qiku shifter hunter-gatherers. According to this legend, the moon Olarune sought to create guardians who could protect the primal world of nature; reaching down from the sky, she touched a handful of chosen shifters, granting them the power to fully assume animal form. But the shifters' druids, the moonspeakers, say that a thirteenth spirit is in the sky—a dark moon that hides its face from the world. This darkness corrupted Olarune's gift, infecting many of her chosen with madness and evil. Or so the tale is told. Shifters with these beliefs have hunted evil lycanthropes for centuries: they simply lacked the resources to eliminate the threat. While these hunters are a minority among the shifters, as a race the shifters have no great love for lycanthropes. A shifter community may take risks to shelter a good lycanthrope, but no sensible person would knowingly welcome an evil werewolf into his home.

While no one knows how lycanthropy began, most know of the Silver Purge that almost brought it to an end. Around 800 YK, the power of the lycanthropic curse began to grow. The scholars of Aundair sought an answer in planar conjunctions or the influence of unknown fiends, while deep in the Eldeen Reaches shifter moonspeakers bemoaned the growing power of the unseen dark moon. Evil lycanthropes—always the most numerous of the shapeshifters—became even more vicious, and many good and unaligned lycanthropes were corrupted and drawn down into the darkness. Afflicted lycanthropes gained the ability to pass the curse to their own victims for the first time, allowing lycanthropy to spread with terrifying speed. By the early years of the ninth century YK, packs of savage werewolves were roaming across western Khorvaire at will and wererats had established warrens beneath the greatest cities of the age. Farmers lived in fear of wolves that walked like humans. What was once a superstition used to frighten children was now a horrifying reality.

The members of the Church of the Silver Flame's Order of Templars had fought shapeshifters in the past. But the heart of the Church of the Silver Flame was in the nation of Thrane, far from the traditional Eldeen haunts of the lycanthropes. As the death toll from lycanthrope attacks mounted in Aundair and Breland, the Church's Diet of Cardinals grew increasingly concerned and the templars began to take a more active role in the defense of the western lands, with the approval of the Galifaran Crown. The scholars of the Silver Flame who were allied with its extremist Puritan branch, and at the time controlled much of the Church's clerical hierarchy, began to study their enemies. A number of factors colored this research: the subjects of study were evil lycanthropes, good lycanthropes were rare and reclusive to begin with, and many had fallen prey to the growing power of the curse. As a result, the Puritans quickly assumed that all lycanthropes were inherently evil. Many priests noticed the similarity between the hybrid forms of the lycanthropes and the common form of the rakshasa, and foolishly asserted that lycanthropes were demons or would become true fiends in time. Curing lycanthropy was a difficult challenge. Natural lycanthropes could not be cured, and an afflicted lycanthrope could be cured only if it wanted to be. The first priests of the Sovereign Host and the Silver Flame who sought a cure decided that it was impossible; only in the last decades of the Purge did a band of more moderate and moral priests prove that it could be done.

In addition to this flawed research, the then-Keeper of the Flame and leader of the Church had an agenda of his own. Jolan Sol saw the lycanthropy situation as an opportunity to strengthen the influence of the Church of the Silver Flame in Aundair. In 832 YK he proclaimed that the curse of lycanthropy corrupted the soul itself. This announcement spread fear throughout Breland and Aundair and strengthened the resolve of the armies of the Flame, who ventured west with the goal of eradicating the plague from the face of Eberron. The battle was long and brutal. Today, many assume

that the lycanthropes were hunted prey, fleeing from the overwhelming force of the Church of the Silver Flame.

Little could be further from the truth. The typical werewolf is far deadlier than the average templar of the Silver Flame, and even if the soldier defeats his prey, one good bite is all it takes to transfer the curse and create a new werewolf. Evil werewolves infected entire villages, and wererats took great pleasure in infecting Silver Flame templars, imprisoning them until the curse took hold, and then sending them against their former allies. Clever lycanthropes fanned the Puritans' paranoia toward the shifters, and these mistrustful folk then foolishly massacred hundreds of shifters before someone could prove to them that shifters did not carry the curse. While some of the shifters later fought alongside the templars, many have never forgiven the Silver Flame—and, indeed, humanity itself—for these deaths.

As the tide slowly began to turn in the favor of the Church of the Silver Flame, the challenge became one of finding the lycanthropes hidden among human and shifter communities. Here again, many Puritans acted with overzealous aggression, harming the innocent in their desperate quest to eliminate the remaining shapeshifters. Ultimately, House Medani produced dragonshard foci that could detect lycanthropes and guide the templars to their true foe, and this heralded the end of the Purge. By 880 YK, the Church of the Silver Flame withdrew its military forces from the Eldeen Reaches, claiming that the threat of the curse had finally been eliminated.

Today, the balance of power within the Church of the Silver Flame has shifted toward its theological moderates, and many feel shame and regret for the actions of their predecessors. While the evil lycanthropes needed to be stopped, the paranoia and zealotry of the age led to the death of many innocents, particularly among the shifters of the Reaches. However, it did accomplish one goal: The Silver Flame did gain many supporters as a result of the Purge, and Aundair is the stronghold of the Puritan faction of the Church in the present day. The Puritans refuse to see the Silver Purge as anything but a triumph; most have been raised on tales of the horrors of the early ninth century YK. They feel no shame about the deaths of non-evil lycanthropes and the lycanthropes or afflicted victims who might have been cured; in the eyes of the Puritans, lycanthropes are monsters—and the duty of the templar is to defend the innocent from evil, not to feel pity for monsters.

While the Church of Thrane no longer follows Keeper of the Flame Jolan Sol's extremist doctrines, the Church continues to hunt shapeshifters in the present day. The present Keeper, Jaela Daran, has ordered Silver Flame templars to subdue lycanthropes whenever possible and to accept the surrender of any lycanthrope, so that the shapeshifter can be cured or exiled to the astral dominion of Lamannia. However, if a lycanthrope does not cooperate, the templars use lethal force. This is

covered under special provisions in the Code of Galifar added during the Purge; the templars of the Church are authorized to defend the people of the Five Nations against supernatural threats, and an afflicted lycanthrope who willfully maintains his condition is seen as intentionally endangering others. The Puritans of Aundair are infamous for ignoring Jaela Daran's edicts, and most Aundairian templars show no mercy when dealing with lycanthropes.

While the cardinals and the Keeper of the Flame maintain that lycanthropy is a threat, rumors have spread regarding exceptional lycanthropes who have been allowed to remain on Eberron. Some say that the Church captured a werebear who had been fighting aberrations in the Eldeen Reaches, and that the Keeper of the Flame released him into the wild after hearing his tale. Some Aundairian Puritans spread gossip that declares that Jaela Daran herself is a lycanthrope; if the tales hold truth, it could be that the Silver Flame selected her to attempt to heal the damage done in its name. Between the prejudice of the common people of the Five Nations and the need to settle things with the Church of the Silver Flame, Khorvaire remains a challenging place for lycanthropes.

845 YK

The Publication of *Deviant Celestia*: Eberron's cosmology is complex, subtle, and at times an utterly mystifying tapestry of relationships. Planar connections wax and wane in a dance so intricate that only the most rigorous academic can accurately track and predict its effect on the world—and not without complicated equations that would frustrate some archmages. Such complexity is bound to breed surprises. In 845 YK the established order of the universe was challenged by the troubled genius, Belental Heirm. A professor of planar research in the fledgling offshoot of Morgrave University established in Wroat, Heirm made a reputation for his complete and utter understanding of the thirteen planar paths and their cryptic movements. In his life's work, the *Deviant Celestia*, Heirm advanced the theory that the planes' sometimes erratic movement could only be adequately explained by the existence of numerous rogue planes lying just outside the paths of the main thirteen in a place he called the Deeper Astral.

According to Heirm's controversial theory these rogue planes interact with the main thirteen, and their courses tug and pull the fabric of the Astral Sea, explaining most of the cosmic complexity observed for centuries. He further theorized that while many rogue planes typically do not directly interact with Eberron, on rare occasions some could, and even proposed that one of these rogue planes may float close enough to Eberron to become conterminous. While the precision of Heirm's mathematical model was remarkable, other academics scoffed at the more eccentric theories proposed in the *Deviant Celestia*. Many could not accept the mind-numbing complexity

of Heirm's cosmos, while even others could not accept the source of the theory.

An utter libertine, prone to fits of rage and melancholy, many believed the Belental Heirm was insane at best, and possessed at worse. When he was implicated in a plot to assassinate King Jarot of Galifar that was perpetrated by a Cult of the Dragon Below, the fears of fiendish possession seemed confirmed. Heirm died a traitor's death at the hands of Galifaran royal agents. Since his disgrace the *Deviant Celestia* and his other works have been ignored by all but a small secretive group of students and professors in Wroat and Sharn.

873 YK

First Sighting of Mordain the Fleshweaver's Blackroot Tower in Droaam: The first confirmed sighting of Blackroot—Mordain the Fleshweaver's new tower—occurred in 873 YK. In the heat of the Silver Purge against the lycanthropes of Khorvaire, a troop of Aundairian templars of the Silver Flame pursued a few werewolves far to the south of modern Aundair. Weeks later, another patrol encountered a lone survivor, half-mad and delirious. He spoke of a tower “with blackened, leathery walls, twisted as the limb of a dragon reaching up to grasp the sun.” The Aundairian soldier could not account for his companions, and his own condition was testimony to the horrors he had seen. His upper torso had been fused to the lower body of what was posthumously confirmed to be a werewolf. His mental state quickly deteriorated and he soon died of self-inflicted wounds.

Blackroot's location in what is now Droaam has long since been confirmed, though the tower is shielded from both scrying and divination. Virtuous champions have set out to destroy the foul wizard and his works. Emissaries from the Five Nations sought his aid in the Last War, and mages have dreamed of stealing his secrets. However, few gaze on the face of Mordain and return unchanged.

Blackroot is surrounded by a twisted, warped land that the gnolls of Droaam call *KhreshtRhyyl* in the Abyssal tongue, “the Forest of Flesh.” Early in his tenure in Blackroot, Mordain released horrid aberrant creatures called skinweavers into the woods. These beasts weave webs, much as spiders do, but instead of producing silk, skinweavers craft their nests using the recycled flesh of their victims, stretching entrails, strands of muscle, and flayed skin between trunk and bough. Many of these are long abandoned, like cobwebs drifting in the wind. Nonetheless, gnawed bones and glistening strands of flesh are a common sight in the forest, and they serve as a clear warning to turn back.

The woods of *KhreshtRhyyl* are unusually dense and humid for Droaam, which is one more sign of the power Mordain holds over this region. The canopy above remains dense throughout the

year, and even at high noon only dim light makes its way to the forest floor. Anyone knowledgeable in such matters as herbalism can recognize certain plants that are usually found only underground; this includes phosphorescent fungi that create paths of light snaking through the darkness. Other plants are unknown beyond the forest. These include potent hallucinogens; bloodvines, which produce human blood in place of sap; banshee's boughs, trees that howl in agony when disturbed in any way; and many others. The ghoul's rose produces the stench of rotting flesh to attract insects, and the deceptively beautiful stormflower can release blasts of lightning on the unwary.

The creatures of the region are as diverse and dangerous as the plant life. Some are aberrations, though most are bestial creatures unique to the area as opposed to being servants of Xoriat or the Dragon Below. The skinweavers, which look like spiders with a human head attached, are one example of Mordain's ingenuity, but tales speak of skinless wolves, insane elementals, and frenzied beasts formed from the combination of two or more of the creatures found elsewhere in Droaam. Adventurers might stumble upon a troll with the voice and wings of a harpy, or a hydra with a medusa's head sprouting from each of its six necks. Rot scarabs, bloodweb spiders, and stranger insects chitter in the darkness. Vine horrors, oozes of colors never seen in the world beyond, and aberrant dryads linger just off the phosphorescent paths. The standard biological laws of nature have been shattered here. Many of these unusually predatory monsters have been fleshwarped to survive with minimal sustenance, and hunting instincts and reproductive systems have likewise been altered; some beasts reproduce at a remarkable rate needed to maintain their numbers, and others are sterile and could be exterminated by travelers. Because of this, even the most innocent creatures can pose a deadly threat. The *tryyl*, a rodent found in the horrific forest, is a little creature possessing the adorable traits of both the rabbit and the hamster. But a *tryyl* also has poisonous flesh, a venomous bite, and an uncanny reproduction rate held in check by its diet within the forest. Should a few of these creatures be brought to Breland or Aundair, they could quickly spread across the land and become an environmental menace.

And finally, at the heart of the Forest of Flesh, lies a tall tower made of what appears to be the flesh of a black dragon, a tower that will actually bleed if cut or slashed. Somewhere within lies the Fleshweaver himself, and whether he will greet any visitors as guests or more raw material for his insane experiments is truly a gamble. Mordain is reclusive and fully concentrated on his research...he leaves the Daughters of Sora Kell alone and they do likewise. However, some rumors coming out of Droaam whisper that the Fleshweaver's true goal is to find a way to reopen the portal to Xoriat, the Plane of Madness...

878 YK

House Deneith Begins Hiring Goblin Mercenaries: In 878 YK House Deneith began to provide its clients among the Five Nations with goblin mercenaries drawn from the Darguun region of Cyre. These mercenaries include members of the remaining Dhakaani clans, who would come to see the Last War as an opportunity to begin the restoration of the ancient Dhakaani civilization. Goblin mercenaries soon become a status symbol among the Galifaran nobility and they became a common sight among the personal guards of the greatest nobles and dragonmarked heirs.

890 YK

The Omaren Revolt is Put Down in Stormreach: In 890 YK the Storm Lord Castal Omaren attempted to eliminate the other Storm Lords and seize sole control of the city of Stormreach in northern Xen'drik. The *coup d'état* failed because Castal Omaren massively underestimated the Stormreach Guard's loyalty to the dwarven Storm Lord Yorrik Amanatu, who used the Guard to stop the coup. After Castal Omaren was killed by Amanatu in putting down the coup, the Omaren family was allowed to retain its lordship over the city but was forced to make major reparations to the other four Storm Lords and to operate under a set of strict penalties which remain in effect to this day. However, the new Omaren lord and his descendants were deeply subservient to the rest of the Storm Lords' council.

894 YK

The Last War Begins: King Jarot ir'Wynarn, the last ruler of Galifar, died in 894 YK. Prince Thalin of Thrane, Prince Kaius of Karrnath, and Princess Wroann of Breland unexpectedly rejected the rightful succession of Princess Mishann, the governor of Cyre and the eldest child of King Jarot, to the throne of Galifar. In contrast, Prince Wrogar of Aundair backed his sister's claim to the Galifaran Crown because of a promise that King Jarot exacted from his son on his deathbed, and the Last War began as Thrane, Karrnath and Breland mobilized their relatively small militaries to prevent Mishann from being crowned Queen of Galifar at Thronehold. When it became clear that no negotiated end to the crisis was possible, each of the contending princes declared themselves to be the king or queen of their respective nations. Thronehold was abandoned and the Kingdom of Galifar dissolved into the vicious civil strife that will last for more than a century and will be known as the Last War (see a more complete exploration of the war below).

896 YK

The Establishment of the Order of the Emerald Claw: The knightly Order of the Emerald Claw was established two years after the start of the Last War at the behest of the Lich Queen Vol (and named after her father, the green dragon known as the Emerald Claw). The order was intended to serve as the military arm of the Blood of Vol religion that had already managed to gain enormous influence in Karrnath at the expense of the faith of the Sovereign Host. The knights of the Emerald Claw often went on missions during the Last War against Karrnath's enemies in Thrane and Aundair, and became especially hated by the Thranes and the templars of the Church of the Silver Flame for their use of Karrnathi undead and other intelligent undead loyal to the Blood of Vol. For Karrnath's enemies, there came to be little separation in their minds between the Emerald Claw and the Karrnathi Crown, as the Order of the Emerald Claw's actual ties as the military arm of the Blood of Vol was unknown to any outside the highest levels of the organization and the order was made up overwhelmingly of noble-born Karrns who were converts to the Blood of Vol. King Kaius I, desperate to shore up his nation's defenses during the Last War, agreed to give prominent positions in his kingdom to the leaders of the Order of the Emerald Claw.

897 YK

Kaius I Allies Karrnath with the Blood of Vol: Kaius ir'Wynarn, King Kaius I of Karrnath, was turned into a vampire by the Lich Queen Vol in 897 YK as part of the price she required for her aid in preventing Karrnath's fall to its enemies in the opening years of the Last War. When the Last War was in full swing, Kaius I was approached by priests of the Blood of Vol. These priests promised to aid Karrnath against its enemies, provided Kaius agreed to a few "minor" considerations. With Cyre and Thrane pounding on his borders, an outbreak of plague and famine that weakened his population and a breakdown in diplomatic relations that left Karrnath temporarily without allies, Kaius agreed to whatever terms the priests had—so long as he was provided with the means to repel the invaders.

First, the priests worked with Kaius' own court wizards to perfect the process for creating elite zombie and skeleton troops to bolster Karrnath's forces. With the addition of armor and weapons, as well as a slight increase in power, these undead were stronger and more formidable than the average mindless walking corpse. Second, the priests provided an elite fighting force dedicated to both Vol and Kaius—the Order of the Emerald Claw. "The Order will help you here and in distant lands, where its agents will foster unrest and revolution in the homes of your enemies," the priests explained. Both of these gifts gave an immediate boost to Karrnath's beleaguered forces, and the

order took credit for the internal strife that soon blossomed in Cyre, Breland, and Aundair, saving Karrnath from total conquest by Aundair and Cyre in the first decade of the conflict.

When Vol, the ancient half-dragon lich at the heart of the Blood of Vol cult, appeared before Kaius I to collect her “considerations” for the aid her priests provided him, he had no choice but to submit. In addition to allowing the cult to establish temples and bases throughout Karrnath, Vol demanded that Kaius partake in the Blood of Vol’s Sacrament of Blood. Instead of the usual harmless ceremony, Vol invoked an ancient Qabalin necromantic incantation that turned Kaius into a vampire lord.

Rather than becoming a compliant undead thrall of the Lich Queen, however, Kaius I fought to keep his independence. Furious that the vampire refused to be humbled, Vol eventually forced the issue by triggering Kaius’ blood lust (something he had been struggling to control since his transformation). When the crimson haze cleared, Kaius discovered that he had attacked and killed his beloved wife and queen. The helpless monarch saw his nation increasingly fall under the Lich Queen’s sway even as Karrnath’s military was able to hold its own once more due to the assistance of the knights of the Emerald Claw and the development of the new Karrnathi undead troops.

910 YK

Kaius II Comes to Power in Karrnath: King Kaius II ascended to the throne of Karrnath after his father, Kaius I, faked his own death to go in search of a way to free his kingdom from the grip of the Blood of Vol. Kaius I had learned that the Lich Queen, Erandis d’Vol, intended to use the chaos of the Last War to turn Karrnath into her own private domain from which she could carry out her plans for genocidal revenge against the elves of Aerenal and the dragons of Argonessen.

914 YK

The Mror Holds Declare Independence: The dwarves of the Mror Holds declared their nation’s independence from Karrnath in 914 YK, which was viewed as a terrible stab in the back of the human kingdom in the Karrn capital city of Korth. Relations between the Holds and Karrnath remained frosty and tense for decades afterwards. The independence of the Holds led the Aurum, a secret dwarven organization dedicated to controlling the wealth and commerce of Khorvarien society, to begin recruiting members from across the continent.

914 YK

The Theocracy of Thrane Established: King Thalin of Thrane died in 914 YK and the Church of the Silver Flame seized control of the kingdom at the insistence of the Thrane populace, who had been driven into a nationalistic and religious furor by their late king's dream of using the Last War to spread the faith of the Silver Flame across the entire continent of Khorvaire. The Church reluctantly established a theocracy in Flamekeep, the capital city of Thrane, ruled by the Keeper of the Flame and the Diet of Cardinals.

918 YK

The Destruction of Sharn's Glass Tower: Unknown saboteurs destroyed the famed Glass Tower of Sharn, once the largest tower ever erected in Khorvaire's greatest city. While Sharn was never directly besieged during the Last War, sabotage by one of Breland's enemies was a constant threat. The most devastating event of the war for Sharn occurred on Olarune 9, 918 YK. A team of wizards working for an unknown patron dispelled the enchantments supporting the Glass Tower, one of the city's oldest floating citadels, which crashed to the ground, killing thousands of people both in the tower and below it on the city's streets.

928 YK

The Kingdom of Q'barra is Founded: Duke Ven ir'Kesslan lead settlers from his home nation of Cyre to southeastern Khorvaire to forge the new Kingdom of Q'barra in this year. For centuries, some people put their loyalty to Galifar above their ties to any single nation. Such folk were traumatized when the Last War shattered the kingdom they loved. Among these Galifaran patriots was Duke Ven ir'Kesslan of Cyre, who petitioned for and was granted rights to settle the land east of the Endworld Mountains by the king of Cyre. Here, in the jungle-covered peninsula called Q'barra by the Lhazaar pirates who first discovered it, the Cyran noble envisioned a land where those who refused to fight their brothers and sisters could start a new kingdom based on the frayed ideals of ancient Galifar.

The Cyran settlers (joined by similar groups of Galifaran patriots from all of the Five Nations) formed a huge flotilla of ships of all sizes and headed out to follow the coast to any hospitable bay in the Q'barran jungle. Drawn from all of the Five Nations, the members of ir'Kesslan's expedition included scholars, lesser nobles, clergy, and common folk who opposed the war and saw hope in the duke's plan. After a long and arduous sea journey, made even more treacherous due to piracy and war, only four out of every six vessels that sailed from Cyre reached Adder Bay, where the exiles

established the town that would become Adderport and eventually, their capital city of Newthrone. Impressed by the beauty of the land and trusting the mountains and seas to shield them from the ravages of war, ir’Kesslan, who became King Ven of Q’barra, vowed his new nation would remain true to the ideals that had held the Kingdom of Galifar together for almost a thousand years.

Over time, the region attracted new settlers—idealists who shared ir’Kesslan’s beliefs and refugees who sought a safe haven from the ferocity of the war. Some of these later arrivals included outlaws, war criminals, defeated troops, and, most recently, displaced Cyrans fleeing the destruction of their kingdom on the Day of Mourning. Not all these disparate groups get along. Added to these tensions, the settlers must deal with the dangers that lurk in the jungle itself. King Ven had seen no signs of humans—indeed, the Lhazaar pirates considered the peninsula cursed—and assumed Q’barra was uninhabited. He was mistaken.

More than ten thousand years ago, the Dhakaani Empire drove the lizardfolk of the Talenta Plains across the Endworld Mountains and into the swamps and jungles of Q’barra. The lizardfolk dwelt mainly in northern Q’barra, along the Torva River and in the Basura Swamp. As the settlers spread throughout the Adder Valley and into the jungle beyond, they began unwittingly despoiling the lizardfolk’s holy sites. The Poison Dusk tribe of pygmy lizardfolk took to ambushing settlers, and in 970 YK the Cold Sun tribes of common lizardfolk launched an assault on the human invaders. The settlers, taken by surprise, suffered serious casualties in the first months of the conflict. Ultimately the magical skills and superior weapons of the humans turned the tide, and the lizardfolk retreated to the northern swamps.

Though truces have been struck and full-scale war avoided, the settlers of Q’barra must still contend with hostile lizardfolk, Valenar warbands, Lhazaar pirate raiders, and kobold marauders from the Endworld Mountains. Recent discoveries of large deposits of Eberron dragonshards have brought House Tharashk and a swarm of prospectors to the region. Tensions among the various groups of settlers continue to run high, especially with the arrival of large numbers of Cyran refugees. Aside from the lizardfolk and kobolds, Q’barra is home to all manner of thunder lizards, dire and horrid reptiles, and giant and venomous vermin. Finally, a dark and ancient force bides its time in the deep jungle, waiting for its moment to strike, for Q’barra is the home of Haka’torvhak—one of the great citadels of the fiends from the Age of Demons and the site of a massive battle between the fiends and the dragons. In the end, the most powerful fiends were bound in the fires deep beneath the city and draconic guardians were left to watch over the place for eternity. The current guardian, the half-fiend black dragon Rhashaak, has been corrupted by the fiendish emanations of his post but

remains bound to his duty, though he is determined to use the Poison Dusk pygmy lizardfolk who worship him as a god to ascend to true divinity.

946 YK

The Fire Storm Strikes Stormreach: In this year, the city of Stormreach in Xen'drik came under attack by the Battalion of the Basalt Towers, a powerful alliance of fire giants. In addition to physical force, the giants employed an artifact that called down arcane meteor swarms upon the city; some of the craters from this conflict can still be seen today. In a curious turn of events, the giants of Rushemé joined with the Stormreach Guard and the forces of the dragonmarked houses in the city to turn back this assault, not out of a desire to protect Stormreach's inhabitants but to keep the city out of the Battalion's hands. The power of the Basalt Towers was broken, but some of the giants survived and recent reports (998 YK) from the interior of Xen'drik suggest that they have rebuilt their forces.

956 YK

Valaes Tairn Mercenaries Establish the Kingdom of Valenar: In the midst of the Last War in 956 YK, elven Valaes Tairn mercenaries from Aerenal annexed southern Cyre, the territory of the nation they had been serving in the great conflict, and declared the independence of the new elf kingdom of Valenar.

Ten thousand years ago, the elves of Aerenal had established a settlement on the southern shore of Khorvaire. Initially, the hobgoblin emperor of Dhakaan was pleased to have a center for trade with the elves, but over the course of the next century this relationship soured and turned to war. The elves could not match the numbers of the Dhakaani goblins and were driven back to Aerenal (see above). War between the empires continued sporadically over the next few centuries. Ultimately, both hobgoblin and elf agreed to respect their then-current borders—the elves would hold their island-continent, and the hobgoblins would continue to dominate the mainland of Khorvaire. Millennia passed, and the hobgoblins' Empire of Dhakaan crumbled to dust after the Daelkyr War. By the time of King Jarot of Galifar, the land once contested by hobgoblins and elves was part of the realm of Cyre. Much of the region was sparsely populated, with the occasional human village, migrating halfling tribe, and a handful of hobgoblin clans hiding in the shadows. When the Last War began, Cyre came under attack from all sides and quickly sought allies.

While the Undying Court of Aerenal had no interest in returning to Khorvaire, the Cyrans drew the interest of the Valaes Tairn. These militant elves had long sought an opportunity to test their blades in epic battle, and they were only too willing to enter the fray of the Last War. For decades the

elves fought on the side of Cyre, battling Talentan warbands, hobgoblin mercenaries, and the forces of Breland and Karrnath. They fought for the love of battle and gold, not loyalty to Cyre. Then, in 956 YK, the elves took action that surprised the Cyrans and the other Five Nations. War Leader Shaeras Vadallia proclaimed that his people had ties to the land from a time before human feet touched the soil of Khorvaire, and that his soldiers had restored those ties with spilled blood. Vadallia declared himself High King of the new elven nation of Valenar, and his warriors have been fortifying their position and slowly expanding their borders ever since, as well as forging an alliance with House Lyrandar.

The Valenar elves have no interest in peace, but they participated in the diplomatic talks at Thronehold that ended the Last War to gauge the measure of their enemies and to gain acceptance in the human courts. Today, Valenar warbands continue to clash with Karrnathi forces, and raids into the Talenta Plains and Q'barra occur on a regular basis. Now that the Last War has come to an end, it remains to be seen whether the Treaty of Thronehold can end this elven aggression.

958 YK

The Eldeen Reaches Gain Independence from Aundair: The Eldeen Reaches declared themselves an independent nation under the protection of the druidic order known as the Wardens of the Wood and the guidance of the Great Druid Oalian in 958 YK as a result of the Last War. The Eldeen Reaches covered the northwestern region of Khorvaire to the Shadowcrag Mountains. The eastern Reaches featured fertile plains and rolling hills, but dense forests covered the majority of the nation. These forests housed some of the most primeval trees on the continent, ancient growths that had survived the rise and fall of empires and witnessed the arrival of humans on the shores of Khorvaire. The forces of arcane and primal magic permeated these woods, and strange beasts and mischievous fey roamed the land. Many dangers also lurked in the deep woods, and the humanoids who made their homes in these forests did not always take kindly to visitors.

In the Age of Monsters, when the goblins forged their empire across Khorvaire, the Eldeen Reaches were the domain of orc clans who sought to live in harmony with the wilderness. The orcs were devastated and decimated in the war against the daelkyr. As a result of that terrible conflict, the forest was seeded with aberrations and horrid creatures formed by the sinister fleshshapers from Xoriat.

As the human nations that would one day join together as the Kingdom of Galifar took shape, the Eldeen Reaches were largely left alone thanks to tales of the “haunted forest” west of the Wynarn River, filled with monsters and demons. Still, over the course of centuries, humans and members of

the other common races slowly drifted into the Reaches. Some came in search of land and opportunity. Hunters and warriors devoted to the Church of the Silver Flame came to battle evil magical beasts, eventually driving the more dangerous creatures like the lycanthropes into the deep woods. Others were drawn to the woods, called by a primal force they could not name. Deep in the ancient forest, those who heard the call met with the Great Druid Oalian, a sentient greatpine who had watched over the woods for more than four thousand years. He taught those who heard his call the ways of the wild, how to access the primal power of the Dragon Between and the duties of the ancient Gatekeepers. His teachings inspired all the druid sects that eventually grew up in the Reaches.

Centuries passed. The druidic society of the Reaches grew and spread throughout the forest, which came to be known as the Towering Wood. The younger races brought their own customs and perspectives to the Reaches, of course, and Oalian's teachings had already begun to diverge from those of the original orcish Gatekeepers. In time, the druids fragmented into a dozen sects. Meanwhile, the nation of Aundair claimed the fertile plains along the eastern edge of the woods, and Aundairian farmers and settlers spread across the river. Despite minor conflicts between shifter and human settler, human settler and druid, and even among the druids themselves, the region prospered.

The Last War proved to be the undoing of the old order. As the conflict intensified, Aundair pulled its forces back to protect its heartland and eastern borders from Karrnath and Thrane, leaving the Eldeen Reaches to fend for themselves. Bandit lords sponsored by Karrnath and the Lhazaar Principalities harried the farms west of the Wynarn River, using the forest as a base and staging ground. In the south, Brelish troops crossed the Silver Lake to occupy the towns of Sylbaran, Greenblade, and Erlaskar. As things went from bad to worse, an army of druids and rangers emerged from the forest. In 956 YK, the Wardens of the Wood rallied the farmers and peasants of the Reaches, crushing the bandit army before it knew what was happening. With order restored in the north, the Wardens turned their attention to the south. In 959 YK, they finally succeeded in driving the Brelish forces back across the lake.

Angry at the Aundairian Crown for abandoning them, the people of the Reaches swore allegiance to the Great Druid, breaking all political ties with the lords of Aundair and resisting several Aundairian attempts to regain control of the forest lands. Since 958 YK, the people of the Eldeen Reaches—now proudly called Reachers—have considered themselves to be part of an independent nation, and they were finally recognized as such with the signing of the Treaty of Thronehold that ended the Last War. It remains to be seen whether Aundair will try to reclaim its old western territories now that the Last War has ended.

961 YK

King Boranel Ascends the Throne of Breland: Boranel ir'Wynarn became the king of Breland in 961 YK. A direct descendant of the independent Kingdom of Breland's first leader, Queen Wroann, the daughter of King Jarot, the last ruler of Galifar, Boranel carried on the high-minded traditions of both Galifar and the Brelish Crown. While ruled as a monarchy, Breland also had a partially-elected parliament that worked alongside the king and the royal court to govern the country, a tradition that had been formally begun by Queen Wroann and expanded by Boranel early in his reign. Under the unwritten Brelish constitution that developed soon after the start of the Last War, the Brelish Parliament made the laws in Breland and the Crown enforced them. The Crown also conducted all business related to foreign affairs and the security of the realm, sometimes informing Parliament, more often not.

The people of Breland loved their king, his vassal lords respected and even revered him, and Parliament saw him as fair and just. It is said that the people of Breland will follow King Boranel anywhere, and this has been demonstrated many times in the course of his thirty-seven-year reign. As Boranel has gotten older, concerns revolving around the succession have begun to manifest. One plan, mostly discussed quietly and in secret among certain noble members of the Parliament, suggested that the nation abandon the monarchy after Boranel's death and turn over more power and authority to Parliament. Another plan hopes that one of Boranel's children will fill the vacuum and become a leader in the same vein as his or her father. So far, none of the heirs has demonstrated more than a passing ability at ruling the nation.

To further spread the tenets of democracy, Breland regularly holds town meetings throughout the realm. At these meetings, the common folk are recognized and allowed to state their opinions for the Crown and Parliament to hear.

The king ruled from the family's ancestral home in Breland's capital city of Wroat, the halls of the mighty Brokenblade Castle. Named after the events surrounding the legendary King Galifar I's conquest of the nation, when (as the story goes) his sword blade shattered in the battle but he managed to win the day anyway, Brokenblade Castle rises alongside the Howling River, near where it empties into and merges with the Dagger River. Parliament Hall, the meeting place and offices of the elected legislators of Breland, is located but a short walk from the battlements of Brokenblade Castle. Boranel also maintained working residences in Sharn and Starilaskur, and kept Castle Arakhain, in the western part of the country, as a retreat.

The Brelish Parliament consisted of both elected legislators and hereditary lords. The citizens of Breland elected their commoner legislators every two years. These elected lawmakers, chosen by

popular vote (one from each village or town, two from each city, and three each from the metropolises of Sharn and Wroat), were sent to the capital to participate in all parliamentary proceedings. The noble legislators gained their seats in Parliament based on the status of their families; each recognized Brelish noble family held one seat in Parliament. Each year, the recognized head of the family appointed a relative to parliamentary duty. In many cases, the yearly appointment was symbolic, and each family has one representative who serves year in and year out. Twenty-seven noble families serve the Crown of Breland as of 998 YK.

962 YK

Zilargo Allies With Breland: Zilargo, the nation of gnomes, was long neutral in the Last War due to its status as an autonomous principality of the Kingdom of Galifar, but formally aligned itself with Breland during the Last War in 962 YK. The gnomes' powerful intelligence network, skilled magewrights and unique arcane elemental-binding techniques were key strategic assets for the Brelish in the war's last years.

The gnomes of Khorvaire had lived in the area known as Zilargo for thousands of years. Situated between the Howling Peaks and the Seawall Mountains, the gnomes thrived despite incursions by and conflicts with goblins, kobolds, and humans. They had always managed to maintain their independence, winning battles with words that they could never win with swords. After King Galifar I established his kingdom, he eventually set his sights on Zilargo. The gnomes met his military forces in the valley north of Dragonroost and immediately surrendered. During the negotiations, the gnomes became an independent province within the kingdom. King Galifar left in victory, and the gnomes secured a safe place in the new human empire—all without spilling a drop of blood. Relying on their innate wisdom and cunning, along with elemental-bound items and illusions, the gnomes of Khorvaire have always been surprisingly dangerous opponents.

During the Last War, Zilargo spent most of the conflict as a neutral observer before aligning with Breland in 962 YK. From that point on, the gnomes provided intelligence and elemental-bound weapons and vehicles to Breland while avoiding most combat. As a result, Zilargo emerged from the Last War stronger than ever, and Breland owes the gnomes a great debt for the services they rendered—and the gnomes always collect on their debts.

965 YK

The Birth of the Warforged: House Cannith finally perfected the creation of modern-era warforged in 965 YK, giving birth to a new generation of living constructs designed to fight the Last

War using lore recovered from quori ruins in Xen'drik decades before. Built as mindless machines to fight in the Last War, the warforged had developed sentience as a side effect of the arcane experiments that sought to make them the ultimate weapons of destruction. With each successive model that emerged from the creation forges of House Cannith, the warforged evolved until they became a new kind of intelligent beings—living, free-willed constructs. Warforged are renowned for their combat prowess, their size, and their single-minded focus. They make steadfast allies and fearsome enemies. Earlier warforged models had been true constructs, such as the warforged titan used for decades before the creation of the first true living warforged thirty-three years ago.

Before the death of King Jarot and the start of the Last War, the master crafters of House Cannith had turned their creation forges to the task of churning out new constructs for a new age. Constructs designed for labor and industry soon led to experiments with models developed for exploration and defense. When King Jarot saw the possibilities inherent in the work of House Cannith, he began to outline his plan to protect Galifar from the threats he imagined were gathering all around the kingdom. For an unknown reason, King Jarot was growing more and more paranoid about the dangers he believed were posed to Galifar by the monster hordes of the western reaches, the mysterious elves of Aerenal, the Seren barbarians of Argonnessen, and others from beyond his realm. At the king's urging, House Cannith began to experiment with constructs designed for war.

Merrix d'Cannith, one of the lords of the house, developed the first version of the warforged. It was a remarkable achievement, but Merrix believed he could create an even better soldier. When King Jarot died and his scions divided the kingdom, each faction had a complement of warforged fighters devoted to its cause. By the second decade of the conflict, Merrix had introduced near-sentience into his created warriors. It was Merrix's son, Aarren d'Cannith, who made the breakthrough that resulted in the warforged becoming truly living, self-aware constructs. Aarren had studied documents recovered from an expedition to the continent of Xen'drik for House Cannith undertaken by his ancestor Kedran d'Cannith decades before. Kedran had discovered the secrets of creating true warforged among the quori ruins left behind from the Quori-Giant War of over forty millennia before. Aarren d'Cannith put this knowledge to use and the first warforged that were truly alive and sentient emerged from the Cannith creation forges thirty-three years ago.

House Cannith sold warforged fighters throughout the last thirty years of the war to anyone who could afford them. Breland, Thrane, and Cyre boasted the largest armies of warforged on the continent, and most of the various competing factions had at least a token force of warforged fighting for them. By the final years of the war, the warforged had become thoroughly associated with the ever-escalating conflict.

The warforged were made to fight in the Last War, and they continue to fulfill their military purpose with distinction. They fight fiercely and usually without remorse, displaying adaptability impossible for mindless arcane constructs. After the war ended, the warforged sought to adapt to life in this era of relative peace. Some settled easily into new roles as artisans or laborers, while others wandered as adventurers or even continued fighting the Last War despite the return of peace. Warforged appear as massive humanoids molded from a composite of materials—obsidian, iron, stone, darkwood, silver, and organic material—though they move with a surprising grace and flexibility. Flexible plates connected by fibrous bundles make up the body of a warforged, topped by a mostly featureless head. Warforged have no physical distinction of gender; all of them have a basically muscular, sexless body shape. In personality, some warforged seem more masculine or feminine, but different people might judge the same warforged in different ways. The warforged themselves seem unconcerned with matters of gender. They do not age naturally, though their bodies do decay slowly even as their minds improve through learning and experience. Unique among constructs, warforged have learned to modify their bodies through magic and training. Many warforged are adorned with heavier metal plates than those their creator originally endowed them with. This customized armor, built-in weaponry, and other enhancements to their physical form help to differentiate one warforged from another.

As the warforged strive to find a place in society for themselves after the Last War, they simultaneously struggle to find ways to relate to the races that created them. In general, the humanoid races of Khorvaire regard the warforged as an unpleasant reminder of the brutality of the Last War and avoid dealing with them when possible. In Thrane and Karrnath, the warforged are still seen as the property of the military forces that paid to have them built, and most warforged in those nations serve as slave labor, often used to repair buildings and roads damaged or destroyed in the war. Throughout the rest of Khorvaire, they have freedom but sometimes find themselves the victims of discrimination, hard-pressed to find work or any kind of acceptance. Most warforged, not being particularly emotional creatures, accept their struggles and servitude with equanimity, but others seethe with resentment against all other races as well as those warforged whose only desire is to please their “masters.”

Warforged originated in Cyre at House Cannith’s primary forgehold of Whitehearth in the city of Eston before its destruction during the Day of Mourning and have no homeland of their own. Most of them have dispersed across Khorvaire, laboring as indentured servants in the cities of Korth, Atur, and Flamekeep, or struggling to find work and acceptance in Sharn or Korranberg. A few

congregate in the Mournland, attempting to build a new warforged society free from the prejudice and mistrust of the older races.

Just as most warforged are not inclined to align themselves with any particular moral or ethical philosophy, few show much interest in religion. Some warforged have found a kind of answer to the questions of their existence by taking up the cause of one religion or another, but these remain a small (if rather vocal) minority among their kind. A larger number gravitate to a messianic figure called the Lord of Blades. This powerful leader gathered a cult-like following of disaffected warforged by preaching a return to the Mournland and rebellion against the “fleshborn” races.

Warforged speak Common, since they were designed to communicate with their (mostly human) creators and owners. Warforged do not name themselves and only recently have begun to understand the need of other races to have names for everything. Many accept whatever names others see fit to give them, and warforged traveling with humans often are referred to by nicknames. Some warforged, however, have come to see having a name as a defining moment of their new existence, and thus search long and hard for the perfect name to attach to themselves.

969 YK

The Lhesh Haruuc Establishes the Kingdom of Darguun: The hobgoblin warleader Lhesh Haruuc lead a hobgoblin rebellion against the humans of Cyre, and the nation of Darguun was born in 969 YK. In ages past, hobgoblins and the other goblin races had controlled Khorvaire. Over the course of thousands of years, a host of goblin nations rose and fell. The greatest civilization of this age, the hobgoblin-ruled Empire of Dhakaan, bred goblins and bugbears as slaves and warriors. The ancient empire has returned in the present day, in a weaker, less influential form, in the new nation of Darguun.

Darguun, carved from what was once the southwestern borderlands of the Kingdom of Cyre, contained a variety of environs. Nestled to the east of the Seawall Mountains, Darguun was composed of fertile plains to the north, a dense tropical forest to the east, and a vast moor to the south. The mighty Ghaal River emptied into the Kraken Bay and literally divided the nation in half, separating the battlefields of the Last War from the unexplored reaches of the southern shore.

For thousands of years the barbaric goblin clans lurked in the shadows, hiding deep within the Seawall Mountains and venturing out only to engage in an occasional raid on Brelish or Cyran settlements. It was human greed that finally brought them back into the light. Lord Cail d’Deneith led an expedition into the Seawall Mountains one hundred twenty years ago (in 878 YK) to seek goblin recruits for his house’s mercenary armies. He discovered more than a dozen tribes and clans scattered

throughout the mountains. With clever words and a lot of gold, Cail won the trust of a few of the hobgoblin chieftains. A host of hobgoblin warriors and their goblin slaves returned to Breland with Cail. These savage hobgoblins were seen as a novelty; it became prestigious for wealthy nobles to employ hobgoblin guards. Then the Last War began.

Both Breland and Cyre soon turned to House Deneith to supplement their armies, and Deneith in turn brought ever-increasing numbers of goblins out of the mountains. House Deneith's profits soared, but ultimately this reliance on goblin soldiers had disastrous results. After seventy years of war, tens of thousands of well-armed goblins, bugbears and hobgoblins were spread across the Cyre-Breland border. With the rise to prominence of the ambitious young hobgoblin chieftain named Haruuc, all the conditions for the creation of the nation of Darguun were in place.

A cunning tactician and charismatic leader, Haruuc realized that the human and demi-human forces in the region were no match for the combined power of the goblins. He arranged secret meetings with other chieftains, and through promises, threats, and appeals to racial loyalty he won most of the tribes to his cause. In 969 YK, the hobgoblins turned on the people they were supposed to be defending. Hundreds of humans were slain, while others fled into neighboring lands or were captured as slaves. The goblins saw such enslavement as poetic vengeance for humanity's long mistreatment of the goblin races since their arrival on Khorvaire three millennia before. Haruuc laid claim to the area, naming it Darguun and establishing the title of the *Lhesh Haruuc Shaarat'kor*—the High Warlord Haruuc of the Scarlet Blade in the Goblin tongue—for himself. Of course, as goblin lorekeepers and dirge singers pointed out to the new ruler, the Dhakaani title of Lhesh had been one that was only intended for temporary use during the days of the empire. But Haruuc aimed to make it permanent in his new nation even as he intended to try and restore a semblance of civilization to his long-neglected people.

Breland and Cyre were completely unprepared for this treachery, and neither kingdom could spare enough forces to reclaim the land, especially after Breland lost the disastrous Battle of Marguul Pass to the Darguul forces. After this disaster, the king of Breland quickly made a deal with Haruuc, offering recognition for Darguun's independence in exchange for continued protection along the eastern front between Breland and Thrane, but warfare between the goblins and Cyre continued right up until the Day of Mourning (see below). Eager to put an end to the war, Karrnath, Aundair, and Breland formally acknowledged the sovereignty of the Kingdom of Darguun with the Treaty of Thronehold in 996 YK. With clearly delineated borders defining the new nation, the Lhesh Haruuc swore to restrain his followers from future violence against the three human kingdoms. Thrane,

however, has demonstrated disfavor with the Darguul aspect of the peace accords, and the templars of the Church of the Silver Flame may yet seek to avenge those humans killed in the original uprising.

Darguun consisted of three regions: the Seawall Mountains, the northern plains, and the southern wilderness. Most of the nation's population lived in the mountains and along the two major rivers, the Ghaal and the Torlaac. The nation is home to three major goblin tribes and the various clans associated with them. These tribes are the Ghaal'dar clans of the lowlands, the Heirs of Dhakaan clans who ruled the mountain depths, and the highland clans of the Marguul.

In the Seawall Mountains, most goblin tribes and clans continue to live as they have for the last few centuries. They spend most of their time fighting each other, following the law of the strong over the weak. One powerful tribe made up of the Dhakaani clans hiding deep within the mountains claimed to be the direct descendants of the rulers of the old empire, and it plotted a return to goblin glory. The Empire of Dhakaan was built on a foundation of martial skill. For thousands of years it dominated Khorvaire, until the coming of the daelkyr. For all of their skill, the Dhakaani goblins could not stand against the might and madness of the Lords of Xoriat. By the time the Gatekeeper druids bound the daelkyr and their servants in the depths of Khyber, the goblin empire was a shadow of its former glory. Over the course of millennia it collapsed into barbarism and savagery, and by the time humans arrived on Khorvaire with the pirate-queen Lhazaar, all that was left of the empire was ruins. Or so it seemed. As the empire crumbled, a few of the greatest generals and leaders took their clans into hiding, determined to preserve the knowledge of the Dhakaani through the darkness they saw coming.

With the rise of Darguun, the clans have emerged once more. If they united behind a single ruler, the Dhakaani clans could easily unseat the Lhesh Haruuc, and if they conquered Darguun, the Dhakaani could pose a threat to the other nations of Khorvaire. There is one huge obstacle—none of the clans agree who should be emperor. Who is the true heir of Dhakaan? This issue has led to endless conflicts between the modern-day Dhakaani clans that so far have kept them from posing a threat to the wider world. One of the major differences between the Dhakaani and the other goblins of Khorvaire, just as it was for the goblins of the original Dhakaani Empire, is the degree of interracial cooperation within a clan. Among the Ghaal'dar and the Marguul, the strong rule the weak. Leadership is founded on fear, and the weaker goblin races hate the stronger tyrants. Among the Heirs of Dhakaan clans, this is not the case. Each goblin species has a role to serve in society, and each embraces this role. The hobgoblins rule not through force of arms but because the goblins and bugbears respect their ability to maintain structure and discipline. The strength of the bugbears is turned against the enemies of the clan.

Even more interesting, two Dhakaani clans are formed entirely of goblins. Both are renowned for their impressive skills. The *taarka'khes* (“silent wolves”) are a corps of goblin scouts trained to provide intelligence in the field during military operations; *taarka'khes* scouts take rogue and ranger levels. The *shaarat'khes* (“silent blades”) are an elite order of spies and assassins. The *shaarat'khes* have long practiced a martial art designed to transform an unarmed goblin into a living weapon. As a result, *shaarat'khes* goblins contain among their numbers both rogues and monks. By ancient tradition, the Silent Clans do not take sides in any conflict. Instead, they act as mercenaries, providing their services to all sides and fighting their brothers when they face one another on the battlefield. This reputation for complete impartiality and reliability has kept the *khes* clans alive for thousands of years. The *khes* clans will execute any goblin in the clan that betrays the secrets of a client. Generally speaking, one must be born into a *khes* clan to learn its ways, but on rare occasions skilled goblins from other clans have gained admission to one of the Silent Clans.

Travel through the mountains of Darguun is difficult; there are few established paths, and the mountain goblins are generally hostile to members of the common races. Travelers on authorized business can obtain a banner of safe passage from tribal leaders, but most tribes do not recognize the authority of other tribes. A banner from the Lhesh Haruuc, whose stronghold is the capital city of Rhukaan Draal, provides some protection, but even it does not guarantee complete safety when traveling through the territory of the highland or Dhakaani clans. Many of the tribes keep slaves drawn from the common races, including humans and gnomes. These slaves were captives taken during the Last War, and the chieftains continue to look for new sources to refill their slave pens.

The northern plains of Darguun were once part of Cyre. Here, the goblins and hobgoblins have taken possession of cities and villages once occupied by the common races of lost Galifar. Many of the structures were devastated during the Last War and have been patched together according to goblin sensibilities. The net effect creates a society that appears ramshackle and shabby. The Lhesh Haruuc commands the lowland tribes, using kobold slaves to farm the land and harvest the food to feed his subjects. Tribal conflicts are still common, but travelers who hold a banner of safe passage from the Lhesh Haruuc are usually protected from aggression.

The southern reaches of Darguun, including the Torlaac Moor and the Khraal rain forest, are wilder and less settled than the northern portion of the nation. Most of the goblin settlements in this region can be found along the Torlaac River, with few outposts deeper in the wilderness.

Darguun is a volatile nation. The Ghaal'dar tribe makes up the majority of the population, and most of the clans in this tribe yield to the authority of the Lhesh Haruuc. They follow because they respect Haruuc's leadership and military power. Should either of those factors change, Darguun

could quickly collapse into chaos and anarchy. As it is, Haruuc has little control over the mountain tribes. The Marguul and Dhakaani clans usually ignore the high warlord's royal edicts, and even the Ghaal'dar clans often fight one another despite Haruuc's orders to work together. The habits created by millennia of barbarism are not so easily laid down in only one generation.

For his part, the Lhesh Haruuc wants to reshape goblin society to match the model of ancient Galifar. Haruuc wants to forge a stable realm for his descendants, but he fears that with his death the kingdom will fall victim to infighting and ambitious clan lords. He has established a great court at Rhukaan Draal, and representatives of all the clans and tribes can be found there. But despite Haruuc's best efforts to re-introduce the trappings of civilization, military might remains the only force the goblins respect, and he frequently has to use this power to quell disputes and drive through his edicts. Each of the three goblin tribes is multiracial and consists of goblins, hobgoblins, and bugbears. It is not too unusual to find members of other races among the tribes. Some of these have embraced the goblin traditions and fought for a place of honor within the clans. Others are slaves, working for the benefit and amusement of their goblin masters.

The Rhukaan Taash, which means "Razor Crown" in Goblin, is the largest and most powerful of the Ghaal'dar clans, and rules over the lowlands. While the clan possesses many skilled warriors, its greatest strength is its vast numbers. Individually, Rhukaan Taash warriors are no match for the soldiers of the Dhakaani clans, but collectively they make up a force that cannot easily be threatened. This clan has been loyal to the Lhesh Haruuc since the hobgoblin led the goblin revolt twenty-nine years ago, but not every member of the clan is completely content. While Haruuc has sought to consolidate his power and earn legitimacy for Darguun, many of the lesser chieftains feel that the goblins should continue to expand the nation. Some have even urged preemptive attacks on Breland and Zilargo, arguing that the humans and gnomes will one day come for them if the Rhukaan do not strike first. Such views shall undoubtedly cause trouble in the future, especially after Haruuc's reign ends, whether he falls from power or eventually dies of old age. For now, it is just another thing for the high warlord to contend with. The Lhesh Haruuc is still firmly in control but getting older. As his strength fades and his battle prowess loses potency, his remarkable skill with words becomes increasingly instrumental in maintaining control over the tribes. In recent years, he has quietly begun looking for talented youngsters from whom he could appoint an heir, approaching the problem from the point of view of a brilliant general needing an equally skilled successor rather than as a king trying to preserve a bloodline.

Most hobgoblin mercenaries employed outside Darguun belong to the Rhukaan Taash or one of the other Ghaal'dar clans. A distinctive ring of scars encircles the head of each Rhukaan Taash

warrior, just above the eyes. This identifying mark is the result of painful initiation rituals each warrior goes through to prove his worth and readiness for adulthood.

The Kech Shaarat or Bladebearers clan, named for a powerful artifact in their possession, is the largest of the Dhakaani clans. For thousands of years the Dhakaani clans have isolated themselves from the rest of the world, but they see the rise of Darguun as the first sign of a restored Dhakaani Empire. Now the clans have emerged from their fortress caverns and are partaking in a brutal struggle to determine the rightful heir to the imperial throne. Since these battles are confined to the depths of the Seawall Mountains and do not involve outsiders, the Lhesh Haruuc has paid little attention to the conflict. But if one leader can win the loyalty of all the Dhakaani clans, he could challenge Haruuc for control of the Darguun nation. Chieftain Ruus Dhakaan seeks to prove his right to rule through conquest. Kech Shaarat has already absorbed two smaller clans, and it seems only a matter of time until Ruus has all of the Dhakaani forces under his control. He outwardly bows to the Lhesh Haruuc's authority, but in his mountain lair considers his own word to be more powerful than that of the lowland pretender. His soldiers rarely leave the Seawall Mountains; they can be identified by sword-shaped brands on one or both forearms.

The Kech Volaar or Wordbearers clan has gone to great lengths to preserve the lore of the Dhakaani Empire. Though Kech Volaar is one of the smallest Dhakaani clans, its armorers and stonemasons are unmatched in all of Darguun. This great skill has allowed their fortifications to hold against the Kech Shaarat and other aggressive clans. Led by Tuura Dhakaan, the strongest dirge singer the clans have seen in over a thousand years, the Wordbearers keep the memory of the ancient goblin empire alive. Instead of seeking conquest through military victory, Tuura intends to prove her right to rule like Jhazaar Dhakaan by gathering the lost artifacts of the ancient goblin empire—both to serve as a symbol and to provide her with enough magical power to overcome her foes. Kurac Thaar, the clan's warlord, is as fanatically devoted to Tuura and her vision of the restored empire as the rest of the Kech Volaar.

Kech Volaar goblins often venture beyond Darguun in search of Dhakaani ruins, but they do not work as mercenaries. They rarely interact with other races except in the pursuit of a mission. Symbols depicting important events are often tattooed on members of the clan; those who read Goblin can learn much about an individual through the study of these markings.

The Marguul tribe consists of an alliance of bugbear-led clans that live in the highlands of the Seawall Mountains. For the most part, the Marguul clans pay homage to the court of Rhukaan Draal, benefiting from Darguun's ties to the outside world. However, one Marguul clan, the Kalkor, refused to bow to the hobgoblin Haruuc. Led by the bugbear chieftain Mograath, Kalkor is not the largest

Marguul clan, but its members are easily the most vicious. Dedicated followers of the Mockery, Mograath and his warriors represent a threat to anyone who travels through the Seawall Mountains—especially those carrying a banner of safe passage from the Lhesh Haruuc. Gruesome facial scars displayed in a fang pattern distinguish members of the Kalkor clan.

972 YK

The Shadow Schism and the Birth of House Thuranni: The elven dragonmarked House Thuranni split off from House Phiarlan in 972 YK even as they both shared the Mark of Shadow, at last creating the thirteen dragonmarked houses that had long been prophesized would come into existence. Before the start of the Last War, House Phiarlan had a comfortable working relationship with House Wynarn, the royal dynasty that ruled the Kingdom of Galifar. The house helped the royals to maintain order in the kingdom, uncover treasonous conspiracies and guard against any threat from outside of Khorvaire. Phiarlan assassins removed insurgent leaders and other internal threats. On more than one occasion, House Phiarlan helped to enforce the strange laws of Khorvarien inheritance, such as the ones which prevented the eldest child of Breland's king from ever succeeding to Breland's throne.

There were occasions, even during the days of a united Galifar, when the rulers of the Five Nations plotted against each other and even against their monarch and House Phiarlan was often involved in those schemes. Nascent organizations that would eventually grow into Breland's intelligence service, the King's Citadel, Aundair's Royal Eyes and their like among the other kingdoms relied heavily on intelligence purchased from House Phiarlan.

With the death of King Jarot, the best efforts of House Phiarlan were no longer able to ensure a peaceful transfer of power and Khorvaire was plunged into a century of warfare. Each of the Five Nations built up its own corps of covert agents and set them to work against the spies of enemy nations, while continuing to rely heavily on Phiarlan intelligence as the House of Shadows worked for all sides.

A house that was more strongly unified to begin with might have been able to remain united even under such circumstances, but House Phiarlan had always been fractious. The Mark of Shadow appeared not in one elven family line but in several and relations among the Phiarlan lines had been strained in the past. Five elven lineages—the Tialaen, Shol, Elorrenthi, Thuranni and Paelion—were the most prominent and influential families in House Phiarlan before the schism. Each line had its particular strengths within the broad field of the house's activities, and preferred clients among the factions and organizations of the Five Nations. Rivalry among those six families, not to mention the

numerous smaller families within the house's hierarchy, often grew fierce. Ultimately, the strains of the Last War proved to be greater than the ties that bound the Phiarlan families together.

The final blow came in 972 YK. The Order of the Emerald Claw—at the time, still an extension of Karnath's government—was a favored client of the Thuranni family, as well as the most important espionage-related organization in Karnath's government. Knight Superior Kadrath ir'Vardikk, a high-ranking Emerald Claw knight, came to Lord Elar Thuranni d'Phiarlan with information that pointed to a Brelish plot to assassinate both Karnath's regent Moranna and its young king, Kaius III. The plot relied heavily on the talents of the Paelion line, who represented the most fearsome assassins of House Phiarlan. Sir Kadrath demanded that the Thuranni line eliminate the Paelions before the assassins could carry out their mission.

At first, Lord Elar was hesitant to strike against others in his own house. He first tried to verify the information Sir Kadrath had brought him. What the Thuranni agents uncovered, however, was a far greater threat than a simple assassination plot against Karnath. Lord Tolar Paelion d'Phiarlan, it seemed, had concocted an elaborate scheme to bring the Last War to an end and gather the reins of power in Khorvaire, not in Breland's hands, but in his own. Part of this plan, Lord Elar learned, involved exterminating the other Phiarlan families as well as the leadership of the other dragonmarked houses.

Some might have dismissed these plans as megalomaniacal ravings that presented little serious threat. But since they originated in the most skilled line of assassins in all of Khorvaire, however, Lord Elar took them utterly seriously, and he ordered an immediate strike by the Thuranni to exterminate the Paelions before Lord Tolar could carry out his plan.

Lord Elar himself killed Tolar and his immediate family, while the Thuranni agents at his command slaughtered every Paelion within the family holdings in the Lhazaar Principalities and every one they could find in the Phiarlan holdings across Khorvaire.

Outraged at this apparent betrayal within the house, Baron Elvinor Ellorenthi d'Phiarlan declared the entire Thuranni line excoriate from the house. Defiant, Lord Elar refused this ancient punishment and instead declared that his line would establish a new dragonmarked house, House Thuranni. The clients of the Thuranni family continued doing business with the excoriate house and Elar—now having taken the title of baron of his new house—managed to acquire some of the clients who had been loyal to the Paelion line.

To the present day, Baron Eldar d'Thuranni maintains that he acted only out of loyalty to his own house and all of the other dragonmarked houses and quashed a plot that would have thrown all

of Khorvaire into even greater chaos. There are many sides to the story, however, and—as in all tales of spies and assassins—the truth is hard to discover.

Some would suggest that the Order of the Emerald Claw—a pawn of the Lich Queen Vol—actually fabricated the evidence against the Paelions, bringing some of it to Lord Elar while planting the rest in the Paelion holdings for Elar’s spies to uncover. Some further suggest a link between the Emerald Claw’s role in the Shadow Schism and Regent Moranna ir’ Wynarn’s decision to outlaw the order in Karrnath just four years later.

Other theories suggest wilder conspiracies. Some claim that human agents of the draconic Chamber helped to bring the schism about in order to fulfill the prophetic claims about thirteen dragonmarked houses or the split of a single house. Others whisper that at least one prisoner in Dreadhold, a half-elven member of House Lyrandar, is imprisoned there for his role in fomenting the Schism. Still others claim that Lord Elar and Baron Elvinor amicably agreed to a split in the house and used a mutual enemy, the Paelion line, as a scapegoat to cloak their true intentions.

Whatever the truth, the Shadow Schism was the most important consequence of the Last War as far as the dragonmarked houses are concerned. Just as the Kingdom of Galifar was fractured into smaller nations, so too the Last War left the dragonmarked houses broken, unsure of their role in the new world and their ties to the new political powers who ruled Khorvaire.

House Thuranni went on to found the Shadow Network, a guild of artisans and entertainers who also served as spies, intelligence operatives and most importantly, assassins.

976 YK

The Order of the Emerald Claw is Outlawed in Karrnath: Regent Moranna of Karrnath, the aunt of King Kaius III and granddaughter of King Kaius I, outlawed the Order of the Emerald Claw in Karrnath in 976 YK, two years after she became the regent of Karrnath. Regent Moranna stunned her kingdom’s people by outlawing the Order of the Emerald Claw, as she herself had once been a devotee of the Emerald Claw’s allied Blood of Vol cult. Moranna had learned the truth about both the Blood of Vol and the Emerald Claw—both were simply vehicles for the vengeance-fueled ambitions of the Lich Queen Vol. Moranna had learned this in secret from her grandfather, the vampiric Kaius I, who returned disguised to Karrnath at this time and revealed the truth to his descendants. Though internal grumbling among the Karrn nobility about the influence of the Emerald Claw had long existed, none had foreseen the regent’s seizing of the order’s barracks and the arrest of its most active and powerful knights. Some members of the Emerald Claw were imprisoned in Karrnath for years; others were tried, convicted of treason against the Karrn Crown, and executed.

This blow against the order reduced the direct influence of the Blood of Vol at the highest levels of Karnath's aristocracy and enhanced and restored the power of the Karrn monarchy over the kingdom, but the Emerald Claw was far from destroyed. The Lich Queen Vol remained determined to use the cult and its knighthood to take control of Karnath and use the kingdom to spread her influence across Khorvaire and gain vengeance on the elves of Aerenal and the dragons of Argonessen.

980 YK

Queen Aurala ir'Wynarn's Reign over Aundair Begins: In late 979 YK, Queen Barvette of Aundair succumbed to a magical illness. Rumors spread that Emerald Claw assassins had struck again, perhaps hoping to restore their favor with the Karnathi monarch. In any event, the transition to power of Barvette's daughter in Aundair went forward relatively smoothly, and Queen Aurala was crowned in 980 YK. After Aurala came to power, Aundair's royal family consisted of Queen Aurala, her husband Prince Consort Sasik, her three children, and the extended families of her four siblings. Aurala's younger brother Prince Adal served as her warlord and minister of magic, and he shares her desire to see the crown of Galifar on the head of an Aundairian noble. He wants that head to be his, though, and not his sister's.

In principle, Queen Aurala ir'Wynarn rules as the absolute monarch of Aundair. In practice, an unofficial triumvirate governs the land: Queen Aurala, her brother Adal (who holds the titles of First Warlord and Royal Minister of Magic), and Lord Darro ir'Lain (Second Warlord of the Realm and commander of the Knights Arcane). The members of the triumvirate have a genteel rivalry with each other. Not one of them completely trusts the other two, but they realize that they currently have a shared destiny.

Another Wynarn brother, Prince Aurad, serves as Queen Aurala's chief adviser and governor of the Aundairian capital city of Fairhaven. Her youngest sisters, the twin Princesses Wrel and Wrey, currently study with the mages of Arcanix. From the royal court of the fortress of Fairhold, built at the heart of the city of Fairhaven, Aurala governed the land using everything at her disposal. Queen Aurala has her eyes fixed on the vacant Galifar throne. She believes that the last century has proved that war will not gain Galifar's throne for anyone. But diplomacy, subterfuge, and more focused battles might succeed where the free-for-all that was the Last War ultimately failed. She encourages the ambitions of Darro and Adal, but she is determined that Aundair will not make any moves unless they fit into her own strategies and intrigues. She hopes that the overtures of peace that resulted in the Treaty of Thronehold continue at least until she has had a chance to reinforce her kingdom's military

strength, but she has reservations about some of the less refined new nations. Currently, the Royal Eyes of Aundair keep watch on the activities of the other nations of Khorvaire as Queen Aurala plays diplomat in public and conspirator in private.

986 YK

Droaam Becomes Independent of Breland: In addition to hosting aggressive tribes of goblins, ogres, and Khorvaire's largest gnoll population, the area of western Khorvaire that became the Kingdom of Droaam has long been home to a wide variety of dangerous monsters—both natural beasts like trolls, gnolls and ogres and strange creatures formed from dark magic like harpies and medusas. Droaam has long been a home to these fearsome creatures. Medusas match wits with harpies and hags. Ogres, minotaurs, and trolls compete in tests of might. Aside from a few fertile valleys, the region is rocky and inhospitable; while glory-seeking knights often ventured into the barrens in search of adventure, no ruler of Breland ever considered the full conquest of the area to be worth the effort. For their part, the various monsters of the region never developed the organization or leadership required to threaten the eastern domain. Instead ogre and troll fought one another, pausing only to crush that occasional questing knight. And so throughout the history of Breland, the western barrens were a place of dark legend. Mothers would threaten to send bad children to the barrens to be eaten by monsters, but otherwise few people thought much about the creatures lurking to the west.

The Last War did not go unnoticed by the monstrous inhabitants of the barrens. As Breland's forces were depleted and diverted to the front lines, monsters began to venture into the lowlands, raiding villages or striking travelers and fading back into the barrens. But these actions were uncoordinated attacks with no long-term goals or effects, since no central authority could exert influence over the various creatures of the land. Other warring nations occasionally sent scouts into the barrens to rile up the monsters or hire monstrous warbands to strike at Breland. Karnath was particularly good at convincing monster warlords who ruled various parts of the barrens to descend upon and pillage the lowland settlements.

A trio of hags known as the Daughters of Sora Kell—Sora Katra, Sora Maenya, and Sora Teraza—arrived in Droaam in 986 YK with an army of trolls, ogres, and gnolls. These crones were already legends. The green hag Sora Katra had haunted the Shadow Marches for generations, while the annis Sora Maenya had terrorized the Eldeen Reaches and the dusk hag Sora Teraza roamed the Demon Wastes in search of ancient knowledge. The hags had prepared for many years to claim a land for their own, and they arrived in the barrens of far western Breland with an army of fanatical gnolls,

ogres, and trolls. Every child in Aundair was raised on tales of the terrible Sora Maenya, and any Brelish bard can sing a dozen songs about the fools who thought to match wits with Sora Katra. Few people believed these myths, and no one expected these hags to emerge at the head of an army of war trolls and skullcrusher ogres—a power unseen in the west of Khorvair since the time of the Dhakaani Empire. What few people realize is that the Daughters are not simply fey hags: they are half-fiends, cambions. Their mother, Sora Kell, is a powerful night hag, though the fathers of the crones have been lost to legend. The Daughters do not have wings, but they possess all other half-fiend traits and abilities.

Within a decade the hags established control over the lands beneath the western Byeshk Mountains, bringing order to the region for the first time in seven thousand years. Many questions linger over this newborn Kingdom of Droaam for the crowned lords of Khorvair. For centuries the hags were content to lurk in waste, wood, and swamp. What caused them to leave their haunts and claim a kingdom? Do they intend to extend their control beyond the Graywall Mountains and claim human subjects, or is a nation of monsters all that they desire? Is the Kingdom of Monsters their only desire, or is it only the first step in a far greater scheme?

Renowned in song as the trickster of the deep swamp, Sora Katra, a half-fiend green hag, has been a figure in Brelish folktales for centuries. Stories abound of those who have gone to her in search of secrets or treasure, planning to best her with wit or steel. With few exceptions, these tales always come to a bad end. Her charisma and skill with words are remarkable, and while the threat of violence forms the foundation of Droaam, Sora Katra's rhetoric is quickly building a fanatical following for the hags. When all three of the hags are encountered, Sora Katra will do most of the talking. She uses her shapechanging abilities constantly, choosing forms to distract or disorient her opponents. She sees the world as a vast gameboard and is always playing out dozens of schemes. One of her primary tools is a criminal organization known as Daask (a Giant word translating as “monstrous eye”), which has spread east through Breland and Aundair.

There are few legends of the half-fiend dusk hag Sora Teraza. Until the founding of Droaam, only the most erudite bards had heard of the blind crone said to wander the Demon Wastes. Many believe that she is the motivating force behind Droaam—that she was the one who sought out her sisters, guided by an oracular vision. She speaks rarely, but her sisters pay close attention to every word. All dusk hags possess oracular abilities, but Sora Teraza's are unnaturally powerful. However, she does not control these visions; instead, the visions control her, as she seems to feel an obligation to fulfill the visions she receives.

The half-fiend annis hag Sora Maenya has terrorized the Eldeen Reaches for generations. Her strength and appetite are legendary, and she is said to have wrestled the dragon Saerylak and devoured him raw. Few creatures have survived her iron grip, and she takes personal pleasure in breaking giants and other monsters that challenge the Daughters. Over the centuries she has devoured shifter tribes and left entire villages barren and empty. She takes great pleasure in hunting rangers and other human prey. While many Droaamites adore Sora Katra, far more fear Sora Maenya. While Sora Maenya is known for her strength, she is no dumb brute. She lets Sora Katra run the nation but Sora Maenya is a cunning orator in her own right. She prefers to ply her skills on individuals, playing games with her prey before tearing them to shreds. She is also an unbridled sensualist, and she is always searching for new tastes and experiences. Of all the sisters, Sora Maenya is most likely to be encountered alone, as she wanders the wilds in search of bloody entertainment. Sora Maenya prefers to fight with her hands; she enjoys the sensation of crushing bones and rending flesh. However, when leading her war trolls into battle, she may choose to use a battle axe or greatsword.

The sisters and their minions established themselves in the ancient Dhakaani ruins at the base of the Great Crag. Over the course of the following year, 987 YK, the hags established their power through force of arms, destroying or scattering humanoid tribes and the domains of lesser warlords. After a sufficient numbers of examples had been made, the sisters called for the remaining powers of the region to present themselves at the Great Crag. There, the hags declared the foundation of the nation of Droaam—a haven for all the creatures feared and shunned by the common races of Khorvaire, including ogres, hill giants, minotaurs, gnolls, trolls, goblins, orcs, medusas and harpies.

Over the next few months, Sora Katra established the basic system of tribute that passes for government in Droaam. Since then the hags have been rebuilding the court at the Great Crag and slowly establishing contact with the outside world. (They petitioned, unsuccessfully, to be included in the peace talks that led to the Thronehold Accords, and thus the Kingdom of Monsters remains unrecognized by the rest of Khorvaire.) While Sora Katra's charisma is undeniable, the long-term goals of the green hag and her sisters remain a mystery.

The medusas of the ancient goblin city of Cazhaak Draal also welcomed the rule of the Sisters. In 985 YK, a mysterious visitor came to speak to the medusas' Queen of Stone: a gray-robed hag, who met the medusa's gaze without fear. Sora Teraza spoke with Queen Sheshka from sunrise to sunset, and after the hag departed, Sheshka spent the evening in silent contemplation. The next day she told her people to prepare for great change. Over the course of the next year she brought together a corps of medusas, preparing them for service in foreign lands. When the Daughters of Sora Kell assumed power in 986 YK, representatives of Cazhaak Draal were quickly dispatched to the Great

Crag. Today medusa architects direct the ongoing construction of Droaam's new capital. Medusas hold many positions of power, both in Droaam and in the monstrous communities that have since spread across Khorvaire; in Sharn, the medusa Kasslak maintains order in the dangerous district of Malleon's Gate, while a medusa named Harash is the second-in-command of Sharn's Daask cell. The deadly power of a medusa commands respect, but in a nation of ogres, minotaurs, gnolls and harpies, the keen intellect of the medusa is often more useful than its petrifying gaze. The people of Cazhaak Draal have prospered since the rise of the hags, and for the moment, the Queen of Stone is content to serve. The Daughters of Sora Kell are formidable enemies, and Sheshka does not have the power to challenge them. But the medusa queen is ambitious and cunning, and she is always searching for ways to increase her influence.

The wilds of Droaam are also home to the dragonmarked elven wizard Mordain the Fleshweaver, an excoriate of House Phiarlan who was banished from the dragonmarked houses' magical academy of the Twelve more than two centuries ago because of the unorthodox and disturbing experiments he conducted. Mordain sought to master the magic of the daelkyr, the fiendish beings who created the mind flayers and many of the other aberrations that haunt the depths of Khyber. Malformed flesh golems and strange, disfigured creatures—the results of his horrific experiments—patrolled the twisted land known as the Forest of Flesh around his living tower, Blackroot. A master transmuter and a deadly foe, Mordain is obsessed with his work and has no interest in the outside world. The Daughters of Sora Kell and their followers avoided the lands around Mordain's tower, and he in turn left them alone.

In any event, whether the crowned heads of Khorvaire liked it or not, the power of the Daughters of Sora Kell meant that the new nation of Droaam needed to be respected. Members of House Tharashk became intermediaries between this new kingdom of “monsters” and the Five Nations, bartering the service of Droaamite mercenaries across Khorvaire. The house takes great pride in having forced mainstream Khorvaire to recognize that orcs and half-orcs are worthy of the same courtesies and opportunities as the races already established in the society of the Five Nations. House members began to use their status to do the same for Droaam's monstrous races, who could be found living and working across Khorvaire with House Tharashk's backing. Not all were pleased with this turn of events, particularly House Deneith, which saw Tharashk moving in on its core business of mercenary hiring.

In addition, after the Last War ended, Tharashk began to work with the Inspired of Riedra to locate crystal wastes in Xen'drik that provided the raw materials crucial to the creation of Riedran crysteel. The Tharashk even sent expeditions to the arctic continent of the Frostfell north of

Khorvaire to prospect the frozen lands for new dragonshard fields. Tharashk might be the youngest of the dragonmarked houses, but its members were filled with ambitious fire. Its leaders intended to make their mark on Eberron and the house was always searching for lucrative new ways to do so.

987 YK

Breland Abandons Droaam: King Boranel of Breland pulled human settlers back from what had become Droaam in 987 YK and sealed off the lands west of the Graywall Mountains. The Daughters of Sora Kell declared the sovereignty of the new nation of Droaam, still reviled as the “Kingdom of Monsters” among the other peoples of the Five Nations.

990 YK

The First Elemental Airships Enter Service for House Lyrandar: For decades, House Lyrandar had made use of elemental galleons, great ships that contained a bound water elemental which allowed them to attain speeds on Eberron’s seas and oceans that were impossible for conventional sailing ships to match. The art of binding elementals within Khyber dragonshards and then harnessing them for other uses had long been known to the Zil gnomes, who had secretly stolen the art from the Sulatar drow of Xen’drik long decades before. In the late 980’s YK the House of Storm decided to try and advance this concept to its next logical conclusion—elemental airships that made use of bound air or fire elementals contained within powerful rings of swirling winds or raging flame for propulsion. Built in Zilargo using soarwood exported by the elven island of Aerenal and making use of the elemental-binding technology only possessed by the Zil gnomes, these vessels could sometimes be found in privateer hands, but the dragonmarked pilots of House Lyrandar were renowned for their skill and expertise. Airships have the advantage of being able to go anywhere—provided the dragonmarked pilot and crew were willing to make the trip. Travel to a dangerous locale, if the crew agrees, could easily double or triple the already extensive cost. Most Lyrandar airships only fly between the metropolises and large cities of Khorvaire, which have invested in creating and maintaining the necessary mooring towers. To go elsewhere by air, passengers had to find a privateer. Since they were relatively new, airships had not come into widespread use yet even by 998 YK, though just as the lightning rail had for House Orien, the airship promised to open up whole new vistas of profit for House Lyrandar if the heirs of Storm could master the arcane technology and construct large enough numbers of the vessels. An airship powered by a bound elemental could maintain a cruising speed of 20 miles per hour through the sky but could achieve much higher speeds for brief periods of time.

991 YK

King Kaius III Comes of Age in Karrnath: King Kaius III took over rulership of Karrnath from his Regent Moranna in 991 YK. The great-grandson of Kaius I, son of King Jarot and first king of Karrnath after the collapse of Galifar, Kaius III has now held the crown for less than a decade. He ascended the throne upon his twentieth birthday, taking over from his aunt, the regent Moranna ir'Wynarn, who had been ruling since the unexpected death of his father, King Jaron, shortly after Kaius III was born.

Karrnath suffered heavy losses during the course of the Last War. For all its military and naval might, widespread famine and rampant disease might have ended Karrnath's bid for power over Galifar before the third decade of the war was over. Thanks to its necromancers and corpse collectors, however, Karrnath was able to field a powerful army of skeletons and zombies even when its living forces became depleted. The Karrn royal family has weathered a number of setbacks and threats to the Crown over the years, always coming through with the support and confidence of most of the nobles and vassal lords. As for the people of Karrnath, they might not have loved all of their rulers, but they always feared and respected them. A fierce patriotism, flamed by slogans and a constant call to arms, kept the people focused on winning the war despite the hardships and suffering they had to endure.

Descendants of King Galifar I, the royal family of Kaius ir'Wynarn still rules Karrnath. The blood of Kaius I flows through a powerful extended family that oversees all government and military functions. The next tier in status, the Karrn nobles, have become warlords over the course of the last century, serving the Karrn Crown as generals and admirals, as well as overseeing the land their noble titles grant them. Since the time of King Kaius II, the warlords have been kept in line through harsh treatment and the use of force. The new king, Kaius III, began to make overtures to change this practice, though he displayed a remarkable ability to perform whatever action is necessary to maintain control and keep his plans on track. While he hopes to keep the trust of his nobles and receive their support willingly, he uses force when such action is required to demonstrate the power and position of the Crown.

Though Kaius III has shown some desire to transform his kingdom along more progressive lines, it remains essentially a military dictatorship ruled by hereditary monarchs of Wynarn blood. Royal mayors govern towns and cities. Royal ministers oversee executive departments that handle all aspects of government and foreign affairs. Laws and regulations promote a society where might makes right, and while the progressive Galifar Code of Justice provides the basis for civil rights in

Karnath, the draconian Code of Kaius that developed from it is more rigid and far less forgiving. Indeed, the nation has labored under martial law since the earliest days of the Last War.

King Kaius III keeps a closely guarded secret. He is not who or what he appears to be. Only a handful of people in the inner sanctum of Kaius' court have even the slightest inkling that something is not quite right, and even fewer know the truth of the situation. What is that truth? It is a long, strange tale that boils down to a simple fact: Kaius III is actually Kaius I.

When the Last War was in full swing, Kaius I was approached by priests of the Blood of Vol. These priests promised to aid Karnath against its enemies, provided Kaius agreed to a few "minor" considerations. With Cyre and Thrane pounding on his borders, and a breakdown in diplomatic relations that left Karnath temporarily without allies, Kaius agreed to whatever terms the priests had—so long as he was provided with the means to repel the invaders. First, the Vol priests and necromancers worked with Kaius' own court wizards to perfect the process for creating specially enhanced zombie and skeleton troops to bolster Karnath's forces. With the addition of armor and weapons, as well as a slight increase in power, these undead were stronger and more formidable than the average mindless walking corpse. Second, the priests provided an elite fighting force dedicated to both Vol and Kaius—the knights of the Order of the Emerald Claw. "The Order will help you here and in distant lands, where its agents will foster unrest and revolution in the homes of your enemies," the priests explained. Both of these gifts gave an immediate boost to Karnath's beleaguered forces, and the order took credit for internal strife in Cyre, Breland, and Aundair.

When Vol, the ancient elven half-dragon lich at the heart of the Blood of Vol cult, appeared before Kaius to collect her "considerations" for the aid her priests provided him, he had no choice but to submit. In addition to allowing the cult to establish temples and bases throughout Karnath, Vol demanded that Kaius partake in the Vol cult's Sacrament of Blood. Instead of the usual ceremony, the Lich Queen invoked an ancient Qabalin incantation that turned Kaius into a vampire lord. Instead of becoming a compliant undead thrall, however, Kaius fought to keep his independence. Furious that the royal vampire refused to be humbled, Vol eventually forced the issue by triggering Kaius' blood lust (something he had been struggling to control). When the crimson haze cleared, Kaius discovered that he had killed his beloved wife.

Now, after eighty years of hiding and secretly working to break all ties with the Blood of Vol, Kaius has returned to govern his nation once more. He has taken the place of his great-grandson, pretending to be Kaius III. The real Kaius III was unjustly imprisoned by his undead ancestor in Dreadhold, where this anonymous convict in the hands of the dwarves of House Kundarak who run the infamous prison has been placed in a magical mask that keeps his features and true identity

hidden. With the aid of various magic items and abilities, Kaius I hides his vampiric nature and masks his appearance to look like his younger great-grandson. A burning desire to rebuild his shattered kingdom drives Kaius forward, making him one of the most troubled and dedicated rulers in all Khorvaire.

Kaius retained the services of his “aunt,” the Regent Moranna, as his chief adviser and minister of internal affairs. Moranna, who was actually Kaius’ granddaughter rather than his aunt, is secretly a vampire like her king, having been transformed into one of Kaius I’s vampire spawn soon after he revealed that he was still alive to Moranna and asked for her help in creating his ruse so that they could save Karnath from the ravages of the Last War and the machinations of the Lich Queen Vol.

Queen Etrigani met Kaius when she appeared before his court on behalf of the government of Aerenal during a diplomatic tour of the Five Nations. An intense courtship followed, and the two were married in 993 YK, on the second anniversary of Kaius’ ascension to the throne. The queen has taken an active interest in the affairs of her adopted nation, and Kaius regularly sends her as an emissary to foreign courts. (Etrigani knows of her husband’s true nature and has fought to overcome her elven cultural bias against undead.) Moranna continues to serve as regent of Karnath, a post that has been transformed from one of rulership to an advisory position. She never ventures far from the royal court or from Kaius’ side, except when he sends her out in his name to handle crises near and far. Moranna, a large, strong woman, has a commanding manner and a no-nonsense approach that leaves most of her underlings shaking in her wake.

The king keeps a harem, but not for the reason that most people think. All of the members of the royal harem are followers of the Blood of Vol who have given their allegiance to Kaius. The young men and women in the harem voluntarily give themselves to Kaius so that the king can feed. He never takes more blood than an individual can safely give, and he never goes to the same individual more than once in any two-week period. The harem is kept secluded in its own wing of Crownhome, Kaius’ family castle in Korth, and its members are forbidden to speak with anyone besides the king, queen or regent.

993 YK

The Voice of the Silver Flame Chooses Jaela Daran as the New Keeper: Jaela Daran assumed the power of the Keeper of the Silver Flame in 993 YK after hearing the call of the Voice of the Flame, and at six years old became the youngest person to ever serve as the spiritual leader of the Church of the Silver Flame. Keeper Daran has determined to maintain the more moderate theological

positions of her predecessor as Keeper and seeks to minimize the political influence of High Cardinal Krozen, the leader of the Diet of Cardinals, and his extremist Puritan faction of the Church.

994 YK

The Day of Mourning: The entire Kingdom of Cyre was utterly destroyed on the Day of Mourning in 994 YK; the Mournland was created within the borders of what had been that proud nation. Once, Cyre shone more brightly than any of its sibling nations in the unified Kingdom of Galifar. The Last War took a toll on the nation and its citizens, slowly toppling its many achievements as it became the near-constant battleground on which the armies of Karrnath and Thrane and Breland clashed. Finally, disaster struck. No one knows if the catastrophe was caused by a weapon from an enemy nation or an arcane doomsday device of Cyre's own design. The cataclysm may have been deliberate; it may have been an accident. In the end, the result was the same.

Beautiful Cyre, the jewel of Galifar's vast imperial holdings, exploded in a blast of arcane power the likes of which had not been seen since the ruin of Xen'drik forty thousand years before at the end of the Quori-Giant War. On what soon became known as the Day of Mourning in 994 YK, Cyre disappeared in a horrific blast of intense arcane power. Now the region that was once Cyre goes by a different, darker name. Now it is simply the Mournland.

A dead-gray mist hugs the borders of the Mournland, creating a barrier that only occasionally offers a glimpse of the desolation and devastation inside. Curiously, the mist tightly hugs the old national border of Cyre, never extending beyond what was a man-made border to infect the other lands of Khorvaire. Beyond the mist, this battle-scarred region remains a grim memory of the Last War, cloaked in perpetual, gray twilight. Like a wound that will not heal, the land is broken and blasted. In some places the ground has fused into jagged glass. In others, it is cracked and burned and gouged. Broken bodies of soldiers from the various factions litter the landscape—soldiers whose dead bodies refuse to decompose. The Mournland is, quite literally, a vast open tomb.

In the Mournland, the wounds of war never heal, vile magical effects linger, and monsters mutate into even more foul and horrible creatures. Arcane effects continue to rain upon the land like magical storms that never dissipate. Mutated by the unnatural arcane forces present across the region, monsters rage and hunt as they struggle to survive. Sometimes even some of the dead, animated by strange powers radiating from the blasted ground, rise up to continue fighting the war that has long since ended for the living. At the same time, in this land of disaster and mutation, a charismatic warforged gathers followers to his side and seeks to build an empire of his own.

The Cyrans who were not killed in the disaster that warped the region fled to safer locales and now live as exiles in other lands. Few sentient beings live within the borders of the dead-gray mists, and no survivors of the old order can be found in this shattered realm. The arcane force that destroyed the nation killed most living things, so survival itself is a near-impossible struggle. Now mutated monsters roam the land, preying on each other and grazing on the stubborn thornweeds that alone seem to thrive in the blasted land.

Scavenger bands brave the Mournland, looking for art objects and artifacts to sell. Though Thrane and Breland attempt to keep such outlaws from operating out of their environs, Karrnath encouraged this kind of activity and offered tempting bounties to those who recovered items of worth or power. In this regard, Karrnath and New Cyre (in Breland) are in competition, for both groups want to discover what happened on the Day of Mourning and recover whatever can be saved from the wreckage. Independent scavenger bands also approach the Mournland from the Talenta Plains, Darguun, and Kraken Bay, while raiding parties of Valenar elves venture into the region in search of worthy challenges.

If the rumors are true, a society of sorts has claimed the Mournland as its own. This society of warforged has grown up around a charismatic and powerful warforged leader—the Lord of Blades. Somewhere within the border of dead-gray mist, the enclave of the Lord of Blades rises above the broken land as a beacon that gathers warforged who have dedicated themselves more to their construct heritage than to their living heritage. Every month or so, another warforged enters the Mournland in search of this supposed haven for living constructs. Some tales speak of the Lord of Blades as a great philosopher and teacher. Others paint him as a warlord and power-mad prophet seeking to establish a warforged nation from which to challenge the weaker, fleshbound races for supremacy of Khorvaire.

The Lord of Blades has established the foundation for a warforged nation in the barren reaches of the Mournland. No one is quite sure where the Lord of Blades came from, and no outsider knows exactly where his mythical city of living constructs might be located. Some tales claim that the Lord of Blades led the warforged armies of Cyre in the Last War. Others cast him as a newer warforged, perhaps the last to come out of the Cannith creation forges before the Thronehold Accords led to their dismantling. One black tale paints a story of how the Lord of Blades caused the destruction of Cyre, warning that he plans to repeat the Day of Mourning in each of the remaining Five Nations.

Whatever the truth, the warforged messiah has become an iconic beacon for a segment of the warforged population—and is considered an abomination by the rest. The Lord of Blades has a

fanatical band of warforged followers at his side, devotees who memorize his sermons advocating supremacy for living constructs. He preaches an apocalyptic vision of a future where the warforged will destroy or enslave the weaker nations of flesh and blood. “We were made to rule Eberron,” the Lord of Blades has declared over and over again, “and the day will come when the warforged will inherit this world through blade and blood!” No one knows how many warforged have joined forces with the Lord of Blades. While most authorities throughout the surrounding regions believe that this dangerous prophet exists, no one has been able to gather much intelligence concerning his activities. Even the elves of House Phiarlan are in the dark about the Lord of Blades—and that is not a place the House of Shadow likes to be.

The followers of the Lord of Blades see their leader as a prophet of sorts. His message is only to the warforged, since his scripture deals with building a nation of living constructs out of the Mournland and then carving an empire from the flesh and blood of the common races. His followers look forward to the Promised Time, when those created as slaves will rule over their former masters.

The Day of Mourning proved to be particularly disastrous for House Cannith. The House of Making had long made Cyre its primary base of operations on Khorvaire, particularly its first and largest ancestral forgehold of Whitehearth, the site in the Cyran city of Eston where the greatest warforged creation forges had stood. On the Day of Mourning, hundreds of thousands of Cyrans perished, including the patriarch of House Cannith, Baron Starrin d’Cannith, known as “the Gorgon” for both his intimidating manner and the symbol of his house.

What caused the Day of Mourning, none can say. Yet, of all the cities of Cyre, Eston suffered the greatest damage. Whitehearth’s destruction claimed the life of not only Cannith’s baron, but also many of the house’s most prominent leaders and dragonmarked heirs. Almost as great as the loss in blood was the loss of the forgehold itself. Whitehearth had been the center of Cannith ingenuity and invention for many centuries. Only projects concurrently researched in Cannith’s forgehold in Sharn by Merrix d’Cannith, the grandson of the first Merrix, survived the Mourning. Whitehearth is never far from the minds of House Cannith’s surviving leaders, and Merrix in particular hopes to recover much of what was lost there. Increasingly, however, the cost of such a recovery effort has exacerbated the growing rift within the house. Some Cannith heirs seek to resurrect Whitehearth one day; others wish to turn their backs on the past and focus instead on rebuilding their house’s profits in the future.

When Starrin d’ Cannith died, he left no direct heir or immediate relations, but it did not take long for claimants to the house’s leadership to appear. Typically, upon the death of a dragonmarked house’s patriarch, the title goes to his closest living relative or his named successor. Starrin’s named

successor was his only son Norran d'Cannith, who died with his father in Cyre and left no children of his own.

When succession becomes disputed, the elders of a house will interpret the will of the former patriarch and choose a successor. However, with the ranks of the house's leadership decimated, no effective or fair vote could be held. Cannith was paralyzed, with three different heirs emerging to claim leadership: Merrix d'Cannith, Jorlanna d'Cannith and Zorlan d'Cannith. Though each had a valid claim to the patriarch's seat, a more problematic set of candidates for control of what was once the most powerful and wealthiest of the dragonmarked houses would be difficult to find.

Merrix was the grandson of the first Merrix and the son of Aarren d' Cannith, the creator of the first true warforged, as well as the nephew of Starrin. The youngest candidate, Merrix was little more than a boy when the warforged were first invented. His age and lack of political experience gave him the weakest claim, but his inheritance of the first Merrix's legendary skills in arcane research and innovation forced his relatives to take him seriously. Merrix had also violated the dictates of the Treaty of Thronehold that ended the Last War to establish a secret creation forge in the city of Sharn in Breland where he still produces new warforged, seeking to constantly improve the living constructs, who Cannith still treats illegally as chattel property. Were the Five Nations to learn of the existence of this violation of the Thronehold Accords, they would be forced to take concerted action against the remains of House Cannith. Merrix wishes only to pursue these secret experiments in peace, but knowing Jorlanna and Zorlan, he is convinced that a firm hand will be required to keep House Cannith on course—not necessarily his hand but definitely one of his choosing.

Jorlanna d'Cannith was a proud, attractive woman in her fifties. She was far closer to the proper age for a dragonmarked matriarch than Merrix and her claim was stronger as well since she was the daughter of Starrin's second wife, Elsabet. Yet, Jorlanna was considered least likely to gain the title because in her youth she had pursued a scandalous romance with a marked heir of House Deneith, and some rumors suggest that she gave birth to a son who was an aberrant dragonmarked heir. This indiscretion still haunts her and her critics use her past as proof of her lack of judgment and fitness to lead.

Zorlan was a distinguished and shrewd scion of the house. His talent with finance and eye for profit made him a trusted adviser to the Gorgon, whose cousin, Xerith d'Cannith, was Zorlan's mother. Zorlan's gifts, however, are eroded by his cold, cruel personality that frightens many in the house. His time in Karnath is rumored to have drawn him into the customs of that land, including the worship of the Blood of Vol. Some fear that Zorlan's ambition could lead him to make alliances between Cannith and dishonorable groups.

These three dragonmarked nobles were determined to each become the next leader of their house, but since none could rally the necessary support, the house remained divided into three separate factions based on geography—Cannith South, Cannith West and Cannith East. Under Merrix d’Cannith, Cannith South was considered by many to be the closest replacement for Whitehearth the house would ever see. With his enclave in Sharn concealing the last Cannith creation forge, Merrix ruled his house’s southern interests (including all of its expeditions to Xen’drik and the Mournland) with an iron fist. Cannith South workshops and enclaves are scattered across Breland, Zilargo and even Darguun, making Merrix the most expansion-minded leader House Cannith has produced in a long time. Some believe that he intended to open facilities in Xen’drik to support his expeditions and research interests there, especially at the Cannith enclave in the city of Stormreach. Merrix actually plans to operate not just a workshop there but a second creation forge—where the Treaty of Thronehold has no legal force.

The relationship between Aundair and Cyre was close during the Last War. When Jorlanna d’Cannith had her indiscretions, she traveled to Aundair and lived there in seclusion. After her exile ended, she used her diplomatic contacts in that nation to negotiate her house’s access to the Eldeen Reaches through the Wardens of the Wood, which allowed Cannith sages to study ruins and magical locales under the druids’ supervision. Members of Cannith West were expected to be socially adept and they engaged in scholarly pursuits, especially researching magical sites in western Khorvaire. They had more contact with other dragonmarked houses and the local nobility than the other Cannith branches did. Jorlanna planned to rebuild the goodwill of the Five Nations toward her house and make a greater investment in the arcane power and research of the Twelve. Since the Twelve is headquartered in Korth, it angers Zorlan that Jorlanna’s status in the dragonmarked magical order is higher than his own.

Though Zorlan grew up in Cyre, he traveled to Karrnath as a house emissary along with the first warforged ordered by that nation. He took up residence there, advising King Kaius II and strengthening his house’s influence with the Karrn Crown. He used profitable arrangements with the Mror Holds and the Lhazaar Principalities to fill his coffers and make himself an adviser to the Gorgon. Where Cannith once had only an outpost in Karrnath, Zorlan’s leadership saw his house’s wealth and prestige there grow. Before the Day of Mourning many Cannith heirs were sent to Karrnath to study administration, diplomacy and to receive martial instruction at the Rekkenmark Academy. Though the steady stream of warforged into Karrnath ended after the Last War, Cannith East still has great expertise in siege warfare and its house members serve as advisers to the Karrn warlords. The Karrn culture has left its mark on Cannith East, and not for the better. Members take a

callous view of mortality and view the undead as little more than the necromantic equivalent of warforged. Research is one of the strengths of Cannith East and current research at its Korth enclave centers on creating a new form of living construct that contains a bound ghostly spirit as its animating intelligence. Living among the Karrns has led many members of Cannith East to join the Blood of Vol. Nearly half the members of the Korth enclave are members of that cult and Zorlan d'Cannith himself is an avid member of the faith and aspires to a position in its lay priesthood. These religious entanglements are likely to deepen the rift between the various Cannith factions in years to come.

996 YK

The Signing of the Treaty of Thronehold and the End of the Last War: The destruction of Cyre on the Day of Mourning and the heavy losses incurred to the remaining Five Nations' armies due to troops lost in Cyre on that day forced the Last War to grind to a sudden, screeching halt. The Treaty of Thronehold, negotiated over the course of two years at the island of Thronehold in Scions Sound at the invitation of King Kaius III of Karrnath, was signed by representatives of all the powers of Khorvaire and officially ended the Last War in 996 YK. The treaty recognized the independence and sovereignty of the nations of Aundair, Breland, Thrane, Karrnath, the Talenta Plains, Zilargo, Q'barra, the Lhazaar Principalities, the Mror Holds, the Eldeen Reaches, Darguun, and Valenar. Droaam, the "Kingdom of Monsters," was not recognized by the treaty at the insistence of Breland. Also at the insistence of Breland's King Boranel, the three remaining factions of House Cannith were ordered by the assembled heads of state at Thronehold to destroy all their creation forges; the remaining warforged were granted the full civil rights of sentient beings. Unfortunately this promise was only kept in the breach by Thrane and Karrnath which declared many of their warforged "indentured servants" to the government who had to give service to the state to pay for the cost of their creation. The treaty also recognized the continued authority of the Sentinel Marshals to track down and arrest criminals—particularly war criminals—across national borders.

The treaty also addressed the issue of war crimes. The independent nations of Khorvaire had no central authority to whom they could turn to levy charges against citizens and military leaders of other countries. The Last War saw many atrocities committed in the name of kings and gods, and the populaces of the remaining Five Nations cried out for someone with the power to convict and sentence those responsible. Thus did the treaty establish the Tribunal of Thronehold, a court that rules from the neutral island, ensconced in a wing of the great castle. From there, the long hand of justice, supported by all sovereign nations, reaches across the continent to smite those responsible for the worst horrors of the war.

Or, at least, so the rulers of the Five Nations would have their citizenry believe. The truth is, for all its symbolic importance, the Tribunal has very little true power. Thwarted at almost every turn by the very nations that formed it, it struggles to carry out its mandate in the face of ruling classes that simply want to put the Last War out of their minds—or else reignite it into an even larger conflagration.

The Tribunal of Thronehold was almost an afterthought to the treaty. Although the documents that could confirm this assertion are now sealed, most people claim that King Boranel of Breland first suggested the formation of a multilateral international court, following months of bickering and fighting among the rulers and representatives. Many of these arguments were sparked by accusations of war crimes and atrocities between rivals, and some people believe that Boranel's primary motivation was to end the arguments, not to bring the perpetrators to justice. The formation of the Tribunal added several weeks of deliberation to the Treaty of Thronehold. Thrane wanted an exemption for formal inquisitions carried out by the Church of the Silver Flame. Queen Aurala of Aundair wanted a strict definition of a "war crime" as opposed to a "military operation with civilian casualties." Kaius III refused, initially, to subject his warlords' troops to foreign oversight. The hobgoblins of Darguun had to have the human concept of "war crimes" actually defined for them. And so on, and so forth.

Eventually, like every other provision of the treaty, this issue was hammered out. The Tribunal's first magistrates were assigned from the ranks of the participating nations' nobles and politicians. The Tribunal of Thronehold consists of ten magistrates, one from each of the treaty's signatory nations, with the exceptions of Q'barra, which refused to recognize the court's authority since it had no precedent in the Code of Galifar, and Valenar, whose warrior elves simply had no interest in participating except as hired "retrievers." Magistrates from Aundair, Breland, Karrnath, and Thrane hold the power of two votes each, while every other magistrate has one. It requires a simple majority for the court to agree to hear a particular case, and to demand the appearance of an accused war criminal, but it requires a two-thirds majority for conviction and sentencing.

The Tribunal of Thronehold holds an immense amount of symbolic power. It represents the efforts of all (well, most) nations to seek justice for the worst offenses of the Last War. It illustrates that they can unify behind higher matters than war, that they can cooperate for the good of all. Symbolic power, however, has not translated into much actual power. By the strictures of the treaty, all nations must cooperate with the Tribunal, turning over records, evidence, and accused war criminals when requested. Most of the nations are quick to accuse rivals of stalling, but are remarkably hesitant to turn over their own materials and "fugitives." The Tribunal lacks the personnel

to hunt down and take most accused by force, so it must reserve such efforts for only the most heinous and fearsome war criminals.

Nations might bring economic pressure to bear against their neighbors at the request of the Tribunal, in hopes of forcing a resolution, but many will not risk their own trade status by doing so, and none will launch military missions for these purposes. Thus, the Tribunal is largely limited to issuing a writ of accusation—a declaration of an individual’s accused crimes, and an insistence that he turn himself in—since it can rarely force an individual to appear. All the signatory nations are required to provide fifty soldiers for the Tribunal’s use, forming an “army” five hundred strong. Most soldiers see this duty as either a cushy assignment or an exile; few take it seriously. These soldiers serve little more than a symbolic purpose; they are not really needed to guard the island of Thronehold, because House Deneith’s Throne Wardens do that, and they are not a sufficient force to invade a sovereign nation in search of a fugitive. (Even if they could, the Tribunal is unwilling to send troops to invade its member nations, since it is justifiably afraid of divided loyalties.) Thus, these troops do little more than serve as court bailiffs, bodyguards for the magistrates, and jailers for the occasional accused criminal the Tribunal actually does manage to drag in.

The ten nations also provide a small amount of money to the Tribunal each year, to keep the court operational. From this treasury, the Tribunal draws funds to hire Deneith, Medani, or Valenar mercenaries when it thinks the charges against a war criminal are so severe that he or she must be brought in. These “retrieval teams” are hated by the sovereign nations, and occasionally face military opposition, but most of the time the various kingdoms grudgingly allow them to operate. Given the delicate nature of these retrieval operations, the Tribunal has given some thought in recent months to hiring smaller, more precise teams than mercenaries—such as skilled adventuring parties.

Officially, anyone can travel to the Hall of Judgment at Thronehold, seek an audience with the court, and levy charges against someone for war crimes. On a practical level, however, the Tribunal rarely has time to listen to anyone who does not arrive with official government, house, or church backing. Even when it does, the only result is a writ of accusation; the Tribunal has never sent a retrieval team out based on charges brought by a civilian.

996 YK

The Appearance of Dolurrah’s Dawn in Droaam: A figure of dark legend to the people of Khorvaire, the elven wizard Mordain the Fleshweaver was driven from the Twelve after his attempts to create new life went horribly awry, and since then he has lingered in the shadows of Droaam. Many terrors exist in Mordain’s domain. But the woods hold wonders as well as horrors. The

strangest of these is the village of Dolurh's Dawn, a bizarre point of light deep within the Kingdom of Monsters. Dolurh's Dawn is a village of 104 people. The origin of the village is a mystery even to those who live there. On Dravago 11, 996 YK, these people awoke in their beds in the village. Each one of them remembered his or her name and the name of the village . . . and nothing else. Despite this amnesia, each villager found that he or she could draw upon talents lying beyond conscious memory—skills that he or she could not remember learning. The next year became a struggle for survival in a very dangerous land. Working together, the people of Dolurh's Dawn crafted weapons, learned to hunt the vicious beasts of the Forest of Flesh, and slowly created a life in this savage land.

A village of amnesiacs appearing from nowhere is strange enough, but the inhabitants of Dolurh's Dawn have not even realized the true extent of the mystery surrounding their little community. The people of the village know their own names, but they remember nothing about the past or the history of Eberron . . . and as such, when they first awoke, they did not recognize any of the other inhabitants of the village. But the first travelers who eventually discover this village are in for a shock. A dwarf named Kordran serves as the town blacksmith. His face might seem familiar to anyone who has been to the Mror Holds, and it should not take long to realize why: They have seen it carved into the side of the Ironroot Mountains, in a monument over a mile in height! For Kordran is Lord Kordran Mror, the greatest king to ever rule the lost Kingdom of Stone beneath the mountains. The mudspattered huntress was Lhazaar, the Sarlonan explorer and pirate who first led humanity to the shores of Khorvaire. Galifar I sits at a table with Karrn the Conqueror and Jarot ir'Wynarn, the last ruler of the kingdom Galifar founded. Rasha'Torn, the orc druid who led the Gatekeepers' final ritual to banish the daelkyr in the Dragon Below and prevent Xoriat from ever becoming coterminous with Eberron is present with Cael Vadallia, a legendary archer and Tairnadal ancestor from the Age of Giants and a human version of Kaius I, the man who would later turn the nation of Karnath over to the Lich Queen Vol and be transformed into a vampire for his troubles. This is a village filled with heroes and legends—yet none of them remember their heroic (or infamous) deeds, nor do they possess the full skills spoken of in the stories.

So what are they? Has Mordain found a way to pull these ancient spirits back from the afterlife, in violation of the laws of Dolurh? Or are these people simulacrums created by the Fleshweaver—clones with vestiges of the heroes' memories, but no true trace of their souls? Either way, what does Mordain have to gain from this experiment and why has he chosen the subjects that he has? The people of Dolurh's Dawn may be nothing more than a strange footnote in the history of Eberron—or they may yet prove that the Prophecy can bring even the greatest heroes of the past back to life when they are needed for an epic purpose.

997 YK - 998 YK

The Expansion of Stormreach: The end of the Last War proved to be good for Stormreach, the small city in northern Xen'drik that was Khorvaire's gateway to the secrets of that mysterious continent. According to a Library of Korranberg census, the city had about nine thousand residents in 996 YK. Estimates suggest that more than two thousand immigrants had joined them by 998 YK, swelling the city's population to more than 11,600 residents. More arrived every day. With the Last War at an end, there was a groundswell of interest in the city. Refugees who lost their homes in Khorvaire came in search of a fresh start. Academics from the Five Nations' universities sought answers to Xen'drik's myriad mysteries. The dragonmarked houses saw untapped potential in the wild lands beyond the city's walls. And so the population grew and the city expanded. Moreover, transients steadily flowed through—hundreds of merchants, sailors, explorers, and others who remain for a few days before passing on to the next port of call.

Following the gaping hole in military service created by the national demobilizations that followed the Treaty of Thronehold, a small company formed to take advantage of the military expertise and discipline now lying fallow. Mackinnon "Mace" Maceck, a dwarf entrepreneur and former Cyran battlefield commander, created a transportation and security firm to contract out his services to the highest bidder. Under his charismatic influence, soldiers, adventurers, and support personnel from every corner of Khorvaire found gainful employment at the end of the war.

This firm, the Blackwheel Company, began by taking the jobs that no other organization, including the dragonmarked houses, would touch. Clandestine smuggling missions into areas deemed too dangerous to risk valuable house or national resources became the company's calling card. As the company grew in reputation and prowess, the dragonmarked houses elected to commandeer this rising military power. A special meeting of the Committee of Twelve was convened, and the dragonmarked houses pooled their resources to essentially buy out the Blackwheel Company. By retaining their services indefinitely and exclusively, the Twelve created for itself a military force that could be deployed anywhere in the world to pursue the aims of the dragonmarked houses' magical academy's council. As the first order of business, the Twelve dispatched the company to the continent of Xen'drik, where Mace, having appointed himself the Field Marshal of the Company, established operations under a new flag—a thirteen-spoked wheel surrounding the motto "United Aim," symbolizing the shared interests of the Twelve.

The group's current base of operations, a massive airship, provides the company with the mobility and firepower needed to operate in the most inhospitable regions of Xen'drik. This airship, the *Glory Road*, is rumored to be a House Lyrandar special project funded by the combined resources

of the dragonmarked houses, and is a sight to behold. This leviathan of an airship provides a mobile base of operations that keeps the Blackwheel Company's nerve center from being tied down to any one location. The current focus of the company appears to be furthering the arcane research agenda of the Twelve—securing dragonshard deposits, exploring ancient ruins, and protecting vital artifacts in and around Stormreach.

The Blackwheel Company was one of four adventurer societies—along with the Cabal of Shadows, the Covenant of Light, and the Crimson Codex—that sought to unlock portions of the draconic Prophecy in Xen'drik. These factions are relatively small and operate primarily within the continent of Xen'drik, although they may have interests elsewhere in Eberron. Dedicated to discovering—and manipulating—the pieces of the draconic Prophecy known as the *Caldyn Fragments* (see below), these organizations often found themselves in direct competition. Their conflicts become bloody as the factions mount rival expeditions, racing into the heart of Xen'drik in pursuit of the Prophecy's mysteries.

These four divergent power groups—the Blackwheel Company, the Cabal of Shadows, the Covenant of Light, and the Crimson Codex—are motivated by one event: the discovery, collection, and translation of various pieces of the draconic Prophecy into a single document. This work was accomplished by a human Library of Korranberg scholar originally from the Brelish aristocracy named Lord Ohnal Caldyn. Even as a child, Ohnal could talk to a dragonmarked individual, or see a dragonshard, or study the skies, and he would make a prediction that at first seemed to go unfulfilled—only to be confirmed later in a different context. Taking to the life of an adventurer, Ohnal made it his mission to gather knowledge and insight into the draconic Prophecy. He began to understand that his ability to see the shifting patterns of reality tapped into a force that flowed through dragons, going back to the very first great Progenitor dragons whose forms created the world.

The notes that Ohnal Caldyn recorded in his red dragonhide-covered tome became known as the *Caldyn Fragments*. The most frequent mistake made by students of the Prophecy is to use “draconic Prophecy” and “*Caldyn Fragments*” interchangeably. They are not the same. The draconic Prophecy is an ever-changing and ephemeral force that, as far as anyone can tell, moves like a shadow behind reality, both reflecting and predicting the ebb and flow of all things living on, above, and beneath Eberron. The *Caldyn Fragments* are the result of Ohnal Caldyn's efforts to capture a small part of the Prophecy in a written form that could be easily understood by humans and manipulated to produce desired outcomes.

Caldyn founded the organization known as the Crimson Codex (named after the red dragonskin journal in which he recorded his prophetic fragments) to use his insights to promote peace

and stability throughout Eberron and possibly support the reunification of Galifar. But as people outside the organization learned about the existence of the *Caldyn Fragments*, others scrambled to obtain copies of the work that could supposedly predict the future. Now, each of the four groups focused on the *Caldyn Fragments* tries to shape and manipulate the predictions to its own ends.

The secret society founded by Ohnal Caldyn and known as the Crimson Codex has a two-fold purpose—to study and manipulate the draconic Prophecy. The organization’s ultimate goal is to avoid another confrontation on the scale of the Last War, reunite Galifar, and return to a golden age of peace and enlightenment. The Codex believes that knowledge is by far the most powerful weapon, and that the Prophecy is the ultimate knowledge. To that end, the Crimson Codex has a network of spies and informants within all the major civilized governments of Khorvaire. This network ensures that treaties are upheld and peace remains a priority. Of the four factions pursuing the *Caldyn Fragments*, the Codex has the strongest connection to the dragons and their kin. Like the great wyrms, the Codex is capable of waiting many years for plans to come to fruition.

Although the Codex is a global operation with interests on each of Eberron’s continents, it continues to focus considerable resources in Xen’drik in pursuit of the ultimate prize: the potent knowledge contained in the *Caldyn Fragments*.

A compassionate and charismatic woman named Lirashana founded the organization known as the Covenant of Light. Although she appears to be a kalashtar, the rumor persists that she is actually a divine spirit—an angel of justice unable to ignore the pain and suffering she saw on Eberron. To the Covenant, the search to unlock the mysteries of the *Caldyn Fragments* is nothing less than a crusade for the powers of Light. It is said that when Lady Lirashana first endeavored to establish the Covenant, she was visited by overpowering celestial music, a force that she would later call the Song. The Song compelled her to create the Covenant in Xen’drik, and to include in its noble mission the pursuit of the draconic Prophecy. Followers of the Covenant also hear and follow the Song and believe that an era of enlightenment and peace can be brought forth by the collective power of virtue in action. Members are expected to behave in a virtuous manner in all aspects of their lives.

Mystics of many different religions have been drawn to the Covenant, and all have their own explanation for the Song. Worshipers of the Sovereign Host claim that it is the voice of Dol Arrah, calling the virtuous to battle. Followers of the Silver Flame attribute it to the Voice of the Flame itself. The kalashtar say that it is an external manifestation of the noble impulses that exist within all mortal minds—the harbinger of *il-Yannah*, the glorious light of the next age of Dal Quor. Regardless

of its source, all Covenant members initially experience the Song directly as music in their minds—a bright and irresistible summons that draws them individually to serve in Xen’drik.

Radiant Hold is the primary headquarters for the Covenant of Light and its chief military outpost and it lies several miles beyond the walls of Stormreach. The faction’s greatest leaders and most prized treasures all rest within its grey stone walls, well-shielded against the plots and weapons of those who would extinguish Xen’drik’s best hope for a bright future.

From the outside, Radiant Hold is something of an enigma. It appears to be a fortified citadel of classic Thrane architectural design, built entirely within the shell of a massive Xen’drik giant ruin. Eight ancient walls radiate from a central keep of crumbling rock, each one pointing in a cardinal direction. Though the outer husk of giantish construction looks as if it could fall apart at any moment, there is also a timelessness about the ruin suggesting that long after Radiant Hold itself is dust, the aged shale of its outer walls will still be standing.

Cast out from their homes, touched by darkness, or consumed by madness and rage, the members of the Cabal of Shadows are a diverse group of troubled souls. Not all of them can be called evil, but none of the Cabal’s goals could be considered virtuous. The *Caldyn Fragments* speak of a time of shadow and change when a dark prince will rule. The Cabal believes that the Traveler, or some agent of his, will bring this prince forth in this era and that its members will rule under him. The Cabalists intend to help bring this time of change about and see the *Caldyn Fragments* as their guide to the Traveler’s will.

The Cabal is made up of various cults, sects, and affiliations known as Obscura. Sects within the Cabal of Shadows can be quite different indeed—a sect of unaligned changelings can work together with a cult of evil tieflings, or even form an uneasy alliance with a pack of mad daelkyr half-bloods. But the Calling unites them all in fear and dread and hope for glory. For the most part the Cabal is scattered throughout Xen’drik, but as with any organization on the continent, the Cabal has interests in and around Stormreach.

As the name suggests, the Cabal of Shadows prefers to remain concealed in layers of darkness. Of all the societies in the city, the Cabal is the most underground, literally and otherwise. Cabalists move in the deepest catacombs and ruins beneath Stormreach, the darkest places where even the Bilge Rats, the city’s infamous wererat-lead thieves’ guild, fear to tread. There are four main Obscura in the Cabal, called the Mourners of Yore, the Defiance, the Instruments of Change and the Children of Xoriat. Each sect has its own organizational details, goals and character, but all follow the mystical force known as the Calling and the four largest sects govern the entire Cabal through the Council of the Obscured. The council, it is said, performs certain dark rituals below Stormreach and

elsewhere in Xen'drik to channel the true voice of the Calling and direct the actions of the Cabal as a whole. Without these regular rituals, it is likely that the sects would turn to savage infighting, collapsing the Cabal from within. The Calling binds the various sects of the Cabal together and calls the members to Xen'drik. The few courageous scholars who have studied the phenomenon suspect that the Calling is a magical aspect of the Traveler that manifests in the dreams and unconscious minds of mortals. All Cabal members initially experience the Calling as a voice in their minds—an irresistible summons that draws them to Xen'drik. It is not lost on the members of the Cabal—or the Covenant of Light's members for that matter—that the forces of the Calling and the Song seem to be suspiciously familiar. More than one member of both factions has been disturbed by the possibility that though both forces are probably opposed, they might actually be manifestations of the same power.

As if all this potential conflict were not enough, the area around Stormreach has recently seen an influx of the strange drow who call themselves the Umbragen or the “shadow elves” in the drow dialect of Elven. As noted above, following the disastrous Quori-Giant War in which the ancient giants of Xen'drik won victory over the denizens of Dal Quor only through the use of tainted blood magics that shattered the jungle continent, the elves and drow took advantage of the chaos afflicting the beleaguered giant civilizations to rebel against their huge masters. To put down the rebellion of their slaves, the giants prepared to make use of their world-shattering magics once again, but to prevent this potential disaster, the dragons of Argonessen intervened and waged war against the giants. In the resulting clash, a group of drow fled underground into Khyber after the destruction of their city of Qalatesh by a storm of massive *dragonshards* (including the largest *dragonshard* in existence called the Heart of Siberys) that rained down from the golden Ring of Siberys. The underworld of the Dragon Below was filled with its own terrors, but nothing as deadly as the conflict between the god-like giants and dragons. After a long and dangerous journey, these drow refugees settled in a new city-state they established deep below the mountainous region of Xen'drik known as the Ring of Storms, the legendary home of the powerful elven necromancers called the Qabalin who had once inhabited Qalatesh alongside these drow and other elves. In their struggle for survival, the dark elves uncovered the ancient lore of the Qabalin and used this knowledge to tap a dark well of magical energy, what some believed to be the arcane powers of the god called the Shadow, which the drow named the Umbra. Over the course of generations, to enhance their own survival in the underworld of the Dragon Below, these drow, now calling themselves the Umbragen or “shadow elves,” performed terrible arcane rituals that bound their body and souls to the Umbra, blending this shadowy force with their own flesh and souls.

For thousands of years the Umbragen held their own in the depths of Khyber, defending the realm they had carved out against all manner of monsters. Then in 997 YK, the balance of power in the region of Khyber beneath Xen'drik changed. A daelkyr known as Belashyrra, the Lord of Eyes, the creator of the race of beholders, awakened and stirred in the primordial dark and an army of beholders, mind flayers and other aberrations arose from the shadows at the fleshshaper's command. The doom of the Umbragen was at hand. Slowly, the dark elves began losing the battle to the fleshshaper's forces and their outlying citadels fell one by one to the aberrations as the daelkyr's horde closed in on their home. In desperation, the Umbragen dispatched agents to the surface of Xen'drik to search for anything or anyone that could be used as a weapon against the aberrations of Khyber. Some of these agents even now are secretly abroad in Stormreach seeking for something, anything, that could be used to save their imperiled civilization.

Finally, deep beneath Stormreach sleeps the fiendish Overlord known as Sakinnirot, the Scar That Abides. This rakshasa rajah has lain dormant for long millennia, but the growth of Stormreach's population since the end of the Last War and the extensive excavations beneath the city being conducted by House Kundarak's dwarves have begun to weaken the ancient arcane prison that contains this incredibly powerful being. Should the Scar That Abides awaken once more, all the world's attention may be focused on Stormreach and Xen'drik.

998 YK

The Present: The adventure begins. . . .

A Short Account of the Last War (894-996 YK)

Though the empire called Galifar was officially a kingdom, it stretched across almost the entire continent of Khorvaire. The last ruler of a united Kingdom of Galifar, King Jarot ir'Wynarn, was a king among kings, and his children—the governor-princes of Galifar's Five Nations, answered only to him. The descendants of Galifar used their society's myriad transportation and communication links—House Orien's lightning rail, House Sivis' message stations, crucial rivers, and caravan routes—to keep the realm unified, peaceful, and rich. Treasure flowed into its coffers, and its armies gleamed with magical arms and armor capable of holding off the forces of any invader. The few autonomous or independent regions left around the edges of Galifar in Khorvaire, such as the Lhazaar Principalities and the Demon Wastes, posed no real threat to its citizens. They were distant foes, easily ignored. The greatest danger to the empire was not outside its borders. It was within.

Galifar was an empire in everything but name. And empires do not die well. This short work attempts the monumental task of summarizing over one hundred years of history spread across an entire continent. Unfortunately, a great deal of information about the Last War was lost in the continual upheaval, chaos, and bloodshed of that terrible conflict. Accounts of these years are buried in layers of propaganda, speculation, insinuation, accusation, and paranoia. Likely no one in Khorvaire will ever know the entire truth. These pages represent the scholars of Khorvaire's best efforts to piece together voluminous and oft-times contradictory accounts. If nothing else, this work seeks to combat the old falsehoods that are repeated endlessly to justify lasting animosity between the Five Nations and their successor states. It is hoped that commentaries such as this one will aid in the elucidation of this terrible period of our history and engender continued study of this tragedy.

At its root, the Last War was simply a war of succession. The dispute that sparked the great conflict was over which of King Jarot's five children would ascend to the throne of Galifar after his death. According to almost nine centuries of tradition, that honor should have gone to Princess Mishann ir'Wynarn, King Jarot's eldest child and the ruler of Cyre. Upon King Jarot's death, Mishann's three brothers and sister would abdicate their rule of the other nations, and Mishann's children would be installed as the new governor-princes of the Five Nations. That was how succession had been handled for the entire history of Galifar.

Instead, Prince Thalin of Thrane, Prince Kaius of Karnath, and Princess Wroann of Breland rejected Mishann's succession. Their refusal to respect a central tradition that had kept the empire unified for nearly a thousand years sparked a war. Yet, while many lay the blame for a century of warfare at the feet of the three rebellious scions, such a view is far too simplistic. A closer look reveals deeper causes for conflict—causes that stretch back in time at least to the unification of the Kingdom of Galifar itself.

Before King Galifar I completed the wars of unification in 1 YK, Khorvaire was dominated—though not entirely controlled—by five independent human kingdoms. In the southwest, the nation of Wroat had been founded by Breggor Firstking in the area of the present-day city of Vathirond. Its people journeyed south and engulfed the once independent city-state of Shaarat, now called Sharn. Far to the north, the nation of Thaliost stretched across the northern coastline of Khorvaire and down into the central waterway that would come to be known as Scions Sound. Southwest of Thaliost, Daskara stretched across fertile plains. In the southeast, the small but wealthy nation of Seaside (also called Metrol) had grown up around the city of Metrol and Kraken Bay and expanded northward. To the northeast, the descendants of the warlord Karrn the Conqueror ruled a kingdom that bore his name, Karnath. These separate kingdoms had existed for thousands of years and had evolved fiercely nationalistic cultures.

Although Galifar I united these five realms (and saw them renamed after his five children) and thus succeeded where his ancestor Karrn had failed, it is no real surprise that his accomplishment was temporary. He and his heirs clearly never eliminated the ingrained cultural attitudes that led the people of Khorvaire to think of themselves first as Karns, Aundairians, Thranes, Cyrans, or Brelish—and only secondarily as citizens of the united Kingdom of Galifar. Indeed, his succession practice of placing the monarch's children at the head of the five principalities only served to reinforce the ancient national divisions. When crisis came, the people and the rulers easily fell back on old viewpoints, drawing lines between themselves and their neighbors based on borders over two thousand years old.

The tinderbox of succession ignited a vast political powderkeg; Galifar had long been on a war footing. For much of his reign, King Jarot was almost irrationally terrified of war. He devoted most of his considerable talents to enhancing his kingdom's defenses. He perceived no end of threats—conspiracies involving the dragonmarked houses, plots among the aristocracy of his realm, imminent elven invasion from Aerenal, a draconic scourge from Argonnessen. He feared the Inspired of Riedra (though he knew almost nothing about them) and dreaded the mysteries of Xen'drik. King Jarot's fears fed a military buildup the likes of which Khorvaire had never before seen. Each area

bristled with armaments. Jarot instigated the research by House Cannith that would eventually lead to the creation of the modern warforged, and himself lived to see the first construct soldiers arrayed amid his armies. At his command, House Cannith began work on the mobile fortresses that culminated in the deployment of Breland's floating strongholds. With the king's urging and approval, House Deneith heavily recruited mercenaries from among the continent's more monstrous races. In hindsight, Jarot's mental state appears to have been imbalanced. At the time, however, none could challenge his viewpoints, and few had any interest in doing so.

What caused King Jarot's nightmarish and irrational preoccupation with an invasion from beyond his kingdom? There are many answers. Some claim an insidious alien entity—the Dreaming Dark—caused Jarot's madness. They say that quori agents of the Dark infiltrated the king's dreams and planted the seeds of his paranoid imaginings. In this case, the Dreaming Dark sought to begin the same process of internal subversion on Khorvaire that it had already used to weaken the kingdoms of Sarlona and eventually establish the empire of Riedra. Others claim that the true threat to Galifar came from the fiends of the Demon Wastes. They posit a force of entropy and destruction that spreads from Ashtakala, the city of fiends in the Wastes, along pathways as much spiritual as material, corrupting every empire and bringing it to eventual ruin. This profoundly ahistorical view treats the fall of Galifar as an event unaffected by any immediate circumstances except the constant influence of a long-dead city of demons.

Finally, a few claim the scions' complicity is far deeper than suspected. The five prince-governors all conspired at one time or another to spread doubts about the strength of the kingdom to their father. Their insecurity and selfishness fed King Jarot's unstable tendencies, exacerbating the tension and increasing the military power at their disposal, though if the Dreaming Dark could enhance Jarot's paranoid it could also have enhanced his children's ambition and distrust of their siblings. All of these theories have one characteristic in common: They are searching for a deeper explanation for something that seems inexplicable. In truth, the people of Khorvaire had spent nearly a half-century expecting war to erupt on their shores at any moment. Under the weight of that expectation, it would have been surprising if war had not broken out.

The Last War Begins

“Great advantage flows to the commander who first recognizes the commencement of hostilities, then acts decisively and with overwhelming vigor.”

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

King Jarot’s eldest scion was his daughter Princess Mishann, who ruled Cyre as its princess-governor. The second oldest was Prince Thalin of Thrane. He was widely rumored to be considered for the title of regent, since Mishann had been a bit wild in her youth—wild enough to frighten some of the more staid nobles of the kingdom. Thus, both Mishann and Thalin thought they might be named supreme ruler of Galifar upon Jarot’s death.

But King Jarot gave only Mishann his blessing when he lay on his deathbed in Thronehold in 894 YK. The king bade his son Prince Wrogar of Aundair, who was there at the time, to support his choice. Wrogar gave an oath to his father that he would support his sister’s claim to the Galifaran throne. Prince Thalin, Prince Kaius of Karrnath, and Princess Wroann of Breland were not present at the king’s death, and were bound by no similar pledges.

At Jarot’s state funeral in Thronehold shortly thereafter, Mishann approached her siblings to discuss the details of her coronation as the new Queen of Galifar. Thalin, Kaius, and Wroann refused to listen, rejecting her succession. They vowed to pit their personal guards present in Thronehold against any such action. Wroann, in particular, declared that it was time for increased liberty and some measure of representative government for the people of Galifar, and that hidebound compliance with royal tradition was now inappropriate. Wrogar backed Mishann’s claim as he had sworn to do to his father, but the two of them had insufficient forces or, at that time, the desire to exert their will on their royal siblings by force.

The siblings and their retinues quit Thronehold with the succession issue wholly unresolved. In late 894 YK, Mishann formally declared herself the Queen of Cyre and United Galifar from her capital of Metrol. She also gave her blessing to Wrogar’s announcement that he would assume the title of King of Aundair. Queen Mishann then instructed her strongest supporters to gather at the Cyran port of Eston, the city where House Cannith maintained its headquarters of Whitehearth, to sail up Scions Sound to Thronehold. She sought coronation over the whole realm when she reached the island, but in truth invited only the nobles of Aundair and Cyre to attend.

Breland, Thrane, and Karrnath issued separate declarations challenging Mishann’s claim to the imperial island. The other ir’Wynarn rulers each decreed that they too would henceforth be

known as kings and queens of their respective nations. King Thalín and Queen Wroann mustered their house guards and previously retained mercenaries hired from House Deneith; Thrane and Breland were ready to fight, in small numbers at least, within days. King Kaius I declared martial law in his kingdom and began mobilizing his warlords, but Karnathi forces were still gathering when the outriders of his allies arrived on the shores of Scions Sound.

Even without Kaius I's forces, Thrane and Breland's troops outnumbered the opposition; Aundair and Cyre had been unable to combine their armies. Indeed, King Wrogar was rallying his beloved rangers from Aundair's Eldeen hinterlands when he learned that Thalín and Wroann were marching to stop Mishann from claiming Thronehold and the Galifaran crown.

Reaching the Cyran port city of Eston on Scions Sound without incident, Queen Mishann set sail with a fleet largely composed of transports and merchant ships. Mishann truly did not expect her royal siblings to escalate the conflict into an all-out war and believed that her fellow rulers only wanted some concessions before they recognized her as the new Queen of Galifar. Still, when her vessels reached the area around Thronehold, the lookouts reported a powerful force arrayed against her. King Thalín had ordered the bulk of his Thrane ships to blockade the island. The advance elements met, and the allies began attacking—and Mishann realized then to her horror that she would be forced to fight her family members for the throne she believed to be rightfully hers according to tradition and legal precedent.

Rather than risk her entire force on the waves, the Cyran queen turned her ships and slid into the southwestern leg of Scions Sound. The few Thrane ships patrolling their capital of Flamekeep's harbor refused to challenge the Cyrans, and the Thrane Navy, with orders to secure Thronehold, did not pursue. Queen Mishann was able to bring her troops safely to land near Traelyn Bridge, south of Flamekeep. There, she learned of the combined Thrane and Brelish army moving to intercept her. Knowing she was outnumbered, Mishann turned north seeking to cross into Aundair and link up with King Wrogar's troops.

894 YK

The Battle of the Galifar Heirs

The first major engagement of the Last War was fought on the western shore of Scions Sound, just south of Thrane's capital of Flamekeep. By moving quickly, King Thalín and Queen Wroann caught the outmanned forces of Cyre as they gathered on the road west of Traelyn Bridge. Thalín was eager to strike the first blow; he, after all, had spoken loudest against the succession, claiming his "divine right" of kingship. He was also on his home ground. With 500 heavy infantry, 800 lightly

armored knights, and 2,000 peasant levies at Thalin's command, his was by far the most dominating force. Breland had brought only the Queen's Swords, an elite force of 150 heavy infantry, and the Free Company of Archers, a group of 200 longbowmen. In all, the newly declared Queen of Galifar faced over 3,500 enemies.

By contrast, Cyre had mustered only the 200 elite cavalry of the Queen's Guard and the 500 heavy halberdiers of her Honor Guard. In hostile territory far from the Aundairian border, Mishann realized that she would be decimated whether she fled or stood her ground. Still, she prepared to sell herself and her forces dearly. Miraculously, King Wrogar's druidic Wardens of the Wood arrived at the Cyran camp from the Eldeen Reaches by magical means, passing without trace to appear in full battle order. His forces included some 1,000 Eldeen elves, druids, and centaurs all serving the Aundairian cause. Although the loyalist forces were still outnumbered, the outcome of the battle was no longer a foregone conclusion. The two armies lined up, heralds met and exchanged challenges, and finally, about noon, the armies clashed.

The Queen's Swords of Breland engaged directly with the Queen's Guard of Cyre, and a rumor circulated that Breland's Wroann had been slain (she was only wounded). The Aundairian forces rained arrows and primal magic upon Thrane's peasant levies, and the undisciplined troops soon broke and ran. Still, Cyre and Aundair had no answer for King Thalin's heavy Thrane cavalry, some of the best mounted troops on the continent. Their thunderous charge after the peasants broke smashed into the left flank of the Cyran army and scattered the druids of the Wardens of the Wood.

The arrival of Aundair's force, led by their ferocious bear-like king, had made a difference, however. His troops allowed the Cyrans to retreat in good order to the south. The next morning, the Karrnathi forces of Kaius I arrived, too late. The militant Karrns had missed the first battle, much to their new king's displeasure. His riders pursued the Cyran and Aundairian forces, but to no avail. Mishann and her remaining Cyran troops crossed Scions Sound north of Aruldusk and reformed in the fortress at Eston. The queen ordered most of the army to hold the city, maintaining it as a staging ground, ensuring that House Cannith's base of operations remained intact, and preserving access to crucial iron and adamantine sources. She then returned to Metrol to oversee the mustering of greater armies.

As mentioned, Galifar was divided into five semiautonomous regions throughout its history. Still, centuries of unity did have an impact on the politics and economics of the continent of Khorvaire. A full understanding of the course of the war, particularly in its early years, requires a discussion of those interdependencies.

Much has been written about Karnathi military prowess; it has long been the defining feature of that nation since the days of Karn the Conqueror. The most influential military minds of Galifar were schooled in the Royal Military Academy at Rekkenmark before the war. This meant that strategy and tactics, much of it derived from the writings of Karn the Conqueror in his *Analects of War*, were relatively uniform throughout Galifar. Karnath also produced steadfast and hard-working laborers. Although led by others in most cases, many of Galifar's major construction projects, including the miles of lightning rail, owed a great deal to Karn workers. Karnath's greatest weakness was food. Although competent producers of meat, wine, and dairy products, Karnath's people were highly dependent on grains and other imports from elsewhere in more temperate regions of Khorvaire with longer growing seasons.

Aundairian excellence was as renowned as Karnathi arms, particularly in the arena of magic. Embodied by the Arcane Congress, Aundair has long been a symbol of arcane accomplishment. Less well-known, but no less important, were the skilled Aundairian craftsmen. True crafters and scholars in nearly every field could be found among the villages of that northern nation. Aundair was also one of the two "breadbaskets" of Galifar. The Eldeen Reaches and those lands bordering it have always been bountiful. The nation's greatest weaknesses were a small population and an arrogance among its leaders. This situation resulted in a significant cultural divide between "the gentry" of the Aundairian east and "those closer to the natural order" in the kingdom's west.

Thrane, the other major prewar exporter of food stuffs, saw itself as the heart of Galifar. Centrally located, this vastly fertile land overflowed with dedicated and passionate people. For the most part a nation of farmers, the populace embraced the "new" religion of the Church of the Silver Flame and attempted to bring "good" into all aspects of their lives. At times intolerant, Thrane was more often generous and gregarious. Although the Knights of Thrane formed a proud and elite force, the country was not strong militarily. No natural barriers existed, and the majority of the people saw no need to make the tough sacrifices that others, particularly the Karns, saw as part of daily life.

Breland had long kept itself apart from the majority of Galifar. Despite boasting the continent's largest city, Breland was considered a relatively backward and unfashionable place. A Cyran poet named it "a nation of tinkerers and free-thinkerers." For their part, the Brelish saw the other nations as overly bound by tradition and far too concerned with appearances. Then again, Breland could afford to adopt an outsider's perspective. Her abundant lands contained fertile fields and vast natural resources. The nation boasted widespread light industry and a large and skilled labor force. Self-sufficiency was the Brelish creed. Breland's weaknesses stemmed from its lack of interest

or understanding of the other nations, and its reluctance to involve itself in “outside” affairs. Truly, Breland was the sleeping giant of Galifar.

Wondrous Cyre was the soul of Galifar. Cyran appreciation spread the length and breadth of the continent, setting standards and aspirations for everyone who considered themselves a part of the empire. Cyran bards, poets, writers, artisans, and scholars poured out a constant stream of creative endeavors, some of them truly brilliant. This cultural hegemony was matched in the arena of diplomacy and negotiation. Cyran administrators, liaisons, lawyers and judges could be found throughout Galifar, settling disputes and bridging divides. Cyre also contained sufficiently fertile lands and, given the House Cannith home city of Eston, her top-level industry was unmatched. On the other hand, the nation was weak militarily, relying on local police forces, Deneith mercenaries, and Karnathi soldiers to keep the peace. Cyre was also supremely arrogant; it was accustomed to issuing orders and having others comply. Thus was the empire interconnected. Against this background, the Last War was fought.

895 YK

Diplomacy’s First Failures

Thinking that a negotiated settlement might still be possible, Queen Mishann sought an end to the fighting. She and King Wrogar proposed a simple partition of the united Kingdom of Galifar into two or three kingdoms. Kaius I, as yet deprived of the glory of battle, sabotaged the entire effort, urging his allies—Thrane and Breland—to reject the treaties. The only lasting result of the months of “peaceseeking” was to allow expatriates from every kingdom to return home, some just ahead of overzealous and nationalistic locals.

The talks broke off when Thrane, Karnath, and Breland laid siege to the Cyran city of Eston in the first extended campaign of the war. King Thalín wanted no more Cyran expeditions launching themselves from that port on Scions Sound against his capital of Flamekeep, and was concerned with the force already established there. The siege initially went well for the three allies, since Thrane and Breland controlled the sea lanes (the bulk of the Aundairian Navy was engaged with Karnath in a struggle for control of Scions Sound in the north). Still, House Cannith was responsible for much of Eston’s buildings and defense works and, not surprisingly, the dragonmarked house had rendered the city nigh impregnable. When King Wrogar’s Eldeen rangers staged yet another unexpected arrival in the west and cut the lightning rail supply lines at the Aruldusk station, a lack of supplies began limiting the attackers’ ability to launch sustained assaults.

Ultimately, the siege was doomed when the three usurpers began quarreling about who would sit upon the Galifaran throne. King Thalín of Thrane had already declared his divine right to the crown of Galifar, and Queen Wroann supported that claim, but only because she was promised greater liberties for all citizens and offered the title of Queen of Breland and Cyre. Kaius rejected Thalín's claim, declaring that he, from the land of Karm the Conqueror and Galifar I, should inherit the Galifaran crown. With the continued raids on their supply lines, distrust engendered by Kaius' refusal to pledge himself to Thalín, word of a strong Cyran force approaching, and a powerful offensive sally by the emboldened city garrison of Eston, Thrane and Breland decided to cross back over Scions Sound and abandon the siege of Eston in 896 YK. Unable to maintain the stranglehold himself, Kaius I was forced to withdraw; again, he was denied honorable battle. The armies of Karmath plundered and burned their way across northern Cyre in a fury, but retreated in the face of Cyran cavalry and heavy infantry who threatened Kaius I's extended supply lines.

This falling-out at the first siege of Eston would prove to be merely the first of many among the Five Nations. All of King Jarot's children had been born to rule, and had gained experience as rulers within the larger Galifaran empire. Each had supporters and plans for their own elevation to the throne. In truth, all five scions of Jarot were ill-tempered and accustomed to having things their own way. All had their excuses for hanging onto power, varying from divine right to greater experience to King Jarot's favor to the defense of freedom and liberty. Jarot had encouraged his children to become powerful rulers, and he did not recognize that national and personal interests had aligned against the continued central control of the empire from Thronehold. The extreme stubbornness of Jarot's children set many precedents and weakened any attempt at diplomacy throughout the years to come.

895 YK

Thalín's Vision

Fueled by religious fervor, King Thalín believed his destiny was to rule far more than just Thrane. He could rely on powerful allies in the Church of the Silver Flame, and the feeling among the nobles of Thalín's court at Flamekeep reinforced his sense of entitlement to the throne: Queen Mishann was no more worthy, and far less pious, than he was. The people of Cyre, with their debauchery and their emphasis on fashion rather than wisdom, could not possibly be led by a woman worthy of the throne.

Even so, the Thrane nobles, the Church of the Silver Flame, and the people were divided over how to proceed. Everyone looked for someone or something to confirm Thalín's claim; most desirable would be a divine mandate or a proclamation from the ruling body of the Church of the

Silver Flame, the Diet of Cardinals. The group was much too shrewd and conservative to take such a bold step, however. Thalín decided that he must act first. He needed to improve his secret network of informers, and so he quietly appointed a spymaster. The newly proclaimed King of Thrane also asked his most trusted dukes and barons to significantly expand their feudal armies. More publicly, he decided to strengthen his ties to the Church, so he underwent a ritual cleansing and vigil at the heart of the Church at its cathedral in Flamekeep. For twenty days, “Good King” Thalín fasted and prayed. On the twentieth day, he experienced a vision of the couatl, enfolding him in silvery feathers, opening his eyes, and showing him a land where silver fires sprang up in the eyes, hearts, and minds of every soul. He knew then that it was his destiny to bring the Flame to all the people of Khorvaire. Mishann’s succession to the Galifaran throne was not just a mistake; it was blasphemy against the Silver Flame.

The proclamation of Thalín’s Vision caused immediate controversy throughout Galifar. Why did not Javor Daran, the Keeper of the Flame for over twenty years, experience this vision? The prelate’s power and skill had been tested, trusted, and understood for decades. Others saw nothing amiss with the Silver Flame granting the king spiritual strength; war loomed, and divine aid was most welcome. Cynics and skeptics—even within the Church itself—discounted the pronouncement, mocking it as “Thalín’s convenient vision of infallibility.” The Keeper of the Flame, a close family friend to the king, and the Cardinals did not formally condone Thalín’s Vision, but neither did they reject it. Internal debate over Thalín’s Vision all but ceased when Aundair moved aggressively, striking south along the shores of Lake Galifar. Aundairian forces quickly overran the least populated of Thrane’s territories—an area south of the city of Passage to the Blackcap Mountains and west from Lake Galifar to the Aundairian town of Ghalt. King Wrogar’s forces, under the command of the Aundairian Lord General Haldren ir’Brassek, a powerful sorcerer, even took the eastern Brelish town of Cragwar briefly. The Arcane Congress at Arcanix raised no objection to the Aundairian occupation, instead declaring itself a noncombatant. A hastily organized and weak counterstrike by Thrane took Cragwar from the Aundairians but was otherwise easily repulsed elsewhere. This was but the first of countless battles between the Five Kingdoms that would bathe the land around Ghalt in blood.

Thalín’s Vision marked the beginning of what has come to be regarded as a dark time in Thrane’s history, even by those currently administering the theocratic nation. In truth, Thalín’s description is not, on its face, overly dire nor at odds with common Church rhetoric. The Church of the Silver Flame has long sought to embrace all Khorvariens, viewing such widespread faith as a cornerstone of achieving a living paradise on Eberron. The real conflict between the Church’s

factions has always centered on the means to achieve this goal. The “good” moderate Church emphasizes teaching and voluntary acceptance to bring outsiders to its religious truths; the “bad” extremist Church stirs intolerant passions and mandates forced conversions. The history of the Church of the Silver Flame is defined by the struggle between these two approaches.

896–905 YK

Karnath’s Reversals

“Armies are the forge of victory, and strong armies require strong nations. Plague, famine, and loss of will—far more than battlefield reversals—can shatter the greatest army.”

— *Analects of War* by Karn the Conqueror

At the start of the war, Karnath’s standing army was larger, better trained, better equipped, and had higher morale than any of the other Five Nations. Still, it failed to put a quick end to the war—partly because of its underestimation of Aundairian audacity and Cyran toughness, and partly because of events outside the Karns’ control, as a horrific series of national catastrophes wracked the new kingdom.

King Kaius I’s travails began in 896 YK, the Year of the Long Winter, which featured a largely nonexistent spring growing season and failed harvests across his northern land. The cities of Karnath, cut off from the agricultural bounty of the Eldeen Reaches by the conflict, deprived of further agricultural products by food hoarding in its ally Thrane, and considered a lower priority than the Karnathi armies, began to starve. Cyre’s nobles along the southern border, hearing of supply difficulties in Karnath, launched a series of surprise attacks against less fortified areas, primarily targeting Karn logistics. Although discipline remained strict and desertion was minimal, the vast military might of Karnath was effectively paralyzed by a lack of provisions. For a time, Karn borders remained intact primarily as a result of a new band of knights, the Order of the Emerald Claw, which emphasized flexibility, self-sufficiency, honor, and accomplishment on behalf of Karnath’s interests regardless of sacrifice. The most imaginative officers of the Karnathi Army broke ranks to join the Emerald Claw and paid a heavy price for their independent ways in later years, but a legend of competence arose around the Emerald Claw that would serve the order well in the years to come.

The spring of 897 YK was just as bad for Karnath. The Karns held the line against the constant Cyran raids from the south, but Kaius I needed an offensive victory to keep his restless nobles in line. Viewing the Aundairians as the weaker foe, he launched a major assault across the

White Arch Bridge that stretched across Scions Sound and connected the Aundairian city of Thaliost to the Karnathi city of Rekkenmark, and Kaius' strike force managed to secure Thaliost for a time. This gave the Karrns a badly needed triumph and restored the kingdom's morale, but the critical shortages in provisions continued to undermine the Karnathi war effort. Fearing a complete collapse of morale on the homefront if the true extent of the failed harvest became known, Kaius was forced to withdraw his troops from Thaliost and use them to control his own populace.

In this dark hour for Karnath, the Blood of Vol, long a fixture in Karnathi religious life, offered previously unknown resources to the king. Fresh food began arriving in Karnath's cities, distributed by agents of the Blood of Vol. Miraculously, the actual harvest proved far less dire than predicted. Attendance at the Blood of Vol's temples and at the Crimson Monastery in the city of Atur skyrocketed, and a number of prominent members of the famous Order of the Emerald Claw were seen at services. Karnath remained severely weakened, but the specter of mass starvation had receded. Even King Kaius I seemed to have been granted a new lease on life, appearing at citizen rallies and troop entrenchments throughout the country after the harvest improved. It was said that the king drove himself relentlessly, refusing all but the briefest periods of rest while his country was imperiled.

A number of historians, principally those teaching at institutions outside of Karnath's borders, raise dark questions about the Blood of Vol's intervention in the northern kingdom. They point to the remarkable reversal in Karnathi food supplies and the enormous upswing in Blood of Vol fervor as a result as evidence that the Seekers had used supernatural means to aid Karnath in its time of direst need. They also viewed the subsequent introduction of undead troops, largely championed by those beholden to the Blood of Vol, as suggestive of the dark heart of that faith's power.

It is difficult to separate bias from fact in these accounts. Whatever its power and influence, the Blood of Vol could not contain the subsequent Karnathi plague, make the Karnathi Army invincible, or continually supply vast amounts of food. Despite the aid the cult provided Kaius I (some say the faithful were responsible for his remaining on the throne), the king never formally converted to the religion or issued more than the most perfunctory proclamations in its favor.

Unfortunately for Karnath, no sooner had the food shortages eased than plague struck the port of Westhaven on Karrn Bay, quickly spreading to Atur and the Karnathi capital city of Korth. In only a few months, fully one-third of the Karnathi Army's soldiers were either dead or incapacitated. The losses among the regular populace of Karrns, who had not enjoyed the same levels of food or access to medicine or healing magic since the start of the war, were devastating. By the spring of 898

YK, the Aundairian Navy had managed to force the bulk of Karnath's ships north of the White Arch Bridge. That enabled a sizable Aundairian force to cross over Scions Sound using the bridge and begin a long-standing campaign in the north on western Karnathi territory. Aundair's armies overran Rekkenmark and pushed far to the east, even approaching the Karn River near Korth. When word of the Aundairian successes reached its ally Cyre, raids launched from the south struck deep into southern Karnath, again focusing on Karnathi supply lines and lines of communication.

The extent of Karnath's predicament at the time was not fully understood outside the highest echelons of the nation's aristocracy. Even so, all knew starvation hovered over the Karn populace and plague continued to stalk the land. It is a testament to Karnathi courage and tenacity that the nation's depleted armies did not fail or shirk their duty in this time of trials. In the worst of circumstances, they stood firm, exacting a price from their enemies for every mile of land they gave up.

Then came one of the first of the Last War's many defining moments. During the spring and summer of 898 YK, new armies arose within the catacombs of Atur, the City of Night, as necromancers and corpse collectors from the Blood of Vol created the first undead Legion of Atur. Rushed into position by Kaius I in time to face Aundair's army at the Karn River crossing, the massed undead warriors turned back the assault and prevented Aundair from capturing Korth. This single act kept Karnath in the war and prevented a humiliating surrender.

Although crucial in keeping Karnath's fighting capacity intact, the creation of undead soldiers to supplement the Karns' military was a diplomatic disaster. Those outside Karnath's borders, and even quite a few inside, were repulsed by the practice, particularly when it became known that mindless undead were being created from the bodies of Karnathi foes slain in battle. These feelings deepened when more advanced undead soldiers—which became known as Karnathi skeletons and zombies—began to trickle up to the front lines as the Blood of Vol's necromancers carried out grisly experiments to create more potent undead troops. In truth, Karnath had little choice but to use the undead troops; surrender or complete military collapse were the only other options.

In 899 YK, Karnathi Navy ships, led by the Bloodsails of Farlnen, a Lhazaar pirate group who had agreed to work for the Karn Crown in return for whatever plunder they could take from Aundair, sortied into Scions Sound and magically bombarded the White Arch Bridge, destroying it and cutting Aundair's primary supply line to its troops in western Karnath, as well as severing the only overland link between Karnath and Aundair. This forced the invaders to halt and regroup. It was several months before Aundairian artifice and sorcery could rebuild the link. By 900 YK, advanced Karnathi skeletons and zombies began arriving in the Karnathi Army in large numbers.

Ten thousand strong, they halted Aundair's relentless, grinding offensive progress and prevented another siege of Korth, pushing Aundair's pikemen, wands, and infantry back from the banks of the Karrn River.

Exhausted from months of intense fighting, the Aundairian troops retreated back towards occupied Rekkenmark. The next year, in 901 YK, Karnath suffered a second bout of the plague at home. By the start of the tenth century YK, the once-feared military might of Karnath had become, at best, a stationary and defensive entity. In order to consolidate its forces and minimize the length of supply lines, the kingdom essentially abandoned its prewar holdings south of the metropolis of Karrlakton and east of the town of Vulyar; Cyre now could enjoy the luxury of ignoring any Karnathi threat to its eastern border. Although it would be decades before the country could once again contemplate major offensive operations, Karnathi pride and military tradition would not allow it to be completely passive at this point in the conflict. Through force of will and appeals to his most elite soldiers, King Kaius I was able to organize various small-scale sorties against Karnath's enemies. For the remainder of the war, these raids ranged across the continent—from the northern coast of Aundair to the Eldeen Reaches to the southern (Cyran) portions of Scions Sound to the Talenta Plains. Later in the war, as Karnathi relations with Breland deteriorated, the Karrns also initiated operations in Droaam and the Brelish heartland.

The start of the tenth century YK also saw the first of a series of vicious battles between irregular troops sponsored by both Aundair and Breland in the southern Eldeen Reaches. Little more than well-armed bandits, these proxies engaged in some of the nastiest fighting of the war—magical atrocities, guerrilla ambushes, the murder of prisoners of war, and other crimes were all alleged in this sparsely populated backwoods region as Breland and Aundair fought for control. Although these events were widely reported, and all knew the powers behind the fighting, both Aundair and Breland's rulers officially denied any responsibility for supporting the rival militias.

A few years later, another event that would be of monumental importance occurred. The elderly and well-loved Keeper of the Flame Jovor Daran passed away. After an unusual delay before the Voice of the Silver Flame indicated its will, a controversial choice was proclaimed. The Cardinal Kaith Serrain, an outspoken advocate of Thrane's glory and greater Church oversight over Thrane's affairs, ascended to become the new Keeper of the Flame and leader of the Church of the Silver Flame. Keeper Serrain was an odd choice to take that position due to his older age, his hard-line stances on Church doctrine and his provocative rhetoric calling for greater Church control over the state. At thirty-one winters, he was far older at ascension than any other Keeper in recent memory. Concerns about the direction of the Church of the Silver Flame soon quieted, however. The new

Keeper followed the former Keeper's general policies and doctrines. Lulled by tempered proclamations, few noticed Keeper Serrain's steadily accelerating personnel changes in the Diet of Cardinals. Thus was laid the groundwork for Thrane's dark days and transformation into a theocracy.

903 YK

The Second Siege of Eston

In early 903, the allied Thrane and Karrnathi navies engaged in a wide-ranging and coordinated offensive against Cyran and Aundairian shipping. Although their losses were heavy, they managed to swing control of Scions Sound to King Thalín and King Kaius I. This allowed a Thrane army to cross over to Cyran territory in the west of that nation and join up with a small but elite Emerald Claw strike force raiding south from Karrnath. Once again the ancient city of Eston was in harm's way.

Concerned about the Thrane masses and the Karrnathi knights, Cyran forces outside the city did little but probe the besiegers. Thrane offered generous surrender terms to the defenders, but they were rejected, as embittered Karrnath hinted at the necessity of "corpse-tribute" from the Cyrans to buy peace. As they had nearly a decade before, Eston's House Cannith-built walls held strong. The attacking armies settled down for a long siege. A buildup of forces and regular assaults by the attackers was nearly matched by midnight sallies of Cyran cavalry that destroyed dozens of siege towers and engines.

The second siege of Eston ended in 905 YK, primarily as a result of two events. First, Karrnath's yet unvanquished plague spread to Thrane, undermining that nation's means and will to fight. Second, the Cyran defenders were reinforced, yet again, by deadly King Wrogar and his elite Aundairian rangers. The rangers arrived one day before dawn and unleashed a barrage of animal summonings that panicked the Thrane levies and unsettled the Karrnathi elite. The Karrns quickly regained their bearings but could do little but stage a fighting retreat to cover the Thrane soldiers' lack of discipline. King Wrogar's diversion of troops to relieve the siege of Eston proved costly on Aundair's northern front with Karrnath. The Aundairian forces in Karrnath were unable to hold back a resurgence of Karrnathi resistance, including a sustained campaign of terror and guerrilla warfare orchestrated by the Order of the Emerald Claw. Over the course of three months, Aundair's occupying troops were beaten back almost to the city of Rekkenmark. Karrnath took advantage of Cyre's focus on Eston to march a column of knights and military engineers, supplemented by undead soldiers, southeast of the Karrn city of Karrlakton. The troops established two separate armed camps and began building fortifications. Fort Zombie (converted from a lightly fortified Cyran keep called

Mishann's Redoubt) and Fort Bones were designed as staging points for future Karnathi operations in the area, attacking Cyran territory from its eastern border.

906–913 YK

Cyre is Embattled

“A stalwart ally is dear as mithral, but should not occasion a lack of vigilance.”

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

In 906 YK, over a decade after hostilities began, the Kingdom of Breland roused itself long enough to launch a major push into Cyre, striking through Marguul Pass in the Seawall Mountains and heading east for the Cyran cities of Saerun and Making. The onset of winter, however, all but closed the pass through the Seawalls with heavy rains and snow, halting the flow of supplies to the advance Brelish elements. Breland's invasion of Cyre bogged down.

Nearly all of Cyre's mustered troops were fighting along the Karnathi border in the north and guarding against an invasion from Thrane in the west. Breland's offensive push added urgency to Queen Mishann's long-standing negotiations with the militant Valaes Tairn warrior elves of northern Aerenal, and soon thousands of elven mercenaries came north to Khorvaire to fight for the Kingdom of Cyre. As they would at various times throughout the war, these deadly warriors harassed their enemies with stealthy guerrilla tactics. Over the next two years, 906-908 YK, the Brelish found that their occupation of Cyran territory had become too costly, and they withdrew their forces in 908 YK.

Although it was the only nation to contract directly with the elves, Cyre held no monopoly on these elite mercenaries. Fearing an end run around its services, House Deneith quickly stepped in and brokered arrangements between nonaligned Valaes Tairn elf warbands and several countries. Some warclans even dispensed with pay altogether, choosing to roam Khorvaire independently, seeking glorious battle against any foe who crossed their paths.

In 908 YK, Queen Mishann was assassinated by agents of the Order of the Emerald Claw. Her son, Brusst, was crowned the new king of Cyre almost immediately. The heir had already gained valuable experience leading the Prince's Own cavalry regiment, also called the Cyran Blues. Cyre's military situation remained stable during the transition of power. Concerned about a war on three fronts, however, King Brusst immediately began making diplomatic overtures for peace to Breland, paving the way for joint Brelish-Cyran operations against Thrane several years later. Although it was a relatively minor engagement in 909 YK, the Sky Battle of Daskaran signaled a new dimension

to the war. This first aerial battle of the conflict occurred between 27 Sky Knights of Aundair on their dragonhawks and 30 Wyvernriders of Thrane above the northern Thrane city of Daskaran. The battle was watched from the parapets of Daskaran and fought across a vast expanse of sky. Six wyverns and five dragonhawks plummeted to their death, and both sides claimed victory. Because the riders came from aristocrats on both sides, the battle became a symbol of the chivalry and honorable combat lost later in the war.

In 910 YK, another royal succession occurred with the death of Kaius I of supposedly natural causes. King Kaius II took the throne of Karrnath with the support of the realm's warlords, wealthy landholders, and senior priests—of both the Sovereign Host and the Blood of Vol. The arrival of Kaius II was a surprise to many warlords of the realm, because he was an unknown quantity—few were aware that Kaius I had even fathered an heir. In reality, none knew that their former king had been transformed into a foul vampire by the Lich Queen Vol and that he had given up his throne to find a way to prevent Vol from using her cult and the Emerald Claw to take over his nation.

911 YK

The Battle of Lurching Tower

By 911, King Thalín's Thrane troops had been operating freely in much of "Old Breland"—the area southwest of Scions Sound held by Breland before the start of the war. Indeed, by this time Thalín, rather than Queen Wroann of Breland, controlled the area. Brelish objections against Thrane's occupation were brushed aside "given the exigencies of war." When Thalín claimed that Cyran forces were raiding north into his territory and that he needed to secure the fortress known as Lurching Tower on Brelish territory near Lake Brey as a staging ground to combat them, Breland hotly disputed that claim.

Thrane mustered an army of mostly peasant conscripts and lead by its noble heavy cavalry "to strike at the Cyran bandits" but in 911 YK, it moved first south, not east. In the face of this crisis, King Brusst of Cyre's years of diplomacy bore fruit—Breland accepted Cyre's offer to help defend itself against the Thrane invaders, shattering the original political alliances that had started the war.

The forces of Thrane that crossed southwards across the Brey River, christened the Silver Legion, consisted of 2,000 heavy cavalry, 6,000 regular infantry, 1,000 heavy pikemen, 2,000 levied irregular archers, and 16 arcane bombards and trebuchets. This force was buttressed by two detachments of the Argent Order, the famed warriors of the Church of the Silver Flame, which provided an additional 2,000 troops. In all, the forces of Thrane numbered some 13,000 troops.

Arriving at Lurching Tower, King Thalin's general sought entry as an "allied" force of Breland. The Brelish commander refused to yield, and Thrane's forces falsely declared that Cyran sympathizers had corrupted the garrison and must be overthrown. The Thranes deployed for a series of assaults. The Brelish defenders fought bravely and defended their walls well. Still, few survived the two days it took for relief forces to arrive.

Cyre brought forth three major bodies of troops: 2,000 Valaes Tairn elf mercenaries, 1,500 Cyran dragoons, and more than 4,000 light footmen, all of which arrived by lightning rail at the large Thrane-occupied Brelish city of Starilaskur. The Brelish defenders amounted to 2,000 heavy horse, 500 dragoons, 1,400 light archers and 1,200 infantry of the Starilaskur garrison, and 400 mercenary crossbowmen. They were backed by the First Metrol Wands, an elite Cyran spellcasting unit. In total, Cyre and Breland mustered more than 14,000 troops. Although the combined Cyran-Brelish army outnumbered the forces of Thrane, it suffered from having two coequal commanders, Field Marshal Tarrah for the Cyrans and General Alida on the Brelish side. The two agreed on little, and the army suffered for their pride.

The Brelish commander wanted to engage the enemy immediately, and pushed for a heavy cavalry charge of the Thrane lines at first light. The more casualty-conscious Field Marshal Tarrah of Cyre preferred maneuver, taking advantage of the superior Cyran and Brelish arcanists and archers. He proposed a softening up through arcane bombardment, targeted at the Thranes' front lines of foot and archers. In the end, no joint plan of action was devised.

At first, it did not seem to matter. The Brelish cavalry charge threw the Thranes' lines into confusion. Combined with a supporting Cyran barrage, the magebred bear-mounted Brelish knights achieved a breakthrough, which the infantry exploited. The battle was almost won for the southern kingdoms when, heedless of their own lives, the soldiers of the Silver Flame's Argent Order fought into range of the First Metrol Wands and decimated them. The Brelish left flank began to collapse, but the discipline and quick thinking of the Cyran dragoons kept it from becoming a rout. Heavily mauled, both sides withdrew to their original positions before sunset.

Under the cover of night, Thrane slipped the remaining 1,000 Argent Order veterans into the small Arresh Woods. In the morning, as the forces clashed, the Argent Order struck the Cyran left flank and sent it reeling. Despite heroic efforts by Field Marshal Tarrah, the fury of the Cyrans' elven mercenaries, and the arcane firepower of the remaining First Metrol Wands, the Thranes' flanking maneuver could not be halted. The Brelish and Cyran lack of coordination hurt as well; each commander expected the other to throw reserves at the problem. By sunset, more than 1,600 Brelish and 650 Cyrans were dead or captured. The Cyran and Brelish forces retreated during the second

night in good order, though their numbers had been reduced by a third. The next morning, Thrane secured the Lurching Tower, threatening to expand its reach ever deeper into northeastern Breland.

912–914 YK

Sieges, Fortresses and Holds

After the Battle of Lurching Tower, the fighting across Khorvaire quieted for a short time. The breaking of the original alliance between Breland, Thrane and Karrnath as Breland shifted to support Cyre signaled a new phase had begun in the war. Today's ally could quickly become tomorrow's foe, and the Last War was becoming a war of every kingdom for itself. Intelligence and diplomatic efforts could not be ignored, and had to be targeted at both ally and enemy.

Cyre moved next. The Cyran army beaten back from Lurching Tower was reinforced and, eager to avenge that loss, advanced against Arythawn Keep, a Thrane castle overlooking the Brey River on Cyre's western border, surrounding it in 912 YK. Thrane's navy still ruled Scions Sound, however—it moved upriver and used its position on the Brey River to destroy the Cyran camp and its supply depots. Once again, Cyre was forced to withdraw in the face of a Thrane offensive.

In the same summer of 912 YK, the first of the massive mobile fortresses being developed in Breland by Brelish wizards and magewrights entered the fray. The first of these massive floating structures, Chydris, scored a decisive victory against the forces of Thrane in the Second Battle of Lurching Tower in that year, helping to drive King Thalin's forces north away from northeastern Breland.

In 913 YK, Cyre once again lost its monarch to an assassination by Karrnath. Although no pronouncements were made this time, it was widely believed that agents of the Order of the Emerald Claw had struck anew and killed King Brusst. King Connos ascended to the throne of Cyre, but the transition did not go as smoothly this time.

Taking advantage of Cyre's succession woes, Thrane's peasant levies and Karrnathi knights pushed from opposite sides, converging once again on the Cyran city of Eston from the west and north, respectively. The Karrns, perhaps mindful of Thrane's abandonment of the first siege of Eston, felt no remorse when they were recalled mid-campaign to repel a renewed Aundairian invasion across Scions Sound into Karrnath. During the confusion of the Karrnathi withdrawal, Cyre's Aerenal mercenaries surged forth from the fortress and won the day for Cyre, driving King Thalin's armies back to the Thrane city of Aruldusk across Scions Sound from Eston in full retreat. The Aundairian invasion of Karrnath that kept Eston in Cyran hands was a large one, supported by soarwood supply

barges, dragonhawk scouts, and a significant number of arcane companies. Despite King Kaius II's recall of his armies from northern Cyre to thwart this invasion, the Aundairian armies gained considerable ground in western Karnath.

In a preview of things to come, the Mror Holds declared itself a sovereign state at the first meeting of the Holds' Iron Council in early 914 YK. The dwarven clan lords correctly reasoned that no one was in a position to enforce the defunct Kingdom of Galifar's claim to the area, particularly not hard-pressed Karnath. Still, the dwarf clan lords were no fools—the Karnns were their best customers for weapons, armor, and other materiel. The Mror Holds' new leadership quickly reassured Kaius II that it intended to maintain close military ties to his nation. As a result, munitions trade and other business between the two states continued. Not content with Karnathi gold, however, the Mror Holds clandestinely engaged Lhazaarite merchants to ship dwarven-made goods south to Cyre and Breland. War profiteering made all the dwarf lords extremely rich in the decades that followed, none more so than the dwarves of House Kundarak.

At this point, it is instructive to address one of the most frequent questions posed by students of the Last War. How could the Five Nations have sustained their war efforts over the course of decades without collapsing economically? First, the war was not an entirely continuous affair. For the most part, each winter signaled a cessation of large-scale hostilities. Furthermore, the spring planting and autumn harvesting times were generally kept sacrosanct. As Karnath's early years showed in vivid detail, harvest failure could decimate a nation. Also, major military operations did not occur in all areas every year. A pause of a year or more was usually sufficient to replace casualties and lost materiel, and to restore morale. Second, the usual historical concentration on significant battles, momentous events, and war innovations concerns only a small portion of the entirety of the Five Nations. A campaign or series of battles that consumes thousands of lives is tragic and morale-sapping, but it is not a precursor to complete collapse. Population levels among the central nations of Khorvaire dropped slightly during the war years, but until 994 YK, still hovered in the area of 15 million souls. The loss of well over 1 million Cyrans on the Day of Mourning shook the other nations so severely that they agreed to cease hostilities. Still, even that horrific loss did not unravel the fabric of Khorvarien civilization. Finally, the Last War showed that the peoples of the Five Nations are a hardy and resilient lot. The passage of centuries has not caused the children of Lhazaar to lose their daring, bravery, toughness, and yes, even their stubbornness. Against tremendous odds they persevered, refusing to let personal loss, agony, or deprivation sway them. That such positive traits should be the basis for a century of bloodshed is perhaps the greatest tragedy of this time.

914-930 YK

The Convulsions of the Silver Flame

In 914 YK, after a reign of nearly thirty years, King Thalín of Thrane died of old age. Even before his death, the Church of the Silver Flame's Diet of Cardinals, now dominated by Speaker of the Flame Serrain and his supporters in the Church's fanatical Puritan faction, had been vocal in its concerns about his weak son Prince Daslin taking the throne. In the countless eulogies and memorials after the king's death, the Church of the Silver Flame first broke its silence about Thalín's Vision, claiming the event was both legitimate and misunderstood.

Keeper Serrain himself spoke of the vision, describing "the silver flame that will reach from ocean to ocean, to build a kingdom of the righteous." The Keeper's confirmation of the previously unsanctified prophecy spread throughout the kingdom like a brushfire, and the results were cataclysmic. Although everyone heard the same words of the Keeper, the vision was interpreted differently by each group. Only one thing was certain: The faith of the Silver Flame was soon embraced everywhere as the highest ideal of the nation. Even the Church was shocked by the fervor and zealotry unleashed by the Keeper's announcement, as if the fire in the hearts of the citizenry of Thrane had been quenched for too long.

Far from muttering and making do as war threatened on every border, the people of Thrane now demanded action, and they found leaders among the most militaristic paladins, mystics, and religious demagogues. The people revolted openly against Prince Daslin ir'Wynarn, and tens of thousands barred his entry into Flamekeep for the coronation as the new king of Thrane at his ancestral palace. The mobs demanded that the Keeper of the Flame lead them and their nation instead, and that the Diet of Cardinals ensure a pure life for the Thrane citizenry by assuming legislative control of the kingdom as well. After stalling for two months "to explore options," the Church hierarchy accepted the people's mandate. In truth, the Church of the Silver Flame appeared paralyzed by these events, and it was several years before it acted in any meaningful or coordinated way as the new government of Thrane.

As militant sects and orders sprang up, each strove to outdo its competitors. By 915 YK, almost any stripe of religious radicalism and zealotry was accepted as normal. Calling a neighbor "impious" could lead to that person's death sentence at the hands of a mob of his fellow citizens. The Pure Land movement murdered foreigners in the streets, the Order of the Pure became a wandering carnival of excessive piety and self-flagellation, and the Fire of Tribulation sect sought to cleanse "speech, deed, and thought itself."

Not all the cults of what came to be called the Righteous Kingdom movement were violent, but the more extreme militias, whether sincere or charlatans, were the ones who exerted the greatest influence. A few nobles, priests, and commoners of Thrane did resist the tide, but they had no one to rally behind. The crown prince was meek in nature and went into private life quietly. While the cities and villages burned and riots ran rampant, Daslin ir'Wynarn did nothing. By the end of 915 YK, it was clear that the vision of a cleansing silver fire that would sweep across Khorvaire actually burned only within the borders of Thrane. Calls to defend the young theocracy from its enemies rose in urgency and strength. Tens of thousands answered, vowing to defend the Mother Church. The new rabble-rousers had only to point, and tell them where to march. In the spring of 916 YK, massed troops stood ready, rising each morning to sing in joyous prayer. Casting about for the worst of the unbelievers, the mobs focused on the Aundairian-occupied west of Thrane. Their fervor unmatched, the newly expanded Silver Legion, the conscripted military force of Thrane and the newly created Pure Legion formed a peasant army thousands of men strong.

The first military engagement of the new, theocratic Thrane was to be at the Battle of the Silver Banners. In the end, religious zeal and military commanders known for little but fiery oratory could not stand against veteran soldiers and competent generals—in a series of sharp, clever flanking fights, a smaller Aundairian force routed the Thrane. Captured Thrane military banners were hung upside-down in the Aundairian capital and subjected to considerable mockery. The Thrane legions retreated to the fortress of Morningcrest, bloodied but unbowed.

Over the next fall and winter, the mass denunciations against internal enemies slowed as the Keeper and the Diet of Cardinals finally began to reassert some semblance of control over the population. For the first time, the Keeper seemed to be truly embracing the secular power forced upon him. A growing number of members of the Diet of Cardinals, including the now majority hardliners in the Diet, publicly supported the tenor, if not all the means, of the fanatical mob fervor. By late summer 917 YK, ominous statements about Breland began circulating among the powerful in Flamekeep. The most volatile religious leaders considered all the nations around Thrane to be faithless, but Breland was deemed particularly blasphemous by the Church's more fanatical leaders. That nation's disloyalty in siding with Cyre against Thrane before the Battle of Lurching Tower showed the Brelish lack of moral character to this way of thinking. The people of Breland's steadfast tolerance of different faiths and viewpoints blinded them to the one truth that was offered by Thalín's Vision and Keeper Serrain's leadership.

Early in the winter of 917 YK, Breland formally complained that Thrane's conscript navy impinged on personal liberties, that the forced conversions to the faith of the Silver Flame in the

borderlands around the small city of Sigilstar in eastern Thrane failed to respect an individual's right to practice their religion as they chose, and that mandatory tithing to the Church in the Lessyk area of Old Breland northwest of the Brey River violated Brelish law, which recognized no state religion. The Diet of Cardinals denounced Brelish "interference in Thrane's internal affairs" and strenuously objected when a group of overzealous Pure Land missionaries was turned away at the Brelish border.

In 918 YK, a "spontaneous" and enthusiastic Southern Crusade milled about in the lands of Old Breland, ridding the land of Brelish "sympathizers" and fully securing it as part of Thrane. Still, Breland refused to be drawn in. With little direction, and even less meaningful leadership, the peasant army ran out of steam and wandered home for the harvest. No pitched battle occurred, but the Keeper of the Flame and the Diet of Cardinals did learn valuable lessons about controlling and directing mob-armies.

In that same year, saboteurs destroyed the Glass Tower of Sharn, the greatest and largest of the City of Towers' spires and the collapse killed hundreds of people. Breland suspected Thrane or Aundairian involvement in the collapse; Thrane blamed Cyran and Karnathi provocateurs. With spying and conspiracies so rampant, each week brought new rumors about the responsible parties. The anger of the Brelish people at the atrocity could find no specific outlet, and the government of the ailing Queen Wroann could not muster the necessary focus to identify one. As a result, no major Brelish offensive was launched in response. The primary impact of the tragedy was a reinforcement of Brelish suspicions and isolation.

The religious and political upheaval in Thrane caused a profound rift in the national branches of the Church of the Silver Flame. Although the Church was never overly popular in Karnath, worshippers could be found in large numbers in Breland, Cyre, and Aundair. Cardinals outside Thrane, mindful of the nationalistic bent to the new religious fervor and seemingly abandoned by the Keeper of the Flame and the Diet of Cardinals, rushed to proclaim their home loyalty and decry the upheaval. Suddenly suspect Silver Flame followers throughout Khorvaire worked diligently to separate themselves from the events in Thrane. Brelish tolerance and Cyran appreciation for spiritual matters allowed most of the Church's faithful to avoid persecution, as long as they left no doubt as to their nationalism and loyalty to their kingdom of residence. The fallout was far worse in Aundair, where King Wrogar ordered his capital of Fairhaven's great Cathedral of the Silver Flame closed.

The Battle of Brey River

In early 919 YK, Keeper of the Flame Serrain spoke to an enraptured crowd in Flamekeep. His vague exhortations concerning a “flame sweeping across nations” were, once again, not widely divergent from long-standing Silver Flame dogma. In the context of the Righteous Kingdom movement, however, they were more than enough to inspire a fresh peasants’ crusade. By the time it arrived at the Brey River in midsummer, the Pure Legion was more mob than army, but its numbers were daunting. Roughly 29,000 conscripts and peasant volunteers, many of them child soldiers, were supported by 3,000 Thrane regulars, 4,000 militant priests of the Church’s Argent Order, 3,000 irregular archers, and 1,000 light cavalry.

They were met at the Lower Ford of the Brey River, within a day’s march of the large town of Vathirond, not by the troops of that city’s supposed ruler Breland, but by a force of roughly 12,000 well-prepared Cyran troops who determined to halt Thrane’s expansion into Old Breland. Cyre fielded 3,000 veteran archers, 1,500 noble cavalry, 2,500 levy light footmen, 2,000 regulars, 2,200 Valaes Tairn elven infantry mercenaries, and 800 arcane battlecasters from the First and Second Metrol Wands.

At first, the trained and professional Cyran troops made the river crossing a slaughter for the green levies of Thrane. They held the ford on the first day of the battle, and during the night. At that point, an army of Brelish troops arrived in the west to restore Brelish sovereignty over the area. Wary of each of the forces arrayed—the massed Silver Flame faithful as well as the Cyran enemies from Marguul Pass—the Brelish troops took up defensive positions. They sent riders to each side informing them that their orders were to keep the combatants from moving toward the Brelish heartland. This inactivity sat poorly with the goblin marauders Breland had hired through House Deneith, but the battle’s second bloody day passed without movement by Breland. Thrane’s troops continued to suffer significant losses, but their assaults wore down the Cyrans’ numbers and morale. Were it not for the ferocious Valaes Tairn elves who appeared to move about the battlefield unhindered, the Cyran position would have been far worse at day’s end.

Thrane and Cyre’s forces clashed again on the third day, but by this time the Brelish goblins had had enough. They broke ranks and rushed the nearest combatant. As it turned out, they slammed into the Cyran left flank. Assuming that Breland had finally decided to fully back its old ally Thrane, the Cyran army’s strained morale failed, and it fled east.

In three days, thousands died at this battle. Bodies washed downstream on the Brey River for miles, with fishermen in Scions Sound and the Cyran city of Eston catching corpses in their nets days

and even weeks later. The Battle of Brey River was easily the bloodiest battle of the first thirty years of the Last War. With the withdrawal of its enemies, the now bloodthirsty Pure Legion turned east. The mob looted and pillaged western Cyre for two weeks before being driven back to Vathirond by the arrival of Cyran heavy cavalry and heavy infantry. Although tempted to strike north and free their former territories beyond Castle Rhonewatch, the Brelish forces received no new orders and thus pulled back to more defensible positions near the Lurching Tower.

Toward the end of 919 YK, Queen Wroann of Breland finally succumbed to old age. Her reign had been a long and prosperous one, but now King Kason ascended the Brelish throne. The new king echoed the sentiments of many in his kingdom when he cautioned against too great an involvement in “foreign entanglements.”

In 920 YK, a Thrane army, now fully backed by the Church, moved against Aundair in the grasslands east of the Aundairian-occupied town of Ghalt. The Aundairian troops, supported by the country’s arcane guardian towers, were too skilled and too entrenched; the Thranes made little headway. For Aundair, a draw was as good as a victory—it continued to hold land that Thrane once claimed as its own.

That same year, the indomitable King Wrogar of Aundair died while hunting in the Eldeen Reaches. Foul play was suspected but never proven. He was succeeded on the throne of Aundair the following year, 921 YK, by his daughter, Queen Wrella. Although the transition of power went smoothly, Aundair had lost a furious warrior, a brilliant commander, and one of its only monarchs who cultivated deep and personal ties with the western Eldeen Reaches region of the kingdom. Aundairian irregulars were used southeast of the Blackcap Mountains and pushed toward the small Thrane garrison in the town of Erlaskar on Silver Lake.

Thrane’s troops at Drum Keep to the east of Erlaskar were besieged by the Aundairians of the Reaches in 922 YK. Aundair did not have the resources or troop strength to take the stronghold, and Thrane could do little more than bring in limited amounts of supplies through the mountainous terrain of the Blackcaps. As a result, this position remained stalemated for fourteen years. Displaying its usual complacency, the only reaction of Breland to the hostilities along its northern border was to hire auxiliaries to harass both sides.

922 YK

The Death of Royals

In 922 YK, Queen Wrella of Aundair’s betrothal and marriage to Prince Deggan of Cyre (the younger brother of King Connos) was announced to great acclaim in both lands. A year later, she

gave birth to an heir. These glad tidings soon turned tragic. The queen's floating coach was surprised by a raiding flight of Thrane wyvernriders ranging deep into Aundair. The Thrane force suffered heavy casualties but scattered the escort dragonhawks and assaulted the royal procession. Both Queen Wrella and Prince Deggan of Cyre perished during the battle. Since the newborn Crown Prince Aarott was too young to rule, Lord Marlex was proclaimed the regent of Aundair until the prince attained his majority.

Even darker circumstances claimed the life of Breland's monarch. Anxious to avoid the further commitment of Brelish troops to the fighting, King Kason stepped up previously tentative efforts to bring a demon regiment from the plane of Shavarath to fight on his kingdom's behalf. During one particularly intense negotiation session with a marilith, the demon broke free and consumed the king and three of his closest advisers before returning to her home plane. Five months later, in late 922 YK, Breland's new Regent Brask was finally able to consolidate power over his realm. He then released details of the former king's folly. Intended to quash the few remaining internal calls for outside help, and as a warning against any other realms that might be thinking along the same lines in recruiting fiendish aid, the announcement extinguished any possibility of reconciliation between Breland and Thrane. Accusations of diabolism and prophecies of Brelish doom spilled from the Keeper of the Flame and the Cardinals in a steady flow.

In 923 YK, Thrane's denunciations against Breland reached a fever pitch. The Pure Legion and the Legion of Perpetual Adoration gathered in southwestern Thrane and marched south. The Brelish Rangers spotted them early, and the Brelish regent gathered the Great Army of Wroat to oppose the Thranes' invasion.

The Battle of the Greenhaunt, as it was later known, was fought in the forests between Cragwar and Sword Keep in northern Breland between Lake Brey and the Blackcaps, with enormous numbers of dead, mostly Thrane peasant levies, being left unburied among the trees. Still, it was less Thrane's superior numbers than Brelish hesitancy and lack of commitment that carried the day. Even decades into the war, Breland proved it was not willing to sustain an all-out war effort, or suffer the large number of casualties this would entail.

Emboldened by their victory in the Battle of the Greenhaunt, Thrane's legions turned against Breland with full force in the high summer of 923 YK, almost cutting the country in half. In desperation, Regent Brask of Breland convinced the gnomes of Zilargo to march north and contracted with House Deneith for greater numbers of goblin mercenaries to support them. The looming Thrane threat to the kingdom's existence brought about the first full-scale stirring of the sleeping bear that was Breland. New volunteers and fresh materiel began flooding north. This fresh resolve blunted

Thrane's southern offensive—the Brelish military rallied and advanced from their capital of Wroat in the west and the city of Starilaskur in the east. Threatened with encirclement, the Thranes retreated and set up defensive formations north of Hatheril, a tiny hamlet south of Lake Brey. In 924 and 925 YK, the fighting faltered as all the combatants paused to regroup. Raids against neighbors were minimal, and no major invasions of territory were launched.

Then, harvests failed in Breland and Cyre, and their armies turned to seizing food supplies from the local population. Thrane rejoiced, and the Keeper of the Flame hinted that a divine hand was acting against the Church's enemies. But the harvests were poor elsewhere as well—too few hands worked the fields, and too many raids had burned farmsteads. After almost thirty years of war, banditry ran rampant in most of the old Kingdom of Galifar.

925–930 YK

Anguish in Occupied Thaliost

Aundair's Regent Marlex, securely in power now, concocted a bold scheme in late 925 YK. Troops would be stripped from Aundair's static offensive campaign in western Karrnath, including the garrisons over the key supply line across Scions Sound, in order to reinforce the two guardian towers operating in western Thrane. A major push in the area of Ghalt would cut off the southern half of Thrane and force the Church of the Silver Flame to sue for peace. Even if the operation was not a major success, Thrane's forces would be pushed that much farther from the Aundairian capital of Fairhaven and would be unable to conduct serious operations elsewhere. Unfortunately for Aundair, a deep-cover devotee of the Flame was embedded in its command staff. At great personal risk, he leaked the plans to his priest, who passed them along to his superiors.

Taking advantage of their superior intelligence, the cardinals gathered another army of faithful, this time at Flamekeep. When Aundair stepped up raids in the region of the city of Lathleer on the Thrane-Aundair border in early 926 YK, the cardinals exercised a previously unknown level of control over their peasant-armies by sending advance elements west as decoys. Suddenly, the Thrane commanders gave a surprise order, and the newly proclaimed Northern Crusade wheeled and arrived in the city of Daskaran in northern Thrane before word could spread. Aundair was caught in the middle of its own plan since the bulk of its own reserve forces were in western Thrane, far from its southern border near Daskaran.

Thrane's Northern Crusade surged across the Aundair River and quickly seized the ancient Aundairian city of Thaliost. Aundair's skeleton army in the east fought courageously but was simply

overwhelmed. Conducting swift and thorough operations that had obviously been planned previously, Thrane's soldiers stormed into the homes of Thaliost's most prominent citizens. Those citizens were given a choice: Swear loyalty to Thrane or die. Given their renowned pragmatic nature, many capitulated. Still, more than a few of the city's elite were steadfast in their loyalty to Aundair and thus were put to the sword. In very short order, Thrane seized control of the city's government. The conquering army's leaders, perhaps too focused on securing Thrane's rule, turned a blind eye when fanatic soldiers of the Silver Flame engaged in widespread sword-point conversions.

The response in Aundair to the fall of Thaliost was bitter, as might be expected. When rumors spread that a Silver Flame spy had betrayed the country to the Thranes, citizens sacked Silver Flame churches and facilities and even lynched the Aundairian cardinal of Fairhaven. The remaining Silver Flame adherents in Aundair renounced their faith, abandoned the overt trappings of their worship, proclaimed their loyalty to Aundair, or denounced the Council of Cardinals—in sum, did whatever was necessary to survive the purge. These crimes and reactions against the Church enraged Thrane's leaders and soldiers.

In the spiraling retaliation between the two kingdoms, Thrane did not lose sight of its military position. The army of Thrane entrenched in depth along the new border with Aundair, guarding all of the land approaches to Thaliost. Aundairian troops were forced to conduct risky crossings of Scions Sound to bring supplies to their forces that remained entrenched in western Karnath. Aundair poured its rage into its originally-planned assault on Thrane, striking east from the town of Ghalt into central Thrane. Thrane's forces slowed the Aundairian advance and even repelled an opportunistic Brelish raid near Cragwar in southern Thrane. At midsummer of 926 YK, Aundair and Thrane met for the Second Battle of the Crying Fields. This time, the forces of Aundair decisively defeated the outnumbered Thrane and seized significant amounts of territory in western Thrane. The Thrane armies were forced to withdraw in humiliation to the east.

Despite these setbacks, Thrane retained and tightened its grip on conquered Thaliost and the surrounding lands. Members of the Northern Crusade seized houses and property abandoned by Aundairian refugees who had fled Thaliost after the start of the Thrane occupation or those who had been “cleansed by the sword.” The ancient Aundairian royal palace in Thaliost was remade into Cardinal Sudro's home, after he was appointed governor of Thrane's newest province by the Keeper of the Flame.

The Aundairians did not give up in their attempts to retake Thaliost. In 927 YK, Aundair's Grand Army of Liberation marched into the Silver Wood west of the city and surged toward Thaliost. This was Aundair's most desperate attempt to retake its pre-Galifar capital, but despite the work of its

sky knights, the Knights Arcane and their knight phantoms, the Fairhaven and Stormhome Wands, and other elite Aundairian units, the offensive failed. The Aundairian army was stopped and then pushed back that autumn by the tenacity of Thrane's soldiers. Unlike Thrane, Aundair lacked the numbers to fight a two-front war, both in Thaliost and near Ghalt in central Thrane. In the end, the Aundairians were forced into a harsh retreat toward the town of Kerkulin, beginning what came to be known as the Shameful March. Humbled by the Thranes, the Aundairians looted food and livestock as they left—robbing from their fellow Aundairians to deny aid to the hated enemy. The depleted Grand Army of Liberation set up defensive positions along the northern coast of Aundair with heavy hearts.

In the high summer of 928 YK, emboldened by Aundair's action the prior year and led to believe that magical support might arrive to strengthen their hand, the commoners of Thaliost successfully revolted against their Thrane overlords, retaking control of the city. The soldiers of Thrane moved to suppress the revolt, but the Diet of Cardinals demanded softer methods be applied first: They decreed that no food would be supplied to the city until the rebels surrendered. The Cardinals misjudged the commoners of Thaliost, who found ways to smuggle food and supplies into the city and resisted the siege. When the "gentler hand" failed, the Diet unleashed the Knights of Thrane. The city was ultimately pacified, show trials were held, and the captured instigators were burned alive as an example.

The attitudes between the Aundairian inhabitants of Thaliost and their Thrane occupiers, unpleasant previously, became even more bitter after the failed revolt. A large garrison of Thrane's soldiers called the Flame's Anointed was assigned to the city from 928 YK forward, and relations between the city's people and its occupiers remain tainted even now, years after the war's end.

Thrane's actions in Thaliost mark the darkest point in Keeper Serrain's reign. It cannot be questioned that the Church of the Silver Flame was in complete control of the Northern Crusade, and that all the measures taken to pacify Thaliost were approved by the Diet of Cardinals. Although the lycanthropic crusade of the Silver Purge had long been a warning of the potential for excesses by the Church of the Silver Flame, the occupation of Thaliost was truly the most "evil" of Church-sponsored activities. Given the fervor of the nation of Thrane at the time, it could be argued that the Church's rulers had little choice when faced with intractable opposition, but that is a circular claim. After all, the mood of Thrane was in no small part a product of the Keeper's and the Cardinals' exhortations. Some have described Keeper Serrain as a weak individual overwhelmed by the passions of his time. Others point to his pre-ascension writings and deem all Thrane's actions to be part of his long-term plans. Certain Silver Flame commentators have suggested that the long-denied Voice of Darkness in

the Flame was responsible. Whatever the cause of this tragic chapter of history, many in the Church of the Silver Flame have spent the last three-quarters of a century seeking redemption. Given all the good the Church has created and all the true evil it has vanquished over the years, it can only be hoped that young Keeper Jaela Daran, the current head of the Church, continues the virtuous path she has laid before the faithful in the wake of the Last War.

Also in 928 YK, saboteurs used powerful magical fire to destroy the White Arch Bridge once more, severing the lightning rail link between Thaliost and Rekkenmark across Scions Sound permanently. No concrete evidence has been unearthed proving whether the attack was motivated by Thrane trying to secure Thaliost from Aundairian forces to the east, by Aundair fearful of further Thrane advances, or even by Karnath seeking to isolate the Aundairian forces occupying its territory. Regardless, neither of the three countries had sufficient magical resources or control of the surrounding region to implement reconstruction. From that day forward, the bridge remained a ruin.

That same year of 928 YK, Duke Ven ir’Kesslan of Cyre led four thousand settlers from all across the Five Nations on an arduous voyage along the coast to southeastern Khorvaire to birth the new Kingdom of Q’barra with himself as its first monarch. These people were all Galifaran patriots who felt more loyalty to the broken kingdom than to the individual nations of central Khorvaire. Many died of disease, hunger, and pirate attack during the journey and in settling the jungle, but the small nation stabilized and became a beacon of peace for those fleeing what the Q’barrans called “the Western War.” As the war continued to rage, the people of Q’barra took no real notice of political or military changes west of the Endworld Mountains; for them, it was all “the civil war in central Galifar.” Even after the Last War ended, their language and attitudes remained stuck in an older time, even as their culture and towns of Addarport and Newthrone grew to resemble those of the humans of Valenar and the Lhazaar Principalities, their primary trading partners.

Many question King Connos of Cyre’s approval of Lord ir’Kesslan’s mission and his grant of the Q’barran lands. Why would Cyre, pressed by decades of war, allow thousands to abandon it? First, the majority of the settlers were steadfast objectors to the war, believing that no Galifaran subject should raise up arms against another. They were more a burden on Cyre than a boon. Still, the king could have forced their support. Second, the land grant involved territories that until recently had been claimed by Karnath. No doubt King Connos hoped to distract and insult his northern foe. Most important, however, Connos was a true child of Cyre—and thus, Cyran appreciation was his lifeblood. Lord ir’Kesslan was an accomplished diplomat, and he appealed to the “poetry in His Majesty’s soul.” King Connos was touched by ir’Kesslan’s vision of Galifar restored and could not deny his request, despite its complete lack of strategic benefit for Cyre. Although the final chapter of

the New Galifar project in the jungles of Q'barra has yet to be written, its beginning was a hope-filled marriage of brilliant negotiation and a war-weary heart.

Finally, the eventful year of 928 YK brought a new monarch to power in Breland. King Boranex was crowned that year, although he had effectively assumed power from Regent Brask when he came of age in 927 YK. His first full year of power would begin in massacre. In 929 YK, the Silver Legion of Thrane, a unit known for its toughness and grit, stepped up its efforts to secure the lands between Lake Brey and the Blackcap Mountains. Ranging south to the hamlet of Hatheril, one company of the Silver Legion encountered stiff resistance. Claiming to follow the “doctrine of Thaliost,” the soldiers of Thrane massacred half the inhabitants of Hatheril as “unbelievers” and forced mass conversion to the Flame on the survivors.

Outrage at this atrocity ran the length of Breland and beyond. Once again, the worst stereotypes of the Silver Flame fanatics were confirmed. Citing this event, the gnomes of Zilargo moved even closer to their western neighbor, sending permanent detachments to train with Brelish wands and rangers. The mounting atrocities compelled a group of Thrane’s cardinals to warn against “excesses of zealotry.” It seemed that not all of Thrane’s priesthood agreed with the Keeper of the Flame’s and the Diet of Cardinals’ approach. Recriminations began to fly in Flamekeep as Puritan hard-liners railed against those who would subvert Thrane’s holy cause. Keeper Serrain ceased making public appearances, and rumors flew that he was ailing (he would be seen little during the remaining years of his reign). Although the path would not be smooth or swift, these tidings are the first evidence that the Church’s elders were stepping away from the abyss.

The Diet of Cardinals issued Breland a formal apology; it even cast from the Church and imprisoned the officer-priests of the Silver Legion company that destroyed Hatheril (they were reinstated to command when passions ran high once again). The cardinals then sent a delegation to Wroat to offer a cessation of hostilities between Thrane and Breland. In 930 YK, an armistice was signed between the two kingdoms. Thrane voluntarily pulled its forces back north of Cragwar and Sword Keep, and Breland assumed control of Old Breland and a border anchored by those strongholds. For Thrane, this retreat allowed the Church to concentrate on quashing any hint of civil war within its ranks, and to focus attention on its many other enemies.

928–936 YK

Cyre in the Balance

“Morale among the soldiers and citizenry—one’s own and one’s enemies—is paramount. Be mindful that in serving it internally, a commander not bolster the foe disproportionately.”

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

Given the assassination of his grandmother and his father by the Order of the Emerald Claw, King Connos of Cyre’s hatred for Karrnath was absolute. Cyran forces had pushed the Karrnathi troops north and east, away from the border, but those hostilities were far from over. Given Breland’s ceasefire with Thrane, Cyre became concerned that the cardinals of the Church of the Silver Flame and their forces would move east. Finally, although Cyre had established a working relationship with Breland, the events of recent years showed that no alliance was truly solid between the nations. King Connos decided that it was time for Cyre to go on the offensive.

929 YK

The Battle of Metrol

In 929, King Connos gathered an army of cavalry regiments and deadly Valaes Tairn mounted elven scouts in the Cyran territory south of Lake Cyre. They were ordered to strike the previously Karrnathi-held regions of Talenta, annexing the lands and establishing a trade route between Cyre and the Mror Holds, the Lhazaar Principalities, and Q’barra. Ultimately, the First Battle of the Plains of Talenta was lost through a combination of Cyran overconfidence and halfling unity. The Cyrans expected to take the tribes apart one by one, but instead they found themselves facing an army as large as their own—and with better knowledge of the terrain. The Talenta halflings and their thunder lizard mounts beat back the Cyran cavalry. Emerald Claw spies made sure that news of Cyre’s failed Talentan campaign soon reached the Karrnathi royal court in Korth.

Cyre’s armies along its northern marches were stretched thin, and many troops had been taken out of the Metrol garrison to support King Connos’ strike east. The next year, in 930 YK, Karrnath was in a perfect position to take advantage of Cyre’s setback. Aundair’s eastern army occupying part of Karrnath had been quiet since its main supply line over the White Arch Bridge had been cut. King Kaius II’s years of rebuilding and marshaling of his forces bore fruit. He gathered a powerful army at the city of Vedykar in southern Karrnath and moved it quickly by lightning rail south of Fort Zombie. The troops were ably commanded by the Warlord Kron ir’Wynarn, Kaius II’s distant cousin, who had previously been lauded for his masterful use of undead, the terrain, and defensive tactics during the

Aundairian invasion of Karrnath. Lord Kron was eager for a chance to display his offensive command skills.

The order of battle included 2,000 dragoons, 1,500 heavy cavalry, 2,500 irregular archers from the Karrnwood, 4,000 crossbowmen, 13,000 light infantry, 4,000 pike, and 12,000 Karrnathi undead, including the First and Second Atur Legions. Most important, though, were two mercenary dwarven engineering regiments from the Mror Holds, who came equipped with arcane bombards, towers, and trebuchets. All told, more than 39,000 troops set out from eastern Karrnath, the largest army that kingdom had ever assembled. “Lord Kron’s Expedition,” as it came to be known, quick-marched the miles south and west to threaten Metrol. In a masterful stroke, Kron had the dwarf engineers fashion a group of large rafts, which the regiments used to cross Lake Cyre at several points along the way, enabling multiple prongs of attack against Cyre’s capital. One detachment was ordered south to intercept any Cyran reinforcements for the city.

Given the lack of Karrnathi military activity in the east, Cyre had not concentrated its defenses in the area. So quick and secret was Karrnath’s advance that the Home Guard of Cyre, 5,000 of the nation’s best heavy infantry, supported by 1,000 engineers and artilleryists, had only a couple of days to prepare. In that time, the nobles and gentry of Cyre quickly raised 2,000 light cavalry and a conscript force of 8,000 of Metrol’s citizens. The Cyran defenders were determined to hold their nation’s capital. A last-minute arrival by lightning rail of 4,000 troops from the west, including a few hard-bitten Cyran veterans of the Eston sieges, bolstered the city’s morale as the smoke from the Karrnathi pillagers began to appear on the horizon. Despite all this, the Karrns had far greater numbers, and half the Cyran army was raw recruits, untested in battle.

Despite the bravery of the troops, the citizenry of Metrol succumbed to panic, and chaos reigned in the Cyran capital. Refugees poured out, heading west and south. Shaken by the populace’s reaction, the Cyran forces decided not to wait for a siege. The Home Guard marched out and took a position outside the city walls on a low hill, covered by archers and with conscripts to either side. The cavalry was held in reserve. Lord Kron’s strategy was to encircle and destroy the Cyran position, and he did this by forming most of his columns into two wings. The token force left to hold the center against the Home Guard did a brilliant job of keeping it occupied. Indeed, the Cyran troops from Eston drove into Kron’s forces on the center left, and Cyran General Diran Forgill prepared the light cavalry to exploit what he was sure was a coming breakthrough in the Karrn lines.

Suddenly, the Karrn plan unfolded. Dragoons and heavy cavalry—all hardened veterans—appeared on the Karrn army’s flanks, slicing into the Cyran conscripts. The western Cyran troops in the center were abruptly forced into a fighting retreat as the supporting troops on their flank

evaporated. Only the Home Guard held its position—and in the end, all 5,000 were either cut down or captured in the dying light of that afternoon. No serious resistance remained to stop Lord Kron's troops from besieging Metrol. One quick blast from the Mror bombards at close range destroyed the city gatehouse, and the victorious warriors poured in. The Karrns had borne decades of famine, disease, and ignominious defensive operations. It was time to show the world that Karnath must be feared.

All that night, all the next day, and for three more days after that, Metrol was an open city. The screaming never stopped. While Metrol was put to fire and sword, the Blood of Vol's corpse collectors performed their gruesome rounds, and a new Atur Legion of Karrn undead arose. After five days of looting and killing, Lord Kron rallied his forces for a triumphant march back to the Karnathi heartland. Certainly, little was left of Metrol to occupy. The victorious Karrns burned and pillaged their way along the western bank of the Cyre River, leaving a charred path 300 miles long.

In the fall, Kaius II offered harsh terms to King Connos, which would have ceded a large portion of Cyran land to Karnath, renounced the Cyran claim to the throne of Galifar, and imposed a yearly Cyran tribute to Karnath. Cyre rejected the offer and began a propaganda campaign, decrying the "martyrdom of Metrol," the "rape of Cyre," and the presence of cannibalistic Karrn undead in the streets of Metrol during the sack.

Although a dismal time for the Cyran military, the aftermath of the sack of Metrol was a triumph for Cyran diplomacy. Cyre played the wronged victim to the hilt. Cyran diplomatic liaisons with Breland, Thrane, Aundair, and even the Cyran cities to the south and west presented graphic accounts of the Karrns' depredations, particularly their corpse-harvesting. Their performances were masterful and rallied all of Khorvaire to Cyre's side. Karnathi atrocities during the sack of Metrol, while tragic, might have actually saved Cyre from political annihilation. Those acts fully united all of Cyre's population against Karnath and gained it great sympathy from the other civilized nations of the continent.

930–935 YK

The Reaction to the Sack of Metrol

After the slaughter at Metrol, King Boranex severed ties between his Breland and Karnath. In response, King Kaius II ordered a series of Karrn raids against far western Brelish outposts. Thrane's Diet of Cardinals, whose proclamations concerning its long-time ally had been muted to this point, condemned Kaius II and announced that Thrane would no longer support its northeastern neighbor and former ally. The Church made it known through back channels that no Silver Flame force would

oppose a Cyran retaliation or Aundairian offensive against Karnath. Confident it would not be distracted by the other nations, and entirely committed to Karnath's defeat, Cyre marshaled naval and land forces for a fresh campaign in the north.

Meanwhile, in Karnath, the afterglow of the triumph at Metrol quickly turned sour. The victory had muted news of another disastrous harvest, and again starvation stalked the land. Even worse, Lord Kron let his triumph and subsequent promotion to Field Marshal of the Armies, the highest-ranking military position in Karnath, go to his head. He began ordering troop movements without consulting the king, and used strong-arm tactics with the Karnathi peasantry to ensure that he and his soldiers were well-fed during the winter. His ultimate undoing occurred when he tired of the arrogance of the Order of the Emerald Claw and barred the order from his presence. When the order presented King Kaius II with eyewitness accounts of Lord Kron's plans to declare himself Karnath's new monarch, Kaius was saddened but not surprised. The declaration of Kron's treachery and his assassination (along with that of his senior staff) shortly thereafter by House Phiarlan operatives devastated the Karnathi Army and significantly weakened Karnath's war efforts.

For their part, the Cyrans chose to ignore their pillaged lands in the east—an advance there would lead only to the nigh-impregnable bastion at Karnath's city of Karrlakton. The Cyran troops who intended to serve as Metrol's avengers pushed north across Scions Sound farther to the west of that Karn city, an area from which the Cyran military had been launching raids for years. King Connos led the Cyran assault personally, and his troops fought with an avenging fury. The Karns were able to stage a delaying action against the Cyran advance at the fortress of Loran Rath, but could do little but slowly retreat. By the end of the summer of 930 YK, Cyre had secured a solid foothold on Karnath's soil north of Scions Sound.

House Deneith's role in the Last War has been widely discussed. Given the demand for mercenary services from the Five Nations, its fortunes soared. Less reported is its role in securing the city of Karrlakton from the ravages of war for the Karnathi Crown. Mindful of House Cannith's own troubles in the Cyran city of Eston, Deneith issued an early proclamation that it would act to "secure and preserve" its home city from any incursions from the other nations. Glad to have the scions of Deneith guarding its largest city and anchoring the southeastern reaches of Scions Sound, Karnath initially supported this decision. Only later, when King Kaius II realized that House Deneith truly meant to keep Karrlakon free from any nation's war effort, including his own, did he regret his father's decision to not assert full Karnathi sovereignty over the city. Still, the Karn king wisely chose not to precipitate a possible civil war within his nation by attempting to occupy and

control the city against Deneith's wishes. No one wished to anger the continent's primary supplier of mercenary troops, or challenge the stout defenses of the Sentinel House's home.

Taking advantage of Karnath's distractions with internal politics and the avenging Cyran offensive, Aundair's troops stepped up their own operations east of the city of Rekkenmark. Though these offensives were mostly large-scale raids aimed at supplementing the trickle of supplies crossing Scions Sound by foraging from Karnathi villages as far east as the Karrn River, they tied down Karnathi troops that could have reinforced the southern front against Cyre.

With the Karrns pressed on two sides and internally divided, their incredible toughness as a people once again came to their rescue. By slowly falling back and extracting a bloody price for every mile, the Karrns caused both fronts to rapidly bog down. The Karnathi commanders knew that, in time, the Cyran passion for revenge would cool and the Aundairians' supplies would run out. By mid-autumn of 930 YK, the Aundairian and Cyran offensives in Karnath had ceased all forward movement, and all the players settled in to weather the harsh Karnathi winter. All knew this was a temporary truce and immediately began refitting their armies and rebuilding their fortifications. Even so, this informal armistice on the Karnathi fronts would last nearly five years.

By 934 YK, King Kaius II had carefully purged his army of all the remaining supporters of the rebellious Warlord Kron ir'Wynarn and once again had begun thinking about his nation's long-term war strategy. Although the Aundairian and Cyran presence on Karnathi lands was galling, those enemy forces had shown no inclination to move forward. Kaius II decided that he needed to finally secure his eastern lands. Heavily supported by undead Karnathi troops and marching mostly by night, Karnath's Eastern Star Legion met and defeated a force of Talenta halflings at the Second Battle of the Plains of Talenta. Karnath took a number of notable halfling chieftains hostage, and in this way secured the good behavior of the northern Talenta tribes. It was a policy that Karnath continued throughout the war.

Aundair and Thrane, meanwhile, engaged in pitched battles with each other's forces from the Starpeak Mountains in the north to the Crying Fields in the south along their respective borders. Neither of the two mortal enemies could claim victory when the low-intensity Aundairian siege of Thrane's Drum Keep, near the Blackcap Mountains in the southeastern Eldeen Reaches, was finally lifted. King Boranex of Breland then ordered the newly completed mobile fortress of Argonth north to secure the Blackcap Mountains region from both of the other nations. Uncertain exactly which of their forces the Brelish king intended to bring to battle, and unwilling to face a powerful mobile citadel, both Aundair and Thrane's troops retreated from the region, and Thrane abandoned Drum Keep to Breland. Although the cardinals objected to their troops' retreat, in truth Thrane's position in

the far west had been untenable since the town of Cragwar had been lost back to Breland. Aundair reassigned its few military “advisers” north to the Eldeen Reaches and left the area almost completely in the hands of hastily commissioned bandit auxiliaries.

936 YK

The First Siege of Korth

Despite relatively stable battle lines in the north of Karrnath, 936 YK saw a large-scale Cyran raid into Karrnath. The timing was excellent for the Cyrans, as the invasion occurred while Karrnath’s reserves were pushing back Aundair’s troops in the north and mopping up the remaining outposts of halfling tribal resistance in the Talenta Plains. The Cyran raiders discovered a vulnerable point in the Karrnathi Army’s defensive lines in southern Karrnath and surged through. The Cyran invaders encountered little resistance, and urgently requested more troops and supplies from Metrol. Acting nimbly, Cyre’s General Brugeff, Supreme Commander of the Northern Front, rushed to exploit the unexpected breakthrough. Although the fighting was pitched at times, and Karrn troops defended bravely, Cyre’s forces were able to make significant progress in advancing towards the Karrnathi capital city of Korth. Hoping to avoid an extended siege of the city, the Cyran troops immediately assaulted Korth’s walls. This attack might have been successful if the Cyran plot to open the Southgate—leading straight into King Kaius II’s palace—had not been uncovered and stymied by the Order of the Emerald Claw. While Korth’s heaviest defending troops, including a detachment of the Conqueror’s Host—the Karrnathi king’s personal guards—pushed the invaders back, priests of the Blood of Vol magically barred the gate. Thereafter, General Brugeff contented himself with pillaging the Karrnathi countryside for miles in all directions.

Karrn marines from the privateering town of Westhaven staged a daring voyage down Scions Sound to harry Cyran supply lines. Karrnathi relief forces returning from the Talenta Plains and those raised by Kaius II from emergency levies in the Karrn countryside countered the besiegers, denying them the ability to procure food from foraging. Finally, King Kaius II stepped out of the Warlord Kron’s besmirched shadow and showed himself to be a powerful military leader like his father Kaius I, rallying the common folk and personally leading undead legions on night raids against Cyran lines.

In the end, the Cyran forces retreated back from Korth towards Scions Sound. Though the siege of the Karrnathi capital was lifted, Cyran forces continued to hold parts of southern Karrnath until late in 940 YK. Karrnath’s villages suffered greatly through this period, and dark mutterings about the “alliance of Aundair, Cyre, and Thrane” were common in Korth at the time. In fact, Thrane

never actively aided Aundair and Cyre, but by failing to carry out its obligations as an ally and relieve the Karrns in any way, it became a target of popular wrath.

Toward the end of 936 YK, Thrane lost its controversial ruler and the head of the Church of the Silver Flame. After a lingering ailment during which the Keeper of the Flame Kaith Serrain reportedly aged prematurely, the leader of the Church suddenly died. In a relatively brief but extraordinarily momentous reign, Keeper Serrain had given full voice to Thrane's territorial ambitions, wrapping them in the mantle of religious mandate. In a last oddity, like so many that characterized his rule, it was months before the Voice of the Silver Flame spoke about ascension. Not until mid-937 YK was the new Keeper of the Flame, Lavira Tagor, proclaimed.

From a long-term viewpoint, Keeper Tagor's appointment was one of the most important events of the early middle war years. The new Keeper of the Flame fully supported the long-standing Church doctrine of spreading the faith of the Silver Flame across Khorvaire. She also made certain that she curried favor among the nation's theological hard-liners, who so dominated the ruling circles. Still, her approach and dictates were significantly more moderate than Keeper Kaith Serrain's. Keeper Tagor began to emphasize core values of the Church of the Silver Flame—using Thrane's military might to do good, not just win battles. For example, it was during Tagor's reign that the Church officially abandoned its stance that shifters and changelings were the “spawn of evil.” No doubt mindful of the world's legitimate grievances against Thrane, and the dire circumstances of the Purified in other nations, Keeper Tagor began to stress themes of redemption and repentance.

In the end, however, Thrane was surrounded by enemies and ruled by the most militant of the clergy. Widespread internal debate, investigation, or condemnation of its own military and ecclesiastical leaders would have been suicidal. A weakening of the Thrane military or any retreat from the Church's religious fervor would have caused revolt. Keeper Tagor conducted a long and slow battle against Thrane's religious extremism, primarily by countering her predecessor's rigid appointments in the Church hierarchy with much more thoughtful and balanced priests. Her battle for the soul of the Church of the Silver Flame was often a lonely one; in her later years, a formidable proponent of Thrane domination arose in the form of High Cardinal Krozen, a staunch member of the hard-line Puritan faction. Given the forces arrayed against her, and the monumental task of returning the Silver Flame to the good graces of the world, Keeper Lavira Tagor might have been the greatest of the Church's prelates.

937 YK

Introduction of the First Battlefield Constructs

Although crude golems, designed by House Cannith and labeled “warforged,” had served in limited numbers in the Five Nations’ royal guards throughout Khorvair since before the Last War, the first extensive use of arcane constructs in the conflict came in the late 930’s YK. Using designs created in conjunction with a college of wizards called the Order of the Pure that was loyal to the Church of the Silver Flame and referred to themselves as silver pyromancers, House Cannith pushed forward with a project first proposed decades before by King Thalin of Thrane: a mechanical horse. In 937, the dragonmarked House of Making began large-scale manufacturing on the construct steeds. Late the next year, the clockwork steeds were numerous enough that the Knights of Thrane could conduct the famous “Clockwork Charge” on the backs of perfectly obedient mechanical steeds. The larger conflict in which the clockwork horses were first used, the Battle of Marsden Field, was not especially memorable—Thrane held the field against a small Cyran army that landed by sea near the small Thrane city of Aruldusk on Scions Sound. The charge, however, was remarkable. The Thrane riders’ attack order held perfect shape against the veteran pikemen of Cyre. The cavalry commanders of Thrane asked for more such warforged steeds, but the Thrane nobles and riding priests disdained them as “contrivances” and “unnatural to the way of war.” Thrane had other interests than lining the pockets of House Cannith.

Cyre, on the other hand, quickly grasped the value of clockwork steeds. The nation’s close ties with House Cannith and a massive investment by the Cyran Crown ensured that significant numbers of Cyran cavalry would soon benefit from these wondrous constructs. More important, a seed had been planted among the artificers and smiths of House Cannith. Years of experimentation followed, and enormous sums were consumed in a search to create even more wondrous mechanical warriors.

939–946 YK

Reprisals and Revisions

“Few wars pass from triumph to triumph. Persistence even in the face of soul-crushing defeat is the mark of a true conqueror.”

—*Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

Over time, the flashpoints of combat in the Last War grew familiar: The Crying Fields between Thrane and Aundair, the town of Cragwar between Aundair and Breland, the city of Eston

between Cyre and Thrane, the town of Vathirond between Breland, Cyre and Thrane, and the city of Korth between Karnath and each of its enemies were all venues for repeated engagements between the contending nations. In the north of Khorvaire, Aundair and Thrane traded quite a bit of territory back and forth while Karnath mostly engaged with Cyre. In the south, Breland, Cyre, and Thrane often shifted alliances one against the other depending on the circumstances of the moment.

939 YK

The Second Siege of Korth

Emboldened by Cyre's continuing occupation of southern Karnath and believing that King Kaius II's attention remained focused there, Aundair launched a massive raid into western Karnath. Surprised by the lack of initial resistance, Aundairian advance units actually moved within sight of the walls of the Karnns' capital city of Korth and set up camp. Both sides prepared for a siege, but it proved to be more anticipation than action. Aundair's supply lines remained too tenuous to support extended offensive operations so deep into Karnath. The two sides settled into a relatively peaceful siege during the winter of 939 YK, but once the weather cleared and Karnathi forces began gathering in the spring of 940 YK, Aundair withdrew its troops back to the occupied portion of western Karnath. The citizens of Korth still refer to this time as "the Short Siege."

A second reason for Aundair's retreat was an uneasy succession. In the Aundairian capital of Fairhaven, Crown Prince Aarott had reached the age of maturity, and he and his supporters began to prepare for his coronation. Regent Marlex initially balked at losing the reins of power. Quite a bit of political machination accompanied the removal of the regent in 940 YK and King Aarott's crowning as the monarch of Aundair the next year. To this day, the Aundairian monarchy has not forgotten the role intrigue played in securing its power and the Aundairian Crown has come to rely on a powerful spy service, the Royal Eyes of Aundair, as a result.

942 YK

The Third Battle of the Talenta Plains

In a combat freed from the nearly immobile battle lines found along Scions Sound, Cyran and Karnathi forces clashed in the Plains of Talenta. The site of the battle was a hundred miles southeast of the western Karnathi town of Vulyar. Some 900 Cyran heavy cavalry rode clockwork steeds, and the Oak and Ash Regiment added 400 heavy infantry. Cyran King Connos' forces also featured superior arcane might in the form of two companies of the First Metrol Wands (including a young Shaladra Antarielle, later a famous Cyran traitor), as well as 3,500 mercenary elf Valaes Tairn

archer/skirmishers and the 2,000 light cavalry of the Kalazar Horse Brigade. In addition, the Making First Legion, the Making Fourth Legion, and the Saerun Pike were all present, adding 7,000 infantry to a Cyran army totaling roughly 15,000 troops. The Karnathi forces were more numerous, including the First and Second Atur Legion (3,000 skeletons and 3,000 zombies), 4,000 displaced Rekkenmark crossbows (2,000 of them undead), and the 8,500 soldiers of the Korth and Vedykar heavy infantry. The heavy cavalry numbered 1,800, including bone knight regiments from the Order of the Onyx Skull and the Order of the Emerald Claw, as well as an undead heavy cavalry force, the City of Night Regiment. In total, Karnath brought more than 20,000 troops to the battle. Its most valuable force was a group of Talentan halfling scouts who called themselves the Thunder Riders.

Cyre knew that its infantry, even with excellent wand and archer support, could not withstand the shock troops of the heavily armored Karnathi bone knight cavalry. King Connos' Cyran troops chose their ground carefully, dug a magically disguised trench, and made clever use of arcane illusions to draw their opponents out. In the morning, the plan went, the Karnathi cavalry would see the weak formation of Cyran infantry in the center and charge. Instead, the horses would fall into a leg-shattering pit half a mile long.

Cyre's plan unraveled when one of the halfling Thunder Riders tumbled into the trench while scouting perilously close to the Cyran lines. He returned to the scout camp and reported his finding. An enormous debate erupted among the Talenta tribesmen. Some halflings urged silence. Others insisted that the Karnathi overlords who held their leaders hostage to compel their service should be punished. The majority, however, reasoned that since the pit would destroy the Karnathi mounts, the Cyran trick was dishonorable and evil—few things have more value to Talenta halflings than livestock, whether reptilian like their thunder lizard mounts or equine. So the Karrns were warned, and the next morning, the cavalry charged the flanks while Karnathi skeletons and zombies fought through the trench.

The fight was vicious. Even though they avoided the trap, the Karnathi army failed to rout the Cyrans. The elven Valaes Tairn mercenaries, in particular, caused havoc wherever they rode, their skirmishing speed and aggression more than making up for their lighter armor and weapons. The elves devastated the Rekkenmark crossbows at one point, throwing the Karnathi flank into confusion and preventing the Order of the Onyx Skull from fully exploiting its advance. In the end, the Cyran lines were forced back, but they did not break.

The following day, the pattern was repeated, with Cyran pike and wands holding up the Karnathi heavy cavalry and infantry. On the third day, the Karnathi undead and bone knights

attempted to bypass the Cyran forces by marching through the night, but Cyran mounted scouts noticed the movement and countermaneuvered. Rather than attack against prepared forces, the Karnathi troops set up defensively. The Cyrans, already tired, declined to engage, and both armies withdrew.

Cyre's triumph in facing down a superior force through superior tactics and generalship was soon dashed. King Connos had fallen in the battle—a fact that was hidden from all but his closest supporters (His page, a lad named Marson, wore the king's helm and armor on the third day of the battle). The Cyran march back to Metrol became a funeral procession as word spread of the battle's cost. King Connos was succeeded by his eldest daughter, Dannel, who was just seventeen years old when she was crowned. Initially, Queen Dannel's power extended only to the great cities of Cyre: Eston, Metrol, Kalazart, and Making. The other great domains of Cyre were held by the proud and powerful dukes and duchesses of the realm, many of whom were dismayed at the placement of a youth on the throne at such a dire time. As a result, the succession was not a smooth one, and Cyre almost splintered into civil war between nobles contending for the throne. Still, Queen Dannel proved tougher than anyone expected, and in less than two years, the wayward dukes and duchesses were bound to her in the Oath of Making, a ceremony that reunified the fracturing kingdom.

Like the former Keeper of the Flame Kaith Serrain, Queen Dannel is one of the most important and tragic figures of the Last War. Elevated to power at a tender age, she shone in her early years—displaying diplomatic skills beyond her years. She was also celebrated as the embodiment of Cyran artistic skill and cultural appreciation: The queen was an accomplished musician, poet, and debater. In a more peaceful time, she might have become Cyre's greatest leader. But because she was faced with the unspeakable and continuous horrors of war, her passion and sensitivity nearly destroyed her. On more than one occasion, the queen retreated into stark depressions, leaving her nation adrift without strong leadership. These periods of despairing inactivity contrasted sharply with Dannel's manic resolve during her brighter times. Cyre's fortunes during the remainder of the war clearly ebbed and flowed with the mental stability of its queen.

In the west, Aundair held steady against Karnath and continued to push forward against Thrane. In 944 YK, Aundair captured the Thrane city of Lathleer without great violence, using a powerful stone-shaking spell to destroy the city gates and then demanding the city's honorable surrender. The citizens of Lathleer, cowed by the flashy display of Aundairian arcane might, chose to surrender the city on good terms. Aundair treated the citizens well from the beginning, though a few reports claimed that the citizens were enchanted into compliance. That same year, the Aundairian wizard Kaldor Ravalon, a devout but secret worshiper of the Silver Flame, defected from the Arcane

Guards of Fairhaven to join the Temple Guards of Flamekeep. At first, his defection was little noticed, but over the following years he shared his expertise in animating vessels, shaping soul containers, and infusing metals, and in this way he helped Thrane's silver pyromancer and House Cannith magewrights devise the silvereye marauder (*Five Nations* 155), a magical construct in the shape of a powerful animal that proved to be a mighty engine of destruction alongside Thrane's armies. Two years later, in 946 YK, the first packs of silvereye marauders were unleashed against Thrane's enemies. Others were built to guard the churches and cathedrals of the Silver Flame.

In 945 YK, Daslin ir'Wynarn, the Blood Prince of Thrane, died in his sleep at his hunting lodge. His son Erivon ir'Wynarn became the new Blood Prince, but like Daslin possessed no real power in a nation ruled by the Church of the Silver Flame. Erivon, however, soon proved himself a more active figurehead than his father, accepting a commission as a captain in the Knights of Thrane. Confirming Thrane's occupation of the city of Thaliost, Prince Erivon built a royal estate on cliffs overlooking Scions Sound, christening it Silvercliff Castle. The Blood Prince's first campaign began in 946 YK, leading Thrane's troops in the Fourth Siege of Eston, a Thrane action against that Cyran city that would last for four years, ending unsuccessfully in 950 YK.

947–963 YK

Old Battlefields and New Combatants

An ally is only as uncompromising as the circumstances that compel it to fight. Prepare well for the day when friends become enemies.

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

After fifty years of near-continuous war, all of the Five Nations were bloodied and depleted, but none was defeated. Every nation's economy was now fully committed to wartime production. The militaries had become expert at training new units, adapting to new tactics, and incorporating new equipment. With periodic breaks in pitched combat, the officers of each nation's forces found that they could sustain the war far longer than they had previously imagined. Furthermore, with each passing year, battlefield wrongs and atrocities committed by each of the combatants mounted, and revenge became a self-propagating reason for continuing the great conflict. Like their weapons, the Five Nations had been tempered by fire and honed to a keen edge.

947–952 YK

The Cauldron in the West

During the late 940's YK, the battle lines and borders around the large town of Vathirond in eastern Breland, an area that became known as the Cauldron, changed constantly. Most of these lands had been Brelish before the war, but that nation had been pushed away from Scions Sound for so long that it sought only to maintain a more or less secure hold on the fortress in its western territories known as Lurching Tower. Cyre was too involved with repelling the Thrane siege of Eston and farther north against Karnath to do more than contain Thrane's expansion west of the Cyran town of Kalazart.

In 947 YK, Thrane conducted a campaign of plunder throughout the Cauldron. Monasteries, libraries, treasuries, and merchant counting houses were systematically looted, their treasures "restored" to homes and churches in the Thrane settlements of Sigilstar, Aruldusk, and Flamekeep. Although Keeper of the Flame Tagor praised the efforts to secure these religious artifacts, her "blessing" before the campaign was far less strident than those of her predecessors, and she cautioned against religious excesses on the battlefield.

In 948 YK, the Cyran lords based in Kalazart and Saerun decided that the Thranes' raiding had to be stopped and brought in thousands of Talentan halfling mercenaries. This measure proved quite effective, as the halflings' thunder lizards trampled their way through Thrane's peasant levies. However, in 949 YK, the halflings decided (in their tribal way) that they should march against Thrane to restore their Cyran patron's honor. The halfling mercenaries, mounted on their thunder lizard mounts, overran numerous supply points, pillaged Thrane villages and storehouses as far north as the small village of Lessyk, and generally made nuisances of themselves along the riverlands of Lake Brey. Cyran attempts to unify the small bands of Talentan raiders into a potent military force that could achieve significant territorial gains proved useless.

The halfling raids churned the already bloodied Khorvarien heartlands, but changed little in the way of the Five Nations' borders. In 950 YK, the raiding of the halflings and the commissioning of new Cyran naval vessels based in Scions Sound ultimately made it impossible for Thrane's armies to maintain the Fourth Siege of Eston. Another conclave of the Talentan tribes took place, and the halflings decided that they had succeeded in restoring the balance of honor. They departed Cyre, taking much food and wealth from the countryside around them. Thrane responded to the tribes' departure from its territory by redeploying the Thrane troops from the siege of Eston into the Cauldron. Soldiers of Thrane's Legion of the Pure sacked the eastern Brelish city of Starilaskur and engaged elven Valaes Tairn mercenaries in Breland's employ south of Vathirond.

Farther west, Thrane's troops overran the Brelish town of Cragwar and the fortress of Sword Keep, driving the Brelish troops south to the village of Hatheril. Brelish reinforcements, buttressed by the Manifest Legion, later drove the Thrane out of Starilaskur, but, as had become all too common in the Last War, nothing was really settled. Breland's reversals in the Cauldron and west of Lake Brey resulted from a lack of troops. Thrane caught the southern kingdom as it was focused far to the west. A large Brelish force had crossed Silver Lake into the Eldeen Reaches and occupied the Aundairian towns of Sylbaran, Greenblade, and Erlaskar. Resistance proved to be minimal, primarily coming from the bandits active in the area. Aundairian regulars were nearly nonexistent in the western reaches of their nation, and Aundair's King Aarott had committed his forces far more strongly in the Thrane town of Ghalt on the Aundairian-Thrane border and northwestern Karrnath. A single Brelish army held all three towns on Silver Lake—in some, the soldiers outnumbered the citizens—for several years until Breland voluntarily withdrew from the area in 954 YK because it needed to reconcentrate its forces.

In 951 YK, the armies of Thrane and Breland clashed again at Cragwar and Hatheril. Thrane also moved in force against both the Tower Valiant and Tower Vigilant that guarded the Aundair-Thrane border, seeking to crush Aundair's strongest border defenses. The year-long twin sieges are the subject of a national epic beloved by Aundairians of every station as a reminder of the personal tragedies of war and the greatness of Aundair. A concerted effort led by Aundair's Knights Arcane finally broke the siege during a campaign that came to be known as the End Year Offensive.

The town of Vathirond had the misfortune to be located in the heart of the Cauldron. That the settlement exists at all today is a testament to the diplomacy and flexibility (some say cowardice) of its civic leaders. Long a cosmopolitan crossroads between Breland, Thrane, and Cyre, the town's elders declared it "neutral" when Thrane troops first approached its walls early in the war. The Brelish garrison was asked to depart or convert into neutral "Vathirond Watchers." Vathirond welcomed Thrane, Cyran, or Brelish forces throughout the war, transitioning as necessary to proclaiming its loyalty to the government of its new overlord. Although its open policy rarely prevented hardship among the citizenry, the town's lack of resistance to the constant stream of armies kept it from complete annihilation.

953 YK

The Sack of Westhaven

The First Company of the Sky, an Aundairian dragonhawk squadron on extended patrol over the northern shores of Karrnath, discovered that the Karrns' privateer port of Westhaven was

strangely quiet. No vessels of the Karnathi Navy were berthed, and many of the privateers were absent. The dragonhawk riders quickly led a detachment of Aundairian Navy ships to the harbor a few days later. Striking at night with magical fire, the vessels burned the docks and bombarded the Karnathi shore defenses. In the morning, Aundairian marines invaded, supported by the Stormhome Wands and the dragonhawk riders. They plundered the city, razing it to the ground. Westhaven was left in charred ruins. It would never recover its former status as a privateering harbor, greatly lessening the Karnathi maritime pressure on Aundairian and Thrane naval operations and commerce in Scions Sound.

955 YK

The Battle of the Crying Fields

Though the Crying Fields on the border between Aundair and Thrane had been the site of numerous battles and would be revisited again in the remaining years of the Last War, the battle fought in that terrible place in 955 YK was the most famous. This was the clash that ultimately gave the area its name.

The Thrane legions were formed from 19,000 peasant levy spear and axe infantry, 2,400 heavy cavalry including a company of Flamehand paladins, 1,600 veteran archers of the Third Athandra, and a company of silver pyromancer wizards from the Order of the Pure. With a total strength of 23,000 troops, the Thrane faithful were confident of success. The Aundairians should have been led by General Retief Dekker, but that noble warrior was assassinated on the eve of battle, most likely by House Phiarlan operatives hired by a more unscrupulous Cardinal of the Silver Flame. Command of the Aundairian troops massing in the region was quickly granted to the young Captain of Horse Lord Darro. Although higher-ranking nobles were available, the other officers knew and trusted Lord Darro, and he enjoyed the support of Aundair's King Aarott. The Aundairian order of battle included 400 knight phantoms of the elite Knights Arcane, 2,000 heavy pikemen, 6,000 light infantry including half-elf and centaur troops from the Western (Eldeen) Reaches, 1,600 magewrights of the Arcane Foot, 2,000 veteran artificer-supported crossbowmen, the famous wizard company of the Fairhaven Wands, and ten lances of the King's Regiment of Dragonhawk Riders. In numbers the Aundairian army were no more than 13,000 troops, but in quality they far outshone the largely untrained Thrane peasant levies.

After an hour of maneuvers, spells, and flying arrows, Aundair's mastery over the battle became apparent. Once Thrane's knights and peasant levies had been stung harshly several times by

the Aundairian forces, the Church of the Silver Flame's foot-priests and sacrosancts could no longer hold them in line. The Thrane heavy cavalry began a massed charge directly at the center of the Aundairian line, desperate to come to grips with its foe. The Aundairians outfoxed the Thranes. As crossbows ripped into the knights' charge, an arcane illusion was torn away, revealing that what had seemed to be a line of light infantry was actually the Aundairian heavy pikemen. The pikemen countered the cavalry's charge as dragonhawks flew onto the scene, engaging the Order of the Pure's pyromancers and spreading chaos in the Thranes' ranks. Although their charge was initially stopped, the Thrane heavy cavalry eventually reformed their line alongside with huge numbers of Thrane's levied axemen. At this point, the Flamehand paladins unleashed their silvereye marauders, sending the Silver Flame's arcane constructs after the Aundairian Fairhaven Wands. The loss of the wands led Aundair's right flank to break and then flee the field. Miraculously, at roughly the same time, Thrane's heavy cavalry—mauled and spell-scarred from its encounter with Aundair's units of heavy pike and the magewrights supporting them—also withdrew from the battle. The supporting Thrane axemen could do little but engage in a fighting retreat as their knights fled the field.

At the end of the day, the Aundairians held the field, but only just. Thousands had perished on both sides. After all that bloodshed, hardly an acre of land had changed hands along the borders of Thrane and Aundair. To this day, the slaughtered of the Crying Fields reenact their futile sacrifice at night when the moons rise and the proximity of the Shadowfell leads the ghosts of the fallen to clash once more—and to take out their frustrations on any of the living foolish enough to venture onto the old battlefield.

955 YK

Cardinal Yisek's Defiance

Thrane's casualties in the Cauldron, near the Brelish town of Cragwar, and in the Crying Fields were serious blows to Thrane's military. For the first time since the rise of the theocracy of the Righteous Kingdom movement, real debate arose in the Church of the Silver Flame about Thrane's continued course in the conflict. Cardinal Yisek, a confidant of the Keeper of the Flame and a theological moderate, spoke out against the carnage, claiming that too many lives had been sacrificed for too little gain.

Many of the citizens of Thrane by this time privately agreed that their nation's participation in the Last War had become too costly—it had killed and crippled tens of thousands of young people (no village across Khorvaire was without a monument and at least one armless, legless, or blind veteran). Still, few citizens of Thrane were brave enough to speak out against the continued

conscriptations. This made Cardinal Yisek's strident objections even more powerful; it opened up a subject that had been debated privately for years but rarely addressed at church or in the public square. Now came criticism of the army, its generals, and the Diet of Cardinals. Many Thranes who had lost loved ones appeared at church to light silver flames in support of Yisek. The Church's hardliners, who apparently had prepared for this day of dissent against their war policy, acted swiftly. A number of prominent cardinals, including a majority of the Diet, warned against displaying weakness and unleashing doubt among the populace about the nation's course. Thrane was committed to the war and to using the opportunities afforded by the conflict to spread the glow of the Silver Flame across Khorvaire. Cardinal Yisek and his few supporters were muted by force, and dissension in Thrane's military ranks quelled forcefully.

Although rumors circulated that the Keeper of the Flame held Cardinal Yisek dear, her only statements urged calmness and compromise. Tragically, the internal debate in Thrane was cut short as Breland, Aundair, and Cyre took advantage of its opponent's internal political turmoil. Launching offenses or large raids, the three nations sought to finally end Thrane's participation in the war. Instead, they succeeded only in rallying the Thranes behind the Church's extremists. The wavering citizens saw no option but to renew their devotion and their war effort. Cardinal Yisek left Flamekeep with an escort of the Avenging Hand and traveled south to Vathirond, then by lightning rail to the cosmopolitan metropolis of Sharn in Breland. Already an old man, he was welcomed there as a voice for peace and became an outspoken critic of the war, respected by many—and completely ignored by the nobility and leaders of the Five Nations.

956–959 YK

The Independence of the Eldeen Reaches and Valenar

Other than the long Aundairian siege of the Thrane-held Drum Keep and the nearly unopposed Brelish invasion of the Eldeen towns north of Silver Lake, little of military import had occurred in the forested western reaches of Aundair throughout the Last War. Still, agents of Karnath, the Lhazaar Principalities, and even Breland fomented rebellion in the region. From isolated highwaymen, the difficulties grew to include entire companies of bandits and even bandit armies (one seized and looted the village of Alvirad in 954 YK, and another razed the village of Niern the following year). Neither the Aundairian rangers, the wizards of Arcanix, nor the court of King Aarott far to the east in Fairhaven could spare the troops to root out the bandits. Every petition to the king from the Reaches to “provide safety on our roads and peace in our villages” was answered with stony silence, with suggestions that it was a local matter, or with counterrequests from the

Aundairian Crown for additional troops from the west to send to the eastern front against Thrane and Karnath.

In 956 YK, the Wardens of the Wood, the largest of the Eldeen druidic sects, decided to act to protect the people of the Reaches. They raised troops from the human, centaur, shifter and elf inhabitants of the western reaches, and in a single ruthless season they found and crushed nearly all of the major bandit armies using these forces and the primal power of druidic magic that drew on the power of the Dragon Between herself. Although this act was generally cheered by the Aundairian nobles, a few of the more prescient saw the coming danger and urged the king to dismantle or at least reassign the newly mobilized forces.

That same year of 956 YK, another neglected backwater region of Khorvaire began to assert itself. Claiming domain over “ancestral lands,” an army of elven Valaes Tairn mercenaries from Aerenal made themselves the lords of southern Cyre and declared the newfound sovereignty of the Kingdom of Valenar. The Valaes Tairn’s War Leader Shaeras Vadallia proclaimed himself the new High King of Valenar. The elves renamed the cities, and a number of Aerenal elves were brought in to initiate new construction in the distinct elven style. The humans of the area raised no objection—Metrol was a distant and far-off place. Queen Dannel and her generals decried the Valenar’s betrayal, but could spare no forces to retake the land. Indeed, they could ill afford the loss of the potent elven mercenaries already in their employ. In the end, the new land was not recognized by any of the Five Nations, but no Cyran army marched south to reclaim the territory, and Metrol’s payments to the elf mercenaries continued.

The actions of the Valaes Tairn elves in 956 YK were puzzling. A people devoted to battle, who idolized their ancestors’ struggle against the overwhelming might of the goblins’ Dhakaani Empire, had never displayed much of an interest in holding land on Khorvaire. After declaring the sovereignty of the huge area of southern Cyre that included Valenar, precious few took on even the most fundamental tasks of governance. Indeed, the former human Cyrans who became subjects of the new state of Valenar discovered a degree of independence they had never known before. Some have opined that the Valenar warriors actually sought to instigate an invasion, bringing glorious war to the sweeping plains of Valenar, where they could reenact the struggle of their honored ancestors against the goblins. If so, they must have been sorely disappointed when Cyre refused their bait.

Whatever the true objective, Valenar’s independence resulted in a greater number of Valaes Tairn warclans employing House Deneith to broker mercenary contracts with other nations besides Cyre. Again, more than a few Valenar bands simply roved the Talenta Plains and other places across Khorvaire as a freestanding fighting force, loyal only to their battlelust.

Cyre's quiescence in the face of this revolt was just the latest in a spiraling cycle of weakness. Queen Dannel, frustrated in shepherding her "loyal" dukes and barons in defense of her beleaguered kingdom, distraught about continually sending proud young men and women to die in meaningless battles, and enraged by her troops' inability to halt Thrane's incursions in the Cauldron, had slowly crept toward an emotional precipice. The loss of the southern territories pushed her into deep despair. Cyran military operations became disjointed as word of the queen's affliction spread and Cyran morale decreased. Cyran nobles stood fast in Metrol, Making, and Saerun, but the rest of the country was largely left to fend for itself. The queen's authority declined sharply, and the Cyran people began whispering, quietly or openly, that perhaps a new monarch was needed.

Perhaps emboldened by the success of the Valenar, the Eldeen Reaches declared itself independent of all Aundairian authority in 958 YK. The Wardens of the Wood, under the guidance of the Great Druid Oalian, announced the new nation's neutrality and their intent to serve as the new state's *de facto* leadership. The few remaining representatives of the Aundairian Army and Crown were politely but firmly asked to leave the Reaches. Most marched out; a notable exception was the "Lost Brigade" of Captain Naathen Sandburr. The site of that unit's defiance was near the Eldeen village of Mossmantle, in a place now called the Bloody Glen. None of the 400 light infantry under Captain Sandburr's command survived, and the captain himself was crucified on an ancient oak by the enraged druids and their animal companions.

Unlike Cyre, Aundair did not intend to sit idly by while more than half the kingdom seceded. A military campaign against the Reaches, however, would require significant redeployment of Aundair's military manpower. After years of tenuous occupation, and faced with Karnathi forces newly freed up for combat on the northern front by Cyre's retrenchment, King Aarott finally abandoned the Aundairian foothold in western Karnath. The Aundairian forces withdrew to a new defensive line at the Starpeak Mountains west of Thaliost. During this retreat, perhaps seeking to pacify his enemies, King Aarott renounced Aundair's support for the longstanding Cyran claim to Galifar's throne that had initially prompted Aundair to enter the war and claimed he would now fight only to restore Aundair's pre-war borders.

His military forces consolidated, King Aarott personally led the Aundairian Army of Western Pacification into the Eldeen Reaches in 959 YK. Because Aarott was unable to reposition more than a fair-sized army from the long front with Thrane, and was wholly unschooled in the tactics of forest warfare, his advance quickly bogged down. Still, the king remained in the area, leading raids and rallying defenses against the Eldeen druids', warders' and rangers' vicious guerilla attacks. He vowed

no more Aundairian land would be lost in his lifetime. This promise would prove true, but not as the Aundairian king had hoped.

959 YK

The Battle of Silver Lake

After more than thirty years in power, Breland's King Boranex began to think that his largely defensive approach in the war had left him without a meaningful legacy. He decided that he would bring a Brelish army north into the newly independent Eldeen Reaches, offering protection and a "civilizing" force to the peoples of the forest. With great fanfare, he gathered 2,000 well-trained heavy cavalry, 2,000 dragoons, 7,500 heavy infantry, 500 Brelish Rangers, 4,000 crossbowmen, and two companies of wands, the Wroat Wands and the Sharn Towers, for the invasion. But the newly independent Wardens of the Wood had no interest in trading one uninvolved royal overlord for another. Although pressed by King Aarott of Aundair's campaign of reconquest in the north of the Reaches, the druids called upon the fey denizens of the forest to counter the Brelish on the north shore of Silver Lake in the southern region of the wooded lands. The Eldeen defenders numbered 20 heavy treant shock troops, 300 satyr skirmishers, 900 centaur light cavalry, 3,300 human infantry, 1,200 elf and half-elf archers, and a company of druids who served as the force's "wands."

All told, the Reacher army barely numbered 6,000 troops. Although outnumbered, the Wardens of the Wood zealously guarded their homeland and cunningly outmaneuvered an overconfident and poorly planned Brelish invasion. The Reachers drove the southerners back across Silver Lake. King Boranex was wounded by mageshot and almost captured when his boat capsized in the lake. By shedding his heavy armor, the king remained afloat long enough to reach shore, but he contracted a coughing plague and was taken back to the Brelish capital city of Wroat on a litter. Despite the ministrations of several clerics of the Sovereign Host, the king's illness refused to pass. He would spend the rest of his days in declining health.

Although largely occupied in the Reaches, Aundair took advantage of Brelish and Thrane distractions on other fronts and launched a small but effective strike force south against the depleted Thrane garrison in the town of Cragwar. After a short siege, that settlement fell to Aundair in 959 YK.

961 YK

The Year of New Kings

The year 961 YK was a year of transition in the kingdoms of Aundair, Karnath, and Breland. According to proclamation, King Kaius II died as any Karnathi monarch should—leading his troops. In fact, after fifty years of rallying his people in desperate times, the aged king's body could no longer contain his spirit. One frigid morning in 960 YK, while reviewing his elite Conqueror's Host, Kaius II simply collapsed and breathed his last. Upon his death, the long-cowed Karnathi warlords began to assert themselves once more. Kaius II's son, Prince Jaron, was forced to conduct a royal tour to ensure a smooth transition of power and the continued loyalty of the restive Karn nobles. The king-to-be soon found that the nobles wanted to see a “redirection” of Karnathi ambitions. They despised the nation's largely defensive stance since the triumph at the Cyran capital of Metrol years before. In truth, these sentiments matched Prince Jaron's mindset perfectly. He assured the nobles that, once he was crowned, Karn triumph in the Last War would soon follow. Aundair and Cyre had been beaten back; it was time to retaliate against Thrane's abandonment of their alliance and insults for Karnath's use of undead in the conflict. After his coronation in 961 YK, King Jaron ordered plans for a glorious Karnathi assault on Thrane.

King Aarrott of Aundair died fighting against Reacher raiders in the west. His daughter Crown Princess Barvette took the throne (though she was not formally crowned until 962 YK). The new Queen Barvette avenged her father's death by imprisoning and then executing the ambassadors that the Eldeen Reaches had sent to Aundair's capital of Fairhaven to sue for peace. The new queen launched another series of incursions into the forest realm. These were largely a waste of soldiers and resources, but some territory that Eldeen at first claimed as its own (notably the Duskwood on the eastern side of the Wynarn River) was taken and held by Aundair.

In Breland, the high command received ailing King Boranex's approval for an attempt to retake the rich mines of the town of Cragwar, this time from its new lords in Aundair. Although this would prove to be the only major confrontation between regular Aundairian and Brelish forces during the Last War, the month-long siege featured heavy fighting and much bloodshed. Among the dead were two princes, King Boranex's eldest sons. In the end, the town was taken by Brelish troops and the royal bodies recovered, but the price paid in Brelish morale was high. The entire nation mourned the brothers, and bards soon named them the “Martyrs of Cragwar.” One month later, the bedridden and broken-hearted King Boranex died. Rumors circulated that he had simply lost his will to live.

So it was that the young, brash Prince Boranel was unexpectedly recalled from delving in the gambling hells and ancient crypts of Sharn and told he would be crowned as the new King of Breland. The 961 YK coronation of King Boranel was a swift and simple affair, “as befitted a land at war,” according to the sovereign. The new king immediately plunged into the minutiae of running the war, proving himself every bit his father’s son. With renewed morale, Breland prepared for battle again. King Boranel also showed that his personal losses had not dampened his lust for life. By taking a Cyran as his bride and queen, he proclaimed that love overcame any politics.

961 YK

The Siege of Shadukar

King Jaron of Karrnath was barely six months in power when a Karrnathi army gathered for the promised Thrane assault. After staging maneuvers around the city of Rekkenmark to draw Thrane’s attention, the bulk of the Karrns headed south, crossed through northwestern Cyre (with little opposition), then traversed Scions Sound, landing north of Shadukar in Thrane.

The forced march, which had relied on transporting the Karrn troops across the Sound using soarwood skiffs, took the Thrane city completely by surprise. General Horacht and his Karrnathi troops looted and pillaged the settlement at will. Hundreds of Thrane citizens were massacred and hundreds more died of famine while the Karrns ran rampant through the area. As usual, the corpses of the dead were animated to reinforce the Karrnathi ranks with more undead soldiers. The Church of the Silver Flame sent soldiers and knights from Flamekeep to liberate the city, and the siege of Shadukar began. Thrane’s forces pressed the Karrns hard, but General Horacht proved himself a master of defensive strategy, making Thrane pay dearly for each assault, counter-attacking with sallies against Thrane camps and positions, and using powerful wands and artillery forces to keep the muddy ground between besiegers and the city walls a deadly quagmire.

In the end, Karrnathi forces retreated by water back across Scions Sound when supplies and reinforcements finally grew short in 962 YK. Still, the withdrawal was anything but quiet—General Horacht ordered that Shadukar should be “put to the torch,” after sealing the city gates shut. Although horrific, Horacht’s tactics worked. The Karrn line of withdrawal was mostly unhindered as the Thrane army, by direct order of Keeper Tagor, focused on rescuing the trapped citizens of Shadukar. A Thrane spearhead under the command of Captain Malik Otherro saved many people, but the city fires were too well entrenched—the city was largely destroyed.

In the weeks after the fire, the Knights of Thrane and their cleric allies struggled to destroy the remaining undead and rid the city of its Karrnathi stench, but the damage and loss of life were

staggering. The city never recovered and remained a fire-scarred ruin, and most today believe it is haunted by the ghosts of its burned residents.

Thrane now found itself at war with all four of its neighbors. Even the most fanatical devotee of the Silver Flame realized such a situation was untenable. Unwilling to seek peace with Aundair and unable to make headway with Cyre's despairing queen, the Diet of Cardinals ordered an end to all raids and other Thrane military operations in the south against the Brelish. Thrane diplomats approached the new King Boranel of Breland. The cardinals promised to withdraw Thrane's soldiers from most of eastern Breland, and quickly implemented that redeployment. The new king and the old priests seemed to put their kingdoms' rocky relations behind them as Breland and Thrane pursued a form of *détente*.

962 YK

Zilargo's Alliance

For almost seventy years, a Zil gnome's response when asked about the status of his homeland's relations with any of the Five Nations was predictable: "We are a principality of the Crown of Galifar, and we are the loyal servants of the kings and queens of Galifar." This proclamation meant the gnomes were effectively neutral—a useful status for Cyre, for Breland, and even for Thrane, all of whom paid enormous sums to Zilargo for siege engines, magical devices, elemental-bound armor and weapons, mercenary companies, and other supplies. This materiel was shipped by sea or lightning rail for prompt delivery—and covered by arcane illusion to disguise its true nature.

In 962 YK, however, the Zil mantra changed to "We are loyal allies of the Brelish Crown." To the other nations, Zilargo's alliance with Breland seemed to cement the two nations, providing unending gnomish support for Brelish adventurism, led by the brash new King Boranel. These fears were realized, at least in part, when the gnomes granted Breland the exclusive services of their bound elementals (though of course they still made these services fully available to the dragonmarked houses). This was one of many factors that led the now-awakening Brelish giant to such dominance during the latter years of the war.

There is disagreement even among the gnomes as to why Zilargo's leaders, the infamous Trust, decided to change their tune and formally align themselves with Breland. Some say that the new Brelish king made threats, and the Zils were making too much money to want battles so close to home. Others claim that King Boranel offered astounding sums of cash, and greed overcame them. A few even announce, with all sincerity, that Breland had shown that it was the only human nation of

honor and, as such, deserved Zilargo's support. In the view of many present-day historians, the Zils acted no differently from the Reachers and the Valenar: They declared their independence. Subtle, cunning, and manipulative—in true Zil fashion—the “alliance” reassured Breland (its former master and the only real threat to Zilargo) while breaking from its control. After all, provinces of a country do not ally themselves with their overlord; only equals becomes allies. As for the timing of this move, the recent coronation of a young and inexperienced king in Breland cannot be overlooked. Indeed, Zil intrigue is a wondrous thing.

962–964 YK

Thrane and Karrnath Lock Horns

Thrane's new understanding with Breland secured its southern border, allowing it to turn its attention to avenging the destruction of Shadukar (ironically, a city it did not even possess at the war's start). In 963 YK, warships of the Thrane Navy punched through Karrnath's naval defenses on Scions Sound, reached the Karrn capital of Korth, and began a devastating naval bombardment using *fireballs* heaved from magical catapults. The attack was not without cost—more than half of Thrane's fleet was destroyed.

Later that year, with winter fast approaching, the Karrn Second Legion of Atur left the Crimson Monastery and—under the direct command of the Blood of Vol—struck against the Silver Flame in the Thrane-occupied city of Thaliost. The fighting in and around Thaliost was fierce, with foul and dishonorable practices carried out on both sides. The priests of Vol animated some of the bodies of priests of the Silver Flame, enraging their followers, while the Thranes exsanguinated and burned the bodies of senior Karrnathi commanders, preventing their use by the corpse collectors.

The most telling result of these Thrane–Karrnathi campaigns, aside from the heavy loss of life and materiel, was to reduce the military pressure on Cyre. With neither Thrane nor Karrnath able to mount a major offensive against her nation, Queen Dannel spent this time forming and training new armies, incorporating the first true warforged units into the Cyran Army. These years of quiet, and the enthusiasm of her advisers about the wonderful new living construct warriors crafted by House Cannith, helped bring the queen out of her soul-crushing despair.

Of course, the relief of Cyre from military setbacks was not absolute. In 964 YK, the famous wizard Hara Drosten failed to prevent a massive goblin raid originating in the Seawall Mountains from pillaging the city of Saerun. Although the Cyran Winged Flame returned to drive the assailants away, this key southwest Cyran staging point was overrun and many of its people enslaved and

carried back to the mountains by the goblins. This should have served as a warning of the goblins' intentions, but it was ignored at the time as the isolated actions of "a few bad apples" among the goblin tribes of southeastern Khorvaire. Cyre would come to regret this inattentiveness.

965–979 YK

The Rise of the Warforged

"War often inspires innovation; be certain that advancements in the manner of conducting war accompany advancements in the means of doing so."

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

Although the true warforged figured prominently only in the latter years of the war, Galifar's King Jarot actually ordered the first construct soldiers from House Cannith before his death. These simple golems proved far too reliant on their controllers and thus nearly useless on the battlefield where split-second decision-making and tactical creativity were necessities. By 959 YK, however, House Cannith had succeeded in improving its rudimentary prewar designs and introduced the first warforged titans. The house even managed to ramp up production quickly—twelve in the first year, twenty-three the year after, and forty-seven in 961 YK. These warforged titans were still early and unstable constructs that possessed only rudimentary intelligence, but both Breland and Cyre had the extraordinary sums of money necessary to purchase them, and the desire to work them into their military tactics and formations. The warforged titans' clear advantage compared to the early golem automatons and clockwork steeds was that they required no direct human guidance to operate successfully on the battlefield. They were fully capable of independent operation.

Despite their size, though, the warforged titans were vulnerable to massed troops, particularly Thrane's pike-and-axe heavy infantry. Of the four hundred warforged titans built from 959 to 964 YK, only seventy-nine were still operating in 965 YK. This depletion was partly a function of their experimental form, but House Cannith also noted that the titans were nearly always placed at the hottest and deadliest points of any engagement. Both Breland and Cyre requested that the titans be scaled down and made more reliable. Six years after the creation of the titans, in 965 YK, House Cannith perfected the modern-era warforged, truly sentient and living construct soldiers. Cyre was the first of the Five Nations to invest heavily in the new warriors, and Breland and the others soon followed. House Cannith began selling warforged by the score, by the hundreds, and in the later years of the Last War, by the thousands.

In 967 YK, Thrane sent two armies into Aundair, hoping to conquer Fairhaven. Aundair met the advancing columns, and, though outnumbered, Queen Barvette's troops drove the Thrane

invaders back. Once again, Aundair's greater arcane expertise triumphed over Thrane's numbers, but it felt its losses, particularly among its irreplaceable elite forces, much more keenly than in previous encounters with the champions of the Silver Flame.

In 968 YK, young Prince Brusst of Cyre was born, named after Queen Dannel's grandfather. The queen's joy was short-lived, as Brusst the Younger died unexpectedly in infancy despite all that divine healers and House Jorasco could do. The queen retreated to her chambers once again, and her nation feared another emotional breakdown.

That same year, Thrane followed up its attempted conquest of Fairhaven and attacked Aundair once again at the Crying Fields on the Thrane-Aundair border. Still depleted from its desperate defense of its capital city the year before, Aundair could not hold the line. The Thranes celebrated their hard-fought victory, and Aundairian forces pulled back to the town of Ghalt to nurse their wounds.

As the decade came to a close, the long quiescent south of Khorvaire erupted. In 969 YK, a charismatic hobgoblin tribal leader named Lhesh Haruuc led a long-awaited goblin rebellion against the human nations. In a single season, the goblins took all the lands from the ocean to the Ghaal River, and from the Brelish fortress of Sterngate to Kraken Bay. The Cyran and Brelish folk who lived there were either slaughtered or enslaved as the new nation of Darguun was born in blood and the goblins became determined to reforge the ancient Dhakaani Empire. Many goblins saw this enslavement as just retribution long overdue for the treatment of goblins by humans since their arrival in Khorvaire millennia before. Queen Dannel was still not fully recovered from her young son's death and refused to reassign Cyran troops from the other fronts to beat back the warriors of the Lhesh Haruuc. The Cyrans held the line against the Darguun goblins briefly at the Ghaal River, but then fell back to the town of Lyrenton. Breland's initial reaction to the birth of the goblin nation was far different—and far more bloody.

970 YK

The Battle of Marguul Pass

Darguun's declaration of independence from Cyre caused little concern in Breland. The goblins' treatment of Brelish settlers in eastern Khorvaire was a far different matter—the public demanded retaliation. A number of Brelish nobles and generals, mindful of the trouble caused by the Reachers and the Valenar for their respective former rulers and perhaps sensing an opportunity for Brelish expansion in former Cyran territory without actually engaging Cyran troops, pressed hard for an attack. King Boranel, reluctant to commit troops to an offensive operation outside Brelish borders

and cognizant of the hobgoblins' military prowess from his adventuring days, was ultimately convinced to invade Darguun only after great debate. The Brelish General Staff claimed that a quick strike through Marguul Pass in the Seawall Mountains would shatter the goblins' defenses and allow for the capture of the Lhesh Haruuc's new capital city at Rhukaan Draal. The leaders crowed about the might of the newest and greatest of the Brelish arcane mobile fortresses, Veldarren. Mindful of disquiet among the troops caused by King Boranel's hesitancy to commit to the operation, the Brelish generals convinced him that a display of royal support for the military was necessary. They assured the king that placing the nineteen-year-old Prince Boramil in the fortress would improve morale while keeping him safe and giving him "valuable battle experience."

Other than the mobile fortress Veldarren, Breland's forces included 4,000 archers and crossbowmen, 2,200 infantry, 400 dragoons, and 2,000 veteran heavy infantry, primarily halberdiers, with 300 Brelish Rangers serving as scouts and skirmishers. The Brelish cavalry numbered 400 light horsemen, but much of Marguul Pass was too steep or rocky for effective cavalry operations to be carried out. The Brelish army also brought 40 warforged titans and 800 warforged infantry in what would prove to be the earliest major battle in the war where the warforged were deployed *en masse*. In all, a Brelish army of more than 10,000 soldiers marched up the pass towards the newborn goblin kingdom.

The mobile fortress Veldarren mounted 20 ballistas and fielded the Tower Wands of Sharn, proud General Minyu of the Brelish capital Wroat, Prince Boramil, and the controversial Lady Colonel Urik ir'Rowan, leading the 240 souls of the Ardev dragoons. Still, Veldarren's deployment was more a result of Breland's arrogance and desire for an overwhelming victory of its own in the Last War, rather than of sound military planning. In truth, the mobile fortress was far too large, slow-moving and cumbersome for an engagement in the close confines of a mountain pass. The Brelish would pay dearly for that miscalculation.

The goblin opposition to the Brelish advance into Darguun was neither especially numerous nor well-organized, but it was tenacious. The bugbear general Acthuun commanded 700 heavy infantry, 3,500 irregular infantry, 2,100 ranged troops (mostly goblin shortbow archers and javelineers), a small company of hobgoblin sorcerers and artificers called the Hammerfists, and 800 wolf-riding goblin cavalry. Acthuun's greatest asset was 600 heavy hobgoblin infantry, well disciplined veterans who had served many of the Five Nations during the Last War as mercenaries. Now they fought for their own nation. In all, just over 7,500 newly united Darguun defenders protected the rebel goblin kingdom, and they were much more lightly armed and armored than the Brelish forces.

A traditional standing fight would have been suicide for the Darguul forces, because their ranged troops could not match the skilled Brelish archers and their light infantry would be decimated by Brelish warforged and heavy infantry. Cowing his troops into obedience by the sheer force of his personality, the cunning General Acthuun refused to assault the mobile fortress directly or charge the Brelish columns as they marched east through the confines of Marguul Pass. Instead, the goblins used a series of landslides to close the pass and then set up their forces behind the blockages. Given the massive bulk of the mobile fortress, the Brelish spent more time digging their way out of the rockslides than moving. A pattern was soon established: The Brelish mobile fortress and human troops slowly cleared rubble and advanced up the pass in daylight, then hunkered down at night; the goblins ambushed outlying Brelish patrols and loosed more rockslides in the day, then at night picked off sentries or decimated Brelish troops stranded outside the fortress walls.

Frustrated after days of slow progress, General Minyu ordered a nighttime Brelish advance supported by arcane *everbright* lanterns. The Brelish troops met a solid phalanx of elite hobgoblin heavy infantry a few miles below the top of the pass. The 600 hobgoblins were entrenched in a narrow gorge, and they fought viciously. One on one, they were more than a match for the Brelish heavy foot, their pikes several feet longer, their tower shields heavier, their will stronger. They held the gorge for more than seven hours, until the Brelish found a way onto the cliffs overlooking the gorge and buried them in a landslide.

The next morning the mobile fortress approached the top of the pass, over the bodies of the fallen hobgoblins. Every pilot was needed to steer it through the narrow gap—the mountain walls were mere feet away. Suddenly, it became immobile, and every entrance opened. Either through treachery or superior spellcraft, the goblins' Hammerfist sorcerers had somehow taken control of the mobile fortress' arcane navigation and controls. Bugbears and hobgoblins hidden in shallow caves along the slopes leaped the narrow gaps (in some cases, simply reaching out and grasping the fortress sides) and scaled the walls, swarming over Veldarren. Goblin irregulars and wolf cavalry moved *en masse* to the mobile fortress' open ramps. The Brelish center, almost entirely composed of light troops, simply fell apart in the midst of this unexpected assault. The Brelish heavy infantry, Brelish Rangers, warforged, and cavalry behind the fortress and on its flanks were pinned down by the goblin archers. After a furiously quick assault, the fortress fell to the goblin attackers. The Darguul army seized the ballistas and used the walls and siege engines to cut a swath through the remaining Brelish formations on the ground.

The aftermath of the Battle of Marguul Pass was a chaotic, panicked rout for the surviving Brelish troops. The whole venture was surely the most shameful and costly battle in Brelish military

history. Of the “noble 10,000” who ventured up the pass, only about 1,500 battle-scarred survivors returned to tell the story at the fortress of Sterngate on the western side of Marguul Pass. General Minyu and Prince Boramil were killed in the battle when the goblins swarmed over Veldarren’s walls. Only through desperate and heroic action did Lady Colonel Rowan and her dragoons contain the rout and prevent the Darguuls from spilling into Breland. The mobile fortress was overrun by goblins as the walls cracked and its bulk settled firmly on the ground. Reinforced and entrenched where it rested—at the tightest chokepoint of the pass—Veldarren became a monumental headstone over the buried hobgoblins. From that day forward, Veldarren, renamed Matshuc Zaal, “the Stolen Fortress” in the Goblin tongue, has sealed and guarded Marguul Pass. This surprising victory cemented the Lhesh Haruuc’s claim to power and is a point of great pride throughout Darguun. Stung by the military disaster, Breland abruptly sued for peace, and Darguun’s birth pangs were over.

The depth of King Boranel’s unease about the invasion of Darguun was revealed starkly when details of the fiasco started filtering in. The king’s wrath was terrible, but, for the most part, it was directed at those who convinced him to launch the campaign in the first place, a group of headstrong generals and nobles. More than a few who achieved their positions due to birth, bribe, or bureaucracy were sacked. During the state funeral for his son, King Boranel spoke movingly of the grief he shared with so many Brelish families and publicly accepted full responsibility for the debacle. Echoing long-standing Brelish sentiments of isolationism, Boranel (somewhat foolishly) vowed that no more Brelish blood would be spilled in “foreign entanglements.” When gnomish Zil diplomats approached him about negotiating a peace treaty between Breland and the Lhesh of Darguun, the king agreed.

971 YK

The Third Siege of Korth

Showing some signs of emotional recovery from the death of her son, Queen Dannel ordered a new offensive against the hated Karrns in 971 YK. The Cyran forces, heavily supplemented by new warforged units, once again pushed north and laid siege to the Karrn capital of Korth. It was never a particularly active siege, but rather one intended to strangle Karnath and slowly demoralize the nation, with its new king effectively held prisoner in his own city by Cyran troops. Cyre maintained the siege for nearly two years, and King Jaron never left the city—indeed, he was rarely seen outside the palace, where he consulted with his warlords and fomented strategies to repel the invaders.

In the same year, Aundair’s arcane siege engines pummeled Thrane’s western defenses and destroyed Fort Light on the Aundairian-Thrane border. The retreating Thrane soldiers withdrew and entrenched themselves anew at Sword Keep directly to the south of Fort Light, keeping the

Aundairian troops from sweeping across southern Thrane. A nearly simultaneous Aundairian strike toward the Thrane city of Daskaran in the north across Scions Sound from Thaliost was repelled, and Aundair's advance into northern Thrane was also stalled.

The winter of 972 YK brought a rare cold-weather Cyran assault on the walls of Korth. Cyran troops actually breached the Karrn capital's walls, advanced a short distance into the city proper, and assaulted the Holygate from the inside in an attempt to seize it and throw it open to the full Cyran army waiting outside the walls. The city garrison—the White Lions of Korth— managed to hold the gate long enough for clerics of the Sovereign Host, led by Alinda Roerith, to fuse it shut using divine magic. Meanwhile, the city's defenders quickly converted each noble's solidly built homes into small fortresses, containing the Cyran breach. Eventually the Karrns rallied behind King Jaron, Alinda Roerith, and the Captain of the White Lions, and forced the Cyrans back across the gap in the walls. The Holygate has remained sealed ever since.

The cost of victory was severe: King Jaron's eldest son Prince Drago was killed in battle. The king himself was wounded, but initial reports claimed it was minor. Soon after, Karnath suffered a second shock when it was announced that King Jaron had passed away unexpectedly. The same proclamation revealed that the old king had a newborn son, named after his father Kaius II. This happy news did little to provide the nation with a strong wartime leader, however. Were it not for the Cyrans at Korth's gates, Karnath might have dissolved as the warlords began bickering over who would be regent. As Cyre prepared another attack on the Karrn capital, King Jaron's sister Princess Moranna, a devotee of the Blood of Vol, emerged from the Karrn city of Atur at the head of a new army of undead and began marching east. This news heartened the Karrns, and they were once again able to hold Korth's walls. As Moranna approached the capital city, the Cyrans abandoned the siege. After coming so close to victory, the retreat in 973 YK from Korth was a bitter pill for the Cyrans. Queen Dannel ordered the army to entrench in Cyran territory across Scions Sound

Given her relief of Korth, it was not surprising that Princess Moranna became the Regent of Karnath for the young Kaius III, her nephew, the next year. No sooner had Regent Moranna consolidated her power over the nation than Aundair struck at Karnath by sea. This assault culminated in the Battle of Ten Bombards, a midsummer naval engagement in 974 YK between Aundairian naval vessels, supported by dragonhawk riders and the Fairhaven Wands, against the First Fleet of Korth in Scions Sound. The Aundairian Navy was beaten back, with significant losses on both sides.

974 YK

The Raid on Rekkenmark

By 974 YK, the former allies of Thrane and Karnath were deeply committed to their mutual ideological struggle against one another. Thrane's theocrats railed about Karnath's "undead abominations against nature and tradition" and Karnath despised the "weak-minded priest-worshippers" who followed the Church of the Silver Flame's Council of Cardinals from disaster to disaster. The two kingdoms engaged in pitched and deadly naval clashes, fought back and forth across Scions Sound to the north, raided each other extensively, and aided, when possible, the other's enemies.

This intense rancor resulted in military raids against civilian targets becoming more common between the two powers. In the winter of 974 YK, a force of 50 Thrane wyvernriders flew over Scions Sound by night. Their small numbers and speed kept their approach undetected by the Karn coastal defenses, which were primarily focused on defending against raiding ships from the other side of Scions Sound. The wyvernriders arrived in the gray light before dawn and set to work, dropping their cargo of alchemical firebombs on the Karnathi city of Rekkenmark. The Thrane wyverns were gone by the time dawn became full daylight, though reports claim they roosted on the ruins of the White Arch Bridge to watch their handiwork unfold. The fires caught hold in two areas: the creosote-stained piers of the Rekkenmark harbor, and the wood, grain, wool, and cloth of the warehouse district. The city was nearly overcome by flames as the wind blowing off the Sound fanned the conflagration. Civilian casualties were predictably very high.

The aftermath of the firebombing of Rekkenmark keenly revealed the ongoing political struggles over the course of the war within Thrane's upper echelons. The Thrane Army's explanations that "fire is a divinely sanctioned weapon" and "this was our vengeance for Shadukar" were undermined when Keeper of the Flame Tagor issued a lengthy "letter of regret" to the people of Karnath. Breland, Cyre, Aundair, Zilargo, and even the nobles of the dragonmarked houses responded favorably to the Keeper's words, but warned that if such an assault were repeated, Aundair, Breland, Cyre, and Karnath would unite to burn every city of Thrane to its foundations.

Ultimately, Keeper Tagor used the outcry against the incident to remove several hardline Puritans from positions of influence in her government. Even so, in later years, as the religious extremists began to reassert themselves, the anniversary of the firebombing was declared a national holiday in Thrane—and it is still celebrated to this day. The year 975 YK also saw the sorry remnants of Aundair's Army of Western Pacification retreat east of the Wynarn River from the Eldeen Reaches. The stories those soldiers brought back to Aundair with them included tales of trees

that decapitated comrades, impossibly accurate elven archery, and the deliberate poisoning of springs by the Reacher druids. After their retreat to safer ground, the Aundairian troops quickly recovered their morale but refused to return east. The troops of the Army of Western Pacification significantly bolstered Aundair's efforts in the east and south after their return, but the Eldeen Reaches were basically abandoned by their former mother country after this time.

In 976 YK, Regent Moranna of Karrnath stunned her country by outlawing the Order of the Emerald Claw. Though internal grumbling among the Karrn nobility about the influence of the Emerald Claw had long existed, none had foreseen the regent's seizing of the order's barracks and the arrest of its most active and powerful knights. Some members of the Emerald Claw were imprisoned in Karrnath for years; others were tried, convicted of treason against the Karrn Crown, and executed. This blow against the order reduced the direct influence of the Blood of Vol at the highest levels of Karrnath's aristocracy and enhanced the power of the Karrn monarchy, but the Emerald Claw was far from destroyed. The Lich Queen Vol remained determined to use the cult and its knighthood to take control of Karrnath and use the kingdom to spread her influence across Khorvaire and gain vengeance on the elves of Aerenal and the dragons of Argonessen.

976-980 YK

Thrane's Many Enemies

By 976 YK, Keeper of the Flame Tagor's attempts at moderation sparked a visible backlash within Thrane. The militant Puritans of the Church of the Silver Flame rallied around a zealous crusader—the young and newly-invested Cardinal Krozen. Just as the Keeper launched a campaign to reaffirm the long-standing armistice between Thrane and Breland (in fourteen years, this agreement had been bent on both sides by raids and border skirmishes but it had not been broken) and even offer concessions to win a new peace agreement with largely defensive Cyre, Cardinal Krozen and his Puritan supporters in the Diet of Cardinals quickly quashed the plan, determined to continue their attempts to spread the influence of the Silver Flame across Khorvaire by the sword. A new campaign would be commenced by Thrane against its southern neighbor, breaking the armistice, as the Thrane Army's commanders judged that Breland's military strength had been weakened by its losses in Darguun. Once again, Thrane nationalism and theological rigidity overwhelmed diplomacy, or even common sense.

In 976 YK, the new Thrane offensive pushed south, retaking the buffer zone created by the long armistice with Breland. King Boranel reacted forcefully to this seeming betrayal by Thrane, and rushed north with a Brelish army that included large numbers of newly purchased warforged.

The massed Thranes crossed the Brey River and recaptured the town of Vathirond, but could move no farther southwest against the Brelish defenders. King Boranel, his powerful royal guard, and the Brelish warforged regiments seemed to be everywhere. The losses among the warforged were heavy, but Thrane's army was ultimately forced back beyond the Brelish fortress of the Lurching Tower. The battle is most remembered for the personal bravery of King Boranel, who led his troops from the front and determined to hold the Brelish line against the invaders. In the aftermath of the battle, the king's praise for the warforged soldiers was unalloyed. Those few who survived the battle were assigned to his royal guard, and even more Brelish funds were earmarked for House Cannith's coffers and the product of its creation forges.

In 978 YK, Thrane's attitude towards its foreign policy again changed. The Keeper of the Flame overwhelmed Cardinal Krozen's supporters with new appointments of moderates to the Church's Diet of Cardinals and reclaimed full control of Thrane's government. The Keeper then succeeded in negotiating a delicate alliance between Thrane and Cyre. Although Thrane's armies had pillaged eastern Cyre repeatedly, all Cyrans knew that Karnath was the true evil. The two nations began preparations for a joint attack northwards. Cyre even convinced its former ally Aundair to briefly cease operations against Thrane in the west and aid the joint Thrane-Cyran death blow against Karnath.

Before the invasion of Karnath could be launched, however, the new alliance collapsed. A series of minor Brelish raids and troop movements in the south aimed at Thrane threatened to escalate into a larger conflict. Rather than back down and withdraw against the Brelish aggression, Thrane's militant hardliners demanded that Cyre commit some of its forces to help the Thranes beat back the Brelish advances. But Cyre had no interest in aiding Thrane against its relatively peaceful western neighbor. Queen Dannel's refusal of aid was trumpeted as an unforgivable insult by the most fanatical cardinals of the Church of the Silver Flame. When Thrane's troops, depleted by the shift of personnel to Thaliost in preparation for the invasion of Karnath, were forced to abandon the town of Vathirond to the Brelish and withdraw back north to Arythawn Keep, the Thranes' denunciations against Cyre were exceedingly harsh. Thrane withdrew its diplomats and military planners from the Cyran capital of Metrol and ended the preparations for the joint Cyran-Thrane campaign against Karnath.

Embarrassed by Thrane's abrupt change in stance, Cyre decided to retaliate against its brief ally. A Cyran army, supported by masses of warforged, laid siege to eastern Thrane's Arythawn Keep in 979 YK. Once the gates fell and the keep was theirs, the Cyrans did not specifically order the warforged to stand down. In an extremely unemotional and mechanical manner—fully compliant

with their training—the living constructs massacred the majority of their fleeing Thrane enemies, running them down for miles and taking no prisoners. Cyran apologists later insisted that the warforged units were “designed as overly aggressive” by House Cannith, but the damage to the reputations of both Cyre and all warforged soldiers was severe.

Sensing the Thrane’s weakness in the wake of the Brelish and Cyran attacks, the Karnathi Navy worked feverishly that winter of 979 YK to build additional troop barges. In the early spring of 980 YK, as soon as the weather on Scions Sound cleared, Lord General Vedim ir’Omik led both living and undead Karrn legions back to the Shadukar Peninsula of Thrane. The Karrns overran the Thrane town of Olath and besieged Angwar Keep, a Thrane fortress that lay east of the Burning Wood on the peninsula. Lord General ir’Omik held the area for a year, but the Karrn siege was ultimately unsuccessful. Despite a small garrison, the Thrane had strong walls and plentiful supplies of courage—no doubt buttressed by fear of another Shadukar-like massacre at the hands of the Karrns. In time, the Karrns, unable to maintain their supply lines and reinforcements against the Thrane defenders, declared victory and sailed back to Korth.

All in all, the years of the war up to 980 YK proved that any peace between one of the Five Nations and Thrane was exceedingly fragile. Thrane’s extremists in the Church of the Silver Flame took advantage of this time—and the attacks against their nation—to regroup, reassert themselves politically, and rail against the moderates’ “sentiments of weakness and concession.”

980–992 YK

Breland Riven

Victory can be had by the swift and focused. Absent quick triumph, however, a robust and well-provisioned enemy may overcome a lack of commitment and become a daunting foe.

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

The final full decade of the Last War saw Breland rise to a summit of power and influence, only to tumble to its lowest ebb. The national division and rebellions that had plagued Cyre and Aundair earlier in the conflict would arrive with a vengeance in the south of Khorvaire.

980 YK

Succession and Retrenchment

In late 979 YK, Queen Barvette of Aundair succumbed to a magical illness. Rumors spread that Emerald Claw assassins had stuck again, perhaps hoping to restore their favor with the Karnathi

monarch. In any event, the transition to power of Barvette's daughter in Aundair went forward relatively smoothly, and Queen Aurala was crowned in 980 YK. The new queen of Aundair found herself ruling a nearly ruined country. The sheer attrition of decades of war, plus the lengthy timescales required to train new clerics, magewrights, and other skilled personnel (as well as to raise new dragonhawks) meant that replacing losses was difficult, particularly when compared to Thrane's levied infantry or even the dreaded Karrnathi bone knights. The quality of Aundairian troops and their arcane support was at its lowest ebb at this point in the conflict.

Queen Aurala's desperation was reflected in her initial actions after taking the Aundairian throne. She sent envoys to her enemies, seeking an armistice. The queen tapped her most skilled and intelligent diplomats and instructed them to, at the very least, delay the onset of new hostilities as long as possible. Meanwhile, Aurala contacted the Lhazaar pirate barons, the Valenar elves, and the Talenta halflings about hiring mercenaries from among their numbers. The queen might even have approached the dragons of Argonnessen and the rakshasas and abominations of the Demon Wastes.

Cyre was dismayed when word spread that Queen Aurala had recognized Valenar's independence as a negotiation ploy in securing the Valaes Tairn elves' aid. The actions of Aundair's new monarch achieved the expected results. Over the next several years, Aundairian forces gained the needed time to recover some measure of their morale, expertise, and numbers. The primary cause of Aundair's respite, however, was the nation's cautious generalship. As Cyre, Karrnath, Thrane, and Breland wore out one another with regular assaults and raids, Aundair ceased offensive operations, entrenched, and rebuilt its forces. Aundairian diplomacy mostly bought time—although numerous peace negotiations were started, little was accomplished. In all, Queen Aurala showed herself a wily fox indeed. The “early years of Aurala” are still remembered as a time of relative peace and rebuilding in Aundair.

Perhaps the most enduring alliance of the Last War was that between Aundair and Cyre. From King Wrogar's initial support of Queen Mishann's claim to the throne of Galifar, relations reached a high point when Queen Wrella married Cyran Prince Deggan and bore him a son. Still, the long war years frayed and eventually undermined even this friendship. In 958 YK, King Aarott of Aundair had renounced his support of Cyran ambitions to reunify Galifar under its own leadership. Toward the end of the war, Queen Aurala's recognition of Valenar essentially ended cooperation between the two once friendly kingdoms. Although Aundair sent no troops into battle against Cyre during the Last War, its rejection of all but a handful of Cyran refugees after the Day of Mourning at the war's end showed just how far relations had deteriorated.

982 YK

Thrane's Messengers

The year 982 YK brought major conflict to the south of Khorvaire. Early that summer, Darguuls under the direct command of the hobgoblin Warlord Unndral Ochsesser conducted an ill-advised attempt to seize territory west of the mountains. Marching out by night from Matshuc Zaal, the Stolen Fortress, the goblins hoped to slip unnoticed past Brelish lines. Keen-eyed human Brelish Rangers saw the dispersed goblin army, however, and hurried to warn every Brelish legion from Vathirond to Sharn.

King Boranel rushed from the Brelish capital of Wroat to meet this latest threat from Darguun, and his army met the goblins between the summit of Dragon's Crown and the Faded Forest in eastern Breland. The Darguuls were defeated in a classic pincer attack that collapsed both their flanks and captured hundreds of goblin prisoners. Surprisingly, King Boranel tempered his victory with cunning. Rather than hold the goblins as prisoners of war, or even slaughter them in an act of vengeance for the Battle of Marguul Pass, the Brelish king sent negotiators to the Lhesh Haruuc. Breland offered the return of the Darguul troops in exchange for a secret alliance between Breland and Darguun against Thrane. Boranel's only demand was the removal of Warlord Unndral Ochsesser from his position as the commander of Darguun's armies—a demand that Lhesh Haruuc had little difficulty imposing on the disgraced leader.

Taking advantage of Breland's distraction with Darguun and Aundair's continuing retrenchment, Thrane's forces crossed Scions Sound and launched a massive western offensive against Cyre in the summer of 983 YK. This undertaking was spearheaded by a squad of four angels called the Messengers, divine generals dedicated to the Silver Flame who were believed to have arrived in response to Cyran and Karnathi depredations against Thrane. The angels rallied the Thranes to a degree of religious fervor not seen since the days of the Righteous Kingdom movement, but they demanded far greater discipline—excesses caused by overzealousness would not be tolerated. The Messengers rode at the forefront of four great Thrane armies: the Army of the Ascended, the Righteous Legion, the Legion of True Brethren, and the Army of the Eastern Crusade. Together, these forces totaled over 100,000 soldiers. The Great Eastern Crusade was a smashing success, capturing the city of Eston's valuable iron and adamantine mines (the Cyran city itself and House Cannith's busy creation forges held out, but in a greatly reduced state). The Thranes' legions then seized Kalazart (the city threw open its gates in surrender) and threatened Swoz. Bad weather, long supply lines, and a courageous rear-guard action by Cyre's young General Alvors Brillik forced a halt to Thrane operations until the spring.

During the next campaign season, the Messengers secured mysterious goals of their own, involving large trunks laden with books and other items recovered from the Cyran settlements. The Messengers also recovered certain swords, spears, armor, and chalices that were considered holy relics of the Silver Flame. As a result, on midsummer day 984 YK, the Messengers ordered the four armies to return to Thrane. Despite some resistance from a vocal minority that hoped to occupy Cyran territory permanently, most of the troops turned around and marched back home in time for the harvest. The Legion of True Brethren remained behind to hold the region around Eston until later that winter.

Thrane's retreat from an essentially prostrate Cyre puzzles military historians to this day. Why give up when victory was at hand? Why not hold what was gained? The Messengers never explained, and after they returned to Flamekeep, they vanished forever, back to their planes of origin. The Keeper of the Flame, the Diet of Cardinals, and the Council of Cardinals refused to answer any questions about the incident, waving it off as a "matter of the interests of the faith and state." A few of the more daring nobles and military commanders in Thrane grumble about this withdrawal to this day, and argue that the tragedy of the Mournland would never have occurred if Thrane had simply occupied the Cyran heartland outright.

985–986 YK

Breland Fractures

The celestial Messengers' invasion unnerved Breland, because it showed that Cyre was vulnerable and that Thrane was far stronger militarily than anyone had suspected. In 985 YK, King Boranel called on the Lhesh of Darguun to uphold his secret treaty and join Breland in an invasion of Thrane. Haruuc kept his word, but the shrewd hobgoblin ruler was really just acting in his own interests. In fact, the high warlord of Darguun was entirely pleased to have his nation treated as an equal and sovereign state by one of the major human kingdoms; his followers' support stemmed mostly from promises of plunder.

Supplemented by the goblins, Breland captured the Brey Crossing bridges across the Breland-Thrane border, seized Thrane's Castle Rhonewatch in a night assault, and made long-term plans to hold the region of southern Thrane known as Old Breland; it had once been, after all, Brelish territory only two generations prior. Brelish troops operated mostly during daylight, while the goblins raided at night—and the combination was too much for the Thrane forces. For almost three years, until the Battle of Cairn Hill, Darguun and Breland secured the area.

In 986 YK, a trio of hags known as the Daughters of Sora Kell arrived in far western Breland. Accompanying them was an army of monsters from their former lands near the Demon Wastes. As the hags moved east, countless others joined them. The regiments of trolls, ogres, and gnolls overran human settlements through the area west of the Graywall Mountains; the limited garrison troops of a distracted Breland proved little opposition. Reports even surfaced that detachments of Karnathi troops, living and undead, were openly attacking Brelish positions and fighting beside the hags' monsters.

That same year, King Boranel championed legislation in the Brelish Parliament known as the Warforged Decree, recognizing the warforged as sentient beings and granting them the rights afforded to all Brelish subjects. The law was set to take effect upon the cessation of hostilities between all Five Nations. By emancipating the warforged conditionally, the Decree guaranteed their service for the duration of the war, while providing powerful motivation for them to remain committed to the Brelish cause. As intended, it also attracted warforged from other nations to the Brelish banner.

Finally, 986 YK starkly revealed an independence that had long been poorly concealed. The sea barons of the Lhazaar Principalities, defanged by King Galifar I and relatively tame for centuries, had been awakened by the war. During decades of raiding, pirating, smuggling, and pillaging, the pirate princes had been accepting letters of marque from all sides in the Last War. In 986 YK, however, the powerful Prince Ryger gathered a unified fleet and began to hunt *en masse*. The pirate prince proclaimed himself to be a lost scion of the Wynarn line and proceeded to prove time and again that his ships could match that of any “regular” navy—including the ships of House Lyrandar. By his deeds and words, Ryger showed that Lhazaar would no longer bend the knee to any outsider. From that point on, no body of water in Khorvaire was truly secure from the Lhazaarite pirates.

987 YK

The Battle of Cairn Hill

Breland's high point of the Last War, the occupation of formerly lost lands in Thrane, came to an end in 987 YK at the Battle of Cairn Hill. General Nystrum Shadar of Thrane—later the spymaster of that realm and chief of the Argentum, an organization of the Church of the Silver Flame dedicated to identifying and “recovering” powerful magic items for the faith—defeated Breland and its allied Darguuls on the Fields of Rhone, just south of Cairn Hill in southern Thrane. The Battle of Cairn Hill is remembered both for its size and because it was fought between two veteran and highly decorated armies. As a result, the intense fighting lasted for four days before a result could be determined.

General Shadar's forces included all 1,700 paladins of the Avenging Hand of the Eternal Flame and Cardinal Moctin's Exultant Guards, 1,500 elite heavy infantry. The Thrane order of battle also included 22,000 hardened levy spear and axemen, 4,000 pikemen, 6,500 veteran archers, three companies of the Order of the Pure's silver pyromancer wizards, and an additional 3,300 veteran heavy cavalry. In total, Thrane brought over 38,000 troops to the field.

Breland fielded just as many veterans, including such famous companies as the Grey Geese archers, the Blues & Irons dragoons, and the Roses of Sharn, a company of all-female wands. Their troops also included 600 Brelish Rangers, 2,000 dragoons, 2,900 heavy cavalry, 14,000 light and medium infantry, 2,500 warforged heavy infantry, 6,000 pikemen, 5,200 magewright-supported veteran archers, 3,000 veteran crossbowmen, and 300 Zilargo mercenary wands. The supporting Darguul mercenaries numbered roughly 5,500 light infantry goblins and 2,000 heavily-armed and armored hobgoblins and bugbears. Totaling 44,000 troops, the Brelish army actually outnumbered the Thrane levies—a rare event indeed. King Boranel also dispatched Chydris, the first and most celebrated of Breland's floating mobile fortresses, to the battlefield.

The battle's first day was spent in skirmish, scouting, and the use of wands and archery. These first few clashes were quickly broken up by reinforcements or maneuver. Neither commander seemed ready to commit his troops fully to battle. The second day saw the heavy use of cavalry to strike at perceived weak points in the respective enemies' lines. The third day began well for Breland, with a volley of archery and arcane fire—the latter provided by Chydris, the Zilargo wands, and the Roses of Sharn. The Darguuls acquitted themselves admirably at first, pressing the Thranes' lines. Then word spread that Thrane cavalry, riding hard, was threatening the Darguuls' plunder-laden baggage train. Many of the goblins' irregulars abandoned the battle line to rush in defense of their loot. This spontaneous retreat drew Chydris and the Brelish pikemen out of position to cover their collapsing right flank. Worse, a piloting error caused Chydris to plow into the ground as it attempted to quickly shift position to cover the gap. Thrane's levies, the Exultant Guards heavy infantry, and archers exploited the resulting gaps and succeeded in overrunning the grounded fortress, destroying its delicate control mechanisms and rendering it no more dangerous than a large, hollowed-out rock. The Brelish reserves were required to be committed to the battle just to stave off total collapse.

When the sun set, Thrane's cavalry and paladins had been driven away from the baggage train, but the very last Brelish reserves had been committed. That evening, the Brelish and Darguul sides exchanged bitter words in their camp. Only a desperate "divided we fall" appeal prevented a

mass nighttime abandonment of the field by the goblins. As it was, several thousand goblins disappeared into the dark anyway. The battle continued to the fourth day. The remaining goblins were angry and fought with great spirit, cutting horses out from under Thrane paladins and using oil grenadiers effectively against Thrane pikemen. But it was not enough—the Brelish commanders realized that it had insufficient forces to exploit any gains or address any weaknesses.

Shortly before noon, the order was given for the Brelish and Darguul forces to withdraw from the field. They did so in good order, and, by direct order of the Keeper of the Flame, the forces of Thrane declined to follow. This was later proclaimed a gallant gesture, but many say that Thrane’s army was so badly bloodied and exhausted that pursuit was nearly impossible. Breland tried to paint the Battle of Cairn Hill as a victory based on Thrane’s casualties, but the loss of the mobile fortress of Chydris and the presence of Thrane forces on the field of battle at the end after the Brelish withdrawal belie that claim. The defeated Brelish and Darguul armies retreated to Castle Rhonewatch and later to the fortress of Lurching Tower back in Brelish territory, relinquishing King Boranel’s claim to the lands of Old Breland.

The Battle of Cairn Hill marked Breland’s last large-scale invasion of Thrane territory, and also the end of Brelish cooperation with the Darguuls. During the retreat, goblin slave-takers dragged along chained lines of Thrane peasant “property.” The Brelish demanded that the Darguuls release their human plunder, but they refused to abandon their most valuable chattel. This resulted in a small skirmish between Brelish soldiers and the goblins, often called the Slave Battle. From that point forward, the two armies marched in different directions, but the goblins kept their slaves.

987 YK

Droaam Lost to Breland

The loss of Old Breland was not the only loss of territory King Boranel and Breland suffered at this stage of the Last War. The slow but steady erosion of Breland’s western flank to the monster troops of the Daughters of Sora Kell was becoming critical. The king decided he could no longer defend the western plains. Boranel ordered his Brelish Rangers to escort all human settlers in far western Breland to safety in the east in 987 YK. The bards recount numerous tales of the Rangers’ bravery, but their most fantastic yarns concern King Boranel’s personal defeat of an ogre champion, which allowed the last sizable group of Brelish refugees to escape across the Graywall Mountains. Brelish troops then sealed off the land west of the Graywalls.

With the last of the humans captured, killed, or driven off, the Daughters of Sora Kell proclaimed the birth of the new Kingdom of Droaam in the western Brelish lands. The three hags

extended their claws over every nook and cranny of their new land. Channeling their monstrous troops' bloodlust, the Daughters commissioned House Tharashk to broker mercenary contracts with the Five Nations for the services of their most aggressive humanoid subjects. By the war's end, such monstrous units of ogres, trolls, gnolls, hill giants, minotaurs and even medusas could be found among Cyran and Karnathi forces; Aundair chose to use Droaamite mercenaries regularly in the Eldeen Reaches against the primal forces of the druids.

988 YK

Enemies Shift

In an effort to replace the unreliable goblins as a supplement to its armies, Breland contacted House Cannith about stepping up the delivery of more warforged troops. King Boranel was politely informed that production was running at full capacity and that the majority of the new living construct troops were already pledged to Cyre. Although there had been no true hostilities between Breland and Cyre in decades, this news worried King Boranel. He decided to seek greater help from House Deneith. The house offered Breland the services of a fairly large number of Valenar elves. Better yet, War Leader and Valenar High King Shaeras Vadallia had given his dragonmarked brokers permission to lower the asking price for any kingdom willing to formally recognize Valenar's claims to southern Cyre. King Boranel was sorely tempted by these terms—his treasury was significantly depleted. He rationalized that Cyre had made no move to retake the territory of Valenar and Queen Dannel's statements on the subject remained ambiguous. Furthermore, Cyre's failure to support Breland's aborted efforts in Darguun or its assault on Thrane showed it was no true friend of Breland. After a great debate with his advisers, the adventurer-king agreed to the Valenar's proposal.

Breland's proclamation of recognition for Valenar independence seriously undermined Queen Dannel. High King Vadallia pressed Cyre for a final statement on the issue, using highly inflammatory language. Cyre would not concede Valenar's independence, but it still did not possess the military power to invade the elven state. In the end, several Valenar warclans remained in Cyran service, but the bulk of Vadallia's elite fighters departed to serve the other human kingdoms or simply to defend their own. Brelish–Cyran relations instantly became more tense.

Just as Breland had been forced to address its lost Darguul mercenaries, Cyre now cast about for additional troops. Even as warforged warriors continued to pour out of Eston's creation forges, the Cyran generals knew they needed more, particularly if the Valenar shift signaled a new aggressiveness on Breland's part. In a scheme no doubt motivated by revenge, Cyran negotiators were ordered to secure goblin fighters from House Deneith. Lhesh Haruuc drove a hard bargain—he,

like the elves, wanted national recognition but was mostly unwilling to lower his price. Cyre complained bitterly but ultimately paid. Unwilling to fight Aundair, Cyre, Droaam, and Thrane all at once, King Boranel sought a treaty with one or more of these powers to allow him to concentrate on the conflict with the others. With the loss of the Eldeen Reaches, beleaguered Aundair could offer little in the way of aid to Breland. There could be no quarter with the monsters of Droaam who had seized the far western Brelish frontier. That left Cyre and Thrane as the likely diplomatic targets. Although bloodshed with Thrane was most recent, Cyre's plots were deeply disturbing. When Cyre refused to meet with Brelish negotiators, and Thrane proved more receptive, King Boranel pushed forward with the latter kingdom. It took time, patience, and heavy-handed tactics by both the Brelish king and the Keeper of the Flame to temper the long-standing passions caused on both sides by the battles in the Cauldron and the loss of Old Breland, but diplomacy actually succeeded in this rare instance. An armistice and a pledge of nonhostility was signed between Breland and Thrane with quiet dignity and no small amount of suspicion.

Those Brelish who had supported the peace treaty as a means toward restoring the aristocracy of Thrane to power were well pleased with subsequent events. Erivon ir'Wynarn, Blood Regent of Thrane, died in late 988 YK of a sudden stroke, and his daughter Diani ir'Wynarn succeeded him. Since that time, Blood Regent Diani's pronouncements have been far more supportive of the Keeper of the Flame, and far less of the Diet of Cardinals. More than a few interested observers inside and outside Thrane argue that the Blood Regent could be convinced, if asked by Thrane's nobles and the Church of the Silver Flame, to return to power as Thrane's monarch. Given the statements of High Cardinal Krozen and his extremist supporters among the Church's Puritan faction, that appears highly unlikely. Still, neither Keeper Tagor nor her successor Keeper Jaela Daran ever spoke definitively on the subject.

In 989 YK, an experimental House Lyrandar airship crashed a few miles west of the eastern Thrane city of Daskaran. An unbound fire elemental razed a nearby forest and two villages before Thrane soldiers destroyed it. The apologetic dragonmarked house made reparations by donating funds to Thrane's war chest. Subsequent tests were far more successful, and in 990 YK, the first elemental airships entered full service with House Lyrandar and the Five Nations. They quickly become popular both for reconnaissance and as raiders. Still, their long construction time and high cost meant that their numbers and impact remained limited in the war for several years.

Valenar's elven troops, as likely roving the plains looking for battle as working in the employ of Cyre, attacked and razed Karnath's Fort Bones in the Battle of the Long Night in 990 YK. The

Captain of Corpses, a particularly bloodthirsty Karrn warlord who led the relief column from Fort Zombie, pledged that the elves “and their Cyran paymasters” would regret their actions. For the remainder of the war, the bones of all the elves and humans slain in the area would be used to rebuild the walls of the Karnathi fortress.

990–991 YK

Regent Moranna’s Follies

For nearly a decade, Karnath had engaged in only minor battles against Aundair, Thrane, and Cyre, and small-scale raids in the Eldeen Reaches, Breland, and the Talenta Plains. The Karrn warlords, though their forces were depleted after nearly a century of war, never ceased agitating for glorious conquest and a restoration of Karrn honor. Regent Moranna proved to be a steady, conservative, and effective ruler of Karnath during much of her reign. Over time, however, she seemed to change for the worse. Perhaps it was a response to the pressures of constant war, but she evolved into a creature bent on boosting her own power and increasingly paranoid about her enemies, internal and external. Her growing mental instability led to two enormous Karnathi military blunders in 991 YK. The first involved an audacious and spectacular sea-borne assault. In conjunction with Lhazaarite warships and marines, Karnathi bone knights and undead sailed around the bulk of eastern Khorvaire, attacked the southern shores of Breland and launched an assault on Sharn, the great City of Towers. Initially taken by surprise, the city rallied its formidable defenses, including more than one team of adventurers, and annihilated all but a handful of the Karrn invaders. Although many decried the loss of elite Karnathi forces on an improbably Lhazaar-sponsored adventure, some in Karnath’s military applauded Regent Moranna’s strategic boldness.

Moranna’s next campaign, however, removed all remaining doubt about her fitness to lead her nation. By late 991 YK, Karnath’s treasury had run dry and, wary of wild expenditures such as payments to the pirates of Lhazaar, House Kundarak refused to extend further lines of credit. Furious at the news, Regent Moranna decried “the dwarven conspiracy” and turned her ire against the dwarven Mror Holds. The Third and Fourth Atur Legions and a group of elite night raiders were ordered to seize several of the largest dwarven clan holdings by force. The most aggressive of Moranna’s warlords volunteered their personal guards, and three actually marched with their troops to the Ironroot Mountains in the east. With a core of elite commanders and troops, and a substantial number of tireless undead, the attack might have worked, if Karnath had kept some element of surprise. Moranna incautiously trumpeted her suspicions and plans, however, allowing the dwarves to prepare well. By the end of the year, a good portion of the undead horde had been destroyed, and the

human troops had run out of supplies. Very little of the Karrns' invasion force, and a mere handful of the warlords, returned home.

Her reputation in tatters and her warlords threatening rebellion, Regent Moranna could no longer maintain her control over the nation. Once again in Karrnath's hour of need, a new monarch was brought from hiding, this time ready to assume the throne. It took some time to organize a proper coronation, but in 992 YK, King Kaius III's rule of Karrnath began. None knew that "Kaius III" was actually the vampiric King Kaius I, the founder of modern Karrnath, who had returned from his decades of secret exile searching for a way to weaken the grip of the Blood of Vol over his kingdom. Kaius I was a ruthless ruler who proceeded to turn his granddaughter Moranna into one of his vampiric spawn and who actually had his own great-grandson, the real Kaius III, locked away to rot in the terrible prison of Dreadhold while he re-assumed the throne of Karrnath. The new king displayed remarkable diplomatic acumen by quickly making reparations and restoring Karrnath's ties with the Mror Holds. Kaius III next surprised the nation by marrying Etrigani, an Aereni elf diplomat who had appeared in his court.

The year 991 YK also saw the grim Brelish fort of Orcbone in western Breland become the site of Droaam's first major incursion east of the Graywall Mountains as waves of ogres, trolls and gnolls assaulted the fortifications. Unlike the attacks that had secured the Droaamite heartland from Breland, this assault was not carefully planned or controlled. It might be that it was more restlessness on the part of the monsters than instructions from the hags that inspired the attack. In any event, the Westwind Riders and other Brelish defenders, all veterans of the Eldeen campaigns, were ready. Breland repulsed the Droaamite monsters' march.

992–993 YK

Thrane Embraces New Flames

Thrane had spent long decades debating whether living constructs possessed souls and so truly could be worshipers and obedient to the Keeper of the Flame's authority. As on many other issues, the Diet of Cardinals was split—supporters of the aged Keeper Tagor in favor of inclusion of warforged among those beings capable of worshipping the Silver Flame but unwilling to directly challenge High Cardinal Krozen's hardline opposition.

In 992 YK, the Diet of Cardinals decided that Thrane's need for more troops overshadowed any theological quandary. Its war chest depleted, Thrane somehow gathered the funds to purchase hundreds of warforged soldiers from House Cannith and incorporate them into its armies on an unprecedented scale. At Keeper Tagor's urging, the living constructs were exempt from long-

standing policies requiring all Thrane soldiers to attend Church of the Silver Flame services. Perhaps because their conversions were never forced, many of Thrane's warforged became quite devout worshippers of the Flame.

This shift in warforged treatment, if not Church doctrine, would be the last major event of Keeper Tagor's service. After almost sixty years at the forefront of the Light, the ancient cleric passed away in 993 YK. The Voice of the Silver Flame almost immediately called Jaela Daran as the Thirteenth Keeper of the Flame. As is the case with most new Keepers, the preternaturally self-possessed six-year-old had no difficulty assuming power. She immediately sued for peace with Queen Dannel of Cyre, hoping to repair the breach wrought between Thrane and Cyran relations in the failed alliance against Karnath. Not surprisingly, her overtures were rebuffed. The Cyran queen's generals, led by the bold Alvos Brillik, were convinced that Cyre could destroy Thrane with an overwhelming naval invasion, across Scions Sound, of Flamekeep, the capital of Thrane and the heart of the Church of the Silver Flame's faith.

Cyre's overambitious and unrealistic plans were leaked to Thrane, and they were never executed. Still, Keeper Daran had no counter to High Cardinal Krozen's claim that Cyre remained an active and present danger to Thrane. Queen Dannel remained the sole royal of Khorvaire who regularly asserted her claim to the crown of Galifar and as long as she did so, none of the Five Nations could afford to seek a real peace with Cyre.

994–996 YK

The Death of Cyre and the Day of Mourning

"Once he is shown to be intractable, a wise ruler allows his enemies no means of retreat or surrender. Only utter destruction prevents a foe from rising again."

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

Even before the Day of Mourning, signs and portents of the disaster to come abounded. Unnatural foes appeared on long-bloodied battlefields. Strange mists gathered in the lowlands of Cyre. Odd noises plagued soldiers' sleep. Then, two weeks before the event, many diviners and oracles actually lost their voices or their sight; one of the Prophets of the Tower in Sharn was said to have gone mad. Still, no one understood what was coming until it was far too late.

The Last Battle of the Last War and the Day of Mourning

In mid-994 YK, Cyre launched a deep-strike invasion of Karrnath aimed at the undead-producing crypts of the Karrn city of Atur. Dodging around the House Deneith-protected city of Karrlakton, a large Cyran army conducted a furious assault that left Atur in ruins. Unwilling to get bogged down once again in Karrnath, the Cyran invaders quickly reversed their march and returned home. With a hastily gathered and vengeful army of Karrns at their heels, the Cyran troops crossed over Scions Sound and pulled back towards their capital at Metrol. Significant Karrnathi forces gathered in pursuit, and a sizable conflict began developing in northern Cyre. This left few regular Cyran soldiers to protect Metrol, the Cauldron, and the lands to the south.

Meanwhile, the recent Thrane and Brelish pact remained strong, and skirmishes along their mutual borders had become nearly nonexistent. The two kingdoms stepped up their diplomatic relations and plotted a joint invasion of Cyre. In a measure either of good faith or of brinkmanship, Breland offered the leadership of the planned invasion to King Boranel's renowned warrior-daughter, Princess Borann ir'Wynarn, and Thrane countered by nominating Bishop-Militant Gradon, a close ally and personal friend of High Cardinal Krozen, to lead the joint armies. In the end, both leaders accompanied the invasion forces. Marching south of the usual battlefields in western Cyre, the vanguard of the Brelish–Thrane army quickly overwhelmed Kennrun and surged across northern Darguun. Advance forces reached the place now called the Field of Ruins. There, the invaders paused to await the bulk of their troops before shifting northeast to storm the city of Making. The next day, the main body of Thrane and Brelish forces climbed up through the gullies and gorges to higher ground, and cut the Saerun Road in half some 200 miles southwest of Making. The invaders numbered over 30,000 troops, including 2,000 Crown Knights and other heavy cavalry, 2,000 heavy pikemen, 4,000 regular infantry, and 6,000 peasant levies on the Thrane side. The Brelish army featured 5,000 Brelish First Dragoons of Wroat, 1,500 heavy cavalry, 2,000 heavy infantry (commanded by the renowned warforged Bastion), 3,000 Brelish Rangers and other skirmishers, 2,500 archers, 2,000 Zil gnome wands, and 3,000 Valenar elven cavalry. Through a series of quick hit-and-run maneuvers using the tireless warforged, the vastly outnumbered Cyran defenders gave the impression to the invaders of being a much larger force. This illusion, and the command and control problems it caused between the invading allies, slowed the Brelish–Thrane advance significantly. Given impossible orders to delay and yet preserve as much of their forces as possible, the Cyrans performed brilliantly.

On the second day, Cyran reinforcements from the east made the battle more even. The Cyrans held the road north with an army numbering perhaps 5,000 light infantry and archers, 9,000 heavy infantry veterans (mostly warforged), 2,000 light cavalry, roughly 1,400 untested Jarp hussars and wands, and a detachment of 3,500 hardened Darguul mercenaries. Although outnumbered, the Cyrans were defending familiar terrain. Late in the afternoon, their battle lines were holding, and the outcome of the struggle was still in doubt. Suddenly, the sky caught fire and deep, gray fogs gathered. Generalship, morale, strategy, and tactics—all was useless that day. The conflagration that enveloped the field was so bright that it blinded soldiers on guard duty at Thrane's Angwar Keep—over the horizon and half a continent away. Both sides died equally on the Day of Mourning.

The devastation was not limited to the battlefield on the Saerun Road—what is now the Mournland's Field of Ruins. The rolling hills to the east of the battlefield became a plateau of jagged glass. To the north, a chasm opened in the earth, glowing with a cold purple light. A choking fog erupted in cities across central Cyre, killing every living thing it touched as it expanded to define the current borders of the Mournland. Not all of Cyre's territory were swallowed in the dead-gray mists that now mark what is called the Mournland—parts of Valenar, Darguun, and the Talenta Plains were still under Cyran rule at the time—but Cyre as a nation simply ceased to exist, along with every living thing that lay within its borders on that day. Scant thousands of Cyrans living at the edges of the devastation managed to flee to safety, and Cyrans who were traveling or living abroad at the time were of course spared. Many of these survivors have flocked to eastern Breland in the years since the Mourning, gathering under the banner of Prince Oargev ir'Wynarn, the son of the late Queen Dannel. Oargev was serving as one of Cyre's ambassadors to Breland on the Day of Mourning, and now plays the role of a king in exile in the town of New Cyre that King Boranel allowed to spring up in eastern Breland to house the Cyran refugees.

The response to the Cyrans' plight after the Mourning is one of the greatest indictments of Khorvaire's "humanity." Although some did extend a hand to those in need, war had so hardened the hearts of the citizenry of the remainder of the Five Nations that most Cyran refugees were turned away. Far more perished in the days after the Mourning than should have.

When the extent of the destruction became clear, King Boranel, wracked with guilt about his possible role in the cataclysm, was the first to allow unarmed refugees to pass through his lines. He eventually granted Prince Oargev and his people "temporary" lands south of Starilaskur and west of Kennrun where New Cyre was eventually founded in the shadow of the gray mists that had overrun their homeland. No other nation was as charitable. Keeper of the Flame Jaela Daran spoke movingly about the faithful of the Silver Flame accepting and providing for the dispossessed, and the

substantial aid provided by the Purified since the end of the war has gone some way in helping that Church's reputation, but the hard-liners in Thrane roused the populace with stories of Cyran depredations and kept the bulk of the refugees out. Aundair, Karnath, Zilargo, and Q'barra established small Cyran refugee communities, but again no significant action was taken. The ruthless Valenar elves slaughtered all who approached their lands; the goblins of Darguun were no more forgiving.

996 YK

The Treaty of Thronehold

The armies of all nations halted offensive operations as word of the disaster in Cyre spread. A growing wave of refugees threatened to overwhelm Cyre's neighbors. Although the panic began to subside when the mists halted mysteriously exactly at the former Cyran border, the proud, powerful, ancient nation of Cyre had ceased to exist. These events lifted the diplomatic stalemate, and negotiation by all sides increased significantly. Still, given more than a hundred years of war, even the cataclysmic events in Cyre might not have guaranteed an end to the hostilities. As it turned out, a confluence of circumstances and leaders made peace possible despite the monumental barriers.

King Boranel of Breland, shocked by the devastation and distraught at his daughter's death on the Day of Mourning, greatly desired a pause in the fighting. Keeper Jaela Daran of Thrane exerted as much influence as she could in favor of peace, and High Cardinal Krozen and his supporters did not resist the Keeper's peacemaking efforts this time; in truth, Thrane was militarily spent after the loss of all its troops in the formation of the Mournland. Queen Aurala of Aundair had a long history of skillful diplomacy, and she was anxious to shift the conflict from the fields of battle to the tables of negotiation (where she felt she could dominate). Finally, and most surprisingly, the old nemesis of negotiation—Karnath—turned out to be a strong proponent for peace. The newest ir'Wynarn royal, King Kaius III, advanced a comprehensive plan for the withdrawal of forces and establishment of new boundaries, including the recognition of several of the new independent states. As a measure of his good faith, Kaius III included the former Karnathi holding, the Mror Holds, among those new lands. King Boranel offered the mobile fortress Argonth as a means to ferry diplomats to the various summits, and pledged that all who accepted such transport would be safe from Brelish arms.

Immediately thereafter, the initial group of passengers, a team of Thrane negotiators, were slaughtered in a particularly gruesome manner. As it turned out, this setback actually aided the peace process. The heroic actions of a Brelish King's Citadel investigator and the renowned paladin of the Silver Flame, Sir Valen Kelain, revealed that the responsible parties were war-mongering agitators

from both the Brelish troops assigned to the mobile fortress and the Thrane delegation. These horrific deeds severely undermined the hardline political forces in both nations.

By 996 YK, real peace negotiations had begun at the island of Thronehold, the former capital of Galifar and the site where the Last War had first begun over a century before. Working from Kaius III's proposal, the participants soon agreed to recognize Aundair, Breland, Thrane, Karnath, the Talenta Plains, Zilargo, Q'barra, the Lhazaar Principalities, the Mror Holds, the Eldeen Reaches, Darguun, and Valenar as the twelve sovereign nation-states of Khorvaire. When the question of Cyre arose, Queen Aurala of Aundair gave voice to a widespread sentiment: "Cyre no longer exists." The delegates further reaffirmed House Deneith's role as an international police force through the Sentinel Marshals and granted it full authority to preserve Thronehold with the Throne Wardens. King Boranel's tenacity and charisma led to one minor Brelish victory (no formal recognition of Droaam as an independent nation) and one major provision (the emancipation of the warforged from national ownership and their recognition as sentient beings). King Kaius III's dedication to peace was proved when he continued to exert his considerable force of personality at the peace table, despite a desperate famine that once again struck Karnath that same year. He was later rewarded when both Breland and the Eldeen Reaches offered food from their bountiful harvests to his beleaguered people.

The major disputes at the peace negotiations involved Aundair and Thrane. Queen Aurala demanded the return of the city of Thaliost but was unwilling to concede prewar Thrane lands now safely behind Aundairian towers in the east. Thrane, of course, held the opposite stance. In the end, it was King Boranel who brought the two sides together by first raising the issue of his nation's loss of Old Breland, and then allowing himself to be talked away from its return if Aundair and Thrane essentially agreed to accept the territorial status quo as the basis of the peace. The concessions on all sides were ultimately acknowledgments on paper of what had been true for almost seventy years on the ground.

The peace created by the Treaty of Thronehold in 996 YK was neither universal nor complete. Minor skirmishes and raids continued as the Five Nations slowly demobilized. Thrane and Aundair exchanged harsh words over Thaliost in 997 YK and again in 998 YK. Still, the other nations made it clear they would not support Aundair, and Queen Aurala backed down both times. By 998 YK, peace had been established, though it was far from secure.

The Aftermath of the Last War

“The most important wartime preparations occur during the cessation of hostilities. War—the ultimate pursuit of a people—never entirely ends.”

— *Analects of War* by Karrn the Conqueror

The empire of Galifar was finally and truly gone with the signing of the Treaty of Thronehold in 996 YK, some two years ago. What would replace it was up to the new nations birthed in the Last War. The blade of Galifar, soundly shattered, will most likely never be reforged. Each of the Five Nations lost much, and none could point to any truly meaningful gain from all the years of sacrifice and bloodshed. Still, each state appeared to be laying the groundwork for the next great conflict. Whether such preparations precipitated a new conflagration, as happened in the late 800’s YK, or allowed for a lasting peace depends on the lessons learned in the forge of war.

One hopes that the Last War taught all nations that continent-wide bloodshed solves no problems. It is far easier to identify the losers of that great crisis than it is to claim any winners.

Karnath began the war unified and strong. It had the greatest military tradition and the most renowned warriors. Its territorial losses in the war were minor compared to other nations, but the independence of the Mror Holds and the Talenta Plains did deprive it of significant natural resources. The most important change was in the nation’s soul. By abandoning itself, at least initially, to the Blood of Vol and the Order of the Emerald Claw, Karnath bathed in necromancy. Its greatest triumphs on the battlefield did little to enhance its military tradition since they were, in part, due to massed undead and more often than not followed by horrific pillage and slaughter. Karnath’s postwar challenge is to restore its tarnished honor.

Prewar Thrane boasted a massive population and an abundance of fertile land to support it. During the war, it claimed divine guidance through the Church of the Silver Flame. Tragically, its faith and its plenty inspired it to the summit of folly. The religious fervor that swept Keeper Kaith Serrain into power featured rigid intolerance and inspired absurd, blood-soaked aggression. In the end, Keeper of the Flame Jaela Daran has followed her predecessor in returning the Church of the Silver Flame to its strong but compassionate ideals. Still, Thrane’s war effort starkly illustrated the dark side of religious fanaticism. Its actions, up to and including the rejection of Cyran refugees, have placed a gloom on the Silver Flame that might never be overcome.

Aundair was devastated by the war. More than half of its prewar territories were lost when the Eldeen Reaches seceded and Thrane took the city of Thaliost. Its conquests in western Karnath were

erased by war's end, and its vicious depredations in the south against Breland and Thrane soiled its reputation. From a bright and shining example of spirit, skill, and arcane prowess, Aundair was beaten down until it was forced to rely in the main on intrigue and diplomacy to secure its independence and national interests. The addition of lands east of Lake Galifar to the nation are some comfort, but Aundair knows that its lack of natural resources render it outmatched in any future war of attrition. Though Aundairians of every stripe grieve and agitate for the lost city of Thaliost, they can do little to redress this grievance.

Breland largely considered itself a land apart at the beginning of the war, and it maintained that attitude nearly throughout. Although a great champion of individual rights and national honor, Breland bestirred itself to action only infrequently, even in the face of depredations by the other nations. It also proved an unreliable ally, switching sides between Thrane and Cyre throughout the war. Most tragically, the war might have visited on King Boranel the affliction of his father—a broken heart. He grieves for his lost children, and he cannot shake the thought that his army's massive push against Cyre could have been the principal trigger of the Day of Mourning. Given questions surrounding the aged King Boranel's succession, Brelish isolationism has again become fashionable.

As for the light and beauty that was Cyre, all was lost. The shattered kingdom remains only as a hope and a dream in countless displaced refugees, scratching out a living in foreign lands. They are, at best, tolerated, and realize that they can find acceptance in their new homes only by abandoning their heritage. Unadulterated pride on the part of Cyre no doubt prolonged the war, raising continual fears about its monarch's claim to the throne of the lost Kingdom of Galifar. Still, Cyre's claims to rule Galifar were no more outlandish than others, and bore the sanction of over eight hundred years of tradition and precedent. Moreover, Cyran actions during the war rarely dragged that nation's honor through the mire, as was the case with many others. With so much lost and so little to call its own, Cyre's survivors are essentially ignored by the surviving kingdoms of Khorvaire in their games of politics and intrigue. That might ultimately prove their greatest mistake in the days to come.

A Gazeteer of the Five Nations

Aundair¹¹



Information based on census ordered by royal decree, 997 YK.

Population: 2 million

Area: 560,000 square miles

Sovereign: Queen Aurala ir’Wynarn, heir to Galifar and Regent of the Brightest Realm

Capital: Fairhaven

Major Cities: Passage, Stormhome

Climate: Temperate

Highest Point: Mount Colieris in the Starpeak Range, elevation 16,112 feet

Heraldry: The head and wings of a dragonhawk, on a field of blue, beneath the tome of knowledge and grains of unending wheat

Founder: Wrogar, fourth scion of King Jarot

National Motto: “What we sow in effort, we harvest in good fortune.”

Espionage Service: Royal Eyes of Aundair

Aundair is a land of earth and sky. On the ground, common folk plow fields and raise crops, toiling to make the land’s villages and communities thrive. The nation’s fields and vineyards are among the most bountiful in all Khorvaire, tended by the same families for generations. Although the

¹¹ In 894 YK, when the Kingdom of Galifar collapsed and each Wynarn scion declared his or her nation to be a sovereign and independent country, Wrogar, fourth scion of Jarot, reluctantly declared himself King of Aundair.

Date

892–920 YK
921–923 YK
923–940 YK
941–961 YK
962–979 YK
980 YK–Present

Monarch

Wrogar (declared king in 894 YK)
Wrella
Marlex [regent]
Aarott
Barvette
Aurala

nation's largest cities attract traders and adventurers from across the continent, most of its citizens live a simple, rural existence. Yet for all their earthy wisdom, idealists inspire the citizens of Aundair, including the nation's arcane mages. Cynics scoff that powerful wizards act as the power behind the throne of Queen Aurala, but there is little evidence that the arcane has an undue influence on the Crown. While the nation utilizes master mages for its defense, the common folk are quite capable of defending themselves. They are steadfast, trusting to what they know, what they can make, and what they can defend by themselves. The trials of the last century have only strengthened their resolve. Without magic, the average Aundairian works long and hard to succeed. With it, she is even stronger.

While the kingdom has orders of knighthood, militias drafted from the common folk bolster its standing armies. This is as much out of tradition as necessity—large and extended families are common, and any threat of danger can bring distant relations running to help. When war looms, young men and women gather in the fields to train with simple and martial weapons. Like a thunderstorm rolling across the plains, a noble's call to battle can marshal armies overnight, mustering commoners willing to fight and die for their land and queen.

When the martial wizards of Arcanix, the Starpeaks Academy, and other secluded schools emerge from their studies, their combined force is undeniable. Enemy tacticians can prepare for an assault against an Aundairian army, but predicting the ways of wizards is far more difficult. To this day, wizards, sorcerers, magewrights, and artificers are held in high esteem.

The influence of wizardry and sorcery has fostered respect for intellect and wit in Aundair. From commoners to kings, most Aundairians have strong opinions and enjoy a spirited debate. A typical peasant may possess an encyclopedic knowledge of local and natural lore, while a lord or lady can often regale listeners with local history. Although labor offers its own rewards, the average Aundairian believes that intellect and dedication can overcome nearly any problem. Magic merely empowers and exemplifies these traits. In fact, respect for quick wits and intellectual discipline may very well be one of the reasons so many talented wizards come from this land.

Aundair, the land of wizards in floating castles, ivy-covered universities, fragrant vineyards, and golden wheat fields, struggles to reclaim past glories in the wake of the Last War. The nation is not what it once was, having lost land and people to the Eldeen Reaches while trading territory with Thrane. Still, it is a proud land, full of proud people, led by a proud and ambitious queen. The common folk of this largely agrarian country stand fast to defend their land, valuing wit and bravado and demonstrating a powerful connection to knowledge and magic.

Before there was a Galifar, the human settlement that would eventually become Aundair grew up along the northwestern shore of Scions Sound, in the approximate location of the modern-day city

of Thaliost. In fact, that city carries the original name of the nation as a reminder of its beginnings. It was not until later, as the nation spread to the west, that Fairhaven became its capital.

Today, Aundair holds a long sliver of land that stretches from the Eldeen Bay and Scions Sound to the Blackcaps in the south, and is bordered on the west by the Wynarn River. The eastern border is harder to identify, and is hotly disputed with Thrane.

Aundair spent most of the Last War in battles against Karrnath and Thrane, and those nations remain rivals to this day. The Treaty of Thronehold established Scions Sound as the border between Aundair and Karrnath, and the two nations eye each other warily over coastlines that bristle with defenses. At any given time, most of the Aundairian Navy's flotillas are patrolling Scions Sound and Eldeen Bay, keeping a close eye on their Karrnathi counterparts. Aundairians keenly feel the loss of the Thaliost region in the east, which wound up in Thrane's hands after the Treaty of Thronehold. Many Aundairians mutter that Thaliost is "Aundair's by heritage" and believe that Queen Aurala's diplomats capitulated too easily. Other Aundairians point out that Thrane's Army of the Northern Crusade was camped in Thaliost when the treaty was signed (and have been in control of the region, for the most part, since 977 YK), so it is not surprising that Thrane wound up with this chunk of land. Aundair would very much like to reclaim Thaliost—through either diplomatic or military means.

The loss of territory on the western border also continues to haunt Aundair and its leaders. Forty years ago, the nation lost two-thirds of its land mass and a fifth of its people when the Eldeen Reaches declared independence. Periodic efforts during the Last War to reclaim "Western Aundair" met with bloody failure, and a low-intensity guerrilla war still wages between the Aundairian Army's border garrisons and the people of the Eldeen Reaches.

Despite the loss of territory, Aundair has strengths that match its strategic ambitions. Aundair's army and navy are slowly rebuilding from their low point at the end of the war, and periodic saber-rattling about "liberating Thaliost" ensures a steady stream of young recruits. The Arcane Congress provides the country with access to arcane magic that often exceeds that available anywhere outside the dragonmarked houses. Moreso than any other nation, Aundair integrates arcane magic into its military efforts—from the spell-flinging sorcerer attached to an infantry squad and the artificer-built arcane weaponry, to the summoned creatures and earthshaking spells of mighty wizards. This arcane potency is enough to make any enemy think twice before clashing with Aundair.

Bolstered by the magical might of the Arcane Congress, the military forces of Aundair are far more than a ragtag militia of farmers. The common troops are better trained—and far more determined—than their enemies usually give them credit for. Put together, the Knights Arcane and the diehard foot soldiers of Aundair remain a significant military force to be reckoned with.

Aundairians are prone to claim that they would never have given up fighting the war had it not been for the Treaty of Thronehold, asserting that the war would certainly have been theirs by virtue of grim determination if nothing else. “Queen Aurala may have surrendered,” they are apt to say, “but my neighbors and I would have fought to the death to defend our lands.” Indeed, none of the Five Nations seems as eager to reawaken the war as Aundair. The loss of the Thaliost region to Thrane and the Eldeen Reaches remain a bitter blow, and many Aundairians long to see their nation reclaim what they see as rightly theirs.

The military forces of Aundair are concentrated in small, mobile units designed to get where they could be most effective, strike fast and hard, and get out alive. The cavalry units of Aundair are more like mounted infantry—ready to deal one good blow with a spear or lance from horseback, then dismount to fight on foot before remounting to retreat or move to another area of the battlefield. The knight phantoms (see below) are the epitome of this idea, using magical *phantom steeds* to travel with amazing speed before fighting on foot with sword and spell.

Most of Aundair’s infantry consists of determined and reasonably well-trained freeborn farmers. Recruits who survive a few battles and professional soldiers are trained as archers or cavalry, or assigned to provide support to an arcane ballista. A standard infantry platoon of thirty troops consists of two militia squads and one archer squad, with a 3rd-level swordmage captain in command. Each squad is made up of ten soldiers in total. An arcane platoon replaces the archer squad with an arcane squad; a ballista platoon replaces the same with an arcane ballista squad. The captains in charge of both kinds of platoons are 6th-level swordmages. An infantry company of ninety troops consists of three standard infantry platoons, and an arcane company is made up of two arcane platoons and one ballista platoon. A major, usually a 5th-level swordmage (or a 7th-level wizard for an arcane company), commands the company. A regiment of three hundred troops consists of three companies, usually two infantry companies and either an arcane company or a cavalry company. The commander of a regiment is a colonel, an 8th-level swordmage. A brigade of six hundred troops, the largest unit fielded by the Aundairian Army, consists of 2 regiments with a general in command, usually a 9th-level swordmage.

A cavalry platoon of twenty-two troopers consists of two light cavalry squads, with a major, usually a 4th-level swordmage, in command. Each cavalry squad is made up of eleven men, including the major. A cavalry company of forty-four troopers, commanded by a 5th-level swordmage colonel, is made up of two cavalry platoons.

Aundair’s emphasis on small, maneuverable units of soldiers and fast-moving cavalry serve the kingdom well. These forces are often able to outflank, outmaneuver, and outthink opposing

forces—except in the Eldeen Reaches, where the guerrilla tactics of the secessionists took Aundairian theories one step further. Certainly, against the lumbering might of Karnath’s undead hordes, Aundair’s lighter forces make up in maneuverability what they lack in sheer power. The use of swordmages and multiclass fighter/wizards as commanders in much of the Aundairian army ensures that virtually every unit on the battlefield has access to some magic to help protect the soldiers or harm the enemy. Aundair also makes the heaviest use of magewrights armed with *eternal wands* as well as magical heavy artillery. Aundair’s greatest asset, however, might be the determination of its soldiers, mostly commoner volunteers who enlist to defend their homes from what they perceive as foreign domination. Aundair’s soldiers are said to have higher morale than anyone else on the field, except perhaps the warforged and, of course, the undead troops of Karnath.

Aundair’s best soldiers bring a combination of warrior prowess and magical might to the battlefield. The best of Aundair’s best are the Knights Arcane, an elite knightly order of soldiers boasting both martial skills and spellcasting ability. The Knights Arcane are a small order, but their importance cannot be overstated—their commander is Lord Darro ir’Lain (unaligned male human swordmage/knight phantom 12), one of the three most powerful people in Aundair, including Queen Aurala herself. Knights Arcane ride forth for the most important battles and take on the greatest challenges on the battlefield. A typical charge includes four knights mounted on magebred heavy warhorses. The following is an example of a typical charge of Aundairian Knights Arcane:

Sir Adric ir’Vellan: unaligned male human swordmage 7.

Lady Dallia ir’Kavin: LG female half-elf swordmage 7.

Lady Arvana ir’Lain: unaligned female human swordmage 7.

Sir Cathrid: LG human cleric (Dol Arrah) 7.

Magebred Heavy Warhorses (4).

The knight phantoms, the most elite units of the Knights Arcane, are sometimes classified as light cavalry, but they are actually dragoons, or mounted infantry. They use *phantom steeds* to ride quickly to the site of a battle and into position, then dismiss the spells and use their combined martial and magical power to carry the day.

Breland¹²



Information based on parliamentary census records, 997 YK.

Population: 3.7 million

Area: 1,800,000 square miles

Sovereign: King Boranel ir'Wynarn

Capital: Wroat

Major Cities: Sharn, Starilaskur, Galethspyre, Xandrar

Climate: Temperate in the north, tropical in the south

Highest Point: Erix Peak in the Blackcap Mountains, elevation 13,256 feet

Heraldry: A roaring bear surrounded by gold wyverns on a crimson shield

Founder: Wroann, fifth scion of King Jarot

National Motto: "We gain what we give."

Espionage Service: King's Dark Lanterns

Distance allowed Breland to develop in ways that were distinctly different from the other human nations. While each of the human settlements that eventually became the Five Nations took root in the rich land surrounding the Scions Sound, the ancestors of the Brelish nation felt confined along the shore of the Brey River. The original settlement, built near where Aruldusk stands today,

¹² From the moment Brey ir'Wynarn took the ruling chair in the Great Hall of Wroat after the unification of Galifar, the descendants of Galifar ir'Wynarn have governed the nation of Breland and its people. Governor-princes in line to one day inherit the throne of Galifar administered the nation until 894 YK, when the kingdom collapsed and each scion declared his nation to be a sovereign and independent kingdom. In that year, Wroann, fifth scion and youngest daughter of Galifar's last king, Jarot, named herself Queen of Breland until she could rightfully claim the crown of Galifar and reunite the shattered kingdom.

Date	Monarch
892–919 YK	Wroann (declared queen in 894 YK)
919–922 YK	Kason
922–927 YK	Brask [regent]
928–960 YK	Boranex
961 YK–Present	Boranel

was quickly abandoned and its people moved south, following the river until they found a site that pleased them.

The original nation of Wroat grew up around what is today the town of Vathirond. The frontier nation did not stop there, however, and soon those within the settlement who wanted more open space and more freedom continued to move south and west. It was about 2,400 years ago that Breggor Firstking led most of the pre-Brelish settlers to fertile fields where the Howling and Dagger Rivers converged and officially established the kingdom of Wroat. Earlier, when the humans of the Lhazaar expeditions had landed on Khorvaire's eastern shores and migrated inland, one of Lhazaar's most powerful lieutenants struck out to map the southern shores of the new land. With four mighty warships and more than a thousand warriors, Malleon explored the coast of southern Khorvaire. Along the way, Malleon earned the name "the Reaver" as he plundered the settlements of goblins, gnomes, and lizardfolk he discovered. Then, about twenty-five years after Lhazaar first led them to this new continent, Malleon sailed into the Hilt of the Dagger River.

When Malleon first set eyes upon the ancient goblin city on the bluff, a city that would eventually grow to become the greatest in the land, he knew that his days as an explorer and pirate had come to an end. Malleon and his loyal warriors conquered and enslaved the goblins and erected a fortress atop their ancient ruins. What was once Duur'shaarat and would one day be Sharn now belonged to Malleon. He named the place Shaarat.

For six hundred years, Malleon, his warriors, and their descendants built Shaarat into a powerful and wealthy city on the bluff overlooking the Hilt. By this point, Breggor Firstking had established the kingdom of Wroat some 500 miles north along the Dagger River. It was inevitable that the two settlements would come into conflict. Breggor wanted Shaarat for his own, but Malleon's descendants refused to yield. The siege of Shaarat lasted for almost a year before Breggor ordered his wizards to destroy the place. Shaarat fell, but Breggor claimed the ruins and renamed the city Sharn. Over the next eight hundred years, the towers rose and the city grew, becoming the second jewel in the nation of Wroat's crown.

The glory of Sharn was lost during the last days of the War of the Mark, when the remnants of the aberrant dragonmarked forces took refuge in the City of Towers. Rather than fall before the onslaught of the armies of the pure dragonmarked houses, the leaders of the aberrant mark forces destroyed themselves and their followers in a display of arcane power that left Sharn in ruins. The city remained abandoned for more than five hundred years. It was Galifar I, king of the newly united kingdom of the same name, who came to the City of Tower's rescue. In 35 YK, Galifar ordered that Sharn be rebuilt so that it could serve as the southern bastion of his kingdom. It took more than five

years to make a portion of the city habitable, then another fifty years for the towers to rise over the ruins, but by 150 YK, Sharn was well on its way to becoming the largest and most powerful city not only in Breland but in the entire kingdom.

Meanwhile, the rest of the nation grew and prospered. It maintained ties with the other nations, and when it became part of Galifar's united kingdom, it served as a valued and powerful realm within the larger empire. But the distances between Breland's capital and the seats of power of the other Five Nations allowed for new ideas and attitudes to develop. No matter how prosperous and large Breland became, it was always seen as "the frontier" by the other nations. And on this frontier, new ideas such as personal freedom, inalienable rights, and individual thinking thrived.

Today, Breland stands as a benign constitutional monarchy that combines a system of heredity and nobility with an elected parliament (The parliament existed prior to the creation of the independent kingdom of Breland at the start of the Last War, during which time it helped the Galifaran governor-prince administer this portion of the realm. Queen Wroann established it as a true legal force in 895 YK, shortly after the start of the Last War). Of course, some feel that the monarchy should be supplanted and replaced by an elected leader, but King Boranel remains firmly in command. Still, no other nation enjoys such power, such diversity, and such freedom for the majority of its citizens. The opportunities are endless, and the wealth of ideas that flow from the Brelish cities to the countryside is truly amazing.

Breland weathered the storm of the Last War amazingly well. The size of the nation, the strength and determination of its people, and its abundance of resources gave it the ability to carry on when others fell back, to choose its own course and not be dependent on allies of convenience. Breland did earn friends over those years, and ties between Breland and Zilargo remain strong now that the war has ended.

The central and southern regions of the nation saw little if any direct conflict over the century of battle, but no one in Breland made it through without losing a friend or loved one to the war effort. While the farms north of Wroat and Galetspyre never suffered the indignity of invasion, it was the sons and daughters of the farmers who went off to fight for Brelish honor and glory. They fought at the borderlands, repelling invaders, and they fought across the borders, taking the battle to whatever nation was considered an enemy that season.

Today, the borderlands of Breland remain strong and on the alert, even as reconstruction takes place to repair the ravages of battle. In the west, the fortress of Orcbone and Shadowlock Keep watch for any incursions from Droaam. Drum Keep, in the north, watches the Eldeen border, where so many on both sides fell in some of the worst battles of the Last War. Sword Keep and Brey Crossing

protect the borders with Aundair and Thrane, while Sterngate keeps an eye on the passes into Darguun. Perhaps the most active post in the current day is Kennrun, where knights and warriors must constantly deal with threats emerging from the dead-gray mist surrounding the Mournland.

Breland is a progressive nation that welcomes all who come in peace with open arms and the promise of honest wages for honest work. Its progressive nature, however, provides a home for those who wish to engage in less than honest work, especially in the larger cities. The nation works hard to maintain the Treaty of Thronehold, for King Boranel believes that peace is a better road to travel than war. King Boranel is well and truly loved by the majority of the Brelish people. Unfortunately, Boranel's age is beginning to show, and none of his surviving heirs have demonstrated even a modicum of his intelligence and charisma. Many believe that Breland's strength relies on Boranel's leadership, and many of his enemies beyond the borders of the nation cannot wait for him to fall. Will the hope of many who covet the Brelish countryside come to pass? When King Boranel falls, so falls Breland? Only time will tell.

Breland's military tradition is one of independence, charismatic leadership, and freestanding militias of commoners answerable to the kingdom's cities and provinces. Breland is also known for the excellence of its archery and, most important, its habit of rewarding merit in its officer corps, rather than seniority, social rank, family connections or perceived piety. Its army is larger than any other of the Five Nations save for Karrnath's.

The Brelish Army has an uneasy relationship with mercenaries, using them to reduce its own losses but never quite trusting them. A Brelish infantry platoon of thirty troops consists of three volunteer squads or, in the last twenty years of the Last War, three enlisted squads. Each squad consists of ten soldiers. These all-volunteer squads, consisting of citizen militia taking up arms on their own initiative, are led by a sergeant, who is usually a low-level fighter or warlord. An all-enlisted squad features trained soldiers, usually from city backgrounds, whose sergeant is a low-level fighter, ranger or warlord. The troops in a platoon are usually led by a captain, a 3rd-level warlord or fighter. A company of one hundred and twenty troops consists of four platoons. A major, normally a 4th-level warlord or fighter, commands the company. A regiment of footsoldiers or archers comprising three hundred and sixty troops consists of three companies. Such regiments are led by colonels, normally a 5th-level warlord or fighter. Colonels are usually mounted, though they command the infantry. A legion—the largest unit that Breland typically fields—consists of two or three regiments of between seven hundred and over one thousand troops and is commanded by a field marshal, who is usually a 7th- or 8th-level warlord or fighter and an adjunct colonel, who is a 6th-

level warlord or fighter. A typical Brelish legion is made up of a regiment of foot soldiers, a regiment of archers, and a regiment of cavalry operating under a field marshal.

Brelish cavalry is organized into lances, squadrons, and regiments. A captain, normally a 2nd-level warlord or fighter, commands a squadron of three lances (the term for Brelish cavalry platoons). Cavalry lances, consisting of either a quartet of mounted corporals who are 1st-level fighters or a trio of heavy chargers, are commanded by a captain who is usually a 2nd-level warlord or fighter. Cavalry squadrons, consisting of either fifteen mounted light soldiers or twelve heavy chargers, are commanded by a major who is a 4th-level warlord or fighter. The squadrons also usually contain two captains who are 2nd-level warlords or fighters and the rest of the soldiers are corporals who are 1st-level fighters. A cavalry regiment groups six squadrons and is led by a major, a 5th level warlord or fighter. Beyond the regiment level, cavalry is incorporated into combined arms legions with infantry, typically with a single cavalry regiment combined with one or two regiments of footsoldiers or archers

Brelish Rangers are troops specialized in reconnaissance, keeping the large Brelish legions moving in the right directions. They operate miles or even days in advance of their regular forces. The most common unit of Brelish Rangers is called a band, or sometimes a “Ranger’s dozen,” of eleven soldiers. Made up solely of trained warriors, a band of Brelish Rangers consists of standard wilderness-skilled volunteers, assisted by a wizard or artificer and led by a human or shifter ranger capable of tracking and assessing enemies’ forces as indicated below:

Warden: human or shifter ranger or warden 3.

Wands (2): human wizard or artificer 1.

Volunteers (8): human fighter 1.

The armies of Breland are quick and flexible, striking from ambush and quick to retreat when things turn against them. They are fierce in protecting their own territory and much more hesitant beyond the borders they know. Brelish troops operate in standard ranks and formations, but are fully capable of fighting even when their commanders are slain. Breland is particularly renowned for the skill of its archers with the longbow.

Breland’s elites include famed strike forces and dragoons. The Redcloak Battalion is the best of the best among Brelish elite forces. Devastatingly skilled heavy infantry supported by magic, the Redcloaks served as an immovable rock in the front lines of several Brelish battles. The group never exceeds forty members but is fully capable of outfighting far superior numbers. More extensive information about the Redcloak Battalion can be found in *Sharn: City of Towers*, on page 140.

A Redcloak strike force is the smallest operational unit of the battalion:

Lieutenant Meira: female shifter ranger 14.

Alain Lanner: male human fighter 9.

Maal Jonz: male half-orc barbarian 9.

Heeson Graccen: female elf cleric 9.

Pol Makker: male dwarf artificer 9.

The Breland Dragoons are elite mounted infantry that are capable of traveling faster and carrying heavier gear than regular infantry. The Breland Dragoons, in their various companies and flashy uniforms, are not quite as famous as the boldest Brelish wands or cavalry units, but in many cases their toughness and mobility carried the day. Like cavalry, they are organized into lances and squadrons. Their weapons and tactics are often unorthodox. These elite mobile infantry lances, like the one below, are supported by an artificer:

Captain: human warlord 4.

Hussar Sergeant: human fighter 2.

Hussar Wand: human artificer 2.

Outriders (8): human fighter 1.

Cyre (The Mournland)¹³



Information based on the Cyran census of 992 YK and accurate as of the Day of Mourning.

Population: 1.5 million (presumed dead save for Cyrans abroad)

Area: 1,020,000 square miles (all now the Mournland)

Sovereign: Queen Dannel ir'Wynarn (presumed dead)

Capital: Metrol

Major Cities: Making, Eston, Tronish

Climate: Temperate

Highest Point: Kenn Peak, elevation 7,576 feet

Heraldry: Crown and bell on a field of green, above a hammer and bellows

Founder: Mishann, first scion of King Jarot

National Motto: “What our dreams imagine, our hands create.”

Espionage Service: Champions of the Bell (disbanded)

Cyre was the future. At the height of the Kingdom of Galifar, Cyre was a land of arcane dreams made manifest. It came to be known as Beautiful Cyre, the Purple Jewel in Galifar's Crown, and Wondrous Cyre. To some, it was considered a land of decadence and arrogance, but to the rest of the kingdom, it was paradise.

When King Jarot attained the throne of Galifar, none of his children were yet of an age to take over the administration of the Five Nations. Regents and the existing governor-princes (Jarot's younger brothers and sisters) continued to govern and served as mentors and teachers for Jarot's scions. Princess Mishann, the oldest of Jarot's children, was sent to Cyre to learn at the knee of her

¹³ In 894 YK, when the Kingdom of Galifar collapsed and each scion declared his or her nation to be a sovereign and independent country, Mishann, first scion of Jarot, named herself Queen of Cyre while maintaining her overall claim to the crown of Galifar.

Date

858–908 YK
908–913 YK
914–942 YK
943–994 YK
994 YK–Present

Monarch

Mishaan (declared queen in 894 YK)
Brusst
Connos
Dannel
Oargev (prince in exile)

uncle and prepare for her role as governor-prince and, eventually, monarch of Galifar. Just as it was since Galifar united the kingdom, just as it would be forever.

However, Mishann and the rest of the kingdom would discover that nothing remains the same forever. When King Jarot died, Mishann prepared for the journey to Thronehold to attend her father's funeral and to take the crown that was her birthright as the eldest scion of House Wynam. Her siblings each brought armed troops to the funeral, and before Mishann could be coronated, Prince Thalin challenged the right of eldest succession. With loyal knights of the Silver Flame at his side, Thalin asserted that he was the better choice to be King of Galifar. Prince Kaius and Princess Wroann supported Thalin, in so far as they wanted a different method of selection to be put in place. "Why should the oldest and weakest automatically gain the crown?" Wroann asked. Prince Wrogar supported Mishann's claim, but the other three rejected her. Wrogar was able to stop the scions from spilling royal blood at Thronehold, but the five siblings and their followers departed the island without reaching any resolution to the question of succession.

Before the year was out, the first battles of the Last War erupted, and each royal sibling eventually declared his or her own ambition to take the Galifaran crown. As the kingdom collapsed and the Five Nations became five distinct and separate states once more, war spread throughout Khorvaire. Beautiful Cyre, of all the nations, wound up as the battleground on which much of the Last War was fought. In addition to the troops from Karnath, Thrane, and Breland clashing with each other and Cyran forces in this region, Cyre also became the place where Darguun, Valenar, Talentan tribes, and Lhazaarite pirates came to loot, plunder, or seek land to expand into.

And so it went, with the great wonders of Cyre falling bit by bit with every battle, until the terrible cataclysm of the Day of Mourning finished the sad destruction of the once-shining nation in one fell swoop. No one has claimed credit for the massive release of arcane energy that obliterated the nation, and no one seems to know exactly what happened on the Day of Mourning. What is known is that something terrible occurred in or around the city of Making, located at about the center of what is now the Glass Plateau, and slowly spread out to destroy the whole kingdom. Those living closer to the borders, as well as those outside the nation on this fateful day, were able to survive the disaster.

Today, Cyre is no more. In its place is the Mournland, a blasted, mutated land surrounded by a dense wall of dead-gray mist. Cyran refugees have migrated to New Cyre and Sharn in Breland, Dragonroost and Zolanberg in Zilargo, and, in smaller numbers, to communities in Thrane, Karnath, and Q'barra. Many Cyrans, still reeling from the terrible destruction, find it hard to forgive the Five

Nations that have refused to provide them with help. Worse, the Valenar elves slaughtered Cyran refugees fleeing from southeastern Cyre by the thousands as they tried to escape the spreading mist.

A second injustice heaped upon the survivors of Cyre occurred during the Treaty of Thronehold negotiations. Though the Day of Mourning was crucial in getting the Five Nations together to end the Last War, no Cyran representation was permitted. “Cyre no longer exists,” Queen Aurala of Aundair argued. “The refugees have no voice in these proceedings,” High King Vadallia of Valenar agreed. And so Cyre did not participate in the accords that redefined the continent and ended the Last War.

Cyre’s last century featured an incredible series of highs and lows. Led by the legitimate heir to the throne of Galifar, Mishannir Wynarn, the country first appeared to be ready to fall to the combined might of Breland, Karmath, and Thrane. But an inspired bit of negotiation brought the warbands of the Valaes Tairn elves to Khorvaire to fight for Cyre (or at least Cyran gold), and the other nations’ leaders quickly turned on each other as each decided to take the crown of the kingdom. For six decades Cyre enjoyed success out of all proportion with its size and might. When the Valaes Tairn’s War Leader Shaeras Vadallia declared himself High King of Valenar, carving out a new elven empire on Cyre’s territory, it seemed Cyre was once again doomed. Then came the warforged, bolstering Cyre’s forces and giving it the strength to survive despite the toll constant warfare was taking on the countryside. Still, the Cyrans’ fortunes were waning, and many parts of northern and western Cyre became battlefields. Step by bloody step, the fighting wound toward Metrol and the few pristine Cyran cities left in the south. Rumors abounded that Queen Dannel and her advisers had plans for a major new offensive that would throw back the invaders. Dannel’s uncanny charisma inspired a nation and, despite the losses, spirits were high. Cyre’s martial academies and arcane colleges continued to attract students eager to learn the skills necessary to defend the nation.

Until the Day of Mourning.

Cyre’s complete destruction in a day by an explosive wave of arcane energy is undoubtedly the single most important moment in the last hundred years. Major battles were being fought all across Cyre, with each of the Five Nations losing thousands if not tens of thousands of soldiers as the dead-gray wall of mist swept outward from the interior. While refugees have gathered in Breland under the graces of King Boranel’s mercy, Cyre as a nation is simply gone, lost behind a wall that follows Cyre’s borders with eerie precision. In its place a strangely tranquil wasteland taunts treasure seekers with tantalizing hints of the greatest mystery of the modern age. . . . What was the Mourning? Will it happen again?

Today there are two Cyres—the citizens who survived, and the blasted wasteland where the kingdom once stood. Within the Mournland, the Lord of Blades is the closest thing the inhabitants have to a king. Outside the Mournland, for the people of Cyre who survived the Day of Mourning, Prince Oargev ir'Wynarn is the rightful leader. While the Cyran people remain scattered across the surviving Five Nations and beyond, the city of New Cyre in eastern Breland is growing, and every day sees a reunion as divided families rejoice in the return of lost kin. Oargev is determined to see the Mournland recovered, its plains purified, its waters cleansed of taint.

While he governs New Cyre, Oargev dreams of rebuilding Cyre the nation. If he cannot do this in the Mournland, he will carve a permanent nation from King Boranel's flank. The Brelish king was the first to reach out to the Cyrans as their lands died, and Oargev hesitates to betray such kindness. To this end, Prince Oargev sponsors expeditions into the Mournland and offers rich rewards for relics and natural specimens brought out of the mists. The young prince has become something of a naturalist, knowledgeable about all the native species of plants and animals, and an expert on the strange mutations found around the Great Chasm. Oargev is particularly eager to recover Cyran royal regalia from Metrol.

None of the provinces of Galifar was as ill-suited to the rigors and violence of the Last War as was Cyre, the Purple Jewel in Galifar's Crown. This crossroads of culture, the heart of the Galifaran empire's artisan soul, fielded a military that was only a pale shadow of its neighbors. Further, it was Cyre's own Queen Mishann who was due to ascend the Galifaran throne after the death of King Jarot, and thus the Cyrans were the last to know of the usurpers' intentions. Had it not been for mercenaries—including the Valenar elves, the goblins of Darguun, and warforged purchased from House Cannith—Cyre could never have survived even until the Day of Mourning. As is so often the case in war, the noncombatants and the innocents suffer most, and Cyre was no exception.

Although Cyre had less of a martial tradition than any of the other provinces of Galifar, it did have a standing army of its own. Smaller than those of its neighbors, this army formed the core of Cyre's defenses, around which the mercenary companies and foreign forces revolved. A Cyran infantry platoon consisted of two volunteer squads and one enlisted squad, each of which consisted of ten men. Each platoon was usually led by a captain who was a 2nd-level cleric of the Sovereign Host or fighter. A Cyran company of about ninety men divided up among the three platoons, commanded by a major, normally a 3rd-level cleric or fighter. A regiment—the largest unit Cyre typically fielded—consisted of three companies and totaled about three hundred troops. Such regiments were led by colonels, normally a 5th-level cleric or fighter. In the later years of the Last War, many of the

volunteer and enlisted soldiers were warforged, though humanoids continued to fill most Cyran officer posts.

“Volunteer” squads consisted primarily of simple citizens taking up arms for their country, bolstered by a cleric and led by a sergeant. The enlisted squad, the core professional unit of the Cyran Army, consisted entirely of trained soldiers led by a sergeant who was a low-level human fighter and a corporal who was a low-level cleric of the Sovereign Host. Each squad was made up of ten soldiers in total.

Cyre rarely fielded any cavalry unit larger than a platoon, which consisted of three cavalry squads, or about fifteen troops in total. A captain, normally a 2nd-level cleric or fighter, commanded the platoon. Beyond the platoon level, cavalry was incorporated into regiments with infantry. A cavalry squad consisted of either a quartet of mounted corporals or paired warforged chargers. Both types were commanded by a major who was a low-level fighter or cleric.

Throughout most of the war, Cyre was far more intent on protecting its own borders than expanding its territory. In addition to its normal soldiers, it made substantial use of special border guardians called Border Sentinels. The most common unit was the bastion, which consisted of two patrols led by a master sentinel, normally a 3rd-level human or half-elf ranger. A border patrol was made up solely of trained warriors, assisted by clerics and led by a ranger capable of guiding them through the wilds of Cyre’s outskirts. A typical patrol consisted of:

Sentinel: human or half-elf ranger 2.

Corporals (2): human cleric 1.

Enlisted Soldiers (4): human fighter 1.

Except in Karnath, the armies of Cyre frequently held back, allowing their mercenaries to lead an attack or a charge. This strategy was not cowardice on their part (no matter what other nations might claim), but instead an acknowledgment that the foreign forces might well know more about how to conduct a particular sort of battle than did the Cyran soldiers. Cyre’s troops usually conducted themselves as guerrilla soldiers and mobile units. They rarely marched into battle in large ranks, preferring speed and mobility. They used light horses and small units to attack an enemy from the flank, then disappeared back into rough terrain unfamiliar to the enemy (This was a particularly favored tactic of the Border Sentinels). All this is sharply distinct from Cyran operations in Karnath. Regular Cyran military forces conducted standard operations there, including trench warfare and massed battles for much of the war.

Cyre relied heavily on adventuring parties and specialized strike teams during the Last War. The following are among the most famous. Taking their name from one of Cyre’s heraldic symbols,

the team of specialized warriors called the Champions of the Bell emerged late in the war, five years before the Day of Mourning, in 989 YK. In that time, however, they captured the hearts and the imaginations of the Cyran people with their daring raids into enemy territory, their retrieval of secrets of state, and—most famously—the rescue of Duke Corlan Varak (Unaligned male human fighter 7) from the dungeons of the city of Atur in Karnath. What the general population of Cyre did not know was that the Champions of the Bell were semiofficial assassins, sponsored by secret elements in the Cyran government. The Champions’ great victories, although genuine, were undertaken primarily to draw attention away from their activities when they were not under the nation’s scrutiny. All the Champions were reportedly slain on a raid into Thrane several weeks before the Day of Mourning, and in fact a memorial procession in their honor was to have taken place in Metrol a mere two days after Cyre’s destruction. In truth, one of the team was taken as a prisoner of war in Thrane. This fact has only recently been revealed—as of yet Thrane’s leaders refuse to say who, admitting only that the individual was released after the Treaty of Thronehold was signed, and they have no more knowledge of his (or her) whereabouts than anyone else. These elite soldiers were master infiltrators:

Elspeth Padalas: Unaligned female human rogue 5.

Beld: Evil male changeling rogue 6

Duril Kelist: Unaligned male human star pact warlock 5.

Gesricar Eight-Fingers: Good male half-elf swordmage 5.

Cyre was the first nation to employ units consisting entirely of warforged, without human officers or advisers. The most famous of these was the Iron Tide, a squad of roughly half a dozen warforged, each with its own area of expertise much like those found in traditional adventuring parties. The Iron Tide was primarily a target-and-destroy unit, embodying the old saw about “the best defense.” If a potent enemy force succeeded in penetrating Cyre’s borders, the Iron Tide might be dispatched against the foe’s advance scouts or command retinue, hoping to blind or even behead the invading army. The Iron Tide operated continuously from 974 YK through the Day of Mourning, though its membership fluctuated somewhat as the unit took casualties and received replacements (The names below represent the Iron Tide’s longest-running roster). Rumor has it that a large portion of the Iron Tide survives today and has joined up with the infamous Lord of Blades in the Mournland. Those who knew the Tide’s members personally claim this is highly unlikely. These warforged elite formed a potent Cyran strike force:

Commander Ironhorn: Unaligned male-personality warforged warlord 7.

Sliver: Lawful Good female-personality warforged fighter 5.

Brick: Evil male-personality warforged monk 4.

Claymore: Unaligned male-personality warforged fighter 4.

Lode: Good female-personality warforged ranger 4.

Rusty: Unaligned male-personality warforged cleric 4 of the Sovereign Host.

Slag: Unaligned male-personality warforged wizard 4.

Karrnath¹⁴



Information based on military draft records, 994 YK.

Population: 2.5 million

Area: 1,350,000 square miles

Sovereign: King Kaius ir'Wynarn III (actually Kaius I)

Capital: Korth

Major Cities: Karrlakton, Atur, Vedykar, Rekkenmark

Climate: Temperate in south with cold, cloudy winters and cool, partly cloudy summers; central to northern region has short, cool summers and long, harsh winters

Highest Point: Mount Tharzil in the Ashen Spires, elevation 9,925 feet

Heraldry: A blood-red wolf head on a shield of silver and black

Founder: Kaius I, third scion of King Jarot

National Motto: "Death holds no terror."

Espionage Service: Decentralized; each Karrn warlord maintains his own informants

Known as the "birthplace of kings," the kingdom of Karrnath was born in war. The art of war remains the birthright of every true son and daughter of the land, and it sings in their blood and their dreams. The first humans to settle the region were Lhazaarite marauders. They built outposts along the barren coastline and raided the softer lands to the south. Slowly, these outposts developed into towns and cities, and the people that remained in the land were tempered by the long, harsh winters.

¹⁴ Since Karrn the Conqueror rose to power, his blood has flowed through the rulers of Karrnath. When King Galifar I established his united kingdom, he set up a system wherein the Wynarn family would rule over each of the Five Nations. This took a bit of getting used to in the other parts of the kingdom, but the Karrns have long had the blood of Karrn sitting on their throne. Occasionally over the centuries, as happens when there are fewer suitable heirs, governorship of Karrnath fell to trusted regents drawn from other parts of the family. Like the others among the Five Nations, Karrnath was administered by governor-princes as part of the Kingdom of Galifar from the founding of the kingdom until 894 YK. In that year, as the struggle for the Galifaran Crown that caused the Last War escalated, Karrnath broke from the larger kingdom and declared itself an independent monarchy under the rule of King Kaius I.

Date

890–910 YK
910–960 YK
961–972 YK
973–990 YK
991 YK–Present

Monarch

Kaius I (declared king in 894 YK)
Kaius II
Jaron
Moranna [regent]
Kaius III [actually Kaius I]

As the descendants of the Lhazaarite raiders continued to spread out and eventually divide into five distinct nations, Karrn the Conqueror rose to power. He transformed the pirates and pillagers of his northeastern realm into a deadly army. Under his leadership, the Karnathi forces swept the remnants of the Dhakaani goblins out of the land and made war upon the other human settlements. Karrn dreamed of ruling a vast kingdom, and in his zeal he conquered two-fifths of the human lands. In the end, no single foe defeated Karrn. Rather, he was overcome by the sheer size of Khorvaire and his own penchant for cruelty.

Karrn's legacy remains, and most people tend to forget the atrocities and prefer to remember the accomplishments. He cleared the heartland of the human nations of the remnants of the goblin empire of Dhakaan. He galvanized the people and kick-started the march to civilization. He built the greatest army of his age. And he died in a kingdom that bore his name. Centuries later, his descendant Galifar ir'Wynarn, a true son of Karnath, would pick up Karrn's dream and unite the Five Nations. Galifar utilized the military power of Karnath to forge his empire and no force could stand against him. Of course, he tempered war with hope and a dream of a better society, and thus succeeded where Karrn had failed. After the Kingdom of Galifar was established, military officers from across the land trained at the Rekenmark Military Academy. Military traditions and training were disseminated to the rest of the kingdom, but as a people the Karnns continued to be more dedicated to and proficient in the arts of war. To this day, every citizen of Karnath serves a term in the military, and every citizen of Karnath practices with the local militia.

Life in Karnath can be cold and hard, but the Karn people are colder and harder. When the Last War began, the people of the land rallied behind their king. It seemed unthinkable that the other parts of the collapsing Galifaran empire could stand against the military might of Karnath. Better equipment and training could take the Karnns only so far, however. They underestimated the arcane weaponry of Aundair and Cyre. They underestimated the divine power of the Silver Flame that bolstered Thrane. And they failed to account for the sheer heart and determination of the Brelish people, perhaps the most underrated kingdom at the start of the war.

Karnath suffered a series of embarrassing and potentially destructive setbacks, forcing King Kaius I to accept aid from the Blood of Vol. Using the necromantic arts at their disposal, the Vol priests called Karnath's fallen warriors back from the grave, setting the stage for the rest of the long, long war. The tireless undead troops bolstered the nation's living soldiers and brought a sense of otherworldly terror to the battlefields. The Karnathi undead were some of the most unusual troops deployed in battle until the creation of the warforged.

A military dictatorship since the start of the Last War, Karnath continues to operate under martial law. This makes it a bit tougher on visitors and adventurer types, but the land is not totally closed to travelers. Instead of the Code of Galifar, the country follows the Code of Kaius. This rigid set of laws and responsibilities is based on the older code, but many rights have been restricted or eliminated in the name of national defense. With the end of the Last War, a handful of the more stringent laws have been lifted, but the overall oppression of a martial system remains.

Today, Karnath enjoys its role as one of the architects of peace, but there are undercurrents of unease throughout all levels of the nation. It came as a surprise when King Kaius III, leader of a harsh band of hardened warriors, pressed for peace. Most of the Karnathi warlords (the highest ranking nobles in the land) believe that their king is simply rebuilding the strength of the nation and searching for an advantage to turn against the other kingdoms. They trust that he will unleash their armies again when the time is right and grasp the throne of Galifar as his own. But there are those among the warlords and nobility that believe that Kaius is too soft, not at all like his father or great-grandfather. They see the Treaty of Thronehold as a symbol of his cowardice, and his efforts to curtail the power of the Blood of Vol as a rejection of the religion of the people. When the current peace finally breaks, it may be Karnath that swings the first sword—despite the wishes of its king.

Karnath spent more of the Last War in active warfare than any of the other four nations; it never left a war footing and never had long-term armistices with its foes. Battles between Karnath and Cyre were particularly bloody, especially when the Valenar elves became Cyran mercenaries. Karnath and Aundair were enemies throughout most of the Last War, although that front had long periods of stalemate and low-intensity battles of attrition. Thrane and Breland were either bitter enemies or tenuous allies, depending on the war's shifting fortunes.

Karnathi forces had seized Cyran territory on the Day of Mourning, preparing to use the area as a staging ground for a push into Breland. For this reason, tens of thousands of Karnns were among the dead on the day Cyre became the Mourmland. Karnath lost as many citizens to famine and disease as it did to enemy action over the course of the war. Shortly after the war began, plague and wheat-blight savaged the nation, bringing low the Galifaran province known for its industry and military tradition. The combination of famine and disease was so devastating that King Kaius I, desperate to save his realm, turned to the Blood of Vol for aid—a decision that forever changed Kaius and Karnath as a whole. When Kaius I, transformed into an immortal vampire by the Lich Queen Vol, returned to power in the guise of his great-grandson King Kaius III, he immediately set about ending the war. But even two years after the Treaty of Thronehold was signed, Karnath is still a militaristic society that's reluctant to abandon its war footing. The warlords remain the most

powerful and influential of Kaius III's nobles. Most towns still have large standing militias, and service in the national army is compulsory. Karn soldiers still engage Valenar raiders to the southeast and battle strange horrors from the Mournland, and every skirmish receives a lot of attention in broadsheet chronicles and talk within the taverns.

Karnath also has the advantage of relatively secure borders. Scions Sound offers a measure of protection from Aundair and Thrane, and the northern waters keep all but the most determined Lhazaarite pirates at bay. Karnath's historic weakness, its southern border, is a lot safer now that Cyre is no longer around. Mutated monsters periodically emerge from the Mournland, to be sure, but that's a far cry from an invading Cyran army. Garrisons in Lakeside and Irontown remain strong and alert, for Karnath and the Mror Holds continue to dispute the border between the two nations, and many Karns want to reclaim the dwarven lands as their own.

While Kaius III has officially broken Karnath's ties with the Blood of Vol cult and declared it no longer the national religion, a significant portion of his citizenry continues to follow the tenets of blood as life and undeath as divinity. The Karn Crown has gone so far as to ban the open worship of the Blood of Vol in Korth, but shrines still draw followers in the towns and villages, and the Crimson Monastery in Atur continues to hold open ceremonies to mostly packed audiences of the faithful. Kaius has had better success in curtailing the influence of the Order of the Emerald Claw. In general, the nation has come to see this group of one-time patriots (at least that was how they were portrayed when the order was originally established) as violent extremists who no longer have the best interests of Karnath at heart (This does not keep some warlords and nobles from working with them, however).

The nation continues to utilize undead forces for defense, but the vast majority of Karnath's undead troops have been hidden away in secret crypts for the day when they will again be needed. This huge force of undead, with more being added every day under the orders of the Minister of the Dead, provides a ready-to-use army that can quickly bolster the living forces of the nation's warlords—while also remaining mostly hidden from the rest of the states of Khorvaire. Kaius III knows what the Minister is up to, but he does not realize the extent to which the undead buildup is continuing.

Karnath, always the most martial of the Five Nations, boasted an army larger and more well trained than any other faction early in the war. Combined with its advance knowledge of the coming struggle—King Kaius I was, after all, one of the Last War's instigators—it seems inconceivable that Karnath would not emerge from the conflict as the clear victor. Still, a series of devastating famines and plagues that may have been orchestrated by the Blood of Vol, combined with diplomatic and

political blunders caused in part by the military's reliance on brute force over creative thinking, offset the nation's immense military power for much of the war.

Long before the Last War, Karnath's culture had been steeped in military reverence. The army was a high calling—the scions of the rich and noble were groomed as officers. Of all the nations, Karnath's citizens were the most eager to fall in behind their leaders on the march to war. Karnath's rulers maintained the focus of their citizenry by never leaving a wartime footing and constantly employing nationalistic rhetoric to keep the people's anger stoked. Karnath's efforts were devoted mainly against Cyre and Aundair in the early part of the Last War, then shifted largely to a violent ideological and religious conflict with Thrane in the later years. Even after the war, the interaction between these former allies nearly qualifies as a cold war unto itself.

While many of the other nations focus on smaller and more mobile units, Karnath makes substantial use of enormous legions and heavy cavalry. Its goal is to defeat an enemy force simply by overrunning it and crushing it into the earth. The undead soldiers for which the nation became infamous—and which resulted in the final diplomatic break between Karnath and Thrane—are most often formed into separate units.

A standard infantry platoon consists of two regular squads and one soldier squad of thirty-three troops. A regular squad of twelve troops consisted of ten trained warriors, supported by a cleric and commanded by a sergeant who was a low-level fighter. A soldier squad was more well-trained than Karn regulars and included ten human low-level fighters, a Karn wizard and a 4th-level Karn warlord. In an arcane platoon, an arcane battle team replaced one of the regular squads. An arcane battle team focused on spellcasters but included soldiers to protect the magic-wielders. A 4th-level Karn wizard or warlock served as the battle team's arcane sergeant while four arcane specialists who were either clerics or wizards assisted him and were protected by ten Karn low-level fighters. A captain, usually a 3rd-level fighter, lead the entire platoon, regardless of its squad composition. An infantry company of sixty-six soldiers was made up of two standard infantry platoons, and an arcane company consisted of two arcane platoons. A major, usually a 4th-level fighter or warlord, commanded a company. A regiment of about two hundred troops included three companies, usually one arcane company with either two infantry companies or two undead companies. The commander of a regiment was a colonel—a 5th-level cleric (of the Sovereign Host or Blood of Vol, fighter, or warlord. A brigade of four hundred troops consisted of two regiments with a general—a 6th-level cleric, fighter, or warlord—as its commander. The two regiments in a brigade might include one cavalry regiment and one infantry regiment. A legion of eight hundred troops was comprised of two brigades led by a warlord, who was a 7th- or 8th-level fighter or warlord.

Karnath was initially reluctant to mobilize large undead units that lacked living officers, due to the inability of the undead to think creatively. Toward the end of the war, however, this approach became more and more difficult to maintain. An undead platoon of sixty undead consisted of two light undead squads and two heavy undead squads (Late in the war, all were heavy undead squads). Light undead squads of thirteen undead include twelve “normal” undead, led by a Karnathi skeleton or zombie. Heavy undead squads consist of ten Karnathi undead, along with a mortal commander or, later in the war, a dread marshal, a special form of Karnn undead that retained its intelligence and creativity. An undead platoon consists of two light undead squads and two heavy undead squads. A platoon is commanded by a captain, usually a 5th-level cleric, wizard, or fighter. An undead company consists of two undead platoons under the command of a living major, usually a 6th-level cleric, wizard, fighter, or warlord. Above the company level, undead infantry are part of the standard Karnathi infantry structure.

A standard cavalry platoon of thirty-three troopers consists of three light cavalry squads. Heavy horse squads of eleven troopers are the most common Karnathi cavalry unit. The commanding sergeant is mounted on a heavy warhorse. In an arcane cavalry platoon, an arcane strike team replaces one of the regular squads. An arcane strike team consists of numerous casters and the elite soldiers assigned to protect them, all mounted on light warhorses. The team is led by an arcane sergeant who is a human 5th-level wizard, his four arcane specialists who are clerics or wizards of 2nd-level and ten human 1st-level fighters. An undead cavalry platoon of thirty troopers is made up of three undead cavalry squads. Undead cavalry squads are terrifying, featuring ten Karnathi skeletons or zombies on skeletal heavy warhorses. A captain, usually a 3rd-level fighter, leads the entire platoon regardless of unit composition. A cavalry company consists of two cavalry platoons—a standard company has standard platoons, an arcane company has arcane platoons, and an undead company has undead platoons. A major, usually a 4th-level fighter or warlord, commands a company. A cavalry regiment consists of three companies— usually one arcane cavalry company with either two cavalry companies or two undead cavalry companies. The commander of a regiment is a colonel, who is a 5th-level cleric, fighter, or warlord. Above the regiment level, cavalry are incorporated into brigades along with infantry regiments.

Despite the skill and determination of their soldiers, and the dependable obedience of undead troops, the armies of Karnath suffer from a lack of creative tactics. For the most part, they rely on the size and strength of their forces, and the expertise of individual soldiers, to overrun the enemy. Armies as large and rooted in tradition as Karnath’s take a long time to adapt to change. The introduction of the undead—most of which, even if intelligent, lacked imagination—did not help

matters. Even by the war's end, Karnathi forces would, more often than not, attempt a straightforward assault unless doing so was clearly the wrong decision. Undead are often used for pursuit and patrol, missions on which their ability to remain constantly active is a major advantage.

For the most part, Karnath's elite units are formed from knightly orders. A few are composed of undead strike forces, however. Karnath's military culture has given rise to a number of knightly orders throughout its history. Some of these groups are loyal to a specific noble or warlord, others to a religious institution like the Sovereign Host or the Blood of Vol, and still others to Karnath itself, but all are considered quite prestigious. For the bulk of the war, the most honored of these was the Order of the Emerald Claw. Consisting of devout patriots and military minds, the order spread throughout the Karnn armed forces—at its height, it accounted for over a quarter of all Karnathi officers, and several legions were made up entirely of Emerald Claw members. Only late in the war, after Regent Moranna declared the order to be traitorous and began purging the most vocal members, did its luster fade.

The Emerald Claw was far from the only knightly order that became heavily involved in the war. Several other groups were able to field whole regiments of their own members, and quite a few military units consisted of a majority of one order or another. Although this situation often increased feelings of camaraderie and solidarity among the officers and soldiers, it also created friction. Rival orders competed with one another, sometimes to the detriment of an overall battle plan, by covertly undermining or lightly sabotaging each others' efforts. Soldiers loyal to one order might prove reluctant to follow the orders of an officer belonging to another. Described below are the largest and most widespread of Karnath's wartime knightly orders, including the region of Karnath in which each is based (though this was not necessarily its only area of influence or political strength), and a brief overview of the group.

Adamant Fang (Vedykar): Trained in both traditional and woodland warfare, its members are among Karnath's almost nonexistent light cavalry.

Blackened Sky (Karrlakton): Champions of industry, the Order of the Blackened Sky makes substantial use of alchemical and mechanical weapons; in recent years, it has also become one of Karnath's greatest defenders against monstrous incursions from the Mournland.

Conquering Fist (Vulyar/Korth): This is a relatively new knightly order that has not yet gained the respect of others of its sort. During the war, the Conquering Fist was based in Vulyar, and often led a charge into enemy territory. After the expulsion of the Emerald Claw, Kaius III relocated the Conquering Fist to Korth, and has been advocating them as the new patriotic heart of the Karnathi military.

Emerald Claw (Korth): This group (discussed above) is made up of Karrnathi patriots who have since been declared traitors; they are secretly servants of the Blood of Vol.

Inviolate Way (Rekkenmark): Restrictive even for a knightly order, the Inviolate Way accepts only applicants of Karrn noble blood who are members of the Order of Rekkenmark and thus graduates of Rekkenmark Military Academy; it is responsible for assisting, serving, and protecting Karrn nobles, royals, and warlords.

Onyx Skull (Atur): The first knightly order to truly embrace the presence of the undead, it provides many of the officers who oversee undead units, and is responsible for the creation of the bone knight paragon path for paladins (*Five Nations* 117).

Karrnath also made use of its own elite units during the Last War. Used primarily as hidden defenders, a Bastion of Frozen Flesh consists of undead corpses that appear inanimate most of the time, but instantly activate and attack when they sense the presence of a living creature within 30 feet. Karrnathi forces often bury a Bastion of Frozen Flesh in shallow trenches in a mountain pass or along a trade route where they expect enemies to pass. Here the corpses can wait indefinitely until activated. On rare occasions, the Bastions are used offensively, smuggled into enemy cities or—in one highly publicized attack—even dropped from low-flying airships into populated areas. A Bastion of Frozen Flesh is usually made up of twenty Karrnathi undead or, more rarely, six bodaks.

A Hand of Karrnath, consisting of four undead operatives, is an elite group that answers directly to Regent Moranna, King Kaius III’s “aunt” and chief lieutenant. These groups took to the field of battle at times, but their primary purpose during the Last War was assassination. The last of these forces were supposedly destroyed on a mission to Cyre during the Day of Mourning, but rumors of their continued activities circulate to this day. This undead band features more than one member with class levels.

Avlast: Evil male ghoul fighter 2

Shiril: Unaligned female wight rogue 2

Lavro: Evil male mummy

Mathir: Evil male ghoul cleric of the Blood of Vol 4

Thrane¹⁵



Information based on military draft records, 996 YK.

Population: 2.3 million

Area: 500,000 square miles

Sovereign: Jaela Daran, the Keeper of the Silver Flame

¹⁵ For the better part of a thousand years, the scions of King Galifar I—all members of the royal Wynarn bloodline—ruled Thrane. The children of Galifar's ruling sovereign were always first in line to govern the Five Nations. Occasionally, as happens when there are fewer suitable heirs, governorship of Thrane fell to trusted regents drawn from other parts of the family. As with the other Five Nations, Thrane was administered by the governor-princes as part of the Kingdom of Galifar from the founding of the kingdom until 894 YK. In that year, as the struggle for the crown that caused the Last War escalated, Thrane broke from the kingdom and declared itself an independent monarchy under the rule of King Thalin. Thalin, like many of the Thrane-based ir'Wynarns, was a devoted follower of the Church of the Silver Flame. He broke with tradition in order to exercise what he saw as his divine right to the Galifaran Crown. With the kingdom under his control, he could elevate the Silver Flame to its proper position as the one true religion of the land and the people. In many ways, it was King Thalin's zealous faith that led to the next stage in Thrane's history. Thrane remained a monarchy until 914 YK, when it became a theocracy governed by the Church of the Silver Flame. At that time, temporal and spiritual power fell to the Council of Cardinals and the Keeper of the Flame. Although the Wynarn line in Thrane continues to appoint blood regents (eldest scions of the royal family), these scions are merely figureheads without any temporal power.

Date

885–914 YK
914–945 YK
945–988 YK
988 YK–Present

Monarch/Blood Regent

Thalin (declared King of Thrane in 894 YK)
Daslin [blood regent, Church of the Silver Flame displaces royal family]
Erivon [blood regent]
Diani [blood regent]

In 299 YK, the Silver Flame was born. One year later, the newly christened Church of the Silver Flame appointed its first Keeper of the Flame—a spiritual leader of the nation who could commune directly with the Flame and pass its will onto the people. In 914 YK, amid the turmoil of the Last War, the people of Thrane abandoned the monarchy and invested the Keeper of the Flame with temporal as well as spiritual governorship of the nation. Thrane became the first theocracy of Khorvaire.

Date

300–320 YK
320–389 YK
389–461 YK
461–524 YK
524–525 YK
525–578 YK
578–610 YK
610–698 YK
698–768 YK
768–825 YK
825–860 YK
860–863 YK
863–903 YK
903–936 YK
937–993 YK
993 YK–Present

Keeper of the Flame

Maliah Sharavaci
Traelyn Ghelios
Darmin Avaroth
Kyra Danth
Bec Avaroth
Valiron Silverthorn
Torah Ariadu
Saren Rellek
Jareen Imistil
Aelyndari Valystar
Jolan Sol
Tzandra Corus
Jovor Daran
Kaith Serrain
Lavira Tagor
Jaela Daran

Capital: Flamekeep

Major Cities: Aruldusk, Sigilstar, Thaliost

Climate: Temperate

Highest Point: Trumpet Mountain in the Starpeak Mountains, elevation 10,965 feet

Heraldry: A silver sword set beneath the symbol of the Church of the Silver Flame (pictured)

Founder: Thalin, second scion of King Jarot

National Motto: “Glory to the Silver Flame.”

Espionage Service: The Argentum

One night in the month of Olarune in 299 YK, the settlers and farmers of Thrane saw dark clouds gathering over the Tamor Hills. A ruddy glow rose from a fissure in the hills. Those who explored the chasm did not return. As months passed, fiends and bloodthirsty beasts crawled out of the fissure from the depths of Khyber and threatened the land. This Year of Blood and Fire was a time of great terror, but it was also a time of inspiration. The paladin of the Sovereign Host Tira Miron gathered priests and soldiers to fight against the darkness. Armed with a singular vision, she ultimately confronted the evil forces within the Tamor Gap, binding their fiendish Overlord and transforming its dark flame to a font of silver light. Through her sacrifice, she became a spiritual vessel for the Silver Flame, a conduit through which it could touch the souls of others.

Many in Thrane see the Year of Blood and Fire as a turning point. Inspired by Tira’s sacrifice and guided by her spirit, Thranes destroyed or drove off the remaining fiends. The common folk turned to the new Church in droves, and the citadel of Flamekeep was soon established over the spot of Tira Miron’s sacrifice. The Church of the Silver Flame spread across Khorvaire, but Thrane remained at its heart. The good people of Thrane had seen the horror of unrestrained evil, and they were determined to stand against that darkness. At times, this missionary zeal spun out of control. Queen Joliana’s fervor for the Flame nearly shattered the kingdom of Galifar centuries before the death of King Jarot. However, most of the followers of the Flame have shown tolerance toward those who pursue other faiths, saving their strength to battle inhuman and supernatural evil.

If the Year of Blood and Fire was the first major turning point in the history of Thrane, the second was surely the death of King Thalin. The Council of Cardinals had grown in power and influence, and Thalin’s heir, Prince Daslin, was seen as weak. Above all, the nation was at war. It took little effort on the part of the cardinals to convince the people to raise the Church above the throne, and Daslin himself acceded to the demand without a struggle. In 914 YK, Thrane officially embraced the Church of the Silver Flame as its ruling body, becoming the first true theocracy in Khorvaire.

While a few archbishops and cardinals crave personal power, most believe that the rule of the Silver Flame is best for Thrane and for Khorvaire. This uncompromising religious zeal made it difficult for Thrane to form lasting alliances during the Last War, but the resolve of its clerics and paladins allowed the nation to hold its own even when beset from all sides. The new Keeper of the Flame, Jaela Daran, does not believe that war within Khorvaire serves the goals of the Church. However, many knights and cardinals still yearn to see a new Galifar united under the all-encompassing glow of the Silver Flame. And in the shadows of the court, the symbolic queen, the Blood Princess Diani ir'Wynarn, looks back on the history of her family and dreams of returning her line to the vacant throne of Thrane.

Imagine being surrounded on all sides by angry, resentful neighbors, and you can begin to understand how the common Thrane feels. Thrane shares borders with all four of its longtime enemies, and Thrane alone abandoned the royal bloodline of Galifar in favor of a theocracy. Moreover, Thrane seized parcels of land from Aundair and Breland—territory that Queen Aurala and King Boranel would like returned. Thrane has also been duly chastised for its cruelty. It demonstrated a startling lack of compassion when it denied Cyran refugees a new home after the destruction of their homeland, and vengeful Karrns resent Thrane for the ruthless wyvernriders firebombing of their capital of Korth—an audacious attack that left the imperious Karrn citizens feeling vulnerable and defenseless. Surrounded by such resentment, Thrane can ill-afford to lead carefree lives. However, they take great comfort in the Silver Flame, for it has never broken their trust or led them astray.

The armies of Thrane claim the blessing of the Silver Flame and for the most part act in the devoted, compassionate, honest, and true manner befitting such an honor. In the early war years, however, more than a few Thrane soldiers descended into religious fervor and committed atrocities against their “heathen” neighbors. Clerics and paladins of the Silver Flame were swept along in the self-righteousness of the levied troops, but as reason began to reassert itself and the dictates of their superiors moderated, they attempted to curtail the worst excesses.

After King Thalín died, the Church of the Silver Flame’s ecclesiastical hierarchy gradually asserted control over all aspects of Thrane’s military. Still, an officer class drawn from the deposed Thrane aristocracy continues to command troops. Indeed, in many ways, the armies of Thrane have become the last refuge of the nobility in a now-theocratic kingdom. Their expertise often leads them to powerful positions of command, though the Diet of Cardinals is careful never to give too much command over the armies to any single officer, no matter how successful or how well-loved by the people. In many ways, constant political interference by religious overseers (and the marked change in their expectations and demands) is Thrane’s greatest weakness. The cardinals do not wish to

assume command of the armies (for a defeat on the battlefield might be construed as a rebuke of the cardinals’ faith or piety), but neither do they trust anyone else to do so.

The armies are almost always made up of levies of untrained infantry troops supported by strong officers, well-regarded cavalry, and middling wands and poor archery. They are remembered more often as large groups than as smaller units: the Army of the Northern Crusade, the Silver Legion, the Legion of Perpetual Adoration, the Legion of the Pure, and so on.

The armies of Thrane are usually raised by one or more cardinals who use Church monies to sponsor, equip, and fund them; in some cases, patriotic Thrane nobles or knightly orders sponsor troops. After the establishment of the theocracy, the traditional Galifaran military ranks of corporal, sergeant, lieutenant, captain, major, colonel and marshal were abandoned in favor of new titles reflecting the young nation’s piety and dedication to the Silver Flame. In addition, because foot soldiers are so much more common than horse troops in the Thrane Army, cavalry officers use a related set of ranks.¹⁶

A standard infantry platoon of twenty-four or twenty troops consists of either three levy squads or two heavy squads. The levy squad is the staple unit of Thrane infantry, consisting of seven human peasants led by a lay priest of the Silver Flame. Levy troops are rarely armored and carry poor weapons, often no more than spears or clubs. Heavy squads of ten troops are slightly better armed and armored, but still poorly trained levy troops, usually led by a 1st-level warlord or

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Thrane’s Military Ranks		
Title	Rank Equivalent	Role
Ordren	Levy	Light infantry
Brethren	Private	Light infantry
Weight*	Levy	Heavy infantry
Pikeren	Private	Heavy infantry
Archren	Private	Light infantry archer
Press Brethren	Levy (naval)	Marine
Faithrider	Corporal	Cavalry trooper
Orderly	Corporal	Non-commissioned officer
Ship-Orderly	Corporal	Naval non-commissioned officer
Foot-Priest	Sergeant	Non-commissioned officer
Foot-Captain	Sergeant	Paladin
Press-Chief	Sergeant	Naval non-commissioned officer
Hoof-Priest	Lieutenant of Horse	Cavalry officer
Riding-Wand	Lieutenant of Horse	Cavalry officer—arcanist
Ship-Priest	Lieutenant	Naval officer
Riding-Captain	Captain of Horse	Cavalry paladin
Ship-Father or Commodore	Ship Captain	Naval officer
Sacrosanct	Major or Captain of Foot	Infantry officer
Argent	Colonel or Field Marshal	Officer of foot and horse
Bishop-Militant	General	Army commander

* Experienced veterans of heavy foot were often called “double weights.”

a paladin. The orderly who leads the platoon is usually a 1st-to-3rd-level human cleric of the Silver Flame. A Thrane company of about one hundred soldiers consists of five platoons. The sacrosanct who leads the company is usually a 4th-level human cleric or a 4th-level human paladin or fighter. A flame of three hundred troops consists of three companies, usually two infantry companies and one cavalry company. It is led by an officer with the rank of argent, usually a 7th-level cleric, paladin, or rarely a wizard dedicated to the Silver Flame known as a silver pyromancer.

Thrane's cavalry units, unlike its infantry, rise to a reasonable standard of training and skill. Their horses are of good stock, and their riders are sometimes among the Thrane nobility and the elite knights of the Church of the Silver Flame. They work closely with wands and with experienced clerics. A cavalry platoon of about twenty troopers consists of two light or heavy cavalry squads with a hoof-priest, a 5th-level fighter or paladin, in command. A light cavalry squad of eight troopers is led by a 3rd-level paladin on the best mount, a 2nd-level cleric and six human hoof-priests who are 1st-level fighters armed with lances and sabers. A heavy cavalry squad of ten troopers consists of six well-trained riders, two hoof-priests who are 3rd-level clerics, a wand who is a 3rd-level artificer or wizard, a captain who is a 4th-level paladin or fighter, and their heavy mounts.

A cavalry company of forty troopers—commanded by an argent who is a 6th-level cleric, fighter, or paladin—is made up of two cavalry platoons, again either light or heavy. A light or heavy cavalry company is sometimes included as part of a flame, along with two infantry companies. Thrane does not usually mix light and heavy cavalry within the same regiment.

Thrane's tactics and success are hugely dependent on the available leadership. Early in the Last War, local Thrane civilian leaders, clerics, and even pious children all commanded enormous armies that saw catastrophic failure due to a lack of skill and experience and too much reliance on divine favor. In the second half of the conflict, the cardinals of the Church of the Silver Flame carefully appointed Thrane military commanders, searching for the perfect blend of competence and piety. The greatest success was realized by those commanders who combined the Thrane willingness to suffer large casualties together with the use of elite forces to turn the tide of battle. In general, levied troops are used to engage and fix the enemy. Once so engaged, cavalry or elite forces, in combination with cleric companies, enter battle to finish the foe. In an ideal situation, the sheer weight of numbers allows the Thranes to surround and annihilate their enemies.

Thrane's individual units are largely forgotten; the names of its armies are the ones most commonly celebrated. However, a few of its paladins and clerics are well known even outside Thrane's borders. The paladins of the Avenging Hand are the finest examples of Thrane martial arts, combining courage with faith and superb horsemanship with savvy use of shock tactics. Their

nickname among many of the levies is simply the Flame's Hand. Their blazon is a white field bearing a red hand surrounded by silver fire. The unit was based out of Flamekeep but spent all its time in the Thaliost region, riding at the head of the Army of the Northern Crusade. It led the assault that took the walls of Thaliost itself, and it was in the front ranks of those that beat back numerous Aundairian attempts to mount a counterattack. Losses among the Flame's Hand were high over the years, but the unit never lacked for volunteers. In the later stages of the war, it marched with the Legion of Perpetual Adoration and helped to curb some of the worst excesses of that time, always defending the peasants and the poor. It also served at the Battle of Cairn Hill, repelling the Brelish/Darguun invasion of southern Thrane. Its founder and first commander was Lady Margil Hetrion, a friend of King Thalin's. Its current Knight-Commander is Alestair Marktaros (Lawful Good male human paladin 9), an individual of such stature that his name has been recommended for elevation to the Church's Diet of Cardinals. An Avenging Hand squad is typically a group of two lances (three knights each) with a hoof-priest and a paladin commander:

Sir Handers Bonnifas: Lawful Good male human paladin 6

Paladin's Heavy Warhorse

Hoof-Priest: Lawful Good female human cleric 3

Knights-Brethren (6): LG male human fighters 2

Light Warhorses (7).

Thrane's navy used both volunteers and conscripts to power its galleys, to conduct boarding actions, and to assault enemy shores throughout Scions Sound. The Red Sails are remembered mostly for the latter—their night operations scuttled many Karranthi, Cyran, and Aundairian ships, merchants, and siege barges. The unit was more feared than loved, however; its commander, Sercyl Ghastor (Evil male human paladin 6), adopted a motto of "Get it done." Persistent reports of execution of prisoners and torture ultimately led to Ghastor's being summoned before the Council of Cardinals for a hearing; he disappeared *en route* to Flamekeep and has not been heard of since. His troops were scattered among other naval units in an attempt to stamp out their wicked practices. This unit is a typical shore party of the Red Sails, looking for able-bodied victims to press into naval service.

Ship-Priest Mally: Evil female human cleric 4.

Press-Chief Witherett: Unaligned male fighter 3.

Ship-Orderly Vinders: Unaligned male human cleric 3.

Press Brethren (8): Unaligned and Evil male and female human fighter 1.

A Gazeteer of Sarlona

The history of Sarlona—of which Lhazaar’s expedition is the most well-known part to the humans of Khorvaire—is a patchwork of legends and truth, with as many pieces missing as are present. Years of war saw a great deal of Sarlonan lore lost for all time—histories of the conquered erased by the conquerors, who were themselves conquered in time. In the end, however, nearly fifteen hundred years of Inspired rule in Riedra have reshaped Sarlona’s sense of itself. For Riedrans of today, the past is not a point of pride but a warning, and one does not seek the darkness that preceded the supposed light of Sarlona’s modern age. The ancient prehistory of Sarlona remains as much an unknown as it does in any part of Eberron. The Age of Demons, the giant explorers of Xen’drik said to have visited this land, the interest of the dragons of Argonnessen in Sarlona and their relationship to the Storm Guardians of Adar—every piece of critical research has a dozen legends that contradict it, and every legend investigated uncovers a dozen more.

Sarlona does have one unique claim to the history of this lost age. It is thought to be the birthplace of the celestial draconic race of feathered serpents known as the couatl. Certainly, this continent was a stronghold for that race during the Age of Demons; couatl and shulassakar (feathered yuan-ti) ruins can still be found there today. Such structures are common in the Riedran province of Khalesh, but the Inspired go out of their way to prevent their exploration. In Syrkarn, the ruins were taken over by the feathered yuan-ti on a grand scale, and it remains uncertain how much of the original race’s lore and history might have been corrupted or rewritten before the yuan-ti were put down. Scholars sifting the legends of the Age of Demons believe that three fiendish Overlords are bound in Sarlona—one within the heart of the mountain of Korrandar in Adar, one beneath the yuan-ti ruins of Syrkarn, and a third in the Krertok Peninsula of the Tashana Tundra. Of the nonhuman races, four appear to have an extended history on Sarlona: the kalashtar, the shifters, the Dorann dwarves of the present day Tundra, and the yuan-ti of the Twelve Kingdoms age. The Dorann dwarves in turn gave rise to a progressive coalition of dwarf and duergar, the Akiak, who split from their kin to migrate south across the Tundra.

Precariously balanced among the planes in an area of Eberron where the planar barriers are unusually thin, Sarlona has many planar wild zones and reality storms. These phenomena produce creatures and effects unseen elsewhere in the world. A few veins of Khyber dragonshards exist on the

continent, largely in the hands of the dromites. Defying any logic, however, Eberron dragonshards simply do not form on Sarlona. Similarly, Siberys shards are not found in equatorial Sarlona at all.

Tied to this phenomenon is the utter absence of dragonmarks. Sarlona was the birthplace of humanity, and today humans make up the vast majority of the dragonmarked population, but no dragonmarks have ever appeared on the people of Sarlona. Early signs indicate that the children of dragonmarked parents do not develop dragonmarks if they are conceived in Sarlona. The Twelve has no explanation for this phenomenon, but many believe that it is one of the keys to the ultimate mystery of the dragonmarks and their purpose in the world.

The lack of dragonmarks mirrors Sarlona's absence from the draconic Prophecy and Prophecy marks never form on Sarlonan geography. The few human scholars and cataclysm mages (*Explorer's Handbook*, p. 58) who have been able to discuss the Prophecy with the scaled lords of Argonessen have found the dragons to be utterly unwilling to speak of Sarlona. Some believe that this is because the dragons know of an inescapable catastrophe destined to originate from the continent. But others have a more disturbing theory. They claim that the dragons do not speak of Sarlona because the continent and the events that transpire there are completely invisible to the Prophecy, and this terrifies the dragons. Whatever the cause, the dragons clearly shun this land. Beyond the fabled Storm Guardians of Adar, the only dragons encountered in Sarlona are rogues. The Chamber has its agents in the land of the Inspired, but something—whether it is fear of the Inspired or fear of the Prophecy—keeps the dragons from coming to Sarlona.

Though the draconic Conclave of Argonessen's official stance is that dragons should steer clear of Sarlona at all times, in reality many rogue dragons take up residence in Sarlona all the time, for reasons of their own or because they have rejected the influence of the Conclave. These dragons are generally left in peace by Riedra's Harmonious Shield military forces, though certain pieces of information have begun to reach the Conclave of Argonessen from rogue dragons and agents of the Chamber operating in Sarlona that the Inspired lords of Riedra have actually been conducting breeding experiments on captured dragons for several centuries. The Inspired have sought to create a new, psionically-active family of dragon known as gem dragons that can serve as draconic hosts for quori spirits much as the human Chosen have been bred by the quori over the centuries to serve as hosts for new Inspired.

Since arcane magic suffuses the very essence of all dragons, those rare few wyrms who try and master psychic disciplines are usually driven insane as their mental powers clash with their natural arcane strength. As a result, were the dragons of Argonessen to unearth hard information that the Inspired have been breeding psionic draconic hosts, it is likely that Argonessen's military forces,

the Eyes of Chronopsis and the Light of Siberys, would descend on Sarlona in a mass whirlwind of pure destruction not seen since the fall of the giant civilizations on Xen'drik.

However, Sarlona is home to one group of dragons who have completely cut themselves off from their brethren on Argonessen—the Storm Guardians of Adar, a clan of blue dragons that calls the tallest peak in the mountainous land of Adar home. Many Adarans believe these majestic wyrms are responsible for the constant storms that plague and defend Adar's borders from the Inspired of Riedra. Adarans imagine that a draconic heart beats at the center of every thunderhead that blows over the land of refuge. Those Adarans are close to correct. The Storm Guardians might be mythic figures, but they are real. They, however, have not been corrupted by their time in Adar or on Korrandar, the great, storm-shrouded volcanic mountain that is the tallest peak in Adar and the Storm Guardians' home. Concerned with the protection of a realm shaped long ago by dragon and couatl magic, the Storm Guardians watch from above and below. They count among their number dragon turtles and sea drakes that stalk the oceans around Adar. Such sea dragons often attack any flotilla that contains more than a few ships.

Most of these dragons are aloof from mortal concerns, but their hold in Korrandar contains what could be considered the soul of Adar—the *Teeth of the Three*. An awe-inspiring and majestic piece of dragon artifice, the *Teeth of the Three* could be the hope of Adar, and perhaps for all of Eberron, in resisting the machinations of the Dreaming Dark. The *Teeth of the Three* is a breathtaking conglomerate crystal made up of three dragonshards of a size never seen in modern Eberron. In the center is a Khyber shard. An Eberron shard and a Siberys shard join the Khyber shard at the base and emerge from that point at 45-degree angles. Each shard is easily double the height of a full-grown human and as wide as that person is tall. Motes of golden, violet, and crimson light seem to materialize near and flow into the crystals, and a diaphanous shaft of silver radiance surges from the center of each upward. This flow forms a wavering flame that dissipates at about 5 feet above the artifact.

The *Teeth of the Three* rests above the head of a creature of legend—a slumbering rakshasa Overlord named Ran Iishiv—and if destroyed, it could spell doom for Adar, Sarlona, and the whole world. This incredible item is a magical focus that might be responsible for Adar's odd mixture of planar energy and the physical manifestations of it as the storms that constantly lash the mountainous kingdom. It could have been why the kalashtar's rebel quori founders were able to cross the barrier between the Plane of Dreams and the world into Adar. The *Teeth of the Three* is a joining of three dragonshards, each amplifying the others' power. It is a nexus that vents the fiendish Overlord's wrath into Adar's storms, at the same time focusing eldritch power to keep Adar as the dragons want

it. The *Teeth of the Three* is a major component of the draconic Prophecy and the dragons who chose to live in Sarlona created it based on their auguries. The artifact seems to pull certain creatures near (such as those who value freedom, life and balance) and push others (like evil and unaligned immortals) away. It is also a massive psychic and magical focus.

It should be possible to tie Adar's magical Shroud to the *Teeth of the Three*, greatly reducing the maintenance the Shroud requires and strengthening its properties. Perhaps such a network is what the dragons sought to build all along. When Ran Iishiv and its fiendish minions were trapped beneath Adar at the end of the great Dragon-Fiend War, the Overlord's rage was so great that the land around its prison boiled, hurling up the great volcano Korrandar. The *Teeth of the Three* was put in place, and the dragons focused their most puissant magic through it to bring the plane of Lamannia, the Twilight Forest, closer to Eberron, though Ran Iishiv's chaotic mind also attracted Kythri, the Churning Chaos' influence. With access to elemental forces drawn from the planes, the dragons pushed the land of Adar higher and a surviving couatl joined with the crystal to channel Ran Iishiv's fury.

The plan worked, as did the idea to channel Ran Iishiv's violent passion into supernatural and natural storms that rage in Adar. The dragons foresaw they would need these storms to protect their hold in Korrandar. Strangely, this has an affect in Adar—whenever more than a few score persons act in anger or violence in the land of refuge, a magical trigger causes a terrible storm (a hurricane on the coast or a tornado-spawning thunderstorm inland) to manifest in the area of the battle. Such a storm is worse for those without shelter in the mountains—a Riedran siege force, for example. The artifact, if it could be freed from its current role of enhancing Adar's defensive weather patterns, could also be transformed into a powerful weapon against the Inspired, since the artifact can trap the soul of any fiend or evil immortal (like the quori spirit of an Inspired) that touches it. The ancestors of the Storm Guardians came to Sarlona long ago, after the end of the Dragon-Fiend War, largely out of a sense of guilt that the dragons had left their couatl allies to make the final sacrifice to imprison the fiendish Overlords alone. The Storm Guardians still look after the couatl ruins that cover Sarlona but view the creation and protection of the *Teeth of the Three* as their most important task—and perhaps the source of their eventual redemption.

Of Sarlona's early human history, almost nothing is conclusively known. Several legendary human kingdoms and empires are said to have risen and fallen here, but only two of those—Aventus and Uoraala—have any general acceptance as having actually existed among Khorvarien scholars of ancient history. Aventus is the common name for a land thought to be called “Aventuu'siana,” though debate ensues as to whether this name refers to the nation or its legendary sorcerer-kings. Aventus is

known today primarily through an aquatic race of the Sea of Rage called the aventi. Thought to be the descendants of Aventus, the aventi have an oral history that tells the story of a kingdom brought down by unnatural devastation, then swallowed by the sea. The Aventus Islands now carry the name of the kingdom that reportedly once stood there. Those isles belonged to the Kingdom of Khunan prior to that land's destruction and rebirth as Syrkarn; now, they are counted as part of the Riedran province of Rhiavhaar.

The Empire of Uoraala presents a tale at odds with much of Sarlona's endless history of increasingly advanced kingdoms razing each other and their neighbors. A race of barbarian nomads having no capital city and no fixed borders, the Uoraala are nonetheless thought to have forged an alliance of northern city-states that in time came to dominate Sarlona down to the Andnemun Desert. The Uoraala were mercenary tribes of the steppes, their archers and cavalry in high demand among the northern city-states around what is now Rhialuun. But when those powers' insatiable demand for troops to throw against each other's walls ultimately resulted in each having more Uoraala mercenaries in their ranks than native soldiers, the war chief Uor (possibly so named after the fact) called on his people to turn against their lords. In a brutally short campaign, a simultaneous three-part military coup saw the creation of the new kingdom that bore its founder's name. The Empire of Uoraala is said to have stood for nearly four hundred years before dissolving in violent political infighting.

Of all the ancient human history of Sarlona, one critical piece is known not because the Sarlonans kept a record of it, but because of its lasting repercussions beyond that land, and this is the expedition of Lhazaar to Khorvaire related above.

To an examination of the existing nations of Sarlona we now turn.

Adar¹⁷



Estimates based on casual psionic census, 1,800 AT (998 YK).

Population: 320,000 (51% human, 45% kalashtar, 4% other).

Area: 745,000 square miles.

Sovereign: Chanaakar, the Speaker of the Word (unofficial).

Capital: Kasshta Keep (unofficial).

Major Cities: Dvaarnava, Haztaratain Monastery, Malshashar, Tashalatora, Xephanan, Zi'til'natek.

Climate: Temperate with warm lowlands and cold highlands.

Highest Point: The peak of Korrandar, elevation 32,495 feet.

Heraldry: The closest to a national symbol in Adar is the symbol of the Path of Light religion

Founder: Unknown.

National Motto: “The storm cannot move the mountain.”

Adar is a nation concerned with survival. At one time, Adarans could get along without working together, but that all changed when the Inspired began their siege on the mountainous land.

¹⁷ No one authority rules Adar. Excluding elders among the mountainfolk, the major points of power in the land are the eight monastery fortresses that guard passes and weak points in Adar's redoubtable terrain. Each of these citadels is a center of power for a specific set of monks and kalashtar. Two factors do keep Adar unified, however. First is the presence of the kalashtar; second is the threat of the Inspired. The aforementioned rule by elders is prevalent in Adaran society. The wisest and eldest lead. Wisdom supersedes age, so many “elders” are not old at all, but often the wisest folk are the oldest. Each elder represents a section of a settlement's population, and that group trusts the elder to look out for them. These elders make decisions for a settlement as a group. The most respected elder, a male or female who has the confidence of all local elders, heads a local council. Such a person is a leader among equals, not a chieftain. Little dishonesty occurs in this system—those who are incompetent or corrupt are quickly replaced. For the most part, merit determines power in Adar. Among Adarans, the Speaker of the Word in Kasshta Keep is a respected figure. The Speaker position has existed far longer than the kalashtar have been in Adar—even they revere the wisdom of the Speaker of the Word. Although the Speaker holds no actual authority, words from this person can move the citizens of Adar to action and sway the minds of masters in other monasteries. Throughout the ages, Speakers have been reputed to be dispassionate and invariably long-sighted. Speakers often suggest their successors, but the Keepers' Council of the Wise makes the final choice. Adarans often speak of former Speakers as if they were highly regarded ancestors.

Date

1301 AT (499 YK)
1365 AT (563 YK)
1579 AT (777 YK)
1658 AT (856 YK)
1761 AT (959 YK)

Speaker

Biiptanu (human female)
Noovakhad (kalashtar male)
Geet (human male)
Geetru (human female, Geet's daughter)
Chanaakar (human male)

The sacrifice of Taratai threw the invading forces back and left the magical Shroud that protects Adar to this day from the Inspired. Still, Adarans know that internal strife is the surest means to their destruction.

Adar's high passes (and the hidden fortress-monasteries guarding them) shelter it from direct assault. Water, a border with Syrkarn, and the largest concentration of defenders in Adar all help to protect Kasshta Keep. The Riedran war machine has yet to find a way to alter the frequent storms that howl out of the mountains. Similar storms occur daily over the waters around Adar, and mighty beasts prowl the seas, as if nature conspires to keep Adar secure. The quori who inhabit the Inspired's bodies actually fear the spirit-binding magic employed by Adar's Keepers of the Word. Immortality is no defense against such sorcery. These truths said, if the Inspired acquired enough intelligence to locate the fortresses in Adar and a way to breach the Shroud, they could strike quickly and take out Adar's major defenses. As it stands, Riedran patrols and feints on the borders cause many Adaran deaths and many more Riedran casualties. Adarans, especially those living on the borders, are accustomed to the heartbreak engendered by loss.

Adar is as a land seemingly plucked from some other realm. Among the mountains that spring up like giants' finger-bones from southern Sarlona, manifestations of other worlds and the natural results of such interference conspire to produce a forbidding environment. Yet, amid unforgiving peaks and between terrible storms, life thrives and evolves. The word Adar means "refuge" in an ancient Riedran dialect; this etymology shows that Adar was named from without. Its people have never been unified—clashes among its mountainfolk continue intermittently, and rancorous debates arise among its mystics. Still, Adar has long been a place of peace and introspection on a continent known for its terrible wars. Only when Adar accepted the strangest refugees of all—renegade quori—did it become a realm beset on all sides by immortal enemies. Adarans must now work together or become instruments of the Inspired.

The earliest tribesfolk who made a home in the deep mountains and valleys called their land *Sthanadiv* ("Land of Earth-Sky"). To this day, Adar is a land of extremes. Korrandar is one of Eberron's tallest peaks, measuring 32,495 feet at its storm-shrouded peak. Nearby gorges plunge to below sea level, filled with the raging waters of glacial and storm runoff. The ocean off Adar's southern horn is extremely deep, and the whole coast has none of the normal continental shelf found around most other lands.

Instead, the sea floor is ragged with mountains. Less than half of Adar's land is below 12,000 feet, and much of that is forested with stout, tough evergreens. The regions above the treeline are arid

and windswept, useless for farming or herding. Glaciers creep across the high passes. As the mountains give way to Adar's high plateau, alluvial hills and stretches of green valley appear, making about 20% of the land arable. The temperatures in deep valleys can be tropical, though usually mild in humidity, and the flora and fauna in such places are abundant. Trees can grow tall here, and some bear succulent fruit. On the high peaks, nothing lives aside from supernatural creatures. In these places, the cold, clouds, and wind are constant.

A stiff breeze is always blowing in Adar, so the wind is continuously strong. In windy Adar, it is never foggy, though rolling clouds might make it seem so at higher elevations. Precipitation is always rain, snow, sleet, or hail—often more than one kind at a time. Powerful storms are common, as are avalanches, earthquakes, flash floods, and mudslides.

Most of Adar is trackless mountains or hills. Altitude sickness can be a problem, but many of Adar's inhabitants are acclimated to life among the high peaks. The mountains are also twisting and treacherous and avalanches are a constant danger to travelers.

Most Adarans are human or kalashtar, rugged mountainfolk who respect wisdom and action. A handful of half-giant families called the pathadrik (drifting giants) wander gypsy-like among the settlements and monasteries. Adarans are resilient and industrious, reserved and incisive. They care about the sensible and the mystical, and the harshness of life among the peaks has not made them grim or fatalistic. Typical Adarans are guarded with strangers but openly emotional among their friends and family. Life is too short to waste time with pretension, and the Path of Light teaches integrity and honesty.

Adarans are generally distrustful. More than a thousand years of siege has taught them to be that way. Most Adarans tend to reject the novel and the strange, preferring the known and the trustworthy. If someone manages to earn an Adaran's gratitude or trust, the resultant loyalty is deep.

Normal Adarans live simply compared to the people of tamer lands. That is not to say they live without joy or comfort, but that they have access to fewer diversions and luxuries. Given this, an Adaran takes great joy in work and leisure and similar pride in strong relationships. To an Adaran, real luxury is found in a sturdy house, loose and comfortable clothing, and another's warm arms to curl up in before sleep. An Adaran toils in the fields, drives animals in small pastures, or hunts in the mountains, then gathers with friends at night to tell stories, make beer and bread, and enjoy a smoke. Adarans value the spiritual because they know material existence is fleeting. They respect the primal spirits of the land along with their ancestors, elders, and those who show good judgment. Spirituality has its place in everything, from patterns of weaving to actual meditation. The arcanists, martial artists, and psychics who protect Adar seek perfection in body and mind. They have to. At any

moment, they might be required to offer body and soul to hold Adar against the Inspired. Even the commoners know that meditation on the Path of Light is important work, not laziness or inaction. In fact, inaction can be considered evil.

Real evil lives in Adar, though. Although the vast majority of folk are concerned with the welfare of at least their local friends and families, a few of Adar's residents are descendants of those who came to the land of refuge to escape persecution or prosecution rightly deserved. Even so, wicked Adarans try to maintain a veneer of propriety—acting honest and assiduous so they can better survive.

Traditional Adaran prayers call on Braahyn (Balinor), the god of the wilds and the moving earth, and his spouse Araakti (Arawai). Many people also respect the primal spirits of nature and those of their departed ancestors. The Path of Light, the dominant religion in Adar, has all but eclipsed these other spiritual practices. Its message has proven preferable to the rule of remote gods and a cold and meaningless end to life in Dolurh. It is a path of choosing one's own destiny and possibly even eventually transcending death itself.

Practitioners on the Path of Light hope to change the *Quor Tarai* of Dal Quor from its current nightmare manifestation of *il-Lashtavar*, the Dreaming Dark, to a tranquil dream centering on *il-Yannah*, the Great Light. Traditionally, contemplation of peace and kindness coupled with similar actions in the world are thought to be enough to eventually change the *Quor Tarai*. The lightbringers (*yannahsur*) among the Path's devotees do just that. Direct action against evil is secondary, and opposition is sometimes seen as reinforcing malevolence by investing energy in it. It is necessary, however, to have those faithful who are prepared to take action. These believers are called shadow watchers (*sheshantol*). Younger kalashtar, and those kalashtar who have made their way from Sarlona to Khorvaire (where they have come under the influence of undisciplined minds or human urges, say some elders) have taken a stronger stand against the Dreaming Dark. These spiritual warriors point to the actions of Taratai, the Path of Light's greatest saint, and have begun to take the war to the Inspired. Priests of the Path of Light can be either lightbringers or shadow watchers, but all such clergy have duties to their communities that preclude constant meditation. Such priests are called lightspeakers (*yannahilath*). They are expected to be shining examples of the Path of Light. Adaran lightspeakers can be of any race, but most are human or kalashtar.

The people of Adar also revere the legend of Taratai. Taratai was the mysterious kalaraq-caste quori spirit that led the other dissident quori spirits into Adar to create the kalashtar and teach the Path of Light. She is a holy mother, a guide, and a warrior. Everyone knows of her sacrifice, and

many people in Adar set aside five days of winter to mourn her passing. This “holiday” is called the Void of Taratai.

Adar has no standing army and its defenders are not organized armies like those of Riedra or the Five Nations of Khorvaire. In Adar, armored soldiers carrying halberds are not the normal defenders of monasteries and temple-fortresses. Even in the villages of the mountains, a town’s defender is more likely to be skilled in unarmed combat than to be reliant on heavy weapons and armor. About one-third of Adar’s chief defenders are kalashtar and most are rogues, monks, wizards, monks and psions rather than fighters or more common martial troops. Perhaps the most famous defenders of Adar are the guides and trailblazers of the Summit Road organization (see below).

Riedra



Data based on psionic census, 1300 Unity (998 YK).

Population: 13,878,000 (racial breakdowns vary by province).

Area: 6,800,000 square miles.

Sovereign: The Inspired Lords of the Unity.

Capital: Durat Tal.

Major Cities: Dar Jin, Dar Ulatesh, Dul Catun, Dul Jhaar, Dul Zeer.

Climate: Varied.

Highest Point: The Crimson Peak, elevation 15,565 feet.

Heraldry: The crystal seed of the Path of Inspiration contained in a red ring, set against a black field.

Founder: The Inspired.

National Motto: “Follow the path.”

Once Sarlona was a land of many nations. These kingdoms had their heroes and gods—a host of proud and unique traditions. Fifteen hundred years ago, a force reached out of nightmare to claim Sarlona. Over the course of two centuries, the Twelve Kingdoms of Sarlona were shattered by war and psychic subversion. The Inspired rose among the ruins and forged a new, unified kingdom from the wreckage—the vast empire known as Riedra.

The provinces of Riedra were largely based on the original Twelve Kingdoms of Sarlona that they had replaced. Dor Maleer shares a border with the Tashana Tundra—a border that has been slowly shifting north over the centuries. Prior to the Sundering of Sarlona, Dor Maleer was a loose federation of clans of many races, including Akiak dwarves, Qiku shifters, and half-giants. During the Unification, the humans and shifters of the region were absorbed into the Riedran empire. The dwarf population of Dor Maleer was virtually exterminated in the Night of Razor Dreams. Dor Maleer is the Riedran frontier, and its people are not as fanatically devoted to the Inspired as their counterparts are in many of the southern provinces. Maleeri are more tolerant of nonhumans than most Riedrans, though dwarves typically receive an unfriendly reaction. Although they perform what agriculture they can in the harsh environment, the Maleeri are primarily hunters, and they respect

such skills. Traditionally, anyone who brings meat to a Maleeri village is invited to stay and join in the meal.

The coastal nation of Rhiavhaar was the homeland of Lhazaar, the “explorer” who paved the way for the human settlement of Khorvaire. The sailors of Rhiavhaar often took to slaving and piracy, and Rhiavhaarian ships were feared throughout the Sea of Rage. Today this region is the westernmost outpost of Riedra, and authorized trade with the Kingdom of Q’barra and the Lhazaar Principalities in Khorvaire passes through the old Rhiavhaar port of Dar Ulatesh. Rhiavhaar is an important hub for the Riedran Navy—known as the Harmonious Sail—and a gateway to Khorvaire, so significant military forces are deployed here. The Thousand Eyes—the Riedran secret police—are especially active in this region. The province of Rhiavhaar includes the Aventus Islands, which serve as a staging area for the Harmonious Sail. These islands hold ruins of the lost aventi nation, but the Riedrans shun these areas. Although the province seems to be under the thumb of the Inspired, having a high concentration of spies and secret police, the Rhiavhaarians are not as devoted to Riedra’s way of life as the Corvagurans. A variety of dissidents hide here.

Khalesh was once a theocratic nation dedicated to the worship of the couatl, with a long history of crusades. During the Sundering, it was revealed that many of the noble families of Khalesh were actually shulassakar. The Inspired combined the general disdain for Khalesh with fear of these alien creatures, and the Khaleshites were largely exterminated over centuries of war. The humans inhabiting the region today are mostly descended from resettled people transported into the province from the west. The Khalesh region includes a number of couatl ruins from the Age of Demons. The Inspired work to suppress knowledge of these ruins, which are hidden in wild zones and protected by the Edgewalkers. The people of Khalesh know that “demons” (actually the benevolent shulassakar) once ruled their land. As a result, they are especially devoted to the Path of Inspiration, believing that great faith is required to resist the temptations of the *altavars*. They shun the ancient ruins and do not assist those who want to explore them.

The Nulakesh Empire dominated central Sarlona for centuries before the Sundering. Nulakesh lacked the magical or philosophical sophistication of many of the smaller Sarlonan kingdoms, but it had a large, dedicated population and extensive natural resources, along with a superbly disciplined army. Nulakesh went through many periods of expansion and decline over the centuries, and it was fading when the quori came to Sarlona. Dream manipulation helped inspire the Nulakeshi war leaders to reclaim their ancestral glory and, later, to convert the disgruntled populace to the Path of Inspiration. The strong martial tradition continues to the present day, and much of the Harmonious Shield is recruited from this province. The Nulakeshi despise nonhumans; as a result, shifters and

ogres are rarely deployed in this province by the Inspired. The Nulakeshi are deeply devoted to the Inspired, and the daily exercises of the peasants often have a martial theme. Many people who would be farmers in other provinces are instead trained as warriors.

Borunan is the homeland of the ogres, another intelligent race native to Sarlona. It is a barren and hostile region, spread across the Andnemun Desert and the Kelshak Mountains. Before the Sundering, the ogres had a brutal and aggressive culture, dominated by powerful oni lords. Despite their martial might, the ogres rarely threatened the other kingdoms; the Borunan clans considered humans to be unworthy foes and devoted their energy to internal struggles. Over the course of the Sundering and the Unification, the ogres were brought under Riedran rule and forcibly converted to the Path of Inspiration. Those who resisted were killed or driven into Syrkarn, where they spawned the mongrel ogres, or eneko, through interbreeding with that land's half-giants. Today the ogres are a surprisingly peaceful folk, their warlike culture expunged by the Inspired. Although ogres form the bulk of the population in Borunan, all villages have Chosen overseers, and human and shifter troops are found in the bastion cities. The people of Borunan tend to be cheerful and straightforward. Feats of strength are admired; a human is not expected to match an ogre but still earns respect for proving his prowess. Athletic events typically include weightlifting and throwing contests.

The pre-Unity people of Ohr Kaluun were driven by a thirst for magical knowledge and a deep paranoia that spread through every level of society. The islands' wizards and priests sought power at any cost, and their pursuit of dark magic often set them at odds with Khaleshite crusaders and Pyrinean scholars. The Kaluunites devoted vast resources to fortification and security, creating labyrinths reinforced with steel, stone, and magic. Unfortunately for them, however, these static defenses could not protect them from the quori, who used dream manipulation to turn Kaluunite factions against one another. Today the mazes of Ohr Kaluun are vast ruins, shunned by loyal Riedrans. The Inspired wield considerable influence on Ohr Kel, the largest island of the chain, while many of the smaller islands are uncivilized by the standards of the Inspired. These places are home to smugglers, monsters, and the dark Riedran dissident group known as the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun. Adventurers seeking to enter Riedra by stealth might be able to find assistance at a smuggler's port. However, the Riedran military is always hunting for these criminals and safe havens frequently move about.

Worship of the Sovereign Host takes many forms in different cultures, but the religion as practiced by most of the humans of Khorvair can be traced back to the Sarlonan kingdom of Pyrine. The Pyrineans placed great value on wisdom and philosophy, and Pyrinean tutors and priests served in courts across Sarlona. However, their faith failed to protect the Pyrineans from the quori. During

the Sundering, the Pyrinean church was torn apart by schisms and heresies, and Pyrine was crushed by the forces of Nulakesh and Ohr Kaluun. Although most of the libraries and temples have been destroyed, explorers might be able to find hidden vaults of knowledge or ancient shrines providing new insight into the worship of the Sovereign Host and the development of that faith. The Pyrinean love of philosophy has made them devoted to the Path of Inspiration—although not as aggressively fanatical to the doctrine as the people of Corvagura or Nulakesh. Many Riedran clerics come from this province. Pyrine is one of the most peaceful provinces of Riedra, and the Thousand Eyes and the Harmonious Shield have a reduced presence in this region. Even though they are dedicated to the Inspired, Pyrineans are not as hostile toward foreigners as other Riedrans are; many Pyrineans enjoy having the opportunity to proselytize and discuss their faith with outlanders.

A land of lush jungles and fertile plains, Corvagura is in many ways the heart of Riedra; it has the highest population density of any region in Sarlona, and both the Riedran capital city of Durat Tal and the primary port, Dar Jin, are located here. The people of Corvagura once served a tyrannical dynasty of sorcerer-kings, but the Inspired helped overthrow these dictators. In addition to having the highest population of the eight provinces, Corvagura also has the greatest number of psychic monoliths (*hanbalani*), a fact that undoubtedly contributes to the fanatical loyalty of the inhabitants to the Inspired. Many branches of the Unity are based in the bastions of Corvagura. A few of the other bastions are dedicated to research; noteworthy subjects include behavior modification, eugenics (specifically, the breeding of improved vessels for the Inspired), and planar theory. Politically and in terms of population, Corvagura is the crown province of Riedra. The inhabitants are deeply devoted to the Inspired, and the bulk of Riedrans who are allowed to interact with foreigners—including most sailors and merchants—are Corvaguran.

In the steppes and savannah of what is now Syrkarn, Mae Khree, Sunyagir, and Lamecha effectively orbited the more powerful Khunan, carving out specific niches for themselves (agriculture for Lamecha, the breeding and training of Sarlona's finest horses for Mae Khree, and the mining of iron, mithril, gems and other precious minerals for Sunyagir). At the same time, each nation made a point of maintaining armies and magical might just powerful enough to keep Khunan and the northern nations from getting any expansionistic ideas. All three kingdoms were wiped from the face of Sarlona by the Sundering.

Today, Riedra's eight provinces—Borunan, Corvagura, Dor Maleer, Khalesh, Nulakesh, Ohr Kaluun, Pyrine, and Rhiavhaar—are divided into territories known as spheres. A sphere is a circular region centered on a fortress-city called a bastion, which is ruled by a particular Inspired lord. The territory takes its name from its master—the city of Durat Tal is in the Sphere of Surasek, in the

province of Corvagura. All Inspired hold the title of Lord or Lady; the ultimate leader of a bastion carries the title of Eidolon.

The typical bastion is a metropolis, and many of them rival Sharn, the biggest city in Khorvaire, in population. They are centers of industrial production, supporting the bulk of a sphere's troops. Surrounding a bastion is a network of villages, spread out in as orderly a manner as possible, taking environmental factors and resources into account. A sphere contains dozens of villages. Most villages focus on agriculture and simple industry. Although some variance in styles and customs exists from province to province, villages within a sphere are virtually identical. No thorps, hamlets, or towns can be found—when a population rises to a sufficient level, the Inspired draw off the excess to create a new village. Riedran villages are functional and ascetic in design. The community is centered around a building that serves as a dining hall and a public assembly, where people gather to listen to the sermons of the local priest or to hear stories of the glorious deeds of the Inspired. Villagers live in communal dormitories, with separate houses for children.

While Riedra has no lightning rail, villages and spheres are linked by a comprehensive network of maintained roads. The Inspired also have a secret system of *psionic teleportation circles* at their disposal, passing through the central hub of Durat Tal. The number of gates is limited. The Inspired can teleport cargo directly from Dar Jin to Durat Tal, but getting those goods to the village of Keloar, for example, requires a caravan.

The rulers of Riedra are the quori. All important decisions concerning the fate of the nation are made in Dal Quor. The bastion lords do not gather in Riedra to debate policy, because such councils are held in Dal Quor. To a foreigner, it seems that the bastion lords and generals of the Harmonious Shield operate unilaterally; however, they all act in perfect accord with the plans formulated in the Plane of Dreams.

While the destiny of Riedra is set in dreams, a complex bureaucracy manages its daily affairs. The Inspired hold the top tier. A powerful Inspired noble rules each bastion city, and Inspired serve as generals, ambassadors, inquisitors, and high ministers. Although powerful, high-caste Inspired are rare, lesser Inspired serve throughout Riedran society, in positions where trust or psionic power are required. Beholden to the Inspired, the Chosen dedicate themselves to being worthy of inhabitation by an *il-altas*. They manage the bulk of the administration of Riedra, also serving as officers in the military. The Chosen, unpossessed human vessels for the quori, serve as the overseers who govern most villages. The most important positions are granted to Chosen who served as Inspired before their quori spirits moved on to other hosts; after decades of possession, the minds of these individuals have been molded by the quori, and they are fully trusted by the Inspired overlords. Whether

Inspired, Chosen, or commoner, Riedrans serve in one of four groups: the Unity, the Thousand Eyes, the Harmonious Shield, or the Dreaming Dark.

The Unity forms the foundation of Riedra, and the vast majority of the Riedran population serves one of its branches. While each branch of the Unity has its own ministers, the seven arms work together in the service of the empire and answer to the local bastion lords. This arrangement separates the Unity from the Thousand Eyes and Harmonious Shield, which both follow different chains of command. All of the Unity's different branch High Ministers are psions. The branches of the Unity include:

The Bountiful Horn: This branch of the Unity oversees Riedran agriculture. Farmers are servants of the Horn, while Chosen administrators tend to storage, distribution, and planning duties. The city of Dul Maar is the seat of the Horn, and its High Minister is Lady Tantashar, a powerful female hashalaq-caste psion.

The Industrious Forge: The Forge manages industry, from the acquisition of raw supplies to the production and distribution of finished goods. Lord Malukath, another male hashalaq-caste Inspired, guides this branch of the Unity from the massive bastion of Dul Kalent.

The Sturdy Wall: This group tends to the infrastructure of the nation, construction, villages, bastions, roads, and the monoliths. It is based in the bastion of Dul Borin under the leadership of Lord Laneth, a male hashalaq-caste Inspired.

The Healing Hand: Overseeing the health of the people, servants of the Hand rely largely on natural healing techniques to care for their charges rather than divine or arcane magic. Bastion-cities include multiple halls of the Hand. Most people receive mundane healing care, but bastion halls might have access to more powerful arcane healing tools. Although the Healing Hand is generally benevolent, it has its darker side. Euthanasia is perfectly acceptable in Riedran society, and the needs of the state always come before those of the individual. If someone who has a genetic condition, a grievous injury, or a serious contagious disease cannot be easily cured, he will be painlessly killed. The Healing Hand also disposes of the dead, typically through cremation. Lady Xushila, a female usvapna-caste Inspired, leads the Healing Hand from the bastion of Dar Hash.

The Sheltering Hearth: The duties of the Hearth range from sanitation to disaster relief. Leaders of the organization serve as liaisons with the other branches of government; if a plague breaks out, the Hearth works with the Healing Hand and the Thousand Eyes to isolate and kill those infected before the disease can spread. In general, the Hearth serves as a sort of emergency management branch of the Riedran state. The Hearth can request the aid of the Thousand Eyes to deal

with certain situations that threaten the security of Riedra but cannot demand it. Lord Dulateth, a male hashalaq-caste Inspired, directs the Sheltering Hearth from the bastion-city of Dar Uldane.

The Guiding Path: This branch oversees education and religion. It is responsible for raising Riedran children, a task that involves equal parts education and indoctrination. When a youth becomes an adult, the pathfinders choose his trade and his pairing. The Guiding Path is led by Lord Surasek, a male kalaraq-caste Inspired, from the city of Durat Tal.

The Iron Gate: The Gate deals with Riedra's foreign affairs, including trade and diplomacy. It oversees all traffic between Riedra and other nations; any Riedran who could come into contact with foreigners—from Lhazaarite sailors to dragonmarked house servants—is carefully vetted. Lady Tureya, a female usvapna-caste Inspired, oversees the Iron Gate from the port of Dar Jin, one of only two Riedran cities where foreigners are allowed entry into the empire.

The Harmonious Shield is the army that stands between Riedra and the countless dangers of the outside world. Whether they are fighting the kalashtar on the Adaran front, combating dromite forays, hunting dwarves in Dor Maleer, or battling skulks in the ruins of Ohr Kaluun, the soldiers of the Harmonious Shield serve the Inspired on the field of battle.

The Harmonious Shield maintains garrisons in the bastion-cities, and it has independent fortresses spread along the borders and in areas deemed to be especially dangerous. The largest Riedran fortresses are called kintams. They are connected by permanent *psionic teleportation circles*, which allow swift transportation of troops and supplies in the event of an emergency. Kintams can be the size of cities, and new recruits of the Harmonious Shield are usually dispatched to a kintam to learn their trade.

Years of daily psychic indoctrination teach Riedran soldiers that honorable death in battle is the surest path to advancement in the next life. Discipline within the ranks is strict, and looting and rapine are serious offenses. A soldier needs nothing that is not given to him by the Inspired. The same training burns mercy and empathy from the minds of Riedran soldiers, so a servant of the Shield feels nothing for the people he kills. This conditioning does not always take hold, however, and a few recruits find themselves horrified by the brutal actions they must perform. Such a warrior must either suppress these emotions or find a way to escape before his “weakness” is discovered. Riedran warriors believe they are fighting for a holy cause against monsters and those corrupted by evil spirits. Fiercely devoted to their nation, they are no more evil than the typical Brelish conscript or knight of Thrane. The Harmonious Shield trains and equips troops for a variety of roles; most soldiers are 2nd-level fighters. The different specialist groups of the Harmonious Shield include the following:

The Stone Soldiers: Most of these soldiers are equipped with chainmail, Riedran-style longswords, and large shields, supplemented by troops wielding reach polearms. Elite stone soldiers are usually fighters, and they are equipped with banded mail and tower shields. Stone soldiers are typically assigned to defend fortresses or to battle the Akiak dwarves or dromite hives—situations where durability is more important than speed.

Air Soldiers: These troops are equipped with longbows and studded leather armor, and they are expected to stay distant from the enemy. Elite air soldiers are fighters and such soldiers are armed with longbows. Air soldiers can be found on most fronts and are the standard Riedran light infantry.

Fire Soldiers: Wearing chainmail shirts and carrying shortbows and greatswords, these soldiers are often used in raids on Adar, when speed and the ability to hit hard and fast are vital.

Water Soldiers: The Water Soldiers are the special forces of the Harmonious Shield, and most recruits chosen for the Water Soldiers are able to move and react swiftly. A Water Soldier's gear depends on the soldier's specialties and the assignment. Water Soldiers work independent of the other units in the Harmonious Shield, in small squads. Although they are occasionally sent into Adar, Water Soldiers are typically used in strikes against dissident groups.

The Bastion Guard: These soldiers work with the Thousand Eyes to maintain order in Riedran cities. This is considered the worst duty within the Shield, since bastion guards rarely see combat.

The Edgewalkers: This special order of supernatural combat specialists patrol the borders of the Sarlonan wild zones and other dangerous regions of the continent where interplanar activity manifests itself, keeping the horrors within from escaping to harm innocent Riedrans. See more on the Edgewalkers below in the *Organizations of Sarlona* section.

The Harmonious Sail: The Riedran Navy, known as the Harmonious Sail, transports Riedran soldiers and patrols the Riedran coasts in search of smugglers and would-be infiltrators from Adar, the Tashana Tundra or Khorvaire.

The Horned Guard: The Horned Guard is an elite force of onis, indoctrinated into Riedran military service as one of the most powerful weapons at the Inspired's disposal.

The Savage Legion: Also known as the Taskaan Legion, this group of Riedran shock troopers is composed of nonhumans—primarily shifters, but including ogres, half-giants, and a few eneko from Syrkarn. Each bastion lord has his own Taskaan guards, raised from birth to serve their Inspired master.

The Sleeping Sword: Made up entirely of Chosen and Inspired (tsoreva-caste Inspired under the command of du'ulora-caste Inspired), this elite force is valued both for its power and its unquestioned loyalty to the state. It is assigned missions requiring psionic power and utter ruthlessness. Members of the Sleeping Sword are typically psions; a few are monks, employing the *Tashalatora* techniques also used by the kalashtar.

The Harmonious Shield also has access to a small corps of clerics of the Path of Inspiration. These holy warriors are reserved for the most dangerous and crucial operations that confront Riedran forces. Harmonious Shield troops are commanded by Chosen and Inspired, who are also typically psions. The High Minister of the Riedran military is the legendary Lord Zoratesh, an incredibly powerful kalaraq-casted Inspired psion.

The population of Riedra is overwhelmingly human. Still, a few nonhuman races have been incorporated into Riedran society over the course of centuries. Members of these races can be seen in most bastion cities. Constant indoctrination and psychic reinforcement have drilled the concept of spiritual evolution into the Riedran consciousness. As a result, the typical Riedran ogre truly believes that he is inferior to the average human, but that he was born an ogre to fulfill a specific piece of his destiny. As strange as it often seems to travelers from Khorvaire, many members of these “lower races” are the most loyal servants of the Inspired. They believe they have farther to go in their spiritual journey and must work that much harder.

According to the Path of Inspiration, the changeling stands between humans and the Chosen. His ability to assume different identities is a tool to help him escape the prison of himself. He is preparing for the selfless service that is required of the Inspired, and eventually to abandon the body completely and become pure spirit. Changelings are raised in the service of the Thousand Eyes, and they spend most of their time hidden within the populace, assuming whatever identity serves the needs of the Inspired. It is an austere, ascetic life. A changeling should have as few attachments as possible and be ready to sacrifice everything—name, identity, possessions—at a moment's notice. A changeling in his natural form is treated with both respect and a slight degree of awed fear by the common folk. He might not be one of the Chosen, but he is a superior being and, most likely, a member of the secret police called the Thousand Eyes. This attitude serves to keep the changelings from using their abilities against the Inspired. The typical changeling believes that he is a hero on the verge of apotheosis. Some manage to avoid or overcome this indoctrination, but a changeling caught working against the Inspired receives no mercy. Riedran changelings are usually rogues, monks, occasionally mastering the arts of the assassin. A rare few are trained in the psionic arts.

So few in number that most Riedrans do not even know they exist, elans hold the essence of quori spirits condemned to eternal impotence for crimes against the quori, often involving endangering the stability of Riedra. Elans undergo the same indoctrination as other nonhumans, believing that they can reclaim the evil spirit within through noble action—a true indignity for the powerless quori, who can only watch as the elan draws on its power. Some elans, whether by force of will or remnants of a rebellious nature, ignore the Path and flee. Those who remain are most often assigned to the Edgewalkers, where their durability is vital.

The Path of Inspiration teaches that savage and simple souls are incarnated as beasts. The shifter stands at the threshold of humanity; he has earned the shape of a human, but he must prove himself lest he regress to an animal form in his next life. Almost all Riedran shifters are part of the Taskaan Legion (also known as the Savage Legion), the ruthless shock troops and household guards of the Inspired’s army, the Harmonious Shield. Each shifter line is tied to a particular *il-altas* and serves the Inspired lord that currently channels that spirit. The Taskaan uniform includes a leather collar bearing the sigil of the lord of the line. Life for a Taskaan shifter centers on war, and the greatest desire of the Taskaan soldier is to die in direct service to his master. Such a death is the surest path to spiritual advancement in the next life. The breeding and training programs of the Taskaan shifters focus on physical attributes. Members of the Savage Legion are typically fighters and barbarians, though some of the Inspired train their “hounds” to be rangers. Considered subhuman, a Taskaan shifter acting in the name of his Inspired lord nonetheless gains the authority to challenge even one of the Chosen. This is a source of great pride for the Taskaan. They are slaves. Like the other inhabitants of Riedra, however, they revel in their chains and pity their “free” cousins.

Over the course of many centuries, the ogres of Borunan have been conditioned to abhor violence. The strength of an ogre is a gift to be used in the service of the nation, not squandered in brawling and battle. Most ogres are devoted to heavy labor, and they are often found serving as miners, lumberjacks, masons, and in other roles requiring strength, endurance, and patience. Taskaan ogres are usually fighters or barbarians; they lack the sophistication required to master more complex vocations. Eneko—the mongrel ogres—are left to their own devices in Syrkarn. They are rarely allowed to exist in Riedra except as members of the Savage Legion. The Path of Inspiration teaches that the oni, once the ruling class of Borunan’s ogres, is a vessel for a lesser *altavar*. That fact explains the oni’s arcane powers and fiendish appearance. According to the Riedran doctrine, the oni has been crafted as a prison for the *altavar*; if the oni lives a noble life of service to the Inspired, he can actually redeem the evil spirit trapped within him. Such a tremendous victory surely earns the oni great advancement in his next life. Of course, the evil spirit tempts the oni, encouraging him to use

his power for personal gain or even trying to get him to turn against the Inspired. To do so might bring power in this life, but it forever dooms his soul. Regardless of conditioning, oni are constantly watched by the Thousand Eyes, the Inspired, and by their own kind. Combining intelligence and power, oni fill many roles. Still, the Inspired are unwilling to trust them with true authority. Oni are usually trained as fighters or monks. The most skilled serve the Taskaan Legion and the Thousand Eyes, while others help to coordinate the civil labors of their less intelligent ogre cousins.

Finally, to a Riedran, no one in his right mind turns against the Inspired. Those who do are clearly victims of influence by the *altavars*. Someone has to help these victims if possible, or do whatever is necessary to ensure that they do not threaten the spiritual advancement of other innocent souls. Those tasks fall to the Thousand Eyes—Riedra’s secret police force. The Thousand Eyes administers justice across Riedra and maintains the reclamation centers. Public agents of the Thousand Eyes—easily identified by their green uniforms and golden badges of office—can be found throughout any bastion city, and people take comfort in knowing that these guardians are always watching. Far more dangerous, however, are the secret members of the Eyes. Nearly anyone in Riedra could be an agent of the Eyes. Furthermore, even when no one is around, certain clairvoyant psychic abilities allow the Eyes to see the deeds of malefactors.

Agents of the Thousand Eyes are typically humans, Chosen, or changelings. The bulk are simply civilian observers, who used their crafts or professions as a cover. More capable agents tend to be rogues or monks, specializing in observation and stealth. Chosen and especially honored changelings are trained in the psychic arts. When force is required, the Thousand Eyes calls on Bastion Guards or the Sleeping Sword, but it also maintains a covert corps of changelings who serve as psychically-powerful assassins.

The city of Dul Zeer is the Thousand Eyes’ greatest stronghold. Here, a network of special psi-crystals allows agents to scry across the continent, and *psionic teleportation circles* let them dispatch forces to any bastion-city or kintam. Agents in villages can be alerted through dreams broadcast from Dal Quor or the closest *hanbalan* monolith. In an emergency, Inspired psions can teleport forces to the site of a disturbance using these circles. It is very difficult to do anything in Riedra without coming under the gaze of the Thousand Eyes. The High Minister of the Thousand Eyes is Lady Sharadhuna, a ruling kalaraq-caste female Inspired.

The final and perhaps most sinister organization that plays a major role in the lives of Riedrans is the Dreaming Dark, which is detailed below in the *Organizations of Sarlona* section.

Syrkarn

Estimates based on and extrapolated from the Khorvarien Varmanc Expedition.

Population: 260,000 (44% human, 42% eneko, 12% half-giant, 1% kalashtar, 1% other).

Area: 1,320,000 square miles.

Sovereign: None.

Capital: Nderitese (unofficial).

Major Settlements: Per, Gjitha, Maszani.

Climate: Temperate to tropical throughout; the equatorial heat is tempered by proximity to the Sea of Rage.

Highest Point: Mount Athay in the Kushtuar Hills, elevation 4,408 feet.

Heraldry: None.

Founder: Unknown.

National Motto: None.

Five thousand years before the arrival of the Inspired and the present age of Inspired dominance of Sarlona, the four kingdoms—Mae-Khree, Sunyagir, Khunan, Lamecha—now known collectively as Syrkarn were the jewels in the imperial crown of Old Sarlona’s Twelve Kingdoms. Today, only ancient stonework and half-forgotten legends mark the fall, passing, and rebirth of this land. Still, to those who have inherited this seemingly inhospitable kingdom, Syrkarn offers a gift denied to both the warring kingdoms of the past and the Inspired-dominated lands of the present. To its people and other Sarlonans who have come to hate and fear the domination of the Inspired, Syrkarn is a name that carries the promise of freedom.

Syrkarn is a vast expanse of arid plains where the four kingdoms of old once stood. Its history is rich with conflict and conquest, and it is one of the few places in Sarlona where the devastating effects of the ancient Magewars can still be seen, untouched by Inspired reconstruction. A land surrounded by Riedra yet distinct from it, Syrkarn has long been left to its own devices for reasons that none but the Inspired truly understand. Nearly all settlements in Syrkarn are agricultural centers—communal farmsteads (*daabi* in the Giant tongue) that trap the windblown soil of the steppes behind vast networks of berms and stone walls. However, nearly a third of Syrkarn's population lives on the open steppes. Though most are nomadic herders or hunters, a distinct class of traders (mostly eneko) are the lifeblood of commerce across the nation. Regular trade roads carry goods, laborers, and knowledge between the larger settlements, allowing the Syrks to maintain a social infrastructure that belies the land’s isolation.

According to the Unity of Riedra, Syrkarn is a protectorate of that empire, and ostensibly owes fealty to Riedra and the Inspired. In truth, however, the Inspired's last act of governance in Syrkarn was to order the land emptied of its human population in the aftermath of a victorious purge of the yuan-ti more than 1200 years ago.

“Sahar” is a general term of leadership common among both humans and eneko, but it can cover a wide range of power. The sahar of a nomadic tribe might rule only two dozen people, half of them her immediate family. The sahar of a large settlement might rule a mixed population of a thousand humans and eneko, and have ultimate authority over security, trade, and commerce in a wide region.

In larger settlements, sahar are usually elected to fixed-year terms, the exact length of which is set by tradition. Among the tribes and clanholds, leadership is a matter of strength or will, with warriors, spellcasters, or manifesters often taking up the mantle of power. Whether by social accident or design, no central leadership exists in Syrkarn, though the sahar of Nderitese—at 5,000 inhabitants, the land's largest settlement—is sometimes asked to broker disputes between other settlements and larger clans.

Smaller disagreements on trade, tariffs, and power-sharing are typically handled by the time-honored tradition of threats and force, but the reality of Syrkarn means that its people typically have little reason to fight. Resources and land are plentiful, and the common culture forged by eneko and human has created social customs and a rule of law unheard of in most other agrarian tribal societies. However, those Riedran exiles who monitor the activities of the Inspired in Syrkarn often claim to see signs of subtle manipulation of the clans and tribes that hint at the use of psionics and matches the Dreaming Dark's *modus operandi*. Rival chieftains who have long histories of being at each other's throats will suddenly declare a mutual commitment to peace and allegiance. Smaller factions will suddenly gain tactical sophistication that allows them to thwart the expansionist plans of more powerful nomadic tribes, or force the larger settlements into a defensive stance.

The least populous (and most mysterious) residents of Syrkarn are the yuan-ti. Descended from the few of their kind who did not flee to Argonnessen when their kingdom was overthrown by the Inspired, these serpentfolk keep themselves well hidden. Even after twelve hundred years, the utter destruction of the yuan-ti at the command of the Inspired remains a potent reminder of the power the lords of Riedra can bring to bear.

Syrkarn is an arid landscape of harsh deserts, lush grasslands, and endless steppes sloping up from the southern extent of the Sea of Rage. Its population consists of an almost equal mix of

Sarlonan human clans and tribes of eneko—the mongrel ogres who trace their lineage back to the ancient kingdom—and now Riedran province—of Borunan.

Though the climate and the isolated life of this land are never easy, the coastal steppes and inland savannah of Syrkarn offer limitless range for animals and agriculture. Herds of wild bison and domesticated goats, deer, and horses roam the grasslands, while cultivated fields of oat grass and flax spread across the Itzaina plains and the steppes of the Lamecha lowlands. The natives grow a range of vegetable crops, including the gnarled root known as *sepse*, native to Sarlona and prized for its high nutritional value. Exotic spices found nowhere outside Sarlona thrive in the heat of the savannah, as does dreamlily. Use of the drug is rare among the Syrk humans, but the eneko (who are immune to dreamlily's narcotic effects) grow it for its medicinal value. Harvests are hard in some years, but the clans and tribes of Syrkarn know bounty more often than not.

Though the ruins of great cities dot the landscape, modern-day Syrkarn is predominantly a land of hamlets, villages, and nomadic town sites. The remnants of human cities are common in the former lands of Mae Khree, Sunyagir, and Lamecha, but the plains and savannah that were once Khunan are marked exclusively by the ruins of the yuan-ti. Shulassakar and yuan-ti ruins are especially common on the Hailana Islands, said to be the site from which the yuan-ti launched their desperate voyage to Argonnessen and left their ancient homeland behind.

The population of Syrkarn is largely a mix of eneko and human clans descended from Riedran refugees. Half-giants are common in Syrkarn, but the nomadic lifestyle of the Sandstrider family in the Andnemun Desert keeps them removed from the affairs of the other tribes and clans. Human and eneko settlements dot the plains, and seminomadic clans wander regular hunting grounds in the forests and river valleys with the changing of the seasons. The clans and tribes both see themselves as the only truly native Sarlonan culture left on the continent—avoiding the stagnation of Riedra and the rigid culture of Adar as they build their lives in the shadows of the past of the Twelve Kingdoms.

Whatever their race, Syrks are thoughtful and hardworking folk who believe that celebration should be the end result of all honest labor. Their love of freedom leads Syrks to respect privacy and the individual, but they balance this with a sense of community that allows them to thrive in the sometimes hostile plains of Syrkarn. A Syrk neither seeks to lead nor to follow. He does the job to the best of his ability, and expects the same in return from those he trusts and depends on.

The love and celebration of freedom is central to the Syrk spirit, and nearly all disputes between Syrks concern obligation, restitution, or a sense that someone desires power not rightly his. Such disputes are not infrequent, but rarely lead to more than threatening standoffs.

Those unfamiliar with Syrk customs can sometimes find themselves caught off guard when angrily accused of some affront by a Syrk native. Those who do not know the appropriate Syrk response (be fierce, be truthful, and apologize when truth turns against you) sometimes needlessly respond with violence that the other party never anticipated or desired.

Syrkarn is a rural and agrarian land, but it is built on the bones of Old Sarlona. As a result, Syrks appreciate art, architecture, and formal music that contrasts with their humble lives. From field laborers to nomadic hunters, Syrks take as much pride in their appearance as they do their work and skill. Textiles are one of the primary trades of Syrkarn, and those too young or too old for harder labor spend their days at the loom or with needle and thread. Nearly a third of Syrk society leads some form of nomadic life, but no great differences can be seen between the Syrk nomads and their brethren who settle in villages and towns. In fact, many Syrks live a cyclical life—wandering the steppes in their youth, later settling in a community to raise children or pursue a formal vocation, then breaking away to take up the life of a nomad or trader in their twilight years.

Likewise, the harmony between Syrkarn's two main races is remarkable, given Sarlona's long history of conflict between different ethnicities and races. Though the human clans and eneko tribes maintain their own separate ways and traditions, little sense of division exists between the races, and virtually all settlements and nomadic groups feature members of both races living alongside each other. Humans and eneko often form lifelong romantic bonds, but they cannot interbreed despite the eneko's mixed genetic heritage as the descendants of ogre refugees who fled the fall of Borunan to the Inspired and then interbred with the nomadic half-giants of Syrkarn. The ogres, who were giantkin, proved genetically compatible with the half-giants because of their shared giant heritages. However, despite their reproductive incompatibility, mixed eneko-human couples do adopt orphaned kin of either race.

Syrks typically define themselves by vocation and deed. A majority of traders and herders happen to be eneko; most farmers and artisans happen to be human. Still, these happenstances are unimportant next to the quality of the artisan's goods, the shot that brings a bison down, or the strength that drives a plow. Syrks take great pride in their work, and they spend as much time as that work allows celebrating the wealth and heritage their land has bequeathed them.

Derived as it is from Riedran refugees and their descendants, Syrkarn's human population is uniformly contemptuous of the Path of Inspiration. Nearly half of all human Syrks follow no gods at all, instead placing their faith and devotion in the land itself. For Syrk faithful, the spirit of Syrkarn is treated as an unaligned primal force that is served by both clerics and druids and probably represents an aspect of Eberron, the Dragon Between herself.

In much of Syrkarn, humans have reclaimed the worship of the Sovereign Host from contact with Lhaazarite traders from Khorvaire. At the same time, the eneko have always invoked aspects of Arawai and Balinor, naming them Rowa of the Enduring Trees and Banor the Bowhunter. Human Syrks thus focus their own worship on Arawai and Balinor, with this accidental meeting of traditions underpinning the long-term social and racial stability in the region.

Among the eneko, some worship Karrak the Final Guardian, a dark god of the ancient Borunan ogres. No analogous faith exists among the humans, and Karrak's sects are among the few eneko-only enclaves in Syrkarn.

Syrks are content to leave others alone and hope for the same in return. For all intents and purposes, Riedra is Syrkarn's only neighbor, and the repressive and isolationist bent of that land means that Syrks frequently define themselves as its antithesis. The Inspired in Riedra clearly have the resources and the military might to take Syrkarn in a heartbeat, driving its people into the sea if they so chose. Although desert and mountain marks much of Syrkarn's inland frontier, unlike Adar, no natural or mystical defenses protect this land from invasion.

The fact that the Inspired have chosen not to invade suggests that they have strong reasons to leave Syrkarn as it is. The Thousand Eyes has agents throughout the land, but these seem primarily focused on maintaining the status quo among the tribes and clans. Isolated skirmishes are sometimes made against the human exiles, but clear benefits can be seen in Riedra's allowing the exile clans to survive as a beacon to the like-minded. No matter how many exiles swell its population, vast Syrkarn will never have the resources or the population to challenge the Inspired. Better to have those who oppose Inspired rule flee for the "freedom" of the barbarian frontier than to disturb the Riedran peace.

Riedran agents harass the mongrel ogre tribes with greater frequency than they do the human clans. Some speculate that this behavior marks a fear that the eneko are more apt to pursue dark magic, as has been seen in the recent rise of the Karrak cults. It is known that the Horned Shadow has sought to recruit both half-giants and eneko from Syrkarn in recent years, but whether any connection exists between the rebellious oni and the cults remains to be seen.

More than anything else, Inspired agents seek signs of arcane magic use in Syrkarn. They are especially watchful for any sign of the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun in the steppes and the yuan-ti ruins. When it is found, the arcane is exterminated. Riedra is intent on seeing that Syrkarn's lost arcane lore stays that way. There is a reason for this concern.

From fragments of yuan-ti lore and contemporary human records, some scholars assert that a rakshasa rajah exists in Syrkarn, possibly beneath the ruined yuan-ti city of Sustrai Mor. The eneko's Karrak cults are said to be numerous within the wasted plain that surrounds the ruins. Among the

Syrk nomads, the city has a reputation for being haunted or overrun with secret sects of yuan-ti. Whatever the truth, the Syrks avoid the place. Whether the Inspired or the Dreaming Dark have reason to fear the might of a bound fiendish Overlord is an open question. It seems likely, though, that the Inspired's unwillingness to risk the resources necessary to destroy the Syrkarn fiend drove the decision to simply empty that land after Unification—denying the fiend (and its inevitable Lords of Dust allies) the followers it would inevitably seek among the land's population.

At the same time, the Inspired show little of the same concern for the rajahs thought to be trapped beneath the Tashana Tundra and Adar. Perhaps the lords of Riedra have some plan for keeping these other fiends in check, either before, or preferably after, they run rampant in those lands. At the same time, the fall of Khunan and the subsequent rise of the yuan-ti suggests to some that the Syrk rajah was once unbound—and that whatever act saw it put down might not have bound it as strongly as the Inspired would like.

Sharing a desert border as it does with Borunan, Syrkarn has a more open relationship with the former ogre kingdom than with the other Riedran provinces. Just as the ogres made their way south centuries ago fleeing the imposition of the Riedran Path of Inspiration, more than a few eneko make the trek north today. The eneko in the Harmonious Shield's Savage Legion are drawn from the ranks of such Syrk exiles.

The Tashana Tundra

Information provided by scholars from various academic institutions in Khorvaire.

Population: 400,000 (70% shifters, 20% dwarves/duergar, 5% humans, 3% half-giants, 2% maenads).

Area: 1,500,000 square miles.

Sovereign: Sky Tellers (shifter nation); Stone Council (Dorann Holds); Jade-Lin (*de facto* Akiak leader).

Capital: Nasq (unofficial capital of Qiku nation).

Major Cities: Whitetooth, Winterstead, Tannishold.

Climate: Subarctic to arctic.

Highest Point: Mount Jorl, elevation 18,320 feet.

Heraldry: Pigment-on-sealskin of an abstract rock mound on a field of three feathers (shifter nation); various clan heraldrys (Dorann Holds and Akiak).

Founder: Unknown.

National Motto: “Banded we live!”

The Tashana Tundra is a land of vast, open spaces and endless sky. Home to the greatest shifter nation of Sarlona, perhaps in all of Eberron, the Tundra consists mainly of grassy, treeless plains that stretch without interruption from horizon to horizon. For many thousands of years, these seminomadic tribes have roamed the grasslands, isolated from the rest of the world and left in relative peace to contemplate the cold, pure spirit of their ancestral homeland.

The Tashana Tundra is better understood as a geographical region rather than a kingdom. Although the Tashana shifters are the dominant people in terms of a semiunified culture (and sheer numbers), they do not recognize political borders, and they have no diplomats or delegations abroad. The dwarves of the Dorann Holds are closer to being an actual political nation, but their isolationist policies have kept them all but invisible in their distant mountain holds. The Akiak dwarven and duergar refugees and the Icebinder half-giants remain essentially nomadic peoples, and little is known of the mysterious Inana maenads. The Tashana Tundra is simply too big, too wild, and too sparsely populated to qualify as a true state in any but the loosest sense of that term.

Tashana means “many waters” in an ancient, nearly extinct shifter dialect. The plains are dotted with hundreds, if not thousands, of small glacial lakes. Many of these remain frozen year-round, but the southern waters thaw in summer. In these months, the Tundra is a place of pure

and unspoiled natural beauty. The landscapes are regularly interrupted by huge mounds of rocks and boulders, some miles wide, that seem to have fallen from the sky. Remnants, presumably, of an earlier glacial age, these rock mounds have a strange and otherworldly beauty. The majority of the Tundra is covered with frosty grasslands. To the north the Eska Mountains rise, and the northern foothills of the Paqaa Mountains encroach upon the southern border. In the far north, the dreamlike and ghostly Tashyvar Islands reach into the Sea of Rage. Finally, the mysterious Krertok Peninsula extends northeast of the Eska Spines.

The Tashana climate is mainly subarctic, with true arctic conditions in the northern plains and mountains, and short summer months of near-temperate conditions in the south. If anything definitive can be said of the Tundra as a whole, it is this—it is a land of strange weather. Blizzards, snow squalls, and whiteouts sometimes descend in an instant, but also common are strange heat waves, downpours of inexplicably warm rain, and savage lightning strikes. The Tundra is well known for reality storms (*aukaraks* in the ancient Shifter dialect), rogue planar breaches and manifest zones that drift over the landscape.

No single civilization controls the entire Tashana Tundra. The people of the Tundra include numerous races, each separate and distinct. The Tundra shifters are divided into three great nations, the Qiku tribes of central Tashana; the coastal Saartuk people, and the more warlike Chuniigi in the north. Although intertribal skirmishes and raids are not uncommon, the elders of all three nations work hard to maintain the peace of recent generations. Whereas the shifters of Khorvaire tend to value self-reliance and personal freedom, the Qiku and Saartuk shifters place much more importance on the community. Allegiance is to the tribe, the family unit, and the nation—in that order. The harshness of life in the Tundra has dictated this be so—rugged individualism in the Tundra is not advised. Going it alone, to a Tashana shifter, is dangerous, stupid, and spiritually misguided.

Tundra shifters do not struggle against their bestial nature, but rather embrace it as a sign of their oneness with all living things. Shifting is a profoundly exhilarating and joyful experience, even when the aim is aggression. Tashanan shifters have a remarkable ability to accept violence and death as part of the natural order. If it is necessary to tear an enemy to pieces, a tundra shifter does so with great passion.

Tundra shifters who choose to explore the wider world might be doing so at the bequest of the community. Such braves gather ideas and knowledge before returning to the tribes, seeking to make the nation stronger. Because Tashana shifters place a premium on community, such a character is likely to be fiercely loyal to his companions. Possessions mean little to shifters aside from their utility. Although they understand the concept of currency, hoarding coins and gems is a strange

practice to them. Shifters from the northern Chuniigi tribes have a simpler, more aggressive viewpoint. While the community concept is still very strong, these are desperate times for the Chuniigi. A tribe might raid another tribe to supplement its hunt, and intratribal conflict can pit factions and families against one another.

The Eska Mountains are home to the isolationist dwarves of the Dorann Holds, who are thought to have migrated from the Frostfell over an ancient land bridge after escaping the enslavement of the giants of that frigid land, much like the dwarves of the Mror Holds. Little is known of these clans today. The dwarves and duergar who eventually migrated to populate more hospitable southern regions appear to have split from the Dorann centuries ago to become the Akiak dwarves. Since then, the Dorann dwarves have maintained a policy of political isolation, although they still trade with the northern shifter tribes and Inana maenads of the Tashyvar Islands. It is said that an increasing number of the Dorann clans are feverishly mining the Eska Mountains, stockpiling raw minerals as they dig.

The dwarves of the Dorann Holds are a mixed lot. The northern clans tend to be more primitive, clannish, and warlike than their distant cousins in the Mror Holds. Whereas the Khorvarien clans settled into a prolonged peace under Karnathi annexation, the dwarves of the northern Dorann Holds have never known such an era of foreign rule, and the typical state of affairs is one of low-simmering clan conflict. The southern Eska clans, by contrast, have much more arable land to work, and hence more peaceful relations, trading among themselves and the nearby humans and shifter tribes. Still, all Dorann dwarves tend toward mild xenophobia and isolationism, and as such have little contact with the world beyond their borders.

These days, a Dorann dwarf adventuring in the larger world is likely to have chafed under the oppressive policies of the recent Stone Council leadership. As the northern clans fall into line under the Hammerhand leadership, southern clans are rallying to the cause of the resurgent Clanguard paladins. A Dorann character is certainly concerned about potential civil war, and might feel compelled to choose a side and take a stand.

When the last Akiak strongholds in the Paqaa Mountains fell to the Riedrans, the scattered remnants of this once-great dwarven nation were forced to the north, where they lived in small mobile refugee camps. The few remaining Akiak are an intriguing people—a fully integrated society of dwarf and duergar, attempting to rebuild and fight back against their Riedran enemies. The Akiak are fighting a guerrilla-style war against the Inspired, launching forays into their occupied homelands while constantly defending themselves against counterattacks by Riedra's psychic death squads. An Akiak character is likely to be driven to take back the Paqaa Mountains, and to eventually bring the fight to the corrupt heartland of Riedra.

The Tashyvar Islands are home to the Inana maenads. Victims of an ancient tragedy, these psionically powerful beings are the last survivors of an island nation that sank beneath the waters of the Lhazaar Sea two thousand years ago. The Inana have recently established a series of small coastal hamlets on the western seaboard of Tashana proper.

Scattered throughout the Tundra are the Icebinders, wandering bands of half-giant psions. Other nomads include many independent human barbarian groups. The terrifying Kalaak—a sect of savage, self-mutilating barbarians said to be in league with an ancient evil much like the Carrion Tribes of the Khorvarien Demon Wastes—plague the central and northern Tundra.

Eschewing technological and industrial advancements, the majority of Tashana shifters choose instead a path of simplicity and union with their natural surroundings. Although much of this choice is strictly a practical matter, it is also a defining spiritual aspect of the shifters of Tashana. Where a foreigner might see the Tundra way of life as primitive, the native sees it as pure and spiritually powerful. The central shifter nations of the Qiku and the Saartuk have enjoyed relative peace for many generations, and as their communities continue to grow and prosper, the shifter mind has turned inward to more spiritual matters. They are no longer driven by a struggle to survive, and now their shamanistic traditions grow more advanced with every generation. This advancement is evidenced by the shifters' sophisticated use of medicinal and magical lichens native to the Tundra.

The Qiku and Saartuk shifter nations are composed of hundreds of individual tribes, each led by a council of elders. The tribe is the basic organizational unit of the shifter people, and each functions more or less independently. Each tribe has one or more shamans—healers and spiritual councilors. In the north, the desperate and more warlike Chuniigi are more fractured and entirely nomadic, following the herds of caribou and competing with the many human tribes and Neanderthal packs in the area.

The three shifter nations have enjoyed a state of relative peace for many decades. The great wars of the past had been devastating for all, and the Tundra is too harsh a land to spill unnecessary blood. Twice a year, each shifter nation holds a gathering of its internal tribes and once a year, representatives from the three nations convene a Summit Council at a secret location in the central plains known as the Speaking Stones. Recent threats by the Kalaak barbarians have tribal leaders uniting in common defense, and a semipermanent Summit Council has gathered for several years now. The Council is led by a triumvirate known as the Sky Tellers, with each of the three great shifter nations represented. Among all three nations, adult males and females are both hunters and warriors, and in times of war, each nation is capable of fielding an army of fighters on very short notice.

The Dorann Holds have long been a collection of loosely confederated dwarven clans, with frequent infighting and skirmishes between various factions. In recent years, however, the infighting has calmed, and several of the clans are working together to an unprecedented degree. The Stone Council, previously an intermittent conclave gathered to settle important intraclan disputes, has been in permanent session in the fortress of Tannishold. Able-bodied dwarves from all clans are being dispatched—forcefully in some cases—to work in massive excavation projects deep in the Eska Mountains. Recent reports indicate that heavily armed militias, controlled by a member of the Stone Council known as Hammerhand, now control many of the major passes and valleys of the Eskas. Opposing dwarf clans are uniting under the flag of the paladin order known as the Clanguard, and rumors of a Dorann civil war hang heavy in the air.

A dwarven and duergar community-in-exile, the Akiak people currently eke out a seminomadic existence. There is no government or military structure per se, but rather *ad hoc* leadership committees and guerrilla bands. The charismatic duergar warlord known as Jade- Lin is attempting to galvanize the clans, and many have rallied to her flag of late. The Akiak refugees are closely allied with the southern Qiku shifter tribes.

What little is known of the Inana maenads suggests that they maintain a radically simple, almost deliberately primitive society in the remote Tashyvar Islands. Separate and distinct coastal villages are designed to be entirely self-sufficient, and there is no indication of any centralized government. Inana colonists have in recent generations established a series of fishing villages on the western seaboard of Tashana, as well as the port community of Winterstead, trading peaceably with the native Saartuk shifter tribes. As a people, the Inana apparently follow some kind of seasonal rhythm, with active periods of exploration and colonization in the summer, offset by almost hibernation-like episodes in the long dark of winter. In fact, visitors to Inanan villages in the dead of winter report entire colonies seemingly abandoned.

The nomadic half-giants known collectively as the Icebinders also follow mysterious internal rhythms. Their migrations do not correspond to any seasonal pattern, nor do they trail any of the great herding animals of the Tashana. Some have suggested that the Icebinders move according to some intricate plotting of the *aukaraks* that sweep across the Tundra. Others say the Icebinders actually control the *aukaraks*, somehow herding the reality storms that sweep across the Tundra like great planar beasts. In any case, each nomadic Icebinder group is apparently self-governed and independent of the others with no central governing body between the nomads.

Among the various peoples of the Tundra, relations are generally peaceful. The shifter nations keep to themselves, having successfully averted large-scale war for hundreds of years. Isolated tribal

skirmishes still occur regularly when resources become scarce, particularly involving the warlike Chuniigi tribes of the north.

In recent years, the refugee people of the Akiak and the tribal leaders of the Qiku shifter nation have joined in alliance. This alliance has historical roots: When the Akiak split from their Dorann dwarven forefathers hundreds of years ago, the shifters of the Qiku nation helped the dwarves in their migration from the Eska Mountains across the Tashana Tundra. After the Akiak established their new clanholds in the Paqaa Mountains, the two groups remained friendly and engaged in significant trade. After the Inspired betrayed the Akiak, the Qiku shifters provided refuge and shelter to the desperate Akiak refugees in the northern foothills of the mountains, where they remain to this day. While there is no formal military alliance, the Qiku provide Akiak guerrilla raiders with supplies and mercenary warriors to assist in their campaign to retake clanholds from the Inspired in the Paqaa Mountain range.

Along the western coast of the Tashana, the Saartuk nation coexists with colonies established by the Inana maenads of the Tashyvar Islands. There is certainly no shortage of space or resources along that shoreline. The port communities of Winterstead and Whitetooth are an intriguing mix of maenad and shifter culture, along with a smattering of various Khorvarien influences brought by increasing sea trade.

In the far north, low-lying Dorann clans have a tradition of trading worked metal and weapons with the Chuniigi, typically for prepared meats and animal products. However, relations have soured in recent years. The Chuniigi are enduring relentless raids by the savage Kalaak barbarians, and these are desperate times for the northernmost shifter nation. Chuniigi now regularly raid Dorann dwarf settlements, and even northern roaming Qiku and Saartuk tribes when necessary.

The nomadic Icebinder half-giants generally have good relations with all three shifter nations, in that they leave one another alone. The scattered and self-sufficient human barbarian and Neanderthal tribes of the Tundra have no overarching organization, and conflict arises only when competition for resources heats up.

The human barbarians known as the Kalaak are an entirely different matter. Of these terrible raiders, little is known—and of that, little is spoken. Some say the savagery of the Kalaak has earned them a reputation entirely out of proportion to their actual power and numbers. There is no doubt, however, that the Kalaak represent a grave threat to all peoples of the Tashana. The savage Kalaak swarmed from the area of the Eska Mountains and laid waste to everything in their path. Undiscriminating in their wanton destruction, the raids target shifter, human, half-giant, and even Neanderthal tribes. The few survivors of these raids describe returning to camps that are not just

pillaged, but utterly savaged and desecrated, with dark references to torture and cannibalism. Some captives are cruelly injured and released; those who can still speak tell of self-mutilating barbarians using hooks and knives to sculpt their own flesh into nightmare visages.

The Kalaak are relentless in their insane killing. Entire herds of caribou are found slaughtered and mutilated, left to rot on the taiga. This terrible waste goes against the very nature of the Tashanan people, especially the shifter nations. Recently, the Saartuk and Qiku tribes have organized scouts and sentries as the Kalaak raids travel farther south into the heart of the Tashana. But it is the northern Chuniigi who have borne the brunt of the Kalaak's aggression. Desperate, the Chuniigi have in turn begun raiding Dorann dwarf clanholds and even other southern shifter tribes, bringing a dangerous instability to the natural order of the Tundra. The source of the Kalaak's savagery is clearly fiendish in origin and they are probably being manipulated by a group of rakshasas or other fiends seeking to free one of their fiendish Overlords trapped deep beneath the ice of the northern Tundra.

A Gazetteer of Argonessen

The continent of Argonessen, the homeland of the dragons of Eberron, is divided into four informal territories, a brief overview of which can be found here. All areas fall under the rule of the Conclave, and the borders between them are open; a dragon of the Thousand can choose to settle in the Vast whenever he wishes. The true borders between the territories are cultural. Any dragon can settle in the Vast—but he must be prepared to live by its harsh rules. For more detailed information on Argonessen, please reference the sourcebook *Dragons of Eberron*.

The Thousand

Dragon Population: 36,300.

Nondragon Population: 24,000 (35% human, 21% stone giant, 12% goblin, 9% orc, 8% dwarf, 6% gnome, 3% yuan-ti, 6% other).

The Thousand Flights of Argonessen—more commonly called the Thousand—is the heart of the dragon homeland. The great wyrms of the Thousand inhabit lairs hewn in the Age of Demons, and the cries of soaring dragons fill the air. Dragons have lived here for hundreds of thousands of years; the territory is replete with monuments to wise wyrms and legendary prophets, shrines to the deities of Thir, and wondrous locations created by the greatest flames of the forge. Crafted through pure magic by colossal draconic artisans, these edifices tower over the landscape. Flying across the Thousand is a breathtaking experience, but one few nondragons ever experience; intruders find scant welcome in the land of the Thousand.

The dragons of the Thousand are organized into extended family groups known as flights. Each flight controls a large domain within the Thousand. Every adult dragon has his own lair, which he shares with his mate and children. Some flights spread out across their domain, with miles between lairs. Others prefer to live in close proximity. These flights use potent magical rituals to draw vast pillars of volcanic rock up from the earth, and then carve tunnels into these massive monoliths; a single pillar can be over a mile in height, serving as a home for up to a dozen dragons.

The flights of the Thousand are segregated by color. Many flights are surrounded by neighbors of the same color, creating patchwork patterns across the land. Most dragons of the Thousand prefer the company of their own sub-species or at least their family of dragons. A few

flights still cling to the antichromatic philosophies of Ourenilach, and some tension arises between white dragons and other flights, largely based around the argument that the less intelligent whites are little better than wyverns. Although this can result in heated debate, violence between dragons is rare. Formal duels or staged battles are accepted by some flights as a way of settling disputes, but most insist that members go to the Vast if they intend to do battle. Crimes between dragons are handled by the divine servants of Lendys, the draconic god of Justice.

With a few exceptions, flights are ruled by the oldest dragon of the line. The clan might debate important issues, but the eldest has the final say. He decides who represents the flight in the Conclave of Argonnessen, and who guards the great treasures of the flight. He appoints the servant of Lendys, who investigates and punishes crimes committed by or against members of the flight; if necessary, a servant of Lendys can call upon the Eyes of Chronopsis for assistance. Beneath the elder, status within a flight is based on age and hoard. The Conclave of Argonnessen is based in the Thousand. Dragons who speak in the Conclave are treated with great respect, regardless of their rank within a flight.

Some dragons of the Thousand trade with the dominion lords of the Vast, bartering for servants or treasures produced in that land. Dragons specialized in creation wander the land, using their skills as architects, artificers, and engineers in exchange for treasures or useful information. Beyond this, the dragons are self-sufficient and self-involved; few real industries exist within the Thousand.

Most nondragons in the Thousand are retainers attached to a particular flight of dragons. Some have served their flight for generations; others are recent acquisitions brought over from the Vast. Nondragon retainers perform tasks that are difficult or demeaning for dragons, and are often called upon to entertain their masters. As a result, most retainers are trained in some form of performance like music or acting.

Many dragons dislike the presence of nondragons. Some of these dragons use constructs as retainers, typically favoring iron golems. Others feel that nondragons have no place in Argonnessen, and any such creature who crosses the domain of such a dragon is killed on sight. Nondragons have no rights in the Thousand. Killing a nondragon bearing the mark of a friendly flight is an insult to the owner, but many dragons consider the life of a single lesser creature to be trivial and pay this no mind.

The Light of Siberys

Dragon Population: 6,510.

Nondragon Population: 7,200 (42% stone giant, 30% goblin, 16% dwarf, 6% human, 6% other).

The Light of Siberys is the stronghold of the draconic army of Argonnessen that bears the same name. This land still bears scars from the battles between dragons and fiends during the Age of Demons. It was the seat of fiendish power in Argonnessen in that age, and ruins built by twisted rakshasa hands are still found across the territory, protected by spells so strong even the dragons cannot shatter them. Ancient battlefields are haunted by the ghosts of fallen dragons. Worst of all are the prisons of the demon Overlords; even in torpor and captivity, these fiends are so powerful that they corrupt the land above their vaults. Defending Argonnessen and the world from these horrors is a dangerous task, but the Soldiers of the Light stand strong against whatever darkness rises.

The Light of Siberys is made up of dragons of all colors and ages. Although some of the dragons are “trueborn” or “born in the Light”—to families that have served the cause for generations—the majority of the young dragons come from the Thousand. Adult dragons of the Thousand are forced to spend fifty years in the Vast or serve for fifty years in the Light of Siberys before they can return to claim land in the Thousand. Some choose to remain after the term is up, but life in the Light is intense, dangerous, and often thankless. Moreover, it clashes with the independent streak that runs through the psyche of most dragons. Most are glad to return to the peace of the Thousand.

A draconic soldier of the Light is dedicated to his duty. Missions abound, from patrolling the skies to standing watch over the Pit of Five Sorrows to hunting down the Talons of Tiamat. Young adults might be frivolous, particularly those forced to work for the Light by the customs of the Thousand. Any adult or older dragon who chooses to abandon the safer life of the Thousand for the deadly duty of the Light, however, is a stern and implacable foe.

The dragons of the Light of Siberys follow a strict hierarchy of ranks (see below in the *Organizations of Argonnessen* section). Although they normally patrol in squads of five or fewer, they are trained to operate in large numbers, and even the lowest-ranking officers, the Lanterns of Siberys, are trained to organize other dragons in times of war. Currently five dragons hold the rank of Glorious Flame. Only one Eternal Flame exists, the Lightkeeper Dolarashynach, a Lawful Good female ancient silver dragon, and she guides the Soldiers of the Light from Verthicha’vivex, the Mountain of Victory.

For the most part, the dragons who serve the Light of Siberys are deeply devoted to their cause. However, exceptions exist. Some simply develop a taste for power and influence. Others are corrupted by the fiendish presences they combat. Regardless of the reason, a few dragons have sought to use their rank within the Light for their own personal benefit. Indeed, it could be that one of the current Glorious Flames is waiting for the right moment to help Dolarashynach move on to her eternal reward.

The Light of Siberys maintains a host of armories and arcane workshops in its fortresses. It has been creating tools of war for nearly a hundred thousand years. The forges of Verthicha's vivex produce weapons and armor for the nondragon allies of the dragons, and for those dragons that choose to fight in humanoid form. Other dragons create magic items and lesser artifacts that can be used by dragons in battle. Much of the manual labor is done by dwarves and giants, but dragons dedicated to creation develop designs and provide the arcane power needed to craft magic items. Despite this strong industrial program, the Light of Siberys rarely exports any of its goods. All are needed for the task at hand . . . or the battles to come.

The nondragons found in the Light of Siberys are closely tied to the military efforts of the order. The stone giants serve as the backbone of the nondragon army and also help with the construction of fortifications and other large-scale projects. The dwarves are largely dedicated to forgework and mining. A force of hobgoblins and bugbears, descended from warriors of Dhakaan long ago brought from Khorvaire by the dragons, have maintained the martial discipline of their lost empire; while the Dhakaani Empire fell long ago, they are sworn to battle the horrors of Khyber. A few humans and others from the city of Io'lokar have joined with the Light. In so doing, they hope to assuage any doubts the Conclave might have about their loyalty to Argonessen.

Unless foreigners can successfully pass as nondragons in the service of the Light, they are met with hostility. This territory is filled with dangerous sources of fiendish power and strongholds of the Talons of Tiamat—in short, it is a rather bad place to be a trespasser.

The Tapestry

Dragon Population: Varies (averages 600).

Nondragon Population: 1,000 (39% human, 21% stone giant, 20% yuan-ti, 12% dwarf, 8% other).

The Tapestry is the youngest and smallest of the territories, born less than four thousand years ago. The dragons of the Thousand cling to their individual flights, and to the traditions and philosophies they see as the property of their lineage. The founders of the Tapestry wanted to bring dragons of different colors together, to set aside the idea that influence and age were inseparable, and to consider new ideas about religion and the draconic Prophecy. They might have established themselves in the Vast, but many of the young dragons hated the violence found there. One of their main objections was the process of sending the young into the Vast, a tradition intended to weed out the weak. Initially, their efforts received little support from the Conclave, but they continued, predicting a great change in the shape of the Prophecy.

Then the first dragonmarks appeared. In the wake of this event, the Conclave agreed to provide the young dragons with territory to continue their work. This land came to be known as the Tapestry of Thought, since it was intended as a land where all flights would come together as one. In time, the Conclave agreed to let the dragons of the Tapestry act abroad, and so the Chamber was born.

The Tapestry is the home base of the Chamber, although some dragons of the Vast serve in that body. In the Tapestry, dragon mystics, prophets, and sages continue their work, while their elders defend the activities of the Tapestry and the Chamber before the Conclave. Both the Eyes of Chronopsis and the wyrms of the Conclave have grave doubts about allowing dragons to intentionally interfere with the outcome of the Prophecy, and many wish to shut down these activities and force the dragons of the Chamber to rejoin the Thousand or disperse into the Vast. For now, however, the Tapestry remains a crucible for new ideas.

The dragons of the Tapestry believe that diversity spawns new ideas. Rather than continue the dragons' natural solitary ways, residents of the Tapestry collaborate with each other. Dragons spend their time working with one or more partners, switching frequently (for a dragon, this can mean anything from years to decades) to gain new perspectives. Dragons of different colors work far more closely than in the Thousand, and, in a few cases, Tapestry dragons have chosen to pair-bond in spite of a difference in color.

Even though they have liberal ideas regarding relationships between dragons and the newly formed bond between nondragons and the Prophecy, the members of the Tapestry are still dragons.

They display great arrogance. Although they are intrigued by the destiny of the nondragon races, most still consider them to be lesser creatures. Some even champion the theory that the best approach is the destruction of the dragonmarked.

The Prophecy is of great concern to the members of the Tapestry, but they are also interested in advancing understanding of all knowledge, from arcane magic to the physical sciences. Combined with their arrogance, these lofty aspirations could have disastrous results; humans are not the only ones who can reach for something beyond their grasp.

The Tapestry was founded on the idea that all dragons should have an equal voice, setting aside the traditional hierarchies of age and color. The Tapestry holds its own conclaves at Vorel'arux, the Valley of Beauty. All dragons are invited to participate in discussion and voting, but in truth few do—few dragons are as interested in the administration of the territory as they are in the acquisition of knowledge. As a result, several older dragons have accumulated considerable influence within the territory. These dragons helped found the Tapestry when they were mere adults, and now, thousands of years later, they have grown into their glory. Only ancient wyrms can speak at the Conclave of Vorel'arux, and these dragons have taken up that role. The wisest among them is a loredrake, Jancarlyrix, a male ancient adamantine dragon. Although he is the strongest voice the Tapestry has, Jancarlyrix still holds to the core doctrine of the territory and takes care to listen to the younger dragons around him.

The Tapestry has no large-scale industries. However, its members are constantly exploring new paths of magic. Although they do not produce massive quantities of treasure, they might develop spells or magic items that cannot be found elsewhere on Eberron.

Despite their enlightened views on dragon relations and the fact that the Chamber works closely with nondragons, the dragons of the Tapestry have little love for the lesser races. Many take the lessons of Aureon's Folly seriously and believe that nondragons simply cannot be trusted. Some are exceptions—a few dragons maintain teams of human scribes or stone giant guardians, and others train promising Seren barbarians to serve as agents in the wider world. But in general, nondragons are rare in the Tapestry, and dragons treat foreigners with great suspicion if not outright hostility. An adventurer had best bring valuable information, or have some other way to win the trust of a dragon, if he wishes to roam through the Tapestry.

This attitude toward nondragons is one of the main differences between those who reside in the Tapestry and the other supporters of the Chamber, the dragons who founded Io'lokar (see above). The two factions share similar goals, but as the latter dragons explore the Prophecy, they are typically looking for outcomes that will aid the lesser races as well as Argonnessen.

A small but significant force of yuan-ti is hidden in the Tapestry. Driven into war against the dragons after the destruction of Io'vakas, these clever spies have long been draconic foes. They seek to steal the wisdom of the Chamber and use it against all dragons.

The Vast

Dragon Population: Varies (approximately 4,000).

Nondragon Population: 142,900 (21% human, 17% goblin, 12% orc, 11% dwarf, 10% shifter, 9% stone giant, 3% yuan-ti, 3% changeling, 3% halfling, 3% gnome, 8% other).

In Draconic, this territory of Argonessen is called *Dja'Valarach*. In Common, it is typically translated as “the Vast,” interpreted as a great void or open space. But to a dragon, the word holds far deeper meaning. It is the space around a dragon in flight. It is the freedom to move in any direction. It hints at the infinite possibilities of the future, unbound and vast. That is what the Vast represents to the dragons of Argonessen—freedom and uncertainty. It is a land without rules, where dragons are free to exult in their power and might, to match wits with other dragons and to rule over lesser creatures.

First and foremost, the Vast is a proving ground. When a dragon of the Thousand becomes an adult, he is given the choice to serve the Light of Siberys or to find his own way in the Vast. Those who go to the Vast must remain there for at least fifty years; those who survive to become older adults might return to the Thousand and claim a lair within the dominion of their flight. However, some choose to remain in the Vast. These dragons prefer the challenge and uncertainty of life in this land. Life in the Thousand is stable, but stagnant. In the Vast, a dragon can be a conqueror, a tyrant, or a defender of the innocent. Every day could end in a life-or-death struggle, and for many dragons, that thrill is worth the risk.

The dragons of the Vast are free to do whatever they want. Life is a deadly game, with living creatures as the pawns. A dragon can take any land that he can hold, and any other dragon can try to take it from him. Gold, treasure, slaves—all these are part of the game of power, the never-ending struggle for status. Some dragons revel in the violence and spend their days hunting the most challenging prey that they can find. Some live in hedonistic splendor among nondragons who worship them. A few actually enjoy protecting lesser creatures; they take pleasure in defending their subjects from the depredations of cruel ravagers and rulers.

The dragons of the Vast relish their conflicts with other dragons. These contests can be drawn out over months or years. A victorious dragon often spares his victim in their first battle, to give the loser time to contemplate the loss and prepare for his final defeat. Although some ravagers thrive on blood and rage, for most dragons, the game is more satisfying than the actual victory. The conflict, not the resolution, is the event to be savored. A dragon who establishes and holds a significant area in

the Vast is known as a dominion lord. His status in the eyes of the other lords is based on the size of his domain, his hoard, the number of nondragons he commands, and the number and nature of dragons he has defeated. Though age is typically a factor, achievement is just as important in the Vast; if a young dragon can consistently defeat his elders, he will gain respect—and become a target for others.

Many dragons leave the Vast after becoming adults. Many more do not survive to adulthood. But some remain in the Vast for their entire lives. These elder dominion lords rarely challenge the young; slaying an adult black dragon provides little challenge or satisfaction for a gold ancient wyrm. These elders continue to play their games with others of similar age, but they also work to maintain the Vast. They import new monsters to replace those slain in battle. They do what is necessary to keep the nondragon population within manageable levels, and restock the supplies if the population falls too low. And they represent the Vast in the Conclave of Argonnessen. They rarely speak with one voice, but they defend their way of life and the importance of this free realm.

Although no industries span the territory, many dominion lords force their subjects to mine for ores and precious gems, and to produce goods worthy of a dragon's hoard. A dominion lord might use these goods to barter with other dragons, potentially trading treasure for slaves as a human might purchase livestock, or offering tribute in exchange for a temporary alliance against another dragon. The Vast also trades in nondragons. In addition to "importing" creatures from other continents, dragons of the Vast are the primary source for the nondragons found in other territories. A dragon who returns to the Thousand could bring retainers with him, while a dragon of the Tapestry might recruit research assistants from Io'lokar.

The Vast has the highest nondragon population of any of the territories. These lesser races have been brought to Argonnessen over the course of a hundred thousand years. Hobgoblins, whose ancestors were saved from the downfall of the Empire of Dhakaan at the hands of the daelkyr, still sing the songs of the *duur'kala*—the Dhakaani dirge singers. Elves, whose ancestors were brought from the shores of Xen'drik long before the Elven Uprising against the giants, know nothing of the Undying Court or the Tairnadal. There are nondragons never seen in Khorvaire, members of races that were exterminated by the giants or the daelkyr. The range of communities that can be found are dizzying. Some are metropolitan, with members of a dozen races living under one roof. Other communities are racially isolated, steadfastly preserving secrets of their forgotten cultures.

Of course, all these creatures have one aspect in common: They live beneath the shadow of the dragon overlords. To a dominion lord, nondragons are an extension of his hoard. Other dragons might try to steal creatures from his domain, or just slaughter his subjects; life is always uncertain,

and an attack could come at any time. Two dominion lords could have completely different styles of rule. Some make frequent shows of force and often require living sacrifices. A few demand worship, and in some cases, their subjects truly believe that these dragons are deities; a few of the oldest dominion lords have developed cadres of fanatical soldiers ready to die for their dragon masters. Life in the Vast can be brutal and short, but the people of this land know little else.

The Dragonmarked Houses

The dragonmarked houses have existed for thousands of years. For some reason not completely understood, the common races living on the continents of Khorvaire and Aerenal developed dragonmarks and the spell-like abilities associated with them. Some sages believe that the abundance of Eberron dragonshards on these continents has something to do with the development of dragonmarks, but no one can prove this theory. What is known is that humans and elves never manifested dragonmarks while living in the Eberron dragonshard-deficient regions of Sarlona and Xen'drik.

Individual dragonmarks appeared within bloodlines, and soon family dynasties sprang up to take advantage of the dragonmarks' powers. Each family created an economic empire using the dragonmarks, and the dragonmarked houses developed into independent commercial enterprises operating across multiple nations. The War of the Mark, which ended about fifteen hundred years ago, stabilized the houses and ended the threat of aberrant and mixed marks that might have destroyed the economy of Khorvaire. Today, twelve dragonmarks shared among thirteen houses form the basis for economic power across the continent.

Agreements reached at the end of the War of the Mark and in the Korth Edicts centuries later formalized the tenets and traditions that all the houses adhere to. These include rules concerning political neutrality (all houses make a show of remaining neutral so that they can operate in all nations), fair trade and practices, family naming conventions, and a ban on marriages between houses so that the dragonmarks remain pure. Family members run each house, with either a matriarch or patriarch serving as the chief executive of both the family and the house's commercial business. House family members form an economic aristocracy on a par with the royal and noble families of the various nations of Khorvaire, and family leaders are literally barons of industry and commerce. Each house also employs retainers and hirelings to aid in the family business. Those retainers and hirelings who show initiative and promise can rise through the ranks to hold important positions within the house. The most effective and promising of these might be invited into the family through marriage to the young scions of the blood, thus making sure the bloodline continues.

Even though the house blood flows through the veins of every family member, not every one of them has a dragonmark; only a small percentage of every generation manifests a mark. Among

those who do, the least mark is the most common to appear, with fewer lesser marks, and fewer still greater marks appearing in each generation. Those who do develop a dragonmark are singled out for great things and have responsibilities to the family that scions without marks never have to worry about.

Arcane magic is the lifeblood of Eberron, encircling it like the Ring of Siberys and seeping up through the earth from the bones of Khyber. Perhaps the clearest manifestation of this pervasive magic is the appearance of dragonmarks among seven of Khorvaire's common races. Dragonmarks are elaborate skin patterns that appear as vague dragonshaped marks made up of blue-green whirls—more intricate and colorful than birthmarks, more distinctive than any tattoo—that also grant their bearers innate spell-like abilities. When it is used, an individual's dragonmark grows warm to the touch. It becomes fever hot when its spell-like abilities are used up for the day, and must be allowed to cool before its power can be drawn upon again.

On the surface of things, aberrant dragonmarks were similar to their true counterparts. An aberrant mark allowed its bearer to make use of one spell-like magical ability per day. It appeared as a mark somewhere on the skin that grew warm when its ability was used. An aberrant mark that was damaged or removed eventually returned. The design of the mark is a sinuous pattern of lines, often with a vaguely draconic shape. That is where the similarities between an aberrant and true mark end. The true dragonmarks have a standard form. Two individuals with the lesser Mark of Passage have exactly the same design on their skin and each mark is drawn in lines of vivid blue and green. A child of two dragonmarked heirs has a good chance of manifesting a mark and all dragonmarks of a particular type bestow the same range of powers on those who bear them.

None of these things hold true for aberrant dragonmarks. No two aberrant marks are identical. Certain standard patterns provide hints as to the powers they grant, but two aberrant marks that grant the same power can be wildly divergent in appearance. Aberrant dragonmarks come in a wide range of colors, including oily black, blood red and vivid green. The flesh around an aberrant dragonmark is often covered with welts and boils and marks related to fire sometimes leave scars or burns on the skin. This has contributed to the dark reputation of aberrant dragonmarks, with observers often mistaking such disfigurements for a symptom of a disease. However, this scarring is usually confined to the mark and has no adverse effect on the bearer. The child of aberrant parents might develop an aberrant dragonmark, but if so, it could bestow any of the aberrant powers. There is no Mark of Fire or Mark of Fear and this lack of a clear lineage is one of the defining elements of the aberrant marks. While the true dragonmarks are bound to specific bloodlines, aberrant dragonmarks can appear on any member of one of the races that can possess dragonmarks without warning. However, there is

one well-known source of aberrant dragonmarks: the mingling of the bloodlines that carry true dragonmarks. When the marked heirs of two different dragonmarked houses produce children, those children are much less likely to inherit the dragonmark of one parent than to manifest an aberrant dragonmark. For this reason, most of the dragonmarked houses forbid their heirs from pursuing romantic entanglements with the marked heirs of the other houses.

There are twelve families of true dragonmarks, each one associated with a number of closely related manifestations. A thirteenth mark, the Mark of Death once borne by the elves of the House of Vol, has faded from history, and no living creature on Eberron carries it. Each dragonmark appears among the members of one large extended family (or, in the case of the Mark of Shadow, two families). By no means does every member of a dragonmarked family possess a dragonmark, but it is extremely rare for a person who is not a recognized member of one of these families to develop a dragonmark (and such cases usually result from indiscretions on the part of a lesser scion of the family).

Each house specializes in a trade or service for which its mark gives its members a competitive advantage, and it controls guilds that regulate all the commerce across Khorvaire in its area of specialization. Each family is made up of a mix of marked and unmarked members, since dragonmarks manifest randomly even among those with the ability to possess them. The guilds employ both dragonmarked and unmarked people, who may be family members or unrelated retainers. The dragonmarked individuals perform their specialized magical functions for the house, and the unmarked handle the more mundane aspects of the trade. For example, both marked and unmarked members of the Windwrights Guild, controlled by House Lyrandar, work aboard ships; the marked heads of the family produce the wind to power the ships, while the unmarked masses fill the other crew roles aboard the vessels.

There are few who know that not all the dragonmarks present among the peoples of Khorvaire fit within the hierarchy of the twelve dragonmarked houses. To those versed in the lore and legends of the Five Nations these aberrant dragonmarks conjure up images of monsters in human form—terrifying creatures who can kill with a touch or control the forces of fire and fear. Even the most reasoned people whisper that aberrant dragonmarks are signs of the influence of the Dragon Below and that those who bear these symbols are cursed souls who spread misfortune wherever they go.

The Korth Edicts saw the dragonmarked houses establish their basic hierarchical models, most of which are still in place today. Most houses follow a similar leadership model. The ultimate authority within a house is the patriarch (or matriarch), who oversees the house's ruling council. The

patriarch is appointed by a council of viceroys; term of office and the means by which an inept patriarch can be removed vary from house to house. Most patriarchs are known by the title Baron.

The patriarch is advised by a council whose members represent each of the nations where the house operates. The members of this council are known as the lords seneschal. In addition to the national lords, additional lords seneschal are appointed by a patriarch to serve as his personal representatives. A seneschal can be dispatched to investigate a corrupt or ineffective viceroy, or to negotiate an especially critical agreement with the other houses or nations. Houses with control over multiple guilds often have an additional lord seneschal appointed to each one. These individuals serve as the ultimate guildmaster, coordinating reports from each region and advising the patriarch.

Viceroys are regional directors. A viceroy manages guild operations and house affairs in his assigned region. This office is bestowed by vote of the local council of viceroys and while a viceroy can theoretically be stripped of his rank, the position is hereditary in most houses. Long-standing alliances ensure that viceroalties remain under the dominion of particular branches of a dragonmarked family.

The next tier splits into two paths. Administrators who specifically oversee guild functions are known as masters, while those who manage the internal affairs of a house are ministers. Beneath these ranks come the standard hirelings of the house, whose titles are simply descriptive. In House Ghallanda, for instance, the Viceroy of Sharn oversees all activities in that city and the Master of Agriculture coordinates supplies and the purchase and distribution of foodstuffs to Ghallanda-associated properties in Sharn, but each individual Ghallanda establishment in the City of Towers is run by a house member with the lofty title of innkeeper. In addition to these offices, any member of the house who has manifested a dragonmark is allowed to use the noble title of Lord or Lady, a custom that dates back to the Korth Edicts. This title does not grant any sort of privilege or rights within the house, however: Lord Cantal might very well muck out the stables, while an exceptional but unmarked administrator could work his way up to seize a viceroalty. Even in a pre-industrial economy, competence has its rewards.

As the price of the dragonmarked houses' acceptance of the Korth Edicts, King Galifar I all but granted them an economic monopoly over almost all of the non-agricultural economic activity of the new united Kingdom of Galifar. This monopoly was centered in the guilds that were established and administered by each house. The vast majority of the people who were employed by a dragonmarked house possessed no blood ties to that house. Instead, they were members of the house guilds.

These guilds were vast, sprawling organizations that covered a wide range of occupations. Why join a house guild? To begin with, each guild maintained a network of trade schools. The price of education included a period of service to the house, along with a long-term tithe. Both varied based on the amount of gold the apprentice could put on the table, but a house always looked for a long-term investment from its students. Students of a guild school were required to sign contracts forbidding them from future competition with the business of the house. A would-be magesmith could learn his craft at House Cannith's academy, but he had to swear to serve only their Fabricators Guild thereafter. Should he start an independent business that challenged the guild, House Cannith would bring the full weight of civil law to bear on him, ruining his business. Access to resources was a tangible benefit of joining one of the guilds. An alchemist associated with the Fabricators Guild could purchase exotic components and reagents directly from House Cannith, which provided him with supplies that independent competitors would have a hard time acquiring. As such, guild merchants sold goods and provided services that independent businesses simply could not match. The reputation of a guild for quality was also a powerful tool. When people were paying 50 gold for a *potion of cure light wounds*, few of them would take a chance on any vendor who did not display the banner of House Jorasco. While a guild-affiliated merchant got more business because of his affiliation, he also had to pay dues to the house along with a share of his profits. In addition, he was required to maintain the standards of quality and behavior set forth by the house. Guild members who failed to meet the satisfaction of auditors dispatched by the house could be penalized or even stripped of their membership.

There were three types of guild membership, all of which further centralized all non-agricultural economic and commercial activity in Khorvair into the hands of the twelve dragonmarked houses. The most common type of guild businesses were those licensed by the guild but not officially bound to its structure. Licensees were trained by the guild and pledged to uphold its standards, but received no regular direction from guild administrators. A licensed inn was named by the owner and had its own menu, but the House Ghallanda seal on the door promised courteous behavior and fair prices. Likewise, a ship captain licensed by the Windwrights Guild was not bound by the routes or schedules of his guild. However, his ship had to pass guild inspections and he had to uphold the honor code of House Lyrandar, in addition to paying the house a percentage of his profits. A licensed business could display the guild's seal using black paint or ink. Bound businesses were those funded by a dragonmarked house guild in exchange for a greater share of profits and a controlling hand. Though a licensed Lyrandar captain owned his own ship, a bound captain's ship belonged to the guild, and guild administrators determined his routes and cargoes. The Gold Dragon

Inn is a popular bound business of House Ghallanda's Hostellers Guild and an innkeeper who runs one of its franchises is expected to prepare the same menu as every other Gold Dragon Inn in the Five Nations. Licensed businesses often have their own flavor, but a customer who goes to a bound business knows exactly what to expect. Bound businesses display the guild seal in silver and the names of many bound businesses are as well-known as the dragonmarked houses themselves. Rarest among the guilds are those businesses that are considered direct arms of the dragonmarked houses: enterprises directly managed by blood heirs of the house, marked or unmarked. House arms are not a separate type of business, but can be either licensed or bound. A Sivilis scribe might choose to head up a bound house arm (for example, a notary's office operated according to the house's terms) while a House Tharashk inquisitive could establish his own licensed house arm (a private investigation service that can be run according to his own wishes). House arms are simply representative of a direct connection to a dragonmarked house's hierarchy that most licensed or bound businesses cannot claim. These businesses display the guild seal in gold and often display the seal of the dragonmarked house itself.

The houses seek to squelch competition between guild businesses. House Cannith has fixed the price of longswords at 15 gold pieces across Khorvaire and every licensed or bound smith is expected to hold to that price. Though adventurers might encounter licensed artisans fighting economic duels in the shadows a far more common scenario is to find independent enterprises being pressured to join one of the guilds. The houses seek to maintain the monopoly on their trades and if a master artisan begins to draw significant business away from a guild, its house will take action. A guild representative might appear, extolling the benefits of membership. The merchant might become the victim of a smear campaign slandering his skills and the qualities of his products. The local guild viceroy might use his political influence to tangle the independent in problems with the local government or strangle his access to the market for raw materials. If all else fails, an independent might find himself dealing with burglars, vandals or even threats to his life. The dragonmarked houses take the maintenance of the monopoly granted them by Galifar I very seriously.

House	Mark	Race	Influence
Medani	Detection	Half-elf	Warning Guild
Tharashk	Finding	Half-orc, human	Finders Guild
Vadalis	Handling	Human	Handlers Guild
Jorasco	Healing	Halfling	Healers Guild
Ghallanda	Hospitality	Halfling	Hostellers Guild
Cannith	Making	Human	Tinkers Guild, Fabricators Guild

Orien	Passage	Human	Couriers' Guild, Transportation Guild
Sivis	Scribing	Gnome	Notaries Guild, Speakers Guild
Deneith	Sentinel	Human	Blademarks Guild, Defenders Guild
Phiarlan	Shadow	Elf	Entertainers and Artisans Guild
Thuranni	Shadow	Elf	Shadow Network
Lyrandar	Storm	Half-elf	Windwrights Guild, Raincallers Guild
Kundarak	Warding	Dwarf	Banking Guild, Warding Guild

House Cannith



House Cannith, consisting of humans with the Mark of Making, includes alchemists, artificers, and magewrights of great skill, as well as the best mundane crafters on the continent. House Cannith arose in pre-Galifar Cyre almost twenty-five hundred years ago. Originally, the Cannith clan consisted of traveling tinkers, repairmen, and crafters whose burgeoning dragonmarks gave them an edge over the competition. As the house developed, it turned its attention to arcane disciplines, studying alchemy and pioneering the techniques of artificers and magewrights. As builders, fixers, and creators, the house maintains a lawful outlook. Some of its greatest accomplishments include the lightning rail, the warforged, and the high-rising towers of Sharn.

The destruction of Cannith's ancestral estates in Cyre at the city of Eston and the death of the patriarch Baron Stannis d'Cannith on the Day of Mourning have thrown the house into chaos. Three leaders have emerged, each intending to lead the house into the future. While the situation has not yet grown as bad as the split in the Mark of Shadow's family that resulted in the creation of a new house, none of the emerging Cannith leaders is willing to accept the others as the new house patriarch. So far, they have reluctantly shared influence in the family by concentrating on their own regions and not attempting to pull the entire family together.

Baroness Jorlanna d'Cannith operates out of Fairhaven and oversees the house's efforts in Aundair, Thrane, and the Eldeen Reaches, which is known as Cannith West. Baron Merrix d'Cannith leads the house's activities in Breland, Zilargo, and Darguun from holdings in Sharn, which is known as Cannith South. Baron Zorlan d'Cannith controls the house operations of Cannith East in Karnath, the Mror Holds, and the Lhazaar Principalities from an enclave in Korth. House Cannith maintains

two guilds. The Tinkers Guild serves to maintain society by repairing damaged structures and vehicles, maintaining infrastructures in the major cities, and performing similar crafts. Cannith tinkers often travel on circuits between smaller villages, using magical and mundane skills to assist communities that they pass through. The Fabricators Guild performs the greatest works of craft, artifice, and magic on Khorvaire. The guild is divided into dozens of specialties, including architects, elemental binders, alchemists, and armorers. The Fabricators Guild closely guards the secrets of its creation patterns. With one of these patterns (each made up of three or more sections called *schemas*), a member of the guild can replicate an item faster and with less effort than someone working without a pattern.

The services provided by House Cannith are invaluable, and all the nations and dragonmarked houses have an interest in maintaining friendly relations with the House of Making. House Cannith's greatest enemy is itself. Both Jorlanna and Zorlan seek to gain control of the entire house, while Merrix is content to rule over the southern interests and continue his secret experiments deep beneath Sharn.

House Deneith



The proud humans of House Deneith carry the Mark of Sentinel. Born in pre-Galifar Karrnath about twenty-six hundred years ago, today the house offers the services of the Defenders Guild and Blademarks Guild, one devoted to protection and the other to supply mercenaries to the highest bidders. From his base of operations in Karrlakton, Baron Breven d'Deneith controls the guilds and oversees the activities of the Sentinel Marshals who, by ancient Galifaran decree and the Treaty of Thronehold, provide law and order across national boundaries.

Since the rise of Galifar, House Deneith has held to a military structure. Heirs of the house are expected to serve in the Defenders Guild, the Blademarks, or the Sentinel Marshals, and leaders of the house are usually chosen from the generals of the Blademarks.

Because of its mercenary forces, Deneith holds the most significant military power among the dragonmarked houses. In the past, it has strictly abided by its vow of neutrality, selling its services to

those on both sides of any conflict. With the Five Nations weakened by the Last War, some within the house feel that it is time for Deneith to exercise its power to forge a new kingdom. Chief among these activists is Shirin d'Deneith, Lord Commander of the Blademarks. A recent convert to the Blood of Vol, Shirin has been working with the Order of the Emerald Claw and may soon attempt to wrest control of the house away from Breven.

The Defenders Guild provides personal protection, including skilled bodyguards and wizards who can place warding spells on their charges. The Blademarks Guild manages mercenary activities across Khorvaire. Members of House Deneith serve as officers, trainers, and strategists, but the rank-and-file soldiers of the Blademarks are largely hired mercenaries. The hobgoblins of Darguun and the elves of Valenar both have strong representation in the forces of Deneith, but most of the house's soldiers are human. One noteworthy troop is the League of the Bitter Blade. This mercenary band is composed of soldiers who served in the elite Queen's Guard of Cyre and are now left with no war to fight and no kingdom to return to—their only home is found in the unit. But should Cyran exiles seek to rebuild their lost nation, the Bitter Blades might form the core of its reborn military forces.

House Ghallanda



The Mark of Hospitality appeared among the halflings of the Talenta Plains nearly thirty-two hundred years ago. By using its powers related to the arcane creation of food and shelter, the Ghallanda clan became a powerful force among the nomads of the Plains. Eventually, the family began to send representatives to the burgeoning human nations, and the Hostellers Guild was born.

Today, the patriarch of the house holds court in the ancient Talenta city of Gatherhold. Here, Baron Yoren d'Ghallanda keeps a firm grip on both aspects of his house's heritage—the traditional nomadic culture still practiced on the Talenta Plains and the “civilized” halflings who have been living among the other common humanoid races of Khorvaire for thousands of years.

In the Talenta Plains, House Ghallanda maintains the shared city of Gatherhold for the many nomadic halfling tribes that use it for trading and clan meetings. In the Plains, the house also provides

a traveling fair called the Wandering Inn for halflings ranging far from the protective walls of Gatherhold. In the other nations, the integrated halflings who grew up among the common races operate the Hostellers Guild. Members of the guild include innkeepers, chefs, and restaurateurs, as well as inspectors who enforce standards and regulate business for all member establishments—those run by the house as well as those licensed inns and restaurants willing to earn the house seal and display it for all to see.

House Jorasco



The Mark of Healing first appeared among the halflings of the Talenta Plains about three thousand years ago, but the Jorasco family eventually moved its headquarters to Karnath to better serve greater Khorvaire. For this reason, most of the Jorasco halflings are cosmopolitan and cultured in the traditions of the Five Nations, with few ties to the ancient nomadic ways of the Plains. Today, the Healers Guild of House Jorasco tends to the well-being of most of Khorvaire. Using both mundane and magical healing techniques, as well as alchemy and herbalism, the healers of House Jorasco deal in curing illnesses, tending wounds, and treating mental maladies in their hospitals and healing enclaves. The matriarch of the house, Baroness Ulara d’Jorasco, is dedicated to overseeing her healing enclave and training hospital in Vedykar. She rarely travels far from the enclave, leaving the business of managing distant healing centers to younger family members. She has little patience for the traditional halflings of the Talenta Plains, who treat her house with suspicion and distrust. Still, House Jorasco has healing centers even among the nomadic halflings, for the house’s code requires that all who need aid receive it—as long as they can pay for the service.

House Kundarak



Possessing great wealth and the magical Mark of Warding, the dwarves of House Kundarak have established themselves as the bankers and moneylenders of Khorvaire, as well as providers of persistent security for businesses and precious goods. While the Mark of Warding appeared among the dwarves of the Mror Holds twenty-five hundred years ago, it was not until the rise of the Kingdom of Galifar that the Kundarak dwarves emerged from barbarism and discovered the full extent of their magical gift. Kundarakhold has rich deposits of precious metals, and the clan initially used its dragonmark to protect its vaults. By 106 YK, House Kundarak was admitted into the exclusive membership of the dragonmarked houses, and today House Kundarak's banking system operates throughout Khorvaire.

House Kundarak is a business, and the heirs of the house are expected to earn their keep. The current patriarch, Baron Morrikan d'Kundarak, coordinates the operations of the Banking Guild and the Warding Guild from vast estates in Kundarakhold. Major branches of the family operate in Aundaire, Thrane, Karrnath, Breland, Zilargo, and the Lhazaar Principalities, each with its own director of operations. These nobles report to Kundarakhold, but manage the daily affairs of the house in their region.

The Banking Guild provides loans, letters of credit, and safekeeping services in all the nations mentioned above. Only the Lhazaar Principalities have relatively minor banking facilities, and the Warding Guild has more extensive operations there due to its administration of the prison island of Dreadhold. One of the most popular services for those who can afford it is the safedeposit vault. A client can rent a vault for 10 gp per day. The client and any delegated companions receive a word of access and can deposit an item (weighing up to 10 pounds) into the vault. Through arcane means, the vault can be accessed from any Kundarak banking center, regardless of where the vault was originally accessed. Members of the house receive a discount on this service.

Other services provided by the Banking Guild include exchanging coins for more transportable forms of wealth, such as gems or bills of exchange. The larger offices link by

magical means, and an individual who maintains a balance with the bank can withdraw funds from any of the major outposts. The house speculates in a variety of businesses (including its own precious metals trade), and wealthy clients can choose to take advantage of investment services. Kundarak also provides credit and loans, but as an institution, the bank only deals with royalty, dragonmarked houses, guilds, and other large groups. However, a Kundarak agent may provide a loan to an individual or adventuring party as a matter of personal speculation.

The Warding Guild consists of experts in magical and mundane security, as well as troops trained to guard Kundarak holdings. The house members stationed at Dreadhold belong to this guild. The guild provides independent security consulting and services; Kundarak locks and traps are renowned throughout the land. The Golden Door is a division of the Warding Guild that designs and implements security protocols of every kind, from mundane doors and locks to the most complicated magic wards. Among the dragonmarked, House Kundarak is best known for the work of this division.

The Iron Gate is the sister sect to the Golden Door. When living bodies are necessary for the safeguarding of valuable sites or objects, the soldiers of the Iron Gate are called. The division's leaders work closely with Deneith's Defenders Guild, and often send business that way when the job turns more on protection of the living than their material wealth. The soldiers of the Iron Gate are just as capable as Deneith's, but they try not to step on their human allies' toes. However, they can and do serve dwarves who prefer the protection of their own kind.

In addition to the Warding Guild's Iron Gate and Golden Door, the house maintains two lesser-known orders not affiliated with guilds. The Keyguard are often believed to be a subdivision of the Golden Door, and thus controlled by the Warding Guild. The truth is that one can obtain the services of the Keyguard only directly from the house. The missions of this elite corps of sneaks and security specialists are decided at the upper levels of the house hierarchy. The Ghorad'din ("manticore's tail") is the secret paramilitary arm of House Kundarak. Outside the house, few have heard of it, and all but a small handful of those are dwarves of other clans. Called into service only rarely, the Ghorad'din is the closest that Kundarak has to a force of house assassins.

House Kundarak is composed of nine bloodlines, including the Kundarak, the Durbannek, the Ghedin, and the Tuvodni. All nine can trace their lineage back to the first wardens who gained the surface world alongside the exiled Mror clans.

Many of the nations of Khorvaire and the dragonmarked houses rely on House Kundarak for loans and security, which gives the house considerable influence. House Kundarak has close ties to House Sivis. Gnomes are found at most major branches of the bank. In exchange for a share of the profits, the House of Scribing provides bookkeeping services, verifies important documents, and

assists with magical communication, in addition to providing the services of its mundane advocates and mediators.

House Lyrandar



House Lyrandar consists of half-elves who possess the Mark of Storm. The house appeared in pre-Galifar Thrane two thousand years ago, but today it operates out of Aundair to avoid the restrictive rule of Thrane's theocracy. The house matriarch, Esravash d'Lyrandar, oversees both the Raincallers Guild and the Windwrights Guild from the island paradise of Stormhome, which the house created off the northern coast of Aundair.

An individual with the Mark of Storm can summon rain to save farmers from drought or keep a hurricane from devastating a coastal city. The Raincallers Guild has devoted centuries to the development of irrigation systems, dams, canals, levees, and reservoirs to help control the forces of nature. The unmarked members of the guild focus on these services. In addition, Raincallers often serve as traveling emissaries of House Lyrandar, and are trained in the arts of diplomacy. Large cities often have Raincaller outposts, but the guild also maintains a corps of wanderers who travel regular circuits throughout the agricultural regions of the Five Nations. The Windwrights Guild controls a vast shipping and transportation business that operates in the air and across the seas using both bound-elemental airships and galleons. The Windwrights Guild dominates the shipping trade.

The core fleet of the guild is made up of the elemental-bound vessels and airships of House Lyrandar, crewed by heirs of the house and providing speedy transport by water or air. However, the vast majority of the guild is composed of independent captains who need not be heirs of the house, or even half-elves. To earn the flag of the Windwrights Guild, a captain must pass regular inspections and pay house dues. In exchange, the guild connects him with customs and cargo.

Common belief holds that captains who choose to work outside the guild are likely to suffer “accidents” ranging from deadly weather to sabotage or piracy. Regardless of whether Lyrandar truly engages in such sinister practices, the rumor alone is enough to convince prospective clients to rely on guild shipping, forcing most captains to work within the guild. The sailors of the Lhazaar Principalities are a notable exception to this rule, and there has long been tension between the Windwrights and the eastern sea lords.

With outposts in Breland, Aundair, Zilargo, Thrane, Valenar, and Karnath, House Lyrandar’s shipping and transporation services rival those of House Orien, and the two often compete over contracts that could be fulfilled over either land or sea. The half-elves find few opportunities in the Lhazaar Principalities, however, and often come into conflict with ships of the Lhazaar princes in the open seas.

House Medani



The half-elves of House Medani carry the Mark of Detection. House Medani originated in pre-Galifar Breland fifteen hundred years ago, using its abilities to detect threats to foresee dangers and establish a base of power related to knowledge in the wake of the War of the Mark. Today, Baron Trelib d’Medani oversees house activities and controls the Warning Guild from an enclave in Wroat. He is a powerful and influential friend of Breland’s King Boranel and has a tendency to favor that nation in his dealings. The Warning Guild offers services related to personal protection. Its members work as bodyguards, scouts, sentries, and inquisitives, ever vigilant for unexpected threats that could pose a danger to the clients they serve.

House Medani and the Warning Guild are synonymous in the minds of many Khorvariens, few of whom realize the degree of official separation that stands between them. Rather than a simple extension of the house, the Warning Guild has grown into an affiliated but largely independent entity. The Mark of Detection often leads to meddling in unpleasant affairs; official separation keeps

the house at a safe distance whenever the unpleasantness turns out to involve the nobility or the other dragonmarked houses themselves.

While the Warning Guild provides valuable experience and training for its members, House Medani's ministers realize that not everyone's gifts are best suited to that path. Heirs and house members whose skills lie elsewhere are encouraged to pursue them, as long as those pursuits benefit the house eventually.

The Warning Guild is administered by members of House Medani, and it reports to the Medani patriarch and his council quarterly with financial reports and news of particular interest to the house leadership. Members of the Warning Guild do not gather information in the same manner as a Phiarlan agent, a Thuranni operative, or even a Ghallanda barkeep. Rather, they piece together a map of the subtle plots threading Khorvaire by keeping those plots from coming to pass. Only when Aurum agents are revealed within the Brelish court can the chain of orders and intrigue that brought them there be carefully unraveled. When an assassination attempt against a Cannith seneschal is prevented, it unlocks layers of scheming that would otherwise never come to light. The Warning Guild provides certification and contract employment for bodyguards, inquisitives, and sentries across Khorvaire, though the bulk of its work is in the larger cities. Bodyguards in Khorvaire can be hired from any number of sources, but those of the Warning Guild are not hired primarily for their muscle or skill with a blade. Rather, House Medani specializes in anticipating attacks and preventing them before strength and steel are ever needed. The guild has enclaves throughout the Five Nations, but they are always small and unmarked. If a potential guild member cannot find the place on her own, that does not bode well for her future in that line of work.

House Orien



The humans of House Orien bear the Mark of Passage. The house originated in pre-Galifar Aundair almost two thousand years ago; its abilities related to transposition and teleportation quickly

earned it a place among the economic powers. Today, Baron Kwanti d'Orien serves as the house patriarch. He oversees house activities and controls the Couriers Guild and the Transportation Guild from an enclave in the city of Passage. Of course, like the rest of his family, Kwanti is constantly on the move, and the house maintains outposts and emporiums throughout Khorvaire. The Couriers Guild takes advantage of the vast transportation network established by the house, as well as the dragonmark abilities related to teleportation. Packages, messages, and passengers that need to get somewhere quickly and discreetly often wind up in the hands of an Orien courier. The Couriers Guild serves both the rich and poor of Khorvaire, though the common folk arguably benefit the most from it. For a reasonable fee, the guild arranges safe transportation for letters or packages. Lightning rail cargo runs cover Khorvaire's major centers and the smaller settlements en route, while Orien caravans serve more remote areas. In addition, the Couriers Guild can arrange express shipping, guaranteeing the fastest service and personal delivery at the recipient's end. For its most exclusive clients (and at its most expensive rates), the guild guarantees safe, next day delivery of any parcel small enough to be carried by the courier charged with teleporting to its destination.

As a side service, the guild also employs an elite group of agents who specialize in secure and high-risk delivery scenarios. If the destination is dangerous or remote, or if the item or information to be shipped cannot be entrusted to the lightning rail or the open road, the Couriers Guild has options for those who can afford them.

The Transportation Guild operates lightning rail and caravan routes throughout Khorvaire, providing constant lines of supply and communication between communities across the continent. This guild also maintains the trade roads that crisscross the land, making travel easier and safer whether travelers strike out on their own or hook up with an Orien caravan. These caravans sometimes use magically cooled wagons and other methods of preservation to keep food stocks fresh during transport. The Transportation Guild is responsible for lightning rail, caravan, and coach routes throughout Khorvaire, including the maintenance of trade roads and courier posts. Tariff agreements made with the nations through which its lines run fund the guild. Taxes paid by the settlements where stops are located go toward station maintenance. Passenger fares and shipping fees on the lightning rail, coaches, and caravans are used for general maintenance, salaries, and overhead, and to boost House Orien's bottom line.

While the Couriers Guild is a valuable part of Orien's business, the Transportation Guild is the house's financial foundation. Nearly everyone involved with house operations works in the Transportation Guild at some point. Piloting a lightning rail is the most glamorous and prized job in the guild, but beneath every pilot are hundreds of guild operatives whose work keeps the rail running.

Orien does not make its employment numbers public, but it is widely surmised that the Transportation Guild is the largest guild in Khorvaire.

The Transportation Guild's teleportation services are typically available only at house enclaves. Once the province of nobles and the dragonmarked viceroys, teleportation has taken on a new significance for Orien in the aftermath of the Last War. In the age of exploration, a new class of adventurers and mercenary heroes often has the need (and the coin) to hire those Orien heirs with the greater or Siberys Mark of Passage. In particular, the long-range teleportation ability of a Siberys heir allows instantaneous travel from mainland Khorvaire to the wilds of Xen'drik.

House Phiarlan



The first dragonmarks appeared among the elves of Aerenal more than three thousand years ago. The Mark of Shadow and the Mark of Death appeared at about the same time and the elves quickly understood the significance of the event. House Phiarlan organized around the Mark of Shadow and began turning the abilities provided by the mark into an economic dynasty. However, with the slaughter of the line of Vol's House of Death twenty-six hundred years ago, House Phiarlan left Aerenal and relocated to Khorvaire, where the elves intermingled with humans and helped lay the foundation for the Five Nations. The Mark of Shadow grants divinatory and illusory powers to those who possess it. The Entertainers and Artisans Guild of House Phiarlan provides gifted members of both professions with gainful employment. The house's true work, done in secret, involves information brokering and espionage. During the Last War, the secret work of the house led to a schism within the family. Some parts of the family favored one side or faction in the conflict, other parts favored other sides. Eventually, the tension became too much, and part of the family split to form House Thuranni (see above).

Today, Baronness Elvinor Elorrenthi d'Phiarlan serves as the house matriarch from her palatial estate in Sharn (The original family enclave in Cyre was destroyed along with that nation, but as luck would have it, all the leading members of the house were abroad on that fateful day). Most

people believe that the elves who work for her are the best entertainers and artisans that money can buy. Few suspect the truth—that each is also an integral part of her network of spies operating throughout Khorvaire. Most of the house’s business (at least for information) comes from Breland, Aundair, and Thrane. House Phiarlan maintains cordial ties with the elf lords of Aerenal, but it has long since accepted that it is no longer part of the elf kingdom.

By the time of the War of the Mark, House Phiarlan had become a neutral organization. Few of the Phiarlan elves were cold-blooded killers, and while Phiarlan spies frequently break the laws of the land in their work, members of the house respect the overall structure of society. To a large degree the leaders of the house see themselves as agents of balance, evening the odds between opponents and exposing feuds that would otherwise fester and grow.

The heraldic symbol of the house is a five-headed hydra. Many say that this represents the five artistic demesnes of the house. But some maintain that the hydra symbolizes the resilience and subtlety of the house: Its eyes are everywhere, and should one head fall, two will take its place. Phiarlan uses a stylized silver mask—the “mask of shadows”—as a secondary symbol. This is reminiscent of the golden mask of the Undying Court; members of the house may wear an actual full-sized mask, or carry a replica of the mask as a brooch, amulet, ring, or belt buckle.

The house has many enclaves, but the most significant are the Five Demesnes. Many consider the primary enclave to be the Demesne of Shadow in Sharn. However, the known enclaves serve as the centers of Phiarlan’s *artistic* endeavors. No one knows where the Serpentine Table (the espionage arm of the house) has its base of operations. Each enclave has a governing council and a baron who represents the enclave on the central council, which quarterly convenes in Sharn to discuss the business of the house. Ostensibly, political position within the house is based on talent, and members of enclave councils often include the local masters of the five disciplines. But ultimately the baron makes the appointments.

The central council (or the Serpentine Table) can replace a baron who is failing in her duties or performing questionably, and this council appoints new barons when an opening appears. Small outposts have no council and are governed by the nearest enclave. Best known for its Artisans and Entertainers Guild, House Phiarlan has hundreds of years to devote to a particular art due to the elven lifespan. As a result, the masters of Phiarlan are legends in their fields. Phiarlan entertainers covered a vast spectrum of arts, and the typical Phiarlan enclave has musicians, actors, poets, dancers, storytellers, and even professional escorts available. While the elves themselves are the primary ambassadors of the arts, exceptional members of other races can earn a place in one of the Five Demesnes and study at the feet of the elven masters. An entertainer with a Phiarlan certification has

an easier time finding work in his field. The elves of House Phiarlan practice hundreds of different styles of song, dance, and other arts, from the ancient traditions of Xen'drik to the modern styles of Khorvaire.

Long ago, the founders of the house divided the arts into five disciplines. The greatest masters and teachers of these arts have settled in the five major enclaves of the house, which are known as demesnes. The Five Demesnes of Phiarlan and the arts associated with them are described below. Teachers of all disciplines train willing students at each enclave, but someone who wants to deal with the best in the field should travel to the appropriate demesne. The discipline of memory encompasses the written word. Novelists, playwrights, and poets are all students of memory. Phiarlan also considers propaganda to be a fine art. A play, a novel, or a song can have a powerful effect on public opinion, and for an extra fee a Phiarlan author can produce work that portrays the client in an especially good light—or vilifies an opponent. Many leaders make use of Phiarlan speech writers; more than one politician has hired a disguised shadow actor to give an important speech on his behalf. The Demesne of Memory is located in the city of Fairhaven in Aundair.

The discipline of motion incorporates the arts of the body. This includes dance, gymnastics, wrestling, mime, contortion, massage, and many more. Phiarlan dancers master dozens of styles and are renowned for their grace. Exceptional acrobats and contortionists may find work with the Carnival of Shadows, the famed Phiarlan circus, while lesser tumblers often entertain the commonfolk on the streets or cheap theaters. The Serpentine Table often recruits gifted students of motion; masters of motion frequently can adapt their skills to burglary and battle. Phiarlan escorts study the arts of motion and shadow. These elves are not prostitutes, but they are graceful companions gifted in conversation, dance, and massage. Dragonmarked escorts can also use their powers to adopt specific identities to fulfill the wishes of a client. Since most people are more comfortable around elves than changelings, a wealthy man who wants the company of a particular woman may hire a Phiarlan companion to impersonate her instead of a changeling. The Demesne of Motion is located in the city of Korth in Karrnath.

The Demesne of Music teaches the arts of sound—both song and the use of instruments. Phiarlan bards have scoured Khorvaire for musical traditions, and some instructors can teach the arts of Adaran chant and other obscure styles. Most Phiarlan bards spend some time at the Demesne of Music, though many also study at the Demesne of Shadow. The Demesne of Music is located in the city of Flamekeep in Thrane.

The Demesne of Shape covers the creation of physical objects. One of the primary duties of the Demesne of Shape is the creation of the resources the house requires for its entertainers—

costumes, sets, props, instruments, and the like. However, the Artisans and Entertainers Guild also covers aesthetic art, and sculptors, painters, and potters can all learn their trades at this demesne. The sale of such goods is a significant source of income for the house, and the woodsmiths of Phiarlan are said to be the finest outside of Aerenal itself. The first Demesne of Shape was located in the city of Metrol in Cyre. The destruction of Cyre during the Last War dealt a blow to the house, but at the start of the war Phiarlan had spread the resources of the house across the Five Nations to avoid just such a disaster, and miraculously (some say suspiciously) all the finest teachers and artisans were visiting other demesnes on the Day of Mourning. The new Demesne of Shape has been established in Wroat, in Breland.

While the finest artists survived the Mourning, a great deal of Phiarlan craftwork and mystical tools were lost in the fall of Cyre. The house may wish to hire a team of adventurers to venture into the Mournland and recover objects from Metrol. In its broadest sense, the discipline of Shadow covers the art of deception. This includes illusion, which the house has refined into a fine art; Phiarlan dream parlors and shadow weavers use magic to produce astonishing shows. It also includes literal shadow plays and puppetry—arts in which the actual actor performs at a distance from the audience. But the Demesne of Shadow also serves as the center for verbal arts of deception and coercion, feigned emotion, and role assumption. Actors and orators learn their craft at this demesne, and while a storyteller may learn his tales at the Demesne of Memory, he learns to deliver a tale at the Demesne of Shadow. Stealth and sleight of hand are also taught in this place, since the stagehand and the puppeteer need to hide in the shadows and avoid the gaze of the audience. Of course, while this is the public reason for such training, many of those who study the arts of stealth are actually members of the Serpentine Table—or hope to be recruited by this inner circle. The Demesne of Shadow is located in Sharn, in Breland. With the destruction of the first Demesne of Music, it is the oldest of the Five Demesnes and is the current home of the house matriarch.

House Sivilis



Using natural talent and the Mark of Scribing, the gnomes of House Sivilis have established themselves as the masters of the written and spoken word. In addition to maintaining the lines of mystical communication that connect the nations of Khorvaire, House Sivilis provides translators, notaries, mediators, and advocates to cities across the continent.

All gnomes are touched with magic because of their fey heritage, and the scholars of Korranberg have spent thousands of years studying arcane phenomena. When the Mark of Scribing first appeared within the Sivilis family twenty-eight hundred years ago, the gnomes were quick to recognize and develop its abilities. Sivilis understood the power it possessed, but it also recognized the danger of being perceived as too powerful; thus, those who bore a dragonmark immediately found ways to make themselves useful to society and to distance their house from the politics of the nation. The gnomes of House Sivilis were among the first of their kind to leave Zilargo and live in human lands. Today, their services are indispensable. Over the centuries they have established and maintained a reputation for absolute impartiality—a vital trait for the force that handles the communications of kings.

House Sivilis loves bureaucracy. A council of nine administrators oversees operations in each of the nations; each council sends one representative to the High Council of Korranberg, which manages the affairs of the house across Khorvaire. As in Zilargo itself, positions of leadership may appear to be obtained through merit, but a great deal of political infighting, intrigue, and manipulation goes on in the shadows. The current doyenne of the High Council is Lysse Lyrriman d'Sivilis. She has led the house for almost ninety years and is known as an extremely shrewd negotiator and planner.

To the casual observer, House Sivilis appears to have no goals beyond expanding its services across Khorvaire. Within the house, a constant shadow war for rank and position unfolds. The gnomes do not allow these struggles to interfere with their work or their relations with their fellows; two Sivilis gnomes plotting against one another may still go out drinking and have a fine time together.

In a sense, the struggles are like an endless game of chess; the gnomes enjoy the game and accept any setback as a new challenge to overcome. House Sivis has two primary operations, the Speakers Guild and the Notaries Guild. The Speakers Guild offers the services of translators, interpreters, mediators, and legal advocates. In addition, the Speakers Guild maintains the network of message stations through which, for a price, a message can be sent from one station to any other station in Khorvaire using *speaking stones*. The Notaries Guild deals with written documents. Sivis scribes use arcane means to authenticate legal documents, and they also perform transcription, translation, bookkeeping, and copying of texts. They specialize in the creation of secure documents, using their abilities to prepare missives that can only be read by designated individuals.

House Tharashk



The humans and half-orcs of House Tharashk use the Mark of Finding to work as prospectors, inquisitives, and bounty hunters. The Mark of Finding first appeared in the Shadow Marches about one thousand years ago. After being visited by House Sivis representatives five hundred years ago, the holders of the mark decided to follow the example of the gnomes and form an economic force of their own.

The initial business of the house was derived from the immense Eberron dragonshard deposits in the region; Tharashk quickly became the prime suppliers of Eberron dragonshards to the rest of Khorvaire. Over the last three hundred years, the house has expanded its operations across Khorvaire, working as trackers and prospectors beyond compare. The affairs of the house are managed from Zarash'ak, the capital of the Shadow Marches, by a triumvirate representing the old clans. Members include Daric d'Velderan, Khundar'aashta, and Maagrim d'Tharashk. The Triumvirate appoints regional leaders to run Tharashk operations in other nations, and these leaders, in turn, appoint lesser officers within the territories they control.

Although orcs cannot manifest the Mark of Finding, House Tharashk includes orc members. The orcs devote their physical strength to mining and prospecting, or to assisting their marked

cousins on bounty hunting assignments. House Tharashk maintains a number of different operations under the auspices of the Finders Guild.

Members help miners locate rich deposits, as well as maintaining significant mining operations of their own. The guild has a virtual monopoly on the Eberron dragonshard trade. Using skilled inquisitives and bounty hunters, both marked and unmarked, the house conducts such business. In addition, Tharashk has recently been acting as a clearinghouse for the services of mercenaries from Droaam, including ogre, troll, gnoll and minotaur soldiers, ogre laborers, harpy scouts, and others.

House Thuranni



Once part of House Phiarlan, the elves of House Thuranni formed their own house during the Last War as the conflict began to turn various house factions against each other. Now Thuranni competes directly with Phiarlan in the areas of espionage, surveillance, and information brokering, as well as in entertainment and artisan endeavors. The two houses share the Mark of Shadow, though the newer version of the house in many ways remains the weaker of the two.

For twenty-five years, since shortly after striking out on its own, House Thuranni has run its Shadow Network from enclaves in Regalport in the Lhazaar Principalities. The house operates outposts throughout Khorvaire, but its patriarch has a fondness for Sharn, the City of Towers. Baron Elar d'Thuranni oversees the activities of the house, selling its services to clients in Karrnath, Droaam, Q'barra, and the Lhazaar Principalities, among others. Rumors persist that the baron deals with the Order of the Emerald Claw, but not even House Phiarlan has been able to confirm this.

Neither elven house advertises its shadow services. Instead, the houses share a public face as entertainers and artisans of renown. House Thuranni has a darker agenda and more aggressive business tactics, however. When someone has a need for its services, or when the house has something important to sell, a representative appears in the shadows to whisper an offer with a

knowing smile. Baron d'Thuranni has two constant companions— greater wraiths named Wrem and Wrek that protect and advise the patriarch, never straying far from his side. Whether he is in Regalport or Sharn or one of the many House Thuranni outposts located throughout the land, the baron's hideous shadows always accompany him on business and pleasure travel.

Unlike the house from which it split, House Thuranni makes no pretense of neutrality or balance. The house sees its actions as having greater purpose than simply supporting the subtle machinations of noble lords and kings. This ideological separation combines with the house's business philosophy to make the heirs of House Thuranni more ruthless and aggressive than those of Phiarlan.

House Thuranni observes the traditional hierarchy of the dragonmarked houses, but also maintains divisions based on the roles heirs play within the house. Though House Phiarlan still maintains its own center for the Demesne of Shape in Thaliost in Thrane, all serious students of architecture, costuming, painting, pottery and sculpture study at the true heart of the discipline—the House Thuranni enclave in the Karnathi city of Atur. Thuranni calls its demesne the True Shapers as an unsubtle jab at the Phiarlans, and students from all races and nations study under its master artists and artisans.

At the heart of House Thuranni, the Dragon's Path remains dedicated to unraveling the draconic Prophecy as it unfolds on Eberron. Composed primarily of older house members with a strong sense of history and a working knowledge of arcane magic, the Dragon's Path includes architects, astrologers, historians and the Thuranni field agents who do their bidding. Members of the order believe that the dragons of Argonessen have kept their knowledge of the Prophecy to themselves for far too long and recall the dragon wars on Aerenal as proof that the great wyrms' agenda sees the "lesser races" as expendable pawns if need be.

Where the Serpentine Table is but one aspect of House Phiarlan, its mirror sect among the Thuranni is the true face of the house—and all other sects are merely veils of convenience. The talent and vision of Thuranni artists is real, but so too is the dedication with which they pursue other, darker arts. Like Phiarlan's espionage network, the Shadow Network divides its agents between four ranks. Unlike in the Serpentine Table, Shadow is the highest rank a member can hope to attain. Those of lowest rank are known as Wisps and they represent a small majority of the Network's membership. Apparitions coordinate groups of wisps, while Phantasms are the house's elite operatives and field agents. Each operative is further defined by one of two descriptors. The Bright classification signifies an agent who excels at mission of an aggressive, physical nature like assassination, while the Pale classification denotes an agent who specializes in deep cover missions that rely more on finesse and

deception. Though rumors of a fifth rank, an office known as the Master of Shadows, have circulated through Thuranni in recent years, little evidence supports such tales...at least so far.

The Lich Queen, Vol, has also taken an interest in House Thuranni, for she has discovered that some of its members are actually distantly related to her own long-lost House Vol. The half-dragon lich hopes to one day use these elves—and powerful Qabalin necromantic magic recovered from Xen'drik—to refound her own lost house and restore the Thirteenth Mark, the Mark of Death, to the world of Eberron. If the majority of the members of the house learned of Vol's plans, they would be outraged and would use all of their considerable resources to end the Lich Queen's threat to Khorvaire and the rest of the world once and for all. But a minority of the house might not be so opposed...

House Vadalis



House Vadalis bears the Mark of Handling, which has the power to calm and control animals. The Vadalis Handlers Guild breeds and sells a tremendous variety of animals, and Vadalis handlers serve as teamsters, trainers, and stablekeepers across Khorvaire. The humans who formed the Vadalis family migrated to the Eldeen Reaches about two thousand years ago. When the Mark of Handling emerged two hundred years later, offering the settlers a defense against the many wild animals of the region, it was seen as a gift from the gods. House Vadalis has developed that gift into a lucrative and powerful economic position.

Today, the power of House Vadalis radiates from the Eldeen Reaches, and the Handlers Guild has outposts throughout Khorvaire. House Vadalis is a family first and a business second. Patriarch Dalin d'Vadalis oversees house operations from an enclave in the heart of the city of Varna, and the house maintains a number of small towns throughout the eastern portion of the Eldeen Reaches.

Vadalis produces remarkable mounts, livestock, and guardian beasts, using natural animals, domesticated magical creatures, and magebred animals enhanced through generations of arcane experiments. From magebred dire wolves to pegasus mounts, Vadalis is the source for all manner of unusual creatures.

In addition to breeding and selling animals, the Handlers Guild provides a host of other services. House Vadalis maintains stables in most major towns and cities, provides training and health care for animals of all descriptions, and hires out drivers and teamsters for caravans and coaches. While they are relatively slow, the messenger bird and mounted post services of House Vadalis provide a connection to out-of-the-way communities that are too small to support the operations of House Sivilis or House Orien. House Vadalis has always had close ties with House Orien, and Orien caravans often use Vadalis drivers and animals. Since the druids emerged from the Great Forest, Vadalis has done its best to maintain strong ties with the Wardens of the Wood. Not all the Eldeen druid sects approve of House Vadalis. In particular, the Ashbound despise Vadalis and often raid the holdings of the house. In addition, House Vadalis made bitter enemies among the elves of Valenar when it sought to steal a herd of Valenar horses twenty years ago.

The Handlers Guild is a mercantile guild under the control of House Vadalis. Unlike the majority of the dragonmarked houses in which guilds control industry while the house handles administrative tasks, Vadalis divides responsibilities in a different fashion. The house handles research into new types of animals and new breeding programs, as well as the sale, care, and training of those animals. The Handlers Guild functions much as an outreach program, operating primarily in areas where Vadalis does not have official house enclaves. The guild serves to gather independent ranchers and breeders, share information and bloodlines, and sell Vadalis methods and training to those who want to improve their own herds through nonmagical means. In addition, the guild licenses the teamsters, drovers, stablehands, and handlers that comprise the most common face of the house in Khorvaire.

The Handlers Guild provides certification for its members, allowing them to find work with wealthy patrons who need their lands and livestock managed. It also deals with business the house does outside the Eldeen Reaches. It has almost no enclaves or outposts, its members instead meeting up wherever their travels happen to take them. Some have noted that such a fluid presence would make an excellent front for any number of sinister causes, but no evidence of such activity in Vadalis has ever been found.

The Cosmology of Eberron

Thirteen different realms beyond the world of Eberron itself make up the whole of Creation—dominions of fire and ice, of eternal forests and boundless sky, of radiant light and impenetrable darkness. These realms are different planes of existence: self-contained worlds beyond the world of Eberron and its neighboring sun and moons. These realms have their own physical and magical laws, their own flow of time, and their own intelligent races and cultures. No one knows the full extent of these planes. Some scholars speculate that each is infinite, stretching endlessly through its own space; others declare that such worlds are only roughly the size of Eberron itself. In any event, each plane is certainly large enough to accommodate years of exploration for anyone prepared to face hostile conditions and dangerous natives.

Two of these planes are always close to the world, overlapping with it in the same physical space: Thelanis the Feywild and Dolurrh the Shadowfell. Thelanis is a verdant, wild twin of the mortal world. Towering forests sprawl for thousands of miles. Perfect prairies of waving, amber grass roll between pristine mountain peaks that soar into puffy clouds. Emerald and cerulean seas crash along endless white sand beaches. The skies are a perfect blue not seen in Eberron—until the powerful storms come, bringing with them coal-black thunderclouds that boil with torrential rains and whipping winds. In this mirror world, the arcane energy of Siberys thrums at the heart of every rock, tree and animal. All of existence is charged with the power of arcane magic in a way not seen anywhere else in the multiverse. Dolurrh, the Shadowfell, is a dark mirror of the material world of Eberron and the polar opposite of the Feywild. All objects (though not animals and intelligent beings) on Eberron have a shadowy analog in Dolurrh. Time and distance have little meaning in the Shadowfell, and arcanists and divine spellwielders who enter the plane can easily travel great distances across it, reemerging in the corresponding location on Eberron in a brief time. However, the Shadowfell is haunted by many forms of both mundane and unique undead and other horrors, making it a perilous place for all travelers, though it also home to many of the mortal races of Eberron who have taken up residence in the dark place.

Eberron, Thelanis and Dolurrh all exist as part of what is known as the “World-Axis Cosmology,” in which Eberron lies at the center of two other fundamanetal planes—the Astral Sea and the Elemental Chaos. The Astral Sea, which lies “above” Eberron and its mirror worlds, is a great silvery void, sometimes experienced as an actual sea or a starry sky through which travelers, objects,

and even the other planes float freely. Travelers move (or float) through the Astral Sea at will (though such movement might simply be an illusion in the mind of the traveler). However, this motion is quite slow as the Astral Sea is a truly vast space. An astral traveler would be wise to use magic or arcane portals to reach their intended planar destination or to make use of astral transports like *planar dromonds*, *astral skiffs* or even the rare *spelljammer* vessels. The Astral Sea is the space behind space—the nonplace that connects all other places and from which, alongside the Elemental Chaos, the Progenitors shaped much of the raw stuff of Creation. It allows spellcasters to teleport from place to place on Eberron, and it serves as a conduit when summoning creatures from the other planes.

Chaos is the raw material of creation, that from which the multiverse arose. Untouched by the stabilizing divine influence of the three Progenitors that formed the world and its mirror counterparts into a more or less permanent state, the Elemental Chaos is a roiling tempest of matter and energy. At times, areas coalesce into coherent shapes and terrain, but much of it resembles a stormy sea of churning destruction. The Chaos is at once the foundation of the world and the greatest threat to its existence. By its nature, the Elemental Chaos seeks to pull the created world into its embrace, and return it to its component parts. Most of the intelligent inhabitants of the Elemental Chaos, such as the slaad and elementals, share a primal drive toward entropy. Many are creative in their own ways, building structures and civilizations, tearing them down, then beginning anew. However, the demons who are native to the plane—driven by an insatiable thirst for destruction—seek only to draw the entire multiverse into the Chaos in their eternal quest for annihilation.

Thirteen other planes of existence float in the Astral Sea as astral dominions or exist within the Elemental Chaos as elemental realms. Some planar scholars describe them moving through the Astral Sea and the Elemental Chaos in complex orbits that bring them variously closer to and farther from Eberron—sometimes even coming close enough to touch Eberron and allow some of their essence to cross over into the world.

Daanvi, the Perfect Order, is an astral dominion where law reigns supreme and even the trees and shrubs grow in regular, ordered patterns. The plane is composed of giant, interlocking mechanical gears of varying sizes that serve as the platforms upon which all living things reside. In Daanvi all things live in harmony born of pure order. Two races of intelligent beings call Daanvi home, the ant-like insectoids called formians and the strange constructs called modrons. Daanvi's polar opposite is the elemental realm of the Elemental Chaos called Kythri, the Churning Chaos, an ever-changing soup of roiling elemental entropy that represents that fundamental plane at its most unstable, a conglomerated mix of all the fundamental elements of Creation. In Kythri, it is not uncommon to see a floating earthberg bobbing in a sea of fire while from the clouds above it rains

shards of ice. Kythri is also the home of the chaotic race of slaad, who seek to spread entropy across the multiverse. According to popular superstition, times of historical stability are linked to the proximity of Daanvi to Eberron in the Astral Sea, while times of unrest and conflict are associated with Kythri's nearness, but no evidence supports these claims.

Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams, is the plane where dreams play out. Dal Quor is a vast repository where dreams go when they are dreamt, a realm formed by millions of creative minds over the past ages of the world. When the mortals of Eberron dream, they psychically project their minds to Dal Quor. Behind the dreams and nightmares that mortals experience lie the cities of the quori—monsters of nightmare that feed on the psychic energy of dreams. The heart of the Plane of Dreams is ruled by the collective consciousness of the plane, which changes its shape and the overall nature of the plane in a cyclical fashion. In times past, the heart of Dal Quor created a region of pleasant dreams and extraordinary creativity but at the current time the Plane of Dreams is a region of nightmares ruled by *il-Lashtavar*, the Dreaming Dark. The quori are the intelligent inhabitants of the Plane of Dreams but their appearance and goals are intimately linked to the nature of the plane's heart. When the plane's collective consciousness shifts all of the present members of the quori species are also wiped out, only to be replaced with a new, entirely different race of quori when the new heart of the plane forms. The present race of quori have no desire to see themselves become extinct and so they have pursued a massive plot to conquer large portions of Eberron so that they might prevent the next change in Dal Quor's nature. Through their human Inspired hosts, the psionically-potent quori rule the empire of Riedra on the continent of Sarlona and pursue their grand plan to control the dreams of all the mortals of Eberron through the work of the Dreaming Dark (see below).

Dolurrh, the Shadowfell, is the Realm of the Dead and one of the two mirror worlds of Eberron, alongside Thelanis. Dolurrh was born through the interaction of the Progenitor wyrms Eberron and Khyber, though Khyber's dark influence was the stronger here and the Shadowfell is awash in the necromantic energies that scholars simply call shadow. A place of hopelessness and despair, this is where mortal souls pass when life has reached its end, streaking across the dark skies of this shadowy world like falling stars. According to the faith of the Sovereign Host, no great reward lies beyond life's bounds, so life on Eberron must be lived to its fullest and drunk to the dregs while an individual has the chance. Immortality is achieved through heroic deeds that leave a lasting mark on the world of the living, for the shades of individuals that persist in Dolurrh bear little mark of their former identities. Other faiths, like those of the Dark Six and the Church of the Silver Flame, hold that those souls which are judged worthy are allowed to move beyond Dolurrh to an eternal reward

promised by those faiths, somewhere beyond the boundaries of Creation. Others believe that certain particularly powerful agents of the gods possess the power to grant certain souls a reprieve from eternity in Dolurrh or beyond, to serve as immortal versions of their former selves known as the Exalted and the Damned. The Shadowfell is home to communities of all the common races of Eberron, who are known as the Shadowborn, and to the shadar-kai, a race of humans who were altered millennia ago by constant exposure to the shadowy, necromantic energies of Dolurrh. Though undead are the most common inhabitants of the Shadowfell, certain demons and devils also find the plane's necromantic energies pleasing.

Fernia, the Sea of Fire, and Risia, the Plane of Ice, are two elemental realms of the Elemental Chaos that are the homes of powerful elemental forces dedicated to fire and water, particularly archons of the respective element. Fernia is also a favorite dwelling-place for fire-loving demons like the balor and even devils like the pit fiend. A similar dynamic is also at work in Risia, which has quite a large population of ice devils (gelugons). Every five years, the midsummer is especially hot and the midwinter particularly cold as these planes draw close to Eberron.

Irian, the Eternal Day, is an astral dominion awash in the radiance of positive energy, the pure essence of life itself. The sun never sets over the riotous and abundantly fertile fields and forests of Irian, where all forms of life find a beneficent home and where the rulers are powerful angels. The greatest of the cities of Irian is known as Hestavar, the Bright City, a major planar marketplace ruled by three of the most powerful angels in all of Creation. The Bright City is a bustling planar metropolis inhabited by the Exalted and certain lucky mortals who have found their way beyond Eberron. In contrast, the dominion known as the Endless Night of Mabar is a starless void that devours life and light, a rambling maze of black tunnels blasted by fierce winds. Mabar is the home of undead creatures who are particularly fearsome as well as various devils.

Lamannia, the Twilight Forest, is an astral dominion of unbounded nature. Plants and animals, magical beasts and elementals, and wild immortals of bestial and elemental aspect run free in its verdant forests, rolling plains, and soaring mountains. Because of the links between Lamannia and the Elemental Chaos, the Twilight Forest is also home to certain species of demon. Animals native to Lamannia often grow larger and stronger than their counterparts on Eberron. Some are sentient animal lords, much like the similar creatures who call the Feywild home. There are numerous planar links between Lamannia and Thelanis, because of the affinity between the two planes' wild natures. Farmers say that crops grow more quickly during the one week every year when Lamannia draws close to Eberron through the Astral Sea.

Shavarath, the Battleground, is an astral dominion inhabited by races of angels and fiends locked in eternal war with each other— angels, devils, and demons. All three races maintain massive strongholds and fortresses across the plane and three-way battles are not uncommon. Some say that Shavarath drew near to Eberron in the year the Last War started and came close at least twice more during the course of the war, each time presaging an outbreak of particularly bitter violence.

Syrania, the Azure Sky, is the astral dominion that is the home of glittering crystal cities floating in an endless blue sky. Each of the glittering crystal cities are ruled by the wisest of angels. The power of the Light on Eberron grows when Syrania draws near, and flying becomes easier in places of the world where its influence is strong— including the great city of Sharn on the continent of Khorvaire, which is located in a Syrania manifest zone.

Thelanis, the Feywild, is the mysterious native homeworld of all the fey races, the fomorians and the eladrin, a world that is the mirror image of Eberron and was created through the actions of the Progenitor wyrms Siberys and Eberron. Because of Siberys' involvement, the Feywild is awash in a flood of arcane energies greater even than those on Eberron. The intelligent beings native to Thelanis—the enigmatic eladrin, the vicious hags, the wild dryads and the tyrannical fomorians—are all charged with the arcane energy that defines this plane. Some are blessed by it, while others are warped. Like the land around them, the fey who inhabit this plane run to extremes. Fey pledged to the cause of good are noble and just, protectors of the natural world and those mortals they choose to show favor to. Fey sworn to evil are the embodiment of dark instincts unleashed, all blood and claw and primal rage. Many scholars believe the ancestors of the elves and the drow of Eberron originally came from Thelanis, a theory that has recently been confirmed with the “worldfall” of several eladrin cities from the Feywild into Eberron. Gnomes are also believed to have been natives of the Feywild and the civilized gnomes of Zilargo maintain ties with their more fey counterparts in Thelanis. Tales speak of travelers drawn into the Feywild's eternal twilight, emerging after what feels to them like mere days, only to discover that weeks or even months have passed on Eberron. The influence of the Feywild is said to be strong near faerie rings and faerie mounds, which are most common in the heavily forested Eldeen Reaches of Khorvaire.

Xoriat, also called the Far Realm, is the Plane of Madness, home to the hideous race of fleshshapers known as the daelkyr and biological aberrations like the beholders and mind flayers that they spawn. Ten thousand years ago, Xoriat drew close to the world and the daelkyr and their aberrant minions invaded Eberron, until the orcish druids called the Gatekeepers finally sealed all the planar connections to their insane realm.

Xoriat is a plane that is terrifyingly remote from the standard planar geometry and is now magically prevented from contact with Eberron by the efforts of the Gatekeepers. The creatures that live in the Plane of Madness are too alien for a mortal mind to accept without being damaged. Where stray emanations from the Far Realm have leaked into the world, living matter either burns to ash or takes on a monstrous new aberrant life. Xoriat is literally the “far realm” because it lies outside and beyond the cosmology that encompasses the world of mortals, angels and fiends alike. It is “outside” of Creation, existing in the theoretical realm of timeless infinity. Knowledge of Xoriat is a triumph of mind over the boundaries of matter, space, time and even sanity. In fact, every mortal or immortal who has attempted to comprehend the truth of the Far Realm came away from the experience with a shattered mind, at best. At worst, such beings were subsumed and corrupted by Xoriat, becoming aberrant monsters themselves. Those who only lightly value the cohesion of their own minds sometimes journey to those stained locations where the Far Realm has touched (or currently touches) the world. There, they seek to gaze Outside.

Although the descriptions of many of the resulting visions are little more than incoherent babble, some share at least a few particulars. A thread of consistency speaks of a space inhabited by vast entities immersed in contemplations so alien that reality itself warps and changes in their presence. Lethal contradictions and toxic natural laws are born at whim only to dissolve like vapor to make way for newer, more insane dreams. Another ongoing theme of the visions describes the Far Realm as a solid mass of translucent, onion-like skins. The stacked layers are pierced with free-floating bone-white rivers, and seepages of blue slime that dissolve all they touch. Elsewhere, gelatinous worms wend through the folds using writhing cilia and lichen-like encrustations. No air or atmosphere exists in the Far Realm. It is one immeasurable, semi-solid amoebic sea. Vast shapes drift at the edge of sight through the realm’s substance, blurrily reminiscent of creatures from the deepest sea trenches of the mortal world. Many of the blurry forms are as large as cities—and those are the small ones. The daelkyr, the foul fleshshapers, are some of the most powerful denizens of Xoriat, as well as their servants, the mind flayers and beholders. Aboleths are also native to the Far Realm, though those ancient horrors serve no one but themselves and were once the masters of Eberron’s seas and oceans long ago during the Age of Demons. Yet, there is some evidence that entities even more powerful and horrifying than the daelkyr call Xoriat home—beings like Mak Thuum Ngatha, the Nine Tounge Worm worshiped by some of the most truly deranged of the Cults of the Dragon Below.

Some scholars believe that the Astral Sea is bounded in its most distant reaches by an encircling realm of utter dark, the very boundary of Creation and the end of all things. They call this

region the Outer Darkness. Some claim that the shining realm of the Sovereign Host lies somewhere beyond this Outer Darkness, and that the Outer Darkness is the home-in-exile of the Dark Six. No mortal is known to ever have visited this place, let alone any divine realm beyond it, so its existence is a matter of pure speculation.

At times, a link between each of these planes and Eberron can develop in which a portion of Eberron takes on some of the characteristics of the other plane. These rare geographical occurrences are known as *manifest zones*. At other times, these unexpected effects can develop randomly and for short but highly intense periods of time at random across large stretches of territory. These areas are called *wild zones* but are found mostly on the continent of Sarlona where, for some unknown reason, the walls between the other planes and Eberron tend to be weaker than on the rest of the world. Manifest zones appear everywhere in Eberron and zones exist that link to all of the planes except Dal Quor. The effects of a manifest zone are sometimes related to the effects of a plane becoming coterminous with Eberron, but this is not always the case. In fact, the most well-known manifest zone in the world, the zone linked to Syrania in which the city of Sharn was built, has characteristics unrelated to the effects of Syrania's conterminous state and only tangentially related to the properties of the plane itself. Manifest zones are, above all, unpredictable. All manifest zones have two properties in common. First, a manifest zone is considered a part of both the world and the plane to which the zone is linked. Second, it is always easier to pass between Eberron and the linked plane in a manifest zone. Besides the manifest zone in which Sharn is built, important manifest zones include the Lair of the Keeper in the Demon Wastes and Lake Dark in Karnath (both linked to Dolurrh), the City of the Dead in Aerenal (linked to Irian) and three manifest zones in the Eldeen Reaches: Greenheart (linked to Lammania), the Gloaming (linked to Mabar), and the Twilight Demesne (linked to Thelanis). Several known manifest zones linked to Kythri and Xoriat exist in the Shadow Marches. Some sages speculate that the massive Fist of Onatar volcano in the Mror Holds is a manifest zone linked to Fernia and zones linked to Risia almost certainly exist in the Frostfell, Eberron's frozen northern continent. The Mournland is believed to contain at least one manifest zone tied to Shavarath, created as a result of the day of Mourning—or perhaps having even caused that cataclysm.

Dolurrh and Thelanis are in constant motion, following their orbits around the natural World of Eberron, rotating in the cosmic soup of reality. With such motion comes the risk of collisions or planar breaches. When such an event occurs, a specific region of the natural world acquires the traits of the colliding plane. Thus, when the Shadowfell encounters Eberron, a pall of gloom settles over the land, and sorrow seizes the hearts and minds of those dwelling there. More

importantly, during these events, travel to the other plane is easier. Portals and crossings open, disgorging the denizens of the other plane into the natural world, and planar bleed sometimes plucks the unwary from the world and pulls them into the Feywild or the Shadowfell. The duration of the planar bleed depends on the severity of the collision, but it lasts for no more than a day before normalcy reasserts itself.

Planar breaches are terrifying occurrences, born in areas where the bounds of reality are tested to the point of breaking. Planar breaches can be created by powerful rituals that bend reality, the appearance of an elder evil, or the awakening of a primordial. In addition, certain areas spawn planar breaches on their own, causing bubbles to form and burst in reality, spewing the stuff of one plane into another. A planar breach builds before it completely forms. As it threatens to explode, a bulge forms in reality, causing the area of the breach to distort and assume a stretched or compacted appearance. A few moments after the event begins, the bulge explodes outward, causing a portion of another plane and its inhabitants to fall into the other plane. The breach and the area all around it fuse into a bizarre amalgamation of realities, gaining the traits of both planes, and allowing passage from one plane to the next. Planar breaches occur between any two planes and even between two different worlds. These phenomena can cause widespread damage and destruction. (For example, one might expect catastrophe when an ocean of boiling water pours into the natural world from the Elemental Chaos.) Some planar breaches spawn elemental motes, free-floating chunks of earth, water, or some other fundamental element, that careen through the skies. Other planar breaches erase vast sections of lands, pulling them into some other world. Most planar breaches do not extend farther than a few hundred feet in diameter, but greater breaches have haunted the world in its dim past, as attested to by the existence of floating islands of matter and stranger objects, formations, and structures in the world. A planar breach lasts for a few hours before stability is restored.

A reality rip is a hole in the fabric of the cosmos, a gap of nothingness that is created when magic goes awry, such as in the wake of an artifact's destruction, the death of a fiendish Overlord, or some other monumental event. Once formed, the rip pulls surrounding materials inside, gobbling up reality until it collapses or the entire plane implodes. Some speculate reality rips tear holes to Xoriat, and in the gap created, the natural movements of the multiverse move to plug the hole before the Far Realm enters into the universe, corrupting and destroying everything it touches.

Because of these phenomenon, some scholars dissent from the "World-Axis" model of cosmology presented above and prefer what is known as the "Orrery" cosmology in which all the other planes of existence revolve through the Astral Sea around Eberron, which lies at the heart of this cosmic orrery. This model seemingly better explains the existence of manifest zones and wild

zones, but the experiences of planar explorers indicates that the World-Axis model seems to be a better representation of actual planar geography. However, in truth, both models are only imperfect representations of the multiverse's true nature, which remains both mysterious and unknowable to mortal minds.

Some sages and planar travelers also bring back stories of Sigil, the City of Doors, that inhabits its own demiplane outside of the normal cosmology. Sigil is a plane unto itself, existing outside the ordered structure of the rest of the multiverse and yet intricately connected to it through its unnumbered planar portals. It is a filthy, noisy city with smoke-choked alleyways and crowded streets. The city is built on the inside of a gigantic, hollow ring that has no outside. Sigil is the most cosmopolitan city in Creation, a place where devils and demons can rub shoulders peacefully with angels and efreeti as well as all the other known intelligent races. It is ruled by the enigmatic Lady of Pain, a being whose origin is unknown—though her rule is absolute and respected, by even the most powerful denizens of the planes. For many inhabitants of Eberron a visit to Sigil through one of the infinite number of portals across the world that connect to the City of Doors is the first step into the wider universe of the planes.

These planes teem with life, in some cases even mirroring the societies, kingdoms, and conflicts of Eberron itself. Many races are native to the planes, or can at least trace their ancestry to planar influences. While the planar origins of these races are unique to Eberron's singular cosmology, most other details remain unchanged from their presentation in other core D&D sources.

The Bariaur: Bariaurs are intelligent, centaur-like creatures with the horns and lower bodies of rams. They are native to the astral dominion of Lamannia, the Twilight Forest.

The Devas (Aasimars): Devas are angels or other planar beings dedicated to good who have been bound into eternally reincarnating human shells as part of the draconic Prophecy. The Church of the Silver Flame believes that devas are in fact the spirits of individual couatls who have broken off from the greater Silver Flame and allowed themselves to be reincarnated in human form to aid the eternal war against darkness. They generally live among human communities and are accepted as unusually beautiful and charismatic men and women. Devas are reincarnated over and over as they volunteered long ago to their creator Siberys at the dawn of Creation to play pivotal, if often minor roles in the Prophecy as the millennia passed. Most devas have no idea what this role might be in each of their incarnations, but sooner or later the course of events leads them to take on the role expected of them in the Prophecy. The term “celestial,” referring to a member of a species resident on the planes dedicated to the cause of good, has a somewhat looser definition in Eberron than it does in other campaign settings that have clearly identified celestial planes. In Eberron, creatures that can be

identified as celestials in the core D&D rules come from such widely varying planes, dominions and regions as Fernia (noble eladrins), Irian (angels), Risia (certain angels), Lamannia (guardinals and other archfey), Shavarath (angels), Syrania (angels), and Thelanis (noble eladrins). As such, devas often have traits and personalities that differ wildly from each other, based on the very specific particulars of their angelic ancestry or the plane that the angel originally called home before the incarnations began.

The Genasi: Elements frolic and fight in the Elemental Chaos. Mingling and clashing types of elemental energy take on aspects of each other—earth swirling like water or floating like air, fire falling like rain, or water frozen ice hard to create a vast plain are commonplace sights. This was the realm from which the genasi, a humanoid race who were the living embodiments of the elements, sprang. Genasi liked nothing better than to surf the elemental storms that roiled across the changeable expanse of the Chaos using magical *stormboards*, exulting in their unquenchable energy and the danger that attended traveling so near these maelstrom's unpredictable cores. Sometimes, during such hair-raising voyages, individual genasi moved closer to the wildly spinning eye of these storms than was wise. An elemental surge from these storms could throw unlucky genasi across the planes and through a tear in the fabric of reality to Eberron. The origin of the genasi race is currently unknown to scholars of Eberron because of their relative rarity, but some theorize that the race was born when members of the more common mortal races of Eberron came into contact with the raw elemental energies of the Chaos in a visceral way, accidentally replacing part of their normal substance with an elemental shell. A similar process may have created tieflings, though through the exposure of mortals to fiendish energies rather than elemental.

The Githyanki and Githzerai: Mind flayers from Xoriat created the githyanki and githzerai to serve as their slaves some nine thousand years ago (*circa* -8000 YK). Some say the mind flayers created each of these races fully formed, while others contend that the illithids twisted a group of either humans or hobgoblins kidnapped from Eberron into the gith. Still other scholars hold that the daelkyr, as the destroyers of worlds, invaded and destroyed another world in the multiverse parallel to Eberron and that the gith were the original intelligent inhabitants of that lost planet who were then handed over to their illithid lieutenants. The mind flayers bred the githyanki to be slave laborers and expendable soldiers, while the githzerai were destined to be personal servants and scribes for the mind flayers and their daelkyr overlords.

When the druidic Gatekeepers severed the world's connection to Xoriat, the gith took the opportunity to turn on their mind flayer masters, escaping their slavery *en masse*. The two gith races were part of different slave castes, however, and came into cultural and political conflict once they

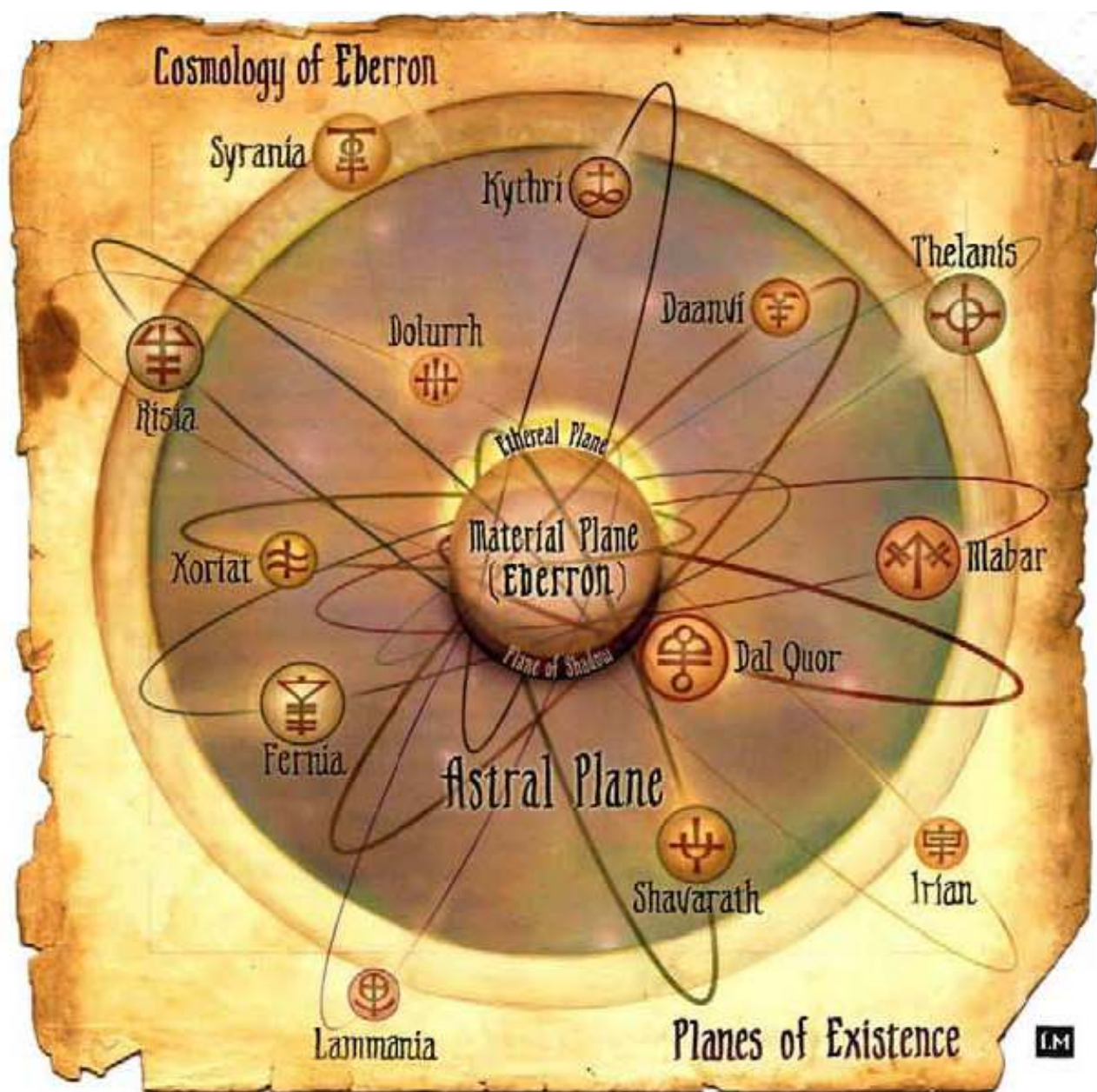
had won their freedom. The githyanki retreated to the Astral Sea, lured by its timeless qualities, while the githzerai fled to the Elemental Chaos—in particular, Kythri—to get as far away from the mind flayers as possible. A few githyanki and githzerai stayed on Eberron, though, forming small communities in widely scattered locations across the world.

The githyanki and githzerai are bitter rivals who are not above raiding each other's communities, but they remain united in their hatred of the mind flayers and anything else that hails from Xoriat. Even rival gith communities sometimes band together to enter Khyber and ensure that the magic seals imprisoning powerful remnants of the daelkyr interlopers from Xoriat remain strong. Other gith communities unite simply to kill as many mind flayers as they can. Unlike the githyanki described in the *Monster Manual*, the githyanki of Eberron have no special connection to red dragons.

The Shadar-kai: Shadar-kai are the descendants of humans who migrated to the Shadowfell millennia ago by accident or choice and were slowly altered by exposure to the plane's shadowy energy. A shadar-kai resembles a human but has gray skin and eyes that are lustrous black orbs, like a raven's. The shadows around a shadar-kai seem to deepen as he moves. A shadar-kai prefers loose dark garments, often with complex but subtle designs. Hair is worn long, sometimes loose, other times elaborately shaved, styled, and/or braided. A shadar-kai's skin always has patterns of tattoos and scarifications, as well as many piercings, which are used to combat the inherent emotionally-deadening environment of Dolurrh through the pain they produce. Shadar-kai prefer light, exotically-shaped weapons. Shadar-kai sometimes take up residence in Eberron, where they are often employed as thieves, assassins or spies by the Five Nations or other organizations because of their natural command over shadows.

The Tieflings: Like aasimar, tieflings live among human and other communities around the world. Descended from humans who interbred with fiends, they are particularly common in the city of Graywall (in Droaam) and Q'barra, as well as near the Demon Wastes, though they can be found across Khorvaire. Fiends in Eberron come from at least six different planes (Dolurrh, Fernia, Lamannia, Mabar, Risia, and Shavarath), so tieflings—like devas—display a wide range of appearance and character traits depending in part on the planar origin of their fiendish heritage. Scholars also believe that some tieflings may have been born to otherwise normal human couples who had the misfortune of conceiving their child near a manifest or wild zone between Eberron and one of the planes with a large fiendish population. The inherent energies of these planes, which give rise to the various fiends in the first place, may have crossed over and “infected” the child, which

lead it to take on fiendish traits after birth and become a tiefling. Tieflings, unlike devas, have become a separate race that breeds true.



The Orrery Model of the Cosmology of Eberron

The Major Religions of Eberron

Thir: The Faith of Dragons

Thir means “Three” in the Draconic tongue, referring both to the three Progenitors and the three ranks of divinity that dragons believe govern reality. The draconic faith acknowledges three divine forces: the Progenitors, the Dragon Gods, and the Sovereigns. The names of the Progenitors are known in almost every culture present on Eberron. Siberys, the Dragon Above, source of all magic and father of the dragons, Khyber, the Dragon Below, the mother of fiends and corruptor of dragons and Eberron, the world itself, mother of all that is natural. The dragons believe that the Progenitors spawned all Creation. All dragons respect the Progenitors as the wellspring of reality, but few worship them directly. Siberys is dead and Eberron and Khyber are simply primal forces too vast to hear the prayers of a single dragon. A dragon who reveres Eberron above all others becomes a druid, while one beholden to Khyber venerates in secret, away from the harsh Eyes of Chronopsis who serve as the guardians and law enforcers of the draconic race.

Most dragons direct their prayers to less remote deities who make up the Draconic pantheon—Io, Aasterinian, Astilabor, Bahamut, Chronopsis, Falazure, Garyx, Hlal, Lendys, Tamara, and Tiamat. Each of these deities is represented by a constellation in the night sky of Eberron, and with the exception of Tiamat, who is magically bound beneath Argonessen as one of the fiendish Overlords of Khyber, it is believed that the Dragon Gods watch the world from a realm that stands beyond the bounds of the cosmos...a place that cannot be reached by any mortal magic. According to Thir, the Dragon Gods influence the affairs of dragons, but they have no time for lesser creatures. Humans, dwarves, and elves would sully the Dragon Gods with their prayers.

Watching over lesser creatures is the role of the Sovereigns, who are identical to the fifteen deities worshipped as the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six by the humanoid peoples of the continent of Khorvaire. The dragons’ priests claim that dragons who embody primal concepts in life ascend to become Sovereigns in death. Instead of falling into Dolurrh, the Realm of the Dead, the spirit of an ascended dragon rises up, taking the place of one of the existing Sovereigns. The former Sovereign spirit then ascends farther, abandoning the cosmos and finding its final reward in the higher realm of the Dragon Gods. The common Thir doctrine holds that there can be only fifteen ascended Sovereign spirits at one time, but many rogue dragons have challenged this theory and sought to find their own

paths to divine ascension. It is an easy matter to map the legends of the ascended dragons to the existing human myths of the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six. A critical difference is that the dragons do not separate the two. Dulazurak (called the Mockery by humans) is the archetype of the dishonorable warrior, but to the dragons, that is still a Sovereign archetype and a valid path to immortality. The forces that the people of Khorvaire separate as the Nine and Six are a single divine host in the eyes of the dragons; good or evil, they are all the Sovereigns who watch over the lesser beings.

The central doctrine of Thir is simple enough. The Progenitors created the world, and the draconic Prophecy is the manifestation of their will and their plan for Creation; it shifts and twists about because Khyber and Eberron desire such different things. Eventually, the draconic Prophecy will run its course, and this creation will come to an end. A new set of Progenitors will be chosen from among the Dragon Gods and the most worthy of the ascended Sovereigns will in turn rise to become the Dragon Gods of the next creation. A new Prophecy will unfold, and the cycle of Creation will begin once more. Bear in mind that the faith of the dragons is just that. No absolute, objective proof supports their beliefs any more than those of any other religion of Eberron. Perhaps dragons can ascend after death; perhaps this is simply myth, and divinatory rituals just draw on the faith of the dragons to generate responses. Most humans find the dragons' view of the Sovereigns to be incredibly arrogant—the beings that other creatures see as gods are ascended dragons tasked with the tedious chore of caring for nondragons.

The Druids of Khorvaire

When one thinks of druids, the Eldeen Reaches immediately come to mind. Indeed, this wild land supports many druids of differing sects. But the druidic traditions of harmony with nature and, especially on Eberron, defense against immortals' corruption, are not confined to the Reaches. Any culture that is close to nature or the land like the Valenar elves or the halflings of the Talenta Plains is likely to develop druidic traditions tied to the primal power of the Dragon Between. Druids exist all across Khorvaire and the other continents have their share as well (though less is known about them).

In addition to the wild defenders like the Gatekeepers and the Wardens of the Wood most people think of when they think of druids, there also exist druid sects dedicated to the more destructive aspects of nature, like the Ashbound and the Children of Winter. Although their followers are grim and dangerous, such traditions are not usually truly evil. Other druids do follow a darker path, incomprehensible to most, that honor ancient horrors like the daelkyr and the fiends of the

Lords of Dust who seek to change the very face of Eberron. Certain druids do not distinguish between the world and any other. Far from being “outside” or “alien,” to them all the planes of existence are natural parts of the cosmos. Other druids, generally those of extraplanar origin, often from the Feywild of Thelanis, are dedicated to the primacy of their home planes over all else. Agents of these sects are drawn to manifest zones on Eberron where they try to strengthen the planar connection, or even try to create new manifest zones.

Druidic religious doctrines are simple and unadorned. They each have one overriding goal or approach which can be stated in a few words. Differences are for discussion by the circle, not scripture parsing or proclamations from superiors. Druid sects do not have holy symbols in the way that clerics of other faiths understand them; each adopts certain marks or objects that identify members to one another. Nor do they use prayer in the way more formal religions do; conversely, ritual forms a much greater part of religious life for the druidic sects’ followers.

Most druidic traditions place little emphasis on the fate of the soul. They are by definition concerned with the worldly; life itself is sacred because it was brought forth by Eberron, the Dragon Between who is the ultimate source of all druids’ primal power. Tacit in most druidic sects is the concept of reincarnation, a belief that life is actually a finite quantity that reappears in the world in a new physical form after the old one ends. Druids honor the spirits of creatures killed for food so that they will not seek revenge in the next life; they aim to disperse souls that were responsible for crimes against nature, to be reborn in scattered, mindless forms. Some sects, however, do have more developed theological ideas about the afterlife.

Druid sects in general do not interact with other types of religions, except those whose actions pose a direct threat to the natural order, like the Blood of Vol and its reverence for the undead. Druids believe that nonhostile faiths are artificial social constructions that are irrelevant unless a convert wishes to abandon them and follow the more natural path of druidism. Druids do not keep a calendar in the way of the more formal religions. The rhythms of sun and moon, the change of seasons—these are the natural accompaniment to life. Each sect observes these moments in their own way. Frivolous distinctions such as naming festivals and counting off days are not important to them.

The oldest druid tradition in all of Khorvaire, the Gatekeepers, hold true to their charge of vigilance against the horrors of the Dragon Below. Today, less than a hundred Gatekeepers work within the Reaches. These druids maintain old wards scattered around the region, seals that hold the daelkyr and other ancient powers in check. They also watch the skies for signs of deadly planar convergences. Most of the Gatekeepers in the Eldeen Reaches are orcs, though a few humans and half-orcs can be found within the sect. Members of the Gatekeepers, dedicated to protecting nature

from the unnatural, spend their lives fighting aberrations and guarding against extraplanar invasion and the release of ancient evils.

The Gatekeepers maintain the oldest druidic tradition on Khorvaire. Over fifteen thousand years ago, the black dragon Vvaraak came to the Shadow Marches and gathered orcish followers around her. She had foreseen a cataclysm that only the younger races would be able to avert, and so she taught the orcs how to work with earth and wood, and how to read the future in the movements of the Ring of Siberys. She charged her students to watch for the signs of the great disaster, and always seek to preserve the balance of nature against those forces that would corrupt it. It was over seven thousand years before the Gatekeepers faced the first real threat to Khorvaire that matched Vvaraak's warnings: the coming of the daelkyr. Leading armies of illithids, beholders, and other aberrations from a portal to the Far Realm of Xoriat, the Plane of Madness, these fiends sought to remake Khorvaire and all of Eberron into a hellish realm similar to their chaotic home plane. The war that followed shattered the hobgoblin empire of Dhakaan and left terrible scars across the continent, but Vvaraak's students ultimately prevailed—the gates to Xoriat were sealed, and the daelkyr who remained were driven into the depths of Khyber and forced to remain there by powerful druidic wards that drew on the primal strength of Eberron herself. But the question remained: Was this the catastrophe Vvaraak had predicted would befall the world, or a prelude to something even worse?

The Gatekeepers were crippled by the war against the daelkyr. The survivors retreated to the depths of the Shadow Marches and the Eldeen Reaches. Gatekeeper barbarians, wardens and rangers hunted down the surviving aberrations, while the druids watched the skies for signs of new dangers. Eventually, humans came to Khorvaire with the migrations from Sarlona that began with the pirate queen Lhazaar. The Gatekeepers shared their secrets with the newcomers, and some humans joined the ancient cause. Today, the Shadow Marches are a stronghold for the Gatekeepers; in the Eldeen Reaches, the Wardens of the Wood and the other sects inspired by the Great Druid Oalian outnumber the Gatekeepers.

The Gatekeepers have a loose structure. Aspirants grow into initiates, and initiates become gatekeepers. Otherwise, rank and respect comes with seniority and deeds. High-level druids guide the Gatekeepers, but they make up only a small part of the sect. For every gatekeeper, there are a handful of aspirants (mid-level druids) and initiates (low-level druids). For every initiate, there are three or four hunters (rangers or wardens). In the Shadow Marches, the sect's orc, human and half-orc barbarian hunters allow the primal fury of nature to guide their actions. In the Eldeen Reaches, human and shifter hunters carefully track the aberrant horrors that have been left behind by the

daelkyr. The Gatekeepers seek to defend nature against aberrations, immortals, undead, and other horrors that have no place in the natural order of Eberron. They remain ever vigilant, preparing for the war against darkness that may rise again. The Gatekeepers of the Eldeen Reaches have a friendly relationship with the Wardens of the Wood, the largest druidic sect in the region. In general, the Gatekeepers have little interest in the domestic politics and international affairs of the Five Nations.

The largest and most influential druid sect in the Eldeen Reaches, the Wardens of the Wood can be found across the nation, guarding both plain and forest. Their ranks have swelled over the last generation, as many a farmer's son or daughter has dedicated his or her life to the druidic mysteries. The Wardens maintain order across the Reaches, and all of the sects respect the power and wisdom of the Great Druid who commands them. Oalian, a massive greatpine approximately 210 feet high and more than four thousand years old, was touched by the spell of a long-dead Gatekeeper druid that awakened the great tree to sentience. Bound to the land and the great forest of the Eldeen Reaches, Oalian is the oldest and most powerful druid on Eberron. The Wardens maintain communities throughout the region, including Greenheart, Sylbaran, and Havenglen.

The great forest of the Eldeen Reaches is filled with a dozen druid sects. Each sect consists of druids, rangers, wardens, barbarians and others who feel a bond to the primal power of nature, and each has its own beliefs and motivations. The largest and most influential of the sects is the Wardens of the Wood. The Wardens are primarily Reacher humans, but include elves, half-elves, gnomes, rare eladrins and a few members of the other common races. The Wardens guard the Reaches' plains and forests, protecting nature and the people living there from all threats—natural and unnatural alike. The Great Druid Oalian, a self-aware greatpine tree, is recognized as the ultimate authority in the region by all the sects except for the Gatekeepers. The Wardens of the Wood directly serve Oalian and act as his eyes and ears throughout the region.

The Wardens of the Wood, like the Gatekeepers, maintain static communities throughout the Reaches where children are raised and taught. The Wardens of the Wood dominate the region. Over the last three decades they have spread out across the Reaches' eastern plains as well as continuing to occupy the great forest. The Wardens seek to maintain the balance between civilization and nature. Human, orc, bird, and beast all have a place in the world—they just need to be provided with the proper aid and guidance. The Wardens protect travelers from bandits, rabid beasts, and the aberrations that lurk in the shadows. They have no problem with agriculture and animal husbandry, as long as both land and beast are treated with respect and compassion. They work with farmers and ranchers to ensure that the needs of nature are met. The druid sects have little influence outside the

Eldeen Reaches. Within the great forest, there are friendly ties between the Wardens of the Wood and the Gatekeepers. The other sects respect the Great Druid, but generally come together only for important conclaves and rituals. Oalian has forbidden open conflict between the druid sects of the Reaches. However, individual druids and rangers often follow their own hearts when dealing with the actions of another, opposing sect. Wardens of the Wood often interfere with the Ashbound's raids, and the Children of Winter occasionally clash with members of all of the other sects. However, all personal vendettas are set aside while druids of any of the sects are in Greenheart, the Reaches' "capital" or in the presence of the Great Druid.

In addition to the Wardens of the Wood, a number of smaller sects—which can prove to be valuable allies or dangerous antagonists—also work within the region. These include the Ashbound, dangerous fanatics who roam the great forest, striking against the farmers of the plains and other forms of civilization—especially arcane magic—that they see as threats to the natural order; the Children of Winter, nihilists who embrace death as the most important part of the natural cycle of life and seek to hasten the coming of the "great cleansing" to the world; and the Greensingers, druids, wardens and rangers with close ties to the archfey of Thelanis, who can be found near the Twilight Demesne, a manifest zone between Eberron and the Feywild in the Reaches' western forest. The Greensingers have the strongest links with the eladrin of Thelanis.

Yet all of these druidic traditions represent the western coast of Khorvaire. There are other druidic traditions from the cultures that dominate the eastern end of the continent. Where the Valenar warrior seeks to channel the spirit of his ancestor through his heroic deeds, the Talentan druid believes that his ancestors are all around him, affecting every aspect of life. The druid serves as the intermediary between the material and spirit worlds and guides his people on the journey of life. The halflings believe that the dead are drawn to Dolurrh and must fight their way free to return to the world. A halfling possesses two tools to help him in this battle: his mount and his spirit mask. The spirit of a halfling's mount joins with him in Dolurrh, and it is their combined strength that gives them the chance to return. His mask holds his spirit or the spirit of his mount—whichever dies first—preserving it so that they may be together in the afterlife; many say that when a rider bonds with a new mount, the spirit of the old will flow from his mask to join with that of the living beast. Some whisper of rituals a warrior can use to trap the spirits of his fallen enemies in his mask and use their strength as his own, though most say that such dark magic will corrupt the caster and transform him into a demon after death.

One of the first duties of the halfling druids is to help his people craft their spirit masks, and as a result halfling druids are often called mask weavers. The druid serves many other crucial roles in

her community. He heals the sick and injured. He helps to find and train clawfeet, fastieths, and the other reptilian beasts that the nomadic tribes of the Talenta Plains rely on. He serves as a diplomat for the tribe, both when dealing with other tribes and with the spirits of nature. And he acts as a storyteller and record keeper, preserving the oral traditions of his people and passing them down to the next generation.

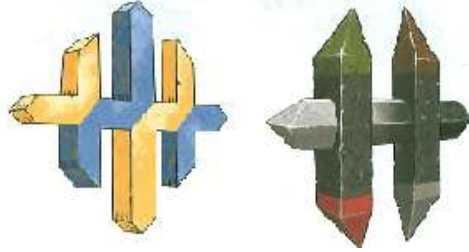
While mask weavers recognize one another as peers, their first loyalty is to the other members of their tribe. Even when a mask weaver dies without training a successor, a tribe will not turn to an outsider in search of aid; instead they will simply wait, confident that the spirits themselves will speak to one of the children of the tribe and teach him the secrets of the mask weavers. While it is rare for a mask weaver to leave his tribe, there are two ways it can happen. Occasionally a young druid is called forth by the spirits and ordered to go out into the world, in search of a hidden destiny that is far more important than his service to the tribe. The morbid alternative is when a tribe is destroyed. Even during feuds, enemy warriors will try to avoid harming a mask weaver, since many say this will bring bad luck to the slayer. As a result, a mask weaver may find himself the last surviving member of his tribe. Most of these orphans leave the Plains, searching for a new life in the wider world. Either of these could serve as background for an adventurer. The druidic path is not the only way to show reverence for the spirits. Talentan clerics usually worship the Sovereign Balinor, although halflings claim that Balinor was once a great hunter of the Talenta Plains.

There is one other druidic tradition of the east: the Horse Watchers of the Tairnadal elves, the Siyal Marrain, who are found in Valenar and Aerenal. The Tairnadal have tremendous respect for the power of nature. Many of the greatest heroes of the elves have been rangers, who combine martial skill with a bond to the natural world. During the elven uprising against the giants on Xen'drik, Tairnadal druids countered the magic of the giants with storm and thunder, and they bolstered the ranks of the elven army with the beasts of the wilds. A number of the druids joined the battle in animal form, and the greatest Tairnadal rangers rode into battle astride druids who used their shapechanging abilities to assume the forms of mighty stallions. In one of the most fearsome battles of the uprising, a giant wizard of the Sul'at League laid a terrible arcane curse on the opposing druids, forever binding them in animal form. The Tairnadal believe that the spirits of these champions of nature live on in their equine descendants, and they hold that these beings deserve the same respect as the other heroes of history. For a Tairnadal cavalry warrior, a horse is not simply a tool or a weapon: He is a brother striving toward the same destiny. The typical Tairnadal ranger who pursues the path of the beastmaster possesses a horse as his animal companion, and he believes that the improved abilities of the horse are a sign of the horse's ancestral guide.

The druids of the Valenar serve two roles. First and foremost, they are charged to preserve the bloodline of the elven horses. The druids protect the breeding grounds, tend to injured horses, and help raise the young. These blood guardians mingle with the herd using their shapechanging abilities, forging the bond between horse and elf from the earliest days. They also help to match elf and rider, working to forge the bond between rider and mount. Beyond this, the Siyal Marrain are warriors. Just as their ancestors fought the giants with lightning and flame, the druids of the modern day may ride with a warband, turning the primal power of nature against their enemies.

All druids, regardless of sect, have one thing in common: knowledge of the Druidic language, which druids receive as a bonus language upon taking their first level of the class. Why would an Eldeen Greensinger and a Talenta mask-weaver speak the same language, not to mention the hermit who has never encountered another druid? If the Gatekeepers were trained by a dragon, why do they know Druidic instead of Draconic? Druidic is not a normal language. One does not learn Druidic in the same way that Elven can be studied, and even if a person knows the language it cannot be taught to someone else the way another skill would be taught. As an initiate masters their first level of druid, he learns many primal mysteries. He learns how to speak with animals, how to calm them, and how to hide from them. He unlocks the secrets of fire. He learns to mend flesh with a touch, and how to ask the plants to entangle and trap his enemies. These are just a few of a druid's secrets, and the Druidic tongue is another. Many druids believe that it is the first language—the primal language of Eberron herself. Some claim to have found Druidic inscriptions carved in the sides of mountains or written in the drifting clouds—if true, Druidic could be some form of the more well-known mystic language of Supernal. Since only druids can even learn Druidic, speaking this language is a way to identify oneself to other druids. When you are about to be boiled alive by kobolds, an appeal to the kobold druid spoken in Druidic could save your life. However, not all druids are allies. A peaceful hermit may despise the violent actions of the Ashbound or the doom-driven work of the Children of Winter. Speaking in Druidic might establish a basic bond, but will do little to reconcile fundamentally opposed ideologies about how civilization should interact with nature.

The Sovereign Host and the Dark Six



As a faith the Sovereign Host began in the ancient kingdom of Sarlona known as Pyrine. Worship of the Sovereign Host takes many forms in different cultures, but the religion as practiced by most of the humans of Khorvair can be traced back to the kingdom of Pyrine. The Pyrineans placed great value on wisdom and philosophy and Pyrinean tutors and priests served in royal courts across Sarlona. Arguably the greatest of Eberron's major religions, the pantheon of the Sovereign Host claims the hearts and minds of an enormous proportion of Khorvair's population in the present day, and even in the face of newer faiths, it continues to grow. The Sovereign Host encompasses nine gods—or fifteen, depending on one's point of view—who hold sway over every aspect of mortal life. These gods are identical to the Sovereigns venerated by the draconic faith of Thir and may indicate that the dragons taught some aspects of their faith to the humans of Pyrine many millennia ago.

Where the Silver Flame requires that its worshipers be devoted to a specific principle and the Blood of Vol demands loyalty to the blood within, the Sovereign Host simply *is*. Where mortal matters intersect the natural world, the gods are there. Worshipers need not seek out the gods of the Sovereign Host, for they are present in every aspect of life and in every feature of Eberron. The chief belief espoused by the followers of the Host or "Vassals" as they call themselves, has been named the Doctrine of Universal Sovereignty. *As is the world, so are the gods. As are the gods, so is the world.* Essentially, this means that nothing exists in the world outside of the attention of the gods. While the gods are divine beings unto themselves, they are also a part of a larger reality. They do not simply oversee the aspects of reality over which they hold dominion; they are part of them, omnipresent. A blacksmith praying for Onatar's blessing on a new undertaking is not seeking the attention of the god of the forge. The god is already there, present in every act of manual creation, every spark of flame, every ring of the smith's hammer. The smith prays to show his faith, to honor and acknowledge the god's presence so that Onatar might bestow his favor on the smith's work and enhance its quality. As with Onatar and the smith, so to with the other deities. Dol Dorn is active in every battle; Arawai's voice is heard in the rustle of every stalk of wheat grown by human hands. This is what Vassals mean

by the Doctrine of Universal Sovereignty: the gods do not just preside over reality; they are present in every part of it.

This belief perfectly illustrated the nature of the gods in the world of Eberron. They and their avatars do not walk the world or speak directly with their faithful. Aid or knowledge is always provided by an angel or other exarch who represents the power of the divine and even these beings are guided by nothing more than faith, for an angel who speaks for Aureon has no more been in his direct presence than any mortal has. The very power of faith causes divine magic to manifest, though whether this faith is rewarded by the gods or is just an end in itself cannot be truly known by mortals. But Vassals believe that every plant that grows, every ruler that rises to power, every sword raised in battle, every beast in the herd and every healer's touch are signs that the gods are working their divine will on the world by using the tools of the world itself. Worship of the Host has grown alongside human civilization and the two are linked—for the gods' portfolios lean toward the elements of civilized life rather than more savage aspects. Law, hearth, artifice, honor: these are mortal constructs, not intrinsic elements of the natural world. Only Arawai and Balinor claim portfolios of a more natural bent and even these—agriculture and the hunt, respectively—are elements of civilized behavior. It is a measure of the Host's civilizing bias that the banished members of the Host's pantheon bear an opposed aspect. Most of the members of the Dark Six represent forces of nature rather than civilized concepts.

This bedrock ideal of the gods as both separate from the world and also a part of it leads to the Doctrine of the Divine Hosts which states: *The Sovereign Host is one in name and speaks with one voice. The gods are the letters of that name and the sounds of that voice.* The majority of Vassals worship the Host pantheon in its entirety, calling upon whichever of the deities is most appropriate to their current circumstances. The faithful feel that to ignore any one of the gods would be foolish, though most Vassals do not revere all the gods equally. Many choose a patron god or two to whom they feel a special bond. A blacksmith may revere Dol Arrah and Kol Korran but has a special place in his heart for Onatar. Similarly, priests of the Sovereign Host revere all the deities, but also devote themselves to a special patron.

Everyone familiar with the scriptures of the Sovereign Host knows that these gods once formed a single pantheon with the other group of deities known as the Dark Six that was called the Nine and the Six and the One. The Host banished the Six for their evil ways and constant scheming against the other gods and mortals. This sundering of the Host is called the Schism, the Divine Fall or the Celestial Exile. Some theologians hold that the rape of Arawai by the Devourer triggered the Schism, but other legends suggest this event took place long after the rift. Vassal theologians debate

what the Schism actually means. After all, the Dark Six still hold divine sway over many aspects of the world and the faithful still pray to them under some circumstances even if only to ward off their attention. The Schism then is more like a family dispute with one branch of the family disowning the other. It represents the efforts of the Host to distance themselves and their worshipers from their darker counterparts. The most ancient texts of the faith, many from Pyrine itself, refer to the pantheon as the Nine and Six and One. So even before the official Schism, the two divine groups were at least somewhat independent of one another.

For centuries orthodoxy has held that this division is based on one of morality—good against evil. But some scholars hold that the “Nine and Six” do not refer to the current ethical division of the Host and the Dark Six but rather to nine gods of civilization and six gods of the savage world. These theorists hold that the Schism was not the result of good defeating evil but rather the gods of civilization defeating those of savagery in shaping the future lives of mortals. Most Vassals believe that the gods came into being as conscious manifestations of the energies of creation that the Progenitor wyrm Eberron released when she created the world. However, almost all human cultures have depicted the Sovereigns at one point or another as dragons and so some Vassals believe that the Sovereigns were the children of Siberys and Eberron—they were mortal dragons who ascended to divinity after the defeat of Khyber’s fiendish Overlords. As this is also what the dragons believe, and there is known to be a family connection between the gods, there may be some truth to this particular take on Sovereign Host theology.

According to Vassal belief, just as the gods are present in all aspects of the world, they are present in all living things. The soul is a tiny fragment of the divine, the animating spark that allows life to exist. Unfortunately, as the years of mortality pass, the individual loses what makes it divine, preventing the soul from returning to the gods or even remaining on Eberron. The afterlife in Dolurrh is not meant to be a place of punishment; it is a realm devoid of divinity, the one place where the Sovereign Host holds no sway. Why worship then, if the gods offer no alternative to the gray emptiness of the Shadowfell? Simply put, Vassals believe in honoring and thanking the gods for the life they have, for an existence on Eberron—however short—that can be made better. By honoring the Host, mortals hope to live a happy life, even if their afterlife will prove otherwise. Of course, some Vassals cling to a faint hope inspired by a few ancient scriptures which hold that one day the Sovereign Host will extend its power into Dolurrh and the afterlife will become a place of divine light rather than dark emptiness.

The symbol of the Sovereign Host is the Octogram or Celestial Crown, an eight-pointed emblem done in deep blue and gold that also can be represented as different two-color combinations

that represent the individual gods of the Host. Many scholars believe that the Octogram represents all of the original sixteen deities of the pantheon—eight points, two separate colors, all bound together as one—“the Nine and the Six and the One” of the ancient Pyrinean scriptures.

The priesthood of the Sovereign Host makes no overt attempts to control governments, but they are not without political influence on Khorvaire. At least three of the four remaining Five Nations (Aundair, Breland and Karrnath) are Host-dominant, leaving little doubt that their monarchs worship the Sovereign Host. Thus, even if the priesthood does not try to alter a ruler’s decisions, a monarch’s actions are unlikely to threaten the dominance of the faith. On a local level, the influence of the Host’s priesthood is far more overt. Mayors, town councils, provincial governors, barons and even dukes might well belong to a congregation of Vassals and see the high priest as an authority figure. Most of the major nobles of the Five Nations have a religious adviser from the Host’s clergy on staff to aid them in matters of faith and history. In many smaller communities, religious leaders are secular leaders as well. It is rare, but in some settlements the priesthood of the Sovereign Host works in opposition to the secular government. This situation develops most often in Thrane, where a small minority of Thranes worship the Host in the midst of a theocracy ruled by the Church of the Silver Flame. Vassals are sometimes persecuted in these areas, not necessarily by violence but through the application of social pressures like price-gouging and poor service. In some nations, worship of the Host—or certain members of its pantheon—is actively restricted. The “monster” races of Droaam, most of whom revere members of the Dark Six, do not hate the Host with the same passion they reserve for the Silver Flame, but they do react with hostility to overt displays of the faith within the small human and shifter populations in that nation. Although the goblins of Darguun have recently been introduced to the Host by missionaries following the Last War, the faith is taking hold very slowly. Some Darguul communities revere Balinor, Dol Arrah and Dol Dorn but are still suspicious of the rest: others still worship the Shadow or the Mockery exclusively. In such areas, overt worship of the Host’s “inappropriate” members might result in violent persecution, imprisonment or even execution.

However, in terms of overall influence, the Sovereign Host has little to fear from other faiths. Even with the growth of the Silver Flame and the Schism that ejected the Dark Six from the Host, Vassals still make up the majority of the civilized population of Khorvaire. The faith has even spread, slowly but surely, to the goblins of Darguun and the rural communities of the druidic Eldeen Reaches. It maintains dominance through a peaceful and simple process of integrating other faiths into itself by claiming other gods and religious practices are simply extensions of the Host by other names. Even members of the other major religions, such as the Church of the Silver Flame, have been

swayed by this argument. After all, the Silver Flame does not claim to be the world’s creator or even as old as Creation itself. Therefore, it cannot be the only god, even if it is most worthy of human worship. A small but notable percentage of followers of the Silver Flame, the Blood of Vol and other religions worship the Sovereign Host in addition to their main patron, seeing the Host as simply a part of the former.

Each of the members of the Nine are also sometimes portrayed as powerful dragons—Aureon as a majestic blue dragon, Arawai as a adamantine dragon protecting a clutch of eggs, Balinor as a stalking green dragon, Boldrei as a copper dragon, Dol Arrah as a red dragon perched on a cloud, Dol Dorn as a silver dragon, Kol Korran as a white dragon lying on a bed of ice-blue gemstones, Olladra as a black dragon and Onatar as a steel dragon.

The Sovereign Host

Deity	Alignment	Portfolio	Symbol
Arawai	Good	Agriculture, fertility, nature	bronze and green Octogram; sheaf of wheat
Aureon	Unaligned	Law, knowledge, arcane magic	black and white Octogram; open tome
Balinor	Unaligned	Animals, the hunt	brown and red Octogram; silhouetted antlers
Boldrei	Lawful Good	Hearth, community, government	orange and gray Octogram; fire in a stone hearth
Dol Arrah	Lawful Good	Honor, sacrifice, the sun, light	yellow-gold and white Octogram; rising sun
Dol Dorn	Good	Just war, competition	red and silver Octogram; longsword on a shield
Kol Korran	Unaligned	Wealth, commerce, trade, thievery	gold and silver Octogram; gold coin
Olladra	Good	Good fortune, plenty	white and dark gray Octogram; domino
Onatar	Good	Crafts, fire, tools, innovation	red and orange Octogram; crossed smith tools
The Dark Six			
The Devourer	Evil	Storms, water, devastation	Bundle of 5 sharpened bones
The Fury	Evil	Anger, insanity, revenge	Red and black winged wyvern with woman’s upper body and head
The Keeper	Evil	Death, greed, hunger, time	Khyber dragonshard shaped like a fang
The Mockery	Evil	Unjust war, murder, treachery	5-blood-spattered tools in the shape of the Octogram
The Shadow	Chaotic Evil	Arcane magic, darkness, corruption	Block of obsidian in shape of a tower
The Traveler	Unaligned	Chaos, deception, change	Eight-pointed configuration of 4 crossed and rune-inscribed bones

Before the Schism, most of the gods of the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six were related to each other as family members. Arawai is the sister of Balinor and the Devourer and the mother of the Fury. Aureon is the brother of Onatar and the husband of Boldrei, as well as the “brother” of the Shadow (see below). Four of the Dark Six also had names, rather than their more fearsome titles. The Devourer, before being exiled by his brother Balinor and his sister Arawai for his rape of the latter, was known as Shurkaan. The Devourer’s daughter with Arawai as a result of this forced union was named Szorawai and she eventually became the Fury. The Keeper, the twin brother of Kol Korran and the son of Olladra and Onatar, was called Kol Tarrant long ago. The Mockery had once

been known as Dol Azur, brother to Dol Dorn and Dol Arrah before he betrayed his siblings and was flayed and exiled for his crime. If the goddess Dol Arrah represented the light of the mortal soul, the Shadow was her opposite, representing the darkness hidden within every individual. The Shadow was the literal shadow of Aureon and Host theology holds that it gained both intelligence and divinity as the price Aureon paid for his mastery of arcane magic. The Traveler was the most mysterious member of the Nine-and-Six, for it was neither child nor parent to any member of the total pantheon, nor was it inclined towards evil like its fellow divine exiles. Instead the Traveler represented change, which could be both bad or good depending on the circumstances.

Perhaps the biggest difference between Vassals of the Host versus Vassals of the Dark Six was that those who followed the Dark Gods believed that Dolurrah was not the inevitable fate and final home of a soul upon death, but a fate that could be avoided if the gods willed it. Thus, for a Vassal of the Six, the Realm of the Dead was truly a place of punishment that could be avoided or endured only temporarily before a soul found its rightful afterlife.

The collective symbol of the Dark Six was known as the Hexagram, which is a six-pointed symbol made of black iron with a different color on each tip. The dark green of the top left bar represents the Devourer, with the crimson on the bottom of the same bar representing his daughter, the Fury. The brown of the top right bar denotes the Mockery, and the gray of the bottom, the Keeper. Perhaps the most curious feature of the symbol then was the horizontal bar that separated these features. The black and white of this bar corresponded to the Shadow and the Traveler, respectively, since both gods can be viewed more as cosmic forces rather than individuals like their counterparts and are less related to the Nine-and-Six as a whole. Some legends even hold that it was the Traveler who was responsible for the Shadow's divinity because the Shadow's creation was the price the Traveler demanded from Aureon so that the Sovereign of Law and Lore could master arcane magic.

There are several variants of the faith of the Sovereign Host which are worth mentioning. They are not true schisms from the basic theology of the religion but are more like popular movements that have chosen to emphasize more strongly certain specific portions of the faith's tenets.

Karrn the Conqueror was a legendary, if ruthless, hero. A thousand years before the rise of the Kingdom of Galifar, Karrn came a hairsbreadth from establishing a Karrnathi dominion across Khorvaire. He was never defeated on the battlefield; it took the treachery of a trusted friend to bring down the Conqueror at the end of his days when he was assassinated. Even though Karrn died with his dreams unrealized, his actions and teachings left a mark on Khorvaire that can be seen to this day. He was a soldier first and foremost, but Karrn was also a spiritual man; he was one of the founders of

the Three Faces of War, a religious sect devoted to the wise Dol Arrah, the brave Dol Dorn, and the cunning Dol Azur, known as the Mockery.

Karrn the Conqueror is long dead, but his *Analects of War* is still studied behind the walls of the proud Rekkenmark Academy in Karnath and the fledgling war colleges of the other nations. In the shadows of these institutions, the Three Faces of War watch and guide the generals of the next age. Adept and initiates of the Three can be found in almost every army, with the notable exception of Thrane.

The Three Faces of War is a soldier's faith. Its shrines are the battlefield and the rampart wall, and its blessings are blood and steel. Faith in the Three will not stop enemies from fighting; these are the Sovereigns of War, after all. But when two soldiers negotiate or meet in times of peace, the mysteries of the Three can provide a bridge and a bond between them.

Xen'drik is a hard land, and in the early days of the city of Stormreach—before the Stormreach Compact and the arrival of representatives from House Jorasco—divine magic often meant the difference between life and death. Luckily for the sailors who followed the faith, priests of the Sovereign Host were on hand to help them . . . for a share of their ill-gotten gains. When the city was founded, a temple to the Sovereigns was established in the district of Forgelight, a location chosen for its security and its proximity to the fighting folk of Stormreach. This temple is easily identified by the Octogram symbol placed above its gate. The icons within the temple depict the gods in draconic form, using the shapes described above.

Mosaics in this Stormreach temple depict images of these divine dragons in battle with fiends. Even though the priests of the temple worship the Sovereigns, their faith is slightly different from the common tradition of the Five Nations; they follow a path known as the Church of the Wyrms Ascendant. According to this doctrine, the dragons are the children of Eberron and Siberys. Once they defeated the children of Khyber in the Age of Demons, the greatest among them were blessed by Eberron and Siberys and drawn up to the heavens to watch over all mortal creatures, a doctrine remarkably similar to the dragons' own religious beliefs.

The priests of the Wyrms Ascendant are fascinated by dragons and seek to acquire artifacts and relics—magical and otherwise—related to dragons. One of the ways in which church doctrine differs from the faith of the Five Nations concerns the afterlife. The priests of the Wyrms believe that those who serve the Sovereigns and build a hoard can literally buy their way into the heavens, joining the Sovereigns on a transcendent plane beyond the known cosmology as heavenly dragons. In practice, there is little difference between the rituals of the Wyrms Ascendant and the common faith of the Sovereigns. The priests invoke the Sovereigns by their traditional names, and while they speak of

ascension and depict their gods as dragons, little about the faith is truly alarming; a warrior who has scant knowledge of religion could sit through a service and not realize that anything was amiss. One obvious difference, however, is the greed of the priests. Graft and avarice are accepted values of the Wyrms Ascendant, since every dragon must have his hoard. Provided that they share their gains with the church coffers, it is taken for granted that priests capable of casting divine magic perform their miracles in exchange for gold or treasures, which is not common on the mainland of Khorvaire.

Worship of the Sovereign Host (and the Dark Six) predates the founding of the Kingdom of Galifar and even the human settlement of Khorvaire. As a result, Vassals of both pantheons use the standard Galifar Calendar in day-to-day life but they measure days of religious significance by the far older Sovereign Book of Seasons which dates back to humanity's early days on Sarlona. The original Vassals of Pyrine divided the year into three seasons instead of four. Yearbirth, the first season, was devoted to planting crops and was associated by some with the Progenitor wyrm Siberys. Yeargrowth, the second season was devoted to the raising and reaping of crops and was associated with Eberron. Finally, Yeardeath was the period when the world was cold and few things grew; its association was with Khyber. Each season was divided into seven "weeks" (the original term is lost) of sixteen days each. The Sovereign Book of Seasons does not recognize the concept of months, and treats the phases of the moons as separate from the timekeeping of the world itself. Each day of the week was devoted to one of the fifteen gods of the original Sovereign Host, with an additional day at the end of the week devoted to the pantheon as a whole. In the present time, the names of the days formerly devoted to the Dark Six now commemorate no deity at all. They have been renamed after the Five Kingdoms and Galifar itself, to show solidarity between the Host and the secular sovereigns of humanity. The new year on the Sovereign liturgical calendar corresponds to the first day of the month of Therendor on the Galifar Calendar. The weeks do not carry any names of their own. To indicate a specific day, someone using the Sovereign Book of Seasons adds a numeric value to the day in question. For instance saying "Yearbirth Thranday the fourth" or "fourth Thranday of Yearbirth" indicates Thranday of the fourth week of Yearbirth. A full listing of the days of the week in the Sovereign Book of Seasons can be found in *Faiths of Eberron*, p. 21.

The Church of the Silver Flame



Of all the varied faiths of Eberron, the Church of the Silver Flame stands apart. The Purified, as followers of the faith call themselves, worship a divine entity of nonmortal origin that was first created at the end of the Age of Demons when the majority of the couatl race, the feathered serpents of Sarlona, sacrificed themselves to bind the fiendish Overlords in the depths of Khyber. The couatl's essence merged to become a source of pure celestial energy very similar in form to the spirit of the Progenitor wyrm Siberys, the Dragon Above. Still, the Purified's god claims no dominion over the world, nor that it has existed since the Progenitors first crafted Creation, unlike the followers of the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six. The Silver Flame is a divine power with a purpose and only those who profess equally lofty principles are called to serve it.

The Purified are bound together by numerous rites and traditions, but by only a single religious doctrine, called the Tenet of Purity: *Burn the corruption and taint of evil from all Eberron. Other gods began the Creation, but it is the Silver Flame, by searing wickedness and darkness from their imperfect world, that must complete it.* This belief that the world can only be made perfect by the Silver Flame and its followers embodies the height of arrogance in the eyes of followers of other religions, but it is absolutely central to the faith of the Purified. They acknowledge the existence and divinity of other gods, such as the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six and of the three great Progenitor dragons. The Purified even honor them, as they know that the Host is worthy of respect. After all, the Silver Flame has never claimed to be a creator deity, and it has not even existed as long as Eberron itself. Even so, the Purified believe that although the Silver Flame was not the first divine force to appear on Eberron, it will be the last. So long as evil exists, the world remains flawed and cannot become whole. By ridding the world of all evil, the Silver Flame will transform Eberron into a paradise without sin or pain. Then the other gods will fade, leaving the Silver Flame to hold dominion over all of Creation. For many millennia since the end of the Age of Demons, the Silver Flame existed but could not communicate with mortals until Tira Miron joined with the Flame.

The Purified believe in a hierarchy of evil. All wickedness must eventually be purged from Eberron, but some is of more immediate import and is more heavily damaging to the world itself,

than other sources of wickedness. It is not that the Church feels any form of evil is acceptable or less important, it is simply about priorities. Entities of alien evil, like fiends and many aberrations, are creatures of innate malevolence and so cause the most harm to the spiritual and physical health of the world. Entities like undead and lycanthropes, though native to Eberron, have been corrupted into hideous things that must be destroyed to prevent their taint from afflicting the world. Creatures of evil mien that are usually malevolent, like medusas, yuan-ti and hags, are also to be opposed, even though they are natural creatures. Purely human or mortal evil should be fought with compassion, diplomacy and leading by example. Whenever possible, people should be shown that there is a better way to live their lives. If this is not possible, the sword might be the only answer, but it should not be the first choice. Finally, the Purified are expected to deal with the evil that always lurks within their own souls. Mortals must purge the very desire for sin from their hearts, a feat that only can be accomplished with the aid and support of the Flame.

The Church not only prioritizes the evil that must be fought, it also recognized that sometimes a lesser evil can be used to fight a greater one. Sometimes, good people might be forced to commit questionable acts in the battle against darkness. The Silver Flame does not encourage such decisions, nor does the Church always approve extreme measures, but sometimes no other choice exists.

The Purified maintain that the soul is a form of divine energy, but that it does not originate from the Silver Flame or any god. Rather, it coalesces from the life-giving energies of Eberron herself. Each person that is born adds a spark of divine power to the world. Those who are faithful to the Silver Flame can spiritually join with it after death, much like the original couatls, their own souls adding the tiniest bit of power to its own near-infinite energy. Others are condemned to Dolurrh after death, where their souls' divinity is extinguished, condemning them to an endless existence as passionless minds with no true spirit, forever wandering the gloom of the Shadowfell. Only the Silver Flame can offer an alternative to Dolurrh and that is proof to the Purified that the Flame will eventually become the only true divine force to reign over Eberron. When that day comes, the mirror world of Dolurrh will cease to exist, for it will no longer serve any purpose.

The Purified had a simple attitude toward the other religions of Eberron: They are all wrong. This does not mean that Purified are hostile towards believers of other faiths. The Purified have an abiding respect for the Sovereign Host and the Progenitors, who created the world the Flame will one day complete. They feel, however, that worshippers of the Host are clinging to old and outmoded ways and that they are unwittingly delaying the coming of paradise. Thus, the Purified proselytize the Vassals of the Host at every opportunity. Followers of the Flame approach the druidic sects in much the same way, acknowledging the druids' role in protecting Eberron from great evils, but believing

that the Church can do a better job, especially if the druids join them. But where the Silver Flame is not trying to convert the other faiths, it is trying to destroy them. The Dark Six, the Dragon Below and the Lords of Dust are all the darkest evils in the eyes of the Purified. Individual members of those faiths might still be saved and brought into the light, but they are few. Templars do not walk down city streets beheading anyone who utters a prayer to the Six, but in regions where the Church has temporal power, such faiths are vigorously stamped out.

The Silver Flame boasts a number of variant sects within the Church. Some are simple theological factions within the hierarchy while others are considered heresies by the orthodox faithful, subject to ostracism or even open conflict. The *Ghaash'kala*, Orcish for “Ghost Guardians,” is a tribe of orcs that believes it has a divine duty to prevent evil from escaping the Demon Wastes of Khorvaire into the world. The tribesmen worship a great spirit called the *Kalak Shash* or “Binding Flame” that gathers the souls of their departed and keeps darkness and evil at bay. Some Purified refuse to accept this as an embodiment of the Silver Flame, unwilling to share a faith with barbaric orcs. Most priests, however, do acknowledge that the Ghaash'kala worship the Flame, though a skewed version of the divine force. The Flame has sent several missionary expeditions to the Demon Wastes to bring the orcs into the fold, but they have had little success, largely because of extremists among the Servants of the Pure Flame faction who would rather see this heretical worship wiped out than accepted.

The Knights Militant are a rigid order of templars who maintain extreme standards of purity and morality, although they tend to emphasize heroic sacrifice in battle rather than imposition of their ways on others. The Order of the Radiant Flame is a monastic order that seeks spiritual union with the Flame in life, instead of after perishing in the battle with evil. They are content to ponder the mysteries of Creation in their monasteries. The Penitent Brethren is a subsect of the Purified that consists almost entirely of shifters who believe that they have been tainted through their biological links with true lycanthropes. They join the Silver Flame in an effort to atone for their in-born sins. The Servants of the Pure Flame, also called the Puritans, are true religious fanatics and extremists. They follow every tenet of the Church to the letter, seek the destruction of every force even remotely opposed to the Flame and have no compunction—unlike the majority of Purified—about forced conversions. The Puritans are the most likely to resort to violence to achieve a “good” goal and they have substantial power and influence in the Church hierarchy, all the way up to the Diet of Cardinals. The Puritans are based primarily among the Church’s hierarchy in Aundair’s major cities, where it has been strongest since the Silver Purge (see below).

The Tarnished is the name the Purified apply to any among them who devote themselves to the cause of the fiendish Overlord trapped within the Silver Flame beneath Flamekeep, who is known as the Shadow in the Flame. While the faithful refuse to believe it, a number of individuals claim that a so-called Voice in the Darkness occasionally whispers to the faithful. Sometimes it tricks devout followers into believing it is the Voice of the Flame herself, or it works with the greed or corruption inherent in a person, offering power or even immortality in exchange for service. The Shadow in the Flame is a potent rakshasa Overlord, and while it lacks the power of a true god, it was a world-spanning force during the Age of Demons. The Tarnished believe that it remains strong enough to follow through on its promises. The greatest of the Tarnished was Melysse Miron, a descendant of Tira Miron herself. Melysse Miron is remembered in history as the so-called Anti-Keeper of the Flame, who challenged the sitting Keeper, Kyra Danth, for the position in 497 YK. Melysse presented herself as a reformer of the Church, claiming that the institution had lost its way. Only after gaining a substantial following that threatened to rip the Church asunder was she revealed to actually be a servant of darkness. She was captured after a brief but bloody struggle with the Church's templars and the Sentinel Marshals and sentenced to an eternity of slumber in the Galifaran prison complex of Dreadhold. No agent so powerful has pledged service to the fiend since, perhaps because what little of its power is not trapped within Khyber is still present with Melysse Miron's sleeping form. Still, those who claim to hear the Shadow in the Flame's voice and bear its powers cut a swath of corruption through the Church's ranks.

The Church also has a small splinter sect on Xen'drik, though this schism is a wholly political rather than theological breach. The priests of the Silver Flame have always sought to spread their faith, and when word reached Thrane of the new city of Stormreach taking shape across the Thunder Sea around 860 YK, the cardinals were quick to send ministers and templars to the shattered land. A wave of Thrane immigrants helped establish the Keep of the Silver Flame now found in that city's Temple District. Keeper of the Flame Tzandra Corus had a vision of a ministry that would bring the Flame to the drow and the giants and a bastion that would hold back any darkness that might threaten the city.

Reality fell far short of the dream. Stormreach was founded by pirates and smugglers, and the priests of the Silver Flame received a cold welcome as they built their Keep of the Silver Flame. Missionaries sent to spread the word to the dark elves rarely returned, and by the time King Thalín of Thrane died, only a single minister and a handful of acolytes were left at the keep. This proved to be another turning point for the Silver Flame in Stormreach. After long debate, they rejected the then-Keeper of the Flame's decision to assume theocratic control of Thrane. Both Church and Crown had

roles to play in human society, the priests explained, and it was a mistake for one to supplant the other; it would only lead the Church away from its true purpose.

The Council of Cardinals was infuriated by this rebellion, but with the Last War in full swing, the Thranes could not afford to send new forces to such a distant post. Instead, the city's Church hierarchy was formally severed from Flamekeep. To this day, the Keep of the Silver Flame in Stormreach receives no support from Thrane, and the faithful are warned to beware the words of these heretic priests. Now that the war is over, some believe that Flamekeep should reclaim the Keep for orthodoxy. However, the people of Stormreach's Thrane-majority neighborhood of Embers stand behind their minister, and Keeper Jaela Daran is more willing to accept theological diversity than her predecessors had been; for the moment, Stormreach has been left on its own.

But one order of the Church stands out in the minds of the Purified and nonbelievers alike. Its members have been known at various times as the Ardent Seekers of the Illuminated World, the Knights Inquisitive, the Office of the Hallowed Confessors and—most infamously—the Inquisition. The Inquisition has been both a knightly order and a monastic one, but in the present era are simply an informal gathering of Church operatives who report directly to the Diet of Cardinals. Whatever their shape, their purpose is to root out the enemies of righteousness and to cleanse the world of them by all appropriate means. The definition of “appropriate” seems to change from era to era and inquisitor to inquisitor. Most would never stoop to outright acts of evil but some believe strongly that the ends justify the means. Some even resort to torture or to burning innocents to cleanse a village of a single evil. Unfortunately, the actions of these few have heavily tainted the reputation of the Inquisition, so that other people see all inquisitors as representing the worst stereotypical aspects of the Church. The Inquisition answers to a single cardinal on the Diet, referred to as the Grand Confessor, whose identity is known only to the Keeper of the Flame and a few elder cardinals. Even other inquisitors see their leader but rarely; they normally receive directives through channels and intermediaries. In his rare personal appearances, the Grand Confessor is masked and cloaked in magical protections against detection. Such extreme secrecy keeps the Grand Confessor free from outside influences.

The Church of the Silver Flame did not come into being until after the formation of the Kingdom of Galifar. Thus, the Church uses the standard Galifar Calendar as their liturgical calendar.

The Blood of Vol



Few religions on Eberron are as misunderstood as the spiritual path known as the Blood of Vol. Seekers, as followers of the faith call themselves, do not worship a divine entity, nor do they revere their ancestors, as do the elves of Aerenal. It would be difficult to classify the Blood of Vol as a religion at all were it not for the fact that its adherents do believe in a divinity—albeit a most unusual one.

If any single doctrine unites the Blood of Vol, it is the concept of the Divinity Within. This notion is embodied in one of the Seekers' most treasured axioms, spoken at the opening of almost every ritual gathering—*“Look not to the skies, nor to the depths below, nor even to the distant past or future. Seek the divine within, for the blood is the life and in its call can be heard the promise of eternal life. One has but to listen.”* This chant illustrates how the faith stands apart from more traditional religions. Seekers believe in no divinity but that which courses through their own veins and refuse to acknowledge the existence of any “god” on principle alone. To them, followers of the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six are living deluded lives that will ultimately end in death and despair. Seeker philosophy does not exclude the existence of the three Progenitor wyrms but views them more as spiritual concepts than as actual beings. Worshipers believe in the power of things seen and grasped, as a dragonshard can be held in the hands, arcane power coursing through it. Seekers hold that any creator who would devise the mirror world of Dolurrh as a soul's final reward is worthy only of contempt. Thus, the faith focuses on the pragmatic—specifically the life-or-death coin toss that is existence. Seekers believe that traditional faith is a self-indulgent conceit, a means for small minds and even smaller souls to come to terms with the true nature of existence. In a world as unforgiving as Eberron, the only faith that is not misplaced is faith in oneself and one's own capabilities. When priests of Vol meditate to gain access to divine magic, for example, they are praying not to deities or to concepts, but in truth, to themselves. The Divinity Within grants the power to shape reality using divine power, not some outside force.

The Seekers maintain that blood itself is the “soul” of life, coursing through the veins of sentient beings like a liquid god. In the mindset of most Vol cultists, creatures that have no blood—

constructs, plants, oozes and the like—are thus removed from true divinity. Vol doctrine holds that blood truly *is* the source of life and that without it, a being is not truly alive at all. As a result, Seekers believe that blood holds the key to myriad doorways of power and wisdom, including the greatest passage of all: the door to life everlasting.

The concept of the Divinity Within is central to the Seekers' view of the soul and to any notion of an afterlife. They absolutely believe in the Shadowfell and the most powerful members of the faith even claim to have been there and returned to tell of its vast, gloomy emptiness. These grim testaments are often spoken in cult sermons all across Khorvaire to further embolden the Seekers' drive to escape that gray final fate. The Blood of Vol maintains, much as the ancient elven Qabalin necromancers of Xen'drik also did, that the key to such an escape from mortality lies in the Blood Within. Those who look outward for succor are destined for betrayal by the very powers that they revere, doomed to a soulless eternity. Only by looking inward and by drawing strength from the Divinity Within, can a soul hope to find its own afterlife: a beautiful creation crafted to its particular nature and character and filled with an eternity of happiness.

The high position of the intelligent undead within the cult might surprise those outside the faith. Vampires, liches and mummies no longer have either blood or life and so can never fully bind to the Divinity Within. The Seekers believe that intelligent undead have made this terrible sacrifice to overcome mortality and to serve the sect's other, living members. Thus, they are revered and respected almost like saints, but they are also pitied, for they can never touch perfection themselves. The undead are champions of the church, guiding the people of Vol to their true destiny, but few who believe in the faith would make the terrible choice to become undead.

The global priesthood of the faith (some would say cult) is the mechanism by which the Lich Queen Vol influences the lives of Seekers everywhere. Most worshipers have no idea that Vol still exists, let alone the full extent of her schemes and manipulations. A secret circle of advisers and functionaries—made up of both undead and mortals who have found ways to cheat death—known as the Crimson Covenant acts as the “ruling body” of the faith—the Blood of Vol's equivalent of the Church of the Silver Flame's Diet of Cardinals—despite the fact that many Seekers never learn of its existence nor the extent of its impact on their own lives. Those who follow the Blood of Vol seek immortality from within and many do not know of or willingly support the secret and dark ambitions of the cult's true leader.

The seat of the faith in Khorvaire today is the Crimson Monastery located in the city of Atur in the kingdom of Karnath. Like the Church of the Silver Flame, the Blood of Vol believes that all other faiths are wrong. The typical Seeker believes in no divinity beyond that which runs in his own

veins and vehemently decries mindless worship until (and often beyond) his last breath. The Blood of Vol holds most other religions in contempt: No sane soul would choose to give up self-determination, the greatest gift of existence. Yet every other major religion on Eberron places the fate of its members in the hands of outside forces, whether gods, angels, demons or nature itself. Perhaps the only tenet that Seekers share with members of other faiths is that a soul's actions in life determine its final reward. Still, where others believe that actions are tallied and judged by those they worship, cultists of Vol hold that an individual's actions are the only way for the soul to escape Dolurrh, for their own sake.

The Blood of Vol has also been around since long before the formation of the Kingdom of Galifar and thus does not use the standard calendar to mark their religious observances or the passage of time. The faith follows the oldest active calendar used on Eberron, the Qabalrin Wheel. Named for the elven civilization that developed it on Xen'drik millennia ago, it was the only calendar of record for much of Eberron's early history. Like its present Galifaran counterpart, the Qabalrin Wheel is divided into months that correspond to the moons of Eberron, but unlike the Galifar Calendar, it still recognizes the thirteenth moon that was destroyed when the giants sealed off the plane of Dal Quor long ago. The Wheel has thirteen months instead of the standard twelve, with the last—Crya, associated with the equally lost Mark of Death—coming after Vult and before Zarantyr on the Galifar Calendar. This renders the Qabalrin Wheel year one month longer than the Galifar year. The Blood of Vol liturgical calendar reckons time from the year when the House of Vol was betrayed, forcing its last scion into an eternity of undeath. To Seekers in the know, 998 YK corresponds to 2398 FH (years since the Fall of the House). Many Seekers do not use this convention, of course, and even those who do still use the Galifar Calendar, for dealings outside the faith.

The Path of Inspiration



Only one religion is tolerated in the Empire of Riedra on the continent of Sarlona—the Path of Inspiration. Its practice is mandatory. Omnipresent yet subtle, the Path is easily overlooked. For a Riedran, work is worship, and life itself is an act of devotion. According to the Path of Inspiration, dedicated and hard-working souls ascend a ladder of spiritual evolution and reincarnation over the

course of many lifetimes, traveling from animal, to nonhuman, to human, to changeling, to Chosen, to the *il-altas*—the “great spirits” that cannot be perceived in this world, but that continue to guide lesser beings by acting through the Inspired. A follower of the Path should embrace the life he is given and learn the lessons he is meant to learn from it, resisting the temptation to rise above his station or change his lot in life.

For the Inspired lords of Riedra, this system of belief accomplishes many ends. It encourages citizens not to question their roles in life—spiritual advancement is the goal, and only by following the path set forth by the *il-altas* (as announced by the Inspired) can such advancement be attained. It also allows the Inspired to fail without shattering their status in the eyes of the people. The Inspired are mortal vessels of godlike beings, not actual gods, and any defeats or setbacks are the fault of the vessel. Finally, it contains just enough truth to weaken any attempts to expose the true nature of the quori. The Riedrans know that their rulers are possessed by immortals, and magically driving out the possessing spirit proves nothing aside from the fact that the exorcist is a foul being to challenge the noble *il-altas*. Since most Riedrans fear or at least distrust arcane magic, they are unlikely to accept the evidence provided by divination spells.

Riedrans are warned to beware of the *altavars*, spirits that have fallen off the Path of Inspiration. These beings suffer eternal torment and assuage their pain by corrupting and torturing others. The precepts of the Path teach that the “gods” worshiped by other cultures are in fact *altavars*, and that these dark spirits are also the source of arcane magic. As a result, Riedrans are taught to fear and despise arcanists and priests of other religions.

No temples have been erected to the Path of Inspiration; the holiest sites are the palaces of the Inspired and the *hanbalani* psionic amplifier monoliths. On days of celebration, people often gather around the nearest monolith to join their thoughts (in the process, unwittingly channeling more of their psychic energy to Dal Quor). Priests of the Path of Inspiration are charged with maintaining discipline and morale among the people of their communities. Only the most loyal priests are entrusted with divine magic. The Inspired cannot actually grant spells, but they can certainly eliminate clerics whose devotion to the state is in question. As a result, true Riedran clerics are usually trusted envoys of the Inspired, often working with the Harmonious Shield or the Thousand Eyes.

Although the Path of Inspiration was created as a tool to manipulate the Riedran masses, nothing is inherently evil about the faith. The divine power of the path is ultimately independent of the Inspired or the Dreaming Dark. Perhaps spells of the Riedran cleric are drawn from the magical energy of the Dragon Above. Maybe the power flows from the raw faith of millions of Riedrans. It

could be that the *il-altas* truly exist, unbeknownst to the Inspired. For most Riedrans, the Path of Inspiration is inseparable from their country as a whole, and the source of its power is Riedra. No Inspired views the Path of Inspiration as a true religion; it is merely a tool. Clerics among the quori worship *il-Lashtavar* (the Dreaming Dark). Aside from the quori, only the shadow lines — those Chosen specifically raised to serve as vessels for the quori agents of the Dreaming Dark—know of this true faith of the quori.

The Path of Light



Adherents of the Path of Light first laid out by the quori Taratai and her kalashtar host, the Adaran monk, Haztaratai, are mostly kalashtar and Adaran humans. They believe that Dal Quor's *Quor Tarai*, the Dream of the Age, has actually been reborn three times—with the most recent occurring after the Quori-Giant War when the Dreaming Heart became the Dreaming Dark—and will continue to pass away and be reborn for millennia to come. Each rebirth destroys the living quori of that time and gives rise to an entirely new race of these alien beings from the Plane of Dreams. Taratai found that those rebirths actually swung between two moral poles. The current incarnation of the *Quor Tarai* contains a heart of darkness, but the next should be one of infinite light.

Taratai became the speaker for those few quori who rejected the Dreaming Dark and she urged them to work toward that blessed transformation of the Plane of Dreams. But the servants of the Dark had no desire to see an end of their world (and their own existence) and set about eliminating all the rebel quori, eventually forcing them into the exile to Eberron that created the kalashtar race. Today, every one of Taratai's kalashtar hosts has perished, though the ultimate fate of her spirit is unknown. The kalashtar mourn her as dead, but most followers of the Path of Light believe that she is still bound somehow to the *Quor Tarai* and can help to affect its rebirth. Believers have continued to practice and spread her teachings from Adar to the rest of Sarlona and on to Khorvaire.

Only through cultivating the emergence of what Taratai saw as the Dreaming Dark's antithesis and ultimate replacement—the Great Light or *il-Yannah* in the Quori language—can the

adherents to the Path save the world from the eternity of nightmare and evil that the Inspired and the Dreaming Dark hope to impose on both Dal Quor and Eberron. In Khorvaire, those who hope to bring forth the *il-Yannah* are almost entirely kalashtar, although a few other beings are also drawn to the idea of promoting and spreading a universal force of radiant energy and purity of spirit.

In Adar, most people show at least some respect to the Path of Light, though Adaran humans also traditionally worship several of the Sovereigns dedicated to the natural world like Aarakti (Arawai) and Braahyn (Balinor). The kalashtar race was born of the exiled quori's quest for the Light and they remain devoted to this principle with every fiber of their being. Many of the followers of *il-Yannah* are known as lightbringers (*yannahsur* in Quori) and these individuals spend much of their time meditating and taking small but positive actions to reinforce the strength of the Light across all of Creation. Others not only meditate but also train within the fortress-monasteries of Adar for the ongoing battle with the Inspired of Riedra, or actively seek out agents of the Dreaming Dark operating in Khorvaire. These lightbringers are called the shadow watchers (*sheshantol*). Those of the lightbringers with the strongest personalities and the finest talents often become leaders in the quest for the Light. They become priests known as *yannahilath*—"lightspeakers." Some of these priests are actually clerics, but most are gifted psions with great psychic power.

All kalashtar seem unnaturally beautiful to normal humans. They radiate a sense of grace and calm, particularly the lightbringers, who reflect the Light within. Path of Light priests are as far beyond the other faithful as ordinary kalashtar are beyond humans, fairly glowing with their dedication and powerful psionic abilities. Many devotees of the Path of Light carry a small quartz crystal, usually on a fine chain about the neck. Among psions, this often doubles as a psicrystal. The priests bear distinctive, swooping headbands studded with crystals, which are often power crystals made from Siberys shards and they might have other crystalline adornments on their clothing. These visible tokens of the Light are openly displayed only among kalashtar or within a protected area such as Adar. Followers who mingle with nonbelievers take great care to blend in, even as they promote the Light, lest they be noticed and captured or killed by the agents of the Dreaming Dark.

The most powerful lightspeakers all dwell within Adar, protected by its natural fortifications, capricious storms and well-defended fortress-monasteries. There they lead the war against darkness through regular meditation. They focus their energies together on establishing a zone of peace and harmony right at the heart of Riedra. As this "bubble" of Light grows, it saps the current *Quor Tarai* of strength and begins to transform it for the next incarnation. The lightbringers believe this is the most direct, effective attack against their enemies. It has the additional benefit of counteracting the Riedran *hanbalani* monoliths' tightening of the connection between Eberron and Dal Quor.

Kalashtar do not usually speak to other races about their ancient, secret war. They can even be arrogant, believing that such “lesser” people cannot understand the enormity of their struggle. The practical needs of survival dictate silence as well. The arcane authorities of the Arcane Congress in Aundair and the Twelve in Karmath distrust the kalashtar and their alien psychic powers. If they knew the truth, they would fear the Inspired far more. Kalashtar and the lightspeakers prefer to conduct their war in their own way, but they value informed allies. Occasionally, this means the lightspeakers or shadow watchers provide information to other forces for good in Khorvaire. Such information is reliable and discreet and it can rarely be traced to its source among Khorvaire’s kalashtar community.

The Cults of the Dragon Below



The Cults of the Dragon Below’s followers may be wild-eyed maniacs or disarmingly serene, while still no less insane. Some give themselves over completely to spreading death, violence and terror, while others cannot see the insanity behind their belief systems, convinced that they serve a greater good. Most have been so psychologically scarred that only insanity makes any sense—it is even comforting. Every Cult priest has his own interpretation of religious theology and his own ideas of how to demonstrate faith in Khyber. One might demand that every cultist remove a finger. Another might insist that the road to paradise is paved with cannibalistic feats. Another might call on worshippers to give up all material wealth, or to acquire as many worldly goods as possible.

Among the savage peoples (mostly the orcs and half-orcs of the Shadow Marches), madness is seen as a path to power. For them, barbarian rage is the purest expression of the warrior spirit and insanity is the quickest way to achieve it. Not many use divine magic and those who do are casters rarely trained in the “civilized” religious studies. The more civilized orc and human Marcher clans incorporate myriad human and orc beliefs, each with its own idea of how to bond with the Dragon Below. Though they might war with each other over their interpretations of the faith, all Cultists respect the power of aberrations like mind flayers and beholders, who they treat as the high priests and special servants of Khyber, and show a similar reverence for rakshasas and other fiends who are the children of the Dragon Below. These cultists are to be pitied more than hated. Unfortunately, their

insane devotion makes them dangerously unpredictable and their ideas of worship can be inimical to all life.

The Undying Court



The Undying Court are not just the Aereni elves' spiritual advisers and ultimate political authority, they actually represent the collective faith of the elves of Aerenal. The Aereni offer their prayers to no distant god but to their own ancestors. Most of these ancestors are long deceased but their spirits watch over the elves of today, acting as guardians to their family lines. Some of the dead have not departed and walk Aerenal still. This combination of spirits and the animate dead is the sum total of the Undying Court: counselors, protectors, soldiers and gods to the elves of the island-continent.

This religion is like no other on Eberron, misunderstood and feared by many, yet it has produced a population more universally faithful to their moral and ethical beliefs than that of more "normal" faiths. The Aereni religion is not rigidly codified or quantified like many others, but if their primary doctrine were to be summed up, it might read something like this: *Existence is a spiritual journey requiring far longer than a single lifetime. Only the Undying can ever truly learn what great wonders lie at its end.* Thus, the elves of Aerenal do not fear death. They welcome it as simply a new stage of the spiritual journey. To the Aereni, no greater honor exists than to be accepted for the Rites of Transition, to become undying and remain on Aerenal to continue the journey and to watch over their descendants. The ritual to create a new undying is carried out by the Priests of Transition, who serve the Court in Shae Mordai and also act as the elven people's clerics.

In life, the elves try to prove their worthiness for this great honor. Some adopt mannerisms to mimic the dead, even painting and mutilating their bodies to appear so. Others lead lives of great spirituality, honoring the Undying Court and serving their fellow elves to the best of their ability. But the fullest devotion to the Undying Court is devotion to one's own family line, for the Court is composed of one's ancestors. Aereni families are insular, keeping to themselves where possible, marrying within the line and focusing their worship and devotion on the ancestors and undying of

their own blood. Thus, worship of the Undying Court changes—sometimes dramatically—from region to region and family to family across the isle.

The Aereni treat the undying in their midst as revered counselors and holy figures. Although the undying counselors are not the secular rulers of the nation—that power is reserved for the Sibling Kings—their advice is heeded by even the most powerful of elves. They are mouthpieces of the divine and they possess the wisdom of many generations.

While the Aereni honor and love the undying, they despise the undead. The Undying Court is empowered by positive, radiant energy that derives from Irian and its members do not feed off the living to survive. True undead are a corruption of this order, a violation of all laws of nature and spirit and are to be destroyed. An Aereni who becomes undead is the worst of all abominations, a blight on the world and the Undying Court.

It is a common misperception that the Aereni have no concept of divinity, that their ancestor worship omits the potential for true gods. This is a great fallacy and the largest hurdle for others to overcome to gain a true understanding of the elven faith. The Aereni do believe in divinity: the assembled spiritual might of the Undying Court itself. A given ancestor or undying counselor might possess knowledge but relatively little spiritual power. The Court as a whole, however, shapes the world of the Aereni, grants divine spells to elven clerics and essentially forms its own collective “god.” The elves pray to their ancestors’ spirits as emissaries and servants of the Undying Court, knowing that these individuals can present their words and deeds to the “God-Court” as a whole. A few Aereni maintain that some form of divinity did exist even before the formation of the Undying Court. They believe that a previous race of beings had reached the end of their spiritual journey as a whole, even as the elves and undying of Aerenal seek to do. These beings ascended to become the gods that would create the next world—divine powers that mortal minds interpret as Eberron, Khyber and Siberys, the Progenitors. These elves also believe that when the elves of Aerenal finally reach the end of their own spiritual journey, they will shape the fate of the new world yet to come.

It should be noted that the three Tairnadal sects of elves from northern Aerenal and Valenar do not worship the Undying Court. They have a separate, yet related, religious tradition that is vested in a clerical caste known as the Keepers of the Past. The Tairnadal also revere their ancestors and believe that their ancestors’ souls represent a collective divine force that can be tapped through faith to produce supernatural power and divine magic. But while they respect the undying, they do not worship them, believing that true divinity is only achieved once a soul has passed from the material world. The Tairnadal believe that the existence of the Undying Court keeps their Aereni counterparts too tightly bound to the past rather than using the blessings of the ancestors to forge a better future.

The Cult of the Lord of Blades



Most people believe that the fanatical prophet of the warforged known as the Lord of Blades is gathering an army in the Mournland. Stories abound of his zealous attendants and his apocalyptic speeches, promising death to the fleshborn and the ultimate ascendancy of the warforged over all of Eberron. Little is known about his whereabouts, his movements, and his actual plans. Some even doubt whether this construct bogeyman even exists.

There are those warforged who are certain of his existence, and draw strength from it. These fanatics call themselves Blades, and they view their charismatic leader as more than just a prophet. To them, he is a divine presence, a messiah sent to lead all intelligent constructs to the promised land free of the prejudice and hate of the fleshborn. Their worship sustains him, and in return, he provides them with a sense of purpose and inner strength. The truth is that the Lord of Blades is a real being rather than an abstract divine principle. Yet despite this, he has his clerics, few though they be, who draw inspiration from their worship and can cast divine magic in his name, in defiance of what most of the other faiths of Eberron believe.

The faith of the Blades is not a typical religion, for they place no special value on spiritual existence. They waste no time on questions about the nature of souls and whether warforged have them; they have self-awareness and free will, and that is enough. They see no purpose to wielding some form of spiritual energy that is granted by a distant god; they receive a tangible benefit from proximity to their leader and increase his power by their own obedience.

Such raw materialism seems to be oxymoronic in a religion. Yet there can be no doubt that the Blades are a religious organization: All the ritual, the prayer, and the spiritual sustenance that believers gain from a faith is present. In the view of some outsiders, it appears to be worship without faith in anything greater than the Blades and their confidence in their leader. Still, for those Blades who have met him, their god's existence is undeniable.

The cult of the Lord of Blades has a simple but clearly defined hierarchy. It starts with the Lord of Blades himself. His warforged followers have memorized his every word, repeating them over and over, and they see his pronouncements as unassailable fact. When the Lord says, "We were

made to rule Eberron,” the Blades know it to be true. They await only his direction to make the future real.

But who is the Lord of Blades? History tells of the warforged Bulwark, an outstanding servant of King Boranel of Breland, who was thought to have influenced that king’s thinking in the matter of providing freedom to the warforged after the Last War. Once the Treaty of Thronehold was signed, Bulwark headed east and was never seen again. Not long afterward, stories of the Lord of Blades began to circulate. Many warforged (and others) believe that the two are one and the same. This is but one of the many origin stories told about the Lord of Blades, however.

The theory of Bulwark as the Lord of Blades is supported by little more than rumor. Indeed, Bulwark has been the origin of several cults. Some warforged revere Bulwark as the liberator of their people, giving him the sort of respect normally reserved for gods, and they pledge their lives to his service. As he departed soon after they were freed, these loyalists were left to choose between remaining in their old lands and following their savior into the east. Those who stayed behind have cultivated small areas of worship and ready the warforged populace for his return. They call themselves the Preparers of the Way, and peacefully integrate themselves into whatever larger society exists around them. Others, known as the Converts, abandoned their former homes and try to retrace Bulwark’s steps to join him in whatever great destiny awaits. Both such groups claim to be followers of Bulwark the Liberator, and have no truck with the Lord of Blades, who they view as an insane tyrant who will only lead many warforged to their doom.

By contrast, the Blades pay homage to a leader in the Mournland, denying that he has anything in common with the subservient Bulwark. A more logical theory dismisses the task of finding the origin of the Lord of Blades. Instead, it posits that many such Lords exist. Reports from adventurers and scavengers have in common the sightings of warforged juggernaut squads moving purposefully in the Mournland. Perhaps the Lord of Blades is no more than a title, carried by whichever leader claims it at the time. Thus, any squad of warforged encountered in the Mournland could contain the Lord of Blades, even though none of them actually do. This theory certainly accounts for the mystery and elusiveness of the Lord far better than any other.

Wherever he came from, the devotion of the Blades to their Lord is clear. This might simply arise because their Lord is the most charismatic of his kind. Alternatively, he could have something extra—some divine authority or even supernatural ability that sets him apart from the rest. Perhaps this power derives from an ancient artifact, or even from an all-consuming obsession with finding such an item.

The cult's organization is military, as befits the warforged mindset and the religious war against the "fleshborn" races espoused by their leader. The entire cult is the Legion, with the Lord of Blades at its head. Below the Lord himself are his captains. Each captain is responsible for a company of followers, each company containing several hundred warforged. Below the captains are lieutenants who direct squads of around fifty followers. The chain of command is enforced rigidly, which warforged find comforting and familiar. Insubordination does not exist among the Blades—the very concept cannot even occur to them, for the orders of their divine Lord are absolute.

The clergy—really more the military hierarchy—of the Lord of Blades has the primary duty of transmitting their master's words to all members of the Legion. This takes the form of long harangues, which followers memorize and repeat as a mantra. Such repetition is typical of any warforged worship, and indeed of all warforged daily routine. The captains and lieutenants also lead their followers in military exercises, honing tactics and devising group maneuvers to assure victory when the holy war finally begins. Some among the high-ranking Blades are tasked with evangelism. These individuals are dispatched in all directions from the Mournland to warforged enclaves across Khorvaire. They have been focusing especially on Karnath and Thrane, which have large populations of indentured warforged to whom the promised freedom of Thronehold never truly came. Among these downtrodden folk they find their most zealous converts. The most passionate of these heralds spend many years as evangelicals in their adopted lands, to better awaken and lead others to their destiny. They do not tire of their self-imposed exile from their lord and god; they know that when the signal is given, all will gather in the Mournland to begin the conquest of the fleshborns' lands.

The major ritual activities of the Blades are large-scale military exercises. Unlike typical military war games, though, these are highly formalized. Group tactics are practiced over and over, until all members are performing exactly in synch; then larger-group coordination is perfected in the same way. In addition, all the Blades engage in the Blade Communion, a periodic adoration of their spiritual leader. This is not some offering of flowery words but a physical communion in which all receive the Lord of Blades' blessing and in return confer upon him some of their own strength, thus increasing his power. It is at this time that the Lord of Blades' few clerics can renew their divine powers.

King Boranel of Breland is obsessed with the idea that his onetime aide Bulwark might now be the Lord of Blades. He is tormented by the thought that he might have unleashed such a threat upon Khorvaire. Still, he also wants the best for his old companion. He wonders whether Bulwark (if indeed that is the true identity of the warforged messiah) would even listen to his former patron—if

he could get word to the Blades' Mournland stronghold. He compulsively collects information about the Lord of Blades, and his Brelish intelligence agents seek out independent investigators to bring the latest news.

Karmath and Thrane feel most threatened by the Lord of Blades' message of freedom, for their economies rely heavily on indentured warforged labor. Thus, King Kaius III and the Thrane Diet of Cardinals have declared the Lord of Blades to be an enemy of the state. Followers of the religion are destroyed immediately, whether they are the property of the state or outside agents apprehended in pursuit of their evangelism.

The center of the Blades' worship is the hidden stronghold of their Lord, somewhere deep within the Mournland. Its location is unknown to any outside the cult, and even new recruits do not visit this headquarters until they are well-established in the cult's organization. The scribes and evangelicals, as well as the Lord of Blades's personal bodyguard, travel to the stronghold frequently and return with the latest pronouncements. The Blades are certain that their leader possesses a creation forge and that he swells the ranks of his followers with new warforged, but no one beyond the inner circle has actually seen the inside of the temple.

The Blades mark time according to the first appearance of the Lord of Blades, punctuated by his most evocative pronouncements. They care little for the calendar of the fleshborn, instead marking the passing of the months, or moons, with quotations, which change each year as determined by the Blades' scribes. For example, the rising of Therendor is called in the current calendar, "We endure." The transition from one day to the next is less important for people who need no sleep and conduct no commerce. Each quarter of the year, however, begins with a Blade Communion. Once a year, following the Blade Communion of Scribing, the official recordkeepers transcribe the Lord of Blades's pronouncements for the year and also name the next twelve months. 998 YK corresponds to the First Year of Thirteen Blades, according to the cult's accounting. This might refer to the number of blades on the body of the Lord of Blades, to the number of companies of the Legion working within the Mournland, or perhaps even to the rising of the moons (though this last is unlikely).

Galifar Month	Blade Communion
Olarune	Sentinel
Dravago	Handling
Rhaan	Scribing
Vult	Warding

The Unique Races of Eberron

The *Shulassakar* and the Yuan-Ti

The dragonkin race of celestial feathered serpents known as the couatl were born on the continent of Sarlona. The majority of their ancient ruins still lie hidden today in the nation of Riedra, the realm of the Inspired. As the couatl fought the fiends during the Age of Demons, they established outposts across the length and breadth of Eberron. The greatest of these was the fortress-citadel of Krezent, located in the heart of what are now the Talenta Plains on the continent of Khorvaire. The city extends down into the depths of Khyber, and by the end of the war, terrible forces had been bound in its foundations. A handful of couatl remained to watch over the world after their race's sacrifice, but they were too few to guard every seal, so they sought out helpers among the younger races. According to legends, a small group of loyal humans from Sarlona, the birthplace of the human race on Eberron, dedicated their lives to the service of the couatl. Over the course of thousands of years, this devotion and their constant proximity to the couatl's celestial presence changed them in body and soul. By the time the goblin Empire of Dhakaan rose to power on Khorvaire, the guardians of Krezent were no longer human. They had become, in the Draconic language, *shulassakar*—the feathered servants.

The people of Krezent are a wondrous sight: humans blended with couatl, with serpentine features and feathers that glow with an inner, silver light. The shulassakar are dedicated servants of the Silver Flame and will give their lives without a moment's thought to combat the forces of darkness. Yet, the shulassakar are very similar in appearance and physiology to another serpentine humanoid race of considerably less benevolent reputation—the yuan-ti. The yuan-ti seem to have first come into being on Sarlona, much like humanity itself. Like the shulassakar, they seem to possess some connection to the couatl and may represent the first, flawed attempt by the celestial feathered serpents to create human-couatl hybrids to be their servants or perhaps are shulassakar who were corrupted by the fiendish Overlords or other dark forces. Today the yuan-ti are found in small numbers on Sarlona and Argonessen but their main populations have taken refuge on Xen'drik.

In any event, the Silver Flame created by the couatl's sacrifice is a force for good but its followers are often blinded by its light, and the shulassakar are no exception. They fight against darkness with ruthless efficiency and will make *any sacrifice necessary* for the greater good of

Eberron, including the lives of innocents. No one can jeopardize the seals of Krezent. The shulassakar seek to repel outsiders peacefully before they venture too deeply into the ruins but those who persist are dealt with swiftly and harshly. The shulassakar have considerable racial pride. The feathered servants do not believe that any other creature can truly touch the silver light of the couatl as they do. The human Church of the Silver Flame and the Keeper of the Flame—these are inherently flawed. While they may mean well, they are tampering with forces they do not truly understand. A shulassakar is more inclined to work with a follower of the Flame than with any other creature, but he will still treat this person as an underling or a child. As far as he is concerned, the physical form of the shulassakar is proof of spiritual superiority. The shulassakar consider their serpentine characteristics to be a blessing and a sign of their bond with the couatl. They believe that a shulassakar goes through cycles of reincarnation like the couatl and that the different forms of shulassakar—identical to those of their yuan-ti cousins—represent this spiritual growth. Thus, when referring to themselves, the shulassakar refer to snaketongues as “bloodsworn,” malisons as “flametouched,” and abominations as “transcendents.” It is unknown if the shulassakar have an equivalent to the insane yuan-ti anathemas.

The shulassakar devote their energy to guarding Krezent and other couatl ruins scattered across Eberron. They are aware of the rising darkness that affects the current age of Eberron—the Lords of Dust that have escaped from their bonds, the Cults of the Dragon Below, the lurking threat of the Dreaming Dark. The shulassakar face these forces directly when possible. A handful of shulassakar bloodsworn have hidden themselves among humanity, watching for signs of the rising darkness. A shulassakar always prefers to solve a problem on its own or to call in a more powerful servant to handle the problem. At the same time, the shulassakar recognize that victory is more important than pride. A shulassakar may approach adventurers openly, especially if one or more members of the party follow the Silver Flame. Because shulassakar have little respect for the young races, however, it is more likely that one will attempt to manipulate or trick adventurers into serving its purposes, believing that humans cannot be trusted to do the right thing simply because it is right.

Physically, the shulassakar are similar to the yuan-ti. There is one major difference between the two races: where the shulassakar have serpentine characteristics, their scales are hidden beneath brilliantly colored feathers. The mightiest of the shulassakar also possess powerful, rainbow-colored wings. Bloodsworn shulassakar do not have feathers but often possess colorful markings on their skin. These are easily mistaken for tattoos but they are magical in nature and can shift color and shape in response to the mood of the bearer. The extent of these markings varies from shulassakar to shulassakar, and generally they will not prevent the bloodsworn from disguising itself as a human.

Despite their physical similarities, the shulassakar and yuan-ti cultures have little in common. The shulassakar claim that the ancestors of the yuan-ti were chosen of the couatl who broke their vows to the Flame after being tempted away by the fiends of Khyber and who have since slipped into decadence. As a result, the shulassakar despise the yuan-ti. If the yuan-ti shared these legends, they abandoned them long ago, and they have no interest in the shulassakar. Mostly driven from Sarlona and their original kingdom of Syrkarn over a millennium ago by the rise of the Inspired of Riedra, the yuan-ti lurk in the shadows of Xen'drik and on the shores of Argonnessen, the continents where they sought refuge from the Inspired, plotting vengeance against the Lords of Riedra and searching for ways to use the draconic Prophecy to gain power.

The Kobolds of Khorvaire

Several draconic races were born from the essence of the Progenitor wyrms—the celestial couatl from the pure essence of Siberys, the mortal dragons from the merging of Siberys' essence with that of Eberron and the humanoid kobolds who trace their lineage to a merging of the essences of Khyber and Eberron during the battle between the Progenitors. True or not, this myth is the driving force behind kobold psychology and culture. Two subraces of kobold exist in Khorvaire: the *iredar* (Draconic for “ones of earth”), who trace their ancestry to Eberron, and the *irvhir* (Draconic for “ones below”) that descend from Khyber.

These two races share a common appearance, but each race has a distinctive body odor that kobolds can instantly detect. Beyond scent, the key distinction between the kobold subraces is supernatural. Kobolds produce a surprising number of sorcerers and warlocks, which is a phenomenon they attribute to their supposed bond to the Progenitor dragons. Irvhir sorcerers typically possess spells tied to corruption and darkness, while iredar sorcerers usually have powers of defense and binding. This is not an absolute rule, and a kobold character can take any types of spell that he desires. However, an iredar kobold that makes use of spells of a more aggressive nature may be viewed with suspicion by his companions, who see these as the powers of the Dragon Below. Stories are told of a third subrace of kobolds: the *irsvern* (Draconic for “ones above”), the children of Siberys. According to legend, these kobolds have wings and live in hidden communities on the peaks of the tallest mountains.

Outsiders often assume that kobolds are primitive and savage since they live in unmodified caverns and rely on oral tradition instead of written records. Also, they live in small tribal communities and have never come together to create cities, nations, or empires. However, kobolds

are just as sophisticated as humans or gnomes. While they prefer to live in natural environments instead of creating artificial structures, kobolds have a great gift for mining and stoneworking, and they often fill their lairs with cunning traps. But their culture is driven by rigid adherence to tradition and the kobolds have never sought to change or progress. They are the children of the dragons, vessels of the Progenitors' will; change will come when the great dragons mandate it.

The kobolds of Eberron prefer to live in natural caverns. The irvhir kobolds make their homes deep beneath the surface, while the iredar kobolds usually live in mountain caves. The kobolds believe that these caverns are the veins of the Progenitor dragons, and they often carve elaborate draconic designs on the walls. Kobolds prefer to live in tribes containing approximately 100 adults. The largest communities can have up to 600 adults. Generally, though, a community splits once its population rises too far above 100 adults, with younger kobolds moving away to found a new community.

Kobolds often bond with horrid animals. Horrid creatures—especially burrowing animals such as rats, weasels, and badgers—are frequently found in kobold communities. Kobold culture revolves around three castes. The stonescales (or *ternmolik*, in Draconic) perform the day-to-day tasks required for the survival of a community: crafts, agriculture, and the gathering of food when agriculture will not suffice. The claws (*gix*) are soldiers and hunters. And the blood seers (*iejirastrix*) are mystics who hear the voices of the Progenitor dragons—sorcerers, druids, and warlocks whose magical powers are seen as proof of the kobolds' divine ancestry. Typically the chieftain of a village is an old claw, though in a peaceful region a stonescale can hold the post. The chieftain manages the daily affairs of the community while the blood seers link the communities together. Seers often travel from village to village to meet with other blood seers, discussing their visions and issues affecting the race as a whole.

Mainstream kobold culture is oriented around the worship of a particular Progenitor wyrm. The irvhir tradition is one of the oldest Cults of the Dragon Below, though it has no connection with the aberration-oriented cults of the Shadow Marches. The iredar kobolds revere Eberron as the source of life and nature; this is a unique druidic tradition with no ties to the sects of the Eldeen Reaches. The kobolds see themselves as the hands of the Progenitors in the modern age. And in the past, visions of the blood seers have often been tied to the draconic Prophecy. It is a mystery, since the kobolds themselves rarely understand the significance of their actions—but even the Chamber respects this uncanny gift. Of course, not all kobolds are bound to these beliefs. A few tribes have split off from these traditions, ignoring the words of the blood seers. Irvhir kobolds often turn to the worship of the Shadow or the Mockery, while independent iredar revere Boldrei and Olladra. Most

kobolds prefer to avoid contact with the outside world. Irvhir kobolds are especially xenophobic, and the gnomish miners of Zilargo have been fighting irvhir kobolds for centuries. Iredar kobolds are more moderate in their views. They have little interest in foreign cultures and fight irvhir kobolds as often as they battle gnomes or humans. In the wake of the Last War, kobolds have had a more active presence on the surface of Khorvaire. Kobold scavengers often rummage through battlefields and ruined villages. Previously unknown irvhir communities have risen from the depths to strike at weakened thorps and hamlets along the borders of the Mournland. Whether these are random attacks of opportunity or driven by the seers of Khyber remains to be seen.

The Drow of Xen'drik

The drow carve a deadly existence out of the now-ruined continent of Xen'drik. The dark-skinned elves, products of the giants' experiments in fusing the essence of some of their elven slaves with the power of Khyber herself, believe it is they, not the rebel elves who fled to Aerenal, who truly preserve the dignity and valor of the elf race. Allied with monstrous scorpions, the drow battle the fallen race of giants over the cyclopean ruins of the mysterious continent. As the most civilized inhabitants of ruined Xen'drik, the drow are the heirs to both the lingering might of lost giant nations and the ancient elven spellcraft once learned at the feet of the giants' own draconic tutors.

The homeland of the drow is a contradiction of sorts—an ancient ruin that nonetheless holds magical treasures of almost unimaginable might. As Siberys shards fall on the broken landscapes and jungles, explorers from other continents brave sahuagin-filled waters to crowd the port city of Stormreach. The jungles of Xen'drik are a harsh and unforgiving land; the drow dwell in the underground realm of Khyber as often as they haunt the jungle-cloaked ruins of aboveground Xen'drik. Covered by thick rain forests and the ruined cities of the ancient giant kingdoms, the continent houses too many dangers for the drow to be able to establish large and stable cities such as those on Khorvaire. The largest drow settlements, those of the Umbragen, are underground. Nomadic drow settlements are small, temporary affairs. Occasionally a relatively large and powerful tribe might stay for some time in the ruins of a giant city, but such occupations are shortlived. The drow stay only long enough to plunder what artifacts they can. Nomadic drow have few of the political struggles and rivalries that the other races have. Family groups are simply too small and scattered to have anything other than sporadic contact. This intermittent contact is fraught with peril, though, as larger and more powerful family groups seek to absorb smaller groups of drow—sometimes violently.

The most common group of drow on Eberon differ from those in other D&D worlds in that they worship a scorpion-god named Vulkoor instead of the spider-goddess Lolth. Vulkoor is often envisioned as a giant scorpion or as a hybrid with the head, arms, and upper torso of a strong male drow and the lower body of a scorpion. Many drow believe that Vulkoor and the Mockery (one of the group of evil deities known as the Dark Six) are one and the same. The drow also revere scorpions, considering other arachnids to be lesser servitors of Vulkoor. Xen'drik drow ritually scar themselves using scorpion venom, leaving white tattoos on their black skin and have relatively low levels of technology. For instance, metal armor is almost unknown among the tribes, though they do seem to have some knowledge of basic metallurgy when forging weapons, particularly the famed drow long knife. Most Vulkoori drow (as the nomadic tribes are known to scholars) have little interaction with members of other races; they fight the giants and monsters that roam their savage continent, and even avoid other drow family groups when possible. Drow are very suspicious of outsiders, and the few who interact with other races do so through the port of Stormreach. When dealing with outsiders, drow reveal nothing of themselves or their family groups whenever possible, always attempting to use the outsiders for their own ends without exposing the secrets of Xen'drik. For this reason, members of other races often find the drow to be a suspicious and sinister group.

Not all drow are Vulkoori tribal savages. The Sulatar have clung to traditions of magic dating back to the Age of Giants—specifically, an ancient form of elemental binding. The Sulatar (“firebinders” in the Giant language) are masters of fire in all its forms. Their champions wear burning armor and bind elementals to their adamantine blades, while Sulatar master crafters create magic items that even the gnomes of Zilargo have yet to perfect. The firebinders remained loyal to the giants throughout the Elven Uprising and, even after forty thousand years, have held to the teachings of their ancient masters. The Sulatar believe that their devotion will eventually grant them access to a promised land of fire, the Land of the Promise, where they will gain immortality and vast power and lead an army that will sweep across the world. Scholars speculate that the promised land is the elemental realm of Fernia, but so far the legends remain just that.

Few explorers have encountered the Sulatar, for the firebinders have little interest in other cultures. To the Sulatar, all will fall when the Gates of the Promise open; until then, they have no need to deal with inferior creatures. In addition to this isolationist attitude, the Sulatar have long fought the Vulkoori, and this has kept their population in check. The firebinders consider the scorpion-worshipping tribes to be savages and traitors, while the children of Vulkoor hate the Sulatar for their continuing loyalty to the giants. It is unknown how many Sulatar live in Xen'drik—it might be that only a single enclave of Sulatar exists—the legendary Obsidian City, deep in the Xen'drik

jungles. Alternatively, hundreds of thousands of firebinders might inhabit the south of the continent—an army that could pose a deadly threat to Stormreach and to Khorvair if the Sulatar chose to emerge from hiding. The firebinders tattoo patterns of flames across their skin, believing that these grant mystical protection. Although the tattoos do not actually confer any benefit, a combination of mystical heritage and long training allows individual Sulatar to exercise great control over bound fire elementals—even if they have no arcane training.

In contrast to the other drow, when doom fell upon Xen'drik, the ancestors of the Umbragen (“shadow elves” in Elven) fled into the depths of the earth. The underworld was filled with its own terrors, but nothing so deadly as the conflict between the dragons and giants. After a long and dangerous journey, these drow refugees settled deep below the region known as the Ring of Storms, the legendary home of the elven Qabalrin who had once lived alongside these drow in their city of Qalatesh. In their struggle for survival, the dark elves uncovered the ancient lore of these elven necromancers and from this Qabalrin knowledge gained the ability to access a dark well of mystical energy that many believed was drawn from the Shadow—a force they named the Umbra. Over the course of generations, the dark elves performed terrible arcane rituals that bound body and soul to the Umbra, blending this shadowy force with dark elven flesh. For thousands of years the Umbragen held their own in the depths of Khyber, defending their realm against all manner of monsters. Then in 997 YK, the balance of power changed. A daelkyr called Belashyrra, the Lord of Eyes, stirred in the dark, and an army of beholders, mind flayers, and other aberrations rose from the shadows. The doom of the Umbragen was at hand. Today the citadels of the Umbragen remain under siege, and the dark elves are losing the battle. They have dispatched forces to the surface in search of anything that could be used as a weapon against the armies of Khyber.

The Umbragen are essentially standard Eberron drow with a few minor modifications; see *Dragon Magazine* 330 (April 2005) for a full exploration of the race. Umbragen society is a ruthless and predatory one, not evil in itself but warped over the millennia by the dangers of their lives in Khyber and the now-constant war against the Lord of Eyes. Their civilization is divided along a major fault line between two ruling councils, the Council of War and the Vault of Shadows, and the Umbragen are ruled by a king who sits on both. Those who follow the path of war battle on the front lines while the arcane students of the Vault search for ways to increase the mystical powers of the race. Rank is earned through conflict and any shadow elf leader—even the king—can be challenged by a direct subordinate. These so-called ascendancy duels include many different forms of challenge, as there is more to being a leader than sheer skill at arms. While such a policy might produce a very chaotic society, in truth such challenges are very rare. Rank is not a matter of ego for the

Umbragen—it is always a question of who can best assure the race’s survival as a whole and so most leaders are revered and highly valued by their people. Umbragen have jet black skin, white or pale hair and slender elven builds like all drow. At a distance shadow elves are indistinguishable from the other drow, but up close, a few distinctive features are noticeable. The eyes of an Umbragen elf are pure black, with no iris or white, while the skin of a shadow elf has an oily gleam, almost as if liquid shadow were flowing across their skin. The Umbragen believe that the Umbra slowly devours the soul of everything it touches, including the Umbragen themselves. Those who are spiritually closest to the Umbra, like most Umbragen wizards, sorcerers, clerics and warlocks, become colder and more ruthless as their dark powers grow. To the Umbragen, the exchange of power for their souls is a fair one and their people respect the necessity of this sacrifice if the shadow elves are to survive. An outside observer might come to the conclusion that these elves worship the Dark Six deity known as the Shadow, which is true in a sense, though the Umbragen do not think in those terms about the Umbra. The Umbragen are more technologically advanced than their fellow Vulkoori drow counterparts on the surface of Xen’Drik, and like the Sulatar make use of metal arms and armor, though their martial classes often prefer to use weapons made of pure, shadowy arcane force drawn from the Umbra and shaped by their own wills. The shadow elves also tattoo their skin with scorpion venom, but prefer strange, arcane, glyph-like patterns across their limbs, torso and faces.

The Serens of Argonessen

A traveler passing through Q’barra or the Lhazaar Principalities on Khorvaire is sure to hear tales about the savage tribes of the Seren Islands. These fierce human barbarians guard the northern coast of Argonessen, and it is said that the waters of Totem Beach run red from the blood of their victims. In Khorvarien song and story, the Serens are typically cast as horrible monsters—firebreathing warriors who consume the flesh of their still-living foes and sacrifice children to their draconic gods.

These stories are much exaggerated. The Serens are fierce warriors who will give their lives to defend the shores of Argonessen from outsiders but they are not cannibals, and their reverence for dragons is more complex than simple awe of the mighty creatures. Approximately thirty Seren tribes are scattered across the islands and the coastline of Argonessen. Every tribe has a legend of a draconic covenant: a tale of how their ancestors were brought from a distant land by a mighty dragon and charged to honor the dragon and defend the land from the weak and unworthy.

The Seren dragonspeaker priests say that the dragons are the embodiment of all that is best in the human spirit. When a Seren dies, his soul is judged, and if he has upheld the covenant, he is placed in the shell of a dragon's egg. When enough worthy souls are brought together in the egg, it hatches and a new dragon is born, distilled from the essence of all the noble souls that went before.

The Seren Islands are harsh and unforgiving, and the tribes exist in continuous conflict. Their civilization has changed very little over the millennia; the Serens are devoted to their traditions. Until the dragons themselves order a change, the Serens will continue to uphold the covenants. Any traveler who wishes to explore the continent of the dragons will have to deal with these barbarians. Seren culture is very warlike, and the Serens repel any invaders. Because of this, the people of Khorvaire and Sarlona have learned to avoid Argonnessen, leaving the Serens to spend most of their time fighting each other. Through these battles the Serens hone their skills and prove their worth as guardians. Only the strongest have a place on the shores of Argonnessen. Children and caregivers are generally spared during raids, allowing tribes to eventually recover from defeat.

Most of the Seren tribes have a similar social structure. The warlord is the mightiest warrior. This position is based purely on skill, and any member of the tribe can challenge a warlord. The warlord oversees all military action: patrolling the land, organizing raids, training young warriors. A council of dragonspeakers, the clerics and druids who use wisdom and magic to guide the tribe, oversees spiritual and domestic matters. Dragonspeaker is a lifelong post with authority within the council based on age. Despite the warlike nature of the Serens, dragonspeakers hold final authority and can overrule a warlord's decisions or even force a warlord to step down from his position. Gender roles vary by tribe and are often dependent on the gender of the founding dragon. In many tribes, female warriors (barbarians) are just as common as men, while in other tribes women become spiritual leaders or are allowed only domestic roles. The Serens claim that the dragons brought them from many lands, and their appearance backs this up. All manner of skin and hair color can be found among the Serens, though there is a tendency toward dark complexions and heavy builds. Tattooing is a common practice on the islands; as Seren warriors win victories in battle, they earn the right to have draconic features tattooed across their bodies.

Seren technology is primitive. Warriors typically wear hide or leather armor. Some rely on dragonscale tattoos in place of physical armor. Weapons are made from wood, bone, or shell. Each tribe, however, possesses more advanced (usually metal) heirloom arms and armor handed down from the draconic founders. These can be both traditional items from the dragons' hoards and dragonscale armor or weapons made from dragon bones or claws. Away from the battlefield, most Serens wear simple, gray clothing. As Serens rise in influence and reputation, they are allowed to

wear clothing and accessories matching the color of the draconic founder. Dragon scale and dragon bone ornaments are reserved for the greatest heroes of the tribe. Such treasures are not passed to descendents upon the owner's death but rather returned to the tribe to be awarded to the next hero who proves worthy.

The Serens speak Draconic as opposed to Common. A Seren may take Common as a bonus language or learn Common at a later time. Seren names are also based on the Draconic language. They do not use family names, instead earning titles and honorifics tied to the draconic founder of their tribe, such as Delhasha'alhasc ("Delhasha the Cold").

Approximately thirty barbarian tribes are spread among the Seren Islands and the northern coast of Argonnessen. A few representative tribes are described here. The Bringers of Fire were founded by a chaotic evil red dragon. One of the largest and most dangerous tribes, they are one of the only tribes known to completely exterminate Seren clans that they view as unworthy. The Bringers of Fire paint their skin red before battle and make use of flaming oil. They are renowned for their volatile temperaments. The White Wanderers were founded by an unaligned white dragon. They are a nomadic tribe charged to protect a series of shrines. They believe in the power of knowledge and magic, and have a high percentage of literacy and dragonspeakers. Explorers and outsiders looking for Serens to deal with would do well to focus on this tribe. White Wanderers have a cold, chilly demeanor, and never let their emotions show. The Stormwalkers were founded by an evil blue dragon. Although one of the smallest tribes, they are nonetheless dangerous and thus, highly respected. The Stormwalkers developed a martial, monastic tradition emulating the natural attacks of the dragon. The Frostblades were founded by a lawful good white dragon. While they ruthlessly defend the land from outsiders, they also seek to preserve weaker tribes from the depredations of more violent tribes such as the Bringers of Fire. Frostblade dragonspeakers know the secret of alchemist's frost and sometimes use this as a weapon in battle.

The Totem Guardians are not a tribe. Rather, they are an alliance of elite soldiers drawn from many tribes. These are the defenders of Totem Beach and the Great Barrier of Argonnessen. Their recruits are drawn from the dreams of dragonspeaker priests who receive dream-visions ordering particular warriors to Totem Beach to join the guardians. In a few very special cases, dragons have personally visited a tribe to call a Seren to the Totem Guardians for unknown reasons.

The Quori

The Path of Light. The Dreaming Dark. The struggle between the kalashtar and the Inspired. What lies at the heart of this epic conflict? The war between the kalashtar and the Inspired has little to do with Eberron. It is actually a struggle to determine the fate of Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams. Dal Quor is a mutable plane. When the mortals of Eberron dream, they mold their own pockets of reality along its fringes. The heart of the plane is shaped by a force greater than any mortal soul, a collective force that can be seen only in the reality that it creates. This is the *Quor Tarai*, the collective consciousness of Dal Quor that represents the spirit of the age, and the age it has currently created is a nightmare. The quori are the children of the *Quor Tarai*, and they call their creator *il-Lashtavar* (the “Darkness that Dreams” in Quori, or the Dreaming Dark in Common).

The nightmarish immortal spirits of the Plane of Dreams known as the quori have a strict caste system, with each caste serving a specific role in Dal Quor and on Eberron. A quori that finds favor in the many eyes of the Dreaming Dark might be physically transformed into a member of a higher caste. Although the quori put the goals of the Dark before everything else, they always look for opportunities for personal advancement. Most quori are cruel but sophisticated, preferring psychological torment to physical conflict. As immortals, they are endlessly patient, willing to wait for decades to take vengeance or bring a plan to fruition. Most quori want to control every aspect of a battle. If caught by surprise, a quori might flee from an inferior foe, returning when it has the upper hand.

Kalaraq quori guide the quori race, and the Devourer of Dreams—the personal emissary of the Dreaming Dark to the rest of his race—is of this caste. Although the kalaraqs never fight one another overtly, each has its own agenda, and each hopes to someday seize the throne of the Devourer of Dreams. Because of this internal conflict, it is very unusual for a kalaraq to leave Dal Quor to inhabit a mortal vessel.

Hashalaq quori are the loremasters of Dal Quor. Even those hashalaqs who do not have Inspired vessels devote a great deal of time to studying Eberron and the other planes, and they are one of the few quori castes that understand the ways of arcane magic. In Dal Quor, the hashalaqs are typically found as advisers to the kalaraqs. They also serve as judges, policing the quori and ensuring that the rivalries of the tsucora never threaten the greater plans of the Dreaming Dark.

The burning tendrils of du’ulora sentinels serve as the brawn to the hashalaqs’ brains. In times of battle, the du’uloras fight in the vanguard, watching dispassionately as their enemies turn on one another. But while du’uloras psychically feed on the rage of others, they are cold and calculating.

Du'uloras are content to serve the Dreaming Dark. Battle defines their existence, and these creatures spend their lives eagerly awaiting the next opportunity to match wits with a cunning foe.

Usvapnas, also known as dream masters (*Magic of Eberron* 148), are the assassins and spies of Dal Quor. They serve the hashalaqs, and they revel in destroying any threat to the Dreaming Dark's plans. The dream masters also sow discontent and worse in mortal minds and have been responsible for much havoc in the mortal world.

Tsucora quori form the masses of Dal Quor. Constantly jockeying for position, tsucoras hope to be reincarnated as a more powerful servant of the Dark in a higher quori caste. Their plans are as often for the ruination of a competitor as they are for the furthering of the *il-Lashtavar*'s plans. None want to return to life as a lowly tsoreva.

Tsoreva quori (*Magic of Eberron* 147) serve as expendable troops in any battle on Dal Quor or as Inspired shock troopers on Eberron. These quori relish battle. They serve as the infantry under a du'ulora's command. Every tsoreva wants only to die well, returning as an honored soldier to the Dreaming Dark. Not all is evil within the Plane of Dreams, however. The ancestors of the kalashtar were the largest group of rebel quori ever known, counting even the kalaraq Taratai among them. Amid the incarnations of conformity and hatred on Dal Quor, a few free thinkers still hide.

The organization known as the Dreaming Dark is composed of the personal agents of *il-Lashtavar*. Quori are immortal, yet they do not know their entire history. They have no recollection of events that occurred before the Age of Monsters on Eberron. Studying this, quori sages concluded that Dal Quor itself undergoes cataclysmic cycles. When the cycle turns, the plane implodes and then explodes. The *Quor Tarai* is transformed and reborn, as are all the spirits tied to the plane. Dal Quor and the quori will always exist in some form, but the quori of the future might have nothing in common with the quori of the present. In fact, evidence suggested that the next age could be radically different. One of the wisest of the quori was the kalaraq named Taratai (see above), and she claimed that *il-Lashtavar* would be replaced by *il-Yannah*—a great light that would banish the nightmare at the heart of the realm. The raw energy of the quori might survive the turn of the age, but personality and memory—everything that defined them—would be destroyed.

For a race of immortals, this was a truly terrifying prospect, and it galvanized the quori to action. They were determined to find a way to stop the turn of the cycle, to preserve the darkness forever. A few quori disagreed, saying that the cycle must be allowed to run its course; chief among these was Taratai. Those loyal to *il-Lashtavar* hunted these heretics until the spirits were finally forced to flee Dal Quor, in time becoming the kalashtar. Even after hounding the heretics from their

plane, the quori continued to study the problem, finally coming to the conclusion that the answer must lie in Eberron itself.

One of the few things the quori know about the previous age of Dal Quor, the age of the Dreaming Heart, is that as it came to a close, the quori entered Eberron and came into conflict with the giants of Xen'drik during the Quori-Giant War. The kalaraq lords of the Dreaming Dark believe that control over the mortals of Eberron might allow them to control the destiny of Dal Quor. Opinions differ as to how this can be accomplished. The dominant belief is that two steps are required. The first is to realign Dal Quor with Eberron, repairing the damage done at the end of the Age of Giants by the Moon Breaker. The second is to gain control of mortal society and, more importantly, mortal dreams. Every night, the dreams of the sentient beings of Eberron shape Dal Quor. The lords of the Dreaming Dark believe that if all mortals can be forced to dream one dream, Dal Quor will never change.

It is this secret philosophy that shapes the nation of Riedra. The Inspired do not conquer for the sake of riches or even power; most quori far prefer the nightmare realm of Dal Quor to Eberron. Serving as one of the Inspired is a chore most would just as soon avoid. They do so to preserve the *Quor Tarai* and thus themselves. The Inspired provide their Riedran subjects with food, shelter, and security. The price for all that is their freedom. If the Lords of Dust or the daelkyr achieve their goals, they will tear the world apart. By comparison, a world under Inspired rule would be safe and stable, but utterly without freedom.

The kalashtar are the spiritual descendants of Taratai and her allies. They believe that the *Quor Tarai* must turn. Furthermore, they feel that the nature of the *Quor Tarai* reflects on Eberron, and that if they can transform darkness into light, they can bring a new age of enlightenment to Eberron. They have believed that they do not need to defeat the Inspired to attain victory. For most kalashtar, prayer, meditation, and simple survival keeps the world moving on the Path of Light. Recently, however, doubt has begun to rise. Many young kalashtar think that their people must be more active in the world, taking the battle directly to the Inspired.

When dealing with the kalashtar and the quori of the Dreaming Dark, a few important points should be kept in mind. First is the arrogance of these races. Both believe that their struggle transcends Eberron. Most kalashtar are noble persons who seek to battle corruption and evil, but they still feel that humans have no place in their war. The Dreaming Dark, on the other hand, sees humans as nothing more than tools and playthings. Second is that even the potent quori do not have all the answers. They do not know exactly why their predecessors invaded Xen'drik. They do not know what caused the end of the last age in the Plane of Dreams, and this is one reason the Inspired are

acting carefully and cautiously. Many feel that the dramatic action of the Dreaming Heart quori in invading Xen'drik might have hastened their downfall. So the quori are seeking knowledge of their predecessors in the giants' ruins of Xen'drik, and plenty of mysteries remain that only heroes can unravel.

The Changelings

Changelings are subtle, shapeshifting humanoids capable of disguising their appearance. They evolved through the union of the race of doppelgangers and humans, eventually becoming a separate race distinct from either ancestral tree. Changelings do not possess the full shapechanging ability of a doppelganger, but they can create effective disguises at will. This ability makes them consummate spies and criminals, and many changelings live up to that dark potential.

Changelings strongly resemble their doppelganger lineage, with only a passing nod to their human heritage. All changelings usually stand between 5 and 6 feet tall. Unlike true doppelgangers, changelings do have gender in their natural form, although they can adopt any shape they like. Changelings have pale gray skin, and their hair is thin and fair. Their limbs are long and slightly out of proportion compared to other humanoids. Their faces have slightly more distinct features than a doppelganger's, including a hint of nose and lips, though their eyes remain blank white and the rest of their facial features do not look quite as finished as those of a human.

In general, changelings are prudent and cautious, preferring to take risks only when they feel that their chances of success are good or the payoff is worth it. They appreciate the finer things in life and take great pleasure in the comforts of a wealthy lifestyle when they can obtain it. They avoid direct confrontation, preferring stealthy strikes and hasty retreats whenever possible. In conversation, they are soft-spoken but have a gift for drawing out more information than the other party intends to reveal. Changelings live wherever humans do in Khorvaire, blending in among them and living in their shadow. They are most commonly found in the large cities of Khorvaire, where they form the backbone of the criminal underworld, though many find more respectable work as entertainers, inquisitives, government agents, and sometimes adventurers. Changelings have no established homeland of their own.

Members of most other races have a clear answer to the question "Who am I?" Dwarves are clever workers of stone, stable, and skillful in battle against goblins and giants. Elves are graceful and observant. Half-orcs are strong and gruff. Each of the civilized races has a sense of belonging and the comfort of the society of others like them. They are accepted by and accepting of others of their kind. Not so with changelings. The mutability of changelings means that they have no one clear place in

the world. Most changelings live scattered among communities dominated by other races. These other races view them with suspicion. While a minority group with a stronger sense of self might react to this prejudice by banding together and forming a strong community of their own, changelings are anything but unified as a species. Many changelings view each other with suspicion, too, and are often prejudiced against their own kind.

Passers are the most human-like of changelings in their thoughts and perspectives. They are ordinary people. They just want to be part of a community and live their lives. A passer endeavors to repress or deny his mutable nature. Since living as a changeling brings suspicion and distrust, passers use their minor shapechange ability to fit into society more easily, to “pass” in their chosen communities. Each most likely has one form he chooses and keeps. Most often, it is human, but in a community not dominated by humans it matches the majority race. Some so thoroughly adopt the new identities that they closely identify with the races portrayed. They rarely travel or adopt other identities. Becomers, reality seekers, and many changelings who have chosen more adventurous lives view passers with contempt, calling them “actors” or “pretenders” who have denied their true selves.

For becomers, living is being not just one person, but many people. These changelings actively use their minor change shape ability and live life in many different forms. They disguise, deceive, and lie as needed to further their individual goals. At the core of a becomer’s identity is the belief that the central aspect of a changeling is his mutability. To fully be a changeling, one must change, convincingly and frequently. For many, however, there is a purpose and integrity to these changes. A becomer considers himself simultaneously to be both a mutable changeling and the individual he portrays.

A few changelings reject the passers’ notion of conformity at the cost of identity and spurn the becomers’ philosophies of transience and impermanence. These deep thinkers believe that there is an ultimate Truth, a Perfect Form, and a Way of Being. Reality is out there, and it can be sought and understood. Their quest is to discover what is real. The reality seekers, also known as perfecters, prefer their natural form and the society of their own kind. These changelings hold strong. Most do not engage in deception, but the definition of deception varies among them. Some reality seekers find any thing remotely deceptive to be disgusting, while most hold this high standard only in reference to their own kind and feel that absolute truth and integrity are only due other changelings. Since the Last War ended, many reality seekers have looked with envy or admiration at the struggles of the newly free warforged and some of their attempts to develop communities. Building on this idea, several utopian changeling communities led by reality seekers have formed in various parts of Khorvaire.

The Shifters

Shifters, sometimes called “the weretouched,” are believed to be descended from intermarriage between Sarlonan humans and natural lycanthropes, now nearly extinct on Khorvaire due to the Silver Purge. Shifters cannot fully change shape but can take on animalistic features—a state they call shifting. Shifters have evolved into a unique race that breeds true. Shifters themselves believe that they actually preceded lycanthropes as a distinct race and that it is the werebeasts who are a corrupted version of them. There may be some truth to this theory as the shifters possess a distinct culture with its own traditions and identity that they brought with them from Sarlona, where their race most likely originated in the Tashana Tundra region that is still home to the Qiku tribes of shifters.

The personality and behavior of shifters are influenced by their animal natures. Many are boorish and crude, while others are quiet, shifty, and solitary. Just as most lycanthropes are carnivores, shifters have a predatory personality and think of most activities in terms of hunting and prey. They view survival as a challenge, striving to be self-reliant, adaptable, and resourceful. Shifters are humanoid in shape, but their bodies are exceptionally lithe. They often move in a crouched posture, springing and leaping while their companions walk normally alongside. Their faces have a bestial cast, with wide, flat noses, large eyes and heavy eyebrows, pointed ears, and long sideburns (in both genders). Their forearms and lower legs grow long hair, and the hair of their heads is thick and worn long. Many races feel uncomfortable around shifters, the same way they feel around any large, wild predator. Of course, some grow to appreciate individual shifters despite their natural aversion, and halflings in general get along well with them. For their part, shifters are accustomed to distrust and do not expect better treatment from members of the other races, although some shifters try to earn respect and companionship through acts and deeds.

Shifters have no land of their own. Being descended from human stock, shifters live in human lands. Unlike changelings, however, shifters often live in rural areas away from the crowded spaces of the cities. They are most commonly encountered in the Eldeen Reaches and other remote areas that can be found in all the nations. Many shifters earn their way as trappers, hunters, fishers, trackers, guides, and military scouts. The fact that none of the dragonmarked houses includes shifters cements their place outside the mainstream of Khorvarien society.

Most shifters incline toward the druidic religion of the Eldeen Reaches, believing in the divine power of Eberron herself, the elements, and the creatures of the world. The most powerful shifter clergy are an order of druids known as the moonspeakers. The moonspeakers tied great meaning to

the movements of Eberron's moons, believing that the moons' ties to the shifters' lycanthropic heritage gave them great power over the lives of shifters. Those shifters who revere the pantheon of the Sovereign Host are drawn toward the deities Balinor and Boldrei, while other shifters follow the Traveler. Shifters rarely worship the Silver Flame, for obvious reasons.

Spread over many nations and nearly always a minority population, shifters struggle to maintain a sense of racial unity and a cohesive view of their society and culture. Despite the efforts of community leaders and others who work to preserve a uniform vision of shifter society, two distinct types of shifter community on Khorvaire have become prominent. The first, and by far the most numerous, is a small enclave of shifters within a larger community of some other race, most often humans. These enclaves are welcomed by some shifters, since they give members of the oft-shunned race a sense of community and belonging much greater than what they receive from the general populace. Others view these enclaves as subtle traps, preserving the rift between shifters and the other races. In light of the unpleasant effects of the Silver Purge on shifters, such concerns are well-founded. Although shifter parents are as dedicated to raising their children as the members of any of the common humanoid races, the family group is not the core of shifter society as it is among many other civilized races. Instead, shifters form their strongest emotional bonds with a group of friends near their own age. When compared to the social interactions of other races, these peer groups are loose, disorganized affairs that emphasize the shifter's self-reliance and personal space more than the cohesiveness of the group.

The second type of shifter community exists apart from the Five Nations, usually sheltered deep within the forests of the Eldeen Reaches. Whether driven by the Silver Purge, the repercussions of the Last War, their own traditions, or the simple desire to live free of the nations governed by other races, many shifters have gathered into barbaric tribes and scattered communities across the wild lands of the Reaches. These communities reinforce the shifter's preference for bonding with fellow shifters rather than members of other races and the shifter enclaves in the cities of other races resemble these shifter-only communities more than they resemble the surrounding cities. While shifters are not isolationists, they greatly prefer the company of other shifters, for few members of the other races understand that the shifter's reticence and personal distance are respectful in their own way, and members of other races often seek out frequent social interactions—interactions that feel in many ways invasive to the shifter's sense of privacy and self-reliant attitude.

The Warforged

As part of the Treaty of Thronehold, the document that ended the Last War, two important decisions regarding the warforged were agreed upon. First, at the insistence of Breland, the status of the warforged changed; they were no longer property, they were people. Second, House Cannith was forbidden to produce any new warforged; the creation forges were shut down and destroyed. Some nations, such as Thrane and Karrnath, sidestep the property clause through “indentured servitude,” forcing their warforged to work as *de facto* property while promising them freedom once they have worked off their debt to the state for their creation. Many people regard the warforged with suspicion, anger, or fear, but the living constructs have begun to find a level of acceptance they never imagined attaining when the war first ended.

Warforged do not reproduce. The vast majority of warforged roaming the continent of Khorvaire are veterans of the Last War. The oldest among them date back to the original production run thirty-three years ago; the newest emerged from the creation forges just over two years ago in the last days of the war. Older warforged tend to be fighters or barbarians. The more recently created warforged, especially those less than five years old, are more inclined to try different career options, particularly in the divine and arcane professions. Two sources of new warforged currently operate in secret. Merrix d’Cannith, grandson of the original creator of the warforged, continues to run an illegal creation forge in the bowels of the city of Sharn. Here, he continues his grandfather’s and father’s experiments. Sometimes he places the new warforged in his employ, sometimes he sells them to special clients, and sometimes he sets them free to see how they choose to survive in the world (a good source of warforged adventurers). To preserve his secret, Merrix is circumspect and runs the creation forge only sparingly. The other source hides within the ruins of the Mournland, where the renegade Lord of Blades controls the remains of the Cannith forge that once operated in the forgehold of Whitehearth in Cyre. He has not really mastered the process, and the forge was damaged in the disaster that destroyed the nation, so he can only produce new warforged slowly and in small numbers—and even then, some of the warforged who emerge from his creation forge show signs of defects and mutations.

Warforged are constructs, but they are not machines. Warforged have bodies composed of inorganic materials like steel and stone but also of living magic. In this way, warforged combine technology and magic in an unparalleled manner. During the Last War, most warforged were discouraged from taking any interest in magic or their own construction. The only practice of magic taught in the House Cannith training halls was that of the artificer, and House Cannith strictly

controlled the training of the few warforged selected for that duty. Thus, most warforged think very little about magic and attach no emotion to it. Magic and how it interacts with a warforged body hold no interest for most warforged beyond pure practicality. A warforged values magic that aids him, particularly magic that repairs his body. Warforged enjoy the ability to accept magic into their composite plating and to graft particular magic items to their bodies, but few warforged are curious about how or why either process works. Still, some warforged, mainly those who have taken up spellcasting, are beginning to investigate their pasts and the rumored links between warforged and the ancient magic of the quori who invaded Xen'drik. These few seekers of knowledge see the discovery of the means to create warforged and *docent* components as a strategic goal.

The Treaty of Thronehold gave warforged their freedom, but only after great debate. House Cannith and Thrane argued ardently that warforged were not living creatures because they do not possess souls. Their evidence for this was that warforged cannot become undead by any known method, not even ghosts or wraiths. They are immune to energy drain, and no one knows of a warforged soul in Dolurrh, the Realm of the Dead. Breland argued that because warforged can be raised from the dead, they must have souls. Of course, House Cannith and Thrane countered that no warforged brought back from death told tales of any kind of afterlife. In the end, the Question of Souls, as that portion of the negotiations came to be known, was left unanswered. Warforged were freed because they could exhibit independent thought and free will. Today many people continue to think of warforged as creatures without souls, and citizens of Thrane often refer to warforged as “the soulless.”

Thirty-three years ago, Aarren d’Cannith created the first sentient warforged of the present era. Other constructs similar to warforged had been created before, but the warforged that emerged from the creation forge on that day marked the successful end to a long series of experiments with the goal of creating living, thinking constructs. House Cannith had been creating constructs built for labor, exploration, and defense for some time before King Jarot, growing ever more paranoid about threats to Galifar, urged Merrix d’Cannith, Aarren’s father, to build constructs designed for war.

For armies of constructs to march on the fields of battle, the constructs needed to be able to think for themselves, and up to that point, even the most intelligent constructs to emerge from the creation forges required minders to give them commands and control their actions. The new intelligent constructs also needed to be inexpensive to build; although an army of intelligent golems would be unstoppable, Merrix d’Cannith realized the Kingdom of Galifar lacked the resources to pay his house to build such an army. After the kingdom split, Merrix devoted all his energy to the concept of sentient construct soldiers, but his son made the first breakthrough, using documents dating back to

Kedran d’Cannith that some say originated in ancient quori ruins that had been explored by Kedran in Xen’drik. When the secret of warforged creation was discovered, the creation forges of House Cannith began selling warforged to whomever could afford them. Breland, Cyre, and Thrane had the largest forces of warforged, but most of the various factions in the war boasted at least a small contingent of the soldier constructs. Warforged participated in all the important battles of the Last War, on the side of at least one of the various parties in the conflict.

Warforged distinguished themselves in the Last War due to their speed traveling long distances, their tirelessness, and their fearlessness in the face of overwhelming foes. They also surprised many with their rather mutable loyalty. Although warforged were unquestionably loyal to their owners, it was found that a captured warforged’s concept of who owned it was often easy to change. Many battles during the Last War were fought for the sole purpose of capturing an enemy’s warforged. Such battles imperiled the capturing force, since the need to use nonlethal tactics against constructs that were under no such constraints made combat doubly deadly. As the war progressed, new types of warforged emerged from the creation forges. Most were made by request in limited production runs, but some were experiments driven by House Cannith. Of these, the warforged scouts and warforged chargers (see the *Edition 3.5 Monster Manual III*) were the most successful products, but they still paled in comparison to the success and the numbers of normal warforged that were built to fight the Last War. Early in their employment in the Last War, certain warforged distinguished themselves greatly in battle after battle, and their growing skill in the tactics and strategies of warfare could not be ignored. Aundair was the first nation to promote a warforged to a true command position. Previously, warforged had been given only temporary field commands, usually only until a human commander could reach the battlefield (Human commanders often lagged behind warforged forces due to their need for rest).

The Kalashtar

The kalashtar race has existed for only eighteen hundred years. It began in Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams, where the kalaraq-caste quori Taratai and her quori followers of light were being hunted down and exterminated by the agents of the Dreaming Dark, the foul collective consciousness that ruled that plane. But there is more to Dal Quor than the realm of the Dreaming Dark. Every sentient creature on Eberron touches Dal Quor when it dreams, and every soul, every race, shapes its own piece of the fringes of Dal Quor. Fleeing from the Dreaming Dark, Taratai led her followers on an exodus through mortal dreams. While the quori could not travel physically between the planes as a result of the Quori-Giant War and the destruction of the world’s thirteenth moon, Taratai believed

that she had found a way to cross through the subconscious realm of Dreamspace on Dal Quor's fringes and into mortal bodies on Eberron—provided that the proper portals could be found and that the hosts could be convinced to accept the travelers.

For a year Taratai and her quori traveled from dream to dream, passing through the dreams of dragons and beasts, never finding a place to rest. The Dreaming Dark's agents were still baying at their heels, and between the Dark and the dangers of the dreams themselves, Taratai's followers were slowly being destroyed. Finally, Taratai found the passage she needed in -802 YK—a subconscious conduit into the mind of a monk named Hazgaal from the mountainous nation of Adar on the southeastern tip of the continent of Sarlona. She knew that she could not maintain the connection for long, but she pleaded her case to Hazgaal, who was the master of the monastery—and to her surprise, he agreed to accept her band of fugitive spirits. Adar was the land of refuge, he said, and no creature would be turned away.

Sixty-seven Adaran men and women—including the Master Hazgaal himself—volunteered to share their bodies with the renegade quori spirits. In order to establish a permanent bond and truly escape from Dal Quor, it was necessary for the quori to merge fully—spiritually and mentally—with their human hosts, creating a synthesis of both personalities. These were the first of what Taratai called the *kalashtar*, a word in the Quori language that roughly translates as “wandering dreams.” It took time for the *kalashtar* to adapt to their new existence, but they were finally free from the Dreaming Dark.

In Hazgaal's body as the *kalashtar* Haztaratai (though many stories still call her Taratai), Taratai continued her studies of the nature of Dal Quor and the Dream of the Age, and she developed the traditions that are the core of the *kalashtar*, and now Adaran, faith called the Path of Light—a series of practices and devotions that she believed would accelerate the turn of the age in Dal Quor.

There was only one uncertainty for the first generation of *kalashtar*: What would happen when one of the *kalashtar* died? Before they found the answer to this question, another mystery was revealed: that of birth. When the first *kalashtar* child was born, they found that the quori spirit that was tied to the parent now also had a bond to the child. The spirit, Harath, found that it took more of an effort to communicate with either of his human hosts, but that he was nonetheless aware of the experiences of each.

Over the next few centuries, the process continued. As more and more *kalashtar* were born, the quori spirits were spread thinly among them, and it became almost impossible for the spirit to communicate directly with the *kalashtar*. The memories and basic personality were still there, however; even if they could not communicate, the spirits were still alive and conscious, experiencing

the world through the eyes of hundreds of descendants. Each generation of kalashtar was more physically distinctive than the last, and each lived longer than the one before; it was clear that the spiritual symbiosis between human and quori was having a minor physical effect on the quori's human hosts as well. As they slowly adapted to better suit their spiritual companions, the kalashtar began to develop potent psionic abilities. The kalashtar did not have access to the full psychic power of their quori ancestors, but they still had astonishing abilities. They could fly, send messages from one mind to another, and transform their bodies into living weapons. It was a time of wonders.

The kalashtar were born in the mountains of Adar, the mountainous refuge nation of Sarlona. Descended from the quori, a race of immortal and alien spirits exiled from Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams, kalashtar have endless patience and a firm conviction that their traditions will some day usher in a golden age for all living beings of Eberron. They do not want to change in any way; they know what needs to be done to fight the Dreaming Dark, and they will continue until they succeed or have been destroyed. This attitude is reflected in the rigid monastic lifestyle of the Adarans, which has remained unchanged and uncontested for more than a thousand years. Almost all of the kalashtar live in one of the eight temple-fortresses that dot the mountain sides. What time is not spent in meditation or prayer is devoted to defense of the realm, holding the natural battlements of Adar against the endless onslaught of the Inspired of Riedra. The Adaran kalashtar have no time for cultural change and no reason to believe that change is necessary.

Things are different on the continent of Khorvaire. The kalashtar of Khorvaire come from a variety of backgrounds. Some migrated to Khorvaire before the Inspired arrived on Sarlona, blending quietly into the humans of the Five Nations before the Kingdom of Galifar united them. Others have been sent by kalashtar elders over the course of the last few centuries. Some came to study Khorvaire, while others were sent away to ensure that kalashtar society could not be eliminated in a single blow by the Inspired. The kalashtar of Khorvaire have more interaction with other cultures and do not have to deal with the constant distraction of war.

As a result, the kalashtar of Khorvaire are generally more optimistic and innovative than their Adaran counterparts, and they enjoy experimenting with new things. The kalashtar population of Khorvaire is split between a number of racial enclaves in the major cities of the continent. This pattern has largely been driven by the war with the Dreaming Dark. The Inspired might be able to arrange for the destruction of a small rural community, but they would never get away with smuggling an army into Sharn. By placing themselves in the capitals of Khorvaire, the kalashtar are also able to monitor the activities of the Inspired ambassadors: They already have strong roots in the cities the Inspired are now working to infiltrate. They cluster together not because they are

uncomfortable around members of other races, but because they need the sense of safety in numbers, and it is easier to spot the actions of the Dreaming Dark in a closed system. Within a kalashtar community, the most influential form of social group is the lineage—the quori spirit that a kalashtar is bound to. This is not the same as a family group. Kalashtar inherit the spiritual bond from their parents, but the bond is always based on gender; a son always takes the father’s bond, while a daughter inherits from the mother. Thus, each lineage is composed of a single gender. All members of a particular lineage think of the others as brothers or sisters, even if they are actually distant cousins at best. Most kalashtar live with other members of their line.

There is no tradition of marriage among the kalashtar. Members of different lines socialize together and procreate (with the children being adopted and raised communally by the others of their lineage), but it is difficult for a kalashtar to imagine living with a member of another line for the rest of his life. In Khorvaire many old traditions are being questioned, however. The kalashtar respect age and wisdom, and most kalashtar communities are governed by a council with a representative from each lineage that has a presence in the community. Conflicts between lines are uncommon; the greater threat of the Dreaming Dark has always held the kalashtar together through periods of possible unrest. The method used to select a representative varies by lineage; in general, the leader is simply the person who has the overall confidence of his line, and it will change if that confidence is ever lost. The different communities are linked by lines of psionic communication; most communities have one psion who can manifest *correspond*, which is used to check in with the guiding councils of the other cities in Khorvaire and the elders of Adar.

As a whole, mental discipline is part of kalashtar life, and this is reflected by their well-ordered society. Kalashtar generally act in the interests of what they consider to be the greater good, and mercy, kindness, and hospitality are important virtues within their society. Well-mannered visitors are always welcome, though a shadow watcher keeps a sharp eye on outsiders until he is certain they are not agents of the Dreaming Dark. Most other people find kalashtar communities to be austere; the disciplined kalashtar have few vices, and most donate any extra income to the community in the interests of defense, so they have few luxuries. But they are capable of enjoying life without much in the way of material goods, taking pleasure from the company of their kin. Some humans find this admirable, while others simply find it to be disturbing—because humans cannot understand the mental bond between kalashtar of the same line, the level of cooperation and lack of conflict between them often seems unnatural.

The Daelkyr

The daelkyr were the lords of the Far Realm of Xoriat, the Plane of Madness. A daelkyr resembled a perfectly formed athletic human male, possessing unearthly beauty and pupilless white eyes. Despite this outward appearance, daelkyr were actually sexless and did not reproduce, since they were formed from the chaotic fabric of the plane of Xoriat itself.

A daelkyr's horrible touch caused disease and biological corruption, and its very presence could trigger madness and confusion. At least six daelkyr (possibly more) inhabit Eberron in the present day. The surviving commanders of the daelkyr army that invaded Khorvaire millennia ago, they were sealed deep in Khyber and cut off from their home plane. For thousands of years, the daelkyr have bided their time in the depths of Khyber, waiting for Xoriat to be able to touch Eberron once more.

The daelkyr are immortal and endlessly patient, and their manner of thinking is almost impossible for mortals (or even other planar denizens) to understand. For the daelkyr, destroying worlds appears to be a form of art, and until Xoriat and Eberron are again linked, the daelkyr are indulging their other sordid escapades. Some are poets, musicians, or sculptors, although their works are invariably bizarre and alien to human senses. Their preferred canvas is flesh, for they are the makers of monsters. Dolgrims, dolgaunts, foulspawn, beholders, mind flayers, neogi, tsochar and other hideous aberrations are the legacy of the daelkyr—living weapons created expressly to destroy life. The subterranean citadel of a daelkyr lord usually supports a garrison of dolgrims, dolgaunt and foulspawn lieutenants, and illithid commanders. Each daelkyr also has its personal, unique biological creations, reflecting its own aesthetic tastes. One might have a preference for oozes. Another breeds psionic vermin, while a third crafts hideous and deadly carnivorous plants. Their experiments—creating new races by twisting existing creatures into new forms—take time. A daelkyr can magically shapechange a creature into something else easily enough; however, creating a new species of aberration such as the dolgrim and dolgaunts (created from Dhakaani hobgoblins captured during the Daelkyr War), foulspawn (created from almost any “normal” race infected by the taint of Xoriat) or neogi (fleshcrafted from the dwarves of the Ironroot Mountains) takes years to accomplish.

The ancient primal seals placed by the Gatekeepers trap the daelkyr beneath Eberron and keep Xoriat from becoming coterminous with the world again, but the daelkyr have not made a concerted effort to destroy these seals. Their motives are inscrutable—above all things, the daelkyr are the lords of the Plane of Madness. Insanity and corruption are the currency they deal in.

Organizations of Khorvaire

The Aurum



The Aurum was a shadowy alliance of some of Khorvaire's wealthiest individuals, and the organization sought to use the power of gold and platinum to increase its political and economic influence across the continent. From its headquarters at Krona Peak in the Mror Holds, this organization espoused a selfish philosophy dedicated to expanding its control over many of the institutions of the Five Nations for its members' own gain and they kept their true intentions intensely secret.

The Aurum was born in the Mror Holds. Even before the Last War and the Mror dwarves' declaration of independence from Karrnath, various members of the powerful dwarven clans had joined together in a secret fraternity designed to increase the wealth and power of its members. With the collapse of the Kingdom of Galifar and the rise of an independent dwarf nation, the members of the Aurum began to look beyond the Ironroot Mountains to both expand their influence and draw in new members.

Guildmasters, crime lords, merchant princes, nobles, and members of dragonmarked houses, among others, joined the secret society at the original dwarven members' invitation, and slowly the Aurum became more than a simple fraternity of the economic elite and self-described masters of the multiverse. Between the influx of new blood and the devastation of the Last War came a rush of new ideas for profit-making schemes, which resulted in a new sense of purpose for the cabal. The Aurum hides its true activities from the world. It claims to the Khorvarien public at large to be an innocent society for wealthy and eccentric students of history; many of its members have impressive personal collections of rare historical tomes and relics of ancient civilizations. Many members of the Aurum truly are interested in history, archeology and the past of Eberron, because they intend to use the lessons—and powerful magical artifacts—of the past to shape the future.

The Aurum's organization is divided into four levels, called Concords—which are divided between copper, silver, gold, and platinum ranks. A higher Concord rank provides a member with greater access to the resources of the Aurum and a greater voice in determining the society's machinations. An Aurum member's rank is based both on their personal influence and the services they can provide for the cabal. A powerful heir of a dragonmarked house gains a starting rank in the Gold Concord, while a minor guildmaster in the employ of one of those house's guilds starts in the Copper Concord. In time, any member has the chance to advance to the Platinum Concord based on their own increasing influence and successful service to the cabal. Most members believe that the Platinum Concord manages the affairs of the Aurum, but the true masterminds of the cabal form an even more rarefied inner circle known as the Shadow Cabinet. The Shadow Cabinet exists outside the structure of the Concords and works to manipulate the nations of Khorvaire. The dwarf rogue Antus ir'Soldorak chairs the Shadow Cabinet and also serves as the Chancellor of the Platinum Concord.

The Aurum acts as a resource for its members to achieve their own personal goals rather than as an active force in and of itself. Its members share their knowledge and resources to improve their personal fortunes or to defeat common rivals in politics and business. The hidden Aurum ministers of the Shadow Cabinet, however, believe that the feudal aristocracy of the Five Nations has no place running Khorvarien society. The Aurum believes that the various kings and queens make excellent figureheads for the common folk to look up to and believe in, but no individual noble has the wisdom or understanding of commercial matters required to actually rule their societies efficiently. The outbreak and duration of the Last War proved this assertion to the Aurum's satisfaction, and the leaders of the Aurum intend to see to it that any future wars are fought only to serve their own interests. To this end, they have been recruiting agents throughout the governments of the Five Nations and the dragonmarked houses, targeting ambitious people who already possess some amount of power and influence and who display none of the crippling effects of excessive morality.

Aurum Concordians wear a plain ring on each finger—eight in all. Members of the Copper Concord wear copper rings, members of the Silver Concord wear silver rings, and so on. More a symbol of status than a precious bauble, each ring has the same value as 10 standard Galifaran coins fashioned from the same kind of metal.

The Chamber

The Chamber consists of dragons from the continent of Argonnessen who want to take a more active role in the world, and their servants of many of Khorvaire's common races. Many, perhaps most of these people do not realize that they work for dragons. This secret organization watches for the emergence of dragonmarks on the "lesser" races, and believes that the draconic Prophecy should not just be studied and contemplated, but actively assisted so that its verses come to pass sooner rather than later.

The Chamber was formed by younger Argonnessen dragons who believed that the Prophecy demanded their participation in the world beyond their continent rather than just the older policy of watching the Prophecy unfold passively. Older wyrms reluctantly allow the Chamber to exist, so long as its members keep a low profile and do not do anything that endangers the outcome of the Prophecy or the dragons themselves (which in elder wyrms' minds is essentially the same thing). To this end, dragons belonging to the Chamber either watch the activities of the humanoid races from afar or use magical means to disguise their true nature when they move about in the world of humans.

The Chamber has little formal structure or hierarchy. Its members share knowledge as warranted, even keeping dragons that are not part of the group informed about their findings and observations if that will help alleviate the Chamber's somewhat precarious political position back home in Argonnessen. Some dragons of the Chamber spend decades disguised as members of the humanoid races, serving as advisers to Khorvaire's monarchs or silent observers of the doings of men and women. Only when a Chamber member reveals his true nature do the leaders of Argonnessen take an interest in the group's activities, and if any dragon is believed to threaten the entire draconic community through his dealings with the common races, he is dealt with quite harshly by the Eyes of Chronopsis, the powerful guardians of draconic law and custom. Members of the Chamber or its agents among the common races may approach adventurers to help in some long-ranging scheme or plan to propel a specific interpretation of the Prophecy forward. Most often, the adventurers never realize that their patron in such situations is actually a dragon.

The Chamber is a loose alliance of relatively young dragons. Its members share resources (including their agents), and have established a network of safe houses and support across Khorvaire and at the port of Stormreach in Xen'drik. The dragons gather and share information, and those with common goals sometimes work together. Still, the dragons of the Chamber have very divergent interests. Some wish to recover lost draconic artifacts from the Age of Demons. Some want to observe the lesser races, to determine the role they play in the unfolding Prophecy. Others oppose

the Lords of Dust and other forces who seek to manipulate the Prophecy towards ends that could hurt the dragons. A few wish to manipulate the Prophecy towards specific outcomes themselves. All dragons of the Chamber are working in the interests of Argonnessen and the dragons as a race—the Eyes of Chronepsis quickly eliminate a dragon who threatens his homeland. But an outcome that is good for Argonnessen might very well be devastating for the people of Khorvaire.

Although the dragons of the Chamber cooperate, each dragon has his own network of agents. Dragons of the Chamber rarely fight one another, but if they are competing over a particular turning point in the Prophecy, they have no difficulty setting their humanoid agents at odds. The Chamber is a young organization by draconic standards, fewer than four thousand years old. Most Chamber observers are mature adults or younger. Some older dragons are tied to the Chamber, including those who founded the organization. Most of these elders, however, have returned to Argonnessen to guide activities from the Tapestry, leaving their children to directly manage their interests on Khorvaire.

The Chamber can be an excellent patron for adventurers, because its members possess wealth and the knowledge required to draw adventurers into the Prophecy. The key is that the Chamber is unpredictable even as a patron. These dragons are always looking to the distant goal, and even a friendly dragon might sacrifice nondragon lives for what he sees as the greater good.

Each DM must decide exactly how much influence the Chamber has had on the course of Khorvaire's history, but any number of critical events could have been set in motion by the Chamber. It is possible that a precursor to the Chamber instigated the migration of humanity to Khorvaire because that group foresaw that it was the only way humans would develop dragonmarks, which to this day do not develop among the humans or other races of Sarlona. Likewise, the cabal might have encouraged the formation of the Kingdom of Galifar to place political limits on the power of the dragonmarked houses.

The Tapestry of Argonnessen is the region of that continent where the Chamber is located. The Tapestry is the youngest and smallest of the territories of Argonnessen, born less than four thousand years ago. The founders of the Tapestry wanted to bring dragons of different colors together, to set aside the idea that influence and age were inseparable, and to consider new ideas about religion and the draconic Prophecy. Initially, these dragons' efforts received little support from the Conclave of Argonnessen, but they continued, predicting a great change in the shape of the Prophecy.

Then the first dragonmarks appeared, proving the younger dragons to have been correct in their belief that the younger races did have a major role to play in the unfolding of the Prophecy. In the wake of this event, the Conclave agreed to provide the young dragons with territory to continue their work. This land came to be known as the Tapestry of Thought, since it was intended as a land

where all colors of dragons would come together as one. In time, the Conclave agreed to let the dragons of the Tapestry act abroad, and so the Chamber was born.

The Tapestry was founded on the idea that all dragons should have an equal voice, setting aside the traditional hierarchies of age and color. The Tapestry holds its own conclaves at Vorel'arux, the Valley of Beauty. All dragons are invited to participate in the discussions and voting, but in truth few do—few dragons are as interested in the administration of the territory as they are in the acquisition of knowledge. The Tapestry is the home base of the Chamber. In the Tapestry, dragon mystics, prophets, and sages continue their work, while their elders defend the activities of the Tapestry and the Chamber before the ruling Conclave of Argonessen.

Both the Eyes of Chronopsis and the more conservative wyrms of the Conclave have grave doubts about allowing dragons to intentionally interfere with the outcome of the Prophecy, and many wish to shut down these activities and force the dragons of the Chamber to rejoin the broader draconic society. For now, however, the Tapestry remains a crucible for new ideas.

The Dreaming Dark



The Dreaming Dark, a secret order of psionic spies and assassins, serves as the eyes and hands of the quori in Dal Quor, the Plane of Dreams. They are the ultimate servants of *il-Lashtavar*, the “Dreaming Dark” or *Quor Tarai* of Dal Quor, the collective consciousness of the plane. While the order generally seems to be allied with the Inspired lords of Riedra, the goals of the Dreaming Dark are subtle and mysterious—and always deadly. This malevolent organization makes its headquarters in the city of Dar Jin, in Riedra. Its secret symbol is an eye partially concealed under a black wing. When used as a badge of office, the style of the eye indicates the position of the bearer in the organization’s hierarchy.

For a thousand years Riedra has been an insular land of mystery. The Inspired wear secrecy like a second skin, and foreigners are not allowed into the lands of the Sarlonan empire. For much of the history of Riedra, there was no contact between the Inspired and the other inhabitants of Eberron, but in recent decades this wall has been lowered as some trade and commerce has opened between Riedra and the nations of Khorvaire; foreigners are still not allowed on Riedran soil save in specially

prepared foreign quarters of two major ports, but Inspired ambassadors can be found in most of the royal courts of Khorvaire.

Even so, the Inspired have long maintained a network of spies stretching across Eberron, even before the break-up of the Kingdom of Galifar in the Last War (for which they might be responsible, as part of a plan to produce another Sundering, this time in Khorvaire, from which their agents can emerge to pick up the pieces). For centuries the Dreaming Dark simply watched the world from the shadows while the Inspired built their power within Riedra. Now the quori are ready to act in the rest of the world to continue their conquests, and the Dreaming Dark serves as their hands.

Should he ever be confronted with the actions of the Dreaming Dark, a Riedran ambassador would deny that his nation had anything to do with the organization. This assertion is actually true. The Dreaming Dark is a separate organization whose leaders dwell in Dal Quor itself. The Dreaming Dark provides information to the Riedran court, but the Inspired rulers of Riedra have no authority over the agents of the Dark present in Eberron; in fact, an agent usually holds a higher place in the hierarchy of Dal Quor than a Riedran governor.

The agents of the Dreaming Dark in the world are the Inspired, human vessels that now hold quori spirits. Some agents use disguises to blend in with the local population; others pose as kalashtar. With a variety of insidious psionic disciplines at their disposal, they can observe and gather information, and over the centuries they have built fifth columns within some nations and dragonmarked houses. As a result, the Dreaming Dark has influence over multiple Khorvarien criminal organizations, trade guilds, and academic institutions. It has agents in dragonmarked houses and royal courts across the the continent and the world.

The Circle of Night, made up of the most powerful psions among the Inspired, coordinates the activities of the Dark's agents. The leader of the Circle, and of the Inspired themselves, is known as the Devourer of Dreams (or the Dreamer), and he serves a still greater power—the collective spirit of the quori, located in the heart of Dal Quor. The Devourer of Dreams can commune with *il-Lashtavar* at the heart of Dal Quor without being absorbed and destroyed. Physically, the agents of the Dreaming Dark are scattered across Eberron. However, when one of the Inspired sleeps, its spirit returns to its body in Dal Quor where it can commune with all the other quori and the Inspired. The Dreaming Dark is a secret order that does not bargain with other organizations. Its greatest enemies are the kalashtar of Adar and the priests of the Path of Light.

Agents of the Dreaming Dark follow one of three paths. Thoughtstealers are the spies of the Dark and they are often guided by tsucora-caste quori spirits. Dominators twist the thoughts of others, and they are usually powerful telepaths tied to hashalaq and usvapna-caste quori. Last are the

dreamblades, the assassins of the Dreaming Dark. Most dreamblade Inspired are bound to tsucora-caste quori, but a few are tied to du'uloras or usvapnas. The Dark has an elite corps of dreamblades trained to fight psychic foes. Such specialists are deployed against kalashtar and rogue shadows (mind-seeded agents who have somehow turned against their Inspired creators).

The Dreaming Dark has no official presence in Riedra. It is highly decentralized to prevent its detection. Nonetheless, the bastion city of Dar Jin contains facilities that function as headquarters for the Dark on Eberron, especially for those agents moving between foreign assignments. Dul Catun, Dar Ulatesh, and Dul Mirn are centers of the shadow lines, the families of Chosen especially bred for possession by the quori of the Dark. The kalaraq-caste Devourer of Dreams is the overlord of the Dreaming Dark and the ultimate leader of the quori. Between his many duties and the risk—however slight—that someone on Eberron could bind him, the Devourer rarely leaves Dal Quor. In his absence, the most influential member of the Circle of Night that governs the Dark is the dominator Tirashana, a ruthless and deadly usvapna-caste quori who has spread a network of mind-seeds across Eberron.

The Library of Korranberg

Located in Zilargo's southeastern-most port city, the Library of Korranberg is the greatest repository of general knowledge in Khorvaire. In addition to serving as a resource for scholars and explorers, the Library often funds expeditions to study ancient cultures or unexplored lands.

The gnomes of Zilargo have an unparalleled thirst for knowledge; this inquisitive spirit gave birth to the Library of Korranberg. A loremaster of the powerful Korran family became obsessed with the theory that the deities of the Sovereign Host were in fact ascended dragons. This gnome, Dorius Alyre ir'Korran, swore that he would amass enough knowledge and information to surpass even the Sovereign Lord Aureon so that he could ascend and take the god's place. The Korran family invested considerable wealth in Dorius' weird obsession; even those who did not believe his theories of divinity were intrigued by the idea of a vast vault for knowledge. In time, Dorius died, but his Library remained. As the centuries passed, it continued to grow and expand. With the rise of the Kingdom of Galifar, gentry and aristocrats from across Khorvaire came to study at the colleges connected to it. Today, the Library of Korranberg plays a significant role in the economy of Khorvaire. It funds many expeditions to further the search for knowledge, and can be a valuable patron for adventurers.

The citizens of Korranberg take great pride in their Library. Citizens of the gnomish city may attend the colleges without charge, and every citizen of the city must devote four years of service to the Library. This service is considered an act of Zil patriotism and an educational experience. Many

choose to extend this period of service, accepting posts as lecturers, researchers, administrators, and other important roles. Each of the Library's eight colleges seeks to advance a particular field of study. Together, the colleges maintain the archives—vast vaults containing knowledge accumulated over three millennia of Khorvarien history. The doyens of each Korranberg college serve on a central council that manages the affairs of the Library. This council is run by an appointed member of the Korran family, descended from the founders of the Library. Like all politics in Zilargo, positions in the Library involve intrigue, blackmail, and scheming. The current high councilor, Alina Alrene, is a cunning gnome woman who has had to fight off many competitors within her own house to maintain her status and position.

The Library is based in Korranberg, but it keeps safe houses in the capital cities of every nation in Khorvaire. These satellite offices provide shelter for Library research teams. While the Library does not focus on the study of arcane magic as much as the Twelve or the Arcane Congress, it has had centuries to fill its vaults. The restricted archives and secret vaults are heavily defended and shielded against scrying and other forms of magical spying.

The Library appears larger on the inside than from the outside—and from the outside, it looks massive. When a researcher reserves time at the Library, a clerk provides a catalog stone—an orange-colored crystal keyed to the topics the researcher wishes to study. A private study cell is provided, which initially looks like a small pool of light in a vast, open darkness located somewhere in the library's extradimensional space. Within the pool of light, a desk, chair, work table, and narrow pedestal are placed for the researcher's use, along with quills, ink, parchment, and sealing wax. When the catalog stone is placed atop the pedestal, alcoves formed of shelves full of books and scrolls rush out of the darkness to create the walls of the study cell. When the researcher completes his work, removing the stone from the pedestal causes the shelves to fall away so that the researcher can exit the study cell.

The Lords of Dust



The Lords of Dust, a foul, evil cabal of rakshasas, night hags and other fiends who managed to escape being bound in Khyber by the Silver Flame at the end of the Great Dragon-Fiend War, have

been playing malevolent games with the common races of Khorvaire for thousands of years. They hide in the shadows of the continent, plotting to free their ancient masters, the fiendish *Na-Vakhti* or Overlords, from the depths of Khyber, scheming to use them to gain greater power, or spreading pain and suffering among the common races as is their nature. The group has bases of operation in the Demon Wastes and Aundair, among other places. The cabal uses a stylized silhouette of a broken tower to identify its members.

This cabal originated in the Demon Wastes in the years after the violent end of the Age of Demons and today secretly spreads its influence across the length and breadth of Khorvaire and the other continents of Eberron. In the Wastes, however, the fiends do not have to hide their true nature. For this reason, no matter how far they wander to manipulate the mortal races and hatch their complex plots, they return home at intervals to revel in their fiendish glory. The Lords of Dust are few in number, but their effective immortality makes them as powerful as it does unfathomable. These fiends serve the causes of chaos and destruction, seeking to set in motion slowly unfolding plans that will eventually lead to the utter collapse of order and virtue, serving the ancient cause of the Dragon Below.

Some members of the Lords of Dust never venture beyond the Demon Wastes, content to play cruel games with the human barbarian Carrion Tribes (see above) who worship them. When not engaged in such sport, these rakshasas and other fiends seek to find ways to release their ancient demonic Overlords who were long ago trapped beneath the broken land. Others among the Lords of Dust look to the trapped fiends as sources of power, content to let their masters remain imprisoned as long as they can draw mystical energy from them with which to make themselves more formidable. A faction within this ancient order is made up of Lords of Dust who travel the world, opposing the dragons of the Chamber and working to promote chaos and despair among the nations of the mortal races.

The Lords of Dust have little interest in complex hierarchies. The most powerful fiends occasionally gather in Ashtakala, the ancient capital of the rakshasas in the Demon Wastes, to discuss their current schemes and goals, but they have no single, overarching leader beyond the sleeping Overlords they serve. Membership is earned and kept through cunning and personal power. The organization also includes a host of weaker fiends, lesser rakshasas and other demons and devils content to serve the scheming lords.

A secret cabal of rakshasa and other fiends, the Lords of Dust have manipulated the destinies of the people of Eberron since the first days of Creation. The rakshasas wove themselves into the developing tapestry of human civilization on Sarlona and Khorvaire in its earliest days. When the

pirate queen Lhazaar gathered her first Rhiavaarian expedition for Khorvaire, there was a rakshasa adviser at her side (in a magical disguise of course). The question arises, however, that if the fiends of the Lords of Dust are so powerful, why have they not brought the world under their direct control? A rakshasa would answer, “How do you know we have not?”

The Lords of Dust had no desire to directly rule the kingdoms of mortals, since with such open power would also come difficult conflicts with Eberron’s other, equally powerful groups—the Dreaming Dark, the Blood of Vol, the dragons of Argonessen and other forces. Their goals stretch beyond the conquest of any one kingdom or even continent—if the fiendish Overlords are released from their ancient prisons in Khyber, the world itself, perhaps even all of Creation, will be remade for their benefit.

The simple hierarchy of the Lords of Dust is comparable to a pyramid, one largely based on each member’s raw and relative power at any given moment. The top rank belongs, as always, to the *Na-Vakhti*, the Overlords, who are rumored to number around thirty beings. These entities, immortal spirits also known as the rakshasa rajahs, ruled the lesser fiendish spirits at the dawn of Creation, but each Overlord is a completely unique being of immense, near divine power, who represents some aspect of the darker nature of the world. An Overlord is not simply a larger or more powerful rakshasa. Despite their vast power and their control of the world during the Age of Demons, the Overlords proved to be both careless and overconfident. They were defeated at the end of the Age of Demons by a powerful alliance of the dragons of Argonessen and the couatls of Sarlona and were bound by the collective divine spirit of the couatls—the Silver Flame—deep in Khyber, the Dragon Below. Today the Overlords are trapped in a state akin to torpor: they perceive reality on Eberron only through vague, dreamlike visions, as seen through the eyes of their most powerful fiendish (and sometimes mortal) servants. Because of the Silver Flame’s binding, an Overlord is not consciously scheming to expand his power across the world. But should he awake once more, he would possess a general sense of where the world stands and what his servants have been up to and he would expect them to bow to him once more.

The second rank of the Lords of Dust belongs to an organization called the Council of Ashtakala. Each Overlord has one particular rakshasa or other fiend with a particularly close bond to the rajah; these fiends are known as *prakhutu* or “speakers” in the fiendish dialect of the Abyssal tongue. *Prakhutu* have the ability to magically link their minds to the dreaming consciousness of their respective Overlord and so can divine his or her will. The Council of Ashtakala included all of the *prakhutu*, but also included a number of other powerful fiendish beings. The council took its name from the ruined fiendish city of Ashtakala in the Demon Wastes of Khorvaire, where the rakshasa

lords met to discuss their plans. The Council of Ashtakala's membership numbered more than ninety fiends, but only a handful of these creatures were actually in the ruined city at any one time.

Beneath the Council of Ashtakala were the Claws of Khyber. These rakshasa were the operational agents who carried out the day-to-day plans of the Lords of Dust. There were hundreds of these fiends scattered across every continent of Eberron. Many were sleeper agents who maintained a single identity for decades at a time. There were rakshasas hidden in Aerenal and even House Phiarlan who had maintained their covers for centuries among the long-lived elves through the judicious use of spells and magic items. Other claws maintained multiple identities, managing dozens of different operations within a specific city or kingdom.

Pawns, those mortals who willingly served the agenda of the Lords of Dust (though they did not refer to themselves with this term) made up the bottom of the organization's hierarchy. The rakshasas made use of thousands of people in carrying out their schemes, but most of these mortals never even knew that they were the tools of a broader fiendish agenda. Pawns might not understand the ultimate goals of the Lords of Dust, but they were usually loyal to their rakshasa contact. Often, a rakshasa making use of multiple identities maintained pawns that filled roles he was not currently playing, hidden by elaborate disguises and the use of magic. For instance, in the city of Passage in Aundair, a rakshasa's pawns might include a city official, a dragonmarked house heir, a beggar and a wizard of the Arcane Congress. At any given time, one of these people might actually be the rakshasa in disguise.

Lured by promises of wealth or even immortality, pawns of the Lords of Dust come from every walk of life. Some are born into families of pawns that have served the fiends as a sacred trust for generations. The barbarians of the Carrion Tribes of the Demon Wastes make up the largest group of these pawns. Each Carrion Tribe dedicates itself specifically to the worship of one of the Overlords and a rakshasa dedicated to that same rajah might bring barbarians of his allied tribe through the Wastes' Labyrinth to provide muscle for his schemes in the outside world.

While the Lords of Dust are referred to as a single, united organization, in reality the group is just a loose alliance. Each *prakhutu* has his own claws and each claw maintains a network of mortal pawns and unwitting agents. The members of the Council of Ashtakala try not to oppose each other directly. At times, they work at cross-purposes or simply choose not to aid another rakshasa whose schemes oppose their own. If one branch of the Lords of Dust in a particular city is discovered and wiped out, that does not mean the evil has been cleansed. There could easily be another claw hiding in the shadows, carrying out an entirely different agenda for his particular *prakhutu*.

The Lords of Dust have several goals, many of which they pursue simultaneously. The Lords of Dust, as noted, generally do not care about direct political power. They instead seek to increase their access to the only power they believe is really worth having—divine and arcane magic. The fiends of the Lords of Dust of all ranks are always seeking to discover ancient sources of magical power that they can cannibalize or acquiring new artifacts and magical items that can increase their personal power. The most ambitious of the fiends even seek to steal the power of the Overlords, hoping to take the place of their masters as the ultimate children of Khyber. The Lords of Dust also yearn for revenge against the dragons of Argonessen, the couatls and all those who serve the hated Silver Flame that keeps the Overlords imprisoned. The Lords are after the proverbial “big potatoes;” they would never risk revealing themselves to kill a single human cleric of the Silver Flame; rather the Lords of Dust would instead seek to corrupt the entire Church of the Silver Flame or lead the followers of the Flame astray into serving their sinister agenda. The Lords always seek to slay or humiliate a dragon, particularly an ancient wyrm. But the simplest and most basic goal of the Lords of Dust always remains to free the fiendish Overlords and restore the terrible dominion they held over the world during the Age of Demons.

The divine bonds of the Silver Flame will not be broken by any simple spell or magical item, even an artifact. Rakshasa diviners and night hag oracles have devoted literally eons to these mysteries and the libraries of Ashtakala contains hundreds of ambiguous prophetic scrolls on this matter that are nearly as open to interpretation as the draconic Prophecy itself. For instance, such a scroll might read, “When the realm of the dead again touches the Dragon Between, and the argent wyrm lights the path to the aegis of infinity, then will the Scar That Abides stir to wakefulness.” It is these maddening mandates that make the Lords of Dust so inscrutable and unpredictable in their actions. Their goals may take centuries to be realized. They may twist events simply to place a beggar on a throne so that his grandson might die beneath the light of the full moon of Aryth to release one of the Overlords. They might create religious cults, start wars or seek to wipe out entire mortal bloodlines in pursuit of a goal that still lies far in the future. Every few millennia, they may actually succeed in unleashing a horror upon the world that has not been seen for a million years.

The actual release of a fiendish Overlord from its prison was one of the greatest threats the world of Eberron could face. Lesser fiends of all races would rush to serve any released Overlord, who could possess the necessary power to free others of its kind from the grip of the Silver Flame. An Overlord could not actually be killed: the only hope was that some combination of forces from the mortal world could reestablish the divine binding magic that had originally held it, which could

require the wisdom of the draconic Prophecy. With its army of fiends, an Overlord possessed the power to overthrow entire kingdoms and perhaps even devastate a continent.

In the world of Eberron, powerful fiends, elementals and celestials are true immortals who exist beyond the possibility of death. Such beings are actually intelligent manifestations of an ideal or of one of the fundamental planes of Creation. These immortals did not reproduce naturally like mundane biological beings, but their overall numbers did remain constant throughout the eons. When an immortal fiend, elemental or celestial was killed, the energy that made up its life force or soul eventually re-coalesced to form a new fiend or celestial of the exact same species or type. These newborn immortals came into existence with an innate core of knowledge, including the history and culture of their particular society or plane—as a result, a newborn rakshasa, birthed in the depths of Khyber, was immediately aware of the existence of the Lords of Dust and his potential role in the organization.

Particularly powerful fiends, elementals and celestials were able to draw fully on the memories of their predecessor. More often than not, these entities retained even the same name and overall identity of their predecessor, though there might be obvious changes in the basic personality.

The amount of time it took for a spirit to reform into a physical creature varied tremendously; generally it took about a week of standard time, but this could be modified by the circumstances of the death. Killing a rakshasa with a normal blade might only eliminate him for about 24 hours; killing him with powerful divine magic could eliminate him for weeks or even a month, while striking him down on ground consecrated to the Silver Flame or the Sovereign Host with a blessed sword forged in his own blood might keep his spirit dissolute for as long as a year. While arcane magical means existed to bind and imprison the souls of such creatures, other fiends or celestials tended to take note when a mortal began binding large numbers of their kind and they could mobilize overwhelming force against such an unlucky individual.

While rakshasas and other fiends reincarnate after death, the fiendish Overlords simply cannot be killed. An Overlord who was utterly defeated in combat simply dissolved its physical body, along with all of its possessions. The Overlord would then reform within the depths of Khyber literally within hours and back at its full strength. Overlords can only be imprisoned, never slain.

Immortal fiends and celestials, even certain elemental beings, never needed to eat, drink or sleep, though not all beings from the planes were immortal. While such immortals did not create others of their own kind through sexual reproduction like the mortal races, they could infuse other beings with their basic essence through sexual or asexual arcane means to create hybrid beings: half-fiends, half-celestials, genasi, devas, tieflings and others. These beings might or might not suffer from

the effects of aging and other biological constraints, but they were not immortal and were not reborn after death, having to take their chances and forge their own destinies like all the other peoples of Eberron.

The one city of any real significance in the Demon Wastes is Ashtakala, the last citadel of the Lords of Dust and the only known surviving metropolis from the Age of Demons. Surrounded by a permanent arcane storm of sand and volcanic glass and shielded from all forms of divinatory magic, Ashtakala rarely reveals itself to mortal eyes. Explorers who somehow manage to penetrate the eternal dust storm find a bizarre yet beautiful metropolis, a citadel built from black basalt and brass. Compared to the shattered ruins of fiendish cities spread throughout the rest of the Wastes, Ashtakala seems impossibly alive, filled with thousands of demons, rakshasas, night hags and other fiends.

While Ashtakala appears to an observer as it did a million years or more ago, it is a city of ghosts and shadows—the image of a thriving city is but an illusion. In addition to the illusory inhabitants and the dark spirits of ancient things that still wander the decaying streets masked by powerful illusions of the city’s zenith, a handful of zakya and normal rakshasas and a host of minor fiends serve the greater Lords of Dust who congregate here. The Lords of Dust occasionally meet in this shadow of their ancient city, and rakshasas return to Ashtakala from time to time to scheme and to study in the vaults and libraries, reading scrolls and tomes that will crumble to dust if ever removed from the city. The power that preserves the image of Ashtakala transforms anyone who enters the city; visitors find their clothing and equipment altered to match the archaic fiendish fashions of the city. A city of fiends is a dangerous place for mortals to visit—only the luckiest of intruders caught by the rakshasa lords are allowed to die quickly, though never painlessly. All fiends return to Ashtakala eventually, sometimes spending centuries in its cold embrace, to remind themselves of the glory that was once theirs. The illusion comforts them with images of the Age of Demons, but it also fuels their hatred for the dragons who tore down their domination of the world and left only these ruins for the rakshasas to occupy.

The Lords of Dust are immortal like all fiends, and their motivations are difficult for creatures of flesh and blood to understand. Sometimes their actions serve a clear purpose; other times they seek to cause chaos for its own sake, toying with mortals like pawns on a chessboard. These games can continue for centuries, even millennia. It is entirely possible that the destruction of Xen’drik during the Age of Giants and the collapse of the Kingdom of Galifar into the Last War were ultimately engineered by members of the Lords of Dust—fiends subtly unraveling the threads of civilization to relish the suffering and pain that ensues as whole societies collapse.

The Lords of Dust are masters of deception, and they rarely deal openly with mortals. Rakshasas can read the thoughts of others and shift their shape to mimic any humanoid form, and they have infiltrated many governments, guilds, and other organizations. Even other schemers, such as the Aurum or the Cults of the Dragon Below, have been compromised by the Lords of Dust. But the plans of the fiends can take decades or centuries to unfold, and a rakshasa infiltrator may spend an entire human lifetime waiting for the right moment to make its move. So, almost any organization can be tricked into serving the agenda of the Lords of Dust, at least temporarily. The one force that knowingly serves the rakshasas is the human barbarian Carrion Tribes of the Demon Wastes.

Two powerful forces directly oppose the Lords of Dust: their ancient enemies among the dragons of Argonnessen and their agents in the Chamber, and the Church of the Silver Flame. The dragons helped to defeat the rajahs during the Age of Demons, and many among the Lords of Dust still yearn for vengeance. Whenever the Lords of Dust manage to identify one of the goals of the Chamber, they will seek to oppose it; in turn, the dragons do their best to expose or destroy rakshasa infiltrators and to prevent the release of their imprisoned masters.

The templars of the Silver Flame serve the same power that now holds the demonic Overlords beneath the earth, and they are relentless in their pursuit of this ancient evil. Mortal flesh can be weak, however, and members of the Church of the Silver Flame can be fooled, bribed, or corrupted by the powerful fiends.

The Lords of Dust are the purest manifestation of true evil to be found on a world like Eberron that is more often illuminated in subtle shades of gray than black-and-white. There is no place within the cabal for mortals, except as tools, playthings, and servants. Most often, adventurers fight against the Lords of Dust, either directly or by exposing their schemes. It is possible for heroes to be tricked into serving the Lords of Dust; a rakshasa in the form of a trusted ally could send them on a quest that causes more harm than good.

Morgrave University

Morgrave University is not the most reputable institution of higher learning in Khorvaire. It lacks the academic resources of the far more reputable Library of Korranberg or Wynam University in Aundair, and many claim that its archeological activities are infested with smugglers and treasure hunters. While the university lacks the clout of its peers in Korranberg and Aundair, it is much more accessible to young adventurers who have yet to build a reputation.

In the past, most nobles were educated in the colleges of Zilargo or Aundair. When Lord Lareth ir'Morgrave of Breland established his university in the city of Sharn two hundred sixty years ago in 738 YK, he claimed it would be “a beacon of knowledge shining from the tallest towers of the city, illuminating the forgotten secrets of the past.” While many city elders applauded Morgrave’s work as providing a major boost to the City of Towers’ cultural foundation, he had his enemies. Morgrave was said to have made his fortune selling ancient Dhakaani artifacts on the black market, and some claimed that the true purpose of the university was to assist him in his treasure hunting and provide a legitimate cover for his tomb robbing. Suspicions aside, Sharn’s proximity to Xen’drik has transformed Morgrave University into a nexus for scholars wishing to study the shattered continent.

The Master of Morgrave University is the oldest heir of the Morgrave line. Currently the university head is Larrian ir'Morgrave, a scholar who has spent decades studying the various civilizations of ancient Xen’drik. Morgrave University struggles to establish its academic reputation, and the sages and scholars on the faculty always watch for an opportunity to prove themselves. That said, Morgrave University’s reputation for corruption is well-deserved. Many priceless relics recovered from Xen’drik or Dhakaani ruins have been “stolen” from the university vaults, only to find their way to the black market or into the hands of the Aurum. Master Larrian has vowed to put an end to these acts of smuggling and profiteering by the university’s agents, but so far he has done little to back up his promises. Some people at the university do have ties to smugglers and thieves, but many of the Morgrave scholars truly believe in their work. A few of them have connections with the Library of Korranberg, the Wayfinder Foundation, and the Twelve. Obviously these ties are not strong enough to get one of them a post at a more prestigious institution, but an adventurer might be able to get a letter of introduction from one of the Morgrave sages.

The Order of the Emerald Claw



The reputation of the knightly Order of the Emerald Claw has gone from one extreme to the other since its formation. When it was established, the order was considered the ultimate expression of Karrnathi patriotism. Today, it has been outlawed and is seen as a terrorist organization working at

crosspurposes to the legitimate government of that kingdom. The secret truth beyond the origin of the order and the evil it serves is terrifying.

On the surface, the Order of the Emerald Claw appears to consist of a small number of fanatics dedicated to the military superiority of a Karrnath that does not want their devotion. In reality, the Order never had any interest in promoting or elevating Karrnath's national interests. Its true master, hidden to all but the top leaders within the organization, was the half-dragon lich Vol, the self-styled Queen of the Dead, who actually named the Order after her father, a green dragon known to the elves of Aerenal many millennia ago as the Emerald Claw. This seemingly small group is like an iceberg; the tip that rises above the surface is nothing compared to the mountain of ice hidden beneath the waves. The Order supports a vast network whose tendrils wind through all levels of Khorvarien society. It has eyes and ears in the halls of government, churches, dragonmarked houses, and private institutions across the continent. Some of its agents never reveal their true nature; others appear proudly in the knightly garb of the Order.

Vol uses the Order of the Emerald Claw to incite fear and terror, to cast suspicion on the actions of Karrnath and its leaders, to foment unrest, and to perform military missions that go beyond the capabilities of her followers within the Blood of Vol cult. Above all, the Order is another of the Lich Queen's tools in pursuing her ultimate agenda—vengeance against the Aereni elves and the dragons of Argonessen for the destruction of her family and the rebirth of the Mark of Death on Eberron. Knights of the Order scour the world for relics and artifacts of powerful magic, often necromantic in nature, that are useful to the Lich Queen. The members of the Emerald Claw are not above stealing arcane research from wizards and artificers to churn out new magic weapons for the Order or for Vol. The garb worn by the knights of the Order includes a distinctive helmet with a half faceplate, a tabard with the green claw insignia over chainmail, and a powerful flail.

The Trust

The gnomes of Khorvaire, ancient immigrants from Thelanis, have lived in the area known as Zilargo for thousands of years. Situated between the Howling Peaks and the Seawall Mountains, the Zil gnomes have thrived despite incursions by and conflicts with goblins, kobolds, and humans. They have always managed to maintain their independence, winning battles with words that they could never win with swords. After King Galifar I established his kingdom, he eventually set his sights on Zilargo. The gnomes met his forces in the valley north of Dragonroost and immediately surrendered. During the negotiations, the gnomes became an independent province within the kingdom. Galifar

left in victory, and the gnomes secured a safe place in the new united human kingdom—all without spilling a drop of blood. Relying on wisdom and cunning, along with elemental-bound items and illusions, gnomes can be surprisingly dangerous opponents. Zilargo's beautiful architecture fills the towns and cities of the gnome nation, and the streets vibrate with bright colors, song, and good cheer. Friendly, helpful inhabitants seem genuinely interested in talking with strangers, and theft and violent crimes rarely occur.

In truth, while the average gnome always makes time to listen to a stranger, this behavior has more to do with the gnomes' thirst for knowledge than with any true sympathy for outsiders. Gnomes believe that every piece of information, no matter how trivial, may someday have value. Zil society is bound together by a complex web of favors, secrets, and debts. For more than eight centuries, an invisible order of spies and assassins has been watching from the shadows, gathering information on all internal activities and using this knowledge to eliminate threats to gnomish society. Every citizen of Zilargo knows that anyone could be an agent of this secret order. Most gnomes actually are good-natured and cheerful, but there is always the chance that a friendly face masks more clandestine activities.

The Triumvirate rules Zilargo. This council, composed of a representative from each of the major Zil cities of Korranberg, Trolanport, and Zalanberg, was originally founded as an oversight committee to monitor the behavior of students and patrons of the Library of Korranberg. The powers and duties of the Triumvirate slowly expanded over time to cover the entire nation.

Each of the three Zil cities has its own Council of Nine, gnomes drawn from wealthy families who manage local civic concerns. In theory, the city's representative to the Triumvirate is democratically selected from its council. In practice, the process is anything but democratic, as secret wars of words and blackmail determine power within each council.

The Trust, the secret order that upholds gnomish customs and protects Zil society from internal and external threats, reports directly to the Triumvirate. It has a coordinator in each city who works with the local Council of Nine. Few realize that the Triumvirate possesses an impressive vault of information concerning political, military, and economic activities that rivals that of the Library, thanks to the work of the Trust.

The Twelve

An arcane research institution and academy funded by the dragonmarked houses after the War of the Mark, the Twelve operates out of a thirteen-tiered keep that floats above the capital city of Korth in Karnath. As part of the agreements that ended the War of the Mark, Hadran d'Cannith suggested that the dragonmarked houses work together to create an institute for the application of arcane magic—a foundation that would study dragonmarks and the more traditional forms of magic for the benefit of all the houses' interests. The keep was built by Alder d'Cannith, a visionary wizard and master fabricator who used his studies of the sky to determine that the keep should possess thirteen towers. "The moons suggest that the perfect number of dragonmarks is thirteen," Alder cryptically explained, "but we shall call the institution the Twelve, for the thirteenth mark was cast off long ago." No one argued with him (While the elves remember the Mark of Death once borne by the elves of House Vol, it is a topic they wish to forget. Aside from the elf leaders of Aerenal, few know the truth behind the lost dragonmark). Over the centuries, the institute has been responsible for many arcane advances. The artificers of the Twelve helped develop the elemental airships operated by House Lyrandar, for example, as well as the message stations of House Sivis.

As an arm of the dragonmarked houses, the Twelve attempted to remain neutral during the Last War. However, many of the wizards and artificers of the Twelve had national loyalties that were stronger than their ties to the institute, and they chose to leave to fight in the war on behalf of their individual states. Quite a few fell in battle. Now that the Twelve has resumed normal operations with the end of the Last War, it seeks to replace its fallen members and make sure that each house is represented.

The Committee of Twelve oversees the institute. The committee actually has more than thirteen members; there are twelve dragonmarks, but the split of House Phiarlan and House Thuranni and the current troubles within House Cannith have caused the membership to fluctuate. The Twelve has access to a tremendous array of mystical supplies and funding, and the greatest wizards and magewrights of Khorvaire fight for workshop privileges at the institute. Advances made at the institute are shared equally among the houses, although there are always rumors of one or more of the houses diverting funds for secret projects or attempting to conceal valuable discoveries.

As an institution, the Twelve seeks to advance the arcane arts. In particular, the Committee of Twelve looks for magical developments that have practical value to society and, more importantly, a potential for profit. The Twelve has a great deal to offer arcane adventurers. It has access to considerable stores of rare mystical components and a vast library of spells. Even the mundane can

find the Twelve to be an invaluable asset, because the sages at the institute can quickly identify unusual magic items or artifacts. However, being a prestigious organization, the Twelve will not deal with adventurers until they have developed a positive reputation.

King Galifar I, not completely convinced of the dragonmarked houses' neutrality and altruistic outlook, established the Arcane Congress above the village of Arcanix in Aundair as direct competition for the Twelve. Today, the two institutes of magical studies engage in a more or less friendly rivalry for resources, students, and arcane discoveries.

The Wayfinder Foundation

In his youth, the Aundairian Lord Boroman ir'Dayne was a great hunter and explorer. He led the only expedition ever to reach the continent of the Frostfell and return to tell the tale. He wrestled ogres in Droaam, fought chuuls in the Shadow Marches, and was the first halfling to travel to Xen'drik and return. Dayne amassed a fortune in his day, but during his final expedition to Xen'drik he contracted a slow, wasting curse that no healing magic has been able to reverse. He has a few years of life left, and while he no longer has the strength to explore on his own, he still wants to unlock the mysteries of the unknown. To this end, he dedicated his fortune to establishing the Wayfinder Foundation—a guild for adventurers and explorers that funds dangerous expeditions to exotic locales, as well as giving bold adventurers a place to display their trophies and tell tall tales.

The Wayfinder Foundation is an exclusive organization. Membership is by invitation only, and offers are extended only to renowned adventurers and explorers. The Wayfinder Conclave manages the affairs of the Foundation. The conclave meets in the capital of Aundair at Fairhaven, and all decisions are resolved by a majority vote. As long as he still lives, Lord Boroman ir'Dayne has the final say on all expenditures of Foundation funds, even overriding decisions of the conclave. Despite his skills, Dayne has been crippled by the wasting curse and rarely leaves the Foundation's enclave in Fairhaven.

Boroman ir'Dayne is a true philanthropist; he wishes to have his name attached to the great adventures of the future, since he himself can no longer participate in the adventures of the present. His one ulterior motive is the hope that an explorer may discover a cure for the strange wasting curse that is slowly sapping his life. Of course, many of the members of the Foundation are more interested in personal wealth or glory than in increasing the reputation of the Wayfinders or pursuing scholarly exploration. The Wayfinder Foundation is very much an alliance of individuals, and each Wayfinder has a distinctly different personality. The Foundation today has a major enclave near the city of

Stormreach in Xen'drik—the continued exploration of that mysterious continent is one of the primary goals of the organization today.

The Wynarns

King Galifar I established a royal dynasty almost a thousand years ago that continues to rule parts of Khorvaire in the present day. When Galifar united the Five Nations under his banner, he gave each of his five eldest children regency over one of the human kingdoms that made up his new empire as prince-governors. His descendants continued this practice as age and the number of offspring allowed, so that for most of the reigns of the Galifaran kings and queens, their children learned leadership by governing parts of the empire and were therefore more or less ready to step onto the throne when the monarch abdicated or died. Succession went to the oldest scion of each generation—at least until the death of King Jarot and the succession struggle that led to the Last War.

Today, the descendants of Galifar ir'Wynarn continue to play instrumental roles in the politics and governance of Khorvaire. Three of the four remaining Five Nations are still ruled by the Wynarn family, and the fourth nation's royal family, while not on the throne, has some influence in the governing of the nation.

Queen Aurala ir'Wynarn rules Aundair, and her extended family and loyal nobles administer to the needs of her people. From the capital city of Fairhaven, Aurala commands all she surveys and plots to use the calm of the current peace to launch a storm that sees her claim the Galifaran Crown for her own. Aurala lacks the military might to achieve this goal by force, but she has come to rely far more than her predecessors on the Aundairian throne to achieve her vision through the use of diplomacy, intrigue and espionage.

King Boranel ir'Wynarn leads the royal family of Breland from an ancient castle in the Brelish capital city of Wroat. Older than the other rulers of the Five Nations and with heirs that have as yet not inspired love and devotion, Boranel worries about the fate of Breland when his head finally becomes too weak to carry the Brelish Crown.

King Kaius III, in actuality the vampire lord (and his own great-grandfather) King Kaius I, rules the kingdom of Karrnath. Few among his court or subjects know the truth about Kaius's identity or nature. He maintains the military dictatorship that has served his state well, while working to stabilize the peace and turn his nation into a more progressive society.

The Blood Princess Diani ir'Wynarn leads the royal family of Thrane, which today serves merely as a figurehead in a society that is a staunch theocracy. Diani works in secret to make

deals with foreign powers and secret organizations like the Aurum in an effort to reclaim control of the government of her nation, but the Church of the Silver Flame has a solid hold on the reins of power in Flamekeep and on the affection of the Thranes and will prove difficult to overthrow.

Other members of the Wynarn family can be found throughout Khorvaire among the landed aristocracy. Perhaps the next most powerful of these is Crown Prince Oargev ir'Wynarn, the last remaining scion of Cyre's ruling family. A leader in exile, Oargev makes his base in the town of New Cyre, graciously provided by Breland for the refugees of the destroyed nation that is now the Mournland. Oargev desperately seeks to recover whatever items of worth and power can be taken back from the Cyran ruins in the Mournland and desires to learn who was behind the arcane explosion that destroyed his homeland and killed more than one million of his Cyran countrymen. Oargev also desires to rebuild Cyre and find some way to reestablish his kingdom.

Organizations of Sarlona

The Broken Throne

During the Sundering of Sarlona, the Twelve Kingdoms of the continent collapsed amid war and acrimony, and were eventually folded into the new unified empire of Riedra by the appearance of the Inspired. Age-old Sarlonan customs were wiped away, castles and cathedrals were shattered and left in ruins. People were told by the Inspired to forget the past. Sarlona had finally risen from the nightmare of war into an age of unity and peace.

Yet the pre-Unity past held as many wonders as terrors for Sarlonans. Art, religion, philosophy, magic—each kingdom had its treasures, and many of those jewels are still out there. Study of the past is forbidden to Riedrans, most of whom have no interest in it anyway, but others find its lure impossible to resist. Over the centuries, a secret Riedran movement has grown, an alliance of those who doubt the religious truths of the Path of Inspiration and seek to reclaim the Sarlonan cultures of the past. These rebels call themselves the Broken Throne. The Broken Throne is not a violent organization, and its members have no plans to fight the Inspired or try to overthrow their rule of Riedra. They simply want to preserve ancient traditions. To this end, they gather relics of the past, both in the form of physical treasures and knowledge. Illiterate Riedran recruits are usually taught to read in the ancient language of Old Common, so they can appreciate books and scrolls recovered from the ruins. Many learn the traditional crafts of their home province's former culture, long ago pushed into obscurity by the Inspired. A few study the religious traditions of Pyrine and Khalesh, the psionic teachings of the Maleeri wilders, or the arcane magic of the Corvaguran sorcerers and Syrk wizards. Members of the Broken Throne believe these are not the tools of dark spirits but are instead wonders to be shared and enjoyed.

The Broken Throne is most active in Riedran villages located near ancient ruins. Within the bastion cities, a few of its members hold significant positions in the Guiding Path, and these pathfinders help cells communicate with one another. A passive force, the Broken Throne takes no direct action against the Inspired. Nonetheless, the practices of the Throne are considered heresy against the Path of Inspiration, and the Thousand Eyes, the Riedran secret police, as well as most Riedran citizens, would ruthlessly eliminate any cell that was exposed.

Factions of the Inspired

The quori are far more unified in action and purpose than their counterparts in the Lords of Dust or the Order of the Emerald Claw. Should the quori fail in their task, *il-Lashtavar* and all of its children will be destroyed. The existence of their entire species is on the line, and as a result, the quori do not turn on one another lightly.

Still, some question the methods and authority of the Devourer of Dreams. Riedra has given those nightmare lords a structure to build their own followings. Lady Sharadhuna, the kalaraq-caste Inspired who currently leads the Thousand Eyes, is the Devourer's greatest political rival. Although Sharadhuna believes that the physical and mental control of humanity should anchor Dal Quor and prevent the turn of the age, she thinks that the Inspired's control of Sarlona is sufficient to accomplish this goal. Sharadhuna believes that the Devourer is pressing for continued expansion of quori control over Eberron not on the orders of *il-Lashtavar*, but because he draws psychic power from the pacified populace.

If Lady Sharadhuna is correct, the Devourer actually seeks to replace *il-Lashtavar*, assuming its place as the driving collective force of Dal Quor. Sharadhuna believes that the quori need be concerned only with fully securing Sarlona, including Adar, Syrkarn, and the Tashana Tundra to ensure the success of their plan to safeguard their existence. She resents the unquestioned authority held by the agents of the Dreaming Dark and believes that the Thousand Eyes is performing the most crucial work of the age in maintaining the Inspired's grip on Riedra. Sharadhuna is gaining supporters among the Inspired, and she hopes to find a way to supplant the Devourer of Dreams as the quori voice of *il-Lashtavar*. Still, she has no idea what such a transformation would require.

Yet another faction is led by Lord Zoratesh, the Inspired commander of the Harmonious Shield, the Riedran Army. He has no patience for the slow, subtle psychic manipulations of the Dreaming Dark, and he wants to launch an outright Riedran military invasion of Khorvaire to speed up the quori's control over all the dreaming mortal races of Eberron. In such a scenario, *psionic teleportation circles* would be used to launch sudden and decisive small unit strikes against the capital cities of the kingdoms of Khorvaire, seeking to eliminate nobles, dragonmarked barons, and other threats to an Inspired invasion. Both the Devourer of Dreams and Lady Sharadhuna believe that this event would be disastrous, providing a common enemy to unite the people of Khorvaire once more, destabilizing Riedran social cohesion and risking the ire of the dragons of Argonessen, the Lords of Dust, and other conspiracies currently watching from the shadows. Zoratesh currently lacks

the support required to pursue war, but if an Inspired invasion of Khorvaire were to happen, Zoratesh would be the one to lead it.

A war between the kingdoms of Khorvaire and the empire of Riedra would be a devastating conflict, with the widespread arcane magic of the Five Nations and the dragonmarked houses matched against the devastating psionic powers of the Inspired and their willingness to sacrifice their huge numbers of fanatical Riedran troops. Even if the Riedrans won the conflict, the Khorvariens would never accept defeat easily and would launch an endless string of uprisings, raids and guerilla insurgencies against the Inspired and the Riedran occupiers. The unity the Inspired brought to Riedra after the Sundering succeeded because the people of Sarlona mistakenly believed that the Inspired were the saviors of humanity, not its conquerors.

The Dream Merchants

People always want what they cannot have, and every new law creates a source of profit for those who challenge it. The major challenger to the ironclad laws of the Inspired in Riedra is a blackmarket cabal known as the Dream Merchants. The Merchants are smugglers first and foremost—they run dreamlily and other illegal Sarlonan goods to Khorvaire, and they provide a black market for Riedrans who want goods beyond the basic tools of survival provided by the Inspired. In the bastions, the Dream Merchants provide other criminal services: theft, forbidden information, fencing of stolen goods, even assassination. Such actions are extremely dangerous, and the costs of criminal services are four times those listed in *Sharn: City of Towers*—assuming the Merchants are willing at all. The Dream Merchants, while established in Riedran bastion cities, are rarely seen in the outlying villages. Individual merchants of the cabal sometimes travel between villages, posing as couriers for the local Inspired lords. They carry *bags of holding* containing a wide range of contraband goods they can exchange with villagers. Wandering Merchants are generally masters at sensing the motives of people who approach them. They are very careful about whom they reveal their true nature to, since one misstep could bring death at the hands of the Thousand Eyes. Although most Riedrans have heard of the Dream Merchants, common wisdom is that these people are the direct servants of the *altavars*, sent to tempt and test the devotion of the innocent. Loyal Riedrans always report such criminals immediately if they are discovered.

Dream Merchants can be found in most Riedran bastion cities. The Merchants also maintain a

number of outposts on the islands of Ohr Kaluun. Their strongest support on the mainland of Sarlona lies in Rhiavhaar—remnants of that lost kingdom’s freebooter spirit holding true. Most Dream Merchants are rogues; a few manage to unlock innate psionic talents.

The Edgewalkers



The Edgewalkers were founded in 390 Unity (88 YK), in response to a disastrous planar incursion in the Riedran province of Nulakesh. However, the group, which is today a special order within the Harmonious Shield, Riedra’s standing army, has its roots in the ancient Sarlonan kingdom of Khalesh.

Before the Sundering, the couatl-worshiping people of Khalesh sought to eliminate all supernatural threats in Sarlona. Although most Khaleshites were killed during the Sundering, their legacy lives on in the Edgewalkers.

The Edgewalkers are a military corps, but the hierarchy is simple and promotion is rare. The bulk of the members belong to the Order of Sentries, soldiers assigned to a specific region of Riedra. All soldiers begin with the rank of sentry. A sentry guide commands a squad of sentries. A sentry warden commands a small watchtower. These officer posts are generally held by Chosen, though a few gifted humans have risen to this rank. A sentry lord commands a fortress. Chosen who advance to this rank are usually tsucora or du’ulora-caste Inspired.

A lord commander coordinates Edgewalker efforts across an entire province. These posts are all held by Inspired. The supreme commander of the order is Lord Kaltarash, the Keeper of Seals, a du’ulora-caste male Inspired who is actually probably the least malevolent Inspired currently on Eberron and a quori whose personality is far closer in personality and beliefs to the rebel quori who became the kalashtar than most, though he remains loyal to the goal of his race’s survival. Kaltarash guides the Edgewalkers from the bastion city of Dar Mun.

A fraction of Edgewalkers belong to the Order of Inquisitors. There are no ranks within this order; technically, an inquisitor stands between the ranks of sentry guide and sentry warden, and the activities of the inquisitors are coordinated by the lord commanders. The seat of the Edgewalkers is

the bastion city of Dar Mun (population 19,320) in the province of Nulakesh. Dar Mun is located between four separate wild zones; two are tied to the plane of Shavarath, one to Daanvi, and one to Dolurh. Despite the Riedran Dar prefix, Dar Mun is an inland community; the Riedrans view it as a “world port” between the planes. In addition to holding garrisons and training facilities for Edgewalkers, Dar Mun has one of the finest (and only) arcane libraries and workshops in Riedra. A permanent *psionic teleportation circle* links the bastion to Durat Tal.

The Edgewalkers are Riedran heroes and always receive a friendly welcome in Riedran communities. Beyond Riedra, Edgewalkers are much less well-known; even in Adar or Syrkarn, few can tell the difference between Edgewalkers and other Riedran soldiers of the Harmonious Shield, and they react accordingly. The exceptions to this hostility are communities close to planar wild zones. Lord Kaltaresh has occasionally sent Edgewalkers to counter dangerous planar surges in Syrkarn and the Tashana Tundra. In these areas, locals might be friendly to Edgewalkers despite a hostility toward Riedrans in general.

Edgewalkers are trained to fight all forms of supernatural evil. They are not simply border guards; they often venture within the planar manifest and wild zones and might be called in by the Harmonious Shield wherever unnatural evil is found. Many of the creatures the Edgewalkers fight cannot be harmed by steel or crystal. Edgewalkers are blessed by the Inspired, and often have magical or psychic powers that they use to battle such evil spirits. The Sarlonan manifest and wild zones long predate the coming of the Inspired, and have posed a threat throughout recorded human history and probably before. Many of the Edgewalkers’ combat techniques are derived from the Order of the Silver Blade, a league of Khaleshite paladins that was wiped out when that kingdom was targeted by its enemies during the Sundering. Edgewalkers can be found near any dangerous wild zone. Depending on the threat presented by the zone, there might be a full fortress or simply a squad of Edgewalkers living off the land.

The Heirs of Ohr Kaluun

If any force still found in Riedra actually frightens the lords of the Inspired, it is the Riedran dissident group known as the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun. Long ago, before the Sundering of Sarlona, the eastern kingdom of Ohr Kaluun was a center for the study of dark and sinister divine and arcane magic. Its priests performed terrible rituals invoking the Dark Six, and its wizards and warlocks trafficked with fiends in their quests for mystic power. A significant segment of the population of Ohr

Kaluun were tieflings, the descendants of humans who had bred with fiends or absorbed fiendish power. In the Sundering, the people of this land were almost completely obliterated.

Some of the few who remain are skulks, transformed by foul spells so they could hide from their enemies. All loyal Riedrans know that the ruins of Ohr Kaluun are the haunts of *altavars*, and that the magic hidden within the war mazes is deadly and damning. Still, some do not care. The Heirs of Ohr Kaluun knowingly embrace this darkness, hoping to gain power to raise themselves above the Inspired. Humans, skulks, oni, dwarves—what binds these people together is a thirst for mystic knowledge and a hatred for the Inspired. Like the first wizards of Ohr Kaluun, they are willing to sacrifice anything—or anyone—to gain the power they seek. The Heirs oppose the Inspired, but anyone who allies with the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun out of hatred of the Riedran system soon learns that the enemy of an enemy is not always a friend.

Like the Cults of the Dragon Below in Khorvaire, the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun are not a unified force. The Harmonious Shield and the Thousand Eyes are always hunting these foul wizards and warlocks, and kill those they discover without hesitation. All tieflings, who comprise a significant percentage of the population of Ohr Kaluun and are often found among the Heirs, are also viewed with great suspicion by Riedrans. Many view tieflings as hosts to *altavars* much like the *kalashtar* and inhabitants of the bottom rung of the Path of Inspiration's racial caste system. But even when one group of the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun are put down, new sects always rise from the ashes, new innocents corrupted by the promises of the darkness. Despite their name, the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun are not confined to the islands of that region of Riedra. A Kaluunite wizard could easily take an interest in the forbidden lore of the yuan-ti of Syrkarn or the lost magics of the *aventi*.

The Heirs of Ohr Kaluun are the Riedran counterpart of the Order of the Emerald Claw on Khorvaire—they are the people who unquestionably serve dark designs. The Heirs willingly accept damnation (or so they believe within the context of the Path of Inspiration) in exchange for power and vengeance. They can be disturbing allies or unexpected foes for those exploring Riedra—a surprise for those who think the Inspired are the greatest evil in the land. The Inspired have conquered Riedra, but they at least take care of the people. If the Heirs of Ohr Kaluun took power in Sarlona, horror would replace the Inspired's stability and oppression.

The Horned Shadow

The Horned Shadow is a young alliance of ogres, oni, and eneko working to forge a new destiny for the ogre races of Sarlona. Within Riedra, these efforts are led by oni who have overcome their indoctrination in the Path of Inspiration. This is a very dangerous game, and the Thousand Eyes swiftly kill any ogre found to be working with the Horned Shadow. But oni are powerful and cunning—thanks to their illusionary powers and natural resistance to arcane magic and telepathy, many oni of the Horned Shadow have been able to avoid the gaze of the Thousand Eyes. The Horned Shadow has spent the last few years building support. As the organization grows, the masterminds of the Shadow debate the best course of action to advance their agenda. Some advocate a mass exodus from Riedra and the establishment of a new ogre kingdom in Syrkarn. Others insist on reclaiming the ogre homeland in the Riedran province of Borunan itself, even if this means the utter destruction of the ogre race in endless battle with the Inspired.

All is complicated by the fact that some of the followers of the Horned Shadow have less than noble intentions. A few oni simply want power for themselves. While they speak of freedom for the ogre race, these mad mages are interested only in bringing chaos and destruction to the world, spilling as much blood as possible as they carve out a new kingdom for themselves. Ogre members of the organization could be noble rebels or bloodthirsty killers whose love of battle comes before any ideals. Members of the Horned Shadow can be solid allies, but they can just as easily be disturbing adversaries, even to those who share their goal of bringing down the Inspired's rule.

The Unchained

The Unchained practice one of the most subtle and powerful forms of rebellion in a society like Riedra where the *hanbalani* monoliths control even what people think. The Unchained dream and they dream free of the Inspired's psychic influence. The founder of the movement was a Riedran human named Sulaan, a merchant who was fascinated by the free dreams he experienced in other lands like Khorvaire, when his mind was no longer subject to the Inspired's continuous nightly barrage of dream imagery. Sulaan eventually learned about the Dreamspace between Dal Quor and Eberron and how to use this extradimensional space to telepathically communicate through dreams. He decided to spread free dreams to the people of Riedra, believing that doing this was the key to change in the world.

Sulaan disappeared five years ago, and many assume that he was taken by the Thousand Eyes. However, some of the Unchained have received dreams of contact from Sulaan. None can say if these

are truly the work of the enigmatic founder, or if the quori are masquerading as Sulaan and using this guise to manipulate his followers.

The Unchained are loosely organized, and most members know only others in their own communities. A few gifted dreamers use their dreams to maintain communication between distant villages, but the Unchained have no grand scheme to try and overthrow Riedran society. Members work to identify others who share their ideas and to teach their free dreaming abilities. In the eyes of the Unchained, dreams alone can win the battle.

The Keepers of the Word

Led by Speaker of the Word Chanaakar, the Keepers of the Word are an amalgam of spellcasting traditions who serve as the spiritual (and therefore also political) leaders of the mountainous kingdom of Adar. Most of the Keepers' spellcasting traditions involved arcane magic and none overtly entailed the pursuit of a specific religion. This order came into being long ago with a covenant among arcanist exiles that sought to preserve their heritage. As the Inspired purged arcane and much divine magic from the lands that became Riedra, the ranks of the Keepers expanded. Their original stronghold is Kasshta Keep, but the siege of the Inspired and the loss of so many kalashtar of the line of Taratai at that battle taught the Keepers not to keep all their lore and members in one place. Representatives from and libraries of the Keepers of the Word exist in all of Adar's major monastery-fortresses. Even some small towns in Adar have a Keeper or two along with a Keeper library-shrine.

A Council of the Wise rules holdings, like monastery-fortresses, controlled by the Keepers of the Word. The Council is made up of individuals who have the confidence of the people they represent. Elders among the Keepers are titled "venerable;" the elder Thatari is referred to as Venerable Thatari, for example. The council selects a person as Speaker to guide discussion, focus on issues, and break deadlocks. In all cases, an elder can be removed if he or she loses the faith of the represented.

Knowledge and its preservation are most important, so many Keepers are dispassionate about other pursuits. However, the influence of Taratai and the kalashtar on the organization has been significant. Numerous Keepers respect the Path of Light, and some practice it. Many Keepers merely read, discuss, and teach the lore already possessed by the order. To a person, they are capable spellcasters. They preserve even techniques thought harmful to the mind or soul, for the sake of learning. Dangerous spells and magical objects are present within Kasshta Keep and other places the

Keepers call home. This policy can prove troublesome as some Keepers are corrupted by the forbidden knowledge and items available to them.

In Adar, the Keepers study the land, its strange phenomena, and its planar connections. They aim to someday connect with the draconic Storm Guardians of Adar and gather information on the draconic history of Adar. As much of this work is for its own sake as it is for some higher purpose. However, Chanaakar's time as Speaker of the Word has changed this situation to some extent, and some grumbling about this change might be heard behind closed doors.

The Storm Guardians of Adar

Legends on wings, the Storm Guardians are reputed to be a clan of blue dragons that calls the tallest peak in Adar, Korrandar, home. Many believe these majestic beasts are responsible for the storms that plague and defend Adar. Adarans imagine that a draconic heart beats at the center of every thunderhead that blows over the land of refuge. Those Adarans are close to correct.

In some ways like Rhashaak, the fiend-tainted black dragon who guards the ruins of Haka'torvhak in Q'barra (*Explorer's Handbook* 145), the Storm Guardians might be mythic figures, but they are real. They, however, have not been corrupted by their time in Adar or on the mountain of Korrandar. Concerned with the protection of a realm shaped long ago by dragon and couatl magic, the Storm Guardians watch from above and below. They count among their number dragon turtles and sea drakes that stalk the oceans around Adar (Such sea dragons often attack any flotilla that contains more than a few ships). Most of these dragons are aloof from mortal concerns, but their hold in Korrandar contains what could be considered the soul of Adar—the artifact known as the *Teeth of the Three*.

The rakshasa rajah imprisoned in Khyber shards under the surface of Adar sleeps only restlessly. It is wrath incarnate. The rakshasas name it Ran Iishiv in the Abyssal tongue, the Unmaker, and one could suppose that the *Teeth of the Three* are in place to keep it quiescent. This is not true, however, because the dragons would possess other such artifacts to quiet the other great fiendish Overlords if this was true. The reality is that the dragons foresaw a time when Adar would serve as more than the prison of a great fiend.

The Storm Guardians live by their duty to guard Korrandar and the powerful artifact it contains, and they are content to be legendary. While some folk near Korrandar have built shrines to the Storm Guardians and even lay valuables within as prayers for peace, the Guardians do not truck with mortals. Those who climb Korrandar are rarely seen again. Though the current Speaker of the

Word is a survivor of such a trek, he does not speak about it, like other similar persons from Adar's history.

The Endseekers

Within Adar boil manifest zones to the elemental realm of pure chaos—Kythri—and the whispers of Ran Ilishiv are said to be audible in the darkest shadows of the mountains. Some of the mystics, mages and warlocks who came to Adar found these places and gained power from them. The strange ways of fate drew many mad magicians together, and they coalesced around the desire to see the end of all that was created by the Progenitor wyrms.

Only dissolution—the utter unmaking of everything—can satisfy an Endseeker. Each one is a lost soul of sorts, often having seen dearly held truths melt away into the chaos of fate. To these arcanists, the multiverse and all of its motion are an abomination, and this travesty must be brought to an end.

Endseekers are usually quite mad, but it is an enlightened sort of madness. They know that something is underneath all of Creation, something from which everything came. It is not a god—it is greater than that, for it is everything and nothing at the same time. It is undifferentiated potential. Creation must be returned to this place.

Although a few Endseekers are malicious killers who randomly destroy, those who survive and flourish take calculated actions. A clever Endseeker might help a diabolic cult, then use his power or influence to set forces of good against that cult—internecine conflict culminating in mutual annihilation of the factions being the goal. Powerful Endseekers, or groups thereof, have networks and wide-ranging plans. The head of such an organization is the eye of calm in a maddening vortex. Seemingly unrelated plots all lead to that center. Endseekers do not work together as a unified whole, though, and might even be found opposing one another. Most Endseekers are arcane spellcasters, and a large number of them are warlocks who have infernal or dark pacts. Even stranger, many Endseeker masters are clerics, their “religion” centering on the divine notion of unmaking.

The Summit Road

Some dissidents within Riedra live long enough to escape, but few places in Sarlona are welcoming, and getting into Adar is not easy. Occasionally, Adaran warriors engage in sorties to bring the war to the Inspired or to get to other lands. Adar's defenders also need intelligence on

their enemies' movements along their borders. In sum, a need for spies against the Inspired and a secret way across Adar's boundary to and from Riedra is obvious. A clandestine Adaran organization called the Summit Road, or simply "the Road," performs these services.

When Adar shut its borders after repelling the initial attacks of the Inspired after the Unification of Riedra, the early focus was on fortifying all points of entry. It was during this time the Shroud was created. The masters of the monastery-fortresses, especially Kasshta Keep, Malshashar, and Shalquar, quickly found they needed a way to get into and out of Adar. This need was the genesis of the Summit Road.

Malshashar has always had friendly contact with the dromites of Zi'til'natek. Zi'til'natek's inhabitants had no love for Riedra's leaders. Preliminary crossings were through Zi'til'natek and underground ways were constructed for the purpose. In this time over a millennia ago, many would-be Riedrans still opposed the Inspired and sought escape to the land of refuge. Adaran warriors also crossed the border and took the fight to the Inspired on a small scale.

Conditions on both sides of the mountains soon stabilized as the Inspired settled in for a long siege of Adar rather than an all-out assault. Over time, more Riedrans became Inspired loyalists and the Adarans became more defensive and insular. The Summit Road evolved. Failed missions and subverted guides proved the need for strong will among Road members. Supernatural defenses were essential parts of any team, so the remaining leaders began to favor mystical recruits. During this growth phase, the Road also put forth tendrils, establishing bases in dromite city-hives under Riedra and even in the Syrk port of Ardhmen.

Summit Road guides call their leaders trailblazers—those who find new ways. New, probationary, and regular members have always been called guides, and most Road agents are guides for years before being named to the position of trailblazer. Guides have differing levels of esteem in the organization, but no official rank differentiates them. Those with less experience usually defer to those with more. Advancement is based purely on merit and is totally optional and based on the decisions of the existing leadership. No guide is ever forced to become a trailblazer against his will, which can be a sedentary job. Masters of the fortress-monasteries in Adar are nominally in control of the Summit Road. It is they who often ask the trailblazers to undertake some task for the good of Adar. The trailblazers in turn assign guides to a task, or even oversee a mission directly. Most trailblazers remain in Adar, so it is harder for the Road to be subverted by Inspired infiltration or mind-seed.

The Road is highly decentralized, like Adar's entire defensive infrastructure. Guides must speak or learn Riedran, and they learn special phrases and sign language that help them identify one

another and communicate secretly. Few outside the Summit Road know this underground language, and unauthorized persons who show such knowledge are often met with hostility.

Cells of the Road operate independently. A group of Summit Road guides is a highly specialized team usually composed of four to six members. Each member has skills that complement those of the others in the group. In this way, each Summit Road squad is a strong support system for its members. Like Adar itself, the Summit Road has no central operations center or capital. Guides work from the Adaran settlements and fortress-monasteries of Dvaarnava, Kasshta Keep, Shalquar Monastery, Malshashar, and even Zi'til'natek while the Road's trailblazers collect intelligence and run missions from these places as well as many others. Some Summit Road agents are stationed permanently outside Adar in the wilder Syrk settlements—especially Ardhmen. Information is shared between groups by psionic, magical, and mundane means, and teams of guides change their bases of operation as needs required. All Summit Road teams were expected to take circuitous routes from their starting points to prevent those origin points from being located by Riedran patrols.

Organizations of Argonessen

The Chamber

A more detailed description of the Chamber's activities can be found in the section entitled *Organizations of Khorvaire*. However, the Chamber is also an important organization in the affairs of Argonessen. The Conclave of Argonessen and the Eyes of Chronopsis both have serious doubts about the actions of the Chamber, and whether the cabal should be allowed to continue its work abroad. The surviving elders of the Chamber—the dragons who founded the movement—are now ancient wyrms. While the younger dragons explore the world, their elders fight to keep their order alive at home. The elder and ancient dragons of the Chamber include accomplished prophets and loredrakes, and their insights into the Prophecy have helped to mollify the great powers of Argonessen about the wisdom of their interference with the humanoid races. But it is an ongoing struggle, with no rest for the wise.

The Conclave of Argonessen

When the dragons first gathered to plot their rebellion against the fiends who controlled the world in the Age of Demons, it was the eldest among them who laid out their plans. This tradition continues to the present day. For a dragon, age is power, and the oldest of the dragons direct the destiny of their kind. It was the Conclave that brought an end to the age of draconic expansion, ordered the destruction of Xen'drik, and authorized the Chamber to operate among the humanoids of distant lands. Aside from their own personal power as ancient wyrms, the members of the Conclave command the military might of the Light of Siberys, and few dare challenge their rulings. Members of the Conclave come from all the territories of Argonessen. Each flight or dominion sends a single ancient wyrm to represent its interests; younger dragons have no voice in the Conclave. In theory, color plays no role. In practice, charisma and sheer might gives the gold, silver, red, and blue dragons greater influence than others. The council meets at the Great Aerie of the Thousand once every decade, with emergency sessions called as necessary. In these meetings (which can last weeks or even months), dragons discuss recent developments in the Prophecy, the actions of rogues and the Lords of Dust, and any news sent in by spies or dragon guardians. Issues are resolved through debate; ultimately a binding vote settles any disputes. Voting involves a major artifact, the *Orb of Ourelonastrix*. This vast crystal sphere is set into the floor of the Aerie's council chamber. Each

member of the Conclave sends a vote as a pulse of magical energy and the orb shows the results. The orb evaluates the mind of each voter, and indicates if a voter is under the influence of magical or psionic coercion. Dragons must physically attend the Conclave to vote. Those who do not wish to vote can take part in debates through arcane proxy.

To date, no nondragon has ever been allowed to attend a session of the Conclave of Argonessen. Nondragon servants—mostly stone giants and trusted children of Io'lokar—maintain the Great Aerie, but the meetings of the Conclave are attended only by dragons and their colossal iron golem sentinels. Any nondragon found to have spied on the Conclave without permission faces fearsome punishment.

To the casual observer, the Conclave appears to have little impact on the daily lives of the dragons. Still, the Conclave decides the direction of the dragons as a race. A decision made at any of the rare and momentous Conclave gatherings can change the shape of Eberron. It is in Conclave that the dragons could decide to destroy the dragonmarked houses, drive the Inspired from power, or bring a halt to the activities of the Chamber.

The Eyes of Chronepsis



No dragon of Argonessen can escape the baleful gaze of the Eyes of Chronepsis. The Eyes are a force of roughly one hundred and fifty elder dragons, hand-picked by the Conclave of Argonessen. Once chosen, they answer only to each other and the dragon deity Chronepsis; not even the Conclave can command an Eye of Chronepsis.

Established in the wake of Aureon's Folly, the Eyes of Chronepsis hold the power of life and death over all dragons on Eberron. They act as both judge and executioner in any case where a dragon threatens the stability of Argonessen or of the draconic Prophecy. They also monitor those dragons that live beyond Argonessen and eliminate any who place Argonessen at risk. The presence of the Eyes is the primary reason rogue dragons on the other continents keep a low profile. The Eyes do not care how dragons treat the lesser races, but a dragon whose actions are too obvious and disruptive could draw unwanted attention to Argonessen. In theory, the Eyes prevent dragons from sharing knowledge with the lesser races. The example of Vvaraak, however, shows that

either it is possible to evade the Eyes, or that the Eyes tacitly approved of her actions to spread the knowledge of primal druidic magics beyond Argonessen.

The Eyes of Chronopsis closely track the draconic Prophecy. Prior to the formation of the Chamber, it was the Eyes who battled the Lords of Dust and their agents to prevent the fiends from manipulating the Prophecy. However, unlike the Chamber, the Eyes have always been dedicated to observing the Prophecy without pushing it in any particular direction. If the rakshasas were trying to force a particular outcome, they would act—but if that same outcome came about naturally, they would simply stand aside. Even when they did act, the Eyes sought only to protect the Prophecy; it is not their mission to take the battle to the Lords of Dust or to fight the other forces of evil on Eberron. The Eyes watch. They gather information. They punish dragons who threaten the homeland. And they protect the Prophecy itself. All else is extraneous.

The appearance of the dragonmarks was a shock to the Eyes of Chronopsis. In the wake of this event, they agreed to allow the dragons of the Chamber to take a more active role in the wider world, and to observe the impact of the “lesser races” on the Prophecy. To date, they have been content to watch—but at any time, the Eyes of Chronopsis could demand an end to the activities of the Chamber.

The Eyes of Chronopsis watch the watchers—they are a force that even the most powerful dragons fear. However, they act only in truly dire circumstances. The actions of a rogue dragon cannot simply threaten Khorvaire; a threat to Argonessen must exist. Although the Eyes of Chronopsis might help adventurers by eliminating a dangerous dragon, they could also be a deadly foe. A dragon providing vital aid to the other races of Eberron—as Vvaraak did before the daelkyr incursion—could be targeted by the Eyes. Alternatively, the Eyes could strike against an organization that threatens the Prophecy—such as a dragonmarked house.

All of the Eyes of Chronopsis are elder dragons or ancient wyrms. Some specialize in scrying and divination, while others are trained in battle. One of the best-known figures among the Eyes is the Lightkeeper Silaesteron, an unaligned ancient male gold dragon who speaks for the Eyes when the Conclave gathers.

The Light of Siberys

A Khorvarien scholar who researches the Elf–Dragon Wars, or who manages to find records of the conflict that destroyed Xen’drik, cannot help noticing that the dragons fought as a disciplined force . . . as an army, not merely a band of admittedly powerful individuals. This break with draconic

isolation was the work of the Light of Siberys, a name used both for a geographic region in Argonnessen and for the dragons who live there. These soldiers have stood ready since the end of the Age of Demons. They guard the prisons of the Overlords. They maintain the borders of Argonnessen itself. And when the time comes for war, they organize the other dragons into a united force, bringing tactics and discipline to the battle.

Little truly threatens Argonnessen, but the Light of Siberys has faced plenty of challenges. The Soldiers of the Light carry out periodic, limited attacks on the elves of Aerenal—perhaps reconnaissance, perhaps training exercises, always short of full-scale invasion. The Light pursues the Talons of Tiamat, an activity that has become far more frequent of late. These militants have dealt with a number of other threats to Argonnessen that the people of the wider world have never even heard of, including planar incursions from the elemental realms of both Fernia and Risia. The Light of Siberys maintains an order of impartial mediators, whom other dragons can call on to attempt to resolve disputes. Finally, it is the Light of Siberys that patrols the longest border of Argonnessen—anyone who crosses Totem Beach must face the Soldiers of the Light.

Although dragons of the Light of Siberys have mastered military operations in large numbers, under normal circumstances they operate in squads of two to five, with the oldest dragon serving as squad leader. Dragons of all colors and all ages serve in the Light.

Within the Light of Siberys, rank is based on age and service; it is possible for a dragon to be placed in command of an older comrade, if he has superior military skills. However, this rank holds no significance outside the Light of Siberys. The Conclave can grant the Light authority to act in its name; otherwise, the dragons of the Light hold no special jurisdiction over other dragons.

Since every member of the Light of Siberys is a living siege engine, the structure of the Light is different from that of a human army. A squad of five dragons is a significantly powerful force; something as great as a full battalion of dragons is rarely required. Nonetheless, the Light has a hierarchy in place to manage engagements involving hundreds or even thousands of dragons. The ranks, in ascending order from lowest to highest, are as follows:

Soldier of Siberys
Lantern of Siberys
Guiding Light of Siberys
Beacon of Siberys
Radiance
Radiant Flame
Glorious Flame
Eternal Flame

The Talons of Tiamat



One shadow from the Age of Demons continues to haunt the dragons to this day: Tiamat, the Daughter of Khyber. Even in her prison, Tiamat holds the power to seduce and corrupt dragons—and some join her of their own free will, dreaming of the power they will possess when she is freed.

In Eberron, deities do not walk the earth. This is true even of the dragon gods. The dragons point to Bahamut's image in the sky, but the platinum dragon has never set foot on Eberron, and his existence is a matter of faith, not fact.

Although misconceptions abound, Tiamat's existence on Eberron is no exception to this rule, for she is not truly a god. Rather, she is one of the mightiest fiends of the Age of Demons, a true daughter of the Dragon Below. Each of the fiendish Overlords has its own mystical dominion; for Tiamat, that province is dragons. Khyber and Siberys were siblings, and the taint of Khyber lies hidden in every dragon—as it does in most mortals. Tiamat has the power to draw that out, corrupting and commanding the children of Eberron and Siberys. The chromatic dragons are especially vulnerable to her wiles, but even metallic dragons are at risk.

During the Age of Demons, Tiamat was the most feared of the Overlords, as she turned an army of dragons and her own twisted spawn against their kin. She was finally defeated by the couatls and bound deep in Argonnessen's Pit of Five Sorrows. Her corrupted spawn were utterly destroyed. Still, so great was the fear she engendered that the dragons placed her among the pantheon of dragon deities and traced her symbol in the stars. Perhaps they hoped that if Tiamat found a place in the heavens, she might never return to Eberron.

Tiamat remains bound to this day, but her power is still felt in the world. She has followers among the Lords of Dust, and she is served by an alliance of dragons and other creatures—the Talons of Tiamat. These cultists work to free the Daughter of Khyber, and they have already succeeded at the first stage of their plans, arranging for the reemergence of Tiamat's dreadful spawn. The Prophecy warns of the terrible consequences of Tiamat's return; now her cult works to fulfill the conditions of the Prophecy, even as the draconic Light of Siberys fights to keep this apocalypse at bay.

Even though Tiamat is not a true goddess, clerics who worship the Daughter of Khyber do receive spells, just as warforged devoted to the Lord of Blades do. Tiamat herself does not grant this power, but faith and devotion to her dark ideals and the dark power of Khyber empowers the dedicated cleric.

Like all the Overlords of the Age of Demons, Tiamat is bound in her prison and can influence the world only through her agents. In her true form, she has power sufficient to threaten entire kingdoms, and the ability to corrupt and control dragons. It is possible that her followers will find a way to grant their dark lady the ability to manifest, at least partially, in the world.

The Talons of Tiamat are the cult of the Daughter of Khyber. Humanoids and fiends allied with Tiamat could possess certain draconic powers; dragons that serve the Daughter of Khyber might gain fiendish powers as a result of her corrupting touch. The Cult can draw on the spawn of Tiamat, vile creatures born from fiendishly tainted dragon's eggs. The spawn have always appeared in small numbers in Argonnessen, a lingering reminder of Tiamat's presence. But now the numbers of the spawn are growing, and the Talons of Tiamat are gathering these forces to build a foul army.

Even though she is bound, Tiamat occasionally stirs in her prison; at these times, she is more conscious and active than any of the other Overlords of the Age of Demons. It is said that she can see through the eyes of any evil dragon, and that she can whisper into the hearts of dragons as they sleep. Her chosen agents can commune with her, and at times they have even summoned aspects of her into the world—far weaker than Tiamat in her full glory, but fearsome nonetheless. Each time that Tiamat has awoken in the past, that event has brought disaster to Argonnessen. Now she is stirring once more, and the prophets say that the doom of Argonnessen could be at hand.

The Talons serve an Overlord of the first age, and rakshasas and other fiends appear among their ranks. As such, they can be seen as a branch of the Lords of Dust. However, the Talons rarely coordinate their actions with the Council of Ashtakala. Most believe that Tiamat is the only true Daughter of Khyber, and the other rakshasa rajahs are merely usurpers with delusions of grandeur.

The agents of Tiamat have many goals that could take them into the wider world. They oppose the Chamber and the Eyes of Chronopsis, and adventurers could be caught in the middle of such a conflict. The cultists are gathering artifacts and tools in preparation for war in Argonnessen. They are spreading the spawn of Tiamat across the world, creating hidden nests beneath major cities. Above all, they are working to manipulate the Prophecy in ways that will result in the release of Tiamat.

Not all dragons touched by Tiamat serve in her cult. Some simply grow hateful in solitude, giving in to greed and hunger. Any ravager or rogue dragon could be a victim of Tiamat's taint; they might simply terrorize a region, or they could one day be recruited to serve the Talons directly.

Appendix I – The Fiendish Overlords

The rakshasha rajahs, the fiendish *Na-Vakhti* or Overlords of Khyber, included several beings of such power that they would normally be considered minor deities. The greatest of the Overlords was Tiamat, the five-headed Daughter of Khyber, who sought to corrupt the dragons to the cause of the Dragon Below. Another Overlord of immense power was Orcus, the Demon Prince of the Undead. Asmodeus, the Prince of Lies and the acknowledged master of most devils, the greatest of the angels who rebelled against Siberys and pledged his sword to Khyber, was also one of the rakshasha rajahs who are currently imprisoned deep beneath Eberron in the Dragon Below.

Some Overlords ruled vast geographical stretches of the world during the Age of Demons, such as Sakinnirot, the Scar That Abides. Territorial even by fiendish standards, this Overlord laid claim to all of the continent of Xen'drik. Like its sibling Overlords, Sakinnirot's rule ended when the pure divine force of the newly kindled Silver Flame bound it in a mystical prison deep underground, in an arcane hold beneath what is now the city of Stormreach in northern Xen'drik.

The Overlord now called Levistus once ruled the frozen lands of the Frostfell at the top of the world, before he was locked deep beneath its icy surface by the sacrifice of the couatls. At some time in the more recent past, Levistus escaped and began to unleash untold horrors on the people of the Frostfell before he was bound once more, this time in a great magical block of blue-black ice. Levistus is the name that men gave to this archfiend after he escaped from his prison; his true name remains unknown to mortals.

Ran Iishiv, the Unmaker, was the personification of rage who controlled most of what is now the Sarlonan nation of Adar. After Ran Iishiv was bound in Khyber by the Silver Flame, his rage reached up and created the great volcanic mountain of Korrandar. His rage is still harnessed by the draconic Strm Guardians of Adar through the powerful artifact known as the *Teeth of the Three* to produce Adar's storms and harsh weather patterns.

Sul Khatesh, the Keeper of Secrets, ruled what is now the kingdom of Aundair in central Khorvaire before she was bound beneath what are now the floating towers of the magical Aundairian academy of Arcanix. Rak Tulkesh, the Rage of War, embodied the hatred and bloodlust that drives mortals to war and his mere presence could turn men's and dragons' minds alike to thoughts of murder. Eldrantulku the Oathbraker was a spirit of discord who turned allies into enemies and lovers into mortal foes. A master deceiver, his title derived from his ability to convince others to break their

most strongly-held oaths. Eldrantulku was not a force of war—he corrupted the innocent, using the time-worn tools of ambition, jealousy and paranoia. Tul Oreshka, the Truth in the Darkness, embodied the fearsome truths that hid in shadows—the hidden true thoughts of those who considered each other friends, the terrible deeds of ancestors, the secret desires and wants of all mortals. Her actions were never predictable and she was as much a threat to her fiendish allies as she was to the Overlords’ enemies. Katashka the Gatekeeper controlled the gate between life and death and chose what passed between the world and Dolurrh. The most ancient undead creatures on Eberron were often servants of Katashka, who was believed to be a servant or another aspect of Orcus himself. Some believed that it was Katashka who created the dracolich that inhabited the Lair of the Keeper manifest zone during the Age of Demons. An obscure legend says that 3,000 years ago Katashka temporarily escaped his imprisonment by merging his spirit with the body of a human wizard named Kyuss, but this newborn demigod was imprisoned anew on an island off the northern coast of Xen’drik before he could bring his full powers to bear on the world once more. According to the legend, if Kyuss is freed again it will be during the final age of the world, a time known as the Age of Worms.

Many of the Overlords, though imprisoned and only semi-conscious, still had influence over mortals through their prime agent in the world, a rakshasa or other fiend known as that Overlord’s *prakhutu* or “speaker” in the fiendish dialect of Abyssal. It should be noted that the direct children of Khyber were the rakshashas, who are the only fiends native to Eberron itself. Other fiendish races—demons, devils, night hags, daelkyr, yugoloths and the like—are actually immortal natives of the other planes that were shaped by Khyber’s influence during creation—Xoriat, Mabar and Kythri. Fiends are also native to the planes of Shavarath, Lammania, Fernia and Risia. All fiends, even those of the same race but different planar origins, embody the nature of their home plane. Thus, a pit fiend from Fernia and one from Shavarath actually embody different characteristics—the Fernian fiend controls the essence of fire while the fiend from Shavarath is an embodiment of battle. However, all fiends, regardless of their plane of origin, acknowledge the rule of the Overlords, for they are the greatest of the children of the Dragon Below. Though all fiends, even the Overlords, can be killed, they are immortal and will simply reform on their plane of origins. In the case of the Overlords this means being reborn in the depths of Khyber approximately twenty-four hours after their death. For rakshasas and other fiends it means having another fiend of their type being created from the essence of Khyber on Eberron or the essence of their home plane if they are not native to the world.

Appendix II – The Frostfell and Everice

The northernmost continent of Eberron is called the Frostfell and sits astride the top of the world like a brooding storm cloud. The people of Khorvaire, in addition to using its descriptive proper name, call it Winter's Home, the Source of Winds, and the Icy Heart of Winter. Only one expedition has made landfall on the Frostfell and returned to Khorvaire to tell the tale. The journey was led by Lord Boroman ir'Dayne, the founder of the Wayfinder Foundation, who is said to be very interested in mounting a second expedition to the frozen land he visited long ago.

The Frostfell is a continental landmass, with a variety of terrain features providing diversity despite the unending cold. The Iceworm Peaks, a mountain range cloaked in great glaciers, bisects the continent. Barren plains of everfrost nestle in mountain valleys where snow rarely falls, while ice sheets cover hundreds of miles on either side of the mountains. Near the coast, tundra prevails, and in the summertime, lichens grow as the ground thaws briefly before plunging back into frigid winter.

The frost-covered lands closer to Khorvaire are slightly more accessible, particularly in the summer. The northernmost islands of the Lhazaar Principalities at the eastern end of Khorvaire are draped in perpetual winter. Similarly, off the northwest coast of Khorvaire lies Icewhite Island with its three children—Tlalusk (the southernmost, nearest the Demon Wastes), Qorrashi, and Icegaunt (the northernmost, between Icewhite and the Frostfell proper). Cartographers consider these islands part of the Frostfell rather than Khorvaire. All are covered in tundra, though more vegetation grows on Tlalusk and the southern end of Icewhite.

Tribes of human everfrost barbarians live on the Tashana Tundra at the northern end of Sarlona, on Icewhite Island off the northwest coast of Khorvaire, and on the islands in Xen'drik's Icemaw Sea. The Sarlonan tribes are true nomads, trailing herds of caribou on their seasonal migrations. The island-dwellers are seminomadic, building settlements in different sites as the seasons change. The primitive humans called Neanderthals by scholars, perhaps a remnant of an earlier race of humanity, coexist uneasily with the everfrost barbarians of Icewhite Island and the other folk of the Frostfell.

Human mountain folk live in the northern Hoarfrost Mountains, where they coexist in relative peace with the dwarves of the Mror Holds. They also live in the mountains of Adar in Sarlona, under the protection of the kalashtar.

Human ice folk dwell in the Frostfell and on the Everice, subsisting on the fish, seals, and whales they hunt on the frozen coasts and ice sheets. Many groups of ice folk have no contact whatsoever with the natives of warmer climes, while a few clans trade with the peoples of Khorvaire or Sarlona.

The savage people of the frozen north (and the distant south) give their own names and mythologies to the deities of the Sovereign Host and the Dark Six. Thus, Aengrist is said to be a name for Dol Arrah in a masculine aspect. The gods Hleid and Iborighu are identified as Olladra and the Keeper, with the mother–son relationship of the standard Host distorted into a sibling relationship.

The race of dwarves is sometimes said to have originated in the Frostfell where they served the cold-loving giants of that continent as slaves and migrated to Khorvaire some twelve thousand years ago, establishing strongholds like the Kingdom of Stone in Khyber before later moving to the surface in the Mror Holds. Some dwarves remained behind in the Frostfell, however. These glacier dwarves are called the Toldun Nordorthak, “Those Who Stayed,” since they continue to inhabit the frozen keeps and glacial strongholds.

Small communities of tundra halflings are known to exist in parts of the Lhazaar Principalities, particularly the region around Skairn in the northern mainland. These halflings are more closely related to those of the Talenta Plains in their cultures and attitudes than to the more urban halflings of Khorvaire, and are known to ride fastieths and white-feathered clawfoots adapted to the cold climate.

Some residents of the Frostfell revere an ancient fiendish Overlord who is said to have been imprisoned in a giant block of ice at the end of the Age of Demons. The war between dragons and fiends raged over the entire surface of Eberron, and Levistus (as he is now known) was imprisoned beneath the surface of the Frostfell. Levistus is served by a particularly active sect of the Lords of Dust. Legend tells that this powerful fiend actually did once slip his bonds, briefly wreaking havoc on the Frostfell before being magically imprisoned again.

That brief taste of freedom made the great fiend loathe his imprisonment all the more, and encourages his followers—if Levistus was freed once, he can be again. It was during this brief period of freedom that the rajah acquired his modern name. His original name is lost to history—or is a closely guarded secret.

The iceberg city of Icerazer in the Frostfell is governed by followers of Levistus. Its population includes a number of rakshasas, but the city is otherwise populated by many humans who have sworn their souls to the great Overlord. Azediel, the cambion Matriarch of Icerazer, seeks

tirelessly to find the *Crown of the Black Fire*, a mighty artifact dating from the great war between the dragons and the fiends which she believes will set Levistus free once more.

Little is known of the opposite end of the world of Eberron, but it is believed to be just as cold as the Frostfell. The Icemaw Sea south of the mainland of Xen'drik is dotted with snow-covered islands and floating icebergs. According to the reports of those few sailors who have braved the Icemaw, the farther south one sails, the more the sea begins to solidify into one great sheet of ice. It is believed that islands are scattered across the southern ocean, some of them possibly quite large, but they are all swallowed in the sheet of eternal ice that lies there. This region of frozen water is known as Everice, or simply the Frozen Sea.

The glimmering cities of the legendary snow elves of Everice seem now to all have fallen. On the islands of the Icemaw Sea, the ruins of these ice cities remain, suggesting that some elves did not follow Aeren but instead fled Xen'drik to the freezing south to escape their giant masters, but did not survive to the present day. Snow elves may yet exist in the Everice, but no explorer has returned with evidence of them.

Magical snow effects—including blood snow, ebony ice, faerie frost, and razor ice—appear occasionally in the Frostfell but seem more common in the Everice. Both regions contain manifest zones linked to the elemental realm of Risia, the Plane of Ice in the Elemental Chaos, which may account for these unnatural weather effects.

Appendix III – Languages of Eberron

Due to the widespread influence of the dragonmarked houses across Khorvaire, Common, a tongue descended from the Sarlonan language called Old Common and used by the first humans to reach Khorvaire with Lhazhaar, developed into the universal language of the Five Nations and then of the Kingdom of Galifar. Commerce and diplomacy used Common to communicate on a level playing field. It is prevalent and as universal as any language could be across the continent. Common was the primary language of the Five Nations. It was a necessary second language in the Mror Holds and Zilargo, and was used extensively even among the halflings of the Talenta Plains, whose original tribal languages, phonetically related to Sarlona's Old Common, were rapidly fading away.

Other prominent languages in use on the continent included Draconic, Dwarven, Elven, Abyssal, Goblin, and Orcish. Written Dwarven was a runic language that used a system of runes called Davek, which had actually first been created by the titans of Xen'drik and the Frostfell, who spoke the related Giant language. This tongue was still in use by the giants of those continents and was commonly found etched on the cyclopean ruins and giant artifacts scattered across Xen'drik. Oddly enough, Giant was also related to Orcish, which also used the runic Davek alphabet of Giant in the rare circumstances that it was written down, though it had very different pronunciations.

Scholars and arcanists also studied Draconic, the ancient language of the dragons of Argonessen and of all arcane magic on Eberron, which was written using a script called Iokharic. Draconic was the oldest language of the mortal races. In Aerenal, the Elven language dominated the land, and dialects of that language were spoken by the drow of Xen'drik and the eladrin of Thelanis, though Common was retained for trade and diplomatic purposes with Khorvaire. Elven was written in the flowing, elegant script called Rellanic. The gnomes of Zilargo also spoke a language very similar to an ancient dialect of Elven as their native tongue, perhaps betraying their common fey roots with the elves and eladrin. Also common on many old ruins scattered across Khorvaire was the written language of the Dhakaani, which most human scholars more commonly referred to simply as Goblin. This language's alphabetic written form, based on Iokharic, was still known among some of the more advanced goblin tribes of the present day nation of Darguun, though more commonly the Goblin language simply used the more well-known alphabet of the Common tongue.

The Inspired of Sarlona spoke Quori, which had no written component since the quori were a telepathic race, while the lesser classes of their empire spoke Riedran, a tongue that combined Old

Common with a scattering of Quori words and phrases and used the same standard alphabet as Khorvarien Common. Riedran served as the *lingua franca* on Sarlona just as Common was the universal language of Khorvaire. The people of Adar spoke their own language, Adaran, which also used the dragons' Iokharic script. The human barbarian tribes of Seren and Argonnessen spoke a mutated form of Old Common called Argon, while the dragons spoke and wrote in Draconic and had at least a passing familiarity with the languages of the lesser races.

The daelkyr and their aberrations spoke the Deep Speech, a language related to the alien communication of Xoriat, the Plane of Madness. The Deep Speech used the elves' Rellanic script, since the language was first written down by the Umbragen drow who were among the daelkyr's greatest enemies in the underground darkness beneath Xen'drik.

The tongue of the gods' angelic servants—as well as the couatl and shulassakar—was called Supernal, a language whose syllables were said to contain the raw magic of Creation first wielded by the Progenitor wyrms and the Sovereign Host. Supernal was written in a mystical alphabet of the same name. The fiends and rakshasas of Khyber and the other dark planes spoke a foul tongue called Abyssal that sounded to listeners like the very embodiment of the Dragon Below's evil and made use of its own demonic alphabet called Barazhad. Abyssal was in fact a shadowy corruption of an even older language linked to the fiendish Overlords and the Dragon Below known as Primordial, which also had used the infernal Barazhad alphabet. Most fiends, especially devils, were equally conversant in Supernal, which was the tongue of the Progenitors and the language from which Draconic had evolved.

Appendix IV – Dragonshards

Among Eberron's most important resources are the three varieties of dragonshards: the fallen shards of Siberys, the crystals found in the soil of Eberron, and those drawn from the depths of Khyber. Each type of dragonshard has an affinity for certain magical functions, and each is used to make a different sort of magic item. All dragonshards appear as translucent rock or crystal with swirling veins of color suspended within them. The shape of these veins suggests the swirls of dragonmarks, though no one has ever found a shard that exactly mirrored a mark. The color moves and pulses within the translucent crystal, making dragonshards look almost alive and lending their color to the overall appearance of the crystal.

Siberys shards fall from the Ring of Siberys, and as a result are usually found in Xen'drik and other equatorial regions of the planet (No prospector has yet dared to explore what must be vast Siberys shard fields in Argonnessen). Siberys shards' crystalline depths contain pulsating golden veins. The most rare of the dragonshard varieties, Siberys shards are also the most closely connected to the emergence of the dragonmarks among the common races of Khorvaire. Scions of the dragonmarked houses attune them to their own marks and fashion them into focus items to enhance their spell-like magical abilities. Dragonmarked Heirs of Siberys, the bearers of the most powerful type of dragonmark, use unattuned shards to increase the power of their own powerful abilities. The Inspired of Sarlona covet Siberys shards, because they can also be used to enhance psionic ability. Since dragonshards are precious to so many powerful groups, a significant find of previously undiscovered shards is often the focus of intrigue or the object of theft. Siberys shards are also sometimes called sunstones or starmotes, and their connection to the dragonmarked houses means that they are often simply called dragonshards with no further qualification.

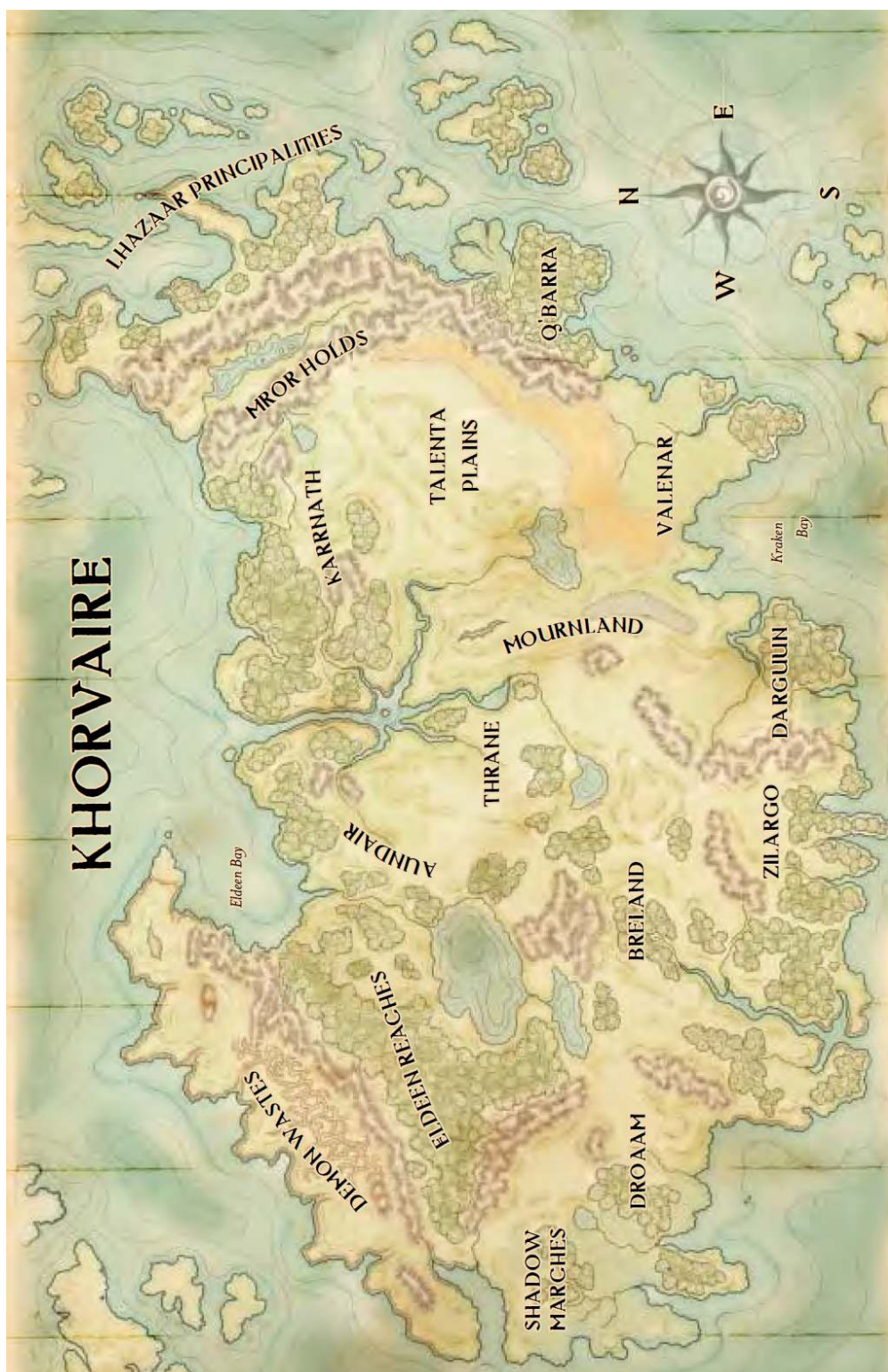
The dragonmarked houses are vitally important to Khorvaire's society and economy. Their artificers thus have both a driving need to develop methods of enhancing their power and the economic resources to do so, which has resulted in a proliferation of magic items designed to harness and enhance the power of a dragonmark heir. These items range from highly specialized devices that increase the effects of a particular mark—such as the *speaking stones* of House Sivis—to general-purpose tools that are useful to anyone who bears a dragonmark.

Prospectors find Eberron dragonshards buried in soil, never deep in rock. They typically appear in clusters encased in geodes. They are found on the continents of Khorvaire and Aerenal

exclusively, and may be tied to the development of dragonmarks. Inside the pinkish crystal of each Eberron shard are writhing swirls of deep red, which is why these shards are commonly known as bloodstones. Like other dragonshards, Eberron shards display a remarkable affinity for arcane magic, but this affinity is very broad compared to the specific uses of Siberys and Khyber shards. An arcane spellcaster can attune an Eberron shard to a specific spell, enhancing the effect of that spell when it is cast on and through the shard. Wizards can encode their spells and rituals in Eberron shards instead of scribing them on paper as scrolls.

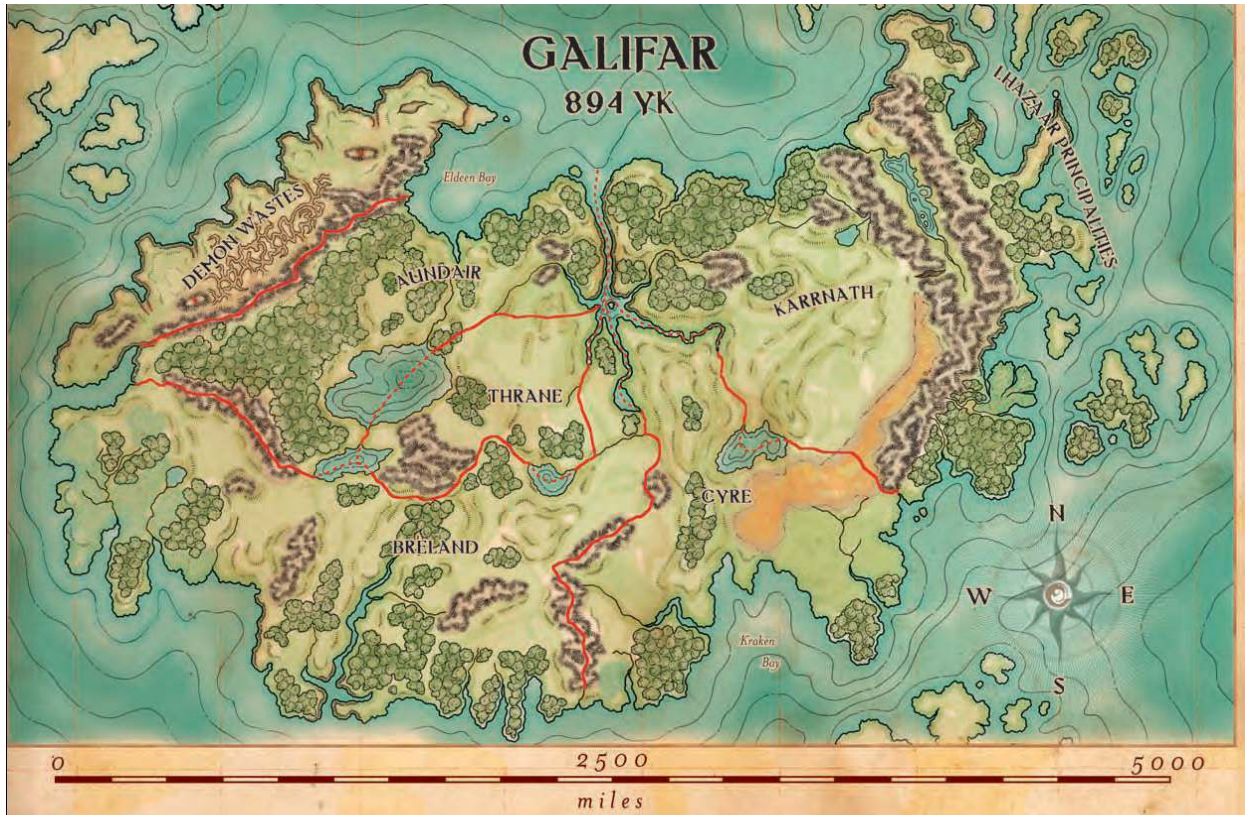
Khyber dragonshards grow on the walls of volcanic caverns deep underground, usually near pools of magma or sulfur vents. They are particularly common in areas tied to fiendish or elemental activity, such as the Demon Wastes, though they are found in underground areas all across Eberron. They are smoky crystals with colored veins of midnight blue to oily black. Their affinity is for magic related to the binding of elementals or even living souls. Thus, crafting a bound-elemental item requires binding the elemental to a Khyber shard, and these shards are common components of binding diagrams, rituals that trap souls and other spirits, and similar magic. They are especially sought after by the Zil gnomes, House Lyrandar and House Orien to power bound-elemental vehicles like airships, elemental galleons and the lightning rail. Khyber shards are sometimes called nightshards or demonstones.

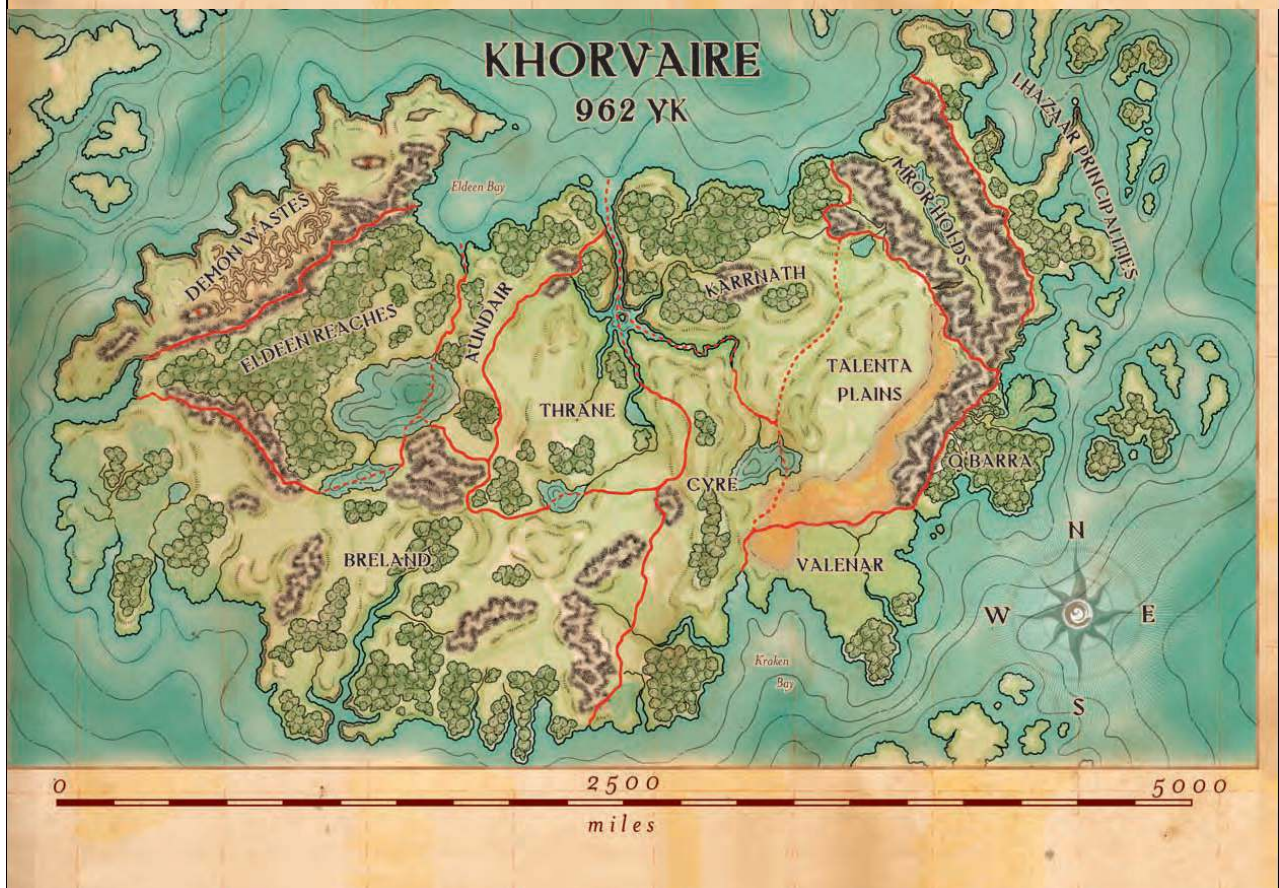
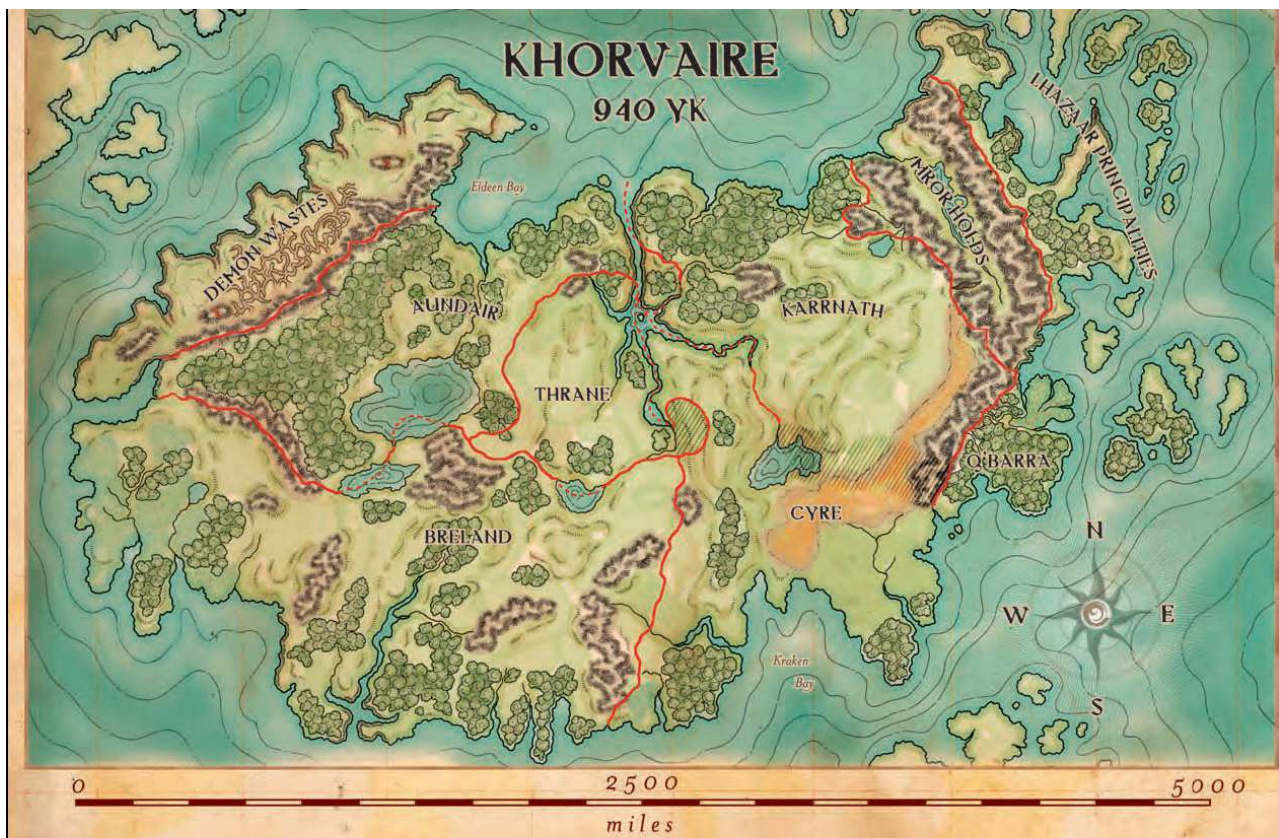
Appendix V – Historical Maps



Khorvaire in 998 YK











ARGONNESSEN



XEN'DRIK



- | | | | | |
|----------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------|
| 1. STORMREACH | 7. FANGS OF ARGARAK | 13. THE HYDRA (RIVER) | 19. TEMPEST'S SPINE | 25. THUNDERWALL |
| 2. THRONE GATE RUINS | 8. THE WASTING PLAIN | 14. MARSH OF DESOLATION | 20. DREAD LAKE | 26. DAR QAT |
| 3. OBSIDIAN CITY | 9. MEL-AQAT | 15. SKYRAKER CLAWS | 21. THE SCIMITAR SPIRES | 27. TAL ESK |
| 4. TITAN'S TEETH | 10. THARGUN DHAK | 16. VALLEY OF SHADOWS | 22. THREE BARREL COVE | 28. ZANTASHK |
| 5. KAPAERIAN ISLAND | 11. PRA'XIREK | 17. THE ASH CAULDRONS | 23. SORROWDUSK ISLAND | 29. ZANTASHK |
| 6. SUN PILLARS | 12. RING OF STORMS | 18. THE BLUESPINE PEAKS | 24. DOWRON'S SHIELD | 30. BAZEK MOHL |

STORMREACH



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